



A HISTORY OF THE MODERNIST NOVEL

Edited by

GREGORY CASTLE

A HISTORY OF THE MODERNIST NOVEL

A History of the Modernist Novel reassesses the modernist canon and produces a wealth of new comparative analyses that radically revise the novel's history. Drawing on American, English, Irish, Russian, French, and German traditions, leading scholars challenge existing attitudes about realism and modernism and draw new attention to everyday life and everyday objects. In addition to its exploration of new forms such as the modernist genre novel and experimental historical novel, this book considers the novel in postcolonial, transnational, and cosmopolitan contexts. *A History of the Modernist Novel* also considers the novel's global reach while suggesting that the epoch of modernism is not yet finished.

GREGORY CASTLE is a professor of British and Irish literature at Arizona State University. He has published *Modernism and the Celtic Revival*, *Reading the Modernist Bildungsroman*, and *The Literary Theory Handbook*. He has edited *Postcolonial Discourses*, volume one, of Wiley-Blackwell's *Encyclopedia of Literary and Cultural Theory*. He has written essays on Joyce, Yeats, Wilde, Stoker, and other modernist and postcolonial writers, and he is working on a monograph entitled *Modernism and the Temporalities of Irish Revival*.

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32 Avenue of the Americas, New York, NY 10013-2473, USA

Cambridge University Press is part of the University of Cambridge.

It furthers the University's mission by disseminating knowledge in the pursuit of education, learning, and research at the highest international levels of excellence.

www.cambridge.org

Information on this title: www.cambridge.org/9781107034952

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First published 2015

Printed in the United States of America

A catalog record for this publication is available from the British Library.

Library of Congress Cataloging in Publication Data

A history of the modernist novel / editor, Gregory Castle.

pages cm

I. Modernism (Literature) I. Castle, Gregory, editor.

PN56.M54H57 2015

809'.9112—dc23 2014048660

ISBN 978-1-107-03495-2 Hardback

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Acknowledgments

When I was first approached by Ray Ryan at Cambridge University Press to edit *A History of the Modernist Novel*, I was wary: How could it be done? I considered an emphasis on individual authors (the Great Personality theory of literary history) or on movements and “-isms” (the Great Event theory) but rejected both in favor of an approach that looked at ideas, problems, and themes as they were articulated at various points (temporal and geographic) and in various constellations of social and cultural significance. I wanted to examine the destiny of the novel ca. 1890–1950, an epoch that witnessed great technological development alongside the most extraordinary savagery; an epoch in which literary and artistic innovations were often coupled with reactionary political positions; an epoch that witnessed the highest forms of spiritualism alongside the brute realities of lived experience. One could say the passage of literature through this epoch enacts something akin to Adorno and Horkheimer’s “dialectics of enlightenment,” in which rationality reveals its dangerous mythic side. One could say of modernism, as Habermas says of modernity at large, that it is an “unfinished project” precisely because this dialectic continues to propel certain trends in contemporary literary production. *A History of the Modernist Novel* is founded on the idea that at any given point new interventions will change the contours of this history (of any literary history), so it is *unfinished* in the sense that it puts into play a series of original investigations into the historical “placement” of the novel in the modernist epoch. It is our hope that these essays will spark conversations about the direction of modernism, the destiny of the novel form, the nature of literary history

and literary canons, and the authors who might have been included or those who might have been discussed differently.

I have been tutored in modernism and the novel by a great many people. For longer than I can recollect, there's been John Paul Riquelme, who taught me much about modernism and about editing. I can still recall the clarity and rigor of Michael North's instruction, which is echoed in every one of his books, and Cal Bedient's insistence on a modernism that doesn't sit still. I couldn't begin to do justice to the multitude of critics and theorists on the novel from whom I have learned since college. My colleagues in Irish studies – people such as Nicholas Allen, Margot Backus, Patrick Bixby, Kevin Dettmar, Sean Duffy, Seán Kennedy, David Lloyd, Vicki Mahaffey, Margot Norris, Jean-Michel Rabaté, and Joseph Valente – have taught me how powerfully Irish writers have influenced the general development of modernist fiction. All of the contributors to this volume are people I have read, admired, quoted, and grappled with over the years, and I am grateful that each and every one participated in the project. Their timeliness and professionalism would be the envy of any editor. As would be the work of the project manager, Sathish Kumar, and his team at Cambridge University Press, and my graduate intern, Christopher Hall, who provided the index. I am happy to have completed another project under Ray Ryan's direction, an editor who has shaped the Cambridge University Press list on modernism in new and exciting ways. The Cambridge series on literary history, of which this volume is a part, is an invaluable contribution to literary and cultural study, and I am proud to be part of it.

Much of my work on this volume was produced in Dublin in the summer of 2014, while being nurtured by such arguments in sound as those produced by Benoît Pioulard, Brian Eno, Stars of the Lid, Labradford, and the master, Miles Davis. I am grateful for their company. As for the history of love? I continue to learn that from Camille Angeles-Castle, a conqueror of time.

INTRODUCTION

Matter in Motion in the Modernist Novel

Gregory Castle

Modernism and the Problem of the Real

In 1933, Virginia Woolf wrote in her diary of her frustration with the novel. “The thing is to be venturous, bold, to take every possible fence. One might introduce plays, poems, letters, dialogues: must get the round, not only the flat. Not the theory only. And conversation; argument.”¹ *A History of the Modernist Novel* attempts to fill in this tantalizing and elliptical description of the novel, made at a time when experimentalism in the form was at its height. It confirms in sometimes surprising ways that the modernist novel has always been “venturous and bold,” from the era of the sensational aesthetic novel of Beauty to the late modernist tales of beautiful failures. It charts the myriad temporalities, lines of development, subgenres and styles that flourished in the modernist epoch (ca. 1880–1950).² A multi-voiced approach to literary history suits well a genre characterized by pluralism and a degree of aesthetic experimentation that frequently entailed collaboration, interdisciplinary borrowings, and hybrid literary forms. Its generic richness – which includes naturalist, aesthetic, fantasy, adventure, Gothic, comic, impressionistic, didactic and parodic styles and modes – is the result of a singular openness to the reality it strives to include. M. M. Bakhtin recognized this in the 1930s, in his examination of the novel as a dynamic and dialogic form. The novel, he wrote, is “the sole genre that continues to develop, that is as yet uncompleted,” the sole genre to occupy a zone of “maximally close contact between the represented object and contemporary reality in all its inconclusiveness.”³

Literary history of the modernist epoch, as Chris Baldick points out, remains “strongly marked” by an emphasis on “radical breaks and unprecedented innovations.”⁴ Speaking of Woolf’s and D. H. Lawrence’s critical reflections on the novel, Baldick writes, that “[b]oth signal an important sceptical departure from habit and convention, a spasm of rebellion that is felt in the experimental construction not just of their own novels in the 1920s but of many other attempts to escape the imaginary tyrant of novelistic custom.”⁵ This “novelistic custom” relied on realism, particularly its tendency to confirm the middle-class, liberal-democratic ideology of the society it represented. Baldick shows that modernism produced a variety of realisms (environmental, psychological, socialist, provincial, artistic) and argues forcefully that “there are oversights and distortions involved in [a] partition of prose fiction into two distinct continents marked on our map as ‘realism’ and ‘modernism.’”⁶ However, contemporary reassessments of realism do not always escape the chronology that would place modernism *after* realism, which means that the classic “antinomy” remains at the center of the discussion.⁷

Many of the essays in this volume resist the dominant narratives in modernist studies, not the least those that modernists themselves constructed. Woolf’s widely influential essays on fiction, particularly her critical assessment of Edwardian realists such as John Galsworthy, Arnold Bennett, and H. G. Wells, established a powerful story of how the modern novel transcended the empirical niceties of early twentieth-century realism by exploring the spiritual dimensions of the “dark places of psychology.”⁸ As David Bradshaw and Anne Fernihough show in this volume, Woolf not only misjudged these novelists but misrecognized the value of materialism and the narrative attention to everyday life – a value she saw quite differently, when she wondered, in 1933, if it was possible to “give ordinary waking Arnold Bennett life the form of art.”⁹ *A History of the Modernist Novel* returns to key debates like this to reassess the importance of everyday life and the technical means by which the novel tried to register and represent it.¹⁰ It places canonical figures in new constellations, explores global connections and describes new hybrid forms, like the “modernist genre novel” and

experimental historical fiction. On the evidence it provides, we can say confidently that the modernist novel was *always in an experimental mode* and it was *always engaged with realism*, and in this double-barreled way it sought narrative access to the Real (i.e., to the irreducible materiality of lived experience) and to the temporal and geographic coordinates of our experience of it.¹¹

The modernist frame of reference in this *History* includes language, narrative form, popular media networks, new and diverse audiences, transnational influences and pressures, the idea of cosmopolitanism as a *Weltanschauung*, and the materiality of everyday life. English-language traditions, together with some of the main lines of continental European development (Russian, German, French) are covered in some detail, as well as new modes of writing, publishing, distributing, and reading modernist fiction. While this *History* is concerned primarily with work in the period before the Second World War, [Parts IV](#) and [V](#) offer reflections on how modernism in the novel reorients itself in the 1940s and early 1950s. This raises the question of belatedness: is it possible that late modernists arrived after the feast of innovation? Is it because they come late that we find such a pervasive aura of failure in their work? Failure is a keynote throughout the modernist epoch, but the relation of failure (and *failing*) to innovation changes as modernist writers learn to rethink the underlying humanist values that shape their sense of success and failure in creative, ethical, and practical life. In late modernism, a trend that has coursed through the epoch comes into its own as a defining trait: the transvaluation of *failure* (defined as part of a rigid, technocratic binary with *success*) into *failing*, which Theodor Adorno associated with the most experimental of modernist works – works that “push contradiction to the extreme, and realize themselves in their resultant downfall.”¹²

Coming late, therefore, does not reduce artistic expression to second-degree intensities or derivations, or to sterile, differential repetitions. Late modernism is conditioned by temporal openness and freedom, by geographical extension and cosmopolitan belonging, but also by the limits of locality and the failures of freedom and belonging. It throws open to the reader the spectacle of a world split

in two: radical solipsism of the sort we find in Samuel Beckett is matched with a vertiginous sense of time and space in which multiple voices create the din of a community – a confused sense of belonging (“a statement to be made, by them, by me, some slight obscurity here”¹³) that, for all its failings, constitutes a new narrative dynamic for character development and the consideration of human action.

One way to approach writing a history of such a complex genre – one with multiple temporalities and modalities of innovation, that resists totalization even as it experiments with unifying visions – is to formulate it as a *negative* dialectical art form that aspires to hold in creative tension two different worlds: the *expressed* world, the diegetic level of fiction that constitutes the “world” of the artwork, and the *represented* world, the non-diegetic level of lived experience that mimetic art seeks to imitate and emulate through faithful resemblance.¹⁴ The represented world, which in fictional forms is manifested most effectively in realist styles, plays a decisive role in the development of the modernist novel, even though it is “inevitably and voluntarily mutilated” in the process,¹⁵ for it is through this mutilation that the expressed world of the fiction emerges out of the world of objects and lived experience. If realist styles and techniques of notation are used, they serve primarily to augment an anti-mimetic world that does not strive to reflect or resemble the “given” state of things.¹⁶ In its tactical, *notational* use of realism, the modernist novel augments an expressed world of anti-mimetic richness by providing narrative points of purchase for reflection and action: the objects that are so prominent in modernist anti-mimetic art.

Realism is at once an inheritance and an opportunity, a practice to be appropriated in the service of an aesthetic agenda that is inimical to its underlying mimetic impulse, which is to create resemblances to the observable world in art works. Appropriations of realism by modernist and avant-garde writers can thus have the effect of *derealizing* narrative, a tactic found in the sensational novels of Ouida, in Andrei Belyi’s *Petersburg* (1913–14), and in Oscar Wilde’s *Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890–91), in which the realism of the story is rendered *unreal*, *unheimlich*, by the introduction of sensational, Gothic, and melodramatic narrative styles; realist

notation, when it is used, jars with the aesthetic fantasy that contains it. Hybrid styles that feature realism tend to accomplish de-realization by virtue of rhetorical elaborations, descriptive exaggerations, or abstractions that serve both to undermine and reaffirm the realist “base” style. To de-realize realism is to make it *more real* as a style, an anti-mimetic style that resists vulgar and conventional “novelistic custom.”

The highest virtue of the nineteenth-century realist novel, especially in France and England, was not its verisimilitude but its generative power, for it was able to create vast and detailed represented worlds, to which their narrators’ ardent aspirations lent an affective dimension and human shape. The represented world in such fictions was as much a reflection of hope as it was of current social conditions.¹⁷ This generative power is not easily refuted. There is a clear trajectory in the history of the modernist novel, a movement forward that entwines realist narration first with aestheticism, then the avant-garde realism of D. H. Lawrence and E. M. Forster, then the protean-styled or “Daedalean” experimentalism of the high modernists (Joyce, Woolf, Proust, Gertrude Stein, Belyi, Thomas Mann, Robert Musil, Flann O’Brien), the highly refined neo-realism of Ernest Hemingway, early William Faulkner, Elizabeth Bowen, and Kate O’Brien, and the ruthless subtractions from representation that we find in Beckett.

What sets the modernist apart from the nineteenth-century realist novelist, for whom the world of the novel maps nearly seamlessly with the world of representation, is that realism becomes a tactic or a technique, a style among others, rather than the literary index of a *Weltanschauung*, in which mimesis both mirrors a specific social order and legitimizes the ideology behind it. What most critics mean by “conventional” or Victorian realism is a form of narrative that assumes a stable and faithful representation of the lived experience of the world as it is *given to* representation. This is the mimetic trick of resemblance. Mimesis calls for a close resemblance to the given world of lived experience in representation (the givenness of reality is *presented again*). The realist novel, in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, sought to reconcile lived experience with

representation, the latter mobilized in such a way as to be the transparent medium of the life narrated.¹⁸ In line with nineteenth-century psychology and social science, the realist novel developed styles of empirical description and dialogue that helped to create a normative discourse of everyday life. It served both an aesthetic function (by giving a “reality effect” to representation) and an ideological function (by redistributing social position and class, at the level of plot and incident, and by relying on omniscient third person and first person narrators).¹⁹ If the nineteenth-century realists sought to reconcile language and the world in a style that veiled the struggle for reconciliation (in the sense of an achieved social totality), then modernists, by virtue of their tactical reuse of realist techniques and methods, aspired toward a reconciliation that was no less utopian but freed from the necessity to achieve a totality or to devalue the struggle that substitutes for that achievement. They put more creative and critical pressure on the negative, and struggled to resist dialectical closure.²⁰ If nineteenth-century realism dialectically integrates art and life, narrative and social experience, then modernist realism seeks to scuttle this integration through tactics of defamiliarization and misrecognition that accentuate the struggle against totality and open the novel to a more inclusive view of everyday life.

The discipline of resemblance that characterizes conventional realist fiction thrives in modernism precisely because resemblance itself can be mobilized in a hybrid or pastiche narrative as a style among other styles; for example, in Joyce’s *Ulysses*, an “initial style” of stream of consciousness uses the mimetic principle of resemblance to show how language differs from the world. “Joyce had created a new realism,” writes Arthur Powers, “in an atmosphere that was at the same time half-factual and half-dream.”²¹ Joyce’s modernism requires the notational function of realism in order to stipulate the resemblance it then perpetually disavows. Novelists such as Woolf, Stein, and Beckett routinely use resemblance (echo, repetition, parallel) to dissemble reality; their language strives to resemble (or re-assemble) lived experience, its tempo and temporalities, and does so in part by estranging itself from the conventions of mimesis. Throughout the modernist epoch, the novel achieves one of the

classical goals of art, as articulated by Sir Philip Sidney, who wrote that “[Nature’s] world is brazen, the poets only deliver a golden.”²² The more radical the stylistic innovations are, the more tenuous the hold on a borrowed embodiment of narrative time and the more “golden” its aspect in the aesthetic autonomy it creates for itself. The modernist novel develops its own world; like all narrative art, it offers its own time to the reader even as it acknowledges conventional temporal markers such as chronology or sequence and the time of world history (as Woolf does in *Mrs. Dalloway* with periodic references to Big Ben). There are levels of “represented reality” in even the most resolutely anti-mimetic novel. “And to think I try my best not to talk about myself,” notes the title character in Beckett’s *Molloy*. “In a moment I shall talk about the cows, about the sky, if I can.”²³ Experimental modernists, who explore the creative and critical potential of anti-mimetic literature, do not abandon realism so much as transform the field of what is representable in a realist style so that it draws attention to the objects (cows, sky) that are merely background in the realist novel and to the subject’s inwardness, his reflections and affections (“If I can”), which are the stuff of the modernist novel. The point is not to achieve resemblance but rather to register in language and literary form the lived experience of the present in a flash of being that resembles nothing, save the flight-pattern of its own emergence.

On the Theory and History of the Novel

The theory of the novel emerged within modernism itself. The prefaces and essays written by the likes of Henry James, Joseph Conrad, and Virginia Woolf have had a profound impact on our conception of the modernist novel as an enterprise that registers the fine gradations of consciousness, that attends to the inner life and memories of one’s protagonists, that creates from experience of the world a “magical suggestiveness” (in Conrad’s vivid phrase) that grants to prose narrative some of the qualities of musical sound. For these modernists, the novel was a forum for expressing what could be known about the world, for offering intimations of the quicksilver

contact we make with objects, for conveying the “triumph and the jingle and the strange high singing of some aeroplane overhead” that overwhelms Mrs. Dalloway in “this moment of June.”²⁴

For all of the commentary these novelists made on the *form* of the novel, a strictly formalist theory of the novel did not emerge until much later.²⁵ Wayne Booth’s *Rhetoric of Fiction* (1966) ushered in a brand of formal analysis that concentrated on point of view, narrative disposition (reliable and unreliable), and the question of narrative *voice*, though his rhetorical approach was eclipsed by the structural narratology of Gerard Genette and Roland Barthes. In the meantime, the dialectical materialism of Georg Lukács’s *Theory of the Novel* (1920) offered a critical perspective on modernist experimentalism. Ideally, “the novel establishes a fluctuating yet firm balance between becoming and being; as the idea of becoming, it becomes a state. Thus the novel, by transforming itself into a normative being of becoming, surmounts itself.”²⁶ From a dialectical perspective, realism both represents the “real world” (for analysis and reform) and constitutes what is real through representation. The nineteenth-century realist novel, for Lukács, was a great bourgeois invention, powered by “the old genuine dialectic” that, by the 1940s, had been “consigned to oblivion.”²⁷ The greatness of this conventional form did not rest on its having *actually* achieved dialectical closure (seamless integration of narrative and experience), but on its ardent aspiration toward that achievement. The failures of the modernist novel were, for Lukács, the failures of a genre to grasp its historical moment and to express, through formal means, a remedy for it.

What Lukács inaugurated subsequent theorists developed further, from Bakhtin who had argued, beginning in the late 1920s, that the novel was dialogic, parodic, carnivalesque, and constantly changing,²⁸ to postwar touchstones such as Erich Auerbach, whose *Mimesis* (1946) remains an important account of how novelistic realism developed out of a long tradition of mimetic representation, and Ian Watt, whose *Rise of the Novel* (1957) inaugurated a mode of literary history that charts the English novel’s emergence and rise as a function of political and cultural modernization. Something of this

approach is discerned in the historicist critics of the novel, such as Walter Benn Michaels, for whom the novel's legibility was tied strongly to our understanding of social conditions (e.g., the relationship between the "gold standard" and narrative technique).²⁹ These materialist approaches, and those driven by phenomenology to explore the horizon of the novel's fictive worlds,³⁰ have led novel theory toward what has remained its central questions: What is the relationship between form and reality? Can the novel do more than shape life into representations? Can it "express" the "qualia" of everyday life, the immediate experience of sensation?

In the last half century, there have been many attempts to retell the history of the novel in terms of its relation to the lived experience of everyday life, a relation that Raymond Williams has described in terms of "structures of feeling," "the culture of a period . . . the particular living result of all the elements in the general organization," which often "corresponds to the dominant social character."³¹ Materialist and feminist revisionism has challenged orthodox attitudes toward everyday life, especially the structures of feeling governing domestic life and the life of women. Works such as Nancy Armstrong's *Desire and Domestic Fiction: A Political History of the Novel* (1987) and Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *Madwoman in the Attic* (2000), tell the story of women novelists in a way that reorients our understanding of the genre, preeminently by widening the scope of objects and events, characters and themes that were available for representation.³² In the wake of Homi Bhabha's seminal work on "narrative and nation,"³³ many studies have considered the impact of empire and colonialism on the shape of the modernist novel. Some of these retain an interest in the nation and nationalism, as in John Kucich's study of British fiction and the fantasies of empire, while others consider alternatives to national identification and belonging, as in Jessica Berman's study of "cosmopolitan communities" in modernist fiction.³⁴ Some studies focus primarily on the modernist novel and its investments in the imperial project, though in others, such as Simon Gikandi's *Writing in Limbo: Modernism and Caribbean Literature* (1992), postcolonial literatures are pitted against canonical modernism. This viewpoint has been challenged in recent

years, most notably by Neil Lazarus, and we are now more inclined to see a modernist moment entwined with a postcolonial one.³⁵

Michael Valdez Moses argues that the novel is fundamental to our understanding of global culture: “the very process of global modernization that has made a world literature possible has itself become a principle subject of that literature.”³⁶ The upsurge of interest in globalization and cosmopolitanism, together with a resurgence of interest in Immanuel Wallerstein’s “world-systems” theory, has created a new context for understanding the modernist novel as a development within a larger global network of literary production and circulation.³⁷ One of the most ambitious projects is Franco Moretti’s five-volume *Collana Romanzo* (2001–03). The two-volume English-language edition (*The Novel*, 2006) is just shy of 2,000 pages and maps the complexity of the literary field with an analytical method that re-conceives *genre as a global system* in which analysis cuts across geopolitical boundaries. But it also shows the novel’s continuing efforts to narrate the ambivalent space of the nation: at once a location and a *dislocation*; an ancestral land, language and way of life, but also a global terrain in which national distinctions are configured in terms of a vast and expanding global network. In a quite different vein, Pascale Casanova’s *The World Republic of Letters* has been widely influential in reading global literature as an extension of national traditions and languages. Casanova is interested in systems mapping; but unlike Moretti, she calls a halt to the critical tendency to disavow or undervalue national literary traditions precisely by linking them to the global systems of which they are, at bottom, mirror images. Her approach hinges on the difference between *national* and *international* writers: “The internal configuration of each national space precisely mirrors the structure of the international literary world as a whole.” She speaks of a “rivalry” between “‘national’ writers (who embody a national or popular definition of literature) and ‘international’ writers (who uphold an autonomous conception of literature).” The “world literary space” is created by “a composite of the various national literary spaces, which are themselves bipolar and differentially situated in the world structure” with respect to “national and international poles.”³⁸ In Casanova’s analysis of the

global impact of representation, “bipolarity” appears to operate in something like a dialectical fashion. Thus Paris is the “capital of the literary world . . . the gateway to the ‘world market of intellectual goods,’ as Goethe put it, the chief place of consecration in the world of literature.”³⁹ The overtones of a spiritualized sublation are clear, as is the recourse to Goethe, whose conception of aesthetico-spiritual *Bildung* is a spectral presence in Pascale’s (and Moretti’s) global literary system.

The last quarter century has seen much in the way of histories of the novel,⁴⁰ and there are plenty of literary studies of the modernist epoch (1890–1950) that have been invaluable to me and to the contributors in this volume. Yet none of these studies attempts to do what we are doing here, which is to tell *a* history by telling *many* histories. This is accomplished through the editorial gambit that brings the many together into a collection (which still resists being a singularity), that makes visible the multiple, recursive temporalities within the (nevertheless) forward-moving development of the modernist novel.

Outline of a History

A History of the Modernist Novel seeks to understand the main lines of development of a form that emerged in multiple times and places. This requires an arrangement of chapters that allows for forward motion as well as lateral extension and thick description. Each part of the volume seeks to capture a moment in modernism – the 1890s, impressionism and early experimentation; a transitional period of revaluation and experimentation with realism; a general embrace at modernism’s maturity of the materiality of everyday life; also in that maturity, the rise of new genres and new means of publication and distribution; the interwar and postwar moments of globalization and late modernist reconsolidations. A method of braiding multiple reflections on different historical moments in order to describe a longer and more encompassing temporal passage is meant to capture the history of a literary field that is at once strongly localized and global in reach and extension. The range of themes and richness of stories, the complex intersections of global, national, and regional

literatures, of linguistic and ideological difference – all of this demands that we avoid creating a chronology and focus on moments or constellations in the novel's development, wherein we may see both the progression through time and the spatial extension of simultaneous events within its flow.

Part I: Modernism and the Challenge to the Real

Bliss Perry, at the turn of the twentieth century, recognized how important realism was to readers and also how *modern* it was: “In exact correspondence with that marvelous technical power exhibited in modern French pictures of the realistic school, there has been developed in realistic fiction a fidelity, a life-likeness, a vividness, a touch, which are extraordinary and new.”⁴¹ Early modernists rejected not this, but what for them was an inartistic tendency merely to copy. “I hate vulgar realism in literature,” Lord Henry tells his friends in Oscar Wilde’s *Picture of Dorian Gray*. “The man who could call a spade a spade should be compelled to use one. It is the only thing he is fit for.”⁴² The aesthetes, like the Gothic novelists, were avowedly anti-mimetic, but they used realist notation to convey the *unreal* pleasures (and horrors) of excess and exaggeration, as in *Dorian Gray*, Joris-Karl Huysmans’s *À Rebours* (1884), and Bram Stoker’s *Dracula* (1897).

The chapters in [Part I](#) challenge key assumptions held by readers and critics alike, principally, the assumption that modernism rejected not only the realist novel but also its underlying premise of mimesis, the production of resemblances of the *real world* (the object world of our everyday lived experience). Many other assumptions – about character, plot, theme, and of course narrative point of view – follow from this one. In early modernist novels, realism retains some of its conventional force, particularly in plot development and description of setting, character, and action; but the same novels might also deploy a realist style tactically to undermine normative genre functions (e.g., faithful mimetic depiction of social milieu, gender and sexual roles, chronology) in the service of non-mimetic aesthetic moods, psychological states, abstract ideas, and concepts.

A good example of this is the aesthetic novel, which, as Joseph Bristow points out, emerges from the sensation fiction of Ouida, in the late nineteenth century, and is refined in “Pater’s superbly studied prose before turning to the innovations that Wilde made when pursuing the idea that the purpose of art lay in the finest experience of beauty.” The aesthetic novel combined stylistic bravura with a tendency toward candid treatment of taboo subjects. If the “sensations and ideas” that motivate the protagonist in Pater’s *Marius the Epicurean* do not form part of a “morally purposeful plot,” they more than compensate by heightening the “responsiveness to beauty.” The ethics of pleasure, “modern Cyrenaicism,” motivates the aesthetic novel, whether in the Gothic and supernatural form of *Dorian Gray* or in the “campy poetics” of Richard Firbank, whose aestheticism is the “perverse apogee” of a style of dissident desire that characterizes the aesthetic novel at large.

Literary impressionism also sought to redefine the role of perception in literature, but focused less on sensationalism and excess than on the refinement of language in the pursuit of capturing the “fleeting impression,” as Walter Pater described it.⁴³ Paul Armstrong shows that “the impressionist project began with a desire to radicalize the aesthetic of realism by exposing and thematizing its epistemological conditions of possibility.” Like Anne Fernihough and Enda Duffy in this volume, Armstrong draws on William James, a key theorist behind modernist conceptions of consciousness and self-consciousness, to argue that the doubleness of the impressionist viewpoint conjoins two ways of *being*: immersion in another’s consciousness and a simultaneous awareness of “the disjunctions between its hold on the world and other points of view that would construe things differently.” Cognitive pattern making, or “consistency building,” is “a temporal process of projecting expectations about pattern that are then modified, refined, or overturned.” As James liked to remark, “we live forwards, . . . but we understand backwards.”⁴⁴

Aestheticism and impressionism developed innovative ways of using *sensation* to convey the empirical dimensions of the represented world (Andrei Belyi’s *Petersburg* [1913–14] is a good example of this). Styles preeminent in conveying interiority and

consciousness – impressionism, stream of consciousness, free-indirect discourse – helped to give shape and form to the ironic conjunctions and surprising dislocations of literary decorum that are the staples of anti-mimetic fiction. Early French and Russian modernists took the Real to be the central problem. Jean-Michel Rabaté unpacks an obscure observation that Proust made early in his career: “We stand in front of the novelist as slaves in front the Emperor: with one word, he can set us free (*il peut nous affranchir*).”⁴⁵ Rabaté argues that the “fictional universes” of writers such as Édouard Dujardin permitted the novelist the freedom to “become someone else: a general, a weaver, a singer, a peasant.” Here again we see an emphasis on everyday life – *Le quotidien si précieux à saisi* – that enables a shift from post-symbolist experimentation to an “ethical modernism” in which “daring experimentation with values dominated.” André Gide, Guillaume Apollinaire, and Jules Romains feature in this tradition of modernism in which the author is a liberating force. By the time Proust starts writing the *Recherche*, the novel has become a “layered space of writing” in which all subjects are set free from their usual positions. The “confusion of self and book” that Rabaté finds in the *Recherche* embodies the freedom of the modernist novel, in which “we experience other lives by proxy” and “leave our cares and selves behind in a giddy superabundance of freedom.”

Leonid Livak’s chapter reminds us that experimental approaches to the Real do not always align themselves with a modernist ethos. In the USSR, “modernism” was a term of abuse and a catchall concept that functioned as Soviet culture’s foil. Livak evades this pejorative sense of the modern and offers a fresh view of the role Russian novels played in advancing the techniques and values of modernist fiction. At the heart of Russian experimentalism is a “new sensibility” “predicated on uncertainty and instability.” This sensibility arises from an “apocalyptic sense of decline and concomitant quest for transcendence” and a desire through experiment to move “*a realibus ad realiora*, from the real to the more real.” Belyi’s *Petersburg* exerted a tremendous “modernizing” influence by using language as “reality-generating medium.” His use of surrealism together with

the more realist style of the *roman à clef* produced a hybrid form that was grounded in the traditions of Russian fiction, yet responded to the call of the avant-garde. His work was especially important for young émigré writers such as Vladimir Nabokov, who drew on a number of literary models and molded a modernist style out of experimentalism with the “new sensibility” itself. This self-reflexive turn is a general tendency in modernist novels that reject mimesis and resemblance as foundational principles – and that draw from language new forms of resemblance for a new sensorium.

Part II: Realism in Transition

Aesthetic and literary movements in early modernism are founded on transition, often violent, abrupt, oppositional, and critical transition. The transition from the heyday of nineteenth-century realist fiction to the bold innovations of the early modernist novel has been a cornerstone in our understanding of the emergence of modernism. As we have seen in [Part I](#), early modernism was a time of widespread reassessment of what actually constituted the “real” and “reality” and how this reassessment was expressed in novelistic terms. [Part II](#) continues this exploration, with an emphasis on the reassessment of realism itself, which is perhaps the most important feature of transition in early modernism.

William Dean Howells articulates the case for realism plainly: “realism is nothing more and nothing less than the truthful treatment of material,” he writes, a means “to depict things as they are, life as it is.”⁴⁶ Howells’s call is the logical and aesthetic limit of nineteenth-century novelistic realism, diametrically opposed to the early modernists who did not believe that a call for the “truthful treatment of material” and the depiction of “life as it is” could remain credible so long as there was radical disagreement over what constituted the novelist’s “material.” Virginia Woolf declared that realists were concerned only with the accurate description of material life, while the “spiritualists” were concerned with life “as it really is” – “a luminous halo, a semi-transparent envelope surrounding us from beginning of consciousness to the end.”⁴⁷ Bradshaw reconsiders the

debate between Woolf and the Edwardian realists, especially Arnold Bennett and H. G. Wells, and begins by establishing that the debate was not between opposing sides (conventional realism vs. experimental modernism) but between peers in a tumultuous and rapidly changing literary *habitus*. Woolf and the Edwardians were equally opposed to a “repressive literary culture,” and if we think of modernism in terms of resistance to such a culture, then Wells’s *Ann Veronica* (1909) should be read as a modernist text “because of its groundbreaking candor” about sexuality and gender – a quality that aligns it with Joyce’s *Dubliners*. Though Woolf pits modernist “spiritualists” against Edwardian materialists in her hugely influential essay “Modern Fiction” (1921), she was much closer to being a “materialist” than she thought. “Deftly and discreetly,” Bradshaw concludes, “yet no less ardently than her Edwardian old guard, Woolf was intent on making her reader reflect on ‘real things beneath the show.’”

Howard Booth illustrates another dimension to the Edwardian/modernist debate, one that seems to have provoked developments in the fiction of D. H. Lawrence and E. M. Forster. Booth links the need to experiment with representations of reality within a tradition of radical thought. “Their texts look for alternatives to modernity,” Booth writes, and these alternatives were “often figured in terms of the organic, and a full connection to the surrounding world – a life, in short, beyond alienation.” Forster’s *Maurice* and Lawrence’s *Lady Chatterley’s Lover*, in very different ways employ outlawed forms of sexual desire and sexual identity in an attempt to offer new modes of development and community. The “good style” of French aestheticism was rejected by Lawrence and Forster, Booth argues; they rejected “compensatory structures of art” in favor of “reparative” forms and styles that could stand as alternatives to an oppressive canon of literary forms.

This reparative spirit runs through American fiction, as Janet Casey and Deborah Clarke show in chapters that argue for the political potential behind what Alain Locke, theorist of the Harlem Renaissance, calls “enlightened realism” and the transformative potential of the everyday, particularly as it is expressed in domestic contexts. In Willa Cather’s work, Casey argues, realism is an

undercurrent – “more accurately, perhaps, a persistent *overcurrent* – that unites superficially disparate schools of modernist fiction, especially on the American scene.” The “middlebrow novel,” African-American fiction, and Depression-era socialist fiction all employ realism tactically to overcome the limits of the dominant “reality.” The revolutionary character of these texts stems from their refusal to legitimize the dominant social world. If they used realist styles, it was “a conscious, meaningful social-aesthetic choice within the context of modernism.”

Clarke’s analysis of the domestic in Edith Wharton, Willa Cather, and Nella Larsen takes a similarly broad view of American writing in a chapter that reassesses the importance of the everyday world – particularly that which has been gendered feminine under the category “domestic” – and the way this reactivates realism for modernism. “Wharton’s exploration of a modernist domesticity,” Clarke writes, “not only reflects . . . the emptiness of modern life but also illustrates that the ‘ordinary’ domestic enterprise provides not a refuge but an intensification of that emptiness.” Modernism *is* domestic, we might say, and this point is especially powerful in the “heterodox modernism” of Nella Larsen, who imbricates consumerism with race and identity, thereby resignifying modernist domesticity as “a space for women to participate in modernity – or to underscore their exclusion from it – and to establish that modernity and domesticity are mutually dependent, not mutually exclusive.”

Part III: The Matter of Modernism

Impressionism, aestheticism, early forms of free indirect style, stream of consciousness – these approaches to the new sensorium of late modernity made possible forms of realism more sensitive to the object world and to lived experience. Ironically, it is very often the case that an appeal to just such quantities – objects, things, bodies – in the modernist novel enables a canny misrecognition, the deliberate refusal to default to known *cognitions* of the object world around us. This refusal in turn calls into question the terms of *re-cognition* (of truth, of authenticity) that govern our experience of material existence.

Enda Duffy explores how we process this world from a scientific perspective and sees a general movement from muscle to nerves. An “altered model of the subject” emerges that resists state-sponsored fantasies of authentic being. He claims that “modernism’s radical move is to lose interest in conventional trajectories of subjective feeling, to attend instead to human energy and its expenditure. ‘Deep feeling’ is replaced by the ideal of a life lived intensely. Why did this change occur?” The answer, put simply, is that we became more aware of new sensory experiences. William James again emerges as a crucial theorist of modernism who refuses to salvage emotion in humanist terms. Duffy argues that modernists such as Joyce and Woolf dwell “on energy expenditure rather than accounts of how emotions were developed, altered, matured.” The radical recasting of emotion that we see in these “stress texts” raises big questions: “Do they teach the reader how to manage ‘stress’?” Or do the challenge “the very presumptions about the relation of organism to environment upon which the category of ‘stress’ was conceived?”

These questions are raised with understandable urgency by novelists who focus on the body, particularly the body’s traumatic reaction to war. Anne Fernihough examines novels by Woolf, H.D., and Rebecca West, who responded to war from “indirect” (or “civilian”) perspectives and forged “a version of the modernist novel that incorporates elements of materialism rather than repudiating it completely.” In Woolf’s criticism as in West’s *Return of the Soldier*, materialism is used against itself “in order to counter what [Woolf and West] think of as a specifically masculine worldview.” In West’s novel, Chris, the shell-shocked protagonist, fails to read the “material signs” that his wife so astutely understands, and for this reason emerges as a “modernist in the making.” Woolf, H.D., and especially West are caught up in the dialectical engagement of convention and innovation, which enables them to move beyond the limited materialism of the Edwardians and to reflect on the impact of war on women’s daily life, on the “continuity between civilian and military experience, showing how war, far from protecting the domestic sphere, turns it into a war zone in its own right.”

The questions raised by Duffy and Fernihough, which echo questions raised throughout this volume, concern how the novel manages our increased sensitivity to the material world, how it selects and organizes from among so many new objects of our attention. Serial and magazine publication and translation, though not modernist innovations, became the site of innovations that involved the very materiality of the novel itself. In modernism, the materiality of text and textual production, marketing, and consumption freely and intimately enter into the writing *and reading* experience in unprecedented ways.⁴⁸ This contextual intimacy reproduces the lived experience of the novel, reconfiguring the limits of its engagement with the literary marketplace. The rise of an increasingly sophisticated print culture, which came on the heels of the New Journalism and the technological and editorial transformations of the 1880s, had a profound effect on how novels were read (through serialization) and written (through the incorporation of journalistic styles). As David Earle argues in [Part IV](#), modernists couldn't help being influenced by a popular marketplace that they often disparaged. This is because, as Sean Latham argues, "magazines run through the very DNA of modernism." The literary marketplace in the modernist epoch was a complex network of exchange and circulation that linked modernist writers with global audiences. Faulkner and Joyce were fascinated by the temporal possibilities of serial publication and by the focus on everyday life that magazines promoted and sustained. The spatial form of the magazine exemplified a "modernist aesthetics of juxtaposition, recombination, and montage." And these "are not merely aesthetic effects," Latham writes. "They are instead essential to the medium of the periodicals."

Seriality is a continuous material transition, the matter of one text bearing on and becoming the matter of another. Translation is another modality of this *bearing on another* that, in modernism, takes on a truly collaborative, sometimes conflictual or resistant, character. Translation raises tough questions about that other sort of *matter* – the *subject matter* of a text – that may or may not get "lost." Emily Wittman's meditation on modernist translations and translators emphasizes the material texture of language and the struggle to

translate one language into another. She argues that “the modernist novel with its exploration of internal landscapes” owes much to Constant Garnett’s translations of Russian fiction and to James Strachey’s translations of Freud. Strachey’s style of “literal” or “quasi-scriptural” translations “expanded the English language, broadened the thematic scope of the modernist novel to include new and often scandalous topics, and offered readers and critics of these novels compelling new interpretive tools.” Beckett more than any other modernist expresses the ambivalence and frustration of translation, which he found “subjectively impossible” and “likened to the experience of constipation.” He speaks of translation in ways that suggest the materiality not so much of the text as of the process. Language takes on a fungible, object quality in translation, so that his French original becomes “decantable” into English. In translation, Beckett confronts the unforgiving limits of language as an artistic medium.

Part IV: Modernism, Genre, and Form

Modernism’s maturity is often associated with great modernist styles, the inimitable linguistic achievements of the cultural elite – which Fredric Jameson describes as “[t]hose formerly subversive and embattled styles.”⁴⁹ “Subversive” and “embattled” describe well a group of writers in the 1920s and 1930s – from Joyce to Woolf, from Proust to Stein, from Lawrence to Forster, from Bowen to Hemingway, from Kafka to H.D. – who, according to Baldick, sought to escape “the imaginary tyrant of novelistic custom.”⁵⁰ Baldick suggests not so much an animus against realism as against the realist novel that tended to affirm, often without reflection, dominant social norms and political values. The “inward turn” that characterizes so much “high” modernism is less about cultivating inner life as it is about building a bulwark to protect that life from hostile social conditions. The tyranny of conventional realist “custom” tended to duplicate these conditions in imaginative forms; the modernists resisted these conditions and celebrated, with Stephen Dedalus, the “mild proud sovereignty” of an “inner world of

individual emotions mirrored perfectly in a lucid supple periodic prose.”⁵¹ The “inward turn,” as Ritchie Robertson shows in his chapter, does not do away with the *reality* of social conditions, but refocuses artistic attention on them; inner culture is increasingly ironic, self-aware, mercurial, tied more to the senses and their enjoyment of them than to any ideal sense of achieved *Bildung*. The early modernist narratives of Arthur Schnitzler, for example, follow in a line of development from Ernst Mach and Nietzsche that emphasizes the interrelation of sensations and consciousness. Schnitzler, in a manner similar to Kafka and Hermann Hesse, breaks decisively “with fictional realism by letting their protagonists experience a ‘reality’ whose relation to the everyday world is an insoluble problem. Thus the relation between ‘inner’ and ‘outer’ becomes an enigma.”

Schnitzler’s stream-of-consciousness style and the “strange mixture of realism and exotic fantasy” depend on the logic of pastiche to create new contexts for shaping mythic intensities. Thomas Mann is especially important for our understanding of how such intensities can be conveyed in sophisticated pastiche styles. As Todd Kontje shows, the modernism of Mann’s *Doctor Faustus* and *Magic Mountain* is strongly determined by Nietzsche’s response to Richard Wagner and his formulation of the Apollo/Dionysius dialectic. Techniques such as “essayism” and montage serve a deflationary or ironic function in narratives that give free reign to “the speculative bubble of abstract discussions and pseudo-philosophical debates” that are punctured by rectifying returns to realism. Like the “new sensibility” of Russian modernist fiction, they created “reality effects” that layered tradition and innovation. Thus Mann “spackles a layer of realistic stucco over the bricks of his modernist montage.” The return to myth in *Doctor Faustus* similarly creates “the structuring framework of a story” that makes use of realist notation to supply “plausible detail.”

The politics of Mann’s tactical application of realism have to do with a refusal to allow narrative to serve a representational function in support of totalitarian thought. Modernists rejected the realist novel on just these grounds — that is, it legitimized the liberal democratic

principles that created a commodified consumer culture. Yet, as Sam Alexander shows, the realist novel very often fought against the worst tendencies of liberal democracy and the laissez faire marketplace, and modernists had much to learn from the solutions offered by their Victorian forebears. His chapter illustrates this struggle by exploring character selection and sense of proportion (i.e., the relative weight given to protagonists and “minor” characters) in Joyce and John Dos Passos in light of their indebtedness to Charles Dickens and William Makepeace Thackeray. The “Wandering Rocks” episode of *Ulysses* is thus “a continuation of the realist effort to contrast antidemocratic institutions with democratic form,” and *U.S.A.*, a compendium of styles that exploits “the notational capacity of realism to overturn the imperative toward selection at the heart of realist representation.” The “democratic ethos” of the modernist novel recovers something of the radical intent of nineteenth-century realists.

When Jameson speaks of the “unique, unmistakable style” of the “high” modernists, he links it to “a unique vision of the world.” He speaks of a modernist style and vision as one’s possession, “as incomparable as [one’s] own body.”⁵² Recent scholarship on the modernist novel has expanded what counts as a “unique vision” and has come to recognize more fully the wealth of styles and generic permutations that effectively democratize the “mild proud sovereignty” of the subject. Indeed, Joyce himself helped effect this shift in *Ulysses*, as Alexander points out. Joyce’s shrewdness when it came to the literary marketplace was shared by many of his contemporaries. The genre novel, the pulp novel, the society novel, the novel in serial offered new standpoints for understanding reality; innovation could now depend on how reality was stylized in the logic of new media and new modes of distribution. As we see in the early modernist novel in Russia, the stylization of reality comes to serve the aim of simulating the Real. The modernist genre novel exploited the generative potential of the mass media marketplace to create forms that combined innovative style and narrative arrangement with popular and formulaic fictional modes (westerns, romance, adventure, crime, and so on). In the modernist genre novel, David

Earle argues, experimentalism inhabits popular media in self-referential ways that not only critique the high/low distinction in the culture industry but enable a reflection on the author's own commerciality. Faulkner and Hemingway, Earle writes, "relied heavily upon popular forms yet have unquestionably been canonized as modernists." Their genre novels, like the pulp avant-garde, are part of "a shadow history of modernism," rooted in a "complex relationship to popular culture and mass audience."

A "shadow history" is precisely what H.D.'s experimental historical fictions offer. Lara Vetter lays much needed emphasis on the historical novel in modernism and shows that H.D. resists "a certain vision of modernism as ahistorical." H.D. uses historical narrative to articulate the experience of trauma at wartime. The early "Hipparchia" (published in 1926) and her later novel *The Sword Went Out to Sea: (Synthesis of a Dream)* by Delia Alton (completed in 1947) constitute a form of historical fiction that explores "how personal trauma is embedded in larger nationalist and imperialist narratives." The "experimental, highly fractured style" of *Sword* "situates the present and the past as equal parts of a static equation." In the historical imbrications of "Hipparchia" and in the "deconstruction of the self/other binary" that structures *Sword*, Vetter identifies a form of modernist historicism that weaves the "mild proud sovereignty" of the self into existing historical narratives.⁵³ The history of the other becomes the history of oneself.

Part V: Modernism in Transit

The history of the modernist novel is the history of a fountain, an upsurge of formal innovations and hybrid formations, generic permutations and offshoots, pastiche and performative styles – all of which illustrate nothing less than modernism in motion, in transit across periods, canons, cultural traditions, and geographical borders and spaces. Modernism is "joy in motion," as Calvin Bedient has declared.⁵⁴ It is filled with a Nietzschean sense of affirmation, an acceptance of the world as "the eternally self-creating, the eternally self-destroying . . . joy of the circle."⁵⁵ Motion implicates modernism

and the modernist novel in ever expanding and deepening global literary traditions; at the same time, it opens narrative to the matter of everyday life, modes of travel, of *being* in transit. The modernist novel in its maturity rejects an instrumentalist notion of temporality (e.g., time as a framework for narrative and plot, for *Bildung*) and embraces impressionistic and subjectivist alternatives that do not abolish time so much as draw upon it as the raw material for new orientations toward “what is past, or passing, or to come.”⁵⁶ On this view, the celebration of present experience – what is “passing,” Benjamin’s “now-time” (*Jetztzeit*) – acknowledges that what matters in time is memory, reflection, digression, pause, reversal, lag, and other temporal permutations. In her chapter, Pamela Caughie explores the links between new sensory experiences and the “time-sense” of the twentieth century, which is best exemplified in the experimental fictions of Gertrude Stein and Nella Larsen. “The drag upon the senses produced by old habits of seeing” she writes, “that lag between what one is capable of seeing, or sensing, and what is ‘being seen’ or felt is the substance of the modernist novel.” Larsen’s *Passing*, like Stein’s “Melanctha,” models a constellational temporality, the “endless repetition of the average” that Stein likened to the “continual or continuous present.” Like Deborah Clarke, Caughie registers Larsen’s challenge to racism and how it shapes consumerism and her protagonist’s desire. She also registers the fundamental importance of “everyday structures” in any attempt to break “old habits of seeing.”

As the contributors to [Part V](#) show, the “experience of being modern” that Caughie sees as a shaping force in modernist literature is a *global* phenomenon. Postcolonial, transnational, and global conceptions of novel form and development have had a profound impact on how we write literary history and how we assess national literary traditions.⁵⁷ Jessica Berman shows how modernist writers “use their narratives to create ‘cosmopolitan communities’ . . . not bounded by the limits of national belonging.” In a similar way, Winkiel looks at how world-systems theory “integrates different kinds of institutions and material practices across times and spaces without eliminating their specificities, hierarchies, or the possibilities

of change.” Her comparison of Joyce and the South African novelist Solomon Plaatje illustrates how the specificities of location encourage rather than inhibit a global connection with other modernists. The Cape Colony, depicted in a complex double temporality (in 1830 and 1910) in Plaatje’s *Mhudi*, is very different from Dublin, circa 1900, Winkiel notes, but both writers exhibit “a similar disjunction between realist detail and generic disruption.” For Berman and Winkiel, locality is freed from the idealist stranglehold of the nation and liberated into the more open horizon of a global context. A modernist aesthetics, Winkiel writes, allows us to see the everyday, the quotidian as a global condition “produced by forces and materials both near *and* far.”

The modernist cosmopolitanism that Berman advocates, which redefines transnationalism as a familiar and disjunctive geography, in a similar way assumes a global frame of reference and a sense of history that is dislocated from imperialist geopolitics. “Henry James’s cosmopolitanism,” Berman writes, is emblematic of a modernist aspiration to get beyond “the dichotomies of home and world, nation and globe,” to create “new models of transnational belonging at once rooted and dislocated.” The Indian novelist Mulk Raj Anand learned the same attitude toward the world through his experience of “the constraints and injustices of British imperialism,” which gave him “a nuanced appreciation of the value of the cosmopolitan argument for anticolonial work.” His *Coolie* uses a defamiliarizing style to show how the protagonist’s inner life is bound up with a response to the “conditions of the impoverished and disenfranchised in late-colonial India.” The materialist emphasis in Anand reflects a larger global trend that links the modernist novel to postcolonial and transnational fictions.

The aspiration toward global inclusion takes a different form in Ireland. As Terry Eagleton has observed, Ireland’s place in the imperial world was characterized by uneven development, with “an archaic moral superstructure” (the Gaelo-Catholic) alongside “an increasingly modern base” (the Anglo-Irish Protestants). This “modern base” performed the functions of a ruling class, but did so badly – Eagleton calls the Anglo-Irish an “atavistic throwback to an earlier phase of the English gentry.”⁵⁸ Yet for all that they provided a link to a larger world and helped to develop a transnational Irish novel that is,

to use Berman's phrase, at once rooted and dislocated. From the time of Somerville and Ross in the 1890s, the Anglo-Irish Big House novel has dramatized the central contradiction of modernism, particularly in Ireland, for it features a social class at once rooted, chthonic, but also mobile, transitory. The house itself manages to convey both safety and menace at the same time, as if these structures, besieged by revolutionary nationalist forces and the depredations of time, asserted themselves against the "filthy modern tide" merely by virtue of a unifying design.⁵⁹ Nicholas Allen points out that this tradition is rooted in imperialism, but that studies of Irish modernism neglect the importance of the Big House as a pivot point in the history of Ireland and Irish culture. "The greater idea of empire," Allen writes, "was the decoration of the world within the home space." The "miscellaneous world" that these aristocratic homes organize, as a bulwark against historical chaos, constitutes a conflict zone. Novels as different as Elizabeth Bowen's *The Last September* and Beckett's *Watt* use a stripped-down notational style to convey with often cruel clarity the ambiguous social and cultural milieu of the Big House, where "the present is a bleached out moment in which the traces of the past are still visible." Danielstown, the Big House in Bowen's novel, embodies the colonial system that it simultaneously undermines through an ironic recasting of its function.

That we find definite traces of this aesthetic in Beckett's *Watt* testifies to the resilience of the Big House and the colonial system that serves as both context and whetstone for Irish identity. For Allen, Knott's house in *Watt*, like Danielstown, is "a local phase of global transition." He argues that both houses "are sites of evacuation. Each holds fragmentary signs of the presence of a world order whose points of contact with local history have moved on after their dislocation." Reading these fragmentary signs is the specialty of a literature governed by a politics of failure. This is Patrick Bixby's main point about the late modernist fiction of Flann O'Brien and Beckett, that they demarcate a "late modernist disposition . . . a complex admixture of diffidence and derision." The seeming failure of the late modernist in terms of the modernist project is signaled in parodic responses to Joyce that call into question "the notion of a

unique modernist style (and the attendant notion of a coherent individual subject)” and “the styles in which Ireland has been imagined.” The challenge to artistic and political authority in Beckett’s *Watt* and O’Brien’s *The Third Policeman* succeeds because they are able to register flickering realities or states of being, the queer temporalities at play across “unstable ontological boundaries.”

Beckett’s *Watt*, composed in the mid-1940s while the author wiled away his time resisting the Nazis, is an exemplary late modernist text. It gives narrative form to the temporalities of belatedness: not the “coming too late” sense of being deprived of something, not the negation of what came before that results from this late arrival, but a condition in which one is never on time within a modernist moment, a condition made possible by the kinds of temporal overlap, recursivity and prolepsis that are hallmarks of modernist narrative from the start. My own meditation on the “destinies of *Bildung*,” is an alternative reading of how time determines character formation, one that uncovers a progressively more experimental rescue operation aimed at redefining *Bildung* in terms of an aspiration – achieved in each moment – that drives the subject rather than an ideal or model that only belatedly and inadequately makes sense of experience in terms of a completed achievement. From the 1880s, when Olive Schreiner published *The Story of an African Farm*, to the time of Beckett’s *Three Novels*, this aspiration redefines *failing* as an opportunity to thrive and belatedness as a “befitting emblem of adversity.”⁶⁰ In modernism, for perhaps the first time, belatedness – experience coming after and obeying a model; an ideal that promises to crown experience at a later time – is recognized as the authentic condition of *Bildung*.

The palpable “darkening” of Europe that nearly surmounted reason in late modernity – the “sabboath night of falling angles somewhere in Erio”⁶¹ – defined the historical conditions of late modernism. It is not surprising that the nadir of realist fiction occurs precisely at this time, the late 1930s through the early 1950s, when the very notion of the Real and what constitutes normative experience of reality was under attack. “Never in all its history,” Lukács wrote in 1948, “did mankind so urgently require a realist literature as it does to-day. And perhaps never before have the traditions of great realism

been so deeply buried under a rubble of social and artistic prejudice.”⁶² Even when buried alive realism remains part and parcel of modernist developments, though in the late phase, we see a resurgence of techniques and temporalities (e.g., multiple narrators, cubist arrangement, nonlinear and intersecting loops, recursive patterns, memorial zones, self-reflection, prolepsis and metalepsis, metafiction) associated with anti-mimetic art. As Tyrus Miller suggests, to speak of late modernism, “we would have to speak of a *failure* to repress, a failure of the forms to contain the turbulent historical energies that sweep through late modernist works. These works are perforated and torn by their relation to history.”⁶³ Indeed, Bixby and I say flat out that failure and failing need to be reevaluated as engines of narrative development that lie outside the dialectics of achieved selfhood and social success.

The modernist novel in transit challenges conventions of narrative at the same time that it defies national, ethnic, linguistic, temporal, and geographical boundaries; it challenges conventional aesthetic values and techniques, but freely appropriates them as part of the challenge. Late modernism amplifies this sense of permanent transition, of never-ending experimental fervor. The lacerating minimalism of Beckett’s prose (which is, nevertheless, full to brimming with lyrical voices) weaves along and beside the carnivalesque lunacy of Flann O’Brien (which is no less lacerating), while grand myth making lies side by side with pedantic “essayism” in Thomas Mann. We see the subtle formal and stylistic ironies of Bowen and Kate O’Brien as well as the blunt-edged vamping that takes Faulkner’s genre novels into the age of mechanical reproduction. And we see generally a return to realism and the matter of the world of representation in ways that echo the practices of early modernists who sought to overcome a false divide between modernism and realism, between the world of artistic expression and the world of representation, between ideal beauty and its downfall. *A History of the Modernist Novel* shows how innovation emerges continuously on both sides of a divide that is not really a divide at all, but the banks of one stream — *modernism in motion*.

Notes

1. Virginia Woolf, *The Diary of Virginia Woolf*, ed. Anne Olivier Bell, assisted by Andrew McNeillie, vol. 2, 1920–24 (London: Hogarth Press, 1980), 161. Qtd. in David Bradshaw's chapter.
2. On the website of *Modernism/Modernity*, the flagship journal of the "new modernist studies," the editors note that journal concentrates "on the period extending roughly from 1860 to the mid-twentieth century." For the purposes of this *History*, which concerns a single genre, rather than a cultural movement (modernism), the 1880s strike me as a reasonable starting point and the early 1950s a good place to stop. It would take another volume to explore the global modernist novel in the late twentieth century.
3. M. M. Bakhtin, *The Dialogic Imagination*, ed. Michael Holquist, trans. Caryl Emerson and Michael Holquist (Austin, TX: University of Austin Press, 1981), 3, 31.
4. Chris Baldick, *The Modern Movement: 1910–1940*, vol. 10 of *The Oxford English Literary History* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004), 5.
5. *Ibid.*, 160.
6. *Ibid.*, 196. On the various kinds of realism, see *ibid.*, chapters 7–9 and 391–401.
7. See, e.g., Fredric Jameson, who speaks of modernism and postmodernism as "two chronological sequels to the moment of realism" in *The Antinomies of Realism* (London: Verso, 2013), 11.
8. Virginia Woolf, *A Writer's Diary*, ed. Leonard Woolf (New York: New American Library, 1968), 65–6.
9. Woolf, *The Diary of Virginia Woolf*, vol. 2, 161.
10. On the importance of "everyday life" – and the object matter encountered in lived experience – see Henri Lefebvre, *Critique of Everyday Life*, 2 vols, trans. John Moore (London and New York: Verso, 1991), and Ben Highmore, *Everyday Life and Cultural Theory: An Introduction* (London: Routledge, 2002).
11. The Real, in Jacques Lacan's sense, designates that which lies beyond our imaginary and symbolic ways of knowing the world. Within modernist aesthetics, the Real serves as an alternative to "reality," to the "real world," and to the "reality effects" that realist fiction offer up as resemblance. On the Real, see Buch, *The Pathos of the Real* (Baltimore, MD: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 2010), 8–15, and Slavoj Žižek, "Psychoanalysis and the Lacanian Real: 'Strange Shapes of the Unwarped Primal World,'" in *A Concise Companion to Realism*, ed. Matthew Beaumont (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2010), 225–41.

12. Theodor W. Adorno, *Minima Moralia: Reflections from Damaged Life*, trans. E. F. N. Jephcott (1951; repr. London: Verso, 2005), 227. Jean-François Lyotard defines “innovation” as a condition of efficiency within modern technical knowledge systems, part of a “command system bent on efficiency,” and offers an alternative in *paralogy*, “a move . . . played in the pragmatics of knowledge” (*The Postmodern Condition: A Report on Knowledge*, trans. Geoff Bennington and Brian Massumi [Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1984], 60–1). I use “innovation” in the sense of a movement into the new, an impulse to trump the known thing, which is suggested by its derivation from Latin *innovatus*, past participle of *innovare* “to renew, restore; to change.” The middle French, *renovacyoun* “spiritual rebirth,” also “rebuilding, reconstruction,” lingers in the sense of an artistic or critical practice that aims for spiritual and cultural rebirth (as in Irish Revival) or national self-renewal (which is a dominant strand in Irish, German, and Russian modernist fiction). (*Online Etymology Dictionary*, http://www.etymonline.com/index.php?term=innovate&allowed_in_frame=0) (accessed July 17, 2014).
13. Samuel Beckett, *Three Novels: Molloy, Malone Dies, The Unnamable*, trans. Paul Bowles and Samuel Beckett (New York: Grove Press, 2009), 347.
14. On the *expressed* and *represented* worlds, see Mikel Dufrenne, *The Phenomenology of Aesthetic Experience*, trans. E. S. Casey et al. (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 1966), 166–98.
15. *Ibid.*, 175.
16. For Jean-Luc Marion, an object (“phenomenon”) reveals itself “unconditionally” in its givenness, in a “pure initiative of appearing”; see Jean-Luc Marion, *Being Given: Toward a Phenomenology of Givenness*, trans. Jeffrey L. Kosky (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2002), 174–5. See also Arne Melberg, *Theories of Mimesis* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995); the essays in *A Concise Companion to Realism*, ed. Matthew Beaumont (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2010); and the special issue on peripheral realisms of *Modern Language Quarterly* 73, no. 3 (September 2012).
17. For Dufrenne, the aesthetic object, through the sensuousness of style, displays its truth in the Real. In addition to this self-evident truth, the aesthetic object is true because it “takes on the original *function* of truth, which is to precede the real in order to illuminate it, not to repeat it” (528; my emphasis). On the narrative contract and the broader political context of social-contract theory, see Carnell, *Partisan Politics*.
18. See D. A. Miller, *The Novel and the Police* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1988), and Nancy Armstrong, *Desire and Domestic Fiction: A Political History of the Novel* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1987).

19. On narrative point of view in the realist novel, see Wayne Booth, *The Rhetoric of Fiction*, 2nd ed. (1966; repr. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1983).
20. On “modernist realism,” see Jameson, *The Antinomies of Realism*, 3–20. See also Alexander’s discussion in the present volume of the realist inheritance in Joyce and Dos Passos.
21. Arthur Power, *Conversations with James Joyce*, ed. Clive Hart (London: Millington, 1974), 32.
22. Sir Philip Sidney, *The Defense of Poesy*, ed. R. W. Maslen, 3rd ed. (Manchester, UK: Manchester University Press, 2002), 85.
23. Beckett, *Three Novels* 9.
24. Virginia Woolf, *Mrs. Dalloway*, ed. Mark Hussey (New York: Harcourt, 2005), 4.
25. Viktor Shklovskii’s theories of defamiliarization and the “device of style” and Vladimir Propp’s understanding of how character, action, and theme interact in folklore, set the stage for later structuralist theories of narrative; see Shklovskii, *Theory of Prose*, trans. Benjamin Sher (1925; repr. Elmwood Park, IL: Dalkey Archive Press, 1990), and Propp, *Morphology of the Fairy Tale*, ed. Louis A. Wagner, trans. Laurence Scott, 2nd rev. ed. (1928; repr. Austin: University of Texas Press, 1968). Narrative theorists such as Gérard Genette have much to say about the novel from a structuralist perspective. Wayne Booth’s *Rhetoric of Fiction*, though concerned with formal elements, is at bottom interested in the rhetorical and ethical structures of narrative acts. For an overview, see Gregory Castle and Matthew Dubord, “Narrative Theory and Theory of the Novel,” in *The Encyclopedia of Literary and Cultural Theory*, vol. 1, 1900–1966, ed. Gregory Castle (Oxford: Blackwell, 2011), 346–56.
26. Georg Lukács, *The Theory of the Novel*, trans. Anna Bostock (1920; repr. Cambridge, MA: M.I.T. Press, 1971), 73.
27. Georg Lukács, *Studies in European Realism* (1948; repr. New York: Grosset and Dunlap, 1964), 4.
28. Bakhtin’s *Problems of Dostoevsky’s Poetics* (ed. and trans. Caryl Emerson [Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1984]) was first published in 1929. The essays in Bakhtin’s *Dialogic Imagination* (ed. Michael Holquist, trans. Caryl Emerson and Michael Holquist [Austin, TX: University of Austin Press, 1981]) were written in the late 1930s and 1940s.
29. Walter Benn Michaels, *The Gold Standard and the Logic of Naturalism: American Literature at the Turn of the Century* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1987).
30. See Paul Armstrong, in this volume, on the concept “qualia.” On the phenomenological approach to the modernist novel, see J. Hillis Miller,

- Fiction and Repetition* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1982), and Paul Armstrong, *The Phenomenology of Henry James* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1983), and *The Challenge of Bewilderment: Understanding and Representation in James, Conrad, and Ford* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1987).
31. Raymond Williams, *The Long Revolution* (New York: Columbia University Press; London: Chatto & Windus, 1961), 48, 63.
 32. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar, *The Madwoman in the Attic: The Woman Writer and the Nineteenth-Century Literary Imagination*, 2nd ed. (New Haven, CT, and London: Yale University Press, 1979, 2000); Nancy Armstrong, *Desire and Domestic Fiction: A Political History of the Novel* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1987).
 33. See Homi Bhabha, ed., *Narrative and Nation* (London: Routledge, 1990), and “DissemiNation: Time, Narrative and the Margins of the Modern Nation,” in *The Location of Culture* (London and New York: Routledge, 1994), 199–244.
 34. John Kucich, *Imperial Masochism: British Fiction, Fantasy, and Social Class* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2007), and Jessica Berman, *Modernist Fiction, Cosmopolitanism and the Politics of Community* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001).
 35. Simon Gikandi, *Writing in Limbo: Modernism and Caribbean Literature* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1992); Neil Lazarus, *The Postcolonial Unconscious* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), 30–1. On the general question of a postcolonial modernism, see *Modernism and Colonialism: British and Irish Literature, 1899–1939*, eds. Richard Begam and Michael Valdez Moses (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2007).
 36. Michael Valdez Moses, *The Novel and the Globalization of Culture* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1995), vii.
 37. See Wallerstein, *The Modern World-System*, 3 vols. (New York: Academic Press, 1974), and *World Systems Analysis: An Introduction* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2004); Stephen Shapiro, *The Culture and Commerce of the Early American Novel: Reading the Atlantic World-System* (University Park: The Pennsylvania State University Press, 2008).
 38. Pascale Casanova, *The World Republic of Letters*, trans. M. B. DeBevoise (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2004), 108. The essays collected in *French Global: A New Approach to Literary History*, eds. McDonald, Christie and Susan Rubin Suleiman (New York: Columbia University Press, 2010) build on Casanova’s central formulation, the global nation.
 39. Casanova, *The World Republic of Letters*, 127.

40. See Michael McKeon, *The Origins of the English Novel, 1600–1740* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1987); Robert L. Caserio, *The Novel in England 1900–1950* (New York: Twayne Publishers; London: Prentice Hall, 1999); Patrick Parrinder, *Nation and Novel: The English Novel from Its Origins to the Present Day* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2006); Rachel Carnell, *Partisan Politics, Narrative Realism, and the Rise of the British Novel* (New York; Houndmills, UK: Palgrave Macmillan, 2006); Patrick Parrinder and Andrzej Gasiorek, eds., *The Oxford History of the Novel in English*, vol. 4, *The Reinvention of the British and Irish Novel 1880–1940* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011).
41. Bliss Perry, *A Study of Prose Fiction* (Boston and New York: Houghton, Mifflin, 1902), 241. Lukács says much the same thing almost forty years later when he notes that the “essence of true realism” involves “the great writer’s thirst for truth, his fanatic striving for reality” (*Studies* 11).
42. Oscar Wilde, *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, ed. Michael Patrick Gillespie, 2nd ed. (1890/91; repr. New York: Norton, 2007), 149.
43. See Pater’s Conclusion to *The Renaissance: Studies in Art and Poetry*, 2nd rev. ed. (London: Macmillan, 1877). On impressionism, see Jesse Matz, *Literary Impressionism and Modernist Aesthetics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001); and Max Saunders, “Literary Impressionism,” in *A Companion to Modernist Literature and Culture*, eds. David Bradshaw and Kevin J. H. Dettmar (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 2006), 204–11.
44. Cited in Armstrong, in this volume. James attributes this phrase to “a Danish thinker” whom his editors identify as Søren Kierkegaard.
45. Marcel Proust, “Le Pouvoir du Romancier” in *Contre Sainte-Beuve, Pastiches et Mélanges, Essais et Articles*, eds. Pierre Clarac and Yves Sandre (Paris: Gallimard, Pléiade, 1971), 413. The text can be dated from 1895 to 1900.
46. William Dean Howells, “Editor’s Study,” *Harper’s New Monthly Magazine* (November 1889): 966. Howells’ viewpoint is sustained by Perry, who writes, “Realistic fiction is that which does not shrink from the commonplace (although art dreads the commonplace) or the unpleasant (although the aim of art is to give pleasure) in its effort to depict things as they are, life as it is” (*A Study of Prose Fiction*, 229).
47. Virginia Woolf, “Modern Fiction,” in *The Essays of Virginia Woolf*, ed. Andrew McNeillie, vol. 4, 1925–28 (London: Hogarth Press, 1986), 160.
48. See, e.g., George Bornstein, *Material Modernism: The Politics of the Page* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2001), and Catherine Turner, *Marketing Modernism between the Two World Wars* (Amherst: University of Massachusetts Press, 2003).

49. Fredric Jameson, "Postmodernism and Consumer Society," in *The Cultural Turn: Selected Writings on the Postmodern: 1983–1998* (London: Verso, 1998), 6, 2.
50. Baldick, *The Modern Movement*, 160.
51. James Joyce, *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*, ed. John Paul Riquelme (New York: Norton, 2007), 145–6.
52. Jameson, "Postmodernism," 6.
53. A more disciplined form of this historicism, "the re-enactment of the past in present thought," was promoted in the 1940s by R. G. Collingwood, in *The Idea of History* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1946).
54. Calvin Bedient, *The Yeats Brothers and Modernism's Love of Motion* (South Bend, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2009), 77. On modernist dialectics and motion, see 170.
55. Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Will to Power*, ed. Walter Kaufmann, trans. Walter Kaufmann and R. J. Hollingdale (New York: Viking, 1968), sect. 1067.
56. W. B. Yeats, "Sailing to Byzantium," in *The Poems*, ed. Richard J. Finneran, vol. 1 of *The Collected Works of W. B. Yeats*, 2nd ed (New York: Macmillan, 1983, 1989), 198.
57. See Susan Stanford Friedman, "Periodizing Modernism: Postcolonial Modernities and the Space/Time Borders of Modernist Studies," *Modernism/Modernity* 13 (September 2006): 425–43; Douglas Mao and Rebecca L. Walkowitz, "The New Modernist Studies," *PMLA* 123 (May 2008): 737–48; and Laura Doyle and Laura Winkiel, eds., *Geomodernisms: Race, Modernism, Modernity* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2005).
58. Terry Eagleton, *Heathcliff and the Great Hunger: Studies in Irish Culture* (London and New York: Verso, 1995), 276, 58.
59. Yeats, "The Statues," in *The Poems*, 345.
60. Yeats, "Meditations in Time of Civil War" II, in *The Poems*, 206.
61. James Joyce, *Finnegans Wake* (New York: Viking, 1939), 21.
62. Lukács, *Studies* 18.
63. Tyrus Miller, *Late Modernism: Politics, Fiction, and the Arts Between the World Wars* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999), 32.

Modernism and the Challenge to the Real

*The Aesthetic Novel, from Ouida to Firbank**Joseph Bristow*

"It was Knockespotch," Mr. Scogan continued, "the great Knockespotch, who delivered us from the dreary tyranny of the realistic novel. My life, Knockespotch said, is not so long that I can afford to spend precious hours writing or reading descriptions of middle-class interiors. He said again, 'I am tired of seeing the social plenum; I prefer to paint it in a vacuum, freely and sportively bombinating.'"

Aldous Huxley, *Crome Yellow* (1921)

In his astute 1951 study of aesthetic novelist Ronald Firbank, Jocelyn Brooke maintains that Aldous Huxley probably had the gifted author of *Vainglory* (1915) and *Inclinations* (1916) in mind when, in *Crome Yellow*, Mr. Scogan speaks of the imaginary Knockespotch's unique narrative style: "Oh, those Tales – those Tales?" Scogan exclaims. "How shall I describe them? Fabulous characters shoot across the pages like gaily dressed performers on the trapeze . . . An immense erudition and an immense fancy go in hand."¹ "The verbal surface of his writing," he continues, "is rich and fantastically diversified. The wit is incessant."² The features that Scogan identifies – the idiosyncratic characters, the arresting scenes, the textured prose, and the inimitable wit – certainly typify the stylized movement of Firbank's finest novels. As Brooke points out, it is not uncommon to encounter exorbitant descriptions of the following kind in Firbank's beautifully wrought *Valmouth* (1918): "With pensive psychic fingers the enamoured Englishwoman toyed with a talismanic bagatelle in New Zealand jade."³ Similarly, in *Caprice* (1917) a character seated in the Café Royal, London – a haunt of fashionable fin-de-siècle artists such as Oscar Wilde – points to a truly exotic personage in her midst: "beyond, blackening her nose with a cigarette, sprawls the most

resigned of women – Miss Whispina Peters, a daughter of the famous flagellist – and a coryphée herself.”⁴ These are hardly the kinds of descriptions one might expect to find in realist novels seeking to record the drearier aspects of “middle-class interiors.” Artifice reigns over authenticity with an incorrigible delight in the ornamental and the absurd.

Scogan’s observations about Knockespotch could also be applied to a much longer tradition of writers who were affiliated with what remains the critically neglected genre of British aesthetic fiction. This is an under-researched history whose antirealist and antimimetic inclinations can be traced at least as far back as the melodramatic romance of the 1860s. Brooke acknowledges that the quotation from *Valmouth* looks like “an elaborate pastiche” of “Ouida” (Maria Louise Ramé), whose overwritten novels and implausible plots caused a sensation half a century before (*RF* 15). Brooke, too, acknowledges that Firbank had a distinctly “ninetyish sensibility” that reveals the influence of illustrator Aubrey Beardsley’s only novel, the exquisitely written *Under the Hill*, which was later issued – in an edition that reproduced the intensely erotic original manuscript version – as *The Story of Venus and Tannhäuser* (*RF* 11, 16). There are also, Brooke observes, evident links with the rococo prose of “Baron Corvo” (the professional identity of Frederick Rolfe), whose eccentric life as a queer Catholic misanthrope became the subject of one of the finest modernist biographies, A. J. A. Symons’ *The Quest for Corvo* (1934). Yet, as I show here, perhaps the most significant writer who haunts Firbank’s unique fiction is Wilde, the Irish author whose downfall in 1895 for committing acts of gross indecency with other men did much to discredit the rise of aestheticism, the movement gaining momentum in the 1860s that championed, in Walter Pater’s memorable phrase, the “love of art for its own sake.”⁵

In this chapter, I take up several of Brooke’s thoughtful leads in order to unravel the development of a genre on which there still remains no single book-length study, though several noteworthy inquiries into important contributions to its history have arisen in the past twenty-five years.⁶ I identify the genesis of aesthetic fiction in Ouida’s ostentatious romances and its scholarly development in

Pater's superbly studied prose before turning to the innovations that Wilde made when pursuing the idea that the purpose of art lay in the finest experience of beauty. This genealogy culminates in Firbank, who, in his strongly allusive works of fiction, looks back on these predecessors while at the same time pioneering a decidedly camp poetics of his own. To be sure, the history that I outline here gestures toward a much more extensive canon of largely forgotten stories and novels that connect strands of late Victorian, fin-de-siècle, and early modernist narrative. The aim, however, is to reveal the ways in which each writer who comes within this evolving canon brings to the fore those qualities that, in Huxley's novel, released the eccentrically named Knockespotch from the "dreary tyranny of the realistic novel." In the process, we see that aesthetic fiction characteristically embraces styles of dissident desire, which arguably reach their most perverse apogee in Firbank's modernist aestheticism.

Ouida's Excesses: The Aesthetic Romance

"Ouida," Brooke writes, "is a much underrated novelist" (*RF* 16). By the mid-twentieth century her sumptuous romances had largely disappeared as something of an embarrassment in the annals of literary history, though her biography remained a curiosity.⁷ Her commercial success, which lasted through the 1880s, was constantly matched by a very mixed press, which grudgingly acknowledged the unrivaled energy of her flamboyant writing. As I will explain shortly, it was her brazen excessiveness that drew admiration from a generation of fin-de-siècle and early modernist male aesthetes. Brought up in the market town of Bury St. Edmunds, she was the bilingual child and only daughter of an unhappily married French father and English mother. M. Ramé, whom Ouida adored, taught his native language in East Anglia before disappearing during the 1871 Commune. Dependent on him for most of her education, Ouida became a precocious writer in her teens, and by 1859 – after she had resided in London for two years – she made contacts that enabled her to contribute short fiction to *Bentley's Miscellany*. Her first novel,

Held in Bondage; or, Granville de Vigne, a Tale of the Day (1863), which luxuriates in the lives of debonair cavalrymen, set a pattern for her subsequent writing. Here her narrator, in a single unrestrained sentence, recalls the Allies' bold victory against the Russian forces at Alma (1854):

Then came the time for Scarlett and his Heavies – and all the lookers-on gathered up yonder on the heights, held their breath when Greys and Enniskilleners, with the joyous cheer of the one, the wild shout of the other ringing through the air, rushed at the massive columns of the Russians, charged them, shaking their serried masses as a hurricane shakes woodland trees, and closing with their second line as it came up to retrieve the lost honour of the priest-blessed lances, mingled pêle-mêle with them, reckless of all odds, cutting their way inch by inch through the dense squadrons closing round them – those “beautiful grey horses” pushing their road with that dash and daring which had once won them Napoleon’s admiration – till the 1st Royals, with the 4th and 5th Dragoon Guards, dashed to the rescue, and sent the Russian columns flying over the plain, like a routed herd of cattle without a leader.⁸

Elements of this breathless style can be traced to the fashionable fiction of the 1830s and 1840s. In particular, Edward Bulwer-Lytton’s *Paul Clifford* (1830) – the Newgate novel that records the career of a gentleman-criminal – comes to mind, especially its opening line: “It was a dark and stormy night; the rain fell in torrents, except at occasional intervals, when it was checked by a violent gust of wind which swept up the streets (for it is in London that our scene lies), rattling along the house-tops, and fiercely agitating the scanty flame of the lamps that struggled against the darkness.”⁹ Yet, as *Held in Bondage* shows, during her early twenties Ouida had already taken such overstated flourishes to an unparalleled extreme.

In her early career, Ouida had greatest impact with *Under Two Flags: A Story of the Household and the Desert* (1867): a monumental, best-selling three-decker novel that records the domestic trials and foreign tribulations of guardsman Bertie Cecil, the exquisite-looking middle son of the near-bankrupt Royallieu family, whose roots go back to Anglo-Norman times. A lover of pleasure as well as a hearty

sportsman, he appears at one point “with the coils of his hookah bubbling among the rose-water,” before we discover him galloping headlong in a steeplechase at Epsom: “he set his teeth hard, and his hands clenched like steel on the bridle.”¹⁰ And when he is not consorting with his fellow officers and the equestrian elite, Bertie conducts affairs with women of all classes. On the one hand, he keeps a former ballet dancer as his mistress: “A celebrity, the Zu-Zu, the last coryphée whom Bertie had translated from a sphere of garret bread-and-cheese to a sphere of villa champagne and chicken . . . said that Cecil cared for nothing longer than a fortnight, unless it were his horse, Forest King” (*UTF* 1:8). On the other hand, he philanders with aristocratic wives who need some relief from their tiresome marriages: “Lady Guenevere was the last of these, his titled and wedded captors; and perhaps the most resistless of all of them. Neither of them believed very much in their attachment, but both of them wore the masquerade dress to perfection” (*UTF* 1:88).

Not surprisingly, military discipline never curbs Bertie’s louche habits, which – given this innate class superiority – prove forgivable in the end. His profligate life in the Household Brigade involves other untold luxuries, as we can see from the ostentation of his bachelor’s apartment:

The hangings of the room were silken and rose-coloured, and a delicious confusion prevailed through it pell-mell, box spurs, hunting stirrups, cartridge-cases, curb chains, muzzle-loaders, hunting-flasks, and white gauntlets, being mixed up with Paris novels, pink notes, point-lace ties, bracelets and bouquets to be dispatched to various destinations, and velvet and silk bags for bank-notes, cigars, or vesuvians, embroidered by feminine fingers, and as useless as those pretty fingers themselves. On the softest of sofas, half dressed, and having half an hour before splashed like a water dog out of the bath, as big as a small pond, in the dressing-chamber beyond, was the Hon. Bertie himself, second son of Viscount Royallieu, known generally in the Brigades as “Beauty.” (*UTF* 1:3–4)

Each and every object in this riot of hunting accessories and fancy bijouterie, all of which exhibit his disproportionate consumerism, shows that Bertie is no ordinary man-about-town. Although this

adept horseman knows how to shoot game and present trinkets with the panache of a true ladies' man, he is also a figure – given his handsome bearing and opulent tastes – who assimilates feminine sensuousness into his virile potency. As an impatient critic remarked, Ouida was famous for representing “scented guardsmen”: the kind of eye-catching soldier who remains somewhat too perfumed for his own good, even if he comes within a hairsbreadth of winning the Grand National.¹¹ It would be left to later aesthetes to experiment even more assertively with Bertie's sexually ambiguous attributes.

Yet Bertie's busy life of military drills, horseracing exploits, and costly flirtation comes to an abrupt end. Debts force him to take out perilous loans with a Jewish creditor, who accuses him of forgery. By the end of the first volume, the man implausibly known as Beauty of the Brigades has abandoned Europe for humble service in the Chasseurs d'Afrique in Algiers. He has swapped his finely decorated rooms for an outlandish colonial landscape: “Sapeurs, Chasseurs, Zouaves, cantinières . . . mingled with jet-black Soudans, desert kings wrathful and silent, eastern women shrouded in haïck and serroual, eagle-eyed Arabs flinging back snow-white burnous, and handling ominously the jewelled hilts of their cangiaris” (*UTF* 1:297). Once she has itemized, like a tourist guide, the captivating characters in this North African procession, Ouida's storyteller presents an even more remarkable creation, the gamine vivandière Cigarette, known also to the colonists as Friend of the Flag:

She was pretty, she was insolent, she was intolerably coquettish, she was mischievous as a marmoset, she would swear if need be like a Zouave, she could fire galloping, she could toss off her brandy or her vermouth like a trooper, she would on occasion clench her little brown hand and deal a blow that the recipient would not covet twice, she was an *enfant de Paris*, and had all its wickedness at her fingers, she would sing you *guinguette* songs till you were suffocated with laughter, and she would dance the *cancan* at the Salle de Mars with the biggest giant of a Cuirassier there. (*UTF* 2:3)

As this description reveals, the spirited Cigarette – somewhat like Bertie – enshrines a mixture of gendered characteristics: “She was more like a handsome saucy boy than anything else under the sun,

and yet there was that in the pretty, impudent little Friend of the Flag that was feminine with it all – generous and graceful amidst all her boldness, and her licence, her revelries” (*UTF* 2:9–10). Raised amid the barracks, this insubordinate subtler expresses a formidable vivacity that emerges in her “dance-delirium” that enthalls her audience (*UTF* 2:35). The same is true of her at times vulgar macaronic speech, which not only tests the limits of literary decorum but also occasionally reflects on language itself: “But?” she asks Bertie (known to her only as *Bel-à-faire-peur*), when she challenges him to explain why he will not avenge his tyrannical commander, Châteauroy. “*Chut, bon camarade!* that little word has been the undoing of the world ever since the world began. ‘But’ is a blank cartridge, and never did anything but miss fire yet” (*UTF* 2:146). As Cigarette’s homosocial banter suggests, the abject preposition proves a blunt weapon compared with the elaborate narrative artillery that Ouida herself employs in a strenuous effort to transform the Victorian romance into a remarkably innovative – because aesthetically excessive – literary object.

The spirited dialogue reminds us that this is no ordinary romance for other reasons as well. Unquestionably, by the middle of the novel the boyish young Frenchwoman and beautiful English chasseur have established a form of intimate trust. Yet it never transforms into a conventional torrid affair. Instead, it is only after Châteauroy has unjustly tried *Bel-à-faire-peur* for treachery that Cigarette declares her love. She reveals her passion the moment the beaten-but-unbowed hero faces the firing squad. Once the executioner pulls the trigger, Cigarette rushes forward to take the bullet. The hyperbolic ending is as near to a heterosexual climax as Ouida’s fiction can admit: when “the shots . . . pierced through from her shoulder to her bosom, a hot scarlet flush came over her cheeks as she felt his touch and rested on his heart” (*UTF* 3:335). Perhaps the only predictable aspect of *Under Two Flags* is that it finally witnesses Bertie restored – by a twist of fortune – to his ancestral estate. Ouida’s sensational plot, which was adapted no fewer than five times for film, inspired later Foreign Legion novels, most memorably P. C. Wren’s *Beau Geste* (1924).

Reviews of *Under Two Flags* were not slow to observe its ludicrousness. The firmest repudiation came from the *Pall Mall Gazette*, whose large readership mostly belonged to gentlemen's clubs. This newspaper recoiled from Ouida's decision to make military officers as "beautiful as Antinous" (Emperor Hadrian's lover), with "delicate brilliant faces like women."¹² Equally distasteful was how these effeminate soldiers were attracted to lower-class women, who appeared as "avaricious as Shylock" and "vulgar as fishwives."¹³ Not surprisingly, the critic deemed this "a novel little more than worthless, and full of manifest absurdities."¹⁴ Yet other critics, faced with such implausibility, found it hard to ignore the verve of her writing. Certainly, in the *Athenaeum* the popular novelist Geraldine Jewsbury was quick to observe that Bertie Cecil counted among Ouida's implausible heroes – men who resembled "well made marionettes, with wonderful joints, which can be stretched and twisted in all directions" and nothing more.¹⁵ Still, Jewsbury could not avoid praising the "spirit and dash" of such patent "nonsense."¹⁶ Much later, in 1888, when Ouida's reputation was faltering, Oscar Wilde – who published four of her contributions in his forward-thinking journal, *The Woman's World* – acknowledged that her most recent novel, *Guilderoy*, showed that she remained the "high-priestess of the impossible."¹⁷ Even though Wilde deplores the style in which Ouida "thinks meanly of the people and adores the House of Lords," he pardons her faults because her writing remains "never dull."¹⁸ Such reasoning appalled the poet and essayist Alice Meynell. Several months after Wilde had been sent to jail, Meynell was thinking of his disgrace when she scathingly commented on the fin-de-siècle fad for conjuring witty epigrams. "Things improbable at first glance in connection with her," Meynell remarked in the *Pall Mall Gazette*, "are to be traced to Ouida: amongst others the 'epigram.'"¹⁹ "Many and many a little author to-day," Meynell somewhat condescendingly added, "would perhaps become less frivolously cheerful on finding the most modern of his inversions in the decorated pages of his half-forgotten Ouida."²⁰

Meynell, who evidently found Wilde's wit derivative and second-rate, had no patience with the praise for Ouida's "genuine and

passionate love of beauty” that G. S. Street had recently given in *The Yellow Book* (1894–97): a journal whose early fame sprung mainly from its celebratory decadence.²¹ Two years later, Max Beerbohm, who had shocked readers of the same journal with his amusing “Defence of Cosmetics” (1894), contended in the *Saturday Review* that Ouida’s greatest gift was her lack of poise and dignity: “Ouida is not, and never was,” he stated counterintuitively, “an artist.”²² The reason for her success was clear: “Writers of enormous vitality never are artistic: they cannot pause, they must always be moving swiftly forward” (“Ouida,” 8). Such, Beerbohm states, is the “irresistible *élan*” of Ouida’s “lurid sequence of books” that her oeuvre marks an instructive contrast with those writers whom he claims to “love best”: namely, those who indulge “delicate and elaborate ingenuities of form and style.” “Too much art,” he maintains, is “as great an obstacle as too little art” (“Ouida,” 8). In this regard, the author that comes to Beerbohm’s mind is Walter Pater, the somewhat retiring Oxford tutor whose “excessive care for words” – as far as Beerbohm can tell – remains “obscure to most people” (“Ouida,” 8).

Pater’s Aesthetic Novel: “Strenuous Self-Control and Ascêsis”

On the face of it, Pater’s aesthetic fiction presents the clearest antithesis to Ouida’s sensational plots and stylistic superfluities. Famed for the rigorous attention he paid to his prose, the erudite Pater, who taught classics at Brasenose College until 1883, made his reputation with his first volume of essays, *Studies in the History of the Renaissance* (1873). There, in a “Conclusion” that startled some readers, he claimed that what mattered most in aesthetic experience was “getting as many pulsations as possible into the given time,” since such intense moments provided a “quickened sense of life, ecstasy and sorrow of love, political or religious enthusiasm, or the ‘enthusiasm of humanity.’”²³ Such vivid phrasing, which derived from anti-moralistic theories of *l’art pour l’art* in France, situated Pater as a leading voice of aestheticism: the belief, in his words, that “the poetic passion, the desire of beauty” generated (in an epithet he

repeated) a “quickened, multiplied consciousness” of an enriching kind (*SHR* 213). Especially memorable in Pater’s 1873 volume is the beautifully cadenced description of Leonardo da Vinci’s *La Gioconda* (usually known as the *Mona Lisa*), in which the portrait enshrines generations of artworks that have sought to depict feminine beauty: “All the thoughts and experience of the world have etched and moulded there, in that which they have of power to refine and make expressive the outward form, the animalism of Greece, the lust of Rome, the mysticism of the middle age with its spiritual ambition and imaginative loves, the return of the Pagan world, the sins of the Borgias” (*SHR* 118). Even though such wording exerts a rhythmical control that *Under Two Flags* seldom exhibits, Pater’s expansive syntax offers a meticulous version of Ouida’s irrepressible interest in accumulating qualifying phrases whose purpose is to elaborate the scenes, characters, and settings on which she bestows such attention. In both Ouida’s and Pater’s respective works of fiction, the result is that their writing draws attention as much to the stylistic exertions of their narratives as it does to the subject matter that their storytellers relate. Yet, for Pater, da Vinci’s mesmerizing portrait contains “strange thoughts and fantastic reveries and exquisite passions” far more aesthetically outlandish than anything Ouida ever conjured, since he compares the *Mona Lisa*’s death-defying beauty to that of the vampire (*SHR* 118). Equally noteworthy is Pater’s audacious celebration of the “Hellenic ideal” that he witnesses in the eighteenth-century German art historian Johann Joachim Winckelmann, whose passion for Greek sculpture “was not merely intellectual,” a fact “proved by his romantic, fervent friendships with young men” (*SHR* 161). For those acquainted with Winckelmann’s career at this time, they would have known that this founding father of archeology was likely robbed and murdered in 1768 by a male prostitute at Trieste. Thus, if Ouida unintentionally made her heroes resemble Antinoüs, Pater maintained a classically informed interest in those men whose homoeroticism became clear through their attraction to such figures.

In 1922, the link between Ouida and Pater came immediately to Arthur Symons’ mind. This leading theorist and noted practitioner

of decadent poetics remarked: "Who of us has not, to a certain extent, admired the bizarre genius of Ouida? Walter Pater did, at one time."²⁴ While there is no biographical evidence to support Symons' intriguing comment, his observation prompts us to think about further features that these two writers share. In Pater's only completed novel, *Marius the Epicurean: His Sensations and Ideas* (1885), the narrator traces the story of a young citizen's aesthetic, philosophical, and religious education during his brief life in Antonine Rome. Throughout, Pater's narrative voice takes pains to reconstruct the culture, environment, and habits of mind that characterize this era. To be sure, the plot is hardly as sensational as Ouida's, since Pater's storyteller dwells on the protagonist's contemplative engagement with a world that is steadily transitioning from Roman paganism to the Christian faith. Early on, we learn that Marius's family history prepared him for some "sacerdotal function," which instilled in him a "strenuous self-control and *ascêsis*" (the Greek term that evokes self-regulating discipline).²⁵ After he has traveled from Pisa to Rome, where he witnesses the emperor Marcus Aurelius remaining unmoved throughout the "cruel amusements" of the amphitheater, he comes into contact with "the unique power of Christianity," especially this new religion's emphasis on chastity, which strikes him as the "most beautiful thing in the world" (*ME* 1:238, 2:113). Yet, as Marius's interest in this subterranean faith draws him away from the emperor's Stoicism, he unexpectedly expires from a fever. As the young man declines into "extreme helplessness," several Christians take it upon themselves to say the Litany of the Dying ("*Abi! Abi! anima Christiana!*") in order to convert him before he loses consciousness (*ME* 2:218). Noticeably, Pater cuts Marius's life short before this highly sensitive individual can reap the joys of an emergent Christian religion. This is a distinctly anticlimactic ending that quietly withdraws from any moral conclusion.

Even if Marius's "sensations and ideas" do not form part of a morally purposeful plot, in which anticipated resolutions follow narrative crises, the extraordinary amount of detail that the narrator bestows upon the young man's responsiveness to beauty places the

novel squarely within the aesthetic tradition. Inclined to the teachings of Epicurus (the third-century BCE philosopher who pursued tranquility), Marius expresses an “innate and habitual longing for a world altogether fairer than that he saw” (*ME* 1:50). To underwrite this point, Pater’s storyteller concentrates on Marius’s “poetic or romantic capacity” when encountering the beautiful (*ME* 1:58). This heightened sensibility appears in an early episode, where we witness Marius and his slightly older tutor Flavian turning the pages of a beautiful book, one that has fine “purple writing on the handsome yellow wrapper,” which is also “perfumed with oil of sandal-wood, and decorated with carved and gilt ivory bosses at each end of the roller” (*ME* 1:59, 60). To be sure, this exquisite item, which contains a transcription of Apuleius’s *The Golden Ass*, is hardly comparable to the trifling “Paris novels” and “pink notes” that litter Bertie Cecil’s extravagant apartment. Nonetheless, it serves as the kind of decorative object that often stands at the center of much aesthetic fiction. More to the point, once the young men start to read Apuleius’s Latin vernacular, they cherish the material loveliness of his language: a feature that becomes increasingly central in modernist fiction from James Joyce and Dorothy Richardson onward. To Marius and Flavian, *The Golden Ass* presents literary style as beauty incarnate:

What words he had found for conveying, with a single touch, the sense of textures, colours, incidents! “Like jewellers’ work! Like a myrrhine vase!” – admirers said of his writing. “The golden fibre in her hair, and the gold thread-work in her gown marked her as the mistress” – *aurum in comis et in tunicis, ibi inflexum hic intexum, matronam profecto confitebatur* [Apuleius, *Metamorphoses*, 2:2] – he writes, with “curious felicity,” of one of his heroines. *Aurum intexum*: gold fibre – well! there was something of that kind in his own work. And then, in an age when people, from the emperor Aurelius downwards, prided themselves, unwisely, in writing in Greek, he had written for Latin people in their own tongue; though still, in truth, with all the care of one writing in a learned language. (*ME* 1:61)

This important passage shows that both Marius and Flavian perceive that such elegant phrasing possesses special properties: it is, in itself, the “gold fibre” it describes. Such recognition positions these friends

as the aesthetes of their age. In Apuleius's writing, Marius and Flavian discover that their everyday Latin can become as gorgeous and gracious as the venerated Greek. Further on, in a chapter titled "Euphuism" – a term evoking the finely honed style of English Renaissance novelist John Lyly – the narrator remarks that these characters have learned the "forgotten duties towards language, towards the instruments of expression" through this gorgeously decorated "golden" book (*ME* 1:99). By implicit analogy, the skill that the second-century Apuleius brings to his Latin prose bears comparison with the evident care that Pater himself takes with the English language.

Pater turned to composing fiction in the late 1870s, several years after he had made his mark not only with his impressive essays in *Studies of the History of the Renaissance* but also with his innovative discussions of classical myth, Shakespeare's drama, Giorgione, Charles Lamb, and romanticism. Besides *Marius the Epicurean*, Pater published eight important "imaginary portraits" (as he called his shorter works of fiction), as well as most of the chapters in his second novel, *Gaston de Latour*, before his early death in 1894. He devoted considerable time to this body of fiction after he had suffered several attacks on the "Conclusion." This document provoked sufficient controversy that Pater omitted it from the second edition of his volume, whose title he shortened to *The Renaissance*, in 1877. (Eleven years later, when the success of *Marius* helped to settle his reputation, he restored the "Conclusion" in the third edition.) The most significant critiques of the "Conclusion" understood the philosophical traditions that informed Pater's contentious claim that, when contemplating beauty, we must learn to appreciate that "[n]ot the fruit of experience, but experience itself is the end" (*SHR* 210). The anonymous reviewer in the *Examiner* stated that Pater's position amounted to "Modern Cyrenaicism": a desire to relish "the best and fullest *μόνοχρονος ἡδονή* [instantaneous pleasure], or – to use the modern equivalent – 'pulsation.'"²⁶ Led by Aristippus, the Cyrenaics of the fourth century BCE taught that pleasure was intrinsically ethical. To the *Examiner*, by contrast, Pater's espousal of this idea proves that "his theories about life are the relaxation of a life" at

Oxford that should be “sternly devoted to duty.”²⁷ Since he is appalled that an Oxford tutor should advance such Cyrenaic beliefs, this critic claims that one’s “daily life” requires “daily morality.”²⁸ The implication is that a good dose of moral restraint will ensure that unbounded pleasure does not become an ethical pursuit in itself.

In *Marius the Epicurean*, Pater responded to these charges. Of Marius, we learn, “there were some among his acquaintance who jumped to the conclusion that, with the ‘Epicurean styte,’ he was making pleasure – pleasure, as they so poorly conceived it – the sole motive of life” (*ME* 1:151). As the narrator observes, Marius’s experience was scarcely based on a degraded hedonism. Instead, the young man cultivated a “new Cyrenaicism”: “Not pleasure, but fulness of life, and ‘insight’ as conducting to that fulness – energy, choice, and variety of experience – including noble pain and sorrow even, – loves such as those in the exquisite story of Apuleius” (*ME* 1:152). Somewhat later, Marius revisits the teachings of the Cyrenaics, and the narrator comments that “the pleasure of the ideal present, the mystic *now*” that this ancient school celebrated came at a price (*ME* 1:155). The problem, Marius begins to understand, was that the Cyrenaics individualistically “detached themselves” from “things only to be enjoyed through sympathy” with others (*ME* 2:27). Regrettably, the narrator observes, the followers of Aristippus failed to connect “the merely æsthetic sense” to a larger moral order, one that enshrined “those attractive conventions, enveloping, so gracefully, the whole of life” (*ME* 2:28–29). Pater’s friend at Oxford, Mary Augusta Ward, grasped the purpose of Marius’s spiritual journey. “Mankind,” she stated in *Macmillan’s Magazine*, “has never been content to spend itself on a worship of ‘moments,’ or in a spirit of fugitive impressions as such”; instead, “it has tried to fix and distil the essence of innumerable impressions in one great tradition – the ethical tradition – which is at once the product and the condition of human life.”²⁹

Several younger aesthetes could not escape the power of Pater’s evolving aestheticism, which placed an increasingly firm emphasis on *ascēsis*: the discipline that reins in a perilous indulgence in pleasure. One of his most significant interlocutors was Vernon Lee

(Violet Paget), who attacked male aesthetes' objectification of women in her novel *Miss Brown* (1884). Even though she initially found Pater to be in person "lymphatic, dull, humourless," she produced one of the largest bodies of critical writing that engaged with his aestheticism.³⁰ By the time she published *Renaissance Fancies and Studies* (1896), however, Lee departed from Pater's confidence that the engagement with the beautiful could uphold an admirable standard of ethical conduct. Certainly, she admitted that his "inborn affinity for refined wholesomeness made [him] the natural exponent of the highest æsthetic doctrine."³¹ Yet, even in light of the self-control that Pater brought to aesthetic experience in *Marius the Epicurean*, she still doubted the assumptions on which he based his critical engagement with art: "Supreme craftsman that he was, it protected him from the craftsman's delusion . . . that subtle treatment can dignify all subjects equally."³²

Like Vernon Lee, Wilde also made a point of observing the contrast between Pater's burnished writing style and his unprepossessing manner. In *The Romantic '90s* (1925), Richard Le Gallienne records a conversation in which he told Wilde he was about to visit Pater at Oxford. "You must not expect him to talk like his prose," Wilde said.³³ "He will not breathe one golden word about the Renaissance. No! he will probably say something like this: 'So you wear cork soles in your shoes?' . . . How extremely interesting."³⁴ But, apart from this light mockery, Wilde usually expressed loyalty to the older man, who had to some degree become a mentor. In solitary confinement, Wilde recalled reading Pater's *Renaissance* twenty years earlier during his first term at Oxford in 1874. He stated that Pater's book had exerted "such a strange influence" over his life.³⁵ Part of the strangeness of Pater's influential book perhaps lays in the way in which it encouraged Wilde to consider the problem that Lee shrewdly identified: namely, the provocative idea that not all objects deserve refined treatment. Wilde's only novel, *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890, revised 1891), participates in a thoughtful dialogue with both *The Renaissance* and *Marius the Epicurean*, just as it echoes at least one of the epigrams that Meynell traced to Ouida. In many ways, Wilde's longest work of

fiction redirects Marius's story in order to tell the tale of a beautiful young man who joins the "Epicurean sty": a shady underworld where Dorian Gray's unabashed pleasures eventually lead to addiction, blackmail, homicide, and self-murder.

"No Artist Has Ethical Sympathies": Wilde's
Picture of Dorian Gray

In July 1890, when it first appeared in a thirteen-chapter version in *Lippincott's Monthly Magazine*, Wilde's *Picture of Dorian Gray* expressed its specific allegiance not only to Ouida's lavish descriptions and Pater's "Conclusion" but also to aestheticism more generally. Simultaneously, this bold novel broadened the possibilities of aesthetic fiction, not least because it both questioned the ethical basis of aesthetic appreciation and engaged the supernatural. Furthermore, Wilde's aesthetic narrative proved much more defiant than works such as *Under Two Flags* and *Marius the Epicurean* in its portrayal of dissident eroticism. If both Ouida and Pater received contentious reviews for their works of fiction, *The Picture of Dorian Gray* caused such offense that leading London newsvendors pulled *Lippincott's* from their shelves. The well-documented controversy that exploded in the pages of several British reviews intimated that the story was fit only for individuals "curious in ordure."³⁶ It was, another sniping commentator remarked, "spawned from the leprous literature of the French *Décadents*."³⁷ Worse still, it struck the conservative *Scots Observer* as a tale suited "for none other but outlawed noblemen and perverted telegraph boys": an insulting allusion to the recent Cleveland Street affair, in which Lord Arthur Somerset was found to have frequented a male brothel where young mail-carriers made extra cash by offering sexual services.³⁸ And when critics were not harping on the disreputable homoeroticism of Wilde's story, they accused him of plagiarizing parts of the narrative from works by Nathaniel Hawthorne, Honoré de Balzac, and J.-K. Huysmans. Wilde refused to be intimidated by this stream of abuse. Within a year, he reissued his novel with six extra chapters in single-volume form. On this occasion, he furnished his story with

an unapologetic “Preface” comprising a list of pithy aphorisms that stressed his staunch affiliation with aestheticism. “*The artist is the creator of beautiful things,*” he states plainly. “*No artist has ethical sympathies.*” “*All art,*” Wilde observes conclusively, “*is quite useless.*”³⁹ By making such statements, Wilde’s “Preface” evoked – though never quoted directly from – figures such as Walter Pater and Théophile Gautier in order to show his affiliation with a tradition that flatly refused to make artworks serve a stern moral purpose.

The furor surrounding the early reception of Wilde’s novel can distract from what is arguably most significant about the position the narrative holds in the aesthetic tradition. Where *Under Two Flags* and *Marius the Epicurean* stress fidelity to their respective historical settings, *The Picture of Dorian Gray* tells a partly supernatural tale of a young man who retains – almost to the very end of the book – his exquisite looks because he transforms into an ageless artwork. Enamored of his portrait, Dorian Gray exchanges places with “the gracious and comely form” that the gifted painter Basil Hallward has “so skilfully mirrored in his art” (*DG* 3:169). This fantastical change occurs not long after Lord Henry Wotton finds himself absorbed in “the beautiful, brainless creature” whose stunning portrait graces the painter’s studio (*DG* 3:170). In particular, he is taken back by Basil Hallward’s statement: “What the invention of oil-painting was to the Venetians, the face of Antinoüs was to late Greek sculpture, and the face of Dorian Gray will some day be to me” (*DG* 3:176). The artist, who also declares that Dorian Gray’s “personality has suggested . . . an entirely new manner in art, an entirely new mode of style,” intimates that he has not only embraced Pater’s *Renaissance* but also realized a new homoerotic aesthetic, one that was arguably bolder than the same-sex desire that Pater disclosed in “Winckelmann” (*DG* 3:177). That Basil Hallward admits that he experienced a “curious sensation of terror” when his eyes first met Dorian Gray suggests that his artwork betrays desires that could, if recognized in public, prove fatal (*DG* 3:173). For that reason, it seems, the painter has no wish to exhibit the portrait. For Lord Henry, however, Dorian Gray’s presence inspires different emotions. The aristocrat is certainly enraptured by the “wonderfully

handsome" Dorian Gray, "with his finely-curved scarlet lips, his frank blue eyes, his crisp gold hair" (*DG* 3:181) – features more commonly attributable to women than men at this time. But, unlike the painter, Lord Henry wishes to dominate the seemingly unsuspecting young man. No sooner has he convinced himself that Dorian Gray represents "the candour of youth . . . as well as youth's passionate purity" than he seeks to manipulate this seemingly impressionable young man (*DG* 3:181). Very quickly, Lord Henry begins to echo several of Pater's best-known phrases. "Be always searching for new sensations," he advises Dorian, as if endorsing Pater's "Conclusion." A "new Hedonism – that is what our century wants," he announces, in phrasing that partly echoes Pater's inquiries into the "New Cyrenaicism" (*DG* 3:187). And when such phrasing is not echoing Pater, Lord Henry makes epigrammatic quips that sound as though they came straight from Wilde's mouth: "Being natural," Lord Henry says, "is simply a pose" (*DG* 3:172). In the end, Dorian Gray becomes so used to Lord Henry's rhetorical habit that at one point he says to his friend: "You would sacrifice anybody, Harry, for the sake of an epigram" (*DG* 3:342). Not insignificantly, this is one of the catchphrases that Meynell knew originated with Ouida.⁴⁰

Wilde's narrator discloses that Lord Henry's emphasis on the search for sensations, like his demand for "New Hedonism" and a "Hellenic ideal," derives from a book that the aristocrat "had read when was sixteen, a book that had revealed to him much that he had not known before" (*DG* 3:183–4). Yet the fact that Lord Henry seems more interested in "the sudden impression that his words had produced" in Dorian Gray than any serious meaning they might have hints that this aesthete's greatest pleasures lie in his somewhat reckless phrasemaking (*DG* 3:184). To Lord Henry, his Paterian ideas amount to nothing more than a random "arrow shot in the air" (*DG* 3:184). He wonders if his suggestion that the "only way to get rid of a temptation is to yield to it" will "hit the mark" in Dorian Gray's vulnerable consciousness (*DG* 3:183, 184). Lord Henry does not comprehend that the urgency he sees in enjoying the best years of one's life ("When your youth goes, your beauty will go with it,"

he cautions Dorian) will lead the exquisite-looking youth toward deceit and corruption (*DG* 3:186). Since Dorian is almost driven mad through the “subtle magic” that works its spell in the seductive aristocrat’s “clear, and vivid, and cruel” phrasing, he declares resentfully to Basil Hallward: “Lord Henry Wotton is perfectly right. Youth is the only thing worth having. When I find that I am growing old, I shall kill myself” (*DG* 3:184, 190). At once, he yearns to swap places with the beautiful figure that Hallward has immortalized in paint. “If it were I,” he exclaims, “who was always to be young, and the picture that was to grow old!” (*DG* 3:189). To ensure this magical transformation happens, he demands ownership of the artwork. Once he has hidden the portrait away in the schoolroom of his home, he takes on its ageless mien. At the same time, the more Dorian pursues his increasingly contemptible pleasures, the more disfigured the portrait becomes, bearing the marks of his heinous wrongdoing. When the crimes become unbearable, he takes a knife to the painting and stabs his image. Through his suicide, the portrait returns to its former glory, while Dorian Gray drops to the floor “withered, wrinkled, and loathsome of visage” (*DG* 3:357).

The considerable legacy of Wilde’s *Picture of Dorian Gray* emerges in a range of writings that appeared during the next twenty-five years. The most immediate consequence was Beerbohm’s rejoinder. In *The Yellow Book*, Beerbohm published “The Happy Hypocrite: A Fairy Tale for Tired Men”; this short fiction, which became a stage play in 1900, amusingly inverts Dorian Gray’s despicable career. Set during the morally lax days of the regency, the story recounts the career of the aptly named Lord George Hell, who “set such a bad example to others.”⁴¹ “Never, never did he try to conceal his wrong-doing,” we are told (“Happy” 11). A tireless womanizer, Lord George fixes his attention on the actress Jenny Mere. He lies almost prostrate before her, declaring his devotion in dreadful platitudes: “I am dazzled in the light of those translucent orbs, your Eyes.” In response, she states: “I can never be the wife of any man whose face is not saintly” (“Happy,” 18, 19). The only way to resolve this conundrum is for the louche aristocrat to visit a mask-maker, who provides “the mask of a saint who loves dearly”

("Happy," 28). The device, contrary to what we might expect, works perfectly. Even though he finds it difficult to smile, his angelic expression wins her heart. Yet the moment Lord George has dispensed with his worldly possessions in order to live with Jenny in the countryside, he still fears that his mask – "the mirror of true love" – might sooner or later crack ("Happy," 27). He need have no worries. After one of his jealous former mistresses rips the waxen image from his face, he suffers no indignity, since he discovers that his own flesh now wears "a saint's face" ("Happy," 43). As the mask melts on the lawn, his newly beautified visage ensures that he and Jenny remain in wedded bliss. The deceptive work of artifice, therefore, has secured the pleasures of romance, in a story that leaves one wondering whether aesthetic fiction might ever again represent authentic feeling.

"Let Us Follow These Bright Ornaments":

Beardsley and Firkbank

Beerbohm's plainly written story contrasts with the strenuously artificial style that some of his contemporaries devised in their contributions to the aesthetic novel. One of most significant interventions came from Aubrey Beardsley, who enjoyed a prolific but short-lived career that made his name synonymous with the decadent art of the 1890s. Best known for the striking, highly sexualized designs he furnished for *The Yellow Book*, Beardsley was also a writer of finely crafted prose, which first came to public attention in the chapters he published from his unfinished fiction, *Under the Hill*, in 1896. Beardsley's antipathy to Wilde is legendary. He went out of his way to poke fun at Wilde's rather heavysset body in the designs for the English-language translation of the one-act tragedy, *Salome* (1894), which Wilde originally composed in French. Yet he learned certain techniques from Wilde's stylized prose. *The Picture of Dorian Gray* opens with an elaborate, sensuous description: "The studio was filled with the rich odour of roses, and when the light summer wind stirred amidst the trees of the garden there came through the open door the heavy scent of the lilac, or the more

delicate perfume of the pink-flowering thorn" (DG 3:169). As attentive readers have observed, this appeal to an aromatic nature is implausible, since the three plants mentioned here seldom bloom at the same time. In any case, the ensuing narration shows that if nature has a place in this odiferous setting, it is simply to produce a pleasing artistic illusion, not authenticate a pre-given reality: "now and then the fantastic shadows of birds in flight flitted across the long tussore-silk curtains that were stretched in front of the huge window, producing a kind of momentary Japanese effect" (DG 3:169). By comparison, in his rewriting of the Venus and Tannhäuser legend – which Wagner revived in his 1845 opera and Swinburne dramatized in his 1866 poem "Laus Veneris" – Beardsley presents the Abbé Fanfreluche at the "ombre gateway of the mysterious Hill" where the Northern Venus reclines in her grotto.⁴² At this "delicious moment," the priest decides that the time may have come for him to "slip into exile":

The place where he stood waved drowsily with strange flowers, heavy with perfume, dripping with odours. Gloomy and nameless weeds not to be found in Mentzelius. Huge moths, so richly winged they must have banqueted upon tapestries and royal stuffs, slept on the pillars that flanked either side of the gateway, and the eyes of all the moths remained open and were burning and bursting with a mesh of veins.⁴³

Here the fauna and flora are altogether stranger than anything we find in Wilde. The excess that we encounter in earlier aesthetic fiction has become distended and grotesque in this rendition of bizarre blooms with cloying scents where obese insects have overfed themselves.

In an early appraisal of Beardsley's achievement, Henry Melancthon Strong observed that *Under the Hill* presented Tannhäuser's conflict between pagan and Christian passion "under a new and witty light": "The characters are trifling; the incidents are equally so. The story has no ending, hardly, indeed, a beginning; we can see no purpose in view." Instead of protagonists embedded in an intelligible plot, Beardsley offers instead "[w]himsicality of thought and treat, curious little flashes of imagination, now humorous, now

half divine.”⁴⁴ It is not unreasonable to claim that Beardsley’s originality lay in his dedication to the frivolous excesses that had long been a hallmark of Ouida’s overwrought prose. What was different about Beardsley was the “exquisite workmanship” that Strong detected in each and every line.⁴⁵ Strong, however, did not know that Beardsley’s earliest version of this narrative, *The Story of Venus and Tannhäuser*, audaciously drove the extravagant aestheticism of *Under the Hill* into the world of fanciful pornography. In this final episode, the Northern Venus fellates the “stunning member” of the unicorn Adolphe.⁴⁶ Yet, as they entwine, human and animal do not descend into bestial grunting; instead, true to the protocols of aesthetic fiction, they transfigure their lovemaking into a work of art: “The Queen bared her left arm to the elbow, and with the soft underneath of it made amazing movements upon the tight-strung instrument. When the melody began to flow, the unicorn offered up an astonishing vocal accompaniment.”⁴⁷

As Brooke recognized, the modernist heir to this extreme of fin-de-siècle aestheticism was Firbank, whose first volume of stories appeared in 1905, just before he entered Trinity Hall, College, Cambridge, where he befriended Wilde’s youngest son, Vyvyan Holland. During the next two decades, Firbank completed a remarkable corpus of aesthetic fiction that took the trifling nature of character and incident to unanticipated lengths. His most substantial work, *Vainglory*, appeared a year after war broke out in June 1914. Published in an exclusive edition by Grant Richards, it features a frontispiece by Felicien Rops, the Belgian erotic artist who provided a design for the French edition of Wilde’s *Salomé* (1893). The *Academy* delighted in Firbank’s eccentric cast of “amusing puppets,” including “Miss Compostella, Mrs. Asp, Monsignor Parr, Winsome Brooks, and Mrs. Henedge” – “arty” and “epigrammatic” types who inhabit a world of “complete artificiality.” Such figures, this reviewer notes, belong more to 1895 than the present moment, since during the fin de siècle “his cleverness would probably have been poisonous.”⁴⁸ As it stands, *Vainglory* might “prove a useful antidote to the war news,” though it remains – not least because the story is filled with breaks and interruptions – “difficult to read through at a sitting.”⁴⁹

Such observations capture the robust inconsequentiality of a typical scene that occurs early in Firbank's novel. In the second chapter, we meet Mrs. Henedge holding a crowded evening party in her "small house with killing stairs just off Chesham Place."⁵⁰ At one point, the conversation turns to "that wonderful woman, Mrs. Asp, the authoress of *The Home Life of Lucrezia Borgia*: a title that obviously revels in the absurdity of making a female homicide sound as if she has a rightful place in domestic fiction (*V* 88). Amid the bits and pieces of stray chitchat that the narrator records in great detail, Mrs. Asp – "who seemed utterly unable for continuity" – starts talking about her most recent novel "to a charmed few." "There's no plot," she says, "no plot exactly. It's about two women who live all alone" (*V* 89). Once we witness Mrs. Thumbler finding herself "unable to imagine a novel with a plot, and two women who lived so quietly," we can immediately tell that Firbank's tale is reflecting on its own distinct lack of incident (*V* 89). Scarcely anything eventuates amid this insistently disconnected chatter. There is, however, a significant allusion haunting these lines. Firbank is in part referring to "the yellow book" that Lord Henry sends to Dorian at the end of the tenth chapter of *Dorian Gray*. "It was," the narrator remarks, "a novel without a plot, and with only one character" (*DG* 3:274). As Wilde's readers knew, the work in question was probably Huysmans' antirealist *A rebours* (1884), in which the ailing Duc Jean Floressas des Esseintes – as Dorian Gray discovers – "spent his life trying to realize in the nineteenth century all the passions and modes of thought that belonged to every century except his own" (*DG* 3:274). Moreover, the style of this "yellow book" was "full of *argot* and of archaisms, of technical expressions and of elaborate paraphrases," such as one might find among "the French school of *Symbolistes*" (*DG* 3:274). This work, which turns out to be a "poisonous book," whose "heavy odour of incense" intoxicates Dorian (*DG* 3:274), has struck some modern scholars as the decadent version of the "golden" book that entralls Marius and Flavian in Pater's novel.⁵¹ Yet it also serves Firbank with the opportunity to hint

that Mrs. Asp's modern fiction touches on a far from salacious – possibly very ordinary and thus all the more subversive – lesbian romance.

That women's intimate love for other women remains a staple part of Firbank's universe becomes clear when the tête-à-têtes gravitate toward Sappho's "Ode to Aphrodite." Before Swinburne and Michael Field (coauthors Katharine Bradley and Edith Cooper) provided an English gloss on the lesbian poet's surging desires for other women, the unorthodox sexuality of Sappho's verse remained the preserve of classically trained scholars.⁵² In *Vainglory*, Professor Inglepin tries his best to provide a translation in the "plain English" that Mrs. Thumbler demands. "Could not," the professor remarks, wagging a finger, as he parses a passionate line from the ode, "Could not, for the fury of her feet!" (*V* 92). "Do you mean," Mrs. Thumbler asks, "she ran away?" "Apparently!" he replies. At this moment, we learn that "Mrs. Thumbler seemed inclined to faint," for reasons that create an almost vertiginous effect in her mind. "'Could not . . .' she murmured helplessly, as though clinging to an alpenstock, and not quite sure of her guide" (*V* 92). At such moments, we relish Firbank's astute camp sensibility. Certainly, Mrs. Thumbler's hyperbolic reaction to Sappho's line reveals Firbank's particular camp aesthetic. But when we recall that Longinus quoted Sappho's poetry as an example of the sublime, Mrs. Thumbler's jittery response – which places her mind on the slopes of the Alps, home to the Romantic sublime – no longer appears capricious. Meanwhile, the professor, who fixates on what interests him alone, alights on what he calls an "adventurous line" of Sappho's: "Decorative, useless," he calls it, "a water-colour on silk" (*V* 89). By this point, it is plain to see that Firbank's idiosyncratic oddballs – who flit unpredictably from topic to topic – inhabit a world that is populated with what his narrator calls "bright ornaments," all of which evoke unpredictable responses in his peculiar *dramatis personae* (*V* 106). The "delicious confusion" of the "pell-mell" objects and trappings that adorn Bertie Cecil's apartment has become, in Firbank's intensely decorated universe, both dizzying and perverse. It remains impossible for his "amusing puppets" to dwell with serious contemplation on any of the artworks, musical

performances, or dances that occupy their restless entertainments, which hurry forth with a speed that even Ouida could not match.

This distinct type of fiction does not rest with Firbank. Not only is it acknowledged in Huxley's *Crome Yellow*, in the exquisite prose of Huxley's biographer, Sybille Bedford, and in the fiction of Bedford's most significant modern critic, Alan Hollinghurst; it also makes its way into the epigrammatic wit that we find in many of Ivy Compton-Burnett's fictions made up solely of dialogue. Many other writers whose careers link the fin de siècle with early modernism contributed to this unfolding tradition. The briefest glance at Henry James's novels shows that several of them, especially *The Tragic Muse* (1889–90), involve direct engagement with aestheticism. At the turn of the century, Lucas Malet (Mary St. Leger Kingsley Harrison) produced exceptional novels, such as *The History of Richard Calmady* (1901), whose studied prose shows the impression that Pater's style left on naturalist fiction. Some years later, Ada Leveson summoned the aesthetic ethos in the trilogy *The Little Ottleys* (1908–16), which displays a fascination with erotic vicissitudes of the social elite that her close friend Wilde featured in his fiction and drama. The list, as lists tend to, could go on. Yet in its remarkable swerves from Ouida's untutored extravagance and Pater's "strenuous self-discipline" to Firbank's knowledgeable embellishments, this is a tradition that we still understand only in piecemeal fashion. As I trust this chapter has suggested, the time has come to reconstruct the dispersed history of the aesthetic novel in Britain, not least for its considerable legacy to modernist fiction.

Notes

1. Jocelyn Brooke, *Ronald Firbank* (London: Arthur Baker, 1951), 10. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (RF). Aldous Huxley, *Crome Yellow* (London: Chatto and Windus, 1921), 151–2.
2. Huxley, *Crome Yellow*, 152.
3. Firbank, *Valmouth*, in *The Complete Ronald Firbank* (London: Gerald Duckworth, 1961), 443. See Brooke, *Ronald Firbank*, 15.
4. Firbank, *Caprice*, in *The Complete Ronald Firbank*, 336.

5. Walter H. Pater, *Studies in the History of the Renaissance* (London: Macmillan, 1873), 213. Pater first used the phrase in "Poems by William Morris," *Westminster Review* 34, no. 2 (1868): 312. Algernon Charles Swinburne also used the phrase at this time; see *William Blake: A Critical Essay* (London: John Camden Hotten, 1868), 91.
6. Significant contributions to scholarship on the contexts of aesthetic fiction include Richard Dellamora, *Masculine Desire: The Sexual Politics of Victorian Aestheticism* (Chapel Hill, NC: University of North Carolina Press, 1990); Dennis Denisoff, *Aestheticism and Sexual Parody, 1840–1940* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001); Andrew Eastham, *Aesthetic Afterlives: Irony, Literary Modernity and the Ends of Beauty* (London: Continuum, 2011); Stefano Evangelista, *British Aestheticism and Ancient Greece: Hellenism, Reception, Gods in Exile* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2009); Jonathan L. Freedman, *Professions of Taste: Henry James, British Aestheticism, and Commodity Culture* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1990); Ruth Livesey, *Socialism, Sex, and the Culture of Aestheticism in Britain, 1880–1914* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007); Diana Maltz, *British Aestheticism and the Urban Working Classes, 1870–1900: Beauty for the People* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2006); Kathy Alexis Psomiades, *Beauty's Body: Femininity and Representation in Victorian Aestheticism* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1997); Talia Schaffer, *The Forgotten Female Aesthetes: Literary Culture in Late-Victorian England* (Charlottesville, VA: University Press of Virginia, 2000).
7. See, for example, Yvonne Ffrench, *Ouida: A Study in Ostentation* (London: Cobden-Sanderson, 1938), and Eileen Bigland, *Ouida: The Passionate Victorian* (London: Jarrolds, 1950).
8. Ouida, *Held in Bondage; or, Granville de Vigne, a Tale of the Day*, 3 vols. (London: Tinsley Brothers, 1863), 2:294–5.
9. [Edward Bulwer-Lytton], *Paul Clifford*, 3 vols. (London: Henry Colburn and Richard Bentley, 1830), 1:1.
10. Ouida, *Under Two Flags: A Story of the Household and the Desert*, 3 vols. (London: Chapman and Hall, 1867), 1:33, 64. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (UTF).
11. "G.," "The Long Arm of Coincidence," *Scots Observer*, 6 September 1890, 410. This comment arises in the critical offensive that the *Scots Observer* made over several months against Wilde's recently published *Picture of Dorian Gray*. The critic "G." suggests that Wilde's style owes much to the reprehensible Ouida's fiction.
12. [Anon.], Review of Ouida, *Under Two Flags*, *Pall Mall Gazette*, December 26, 1867, 12. In *Under Two Flags*, Bertie regards "the handsome Antinous-form" of his injured younger brother (1:123).

13. *Ibid.*, 12.
14. *Ibid.*, 12.
15. [Geraldine Jewsbury], Review of Ouida, *Under Two Flags*, *Athenæum*, February 15, 1868, 248.
16. *Ibid.*, 249.
17. [Oscar Wilde], "Ouida's New Novel," *Pall Mall Gazette*, May 17, 1889, 3, reprinted in Wilde, *Journalism Part II*, ed. Mark W. Turner; and John Stokes, *The Complete Works of Oscar Wilde*, 7 vols. to date (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000–continuing), 7:217.
18. *Ibid.*, 7:216, 217. Toward the end of his review Wilde listed several of "Ouida's aphorisms on women, love, and modern society," including "It is the folly of life that lends charm to it" (7:216).
19. [Alice Meynell], "Praises of Ouida," *Pall Mall Gazette*, August 16, 1895, 4.
20. *Ibid.*, 4.
21. G. S. Street, "An Appreciation of Ouida," *The Yellow Book*, 6 (1895): 175.
22. Beerbohm, "Ouida," *Saturday Review*, July 3, 1897, 8. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text ("Ouida"). Beerbohm reprinted "Ouida," in *More* (London: John Lane, 1899), 101–16; it is significant that he dedicated *More* to "Mlle. De la Ramée with the author's compliments and Ouida with his love."
23. Walter H. Pater, *Studies in the History of the Renaissance* (London: Macmillan, 1873), 212. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*SHR*). Pater later changed the line to read "ecstasy and sorrow of love, the various forms of enthusiastic activity" (*The Renaissance: Studies in Art and Poetry*, The 1893 Text, ed. Donald L. Hill [Berkeley: University of California Press, 1980], 190).
24. Arthur Symons, "The Nietzschean Follies, IV: Feminine Fiction," *The Smart Set*, 67, no. 4 (1922). Symons partly reiterates Beerbohm when he remarks of Ouida: "She loves beauty, but she loves it as a savage might love it" (124).
25. Walter Pater, *Marius the Epicurean: His Sensations and Ideas*, 2nd ed., 2 vols. (London: Macmillan, 1885), 1:31. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*ME*).
26. "Z.," Review of Pater, *Marius the Epicurean*, *Examiner*, April 12, 1873, 381. The Greek term recurs several times in Pater's novel.
27. *Ibid.*, 382.
28. *Ibid.*
29. "M. A. W." [Mary Augusta Ward], "Marius the Epicurean," *Macmillan's Magazine* 52 (1885): 136.
30. Vernon Lee, Letter, July 18, 1881, in *Vernon Lee's Letters*, ed. Irene Cooper Willis (n.p.: Privately Printed, 1937), 78.

31. Vernon Lee, *Renaissance Fancies and Studies* (London: Smith, Elder, 1895), 258.
32. *Ibid.*, 258.
33. Richard Le Gallienne, *The Romantic '90s* (New York: Doubleday, Page, 1926), 99.
34. *Ibid.*, 99–100.
35. Oscar Wilde, “To Lord Alfred Douglas” [January–March 1897], in *The Complete Letters of Oscar Wilde*, eds. Merlin Holland and Rupert Hart-Davis (London: Fourth Estate, 2000), 735.
36. [Anon.], Review of Wilde, *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, *St. James's Gazette*, June 20, 1890, reprinted in *Oscar Wilde: The Critical Heritage*, ed. Karl Beckson (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1970), 68.
37. [Anon.], Review of Wilde, *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, *Daily Chronicle*, June 30, 1890, 7, reprinted in Beckson, ed., *Oscar Wilde*, 72.
38. [Anon.], “Reviews and Magazines,” *Scots Observer* July 5, 1890, 181, reprinted in Beckson, ed., *Oscar Wilde*, 74.
39. Oscar Wilde, *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, ed. Joseph Bristow, vol. 3 of *The Complete Works of Oscar Wilde* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003), 3:167–8. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*DG*).
40. Ouida, *Othmar*, 3 vols. (London: Chatto and Windus, 1885), 1:63. On Ouida’s epigrammatic presence in Wilde’s fiction, see Talia Schaffer, “The Origins of the Aesthetic Novel: Ouida, Wilde, and the Popular Romance,” in *Wilde Writings: Contextual Conditions*, ed. Joseph Bristow (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2003), 212–29.
41. Beerbohm, “The Happy Hypocrite,” *The Yellow Book* 11 (1896): 11. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (“Happy”).
42. Beardsley, “Under the Hill: A Romanic Story,” *The Savoy* 1 (1896): 156.
43. Beardsley, *Under the Hill*, 156. Mentzelius (Christian Mentzel [1622–1701]) was a German botanist.
44. Henry Melancthon Strong, “Aubrey Beardsley,” *Westminster Review* 154, no. 1 (1900): 93.
45. *Ibid.*, 93.
46. Beardsley, *The Story of Venus and Tannhäuser* (London: Private Circulation [Leonard Smithers], 1907), 70.
47. *Ibid.*, 70–1.
48. [Anon.], Review of Firbank, *Vainglory*, *Academy*, June 26, 1915, 411.
49. *Ibid.*
50. Firbank, *Vainglory*, in *The Complete Ronald Firbank* (London: Gerald Duckworth, 1961), 80. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*V*).

51. On the links between Pater's "golden book" and Wilde's "yellow book," see Linda C. Dowling, *Language and Decadence in the Victorian Fin de Siècle* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1986), 104–74.
52. See Swinburne, "Anactoria," in *Poems and Ballads* (London: John Camden Hotten, 1866), 65–76, and Michael Field, *Long Ago* (London: David Nutt, 1889).

What Is It Like to Be Conscious? Impressionism and the Problem of Qualia

Paul Armstrong

Consciousness has become a hot topic in the cognitive sciences because of the problem of “qualia,” the dilemma of how to explain the first-person, lived experience of a sensation such as “seeing red.”¹ This is also a central concern of impressionism. The term “impressionism” is so heterogeneous that it might seem to defy definition, ranging from the painters in Monet’s school to the literary impressionists who led the novel’s transition from realism to modernism (especially Henry James, Joseph Conrad, and Ford Madox Ford).² What “impressionism” generally designates, however, is an interest in developing representational techniques that would do justice to first-person perceptual experience. As one recent study observes, “literary impressionism is usually described as a set of stylistic and formal strategies designed to heighten our sense of individual perceptual experience,” and the term “impression,” although variously defined, “signifies the mark of sensory experience on human consciousness.”³ How to render the subjective experience of a sensation or a perception with paint or words is the distinctive challenge of impressionist art, and the difficulties (perhaps impossibility) of attaining this goal are responsible not only for the heterogeneity of impressionism but also for its many paradoxes and contradictions.

Historically, the impressionist project began with a desire to radicalize the aesthetic of realism by exposing and thematizing its epistemological conditions of possibility. In painting as well as literature, the impressionists became impatient with the conventions of representation because they were inconsistent with the workings of consciousness and consequently seemed artificial. The paradox of

impressionism, however, is that the attempt to render faithfully the perceptual processes through which consciousness knows the world thwarts mimetic illusion building. The result is art that can seem strange, baffling, and unrealistic and that calls attention to itself as art (the formal qualities of the picture plane or the textuality of narrative discourse). This paradox points the way to the abstraction and anti-mimetic textual play that characterize the aesthetic of modernism. The reasons for these changes have to do with the elusiveness of consciousness as a target of representation. Impressionism gives rise to modernism because of the instabilities of an aesthetic of qualia.

The term “qualia” is associated with the philosopher Thomas Nagel’s memorably titled essay “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?” in which he argues that conscious experience cannot be adequately explained in the objective terms of science. Nagel’s critique is aimed at the reductionist program of neuroscientists such as Francis Crick who, defiantly proclaiming “you’re nothing but a pack of neurons,” contends that “the neural correlate of ‘seeing red’” is objectively definable.⁴ Nagel is skeptical that first-person experience can be captured by the terms and concepts of the physical sciences because, he argues, “every subjective phenomenon is essentially connected with a single point of view, and it seems inevitable that an objective, physical theory will abandon that point of view.” As he observes, “even to form a conception of what it is like to be a bat (and a fortiori to know what it is like to be a bat) one must take up the bat’s point of view.”⁵ Whether humans without sonar echolocation can ever do this is perhaps doubtful, but it is worth noting that “point of view” is also a literary term often associated with impressionist art. Whether and how a point of view (of a human, if not a bat) can be rendered in a work of art so that the viewer or reader can imaginatively recreate its lived immediacy is the central question of impressionism.

Cognitive literary critics have recently argued that neuroscience has much to learn from literature because of its understanding of phenomena like qualia that defy objective, physical analysis.⁶ When David Lodge argues that “literature constitutes a kind of knowledge about consciousness which is complementary to scientific

knowledge,” it is no accident that the example he chooses is a novel by Henry James. After the cognitive scientist in Lodge’s novel *Thinks* . . . explains “the problem of consciousness” (i.e., “how to give an objective, third-person account of a subjective, first-person phenomenon”), the other lead character who not coincidentally happens to be a creative writer replies: “Oh, but novelists have been doing that for the last two hundred years,” and as proof she recites from memory the opening lines of *Wings of the Dove*. As Lodge observes, “we read novels like *The Wings of the Dove* because they give us a convincing sense of what the consciousness of people other than ourselves is like.”⁷ This accomplishment is not unique to impressionism (the other example Lodge’s writer gives is a poem by Andrew Marvell), but the impressionist aesthetic is of special cognitive interest because it represents not primarily the “what” of the world but the “how” of its perception by consciousness. This thematization of perception lays bare processes, problems, and paradoxes that are involved whenever literature and other arts attempt to render subjective experience.

These experiments are instructive because the access literature provides to qualia is not as straightforward as Lodge suggests. The artistic representation of experience is not, after all, a matter of simply offering up consciousness for direct inspection or of immersing us fully and immediately in another world. The “like” in “what it is like” can only be rendered by the “as if” of aesthetic staging.⁸ When literary works from whatever genre or period attempt to recreate what it is like to be someone other than ourselves, they can only do so by using styles, conventions, and techniques that are not identical to the subjective experience they seek to represent. Hence the paradox of Lodge’s example that Henry James renders the consciousness of Kate Croy not immediately and directly but through a recognizable, finely wrought, and notoriously controversial literary style.

Although similarly an attempt to capture the immediacy of perceptual experience, impressionist painting is also an identifiable style – so much so that what was originally a protest against established artistic methods would eventually become a convention

and even (some might say) a cliché (avant-garde works turned into calendar art). Lodge credits the invention of “free indirect style” with giving novels extraordinary power to open up inside views into other lives (see *Consciousness* 37–57). Not simply natural, immediate, and transparent, however, this technique is a contingent historical construct – a stylistic convention that only emerged through a long history of literary experimentation and that can be deployed in a variety of ways for different purposes.⁹ Literature may have powers to render what it is like to be conscious that the objective measures of science lack, but there is still a gap between the “as” of the “as if” recreation of another point of view in art and the immediacy of first-person consciousness. This gap is both disabling and empowering. It prevents literature from ever completely transcending the divide between one consciousness and another, but it also makes it possible for art to stage versions of other lives and to experiment with different ways of doing so.

Impressionism exposes this gap by attempting to overcome it, and this is why it is such a paradoxical phenomenon. Consider, for example, the contradictory aims and effects of Monet’s painting *Impression: Sunrise* (1872), often cited as emblematic of the impressionist aesthetic (see [Figure 1](#)). An attempt to render a visual sensation at a particular moment, under specific conditions of light and atmosphere, this painting exemplifies Zola’s description of impressionism as “a corner of nature seen through a temperament.”¹⁰ Aiming to capture accurately and precisely the experiential effects of a moment, it is both objective and subjective. Hence the paradox that impressionism has been regarded as not only more “scientific” but also more personal and phenomenal in its approach to representation than the conventions of realism it challenges.¹¹ The claim to greater realism of Monet’s painting of the sunrise is both its truth to the atmospheric conditions of the moment and its truth to the perceiver’s visual sensations. In a further important complication, however, it can only represent this perceptual experience in an arrangement of colored brushstrokes, and so another contradiction of this painting – one that looks forward to modernism’s focus on the picture plane – is that its atmospheric, sensational effects depend on

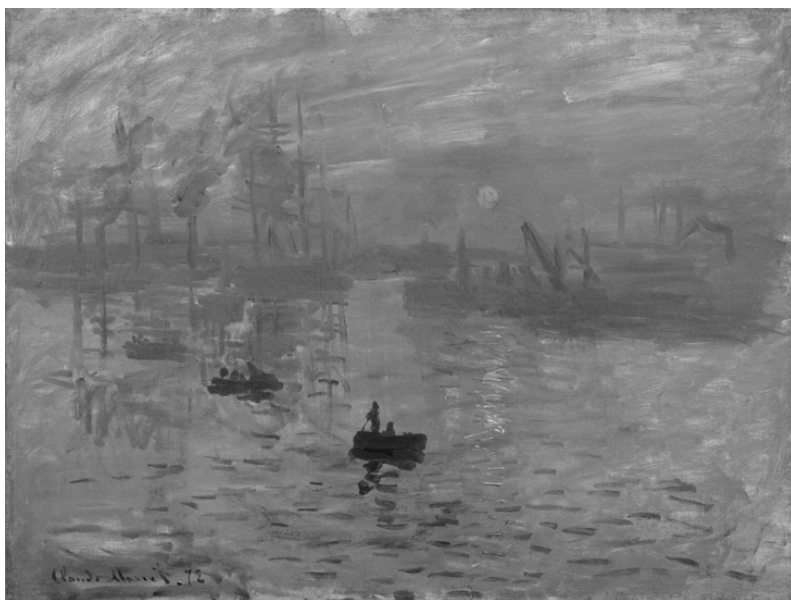


Figure 1 Monet, *Impression: Sunrise* (1872)

relations between color contrasts (red versus blue), shapes (the intense, off-center circle of sun and the sketchily indicated ships), and brushstrokes (vigorously and roughly applied in the sky and the water) that emphasize its tangibility as a made object (even signed and dated by its maker in the lower left corner).

The effects of these contradictions on the viewer are paradoxical and double, simultaneously immediate and reflective. Monet's painting is both an incitement to vicarious immersion in a momentary sensation and a call to reflect on the cognitive conditions it simulates as well as on the artistic techniques whereby it criticizes the unnaturalness of realism. As the art historian James Rubin perceptively notes, "Monet's techniques concentrate on purely visual phenomena to create a fascinating interplay between presence and absence – an interplay that calls attention to representation and illusion."¹² Oscillating between presence and absence, this painting seeks to render a first-person experience that it is not and cannot be, and its effort to create a simulacrum of experience foregrounds the material,

technical means through which it seeks to do so. This contradiction has the paradoxical effect of promoting aesthetic reflection about the formal features of the work (the abstract play of colors on the picture plane that is a harbinger of modernist abstraction) even as it incites the viewer to recreate an “as if” doubling of the original moment of sensation – a simulacrum of the moment that both is and is not what Monet experienced. The qualia of the sensation of the sunrise is both there and not there in Monet’s painting, and this duality sets in motion an oscillation between sensuous immersion and epistemological, aesthetic reflection.

These oppositions are evident in the conflict between two famous beholders, John Ruskin and E. H. Gombrich, who disagree about impressionism because they emphasize contrary poles of its defining paradoxes. According to Ruskin’s well-known formulation, “the whole technical power of painting depends on our recovery of what may be called the *innocence of the eye*; that is to say, of a sort of childish perception of these flat stains of colour, merely as such, without consciousness of what they signify, as a blind man would see them if suddenly gifted with sight.”¹³ Ironically and inevitably, this account of primordial perception prior to the imposition of conventional categories relies on metaphors – fanciful comparisons to how a child or a blind person would see that are not strictly accurate. As the neuroscience of vision has discovered, the rear visual cortex will atrophy if it fails to receive stimuli during critical periods of early life that allow it to organize itself.¹⁴ Without establishing patterns of response to orientation, movement, and color, the visual brain loses its ability to make neuronal connections, and so a blind person who was suddenly granted vision literally could not see. Even if Monet’s painting is not how either a child or a sightless person would perceive the scene, Ruskin’s comparison is nevertheless evocative because it uses the “as if” of figurative language to suggest in memorable terms what it is like to have an original sensation.

Famously objecting that “the innocent eye is a myth,” Gombrich insists on the role of “schemas” in perception and painting: “seeing is never just registering. It is the reaction of the whole organism to the patterns of light that stimulate the back of our eyes.”¹⁵ This is indeed

a central doctrine of contemporary neuroscience, which understands vision as a to-and-fro process of assembling inputs back and forth across the visual cortex. In ways Gombrich insufficiently credits, however, impressionism also entails purposive play with pattern. Monet's painting relies on gestalts and constructs for its effects, not only in the formal alignment and juxtaposition of shapes and colors on the picture plane, but also in the viewer's ability to recognize features of the scene (the ships and the harbor, the rising sun, its reflection on the water) that both are and are not "there." The oscillations between presence and absence characteristic of the viewing experience are not evidence of formlessness but are the product of an interplay of figures and patterns. Ruskin and Gombrich are both wrong as well as right about what Monet is up to. Ruskin correctly understands that impressionism is an attempt to render qualia, but Gombrich is right that to do so it must deploy the aesthetic and cognitive resources of the "as if" to suggest "what it is like."

Similar paradoxes characterize literary impressionism, as is evident in the notoriously contradictory pronouncements of its most prominent advocate, the novelist and critic Ford Madox Ford. According to Ford, "any piece of Impressionism, whether it be prose, or verse, or painting, or sculpture, is the record of the impression of a moment."¹⁶ The goal is to produce "the sort of odd vibration that scenes in real life really have; you would give your reader the impression . . . that he was passing through an experience," with "the complexity, the tantalisation, the shimmering, the haze, that life is."¹⁷ As Ford and his sometime collaborator Joseph Conrad recognized, "Life did not narrate, but made impressions on our brains. We in turn, if we wished to produce on you an effect of life, must not narrate but render impressions" (Conrad 194–95). Following this advice, impressionist narratives such as *The Good Soldier* and *Lord Jim* disrupt temporal continuity, jumping back and forth across time to offer disconnected perspectives on events and characters that can be bewildering because they resist our attempt to build patterns. Ford claims that "the object of the novelist is to keep the reader entirely oblivious of the fact that the author exists – even of the fact that he is

reading a book" (Conrad 199). But these disorienting techniques would seem to have the opposite effect. Rather than promoting discursive invisibility, they call attention to the constructedness of the text and to the cognitive processes its disjunctions dramatize.¹⁸

As with the oscillations between presence and absence set in motion by *Impression: Sunrise*, this contradiction foregrounds the fact that qualia cannot be given directly and immediately in painting or literature but can only be recreated, simulated, and staged through manipulations of the "as if." Hence Ford's claim that "the Impressionist must always exaggerate" ("On Impressionism" 36), advice which would seem to fly in the face of his doctrine that the author and the text must disappear. Distortion is inevitable in painting and literature, however, because representation necessarily renders something "as" something other than itself. Rather than seeking to disguise this dilemma through mimetic illusion making, the disruptions of impressionism expose it.

Impressionism consequently has much in common with Viktor Shklovsky's well-known aesthetic of defamiliarization. The purpose of art, according to Shklovsky, is "to make objects 'unfamiliar,' to make forms difficult, to increase the difficulty and length of perception" and thereby to "recover the sensation of life, . . . to make one feel things, to make the stone *stony*."¹⁹ Similar to the oscillations set in motion by impressionism, the effects of such defamiliarizing techniques can be paradoxical – not only promoting a sense of presence by revivifying perception, but also disrupting immersion by promoting reflection about how habit blunts sensation, and in doing so calling attention to artistic forms that resist naturalization. This doubleness is akin to the effects of distraction and bewilderment that Ford describes as characteristically impressionist:

Indeed, I suppose Impressionism exists to render those queer effects of real life that are like so many views seen through bright glass – through glass so bright that whilst you perceive through it a landscape or a backyard, you are aware that, on its surface, it reflects the face of a person behind you. For the whole of life is really like that; we are almost always in one place with our minds somewhere quite other. ("On Impressionism" 41)

This is an experience of doubling, an oscillation between presence and absence – simultaneously a heightening of perception and an interruption of automatic processing that prompts the viewer to reflect about an odd optical effect, a peculiarity that is aesthetically interesting even as it foregrounds otherwise unnoticed aspects of consciousness. This duality both renders qualia – what it is like to have a visual sensation – and calls attention to the way in which the staging of “what it is like” requires a manipulation of the “as” (here figured as an experience of decentered consciousness as if we were in two places at once).

If the “as” of representation prevents the impressionists from presenting qualia immediately and directly, it also allows them to foreground and explore various aspects of perceptual experience, and the differences in how they do this are reflected in the multifariousness of the impressionist aesthetic. James, Conrad, and Ford develop characteristic representational strategies that dramatize three distinct aspects of perceptual life: how patterns of consistency building and gap filling define a particular point of view, how understanding is a temporal process of anticipation and retrospection, and how the relation between consciousnesses is paradoxically both intersubjective and solipsistic (complementary perspectives on a shared world riven by an unshareable my-ownness). Their techniques dramatize each of these dimensions of consciousness in ways that are correlated to what cognitive science reveals about the workings of the brain. Complementary to the kind of knowledge science can provide, their narrative experiments stage for the reader simulacra of what these different aspects of perceptual life are “like,” even as they call for reflection about their epistemological and aesthetic implications.

On the first point, it is a basic principle of cognitive science that the brain knows the world by constructing patterns. Despite centuries of visual metaphors that depict the mind as a “mirror,” the sensation that we are watching a full-color picture that corresponds point-by-point with the external world is an illusion – a complex illusion that the brain constructs so efficiently that we rarely notice the hermeneutic machinery that produces it. As neuroscientist Semir Zeki notes, “what we see is determined as much by the organisation

and laws of the brain as by the physical reality of the external world.”²⁰ Visual inputs are filtered and differentiated according to the variable sensitivities of the receptors on the retina (rods and cones) and of the pathways transporting them (large- and small-ganglion cells that lead to the optic nerve). These separate, distinctive signals are then structured into patterns by the reciprocal interactions among visual systems within the cortex. For example, color does not exist as such in the external world but is a complex construction of constancies out of a flux of inputs that depends on the sensitivities of our sensory apparatus and interactions between neurons across the cortex. Different areas of the rear visual cortex are specialized to detect orientation, motion, and color and to identify objects and faces, and vision is a complex process of “binding” (to use the customary neuroscientific term) that synthesizes the activity of anatomically distinct, relatively autonomous regions of the brain. Because of the interactions produced by these reciprocal connections, the brain makes it possible for us to see by combining parts into meaningful patterns. Vision is literally hermeneutic – a circular, recursive process of assembling parts into wholes.

What this constructive activity is “like” in the experience of consciousness is a defining preoccupation of literary impressionism. James makes “point of view” a central principle of novelistic composition because of his fascination with the constructive powers of consciousness – how we know the world by “guessing the unseen from the seen” and composing patterns from a limited perspective that leaves some things hidden and indeterminate.²¹ Readers of *What Maisie Knew* or *The Ambassadors* are given a simulacrum of what this composing power is “like” – an “as if” experience of seeing the world as Maisie or Strether do but also noting ironically what they probably fail to observe or too imaginatively fill out (so that we share the child’s bewilderment even as we understand the narcissistic machinations of adults that baffle her, and we are not as surprised as Strether is when he learns that the “virtuous attachment” between Chad and Madame de Vionnet is not purely chaste). By thematizing a character’s perspective on the world and dramatizing how it is constructed according to certain assumptions, habits, and

expectations, James allows us to immerse ourselves in another consciousness (experiencing what it is like to share their point of view) even as we also observe its characteristic limitations and blind spots and notice the disjunctions between its hold on the world and other points of view that would construe things differently (the adults who cruelly laugh at Maisie's naïve questions, or Woollett's worries that Strether has been carried away by the Parisian Babylon). This doubleness calls attention to the constructive powers of cognitive pattern making that we ordinarily do not notice in everyday perception and that traditionally realistic fiction tacitly employs to portray objects and characters by unfolding a series of aspects that display them. James's experiments with point of view make perspectives a theme in themselves and playfully shuttle his readers back and forth between inhabiting another consciousness from the inside and observing with ironic detachment the defining strengths and vulnerabilities that characterize its constructive activities.

Conrad's and Ford's ambiguous, fragmentary narratives deploy different techniques for similar purposes. In *Lord Jim*, the inconsistencies between the different perspectives Marlow receives on the titular character resist synthesis into a coherent point of view and consequently leave him frustrated and bewildered: "The views he let me have of himself were like those glimpses through the shifting rents in a thick fog – bits of vivid and vanishing detail, giving no connected idea of the general aspect of a country. They fed one's curiosity without satisfying it; they were no good for purposes of orientation."²² Marlow's glimpses of Jim remain fragmentary and disconnected, and their refusal to synthesize foregrounds the drive to build consistency among elements in a pattern that is necessary for lucid comprehension. In Ford's impressionistic masterpiece *The Good Soldier*, the similar inability of the narrator Dowell to reconcile different versions of events as he revisits and revises his many mistaken assumptions and beliefs also leaves him baffled: "I don't know. I leave it to you," he repeatedly tells the reader even as his narrative draws to its inconclusive close.²³ The notorious ambiguities of both of these novels challenge and defy the reader to do a better job of fitting evidence into consistent patterns. In wondering

whether to trust or doubt their narrators' explanations and interpretations, we replay their uncertainties in our own experience. In this respect these texts resemble those ambiguous figures that can be construed as either a rabbit or a duck or as an urn or two faces – figures that fascinate cognitive scientists because they play with and lay bare the reliance of consciousness on patterns to make sense of the world.²⁴

The impressionists' strategies of narrative fragmentation also call attention to the temporal dynamics of consciousness. Consistency building in reading, as in life, is a temporal process of projecting expectations about pattern that are then modified, refined, or overturned. As the psychologist and proto-cognitive scientist William James liked to say, "we live forwards, . . . but we understand backwards."²⁵ Neuroscientist Francisco Varela has shown how the lived experience of time's to and fro is correlated to how neurons fire (how they generate "action potentials") and to how neuronal assemblies form and dissolve.²⁶ Neuronal assemblies come and go in a cycle of excitation and relaxation that exhibits a particular periodicity. This rhythm is a natural property not only of single neurons but also of collections of brain cells, and it is the neural correlate of our consciousness of time passing. The temporality of brain rhythms makes it possible for different regions of the brain to coordinate their activities. When we listen to music at a concert or watch a music video, for example, regions of the brain interact from the far corners of the cortex: auditory neurons in the mid-brain, motor and sensory areas across the central sulcus (as we tap our feet or recall playing an instrument), the visual cortex (as we coordinate what we see and what we hear), and areas of the cerebellum and the amygdala (as we respond emotionally). After an assembly is synchronized through a wavelike pattern of oscillatory excitation, it relaxes and must form again – or be replaced by another assembly. This pattern of phases corresponds neurologically to the rhythms of the passing moment as we read or listen to music.

Ford and Conrad elevate the to-and-fro process of temporal assembly from a cognitive necessity into an aesthetic principle. Arguing in the name of a heightened realism, Ford claims that

“what was the matter with the Novel, and the British novel in particular, was that it went straight forward, whereas in your gradual making acquaintanceship with your fellows you never do go straight forward” (*Conrad* 136). By keeping a rough parallel between the chronology of presentation and the sequential order of events, the novels Ford criticizes assist the reader’s efforts to discover and build patterns and thereby actually encourage the immersion in an illusion on which realism depends. Ford’s point, however, is that this continuity disguises the processes it manipulates. In getting to know any state of affairs, we “never do go straight forward” inasmuch as we are always going back and forth between expectations about what lies beyond our horizons and corrections of previous guesses in light of evidence that has since come into view. By making the bewildered reader work harder and more reflectively than with continuous narration to build coherent patterns out of the scattered bits and pieces that a Dowell or a Marlow offers, Ford and Conrad transform anticipation and retrospection from implicit cognitive processes into explicit issues in the experience of reading.

James dramatizes the temporality of understanding through different but related strategies that attempt to stage what it is like for a point of view to revise itself. Where Ford’s and Conrad’s readers must go back and forth to clarify retrospectively what a fragmentary presentation may initially leave mysterious, James typically invokes a kind of temporal double vision that joins together simultaneously the perceptions of a present moment and future acts of backward-looking reflection. At key dramatic moments when unexpected complications take Strether’s consciousness by surprise, James depicts in tandem the immediacy of his present experience and the mediating musings of the future that reflect back on it as part of the past. For example, when Strether unexpectedly encounters Chad and Madame de Vionnet in the countryside, the narrative soon shifts from the simple present to a complex temporal double vision that holds two pictures against each other simultaneously – the embarrassments of the moment that everyone awkwardly attempts to cover over and our hero lost in thought on his bedroom sofa until the early hours of the following morning: “He was to reflect later on and in

private . . . Strether was afterwards to remember . . . Strether was afterwards to remember further . . . he was to remember further still.”²⁷ This conjoined rendering of the scene itself and Strether’s retrospective reflections on its various meanings and implications is a more complicated version of Isabel Archer’s famous all-night vigil in chapter 42 of *Portrait of a Lady*, where James depicts the present of self-consciousness as it looks back over the past. In the temporal double vision of *The Ambassadors*, James plays with how we live forward but understand backward by simultaneously showing Strether doing both.

The literary impressionists play similar double games with the reader in order to stage what it is like to share the world with other consciousnesses. Any experience of reading entails a doubling of my consciousness with the intentionality held ready by the text that enacts what Merleau-Ponty memorably calls “the paradox of the alter ego.” As he explains, “the social is already there when we come to know or judge it” because the intersubjectivity of experience is primordially given with our perception of a common world. And yet, Merleau-Ponty continues, “there is . . . a solipsism rooted in living experience and quite insurmountable” because I am destined never to experience the presence of another person to him- or herself.²⁸

Neuroscience has proposed three ways of explaining the paradox of the alter ego, and the emerging consensus is that all three probably work in combination in the brain’s complicated, messy interactions with the social world.²⁹ The first approach, known as “theory of mind” (ToM) or “theory theory” (TT), focuses on our capacity to attribute mental states to others – to engage in “mind reading” through which we theorize about the beliefs, desires, and intentions of others that we recognize may differ from our own. The second approach, “simulation theory” (ST), argues that we do not need “theories” to understand the simple, everyday behavior of others but that we instead automatically run “simulation routines” that put ourselves in their shoes by using our own thoughts and feelings as a model for what they must be experiencing. Critics of ST claim it begs the question of how the simulator senses what is going on in the other person, but an answer may be provided by “mirror neurons”

that were first discovered in the motor cortex of the macaque monkey. These neurons fired not only when the animal performed a specific action but also when it observed the same action by another monkey or an experimenter – not only when the monkey grasped a piece of food, for example, but also when the scientist did the same thing. Experiments have shown that mirroring processes are evident not only in the motor cortex but also across the brain, in regions associated (for example) with emotion, pain, and disgust. All three of these theories are attempts to explain the acts of doubling “me” and “not me” that human beings routinely, automatically engage in as they negotiate their way through a paradoxically intersubjective and solipsistic world.

James thematizes this doubling in his experiments with point of view. By projecting the reader into the world of the character whose perspective he recreates – into Maggie’s suffering but scheming consciousness in the second half of *The Golden Bowl*, for example, as she learns to read the inwardness of other characters while holding herself opaque – James gives us a rare view of another life from the inside, experienced by another for herself. Simulating and mirroring her consciousness, the reader experiences as she does the gap between her perspective and other points of view that remain obscure and mysterious to varying degrees. Theorize as we might about other minds, we can never know, for example, whether Adam Verver shares his daughter’s awakening, or whether Charlotte realizes she is defeated even though she pretends victory. This double movement of transcending and reencountering the gap between selves dramatizes in the reader’s own experience the paradox of the alter ego and stages what it is like to theorize, simulate, and mirror other consciousnesses.

More radical than James in their skepticism that no amount of doubling can ever close this gap completely, Ford and Conrad develop narrative techniques that call attention to the otherness of the other that makes intersubjective relations also solipsistic. Their works return again and again to the residue of opacity left over by any act of theorization, simulation, or mirroring. In *The Good Soldier*, for example, Dowell affirms his intersubjective bond

with others by imagining a “silent listener” with whom he will share his reflections, only to complain almost immediately that this presence is absent and no help at all: “You, the listener, sit opposite me. But you are so silent. You don’t tell me anything” (*Good Soldier* 19). If the collapse of everything he had taken for granted about his world has shown Dowell how isolated he was even as he thought himself a member of a community, he seeks through writing to overcome his newfound solipsism only to discover it again because we, his readers, cannot converse with him. Marlow similarly reaches out to another only to be confronted with the barriers dividing us: “It is when we try to grapple with another man’s intimate need that we perceive how incomprehensible, wavering and misty are the beings that share with us the sight of the stars and the warmth of the sun. It is as if loneliness were a hard and absolute condition of existence” (*Lord Jim* 137). By multiplying Marlow’s informants and dramatizing their irreconcilability, Conrad opens Jim’s world to us only to emphasize its impenetrability. According to James, reading a literary work “makes it appear to us for the time that we have lived another life – that we have had a miraculous enlargement of experience.”³⁰ More complex and paradoxical than this formulation suggests, however, the experience of reading impressionist fiction is a simulacrum of the odd if everyday sensation that other consciousnesses are both complementary and inaccessible to our own.

One of the curiosities of impressionist experimentation in both painting and literature is that it must resort to such complicated technical innovation in order to render the seemingly simple, self-evident presence of consciousness to itself. But this contradiction is also a defining characteristic of modernism. For example, after denouncing the “tyranny” of plot and the “ill-fitting vestments” of conventional representation that fail to capture life’s “luminous halo,” Virginia Woolf memorably demands: “Let us record the atoms as they fall upon the mind in the order in which they fall.”³¹ She recognizes as well, however, that rendering first-person experience in all of its immediacy requires techniques and conventions, and

so she worries that her generation will be condemned to “a season of failures and fragments,” “smashing” and “crashing” and “writing against the grain,” because “the Edwardian tools are the wrong ones for us to use” and more adequate techniques have yet to be invented.³²

Hence the seeming paradox that the effort to render “what it is like” to be conscious produces a panoply of stylistic innovations, from Woolf and Joyce to Faulkner and beyond, a technical variety that the overused umbrella term “stream of consciousness” drastically oversimplifies. The issue is not which of these modernists’ distinctive modes of stylistic experimentation gets the “luminous halo” of qualia right.³³ Is “Time Passes” a more accurate representation of the “atoms” than “Sirens” or “Oxen of the Sun”? Is Benjy’s narration a more faithful rendering of consciousness than Quentin’s or Jason’s – or Mrs. Ramsay’s, or Leopold Bloom’s, or his wife Molly’s? The absurdity of these questions suggests that this is not the right way to frame the problem. What the experiments of the modernists and the impressionists reveal, rather, is that the quest to render the “what it is like” of qualia requires the deployment of the “as if” of representation and that this is open to endless variation.

The point is not that James, Conrad, and Ford are more or less “right” about consciousness but that their different technical experiments with figuring “what it is like” to be conscious use the “as if” to stage in the reading experience various dimensions of cognitive experience that neuroscience explores from its different perspective. The variability of the “as” in the “as if” and the “like” in “what it is like” is what gives rise to the variety of stylistic experimentation through which impressionism and modernism stage and explore consciousness, never getting “it” quite right because they are always staging what it is “like,” a process of experimentation, innovation, and variation that makes representation historical. Literature can never fully capture “what it is like” to be conscious any more than science can, but the experiments of impressionism and modernism can help us to understand why this is so, even as they attempt to transcend the limits of the “as if” and convey an experience that is beyond their grasp.

Notes

1. For example, see Nicholas Humphrey, *Seeing Red: A Study in Consciousness* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2006).
2. These figures are the primary focus of this chapter, but the term “impressionism” is sometimes extended to include any writer who attempts to render subjective experience, from Walter Pater and Stephen Crane to Joyce, Proust, and Woolf. For example, see Maria Elisabeth Kronegger, *Literary Impressionism* (New Haven, CT: College and University Press, 1973).
3. Adam Parkes, *A Sense of Shock: The Impact of Impressionism on Modern British and Irish Writing* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011), ix.
4. Francis Crick, *The Astonishing Hypothesis* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1994), 3, 9.
5. Thomas Nagel, “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?” *Philosophical Review* 83 (1974): 442, 437, 442n. For an instructive commentary on Nagel’s argument, see Jaegwon Kim, *Philosophy of Mind*, 3rd ed. (Boulder, CO: Westview, 2011), 267–71.
6. For example, see Alan Richardson, “Defaulting to Fiction: Neuroscience Rediscovered the Romantic Imagination,” *Poetics Today* 32 (2011): 663–92.
7. David Lodge, *Consciousness and the Novel* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2002), 16, 29–30. He quotes his novel *Thinks . . .* (New York: Penguin, 2001), 42–3.
8. See Wolfgang Iser, *The Fictive and the Imaginary* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1993).
9. See Erich Auerbach, *Mimesis: The Representation of Reality in Western Literature* (1946), trans. Willard Trask (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2003), and Dorrit Cohn, *Transparent Minds: Narrative Modes for Presenting Consciousness in Fiction* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1978).
10. Quoted in James H. Rubin, *Impressionism* (New York: Phaidon, 1999), 48.
11. See Mary Tompkins Lewis, “The Critical History of Impressionism,” in *Critical Readings in Impressionism and Post-Impressionism*, ed. Mary Tompkins Lewis (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2007), 1–19.
12. Rubin, *Impressionism*, 115.
13. James Ruskin, *The Elements of Drawing* (London: Smith, Elder, 1857), 6n (original emphasis).
14. See the classic experiments of Thorstein N. Wiesel and David Hubel on the impact of visual experience on the development of the visual cortex, especially “Extent of Recovery from the Effects of Visual Deprivation in

- Kittens," *Journal of Neurophysiology* 28 (1965): 1060–72. On the neuroscience of vision and its aesthetic implications, see my book *How Literature Plays with the Brain: The Neuroscience of Reading and Art* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2013), 54–90.
15. E. H. Gombrich, *Art and Illusion* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1960), 298.
 16. Ford Madox Ford, "On Impressionism" (1913), in *Critical Writings of Ford Madox Ford*, ed. Frank MacShane (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1964), 41.
 17. Ford, "On Impressionism," 42; Ford Madox Ford, *Joseph Conrad: A Personal Remembrance* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1924), 204.
 18. The analysis here and in what follows develops arguments originally introduced in my book *The Challenge of Bewilderment: Understanding and Representation in James, Conrad, and Ford* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1987).
 19. Viktor Shklovsky, "Art as Technique" (1917), in *Russian Formalist Criticism: Four Essays*, trans. Lee T. Lemon and Marion J. Reis (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1965), 22, 12.
 20. Semir Zeki, *Inner Vision: An Exploration of Art and the Brain* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999), 3.
 21. Henry James, "The Art of Fiction," in *Partial Portraits* (1888) (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1970), 12.
 22. Joseph Conrad, *Lord Jim* (1900), eds. J. H. Stape and Ernest W. Sullivan II (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012), 62.
 23. Ford Madox Ford, *The Good Soldier* (1915), ed. Thomas C. Moser (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1990), 282.
 24. See Semir Zeki, "The Neurology of Ambiguity," *Consciousness and Cognition* 13 (2004): 173–96. Also see the chapter "The Neuroscience of the Hermeneutic Circle," in my *How Literature Plays with the Brain*, 55–76.
 25. William James, *Pragmatism* (1907) (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1978), 107. He attributes this phrase to "a Danish thinker" whom his editors identify as Søren Kierkegaard.
 26. See Francisco J. Varela, "The Specious Present: A Neurophenomenology of Time Consciousness," in *Naturalizing Phenomenology: Issues in Contemporary Phenomenology and Cognitive Science*, eds. Jean Petitot et al. (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1999), 266–314. Also see the chapter "The Temporality of Reading and the Decentered Brain" in my *How Literature Plays with the Brain*, 91–130.
 27. Henry James, *The Ambassadors* (1903), in *The Novels and Tales of Henry James* (New York: Scribner's, 1909), 22:259–60.

28. Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945), trans. Colin Smith (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1962), 362, 358.
29. See the chapter “The Social Brain and the Paradox of the Alter Ego,” in my *How Literature Plays with the Brain*, 131–74.
30. James, “Alphonse Daudet” in *Partial Portraits*, 227–8.
31. Virginia Woolf, “Modern Fiction” (1921), in *The Common Reader: First Series* (1925), ed. Andrew McNeillie (New York: Harcourt, 1984), 149–50.
32. Virginia Woolf, “Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown” (1924), in *The Captain’s Deathbed and Other Essays* (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1950), 112, 114, 116, 117.
33. The prominent cognitive narratologist David Herman makes this mistake when he characterizes modernist techniques as a teleological progress toward the insights of the “enactivist” theories of cognitive science. See his essay “1880–1945: Re-minding Modernism,” in *The Emergence of Mind: Representations of Consciousness in Narrative Discourse in English*, ed. Herman (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2011), 243–72.

*Modernism and the French Novel: A Genealogy
(1888–1913)*

Jean-Michel Rabaté

In the last decade of the nineteenth century, Marcel Proust evoked the “power of the novelist” with a startling image: “We stand in front of the novelist as slaves in front the Emperor: with one word, he can set us free (*il peut nous affranchir*).”¹ When we move into a fictional universe, we become someone else: a general, a weaver, a singer, a peasant. We experience other lives by proxy; we leave our cares and selves behind in a giddy superabundance of freedom. Proust’s choice of words evokes another freedom, the freedom of the artist liberated from stylistic constraints, as exemplified by symbolist poets who had discovered “free verse.” Stéphane Mallarmé had called a “crisis in verse” the moment when the ancient tyranny of the alexandrine had been destroyed. When in 1897 Mallarmé observed that “[l]iterature is here undergoing an exquisite and fundamental crisis,”² “literature” referred to poetry only. Victor Hugo had confiscated verse, swallowing it in his larger than life personality. The “very modern taste”³ praised by Mallarmé led to the practice of “free verse,” which meant abandoning the codes, rules, and guidelines that had determined French versification for centuries. However, as Proust pointed out, the escape from formal shackles abundantly displayed by French poets after Rimbaud, Lautréamont, Verlaine, and Mallarmé, ushered in a new conformism, not the larger freedom that would concern “literature” at large.

In Proust’s view, the perverse effect of the newly gained freedom of the post-symbolist poets led to the prevalence of a modern obscurity. In 1896, Proust published “Against Obscurity”⁴ in the symbolist *Revue Blanche*, where he took to task the devotees of the new school for their habit of writing incomprehensibly. Proust

rejected the argument that obscurity stemmed from the invention of a new style. Even Hugo and Jean Racine had been accused of being obscure in their times, but this had little to do with the quest for obfuscation and circumlocution that he saw in symbolist writing. Proust pounced upon the deliberate obscurity of the moderns. Recent obscurity did not derive, he argued, from the depth of thought, as with Heraclitus or Hegel, since a poet who stuffs his works with philosophical reflections errs by having chosen the wrong genre. Such a caveat would be unheeded by Proust two decades later when he composed his magnum opus, which became a true “philosophical novel.” Yet, as he insisted, poetry should not be metaphysics by other means. Against the wish of symbolist poets to reach the “absolute” in verse, Proust praised the perfect simplicity of a prose writer like Anatole France.⁵ The new poets forgot that universal truths have to be embodied in particular characters or situations.

Stung by the criticism that he took as an “aggression,” Mallarmé replied immediately that his contemporaries did not know how to read.⁶ The “insult of obscurity” was used by “those who, in telling the crowd it doesn’t have to understand, are the first to simulate embarrassment.”⁷ This debate, which marks the turn of the century, cannot be reduced to an opposition between poetry and the novel or to a clash between experimental writing versus realistic fiction. It may have something of a generational divide, yet Proust was attacking less Mallarmé, whom he respected, than his younger epigones. This debate impacted the prose fiction written in French in the last decade of the nineteenth century and the first two of the twentieth, and is crucial for our understanding of modernism.

We need first to agree as to what we are referring to when talking about modernism in a French context. In a chapter devoted to French literary modernism, Kimberley Healey began with the assertion that French modernism did not exist.⁸ The term would be an Anglo-Saxon invention imported from the fifties and retroactively applied to works from the twenties and thirties. Indeed, it has been accepted by French literary critics only recently, since the 1990s say. However, the term that was current since Baudelaire was that of

“modernity.” It defines a French tradition that takes Baudelaire, Mallarmé, and Lautréamont as its beacons. Even if I tend to agree with this Malthusian assessment, I believe that something like a French modernism has existed and that its origins explain its peculiar character. It is exemplified both by authors who wrote in the wake of symbolism, like Edouard Dujardin, the younger André Gide, Alfred Jarry, and Guillaume Apollinaire, and by authors who come from different horizons such as Jules Romains and Marcel Proust.

The inventor of the term “modernity” in French was not Chateaubriand, who used it for the first time in his *Memoirs* to qualify the lack of beauty of the present age, but Charles Baudelaire, whose *Painter of Modern Life* launched the equation of beauty with modernity. On Baudelaire’s view, beauty was made up of two halves: an “eternal” half and an ephemeral or fashionable part. A painter such as Constantin Guys combined the transitory in his rapid Parisian sketches of passersby and a norm of absolute beauty. Guys represented beauty via fleeting street scenes and the vagaries of contemporary fashion. This aesthetic led to what we call modernism today only after it had been redefined by Rimbaud and Verlaine. It was Verlaine who used the term “modernism” in September 1872, but contra Walter Benjamin, who dubbed Paris the “Capital of the Nineteenth Century,” it referred not to Paris but to London. This was in a letter written to his friends after he had left Paris and abandoned his wife in order to live with Rimbaud. To his Parisian friends who still lived in a more ancient and stable cultural milieu, Verlaine had to give a taste of a different modernity, since London exemplified what he called his own “modernist” poetics: “London is (...) black as a crow and noisy as a duck, prudish although *all the vices are here for sale*, eternally drunk despite ridiculous *bills* on alcoholism, immense, although at bottom nothing but a confused collection of clamoring, rival, ugly and flat little towns; without *any monuments at all*, except its interminable docks (which anyway are sufficient for me and my more and more *modernist* poetics).”⁹ The term “modernist” was thus used in 1872, around the time of Pater’s *Renaissance* (1873), almost a decade before Henry James’s *Portrait of a Lady* (1880). In 1872, London appeared to Verlaine much as New

York appeared to Duchamp in 1915, the embodiment of a bold and stark modernity. The lack of monuments reflected the functionality of a city geared toward industrial production. The scale of its activities, endless docks revealing imperialist networks on a gigantic scale, rendered them quasi sublime. On that same spot, Verlaine and Rimbaud had been preceded by other French artists, Monet and Pissaro, who had gone to London in 1870, and came back full of “impressions.” Their pictorial equivalents proved productive since they launched the first artistic revolution of the nineteenth century: impressionism.

If for Verlaine the sublime infinity of the London docks generated a new poetics, it was because it could be distinguished from the avant-gardist quest for the “absolute” embodied by his more radical companion, Rimbaud. Verlaine’s modernism was a reaction to the verbal experimentations of Rimbaud. Rimbaud’s project aimed at a fundamental upheaval of all values and required the invention of a new language. Rimbaud never spoke of “modernism” but used terms such as the “modern” or the “impossible.” This is why he declared that “[w]e must be absolutely modern” in the last section of *A Season in Hell*.¹⁰ Yet, even if the motto of “One must be absolutely modern” is often seen as the key to Rimbaud’s poetics, its true meaning is more dubious, as the context evokes the loss of an “eternal sun” and a downward movement to a city of fire and mud. As we know, Rimbaud soon stopped writing; he left Verlaine to continue a French modernist tradition in verse. Which leads us back to the predicament sketched by Proust in 1887. How could one continue writing novels after the radical breaks in syntax and imagery produced by the cumulative effect of poets like Rimbaud and Mallarmé?

There was at least one positive answer to this quandary, and it came from a disciple of Mallarmé: Edouard Dujardin. His claim to fame rests on a slender novel that had an enormous impact on modernism in general. When Dujardin published *Les Lauriers sont coupés* in 1887, he knew that this was an experiment that he saw as a musical and poetic stylistic exercise. George Moore, who had a keen eye for formal novelty, praised it as it was serialized in 1887,¹¹ and then pointed it out to James Joyce who bought it in a railway kiosk in

1903 during his first stay in France. Joyce then played with his own concept of the interior monologue. Dujardin did not start *ex nihilo* the tradition of “stream-of-consciousness technique,” but he was the first writer who used it to narrate a whole story. Joyce may have acknowledged his debt to Dujardin in order to hide more important debts to Tolstoy, yet Dujardin revealed that this type of writing was possible, and could also be done better.¹² When *Ulysses* was published, Valéry Larbaud was alerted to the importance of Dujardin’s symbolist novel. It was slightly rewritten (Dujardin got rid of some symbolist mannerisms and pared down the style) when republished in 1924, but by then had been enshrined in the history of Anglo-Saxon modernism as a rare bridge between French symbolism and French modernism.

Dujardin’s author does not appear in the narrative. The absence of a third-person narrator finds an equivalent in Dorothy Richardson’s novels or in the “Penelope” episode of *Ulysses*, a novel in which interior monologue is usually framed in a third-person narrative. The opening paragraph presents a young man, who we will learn indirectly is called Daniel Prince, barely twenty, an inexperienced student, striding forward toward us in the midst of a Parisian crowd: “An evening of setting sun, remote air, deep skies; and of obscure crowds; sounds, shades, multitudes; infinite vastness of space; a vague evening. . . . For from the chaos of appearances [...] I emerge” (*BS*, 4, trans. modified). All the descriptions of Paris, of the people, even the dialogues, are filtered by the young man’s gaze: “Paris, on a bright evening of setting sun, the monotonous noises, the pale houses, the foliage of shadows; a milder evening; and the joy of being someone, of walking; the streets and multitudes, and, stretching far in the air, the sky; all around, Paris sings, and, in the haze of shapes perceived, softly it frames the idea” (*BS* 3). The impressionism of the passage is clear, but there is an unmistakable unanimist feel to this, an *unanimisme avant la lettre*, since the movement was launched by Jules Romains in 1908 only. However, here the most recurrent analogy is with music: the Paris crowd is a symphony made up a many individual motifs. Dujardin was one of the editors of the *Revue Wagnerienne*, and this was indeed the first Wagnerian novel.

The perspectivist mode of narration poses technical problems that are hard to solve. When we follow Prince as he goes up some stairs to visit a friend, the result sounds clunky: “Here’s the house I have to go into, where I shall find someone; the house; the entrance to the hall; let us go in. (...) The first floor landing; the wide, well-lit staircase, the windows. I’ve confided in him, in this decent friend of mine, about my love affair” (*BS* 3). Yet, as soon as the narrative progresses, a definite sense of rhythm imposes itself. Rhythm is provided by the interpenetration of the inner and outer worlds, in fact by the city itself, one of the most important characters in the novel. One can easily retrace the protagonist’s peregrinations on a map of Paris. At some point, Prince strolls down the boulevards, and the narrative blends various types of music with his own thoughts and reveries. He is full of sexual lust for the young woman he is going to see that night, and his inner monologue follows a roller-coaster ride from tumescence to detumescence and back. Popular songs lead to the repeated motif of “I love you more.” Prince catches himself as he is going to indulge in a true erotic fantasy, and his reverie is undercut by “I’ve my lecture tomorrow” (*BS* 47–9). Just like Bloom who ogles the sexy thigh of a beautiful woman in the street, Prince catches sight of an exciting red-haired woman under the arcades of Rue de Rivoli, but he is talking to a friend who distracts him as they reach Place du Palais-Royal, and then she is gone (*BS* 8). Stephen Dedalus glances through Mr. Deasy’s letter in “Nestor” just as we see Prince going through a series of letters written to him by Léa (*BS* 33–45), which allows for a recapitulation of his timid and tortuous courtship.

A mixture of dramatic irony and diffuse eroticism pervades the pages of *The Bays Are Sere*. Prince has fallen in love with a *cocotte*, Léa d’Arsay, a struggling actress performing in cheap plays. She takes advantage of his infatuation shamelessly, which is obvious to the reader, but not to Prince. By conceding minimal favors, Léa has already obtained handsome sums of money, whereas we know that Prince is hard-up, counts all his expenses, and relies on family stipends to make ends meet. Yet he cannot prevent himself from splurging to impress her. Now Prince has decided that Léa should

pay back in kind, or he will leave her. Ironically, she appears quite willing to pay up at one point, but he fails to seize the occasion. When he musters his courage at the end, she withdraws. We are privy to his mixture of scruples, since his love has to be “pure,” and sordid calculations: he has paid enough now, the time has come for him to spend a night with her. Indeed, Léa summons him to her place and tries to put her shy suitor at ease by pretending to fall asleep in his arms. A torrid evocation of her body follows, and yet it is couched in his own terrible symbolist clichés: “. . . and it is her body’s perfume I can sense in the deep essence of the mingling of flowers; yes, her woman’s being; and the profound mystery of her sex in love; lecherously, daemonically, when virile mastery of fleshly impulse surrenders to a kiss, thus the terrible, bitter, blanching ecstasy rises . . . To possess such joy!” (*BS* 55). In a hilarious anticlimax, Prince is so absorbed in his lurid fantasies that he dozes off. He is woken up by Léa’s taunting, “Congratulations, my dear” (*BS* 56). She also wonders where he has spent the previous night (“So didn’t you go to bed yesterday?” she asks [*BS* 56]), which hints at her own private nighttime schedule. Later, he kisses her hair without her noticing it, and she perceives the beating of his heart and asks in a mock-naïve way, “Something wrong with your heart?” (*BS* 57), which allows us to gauge how intense his excitement is. Since interior monologue is sustained throughout in *The Bays Are Sere*, the sexual innuendoes contained in the popular songs reverberating in his thoughts betray Prince’s ignorance, all the while generating dramatic irony. Prince’s words are at odds with his actions, as when he is at a loss for a compliment, paralyzed by ineptitude and inexperience. He hides his inhibition under a Romantic respect for pure feelings while adding up sums already spent for Léa in a sordid and obsessive spiral. Finally, sensing that this might be the night, he opts for action. A sequence of dreamy sentences is soon replaced by exhortations: “Goodbye to respect – long-drawn-out expressions of respect – for understanding love, the noble schemes, late-flowering loves, so lengthily prepared, departures, renunciations, goodbye to the renunciations, I want her!” (*BS* 77–8). The fluctuations of a lover’s indecision are captured in a myriad of tiny hesitations. Just

after this upsurge of emotions, Léa comes closer, puts her hands on Prince's shoulders. We are bracing for something like a kiss.

... and as I grow intoxicated and carried away with her, she speaks to me:

– You will come to the Fair at the Continental on Sunday: you'll see how pretty I'll be ...

Yes, indeed, *immortally*.

– I'll be very sorry not to see you; and then, I'll be a credit to you ...

Indeed, *you all-seductive and beloved one*.

– You'll bring me, won't you, that pinafore for my costume ...

Her costume? ... Yes, that pinafore, that money I promised her ... I'd

forgotten all about it. She wants the money at once ...¹³

Then, after he has surrendered the money he has in his pockets, Prince leaves without having achieved anything. Moreover, we are not sure whether his leave-taking is final; he takes the decision never to see her again yet says "Au revoir ("See you again") as they part. The book's refrain of "To the woods no more" will last as long as the song – a definitive farewell to a fickle mistress – is a simple goodbye that will be repeated soon after. Prince regrets not to have stuck to his resolution to leave Léa's honor intact, yet we know that he keeps lying to himself (*BS* 79). Indecision reigns supreme, a lesson that Joyce did not forget when he ended both *Exiles* and *Ulysses* with a sense of uncertainty and doubt.

Dujardin's originality is to let his characters expose themselves through speech, which forces readers to read between the lines. It is only when we realize how immature Prince is that the novel becomes truly funny. We follow him into a cheap restaurant where he fantasizes about seducing a beautiful woman sitting there, while being embarrassed about the food he orders. He dares not finish a succulent morsel of chicken for fear of looking clumsy, terrified at the thought of not looking at ease. Dujardin provides a subtle diagnosis of the French disease, the terror of being thought "ridiculous." We laugh and suffer when we accompany Prince in his vain quest for love. The game could be cruel, were it not for the function of an invisible yet skillful "arranger" who organizes musical recurrence and introduces rhythmic variety in a deft montage of narrative sequences. In modernist fiction, the place and function of the

narrator are expanded when they are not called into question. From Dujardin to Joyce, the quintessentially modernist figure of the “arranger” is an inner textual agency pulling all the strings of the characters and marshaling various narrative strategies. The more freedom is granted to a character, the more dependent he will be upon the hidden puppet master. Léa laughs behind her sleeve at Prince’s clumsiness. She exploits his weakness, and we laugh too both at his contradictions and at her wiles. Mallarmé was quick to perceive the novelty of Dujardin’s “discovery” in a letter of 1888: “you have set down a rapid and dancing mode of notation whose sole aim [. . .] is to express, without misapplication of the sublime means involved, an everyday life that is so crucial to grasp. So there is here less a happy result of chance than one of those discoveries we are all tending towards in our different ways.”¹⁴ *Le quotidien si précieux à saisir*, this sketches the program of French modernism. The point is less psychological realism than capturing the net of anonymous lives crossing each other in big cities, and rendering the rich polyphony made up of countless lives’ strivings in their half-hearted passions. Readers are immersed in the characters’ thoughts and interpret what they hide and reveal, while noticing how porous they are: the bustle of the streets, the glimpses of other people, the cheap music of organ grinders, friends’ desultory comments, all enter the mind of Prince and transforms his flat, limited, and one-sided perspective into a privileged filter for a collective apprehension of modern life. Dujardin knew that his invention remained a poetic device, which is how he defined interior monologue in 1931: “Interior monologue is, like poetry, unheard, unspoken speech, through which a character expresses his most intimate thoughts, closest to the unconscious, prior to all logical organization, that is to say as it comes into being, by means of sentences in direct speech reduced to their syntactic minimum, in order to give the impression of raw experience (*le tout venant*)” (*BS* 113).

It is no coincidence that Prince and Léa live in Paris, and that the only thing they can do together at night is hire a cab and take a ride through the Champs Elysées and other chic areas of the capital. We will go to very different parts of Paris with the hero of Charles-Louis

Philippe's *Bubu*, a novel discovered in Paris by the young T. S. Eliot in 1910, much as Joyce discovered Dujardin in 1903.

I now want to turn to three novels written at the same time, and which were felt to be “modern” but in widely different and divergent ways: Alfred Jarry's *Messaline* (1901) and *The Supermale* (*Le Surmâle*) (1902) and Charles-Louis Philippe's *Bubu de Montparnasse* (1901).

Jarry also derives from Mallarmé, who congratulated him on the success of *Ubu Roi* and corresponded with him. When Mallarmé died in 1898, Jarry attended the funeral. Jarry wrote a moving obituary discussing the “island of Ptyx,” as a way of alluding to the most esoteric and obscure of Mallarmé's sonnets, the sonnet in “X.”¹⁵ But it is also a bridge to a not yet invented movement, futurism: Marinetti was impressed by the Ubu plays, and met Jarry several times. In 1906, Jarry thanked Marinetti who has sent him *Roi Bombance*, a play inspired by his own Ubu series.¹⁶ Here, I want to focus on the two main novels published by Jarry, *Messaline* and *The Supermale*. While the first novel takes imperial Rome as its setting, the second is situated in the future, by a neat inversion, in 1920. What has not been translated into English is Jarry's subtitle for the second novel: “A modern novel.” *The Supermale* is indeed “modern” because it heaps up real and fantastic machines, bicycles, locomotives, fast cars, phonographs, dynamos, and a terrifying machine to inspire love, which finally explodes and kills the hero. In fact, the plot is very similar to that of *Messalina*: in both novels, the main characters seek a paroxysm of sexual pleasure from which they die after having beaten the world record in the accumulation of orgasms. The feminine half of the diptych is situated in the past of Suetonius and Tacitus, whereas the future is marked by American inventors and delirious machinery, but the central conceit is the same: sexual excess leads first to a new wisdom, then to an explosive demise.

In what sense is *The Supermale* a modernist novel? First, the narrative techniques are quite surprising: for the two main “events” narrated – the crazy bicycle race of ten thousand miles that is won by the hero, André Marcueil, against both a racing locomotive and a team of five cyclists fueled by “perpetual-motion-food,” and the sexual contest in which the hero, disguised as an Indian, is supposed

to have sex for a whole day and reach eighty-two orgasms – we have the mediating voices of a journalist and of a doctor who watches, records the feat, and speculates on God and “pataphysics,” the pseudo-science invented by Fautsroll, another character of Jarry. It can be called modernist in another sense, since even though it is shot through with science-fiction speculations about a futurist intermixing of men and machines, it keeps harking back to the past, and we know that Marcueil’s idea of being able to make love indefinitely comes from his reading about Messalina in a Latin text by Juvenal. The “novel of ancient Rome” and the “modern novel” are thus composed together and work as a lemniscate, the symbol of infinity embodied in the simple graphic representation of a bicycle. Marcueil is both a super-athlete and a fine Latinist who can take as his point of departure the word “*rigidae*” in Juvenal’s satire.¹⁷ The sexual meaning becomes clear after a while: Jarry believes that sexual excess leads to a superhuman transformation of women and men into a rigid phallus. The deliberate ithyphallicism sought by Messalina and Marcueil betrays in fact a bisexual fantasy; in Jarry’s world, men and women have the possibility of attaining a superhuman and paroxystic sexual bliss, almost always identical with death. This is why the love scene between Marcueil and the young passionaria Ellen is fraught with tension and aggression. After he reaches the fatidic number of eighty-two orgasms, Ellen feels hostility toward Marcueil, adding: “That wasn’t the least bit funny.” She even tries to blind his eyes with a pin, upon which he hypnotizes her to stop the attack.¹⁸ It is only after he mistakenly assumes that Ellen has died that Marcueil feels some belated tenderness, manifested by a long poem he recites on her body. He concludes: “I adore her,” but we discover that she wasn’t dead at all, and that the poem and the profession of love were in fact triggered by the last machine, the “love machine,” before it explodes and kills him.

We have entered another world; one can say that Jarry single-handedly invented both futurism and the desiring machines popularized by Deleuze and Guattari. It is not a coincidence that the best essay on Jarry’s philosophy was written by Gilles Deleuze.¹⁹ To move from Jarry, whose fame rested upon the immortal invention of

Ubu, to Charles-Louis Philippe, we require only the addition of one letter: obviously, when Philippe chose Bubu as the nickname of his eponymous hero for his best-known novel, he knew that he was adapting Jarry's frightening invention to a specific locale – what was a metaphysical and anarchist farce in Jarry's plays became the patient and empathic exploration of the Parisian world of pimps and prostitutes. Charles-Louis Philippe would probably not be included in the corpus of French modernist novelists had it not been for T. S. Eliot's testimony of the durable impact left on him by the novel. It brought to Eliot the phrase "mixing memory and desire" that he used at the beginning of the *Waste Land*, and oriented him in the idea of a critique of modern civilization via an examination of its sexual codes. Indeed, Charles-Louis Philippe blended modernism with the proletarian novel. Like Jarry, he died young, being thirty-five in 1909, and never tried to hide his poor background, his lack of education, and his lower social status. *Bubu de Montparnasse* dates from 1901 and is the first French novel that attempted to understand prostitution from the inside, that is, from the triple perspective of the agent (Berthe, who had a badly paid job, abandons it to prostitute herself); her initiator, protector and exploiter, Bubu; and her client. Thus we keep alternating between the points of view of Berthe; her client or "john," Pierre Hardy; and her pimp, Maurice Bélu, a.k.a Bubu. The events are based upon a misadventure that happened to Philippe: he had started living with a young prostitute, was hoping to reform her, but as soon as her pimp came back to claim her, she followed him. He then decided to investigate prostitution and wrote his novel, which feels both raw and documented. The plot of the novel is relatively straightforward: a pimp and a young man just arrived from the province vie for Berthe's affection. She is a young and charming prostitute who catches syphilis. Bubu does not mind, and he catches it deliberately from her. In between, she has contaminated Pierre, who is more distraught than Bubu. While Berthe tries to get cured in the hospital, a penniless Bubu robs a store, is caught soon after, and goes to jail. Then Pierre and Berthe become more intimate, even begin living together. But Bubu is released from jail and comes back at night with a few friends to retrieve Berthe. She

follows him passively, even asks Pierre to pay for their last night together. He remains alone, in despair.

The style of the novel is deceptively simple. Its opening recalls that of *Dujardin*: we find a similar subjective focalization, which seems to imply that Pierre Hardy is the “hero” of the story. It begins with an evocation of Boulevard Sebastopol on the evening of July 15, just after the festivities and attendant “orgies.” Everyone is either exhausted or frustrated, or both, as is Pierre:

Pierre Hardy, having worked all day in his office, was strolling among the passersby on the Boulevard Sébastopol. But a young man of twenty, only six months in Paris, walks with small assurance amidst the Paris charivari. [...] A man walks carrying with him all the properties of his life, and they churn about in his head. Something he sees awakens them, something else excites them. For our flesh has retained all our memories, and we mingle them with our desires.²⁰

Assurance is indeed what Pierre lacks, and his family name of “Hardy” sounds ironical as soon as he is contrasted with Bubu. Bubu strides up and down the boulevards; he owns them. He feels at home and has made a decision to abide not by society’s laws, but his own. He is the perfect pimp. The true turning point of the novel is chapter 4, after Berthe realizes that she has caught syphilis. Bubu is shocked, visits his mother who is no help, and meets his friend Le Grand Jules, another pimp, who calms him down by explaining that they all have it. Bubu regains his “faith” and feels that he will be “fortified” by inevitable accidents such as catching the disease. Everything spins in his mind as he gets drunk on absinthe and reaches a Nietzschean illumination beyond good and evil:

The second absinthe filled Maurice with murmurs, broke like a wave and flowed over his heart. He felt it humming in his head with a thousand awakened thoughts which revolved, laughed and sang. The echoes of good replied to the echoes of evil like voices calling one to the other, and like steps going away. Berthe leaned over to love him, and laughed for having the pox. The world was like a man, innocent and pox-ridden, drinking absinthe in the terrace of a café. Grand sentiments such as Love, such as Faith, such as Knowledge, walked crying aloud in the streets near the railway-stations. Joy was everywhere, and each

movement seemed a dance; men seemed small beside this dreamer, and Life laughed like a woman intimately known, who bows before our will. (BM 60)

This makes him choose to have sex with Berthe soon after, just to catch the disease and share her fate. The most “modernist” moment in the novel at the level of style is the long and rambling letter sent by Berthe to Pierre – with its bad syntax and terrible spelling, it announces the lack of punctuation of Molly Bloom’s monologue,²¹ while making a terrible accusation: Berthe accuses Pierre of having given her the pox (whereas we know he caught it from her). In fact, all this shows the fundamental difference between Pierre and Bubu: Pierre is a passive victim whereas Bubu accepts his fate and rises above it.

André Gide and Georg Lukács both pointed to the importance of this novel. They knew that *Bubu* did not impose itself by its style but by its authentic tone (a point made by Eliot as well, see BM 6) and ethical positioning. In *Soul and Form*, Lukács highlights the role of ethics in Philippe’s vision: Philippe “aspired to a harder, more rigorous world, and the ways which led him there were to be ethics and work. His ethical sense was always very strong; even the abject Bubu is a product of it. When Bubu learns that his mistress is ill, he wants to abandon her, but his friend – another pimp – says he would consider such behavior dishonorable. [. . .] Philippe’s development, like that of every strong man, was from lyricism to objectivity.”²² The basic law of pimping is: One doesn’t cast aside a woman just because she has the pox. Given this reliance on codes of honor regulating the mores of sexual commerce, what stands out is that the true hero of the novel is not the sentimental Pierre, who doesn’t do much to save his romantic love, crushed as he is by the superior stare of the pimp, but Bubu. Bubu is decidedly the “free man” because he can walk up and down the boulevards fearlessly, nothing can drag him down, he is superior to adversity, he is not afraid of fights or prison, of the police or of syphilis. He is beyond love and pity, which explains why he keeps Berthe.

After the death of the novelist, André Gide read a homage to Philippe on November 5, 1910, and it is probable that T. S. Eliot

heard it and understood the importance of *Bubu*.²³ In his lecture,²⁴ Gide presents Philippe as a French Dostoevsky. Like the Russian writer, Philippe did not strive for a perfect artistic form, which made his ethical directness shine all the more. His compassion for the poor and the humble was authentic, which marked him as an exception in the French literary scene. Philippe knew that he announced a new generation, those he had called “the barbarians.” This class of writers was made up of people who had had little education and had no symbolic capital at their disposal. They were thus in a better position to capture intuitively and render fully the changes that modernity was bringing to disenfranchised populations living in big cities. Social alienation, sexual humiliation and exploitation, the strategies of survival among the louche demi-monde, and the constant experience of raw suffering were the themes of Philippe’s novels. Later, they were counterbalanced by the display of tender feelings for his mother and his redeeming love for fallen women. However, in his later years, Philippe discovered Nietzsche while also falling under the influence of Claudel, an experimental lyrical poet and playwright who was a staunch Catholic. Accordingly, Gide saw in the glorification of the pimp Bubu a Nietzschean trait. The weak and meek hero accepts his humiliation while secretly admiring the strength of Bubu, in whom he recognizes a superior man.

Gide was full of praise in November 1910, but his tone became more critical later. When he wrote another homage to Charles-Louis Philippe in 1935, Gide added: “I hold for certain that, today, Philippe would be a fascist, truly, as extraordinary as it may sound. Given his need for certainties, and as a reaction to his earlier books that were all about pity, he would now think: woe betide the weak!”²⁵ Gide had perceived the rationale of the evolution of the French modernist novel: its ambition was not to experiment with style or language, but by playing with points of view, to reach a new ethical synthesis. His own evolution had testified to the overcoming of a late symbolism in the name of a Nietzschean “reevaluation of all values.” If Gide defended Mallarmé himself, he gave a wonderful satire of the symbolist and decadent Parisian milieu in the witty parody of *Paludes* (1895), a novel contemporary with the new pagan catechism of

Nourritures Terrestres begun then and published in 1897. *Paludes* was the most “postmodern” of Gide’s novels – it could be signed Donald Barthelme – and it opens with an ironical preface that leaves the reader free to make sense of an “open” text:

Before explaining my book to others, I wait for others to explain it to me. To want to explain first of all means immediately restricting the meaning; for if we know what we have meant, we do not know that we meant only that. – One always says more than THAT. – And above all, what interests me is what I have put there without knowing it, – that part of the Unconscious that I would like to call God’s part.²⁶

In this reflexive parody of parody, a “*sotie*,” which is the name Gide gave to *Paludes* to suggest “a satirical farce,” he provides a hilarious caricature of French esthetes of the turn of the century. Later on, for Nathalie Sarraute and Roland Barthes, it would be in Gide’s *Paludes* that one could find the more productive and prophetic book in Gide’s abundant corpus.

It was the same Nietzscheanism that led the young André Gide to launch the notion of “immoralism.” For Gide, there was a link between the influence of Oscar Wilde and that of Nietzsche; it was Wilde who introduced him to Nietzsche, among other decadent things. Wilde and Nietzsche denounced the repressive structure of Christian morality. For Gide, the real impact of Nietzsche was deferred, which explains why the same character, Menalcas, is a pre-Nietzschean in *Les Nourritures Terrestres* (1895) and a post-Nietzschean in *The Immoralist* of 1900. What Gide found in Nietzsche was a program of liberation that allowed him to understand how his own Protestantism, akin to Nietzsche’s family background based on Protestant values, brought about its own negation, an undoing that might unleash a new and excessive freedom.

There was a shift from post-symbolist experimental writing to an ethical modernism in which daring experimentation with values dominated. This feature is central in two books: Guillaume Apollinaire’s *The Heresiarch & Co.* (1910) and Jules Romains’ *Death of Somebody* (1911). Apollinaire’s book is made up of stories he had published in symbolist reviews such as *La Revue Blanche* and

Messidor since 1902. The overarching theme is that of the “Wandering Jew.”²⁷ In the first story, “Le Passant de Prague,” the narrator, who calls himself a philosemite, meets Laquedem, the Wandering Jew. Laquedem is hearty and lusty despite his ancient age, and he has sex with a prostitute, but will not stop walking even as he is copulating! He is seen crossing the Jewish ghetto of Prague. He has to die every hundred years and then survives for an illusory afterlife. The tale of his endless travels had been told to a “Chrysostom Daedalus” who rings a Joycean bell. Apollinaire anticipated the modernist tale of Kafka’s “The Hunter Gracchus,” with a hero who cannot die. Modern man cannot be born because a true death is no longer available. Apollinaire invents a proto-surrealism in prose with stories that range in tone and scope between obscure theological fantasies and Raymond Roussel’s neo-Dadaism. In another story, the narrator follows a rag picker, collects trash, and finds in the trash a curious ring with a pale stone in the middle. He put it on and learns that this was the gallstone from a rich old man’s bladder that he had given to his mistress as a token of his love. Upon learning that this gift had been trashed like rubbish, the old man dies suddenly and the narrator leaves the relic on a church altar. Erudition is abused and perverted as in metaphysical *ficciones* by Borges. The tales unfold like the bad dreams of a perverted theologian with a poetic sensibility. The last story of the volume, “L’Amphion Faux Messie,” proved surprisingly prophetic. The main character, Baron d’Ormesan, was based on Géry Pierdet, a con artist from Belgium befriended by Apollinaire in 1905. Fleeing the police, Pierdet spent several years in the United States and came back in 1911, just after the publication of *The Heresiarch & Co.* To help him out, Apollinaire hired him as a secretary. In May 1911, Pierdet stole art objects from the Louvre and hid them in Apollinaire’s flat. When the *Mona Lisa* was stolen in August 1911, Apollinaire brought back these stolen objects, which attracted the attention of the police. He was jailed for a week. Pierdet denounced himself, but Apollinaire lost the love of Marie Laurencin as a consequence, and never recovered his peace of mind afterward. In a story reminiscent of Jarry, the baron projects his own image via

several screens so that people believe that he is everywhere. Finally he embodies a false messiah, whom all the Jews take as a true savior. In an almost Sadian story, “A Good Film,” Baron d’Ormessan launches a film company and enacts true murders for the delight of rich viewers. He forces a man to shoot a woman and her lover in front of the camera. When the wrong man is condemned and executed, he films this as well. This was Apollinaire’s take on modernism – a mixture of technology and myth spiced with a good dose of perversity.

The contrast could not be greater with Jules Romains’ modernist novel, *Death of Somebody* (1911), in which he attempts to give a shape to his *Unanimiste* program. Eschewing Apollinaire’s mythical parallels, Romains described the most common and banal person – a total antihero, since nothing ever happened in his life, except for his death. Romains wanted anonymous lives to be documented as fully as possible, giving a novelistic realization of the vision put forward in his poetic sequence *La Vie Unanime* (1908). Here, we meet Jacques Godard, a widower and pensioned retiree. He lives alone in Paris, catches cold after a visit to the Pantheon. He dies miserably on page 12 while beginning to live in other people’s memories. This spreads from his neighbors, his parents still alive in their village, their small community, and finally Parisians or passersby who know nothing about him. The banal death of an anonymous citizen ends up releasing collective forces that bring about a nonreligious transfiguration. For Romains, events exist only if they are experienced collectively. Once they are perceived by a group, they take a life of their own.

Godard, retired from the French railway system, had been a sad widower who had lost touch with his village in Auvergne and never visited his old parents. It is only after his death that the circle of solitude is broken; for a while, from his very demise, a new collective conviviality emerges. Groups are being formed, first when the neighbors learn of the solitary death and decide to pay for the funeral crown, then when the old father takes a train to go to Paris for the funeral. The study of sheer banality turns into an investigation of the dynamics of the social world. This culminates with the funeral; at

one point, the little group reaches an avenue in which the police and trade-union strikers are fighting. They observe a truce as all salute the funeral. When the mourners go into the chapel, the dead man assumes the proportions of a vital force: "The dead man was now so great that he needed no one any longer. To think of him was not to do an act of charity but to yield to a force. He gathered himself together and was created anew. He was the master."²⁸ This reassures the priest, who was doubting his vocation! Here is the occasion for a last metamorphosis of our "nobody." He has become one in a group, a mass, a crowd, and finally the expression of "life" as such. Romain evokes a material soul dissolving and reconstituted, moving in eddies until it creates a collective spirit:

Like a whirlwind shut in by the walls of a ravine, the dead man swirled round and round within the boundaries of the chapel, while the little seated congregation was gripped in a kind of frenzy of parturition, with organ music as the voice of its vagitus. [...] The movement was so violent that it could almost be seen. Beneath the friction of the whirlwind, the air was sizzling and smoke streamed up the centre of the chapel as from an overheated axle.²⁹

Romain's main idea was that communities condense and exhibit life. Individuals need to find this source of strength and become one with it, most often in moments of collective ecstasy that make them blend with a pantheistic continuum of life. Personal tragedies, collective catastrophes, and social movements lead to such a mystical realization.

The person who objected to these ideas most resolutely was Apollinaire. He had been a close friend of Romain earlier, but in April 1911, he launched a ferocious attack on Romain's play, *The Army in the City*, because it was presented as "classical and national." Apollinaire attacked it as a bad historical melodrama, and quoted Romain's 1910 *Manual of Deification* that stated the need to "wake up groups from their somnolence" by "doing violence" to them, in sudden explosive or extravagant actions.³⁰ This quarrel led to the termination of Apollinaire's contract with the *Nouvelle Revue Française*, since Romain had many friends there, which marked a

split in French modernism. Apollinaire was appalled by the way in which Romain Rolland was fascinated by collective violence, which brought literature too close to speeches by “a trade-union leader proclaiming class-war.”³¹ The clash between two forms of early modernism, both of them aiming at an impact on the public, was explicit. Rolland’s modernism attempted to address the common man in the name of social fraternity. The masses would be educated by the avant-garde, even if this meant exerting violence on them. Apollinaire’s modernism, and later on, the modernism of the surrealists, would continue the program of symbolism by other means. Experimentalism might risk losing the audience at first, but one would hope that the public would educate itself if it wanted to understand the new spirit. Yet in *Death of Someone*, one can see a premonition of the new objectivism of the *Nouveau Roman* in the 1950s, whereas the term of “surrealism,” indeed coined by Apollinaire, was rarely illustrated in the novel. It remained to Proust to tie up all those strands in *La Recherche*, at once a unanimist novel going back to Balzac, a *Künstlerroman* in the post-Romantic tradition, a philosophical novel, and a compendium of everything he had thought and written about in art, sexuality, politics, love, and life.

If we compare the beginning of *Les Lauriers sont coupés* with the famous overture of *La Recherche*, one can measure what Proust owes to his symbolist predecessors, a debt that led contemporaries such as Gide not to accept his stylistic tour de force. Gide, who advised the *Nouvelle Revue Française*, famously refused Proust’s sprawling manuscript on the ground that he did not see how one should follow for thirty pages the thoughts and reveries of a little boy who can’t go to sleep. Gide, who knew Proust, treated him, ironically, as a spoiled child and a belated symbolist. He soon recognized his mistake and did all he could to bring back Proust to Gallimard. Indeed, with Proust’s amazing opening, we are plunged *in medias res mentales*, as we are with Dujardin’s hero, but here the *medias* are not just the whirling images and associations evoked by the narrator who goes to bed early enough soon to wake up, not knowing where he is, hence, who he is; Proust’s *medias res* ushers in the layered space of writing, a mental space in which all subjects are spinning: “A sleeping man

holds in a circle around him the sequence of the hours, the order of the years and worlds.”³² As *medias*, the spinning wheels of time and space forcibly include the reader, since the narrator too becomes the subject matter of the books he was reading before falling asleep: “it seemed to me that I myself was what the book was talking about” (*SW* 3). We identify with such an unstable narrator who keeps dissolving and metamorphosing along with his landmarks, and whose only references are the effects of habit. The confusion of self and book is indeed the main theme of the novel that we are reading and that, we must imagine, the narrator will begin writing at the end.

With Proust’s masterpiece, architecture (the book is compared with a cathedral), music (Vinteuil’s septet plays a structural role for Swann’s love story), and art, with the reference to Vermeer’s yellow wall (its endless flight underpins the resuscitation of dead Bergotte as he turns into his own books) – all converge in the first *Gesamtkunstwerk* of French modernism. We have been told many times about the complex genealogy of Proust’s novel, its transformation from a critical book on Sainte-Beuve into a compendium that included everything he was reading, experiencing (as the changes brought to France by the Dreyfus affair and the First World War), or thinking. Truly, *In Search of Lost Time* can be seen as the novelistic equivalent of Hegel’s *Phenomenology of Spirit*, since in both works we follow the trajectory of a consciousness that progresses in knowledge from ignorance to certainty, from recognition of self to recognition of others, and finally to truth or “absolute knowledge,” the point when the narrator realizes that the only true life is one to be lived in a book. We will have passed through the various hells of love with its attendant jealousy, and the maddening spirals of social snobbism, until the complete redistribution of values brought about by modernity (at the end, the vulgarity of the Verdurins is marked by social triumph, and the Guermantes slowly vanish into their own past) points out why these circles are the signs of a delusion, if not a total waste of time. Proust regularly insisted that his ambition was to complete a “dogmatic” and “constructed” work, a treatise that could have been subtitled “In quest of

truth,” as he put it in a letter to Jacques Rivière on February 6, 1914.³³ Yet, the “absolute knowledge” about the abolition of time that he proffers at the end never completely contains proliferating narrative series such as the interminable “novel of Albertine” of the last sections along with the ever renewed discussions of homosexuality in the *Sodom and Gomorrha* volumes. These sections are marked by a narrative excess, an endless flow of words that could not be encompassed by the theoretical program – Heraclitus had won over Hegel – but here is precisely where Proust’s radical modernity lies. Here, perhaps, French modernity harks back to Baudelaire’s original concept and thus goes beyond mere modernism.

Notes

1. Marcel Proust, “Le Pouvoir du Romancier,” in *Contre Sainte-Beuve, Pastiches et Mélanges, Essais et Articles*, eds. Pierre Clarac and Yves Sandre (Paris: Gallimard, Pléiade, 1971), 413. The text can be dated from 1895 to 1900.
2. Stéphane Mallarmé, “Crisis of Verse,” in *Divagations*, trans. Barbara Johnson (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2007), 201.
3. *Ibid.*, 203.
4. Marcel Proust, “Contre l’Obscurité,” in *Contre Sainte-Beuve, Pastiches et Mélanges, Essais et Articles*, 390–5.
5. *Ibid.*, 393.
6. Mallarmé, *Divagations*, 236.
7. *Ibid.*, 235.
8. Kimberly Healey, “French Literary Modernism,” in *Modernism*, eds. Astradur Eysteinnsson and Vivian Liska (Amsterdam: John Benjamins Publishing Company, 2007), 2:801.
9. See Edmond Lepelletier, *Paul Verlaine: His Life – His Work*, trans. E. M. Lang (1909; repr., New York: AMS Press, 1970), 256; trans. modified.
10. Rimbaud, *A Season in Hell*, in *Rimbaud: Complete Works and Selected Letters*, trans. Wallace Fowlie (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1966), 209.
11. Dujardin quotes Moore’s letter in *Interior Monologue*. See Edouard Dujardin, *The Bays Are Sere*; and *Interior Monologue*, trans. Anthony Suter (London: Libris, 1991), 90. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (BS).

12. See Vicki Mahaffey's excellent "Streams Beyond Consciousness: Stylistic Immediacy in the Modernist Novel," in *Handbook of Modernism Studies*, ed. Jean-Michel Rabaté (Oxford: Wiley-Blackwell, 2013), 39–42.
13. I have modified the translation of Anthony Suter, to be closer to the typography of the original; see Edouard Dujardin, *Les Lauriers sont coupés* (Paris: Messein, 1968), 120–1. This is the 1924 edition. I have followed the original edition, available online, and italicized the words from the 1887 edition that were deleted in 1924.
14. This letter is quoted by Dujardin in *Interior Monologue*. See *Bays Are Seres*, 22.
15. Repr. in Alfred Jarry, *Gestes et Opinions du docteur Faustroll, pataphysicien*, in *Oeuvres Complètes*, vol. 1, ed. Michel Arrivé (Paris: Pléiade, 1972), 685–6. See Marieke Dubbelboer, *The Subversive Poetics of Alfred Jarry: Abusing Culture in the Almanachs du Pere Ubu* (London: Legenda, 2012), 35–7.
16. Alfred Jarry, *Oeuvres Complètes*, vol. 3, eds. Henri Bordillon, Patrick Besnier, Bernard Le Doze, and Michel Arrivé (Paris: Pléiade, 1988), 635–6.
17. Alfred Jarry, *The Supermale*, trans. Ralph Gladstone and Barbara Wright (Cambridge, MA: Exact Change, 1999), 30.
18. Jarry, *The Supermale*, 104–5.
19. Gilles Deleuze, "An Unrecognized Precursor to Heidegger: Alfred Jarry," in *Essays Critical and Clinical*, trans. Daniel W. Smith and Michael A. Greco (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1997), 91–8.
20. Charles-Louis Philippe, *Bubu of Montparnasse*, trans. Laurence Vail, with a Preface by T. S. Eliot (New York: Shakespeare House, 1951), 15. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*BM*).
21. The real life model for Berthe had been spirited away to Marseille after the publication of the novel, helped by Philippe and friends fearing that she might be killed by her pimp. The only reproach she made then was that Philippe had not corrected her orthographic mistakes when reproducing her letters in the novel. See the documents in "Autour de Bubu," in Charles-Louis Philippe, *Bubu de Montparnasse*, ed. Bruno Vercier (Paris: Garnier-Flammarion, 1978), 206.
22. Georg Lukács, *Soul and Form*, trans. Anna Bostock (New York: Columbia University Press, 2010), 122–3.
23. See Nancy Duvall Hargrove's *T. S. Eliot's Parisian Year* (Gainesville: University Press of Florida, 2009), 35.
24. André Gide, "Charles-Louis Philippe," in *Essais Critiques*, ed. Pierre Masson (Paris: Gallimard, Pléiade, 1999), 475–92.

25. André Gide, in Maria van Rysselberghe, *Les Cahiers de la Petite Dame: Notes pour l'histoire authentique d'André Gide*, vol. 2: 1929–1937 (Paris: Gallimard, 2001), 495; quoted in a note by Pierre Masson in *Essais Critiques* 1241.
26. André Gide, *Paludes* (Paris: Gallimard-Folio, 1973), 12.
27. Guillaume Apollinaire, *The Heresiarch & Co.*, trans. Remy Inglis Hall (Cambridge, MA: Exact Change, 1991).
28. Jules Romains, *The Death of a Nobody*, trans. Desmond McCarthy and Sydney Waterlow (New York: Huebsch, 1914), 122.
29. *Ibid.*, 123–4; trans. modified.
30. Guillaume Apollinaire, *Oeuvres en prose complètes*, vol. 2, eds. Pierre Caizergues and Michel Décaudin (Paris: Gallimard, Pléiade, 1991), 960–3.
31. Guillaume Apollinaire, “La Vie Anecdотique,” in *Oeuvres en prose complètes*, vol. 3; eds. Caizergues and Michel Décaudin (Paris: Gallimard, Pléiade, 1993), 54.
32. Marcel Proust, *Swann's Way*, trans. Lydia Davis (New York: Viking, 2002), 5. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*SW*).
33. Marcel Proust, *Correspondance, Choix de Lettres*, ed. Jerome Picon (Paris: Garnier-Flammarion, 2007), 212–13.

CHAPTER 4

Russian Modernism and the Novel

Leonid Livak

Few branches of the humanities have recently undergone changes as drastic as Russian studies, whose methodological assumptions and interpretational paradigms imploded with the Soviet empire. Modernist studies have benefited from this development. In the USSR, “modernism” was a term of abuse and a catchall concept that functioned as Soviet culture’s foil. Russian studies in the West, meanwhile, lacked knowledge about Russian modernism and experienced the growing pains of a discipline shaped by the cold war: some scholars shunned modernist art and thought for their political extremes, others held the Stalinist view of modernism as a rictus of the dying bourgeoisie. Systematic research into Russian modernism (as distinct from attention to select authors) emerged in the West in the 1970s; made its way, in a highly politicized form, to the USSR in the 1980s; and flourished everywhere in the 1990s. Contrary to their Anglo-American, French, or Germanic counterparts, Russian modernist studies are a young field with little methodological consensus. The field’s very designation is contentious, since, before becoming a Soviet expletive, the term “modernism” had been used mostly by critics, from the late 1900s on, rather than self-referentially by artists, in an attempt to rise above the proliferation of “isms” in Russian literary life.

Even Russian modernism’s geography and chronology are in flux, as the once paramount year – 1917 – recedes into irrelevance, where aesthetics are concerned, while formerly excluded writers reenter cultural history. Quarrels about Russian modernism’s timing used to entail its origins (located, variously, between the late 1880s and early 1900s). Post-Soviet scholarship has questioned the little consensus

existing in modernist chronology, namely its upper boundary, informed by the assumption that modernism could not survive in a communist state. The more we learn about Russian émigré culture, the more we realize that Russian modernism received a second lease on life in exile. Today, we know enough to make a case for tracing Russian modernism beyond 1917, and past the Stalinist crackdown, which all but spurred modernist creativity in what today's cultural historians call Russia Abroad (interwar Russian diaspora in central and western Europe) until the fall of Paris in 1940.

And if such methodological quandaries were not enough, one would be well advised not to enter Russian modernist studies through the door of the novelistic genre. The novel dominated Russian literary life in the 1850s through the 1870s, falling into desuetude just when it became Russia's calling card abroad. As the novel's coryphaei died (Dostoevsky in 1881, Turgenev in 1883) or renounced art (Tolstoy after *Anna Karenina*), no fresh talent replaced them. The pulse of Russian letters beat elsewhere: in short fiction (Leonid Andreev, Ivan Bunin, Anton Chekhov, Maxim Gorky) and in poetry – the battering ram of the modernist revolt against civic-minded utilitarians who favored the novel as an ideological vehicle. Even those artists who had begun as novelists (Aleksei Remizov, Mikhail Prishvin) switched to shorter prose and, collecting it in book-length narratives, shunned novelistic motivation. Obversely, if Gorky's stories had been read as part of nascent modernist culture (a source of anxiety for Soviet exegetes), the writer signaled his rupture with modernism by turning to the novel and heeding its nineteenth-century canon.

Nor did novels by modernist poets – Dmitrii Merezhkovskii's *Christ and Anti-Christ* (1895–1905), Mikhail Kuzmin's *Wings* (1906), Fëdor Sologub's *The Petty Demon* (1907), Valerii Briusov's *The Fiery Angel* (1907), Andrei Belyi's *The Silver Dove* (1909) – meaningfully challenge canonical practices. The genre vegetated on the periphery.¹ Belyi attempted its revival in *Petersburg* (1913–14), but did not reverse the novel's fortunes. By the early 1920s, short prose, free from psychological speculation, dominated Russian letters whose modernist observers prophesied, before T. S. Eliot

("Ulysses, Order and Myth," 1923) and José Ortega y Gasset ("Decline of the Novel," 1925), the novel's demise, at least in its classical form, after the collapse of the old ideas of time, space, and personality.² Even longer prose by modernists shunned psychological analysis and indulged in narrative fragmentation, mythopoetically obfuscating heroes and plots to convey distaste for the referential illusion, that staple of the nineteenth-century canon. Already by the mid-1910s, but especially in the 1920s, this distaste transpired in the shift of focus from the story to its artistic medium, manifest in widespread stylistic experimentation; the affirmation of authorial consciousness as art's true protagonist; and a self-conscious turn to low-brow modes (crime, adventure, sci-fi, melodrama) – all of it validated by Formalist theorizing that knocked the novel off its cultural pedestal as a mere set of plot-structuring devices. On modernism's fringe, meanwhile, the Left Front of Art (Lef) called for the novel's wholesale replacement with nonfictional "literature of the fact."

All this (anti-)novelistic ferment was put to the sword in the USSR in the 1930s, when the torch of modernism passed to émigrés and modernist reflection on the genre of the novel reached its second peak, after *Petersburg*, in Vladimir Nabokov's *The Gift* (1937). But this does not obviate the fact that *the Russian modernist novel* may be an oxymoron. How else are we to read the coincidence of the genre's fall from grace with first modernist stirrings; its growing crisis with every modernist cohort; the continuous search by hostile critics for the signs of "a novelistic renaissance" as an indicator of the demise of modernist art and sensibility; or the genre's new rise under Stalin, in tandem with the imposition of the nineteenth-century canon as the standard for all Soviet writers? It was as an anti-modernist reaction that contemporaries understood the novel's triumph in Socialist Realist guise. But where émigrés saw the revenge of antiquated aesthetics, Stalinists hailed new art superseding modernism the way Soviet society superseded the bourgeois West. In sum, while Anglo-American critics speak about "the modernist novel," whose history reflects the crisis of the Victorian worldview, one is hard pressed to line up enough convincing

examples to make a case for *the Russian modernist novel* in a time marked by aversion for this genre among Russian art's movers and shakers. Rather than drop yet another dubious notion into Russian modernist studies, it is more productive to frame our inquiry in terms of the dynamics between *Russian modernism* and *the novel*, turning the genre's life into a sounding board for issues central to the appreciation of Russia's place among European cultures of modernism. These issues are numerous, and their framing with the novel in mind yields points of orientation in the chaotic field of Russian modernist studies. Contemplating the genre's plight in the period dominated by modernist aesthetic and philosophical concerns, we confront the fluidity of generic boundaries; the porousness of fact and fiction; the encroachment of theory on artistic practice; and the inadequacy of stock contrasts – realism-modernism, experimentalism-traditionalism, obscurity-accessibility – as classificatory tools.

The issue of boundaries is historically germane to the novel – a tensile, omnivorous genre resisting definition. But even such an experienced practitioner as Henry James criticized Russian novels as “large loose baggy monsters” and “fluid puddings.”³ In the 1910s, the Russian novel experienced further erosion vis-à-vis the story and the novella, in the writings of Bunin, Prishvin, and Remizov. A decade later this process defined Russian prose. Boris Pil'niak's *The Naked Year* (1922), for example, calls itself a novel but consists of tenuously related episodes, previously published as separate stories, describing revolution and civil war from the viewpoints of many actors and observers. Isaac Babel's *The Red Cavalry* (1926), an account of the 1920 Polish-Soviet conflict, is a set of autonomous stories (called chapters in editorial correspondence) loosely linked by a narrator and read by contemporaries as an anti-novel “conveying the tempo” and “feeling the pulse” of modernity in contrast to classical “novelistic sour dough.”⁴

The Naked Year crosses the line between fact and fiction. “I, the author,” appears at the end, in a hitherto fictional narrative, transforming it into a witness account of postwar reconstruction echoed in the structure of the last chapter – a set of drafts letting us peek into

Pil'niak's creative laboratory as if it were a construction site. Babel's reader is never sure about the documentary value of the stories motivated by personal experience. Viktor Shklovskii explicitly ties these experiments to the problematics of the novel. Introducing his *Zoo, or Letters Not about Love* (1923) as an "accidental novel" made up of nonfictional sketches, he proposes to stitch them with a fictional love tale into an epistolary novel. The generic choice is then deconstructed: the hero's beloved bans emotions from the letters. Like Babel, Shklovskii eschews psychological analysis and builds a narrative from discreet autobiographic segments. The result is a mix of minutiae from his Berlin existence, used for exercises in stylistic expressionism, reflections on art, and portraits of acquaintances. The book ends with Shklovskii's petition for repatriation, addressed to Soviet authorities in a crowning confusion of fact and fiction. This loose, but hardly baggy, anti-novel is indeed "not about love." It is about Shklovskii's ability to apply his theory of the novel, a genre he holds in low regard, hence his remark: "A decent critic who is not a softie should be able to write, at a drop of a hat, a competent novel, even if a bad one."⁵ Enough to make James miss the puddings and monsters of old.

Such fluidity of genre and motivation grew out of the reappraisal to which Russian modernists had subjected discursive modes once seen as nonartistic – memoirs, diaries, letters, criticism, journalism.⁶ Like experiments with fragmentation in Belyi's *Petersburg*, this revaluation, codified in Vasilii Rozanov's diary-style *Solitaria* (1912) and *Fallen Leaves* (1913–15), became a modernist marker in the 1910s. A decade later, narrative fragmentation, generic fluidity, and the (con)fusion of fact and fiction were Russian art's standard fare. The novel's specificity all but collapsed: Boris Eikhenbaum read Tolstoy's diaries as disguised novels; Shklovskii treated Rozanov's writings as novels without motivation.⁷ In the Russian modernist culture of the 1920s, texts became novels by external designation. This generic relativism echoed postwar debates in the West, where young modernists assailed imaginative art, epitomized by the novel, prompting André Gide's reflection on the genre in *The Counterfeiters* (1925), which he provocatively called his first novel.⁸ Even size was

not a criterion: Il'ia Erenburg hesitated to call his long picaresque, *Khulio Khurenito* (1921), a novel; while Vladimir Nabokov applied the same marker to narratives that could pass for long stories (*Mary*, 1926; *Glory*, 1930) or novellas (*King, Queen Knave*, 1928; *The Defense*, 1930).

During the Stalinist clampdown, generic hybrids and motivational experiments came under fire as “western fads expressing the ideology of capitalism.”⁹ The outcome of this call to order, the Socialist Realist novel, went “back to the future”: claiming to model new reality under construction, it turned to the old canon, and thence to ritualized eighteenth-century forms. This brings us to the stock juxtaposition of realism and modernism. To interrogate this tool for classifying texts, often deployed in tandem with such taxonomical pairs as experimentalism-traditionalism and obscurity-accessibility, is to pry open the Pandora’s box of the Russian novel in the modernist period. The Stalinist contrast of realist and modernist art (exported by Georg Lukács’s *The Meaning of Contemporary Realism*, 1957) reiterates Russian anti-modernist polemics from the 1890s on. The true stakes in modernism’s clash with nineteenth-century mimesis will remain obscured until we acknowledge the realist-modernist critical dichotomy for what it is – an ideological fiction with little explanatory value outside its historical context.

When this contrast first emerged in Russian criticism, then policed by positivists and utilitarians, it was mocked in modernist circles as illiterate because it was rooted in the referential illusion – the assumption that art could faithfully mirror the outside world construed as reality. At issue was not whether modernists fled reality, but their understanding of it and, thus, of artistic realism.¹⁰ The quarrel about the nature of reality was at the core of the conflict pitting the intelligentsia establishment against the intellectuals and artists who rallied for a “new sensibility” predicated on uncertainty and instability and arising from their apocalyptic sense of decline and concomitant quest for transcendence. Art that saw reality as a system of observable and knowable facts came under withering critique from early modernists (“Decadents” and “Symbolists”) who located reality beyond rational cognition: it could only be intuited by the

spiritually gifted. Subsequent waves of Russian modernists found this nonmaterial(istic) reality in human consciousness, viewing the world as a construct of the psyche. In the 1910s, this idea replaced the metaphysical bent of early Russian modernism, coinciding with Western “realism of consciousness” which Auerbach saw as yet another mimetic mode making the novels of Woolf and Proust no less realistic than those of Balzac.¹¹ Russian modernists styled themselves as true realists and branded old mimetic practices as naïve and superficial.

The epistemological quest for reality ran through Russian modernism under the slogan *a realibus ad realiora*, from the real to the more real; but attempts at naming it – Viacheslav Ivanov’s *realiorizm*, Nikolai Chuzhak’s *ul’tra-realizm* – came to naught, unlike their belated French echo, *surréalisme*. Stalinists revived the realist-modernist dichotomy by elevating to an absolute principle a local conflict between the old cultural guard clinging to positivism (which also informs Marxist thought) and modernist pioneers laying siege to the fin de siècle intelligentsia establishment. Ignoring this historical context, we perpetuate what Lidiia Ginzburg decried, in a transparent jab at Lukács, as “the fallacy of mechanically sorting twentieth-century writers into modernists and realists, most often on the basis of purely external and secondary features.”¹² This division is a dull tool indeed when applied to Russian prose, the novel in particular.

Fëdor Sologub’s *The Petty Demon* (1907) is a case in point. In Stalinist criticism, this satire of provincial mores – made up of interlinked stories about a teacher’s descent into insanity and a schoolboy’s descent into debauchery by an older woman – exemplified modernist antirealism and remained unpublished from 1935 until 1958. As a result, in Western scholarship, it became a centerpiece of Russian modernism’s alleged antirealist ethos. But it is hard to find in this novel a break with previous stylistic or narrative practices; and its aesthetically traditional dramatization of modernist tropes, drawn from Nietzsche, mirrors the ideological exploitation of art in canonical novels. *The Petty Demon*’s interpretive community praised or vilified the novel, not for a departure from conventional poetics but for the fusion of these poetics with the vision of reality as a

transcendental realm hidden in the mundane that Sologub's presents in his text. The novel leaves us a choice: to explain supernatural events by the hero's madness or accept the otherworldly behind a picture of life grounded in the referential illusion. Sologub creates this ambiguity, which Tzvetan Todorov sees as the axis of the fantastic in art, by downplaying psychological analysis and narratorial omniscience. The resulting clash of positivist and mystical modes resonated with fellow modernists; but it did not prevent other critics from reading *The Petty Demon* as a revival of old realism. And even when Marxists consigned the novel to the antirealist camp, they were driven as much by its epistemological ambiguity as by Sologub's visibility in the culture of modernism (aggravated by the mockery of the radical Left in his next novel, *The Created Legend* [1914], built on similar aesthetic and philosophical premises).

The methodological utility of the realist-modernist contrast is all the more dubious because *The Petty Demon*'s unsure place in the literary field was not exceptional. Similar ambiguity marked the prose of Remizov, a future darling of the surrealists, and Belyi's first novel, *The Silver Dove* (1909), hailed, at once, for reviving positivist art and for fusing the transcendental with the mundane. But the problem with realist-modernist taxonomy runs deeper. What are we to make of many contemporaries' inability to tell apart Sologub and Leonid Andreev? This lack of discriminating taste is a constant adage in modernist criticism, which excoriates the likes of Andreev for allegedly counterfeiting the "new sensibility" – manifest in the subject's overriding epistemological and ontological anxiety – in a kind of art that belongs, aesthetically, in the nineteenth century. But so does the prose of most self-styled "new artists" prior to Belyi's *Petersburg*. Besides, Andreev begged to differ. Seeing himself as a modernist, he decried "the Tower of Babel confusion" in Russian art: "In the eyes of pure Decadents I am a vile realist; for hereditary realists I am a suspicious Symbolist."¹³ Realism, of course, was in the eye of the beholder. And if many novels have been excluded from modernist studies for allegedly vulgarizing modernism – to wit, such artistically pedestrian tales about "new men and women" living by the "new sensibility" as Mikhail Artsybashev's

Sanin (1907) and Anastasiia Verbitskaia's *Keys to Happiness* (1909) – this is because we tend to favor some contemporary critical opinions over others thanks to their authors' rank in the modernist hierarchy, as we imagine it today.

Students of Russian modernism find themselves in a bind. Striving to overcome Soviet bias, they rely on the resonance of texts in their interpretive communities; but by doing so they internalize the factional fault lines of contemporary artistic life, uncritically elevating them to the status of classification standards. Do modernist accolades to *The Petty Demon* reflect its qualitative superiority to the vilified *Sanin* and *Keys to Happiness*, or Sologub's privileged place in the literary field? An argument could be made that Sologub's dramatization of modernist philosophical commonplaces is as vulgarizing as Artsybashev's: witness their concurrent marketplace success, echoed by Verbitskaia's bestseller, subtitled "a modern novel" and equipped with not one but two epigraphs from Nietzsche. Factionalism is as germane to modernism as ideological bias to Marxism. Both shape the classification of texts. Take Mikhail Kuzmin's *Wings* (1906), a novel that, today, flanks *The Petty Demon* by virtue of expressing the "new sensibility" through an aesthetic and philosophical apologia of sexual deviance more daring than in Gide's *The Immoralist* (1902). Gide's elliptical linkage of pederasty to a hero's spiritual renaissance bursts into the open in *Wings*, which frames a young man's homosexual epiphany as an initiation into modernist values. We understand why a Marxist would treat *Sanin*, *The Petty Demon*, and *Wings* as homologous texts; but it takes the knowledge of Kuzmin's place in a rival clique to explain why Belyi tossed *Wings* in the same trash bin with Andreev and Artsybashev, while citing *The Petty Demon* as a counterexample.¹⁴

If the contrast of realism and modernism is barren in conceptualizing Russian prose from the 1890s on, other stock tools, such as the opposition of traditionalism to experimentalism, or of accessibility to obscurity, are hardly more helpful, since they were developed with very specific models of artistic praxis in mind. Take T. S. Eliot's 1928 self-description as a "classicist in literature," which does not strike Ezra Pound as incompatible with the program of "making it new":

both regard tradition as the axis of their artistic “consciousness of place in time.”¹⁵ Nor do we find support for modernism’s reduction to aesthetic iconoclasm in Arthur Rimbaud’s censure of Charles Baudelaire’s artistic traditionalism. Rimbaud extols the sensibility of *The Flowers of Evil* (1857) despite the tension between his own prerogative of being “absolutely modern” and the classical poetics of Baudelaire’s book, which do not undermine its status as a founding text of modernism, “alien to us in form but our kith and kin in striving and sensibility,” as Briusov puts it in 1905.¹⁶ The avant-garde cult of novelty, to be sure, is as central to early Russian modernism as to its later iterations, but the meaning of “the new” and of “making it new” evolves in the first three decades of Russian modernist experience.

Before *Petersburg*, “new aesthetics” and “new ethics” are dramatized in Russian prose fiction by traditional means. Belyi’s *Symphonies* (1899–1902) and Remizov’s folk stylizations (*Posolon*, 1907) are exceptions; and neither author extends his experiments to the novel at this time. Such indifference to formal innovation may derive from the early modernist conception of reality as transcendental but objectively existing in historical (antiquity, old Russia, etc.) or mystical realms: the intuitive exploration and erudite recreation of reality constitute art’s novelty and de-prioritize aesthetic iconoclasm. The change occurs in the 1910s, when Russian modernism turns to the psyche as the source of reality: experiments with language and narrative then become means of conveying the unique relation of individual consciousness to the world.

Valerii Briusov’s *The Fiery Angel* (1907), for example, hardly fits the notion of experimental and difficult art. The novel is narrated by a knight whose liaison with a witch unfolds against the backdrop of sixteenth-century Germany. Why should a modernist trailblazer write in a subgenre that had long left the drawing room for the nursery? Precisely because the historical romance was low-brow enough to vex the guardians of the novelistic canon; marginal enough to pique readers’ curiosity; and hermetic enough, in its esoteric subject matter, to showcase authorial erudition while acting as a repository for stories from Briusov’s life. Aesthetic

traditionalism hides as much as it reveals here. Targeting two audiences, *The Fiery Angel* narrates a tale, conventionally and accessibly, for the lay reader; and another tale visible only to the participants in the culture of modernism. In this hermetic dimension, the sentimental triangle of knight Ruprecht, witch Renata, and count Heinrich mirrors the one linking Briusov to writers Nina Petrovskaja and Belyi. Their story is as tormented, violent, and steeped in the occult as the story of Renata.¹⁷ Such layering has tremendous potential for generating new texts. Texts that are “lived”: the heroes reflect the aesthetically meaningful behavior of the prototypes and inform their subsequent comportment. Or texts that are written: in similarly multilayered *Petersburg*, a terrorist intrigue against the historical backdrop of the 1905 revolution conceals a story for the initiated – a mythopoetic retelling of the triangle uniting Belyi, actress Liubov’ Mendeleeva, and her husband Aleksandr Blok, the author’s friend and fellow poet.

This programmatic fusion of art and life (*zhiznetvorchestvo*, or life-creation, in modernist parlance) explains *The Fiery Angel*’s prominence in Russian modernist culture. Yet the novel resists classification by stock taxonomical tools. The future author of *Petersburg* applauded Briusov’s lack of “modernist plumage,” as he then called stylistic and narrative innovation, and saw the novel’s achievement in “telling a story that should not be spoken about.” Belyi’s whipping boy, Kuzmin, also praised Briusov for hiding “under an apparent narrative a profound and secret one.” Both saw *The Fiery Angel* as a new novelistic model.¹⁸ Kuzmin thus wrote “deceptively simple and seemingly accessible” novels,¹⁹ airing the “new sensibility” by old aesthetic means (*Wings*) and hiding *romans à clé* in traditional, straightforwardly narrated picaresques (*The Adventures of Aimé Leboeuf*, 1907; *The Wonderful Life of Joseph Balsamo*, 1916). His prose is so neo-classical – in all senses, since it draws on Byzantine, early modern French, and nineteenth-century Russian sources – that Remizov, avenging the lukewarm reception of his own writings by Kuzmin’s clique, branded his rival a spiritual impostor.²⁰ But factionalism aside, Remizov’s poetics, inspired by many of the same sources and growing more experimental the

farther he moved (significantly for us) from the novel, resonated with the target audience of Kuzmin's *World of Art* circle which sought inspiration in pre-modern historical loci, skipping over modernity as aesthetically and spiritually sterile.

It would be gratifying to think that the experiments pursued by Belyi, Remizov, and Rozanov in the 1910s moved the Russian novel within the taxonomical coordinates hitherto dominant in modernist studies (realism-antirealism, traditionalism-experimentalism, accessibility-obscurity). History puts a damper in such hopes. As experimental prose became the new norm validated by Russian Formalist thought, which theorized the literary process as a series of generational conflicts expressed in periodic aesthetic revolutions, even consummate positivists felt the need to spruce up their art with signs of the fashionable quest for novelty. Once upon a time, the cardinal sin selectively imputed to authors consisted of faking the "new sensibility" in aesthetically traditional narratives. Now the crime amounted to the use of modernist aesthetic devices in texts informed, according to their detractors, by the traditional (positivist) worldview, thereby lacking the perennial sense of universal crisis (metaphysical, psychological, ethical, social, cultural) and concomitant transcendental longing informing Russian "new art" from the 1890s on. Our classification tools are again wanting.²¹ Stock critical filters do not adequately differentiate between such anti-novels as Babel's *The Red Cavalry* or Remizov's *Russia in the Whirlwind* (1927), and many future classics of Socialist Realism alien to Babel's and Remizov's ethos of temporal, spatial, and psychological subjectivity but sporting markers of modernism in their handling of style, narrative, genre, and motivation.²² Then there are liminal cases – writers and texts excluded from the Soviet canon but marginal to modernist studies. Andrei Platonov, for example, who was equally at ease in modernist and Socialist Realist poetics; or Mikhail Bulgakov, who replaced Andreev as the *bête noire* of modernist critics (Artsybashev's role went to Erenburg, also called "Verbitskaia in pants").

Bulgakov's case encapsulates the taxonomical quandaries of Russian modernist studies, especially as concerns the novel's plight.

In the 1920s, he was mocked as an epigone of modernist trailblazers. His first novel, *The White Guard* (1924), sports such telltale signs as narrative fragmentation, phonetic games, disruptive page graphics, subjective viewpoints, conflation of documentary and fictional material. But these do not support *The White Guard's* interpretation of the events described – civil war in Ukraine. The novel manifests what passes at the time for antiquated sensibility. Fascination with destruction and longing for a *tabula rasa* renewal are subtexts of modernist experiments. Bulgakov belongs to a different tradition. His novel glorifies the bourgeois household as a haven from social and cultural chaos, recoiling from the aesthetic and existential revolt against *byt* (everyday life) and the family, a revolt central to Russian modernism. Aware of this disconnect from the sources of his “modernist plumage,” Bulgakov assails the modernist ethos of destruction, depicting its mouthpieces (Shklovskii specifically) as agents of the cataclysms the novel’s heroes flee behind the cream-colored curtains of their cozy home.

Yet, Russianists are loath to side with Bulgakov’s modernist detractors, largely on the strength of his magnum opus, *The Master and Margarita* (1940). The novel’s reliance on the fantastic (Satan’s visit to Stalinist Moscow), coupled with the retelling of the Passion, formed such a contrast to Socialist Realism that, upon its belated publication (1967), the book fell into the Soviet aesthetic limbo populated by texts suspected of “modernism.” But if we use this term without the abusive connotations of Marxist aesthetics and free Bulgakov’s novel from the political context informing its unofficial cult in late Soviet culture, *The Master and Margarita's* classification proves problematic. Critics placing it next to Belyi’s *Petersburg* struggle to find rationale for such pairing. The novel’s reflection on the institution of authorship and the nature of reality resonates with modernist concerns; yet it “lacks the nervous, edgy tenor of much Russian modernist fiction,” and its treatment of these concerns “runs counter to the anxiety and uncertainty of modernity.”²³ Bulgakov shares modernism’s metaliterary focus: we read the Christological novel his hero is writing. But the narrative alternates so neatly between Stalinist Moscow and biblical Jerusalem as to

eliminate the core principle of modernist metafiction which makes readers into co-creators of meaning who parse through narrative planes, times, and voices. In its writer-protagonist, *The Master and Margarita* embodies the “modernist project, which presumes the existence of other worlds to which poets have privileged access”; but it does so following Tolstoy’s mimetic strategies.²⁴ Bulgakov’s turn to the gospels evokes early Russian modernism, whose investment in the irrational he nevertheless replaces with the positivism of David Strauss (*Life of Jesus*, 1836) and Ernest Renan (*Life of Jesus*, 1863). Recourse to the fantastic aligns *The Master and Margarita* with *The Petty Demon* and *The Fiery Angel*. But Bulgakov allows no room for rival (rational vs. supernatural) readings of the irruptions of the otherworldly into the everyday: the Moscow subplot is mostly a comic relief tool and a satire akin to major Soviet picaresques (e.g., Il’ia Il’f and Evgenii Petrov’s *The Twelve Chairs*, 1927, and *The Golden Calf*, 1931). And since we cannot compare our reading with the novel’s reception in Bulgakov’s interpretive community, the issue of the text’s classification looks sterile; all the more so because, focusing on Bulgakov, students of Russian modernism overlook more productive material.

For example, a historically contextualized view unmoored from stock critical coordinates reveals continuity between the novels of early Russian modernists and those of the 1920s. Iurii Tynianov is a case in point. Like all Formalists, Tynianov saw fiction as a corollary of scholarship and criticism. Until recently, however, his novels, narrating the lives and times of his academic subjects (Wilhelm Küchelbecker in *Kiukhlia*, 1925; Aleksandr Griboedov in *The Death of Vazir-Mukhtar*, 1928) have not been identified as material for modernist studies. Yet they owe much to the historical romances of Briusov, Kuzmin, and Merezhkovskii, even if Tynianov would disavow such lineage, as befits a modernist typically reluctant to acknowledge immediate precursors. Tynianov shares with his predecessors, poets turned novelists, a self-confessed preference for poetry and playful condescension to the novelistic genre rivaling Shklovskii’s.²⁵ Like Briusov and Kuzmin, he renews literary language under the guise of stylizing exotic sources (the speech of

Russia's early modern elite) and targets two audiences. Ostensibly accessible, his novels hide a system of in-jokes and self-conscious narrative tools for the benefit of those versed in Formalist theories. This dual intent shapes the reception of his novels, which are not proscribed under Stalin, but are read by the initiated as products of the culture of modernism.²⁶ Tynianov presents an alternative to the anti-novels of Pil'niak, Babel', Shklovskii, and Remizov: he chooses not to challenge readers by overt experiments, and capitalizes instead on the early modernist tradition of concealment. Under deceptively smooth surfaces, his novels manifest narrative fragmentation, stylistic expressionism, subjective viewpoints, generic fluidity, tension of fact and fiction, and metaliterariness. All this points to Tynianov's modernist sensibility, but his novels resist description by the conventional taxonomic tools of modernist studies.

In sum, divorced from specific contexts and interpretive communities, stylistic and narrative traits associated with modernism are insufficient classification criteria. Russians have read as modernist aesthetically traditional novels that, in a specific historical moment, express the "new sensibility" in the opinion of a given interpretive community. Obversely, novels bearing the aesthetic signs of modernism have been treated as non- or anti-modernist, if they display ethics and philosophy codified as traditional. Stock critical coordinates actually obscure relations between texts and the culture of modernism informing them. Such coordinates cannot explain why a veteran of that culture, Vladislav Khodasevich, experienced Briusov's *The Fiery Angel* and Nabokov's novels as equally modernist.²⁷ For him, the two novelists shared a sense of time, space, and personality alien to the positivist worldview, their ways of conveying this sense notwithstanding; even if Briusov's aesthetic traditionalism and flight into the fantastic had little to do with Nabokov's experimental prose which subverted positivist mimesis while ostensibly relying on the referential illusion. Thus, insofar as the problematics of *Russian modernism and the novel* are located at the intersection of the "new sensibility" and the genre's idiosyncratic practice by individual authors, it is useful to identify some texts that go the farthest in expressing modernist sensibility, while keeping

immune to Russian modernism's anti-novelistic ethos; that is, novels by a minority of Russian modernists who sought to revive rather than deconstruct the genre.

If we placed Russian novels along an axis taking the measure of their engagement with the culture of modernism, and another measuring their concern for the genre's vitality, we would see that the criteria begin to coalesce in *Petersburg* which demarcates two eras in Russian modernism. A blueprint for this event appears earlier, in Belyi's 1908 review of Stanislaw Przybyszewski's *Homo Sapiens* (1901).²⁸ All that he ascribes to the Polish novel – fragmented depiction of space, time, heroes, and events; reliance on active readership to make sense of the narrative; lack of psychological speculation as a motivating link between the inner life and actions of characters – Belyi develops in *Petersburg*, which earns him the title of “a cubist in literature.”²⁹ The novel traces, over the course of a week, two overlapping stories – a mythopoetic parable of Belyi's tragic affair with Blok's wife, and a terrorist plot in the imperial capital. *Petersburg's* style matches its unconventional narrative. Written by a poet, this “philological novel” explores language – phonemes, morphemes, syllables, syntactic rhythm, page graphics – as a reality-generating medium: Belyi mocks positivist assumptions by showing the world as a linguistic illusion originating in the psyche.³⁰ With this novel, he becomes, in Evgenii Zamiatin's words, “a writer for writers” charting the course of Russian prose, whose practitioners place him next to Joyce.³¹

The appreciation of Belyi's impact on the prose of Russian modernists has been hampered by the preeminence of politics in the study of post-1917 Russian art. Take Zamiatin's own novel *We* (1921). With the Soviet experience receding into history, scholars now approach *We* not just as a dystopian response to Marxism, but as a dramatization of Zamiatin's modernist manifesto, “On Literature, Revolution, Entropy, and Other Matters” (1923). The novel and the essay pick up Belyi's thread. They reassert the Nietzschean vision of life as the elemental clash of Apollonian and Dionysian forces; stress relativity and irrationality, following Einstein and Freud, as principles inherent in the universe and the individual; reiterate the

bankruptcy of positivism and of the referential illusion as its artistic expression; and see linguistic and narrative experiments as ways of encoding modernity's fluidity and uncertainty. Heeding *Petersburg's* cues, *We* is comprised of short chapters with puzzling titles whose discontinuity echoes the lack of cohesion in elliptical point-of-view narration. The hero-narrator withholds more than he reveals about the actors, events, and their setting – a rationally organized city-state guarded by a wall from natural chaos. This wall metaphorizes the firewall of reason protecting the well-ordered society, and both are breached by the irrational energy inherent in humans. The fact that Soviet censors banned *We* speaks not so much to Zamiatin's politics, for he remained in Russia longer than most émigrés, but to the positivist roots of Marxism which a modernist found indefensibly naïve.

Zamiatin's turn to the novel as a modernist medium was atypical. *Petersburg* furnished a popular stylistic and narrative model for depicting revolutionary chaos in early Soviet prose, but despite Belyi's "modernizing" efforts, the novel continued to epitomize the pre-modernist worldview for the new cohort of verbal artists who used Belyi's linguistic and narrative devices better to undermine, rather than revive, the form. Belyi admits as much in a 1925 critical sketch which ridicules "the claims that revolutionary processes have found a reflection in the traditional novel; for such a novel is dead [. . .] The novel itself is a prerevolutionary form clearly disintegrating in prerevolutionary times under the impact of the growing revolutionary rhythm, so that Shklovskii is right to point to the replacement of the novel with a special kind of personal diary."³² His novels published after *Petersburg*, in fact, were decried as graphomaniacal eccentricities in Soviet Russia.³³ His novelistic experiment did not fare better in Russia Abroad. For example, on Shklovskii's prompting, exiled poet Il'ia Zdanevich wrote neologistically named *Parizhach'i* (1926), fusing Belyi's experiments with the legacy of Russian Futurist phonetic and morphological "transrationalism." The novel traces two hours in the lives of four Parisian couples, during which time the eight personages cross paths, converse, and try all possible mating combinations. The narrative is split into

sections with time indicators for titles; the reader follows eight stories whose actors roam in Paris more like Bloom in Dublin (Zdanevich being a Joyce fan) than Belyi's heroes in Petersburg. Symptomatically, *Parižhach'i* went unnoticed. The novel's arrival in Russia coincided with the hardening of Soviet cultural policies (Moscow publishers rejected Zdanevich's next novel, *Rapture* [1927], on aesthetic and philosophical grounds), and local modernists had bigger fish to fry than heed Zdanevich's dialogue with Belyi. Émigré modernists, for their part, dismissed Zdanevich thanks to his openly pro-Soviet politics and because they viewed Belyi's prose, due to its clear impact on early Soviet prose, as ideologically suspect and aesthetically "provincial."

The consolidation of the Russian modernist milieu in Paris, dominated by younger exiles, produced a sustained and constructive interest in the novel – an effort at generic rehabilitation that appears to be a peculiarity of late Russian modernism. After an infatuation with the Soviet avant-garde in the 1920s, largely in response to the émigré establishment's partiality to the nineteenth-century literary canon, younger exiles forged an artistic identity at the crossroads of Russian and French literatures. This process entailed a replacement of Russian models, Soviet and older émigré, with French ones, and the appropriation of the mythology of the postwar French modernist cohort. Russian *littérateurs* were privy to the debates about the novel which raged in France against the backdrop of the publication of Marcel Proust's *In Search of Lost Time* (1917–27), spilling into André Gide's *The Counterfeiters* (1925), Louis Aragon's *Parisian Peasant* (1926), and L.-F. Céline's *Journey to the End of the Night* (1932), all of them turned into artistic springboards by émigré modernists.³⁴

Contributing factors in the novel's émigré rehabilitation were the Stalinist crackdown in the Soviet field of cultural production and the concomitant upsurge in Soviet metafiction (some of it in novelistic form; e.g., Konstantin Vaginov, Veniamin Kaverin) negotiating the institutional crises of art and authorship.³⁵ Reaching Paris, these texts validated the émigré self-image as the avant-garde of Russian culture. Under the circumstances, vanguardism entailed a sense of responsibility that expanded the scope of modernist concerns to

cultural preservation and continuity. Conservation, hitherto a hostile trait, moved to the fore of modernist prerogatives. At issue was the identification of values – spiritual, philosophical, ethical, aesthetic – that needed salvaging in contrast to those which, in Soviet guise, corroded Russian culture. The novel offered an ideal discursive medium for this project, whose ethos disenfranchised the stylistic and narrative practices associated with the genre's deconstruction by the Soviet modernists of the 1920s and by their teachers – Belyi, his attempts at reviving the genre notwithstanding, and Remizov, who found a more responsive audience among the French than among his fellow émigré littérateurs. Articulated as a return to simplicity and sincerity, this changing of the guard in Russian modernist culture involved the branding of a wide spectrum of recent prose, from Pil'niak to Shklovskii, as pretentious and shallow.

There was, of course, nothing simple about the new effort; even if, to cite Iurii Fel'zen, exiles were better off with Proust than with Joyce (who was, *inter alia*, too reminiscent of Belyi).³⁶ Fel'zen himself strove to reconcile modernism and the novel. His longer narratives (*Deceit*, 1930; *Happiness*, 1932; *Letters about Lermontov*, 1935) and short prose form one autobiographically motivated text, dubbed *roman s pisatelem* by its hero. The polysemy of *roman* opens the phrase to several readings – a novel with/about a writer; an affair with a writer – which are the axes of Fel'zen's project. The stories of the hero-narrator's artistic maturation and sentimental education are linked by the philosophy of love and art hailing from *In Search of Lost Time*. Like Proust's novel, *roman s pisatelem* recounts the aesthetic and emotional journey of a self-scrutinizing protagonist whose analytical focus is the core of Fel'zen's art. Once dismissed by Russian modernists along with the novel, psychological speculation makes a comeback in émigré prose, not least as an antidote to the primitive Socialist Realist hero. Heeding Proust's stylistic search, Fel'zen violates normative morphology and syntax; yet exiles favorably contrast his iconoclasm to the "linguistic pretension" of early Soviet modernists. In these aesthetics of opposition, Soviet avant-garde practices merged with Socialist Realism to the benefit of émigré modernism and thanks to its polemics with Stalinist

values – a debate that punctuates *Letters about Lermontov*. Here Fel'zen's hero swaps his diary for monological correspondence with a beloved whose coldness he compensates in another *roman*, that with his idols, Lermontov and Proust, and literature at large. The novel's title and structure allude to *Zoo, or Letters Not about Love*, used by Shklovskii as a platform for surrendering to the Soviets and deconstructing the novelistic genre. In contrast, *Letters about Lermontov* redefines what it means to write about love by glorifying Proust's solipsistic individualism as the source of creativity and the axiological matrix which put Fel'zen's *roman s pisatelem* on a collision course with the new Stalinist as well as the old nineteenth-century canons, both moored in the intelligentsia's utilitarian puritanism to which Fel'zen traces the genealogy of Russian Marxism.³⁷

Fel'zen's method came under Nabokov's parodic fire; for Nabokov opposed to neo-Proustianism his own – omnivorous and irreverent – approach to literary sources. Their quarrel abutted the larger issue of constructing the modernist tradition, which informed the feud between Nabokov the Berliner and the émigré modernists in Paris who saw as promiscuous Nabokov's pragmatic exploitation of a wide array of models. Indeed, Nabokov's oeuvre is a melting pot of Russian modernism, from all periods and political sides, tempered by a list of foreign teachers, where Joyce flanks Proust, and Kafka sits next to Gide.³⁸ It is little wonder that *The Gift*, Nabokov's last Russian novel, intended as a sum total of his poetics and thought, is an encyclopedia of "Russian modernism and the novel." *The Gift* contemplates and incorporates into its narrative fabric such signal issues of modernist literary history as the invasion of imaginative writing by criticism and scholarship; the porousness of fact and fiction; the relation of artistic experiments to the "new sensibility"; the balance of innovation, targeting an active but restricted audience, and the preservation of traditions; and, last but not least, the role of genres, at a time of their extreme fluidity, as mediums for aesthetic iconoclasm, philosophical self-expression, and cultural continuity.

The Gift scours artistic and intellectual history for a usable legacy in which to anchor Russian literature and culture. This survey is couched in a metafictional, autobiographically motivated story of an

émigré's artistic, philosophical, and sentimental education (hence Nabokov's attention to Fel'zen's project). By way of literary exercises heavy on critical (self-)reflection – they range from the protagonist's poetic juvenilia, steeped in early modernist aesthetics, to his new poem in the making; and from a cautionary tale about the tragic demise of a young émigré poet, undone by the early modernist practice of “life-creation,” to the life-affirming story of the hero's father, written as an apprenticeship in Pushkin's poetics, and to the satirical, Gogolian biography cum exorcism of the positivist intelligentsia's patron saint, Nikolai Chernyshevsky – the hero moves toward the ultimate goal of expressing his matured aesthetics and worldview in “a good, thick old-fashioned novel” that mirrors Nabokov's own program of salvaging the nineteenth-century canon from the claims of Socialist Realism and adapting this canon to modernist sensibility.³⁹

Importantly for our understanding of Russian modernism's place vis-à-vis its Western counterparts, Nabokov enlists a foreign text as his aesthetic springboard, but never openly acknowledges the debt, even if it does not go unnoticed by his émigré readers.⁴⁰ His reference point is *The Counterfeiters*, whose hero nurtures the idea of a novel that codifies the rules and tests the limits of the ailing genre. Attuned to Gide's debate with positivist mimesis and Proustian circularity, and heeding the hierarchy of authorial consciousness in Gide's metafiction (which excludes its hero's eponymous novel from *The Counterfeiters*), Nabokov radicalizes his model by obfuscating *The Gift*'s relation to its protagonist's novelistic project and thereby sending the readers on a still-ongoing critical hunt for structural and semantic clues that immerses us into the problematics of the novelistic genre. Nabokov far surpasses Gide's narrow concern for the viability of a literary genre by turning *The Gift* into a polemical shooting range that targets those intellectual and aesthetic trends – past and present, Russian and Western – which, in the author's view, set the conditions for the current crisis of Russian literature and culture.⁴¹

One could easily line up other authors and texts for a productive examination of the problem “Russian modernism and

the novel” – Gaito Gazdanov, Sigizmund Krzhizhanovskii, Iurii Olesha, Andrei Platonov, Boris Poplavskii, Sergei Sharshun, Konstantin Vaginov – although any such discussion must include the towering examples of *Petersburg* and *The Gift* in which Russian literature comes the closest to laying claim to its own “modernist novel.” Then again, Russian modernist studies are only now coming of age, so that much of the story outlined in this chapter is to be continued.

Notes

1. Boris Eikhenbaum, “Roman ili biografiia” (1913), in his *O literature* (Moscow: Sovetskii pisatel’, 1987), 288–9.
2. Kornei Chukovskii (June 28, 1920), *Dnevnik 1901–1929* (Moscow: Sovremennyi pisatel’, 1997), 146. Boris Eikhenbaum, *Molodoi Tolstoi* (1922); “O Shatobriane . . .” (1924), in his *O literature*, 35, 367. Osip Mandel’shtam, “Konets romana” (1922), in his *Sochineniia*, 2 vols. (Moscow: Khudozhestvennaia literatura, 1990), 2:204.
3. Henry James, “Preface,” in his *The Tragic Muse*, 2 vols. (New York: Scribner’s, 1908), 1:x; *Letters*, 2 vols. (New York: Scribner’s, 1920), 2:237.
4. Viacheslav Polonskii, “O Babele.” *Novyi mir* 1 (1927): 216.
5. Lidia Ginzburg’s diary (1925–26), in her *Zapisnye knizhki. Vospominaniia. Esse* (SPb: Iskusstvo, 2002), 35.
6. This process is at the center of Formalist theorizing. See, e.g., Iurii Tynianov, “Literaturnyi fakt” (1924), in his *Arkhaisty i novatory* [1929] (Munich: Wilhelm Fink, 1967), 23–9.
7. Boris Eikhenbaum, *Molodoi Tolstoi*, 36. Viktor Shklovskii, *Rožanov* (Petrograd: OPOIaZ, 1921), 16–39.
8. André Gide, *Romans* (Paris: Gallimard, 1998), 1081; *Journal des Faux-Monnayeurs* (Paris, 1995), 35.
9. Fedor Ivanov, “Fetishisty fakta.” *Krasnaia nov’* 7 (1929): 235.
10. See Roman Jakobson, “On Realism in Art” (1921), in his *Language in Literature* (Cambridge, MA: The Belknap Press, 1987), 19–27.
11. Erich Auerbach, *Mimesis*, trans. W. Trask (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1953), 534–46.
12. Lidia Ginzburg, *O literaturnom geroe* (Leningrad: Sovetskii pisatel’, 1979), 80.
13. Letter to Maxim Gorky (December 23/26, 1912). *Literaturnoe nasledstvo* 72 (1965): 351.
14. Andrei Belyi, “M. Kuzmin. Kryl’ia.” *Pereval* 6 (1907): 50–1. Vatslav Vorovskii, “O burzhuznosti modernistov” (1908), in his *Literaturno-kriticheskie stat’i* (Moscow: OGIZ, 1948), 201.

15. T. S. Eliot, "Preface," in his *For Lancelot Andrewes* (London: Faber and Gwyer, 1928), ix–x; "Tradition and the Individual Talent," in his *Selected Essays* (London: Faber and Faber, 1953) 14. Ezra Pound, "Harold Monro." *Criterion* XI:45 (July 1932): 590.
16. Valerii Briusov, "Sviashchennaia zhertva," *Vesy* 1 (January 1905): 26. Arthur Rimbaud, "Lettres du 'voyant' [15 mai 1871]," in his *Poésies* (Paris: Gallimard, 1994), 205. See also T. S. Eliot, "Baudelaire," in his *Selected Essays*, 423–4.
17. Vladislav Khodasevich, "Konets Renaty." *Koleblemyi trenozhnik* (Moscow: Sovetskii pisatel', 1991), 269–78. See also Nikolai Bogomolov, "Prose between Symbolism and Realism," in *The Cambridge Companion to Twentieth-Century Russian Literature*, ed. Evgenii Dobrenko (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), 30–1.
18. Andrei Belyi, "Ognennyi angel" (1909), in his *Arabeski* (Munich: Wilhelm Fink, 1969), 454–6. Mikhail Kuzmin, "Khudozhestvennaia proza 'Vesov'." *Apollon* 9 (1910): 39–40.
19. Boris Eikhenbaum, "O proze Kuzmina" (1920), in his *O literature*, 348–51.
20. Aleksei Remizov, "Poslushnyi samokey," in his *Izbrannoe* (Leningrad: Lenizdat, 1991), 579–82.
21. See Robert Russell, "The Modernist Tradition," in *The Cambridge Companion to the Classic Russian Novel*, eds. Malcolm Jones and Robin Miller (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 223–4.
22. D. Furmanov, *Chapaev* (1923); A. Fadeev, *The Rout* (1926); K. Fedin, *Cities and Years* (1924); F. Gladkov, *Cement* (1925); A. Serafimovich, *The Iron Flood* (1924). For an example of the modernist critique targeting such practices, see Evgenii Zamiatin, "O segodniashnem i sovremennom," in his *Litsa* (New York: Mezhdunarodnoe literaturnoe sodruzhestvo, 1967), 215.
23. Russell, "The Modernist Tradition," 227.
24. Caryl Emerson, *The Cambridge Introduction to Russian Literature* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008), 170–8.
25. Iurii Tynianov, "Avtobiografiia," in his *Sochineniia*, 3 vols. (Moscow: Khudozhestvennaia literatura, 1959), 1:9.
26. Georgii Adamovich, "Literaturnye besedy." *Zveno* 210 (1927): 2. Lidiia Ginzburg, *Zapisnye knizhki*, 383. Al'fred Bëm, "Iurii Tynianov." *Sovremennye zapiski* (1932): 461–2.
27. V. Khodasevich, "Konets Renaty," 269–78; "O Sirine," *Literaturnye stat'i* (New York: Chekhov, 1954), 245–54.
28. Andrei Belyi, "Prorok bezlichii," in his *Arabeski* (Munich: Wilhelm Fink, 1969), 3–6.
29. Nikolai Berdiaev, "Picasso" (1914); "Astral'nyi roman" (1916), in his *Krizis iskusstva* (Moscow: G. A. Leman, 1918), 32, 41.

30. See Carol Anschuetz, "Bely's *Petersburg* and the End of the Russian Novel." In *The Russian Novel from Pushkin to Pasternak*, ed. John Garrard (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1983), 125–46.
31. B. Pasternak, B. Pil'niak, G. Sannikov, "Andrei Belyi." *Izvestiia* 8 (January 9, 1934): 4. E. Zamiatin, "Andrei Belyi" (1934), in his *My* (Kishinev: Literatura artistike, 1989), 609–10.
32. Andrei Belyi, "Literatura i krizis zhizni," cited in Nikolai Bogomolov, *Russkaia literatura pervoi treti XX veka* (Tomsk: Vodolei, 1999), 476–7.
33. Osip Mandel'shtam, "Andrei Belyi. Zapiski chudaka." *Krasnaia nov'* 5 (1923): 399–400.
34. See Leonid Livak, *How It Was Done in Paris: Russian Émigré Literature and French Modernism* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 2003).
35. See David Shepherd, *Beyond Metafiction: Self-Consciousness in Soviet Literature* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1992).
36. Iurii Fel'zen, "O Pruste i Dzhoise" (1932), in his *Sobranie sochinenii*, 2 vols. (Moscow: Vodolei, 2012), 2:217–20.
37. See Livak, *How It Was Done in Paris*, 121–34.
38. See Magdalena Medaric, "Vladimir Nabokov i roman XX stoletiiia." *Russian Literature* 29, no. 1 (1991): 79–100. Wolfgang Kissel, "Russkoe tvorchestvo Vladimira Nabokova kak sintez modernistskikh techenii Serebrianogo veka." *Modernités russes* 7 (2007): 599–620.
39. Vladimir Nabokov, *The Gift* (New York: Vintage International, 1991), 4.
40. Petr Bitsilli appears to be the first Russian critic to have identified André Gide as Nabokov's "teacher," in "Zhizn' i literatura." *Sovremennye zapiski* 51 (1933): 286.
41. See Livak, *How It Was Done in Paris*, 164–203.

Realism in Transition

*Bootmakers and Watchmakers: Wells, Bennett,
Galsworthy, Woolf, and Modernist Fiction*

David Bradshaw

To a surprising extent, our current understanding of the relationship between Edwardian and modernist fiction continues to be inflected, if not shaped, by a protracted wrangle about sex and character that took place almost a hundred years ago. As a result, what is arguably the faintest of hairline cracks in the history of the early twentieth-century novel (if there is any rent at all) still tends to be thought of as a gaping fault line. Late September 1920 found Virginia Woolf “making up a paper upon Women, as a counterblast to Mr [Arnold] Bennett’s adverse views reported in the papers.”¹ In *Our Women* (1920), Bennett asserts, among other things, that “intellectually and creatively man is the superior of woman, and that in the region of creative intellect there are things which men almost habitually do but which women have not done and give practically no sign of ever being able to do.”² If it was ever completed, Woolf’s “paper” has not survived, but her annoyance with Bennett and his supporters was discharged in a brace of spirited letters to the *New Statesman*.³ By this point, of course, Woolf had already been dismissive of the “living, breathing, everyday imperfection” of the “materialist” fiction of Bennett, H. G. Wells, and John Galsworthy in “Modern Novels” (1919).⁴ Three years later, the female narrator of *Jacob’s Room* would go on to suggest that the works of Bennett (and John Masefield) should be “burn[ed] . . . to cinders. Let not a shred remain. Don’t palter with the second rate. Detest your own age. Build a better one.”⁵ In 1923, Bennett hit back in an article entitled “Is the Novel Decaying?” in which he claimed that the characters of *Jacob’s Room* “do not vitally survive in the mind because the author has been obsessed by details of originality and cleverness.”⁶ He went on to

remark, in 1926, that “Mrs Woolf . . . told us ten thousand things about Mrs Dalloway, but did not show us Mrs Dalloway,”⁷ and he would also be less than complimentary about Woolf’s writing in his reviews of *To the Lighthouse* (1927), *Orlando* (1928), and *A Room of One’s Own* (1929).⁸ “Virginia Woolf has passionate praisers,” Bennett wrote in “The Progress of the Novel” (1929), “who maintain that she is a discoverer in psychology and in form. Disagreeing, I regard her alleged form as an absence of form, and her psychology as an uncoordinated mass of interesting details, none of which is truly original. All that I can urge in her favour is that she is authentically feminine, and that her style is admirable.”⁹

Earlier in the decade, Woolf’s hostility to Wells’s, Bennett’s, and Galsworthy’s fiction had been rekindled in three essays that have acquired the status of foundation texts in the annals of modernist fiction. Their shared *donnée* is that to a greater or lesser extent the novels of these “Edwardian” writers are populated by psychologically unconvincing characters and disfigured by an undisciplined concern with “materialist” detail, extraneous facts, and excrescent social commentary, whereas the fictions of Joyce and other “Georgians” (including, by implication, Woolf herself), are the work of consummate craftsmen equipped with abundant psychological acuity. Having first broached her hypothesis in “Modern Novels,” Woolf reprised and expanded it (as a direct response to Bennett’s “Is the Novel Decaying?”) in “Mr Bennett and Mrs Brown” (1923). She presented her argument in its most extensive form in “Character in Fiction” (1924) – which, confusingly, was also issued as a pamphlet under the title *Mr Bennett and Mrs Brown* in the same year¹⁰ – before reiterating it once more in “Modern Fiction” (1925), a reworking of “Modern Novels” that she revised for inclusion in her first *Common Reader* collection.¹¹ Woolf had prepared for her “Mr Bennett and Mrs Brown” essay by reading Bennett’s *Riceyman Steps* (1923), which she wrote off as “dishwater”¹²; yet only a few years earlier, she had praised his *The Price of Love* (1914) as a “good” novel and had been “depress[ed]” by the “very astute realism” of *These Twain* (1916).¹³ Following the success of such experimental works as “The Mark on the Wall” and “An

Unwritten Novel,” however, Woolf rejected the materialists with gusto, and “Modern Novels” and its successive iterations are the highly influential fallout of her modernist turn of mind.

In “Character in Fiction,” Woolf claims that enquiring of Wells, Bennett, and Galsworthy about “how to create characters that are real” would be like “going to a bootmaker and asking him to teach you how to make a watch.”¹⁴ The most obvious problem with this withering put-down, however, is that its implied emphasis on severance and exceptionality, on there being a categorical distinction between the modernists and those who flourished just before them, occludes crucial debts and continuities. Modernism did not burst forth in full bloom “about the year 1910” but grew organically yet aberrantly from its Edwardian mulch.¹⁵ David Trotter has called Woolf’s quartet of essays “among the most influential . . . ever written about the modern novel,” while Robert Squillace has noted that when Woolf “invented the modernist movement” in “Mr Bennett and Mrs Brown” and its companion pieces, “she constructed a metaphor of generational conflict to characterize the period between 1900 and 1922” that is as misleading as it has been canon-forming.¹⁶ Undoubtedly, the best novels of all three of Woolf’s Edwardians had been published by 1918. Wells’s scientific romances of the 1890s, such as *The Time Machine* (1895), *The Island of Dr. Moreau* (1896), and *The War of the Worlds* (1898), and his Edwardian novels of realist topicality, such as *Kipps* (1905), *Tono-Bungay* (1909), and *The History of Mr. Polly* (1910), were not overshadowed by the many works of fiction that followed before his death in 1946; Bennett’s most assured novels would remain *Anna of the Five Towns* (1902), *The Old Wives’ Tale* (1908) and *Clayhanger* (1910), and Galsworthy’s *The Man of Property*, the first and most achieved of his Forsyte series, appeared in 1906 and was not superseded by the novels that followed in its wake. After the war a new generation of novelists did indeed take center stage – Woolf, Joyce, Huxley, Ford, Richardson, and Lawrence preeminent among them – but their advent did not signal the sudden eclipse of their materialist contemporaries.

In fact, if we use “the concept of modernism” to describe literary effects and shared thematic concerns, rather than “to evaluate” which

writers of the period under review “are considered innovatory . . . and those who aren’t,” Trotter has urged, then a less cataclysmic and more nuanced account of the early twentieth-century novel emerges.¹⁷ Moreover, if we adopt an approach that is based less on technical differences and more on thematic affinities, it is easier to delineate Woolf’s proximity to this Edwardian triumvirate rather than her generic separation from them. And once we’ve set aside the notion of modernism being heralded by template-shattering convulsions and reconfigure Wells, Bennett, and Galsworthy as pioneers rather than a superannuated old guard, then they quite naturally take their (subsidiary) places alongside Woolf in a history of the modernist novel that accommodates diversity rather than penalizing conventionality. Taking such a line, Anne Fernihough is one of a number of recent critics who have resisted Woolf’s sharp-edged distinction between Edwardians and Georgians and have stressed instead the connections to be found within the work of a range of novelists active in the era between the late nineteenth century and the early inter-war period. While acknowledging that Wells, Bennett, and Galsworthy are still “preserved in aspic by Woolf’s memorable attacks,” Fernihough shows how both Edwardian and modernist writers shared a keen interest in, among other things, vitalism, eugenics, and hyper-individualism.¹⁸ Another fundamental aspiration that was shared by both novelists of the avant-garde and many mainstream writers was to be allowed to express themselves without being gagged or indicted by the prudery that was pervasive in the first half of the century. We shall now turn to Wells’s *Ann Veronica* (1909) as an example of an Edwardian text that is frequently overlooked in histories of the modernist novel but which demands to be included not because of its technical virtuosity (it has very little) but because of its groundbreaking candor.

In 1911, Wells argued with infectious passion that the novel was on the cusp of becoming

the social mediator, the vehicle of understanding, the instrument of self examination, the parade of morals and the exchange of manners, the factory of customs, the criticism of laws and institutions and of social

dogmas and ideas. It is to be the home confessional, the initiator of knowledge, the seed of fruitful self-questioning . . . [T]he novelist is going to be the most potent of artists, because he is going to present conduct, devise beautiful conduct, discuss conduct, analyse conduct, suggest conduct, illuminate it through and through.¹⁹

Although Woolf is now unequivocally associated with high modernism, she was, quite possibly, much more sympathetic to this baggy, permissive, and revivifying account of the novel's potential than her landmark denunciations of the Edwardians would lead us to believe (in the same way that, at one level, Wells's rousing vision of the novel surely casts some light on *Ulysses*). For example, though Woolf could be contemptuous of Wells's crude characterization and his patent lack of interest in form, she generally warms to the topical charge of his novels. As she put it when drawing attention to "the Niagara [of opinion] which Mr Wells pours out when his blood is up," during the course of her review of *Joan and Peter* (1918), "No one . . . [is] so vivid, so pressing, so teeming and sprouting with suggestions and ideas and possibilities."²⁰ Few of Wells's novels are more "vivid" or "pressing" than *Ann Veronica*. He had been roundly criticized for his disdain of conventional marriage and his promotion of free love in *In the Days of the Comet* (1906), but when he stepped out of line even more brazenly in the blatantly less fantastic *Ann Veronica*, it did not take long for his book to become the first novel of the twentieth century to be greeted with the kind of vilification that had marked the publication of Vizetelly's translations of Zola in the late 1880s, George Moore's *Esther Waters* (1894), and Hardy's *Jude the Obscure* (1895).

Wells's novel recounts the struggle of the feisty Ann Veronica Stanley to escape both her home and the restrictive mores of her time. We know this twenty-one-year-old student of science will be a woman to be reckoned with when, in the second paragraph of the novel, she travels home from London to Morningside Park by train "with both her feet on the seat in an attitude that would certainly have distressed her [dead] mother to see and horrified her grandmother beyond measure; she sat with her knees up to her chin and her hands clasped before them."²¹ With her aunt censoring her

reading at home (13) and her father only reading books with chromatic titles in order to escape from the realities of contemporary society (16), Ann Veronica cannot wait to flee from suburbia. Mr. Stanley believes novels are dangerous in that they heave with “sham ideals and advanced notions. Women who Dids, and that kind of thing” (27). He even suggests that “There ought to be a censorship of books. We want it badly at the present time. Even *with* the censorship of plays there’s hardly a decent thing to which a man can take his wife and daughters, a creeping taint of suggestion everywhere” (27–8; see also 282). Further on in the novel, Mr. Stanley even goes so far as to declare that “people who wrote novels ought to be strung up” (96) and that children were being made daily more unfilial by “[r]ubbishy novels” (102). His daughter duly decamps to London, only to be propositioned among the prostitutes of Piccadilly Circus (85), and to be almost raped by a sexual opportunist in a *cabinet particulier*, which she regards as “a very great lark indeed” (165). During the remainder of the novel, Ann Veronica consorts with Fabians, becomes an ardent suffragette, is involved in a raid on the House of Commons, uses a false name when arrested, gets sent to prison, defies the prison chaplain, becomes engaged to someone she does not love, breaks off her engagement, and finally elopes with Capes, a married (but separated) demonstrator at Imperial College and a shameless clone of Wells himself.

Unsurprisingly, *Ann Veronica* was widely lambasted. “It is a book capable of poisoning the minds of those who read it,” thundered the *Spectator*. “[Wells’s] is a community of scuffling stoats and ferrets, unenlightened by a ray of duty and abnegation . . . Unless the citizens of a State put before themselves the principles of duty, self-sacrifice, self-control, and continence not merely in the matter of national defence, national preservation and national well-being, but also of the sex relationship, the life of the State must be short and precarious.”²² More significantly, as a direct result of the *Ann Veronica* rumpus, a meeting was held in November 1909²³ during which it was agreed to implement the kind of censorship called for by Mr. Stanley: the formation of

a Circulating Libraries Association to ensure that only works of “good taste in subject or treatment” would be found on [the Libraries’] shelves. A circular was sent to all publishers announcing the following resolve: “In order to protect our interests and also, as far as possible, to satisfy the wishes of our clients, we have determined that in future we will not place in circulation any book which, by reason of the personally scandalous, libellous, immoral or otherwise disagreeable nature of its contents, is in our opinion likely to prove offensive to any considerable section of our subscribers. We have, therefore, decided to request that in future you will submit to us copies of all novels . . . at least one clear week before date of publication.”²⁴

While this turn of events simply made explicit ground rules that publishers had long been obliged to observe, such an “outright declaration of censorship” caused bitter controversy.²⁵ Some of the most consistent criticism came from Bennett, writing as “Jacob Tonson” in the *New Age*, and the hullabaloo raged on for most of 1910, with *Ann Veronica* being banned by many public libraries.²⁶ In July that year, Wells’s novel, “in which,” as he himself put it, “the youthful heroine was allowed a frankness of desire and sexual enterprise hitherto unknown in English popular fiction,”²⁷ even prompted a gathering of the National Social Purity Crusade, and a *Spectator* editorial about the conference. St. Loe Strachey (author of the anonymous *Spectator* review that had instigated the *Ann Veronica* uproar in December 1909) expressed himself in favor of “voluntary rather than State action,” with regard to censorship, though he believed that without any action at all “literature would become a plague-spot.”²⁸

Regardless of its conventionality, *Ann Veronica*’s polemical “frankness” and the cultural commotion it occasioned make it an undressed cornerstone of the modernist movement, and without its calculated iconoclasm, for example, it is a moot point whether Lawrence (despite his finding it “rather trashy”²⁹ when he read it) would have had the confidence to portray the phenomenal Ursula Brangwen with quite the bravura he summons in *The Rainbow*. The days when fiction was in thrall to the “tyranny of the Libraries”³⁰ were far from over, but the two or three years following the publication of Wells’s novel witnessed a renewed determination

among writers of all kinds to fight a war of resistance against the all-powerful legions of prudery. When Bennett's *New Age* anti-censorship pieces were reprinted in his *Books and Persons* (1917), Woolf, in her *TLS* review of it, reminded her readers of the key role Bennett had played in the *Ann Veronica* hue and cry and quoted some of the most egregious denunciations of Wells's novel before concluding: "We must be very grateful to Mr Bennett for the pertinacity with which he went on saying in such circumstances 'that the first business of a work of art is to be beautiful, and its second not to be sentimental.'" Woolf could not resist a passing swipe at the "infantile realisms" of Bennett's fiction, but she is unequivocal about his role as a guardian of literary freedom.³¹ Bennett went on to support *The Rainbow* against the obloquy of the notorious James Douglas and others,³² just as, in the 1920s, he would publicly support *The Well of Loneliness* against the same benighted opponents.³³

Overall, as Squillace has noted, Bennett was very supportive of the modernist project, perceiving "continuity where . . . Woolf saw disjunction."³⁴ Similarly, Joyce never forgot the support he had received from Wells as he battled the prudes to get *Dubliners* published, while in his review of *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* Wells revealed himself to be one of the few readers, alongside the likes of Pound, able to do justice to Joyce's vision.³⁵ One way or another, through the "pertinacity" of their opposition to the cultural blockade mounted by the circulating libraries, public librarians, craven publishers, public morality watchdogs, and government agencies, and their broadly unwavering support for writers such as Joyce, Wyndham Lewis, and Dorothy Richardson, Wells and Bennett played a role that is still too frequently overlooked in accounts of the development of the modernist novel. An equally visionary and libertarian spirit prompted Galsworthy to take a leading role in the creation of P.E.N. and to become the first president of P.E.N. International from 1921 to 1932 (he was followed by H. G. Wells, who was president from 1932 to 1935). In his role at P.E.N., Galsworthy was at the forefront of the globalization of literature, and Rachel Potter is not the only commentator to applaud "the enduring trans-historical and transnational moral clarity of

Galsworthy's vision."³⁶ Bennett himself had to endure an "onslaught" from the arch-prude Douglas in connection with *The Pretty Lady*, his prostitute-themed novel of 1918, which led to it being boycotted by booksellers.³⁷ The fate of this materialist text further underlines the fact that the British literary scene between 1900 and 1922 witnessed the gradual emergence of the modernist novel in defiance of the many-headed Mrs. Grundy rather than a sudden and purely technical paradigm shift. As Maria Di Battista puts it, "Edwardian and Georgian realists were as subversive of tradition as the most militant avant-gardist,"³⁸ and it makes no sense to largely exclude Woolf's Edwardian "bootmakers" from historical surveys of this insurrectionary era. Wyndham Lewis satirizes Bennett's middlebrow prestige in *The Roaring Queen* (printed in 1936, but only published in 1973) and Lawrence expresses his disgust for Galsworthy in his characteristically intemperate "John Galsworthy" essay of 1928. When these sources are coupled with Woolf's four frequently cited and reprinted essays, it is not surprising that a tendency to denigrate Wells, Bennett, and Galsworthy as lumbering and banausic traditionalists has become entrenched over the past hundred years. But if we look at the period from a different angle, it is possible to appreciate that their own writings and their public advocacy of their modernist contemporaries are two sides of the same, pertinacious and principled standpoint.

Woolf's account of early twentieth-century literary history obfuscates not only the overall picture but quite possibly her own career as well. "It is impossible to tell how many 'beginners' were unable to publish fiction in this climate," Nicola Wilson has written of the *Ann Veronica* controversy and its aftermath, "but even a writer like Joyce . . . was not unaffected by the cautious publishing world."³⁹ Woolf began writing what would become her first novel, *The Voyage Out*, around 1907, and her progress was fairly steady until early 1909, when she told Clive Bell she was "terrifie[d]" by the "boldness" of her vision.⁴⁰ There followed four years of drafts, revisions, self-doubt, and mental breakdown. And while it would be going far too far to suggest that these problems were all brought

on by the fate of *Ann Veronica*, the censorship brought in as a result of it must surely have affected her confidence and troubled her “boldness” as a would-be novelist. *The Voyage Out* was eventually published in 1915, and in some ways it parallels Wells’s novel. Ann Veronica is propositioned in Piccadilly Circus just as Woolf’s Helen Ambrose brings to mind Piccadilly Circus and its prostitutes in the opening pages of *The Voyage Out* and Rachel Vinrace evokes them on a number of subsequent occasions in the novel. Ann Veronica has a nightmare, having been pursued by an “undesired, persistent male” (88), just as Rachel has a nightmare at the end of the fifth chapter of *The Voyage Out*, having been groped by the patrician Richard Dalloway. More intriguingly, while Ann Veronica comes straight out with her desire for Capes, *The Voyage Out* betrays a sustained anxiety about what can and cannot be said about such matters as childbirth, homosexuality, sex and desire, suggesting that Wells and Woolf were equally conscious of what they were up against as writers, even if they responded to the repressive literary culture of their time with different kinds of fiction.⁴¹ Woolf’s second novel, *Night and Day* (1919), hosts in Celia Milvain a doggedly prurient snooper, while her third, *Jacob’s Room* (1922), is just as provocatively smutty, in its own way, as the “conscious and calculated indecency” Woolf pinpoints in *Ulysses*.⁴² One way or another, the reader is prompted to respond to Woolf’s first three novels in a manner that is no less socially and culturally engaged than Wells’s or Galsworthy’s ideal reader. Deftly and discreetly, yet no less ardently than her Edwardian old guard, Woolf is intent on making her reader reflect on “real things beneath the show.”⁴³

Furthermore, by the mid-1920s, it could be argued, the binary and exclusionary view of the novel with which Woolf has become so closely associated was to some extent repudiated by her. In her contribution to a 1927 forum entitled “What Is a Novel?” for example, Woolf draws attention to the downside of having too rigid a conception of the form and more or less comes to Wells’s defense following the publication of *The World of William Clissold*, his sprawling and opinionated triple-decker of 1926.

A notable instance was lately provided by Mr Wells's *William Clissold*. It was condemned a thousand times not for this fault or for that, but because it was not a "novel." It is high time that this imaginary but still highly potent bogey was destroyed. And since we are without law-givers, let us implore the novelists themselves to come to our help. When they write a novel let them define it. Let them say that they have written a chronicle, a document, a rhapsody, a fantasy, an argument, a narrative, a dream. For there is no such thing as "a novel."⁴⁴

These remarks are symptomatic of a more laissez-faire attitude to fiction that is increasingly apparent in Woolf's writings of the late 1920s as she moved toward the genre-busting achievement of *The Waves* (1931). Yet only a few years earlier, in "Character in Fiction," she had insisted "that all novels . . . deal with character, and that it is to express character – not to preach doctrines, sing songs, or celebrate the glories of the British Empire, that the form of the novel, so clumsy, verbose, and undramatic, so rich, elastic, and alive, has been evolved."⁴⁵ In truth, Woolf was always in two minds about the novel, one "Edwardian" and one "Georgian," as she might have put it. During the course of 1929, for example, she was adamant, in "Women and Fiction," that the novel "will become, more than at present, a work of art like any other . . . it will draw off the aliens who have been attracted to fiction by its accessibility while their hearts lay elsewhere. Thus will the novel be rid of those excrescences of history and fact which, in our time, have made it so shapeless."⁴⁶ In the same year she observed, in *A Room of One's Own*, that works of fiction "are not spun in mid-air by incorporeal creatures, but are the work of suffering human beings, and are attached to grossly material things, like health and money and the houses we live in."⁴⁷

Bennett's death in 1931 left Woolf "sadder than I should have supposed. A lovable genuine man."⁴⁸ Their literary kerfuffle had never really soured their personal relationship, but Bennett would no doubt have been surprised to discover that during the early 1930s Woolf struggled with a form of fiction that he, Galsworthy (who died in 1933), and especially Wells would have found far from unrecognizable. Following the publication of *The Waves*, Woolf

turned her attention to a novel that was known in its early stages as “The Pargiters.” Some of this material would eventually find its way into *The Years* (1937) and *Three Guineas* (1938), but Woolf was minded at first to intercalate fiction and commentary in a patently Wellsian fashion (as she had done, to a certain extent, in *A Room of One’s Own*). As she recorded in her diary on May 31, 1933. “The thing is to be venturesome, bold, to take every possible fence. One might introduce plays, poems, letters, dialogues: must get the round, not only the flat. Not the theory only. And conversation; argument. How to do that will be one of the problems. I mean intellectual argument in the form of art: I mean how give ordinary waking Arnold Bennett life the form of art?”⁴⁹ She also said at the time that her novel in progress was “not a novel of vision, but a novel of fact.”⁵⁰ Not long afterward, she abandoned this experimental “Novel-Essay,” but *The Years* remains in some ways strikingly indebted to the Edwardian materialists given its author’s supposed contempt for them.

In *Three Guineas*, Woolf notes with despair that in the late 1930s “the patriarchal system” remains firmly embedded in British life and is epitomized by “the private house, with its nullity, its immorality, its hypocrisy, its servility.”⁵¹ In *The Years* this “system” is anatomized through the “dense materialism”⁵² of Woolf’s narrative and is captured in the regular reappearance of an armchair with clawed feet, a walrus hairbrush, a family portrait, and other artifacts that reify the values the novel confronts. Woolf proceeds, in other words, in a fashion that is not entirely dissimilar to Galsworthy’s in *The Forsyte Saga* (just as *The Years* would attract sales of an almost Galsworthian magnitude). And in spite of her declared (and distinctly blinkered) antipathy to Galsworthy’s novels in the sixth chapter of *A Room of One’s Own* – “they celebrate male virtues, enforce male values and describe the world of men”⁵³ – her penultimate novel returns precisely to the territories (the family house and the family saga) with which his name had become synonymous. Just as *The Man of Property* opens in 1886, and just as a great deal of it takes place in the gloomy, professional, “dark green velvet and heavily-carved mahogany”⁵⁴ interiors of the various Forsyte houses in London, so

The Years opens in 1880 and largely takes place in the several London households of the Pargiters. *The Forsyte Saga* charts both the gradual erosion of “patriarchal life” (FS 15) and its indelible impact on those born into it, especially women. In the early chapters of *The Years*, Woolf appears to go out of her way to recreate the “rich brown atmosphere” (FS 32) of Galsworthy’s chronicle. *The Forsyte Saga* begins with a gathering of the family in an imposing West London house and ends in a volume called *To Let* (1921), in which Robin Hill, the house that Bosinney has built for Soames at such terrible cost, is put up for rent, while *The Years* begins with the children of the two-faced Abel Pargiter gathered together in his West London house and ends with a cross-generational party in a hired office. Both novels plot the same economic and sociological pathways from the late nineteenth century to post–First World War England, and while, at a superficial level, *The Years* may seem to burlesque the materialism of the Edwardian novel, at a more profound level it might be seen as a belated refurbishment of the genre. *The Years*, in other words, might be considered a plum example of “late modernism” in that it “reopens the modernist enclosure of form onto the work’s social and political environs, facilitating its more direct, polemical engagement with topical and popular discourses.”⁵⁵

While the differences between, say, Bennett’s *Hilda Lessways* (1911) or Wells’s *The New Machiavelli* (1911), and *Dubliners*, *The Good Soldier*, or *Ulysses* are immense in terms of technique and narrative complexity, Woolf’s “myth of generational and artistic schism”⁵⁶ has obscured the scandalous connections between these texts. Her essays were never intended to have had the influence they have enjoyed for far too long and it could not be clearer at this stage that their central thesis and key terms are more usefully interrogated than applied. For while her representative Edwardians may have only a weak claim to be regarded as horologists, they were hardly the cobblers Woolf made them out to be, and their crucial, if restricted, contributions to the modernist novel, both textual and cultural, demand more consistent acknowledgment.

Notes

1. Virginia Woolf, *The Diary of Virginia Woolf*, ed. Anne Olivier Bell, assisted by Andrew McNeillie, vol. 2, 1920–24 (London: Hogarth Press, 1980), 69.
2. Arnold Bennett, *Our Women: Chapters on the Sex-Discord* (London: Cassell, 1920), 101.
3. Both are reprinted in Woolf, *Diary*, vol. 2, 339–42.
4. Virginia Woolf, “Modern Novels,” in *The Essays of Virginia Woolf*, eds. Andrew McNeillie and Stuart N. Clarke, vol. 3, 1919–24 (London: Hogarth Press, 1986), 31–2.
5. Virginia Woolf, *Jacob’s Room*, ed. Edward L. Bishop (Oxford: Blackwell, 2004), 88.
6. Quoted in Woolf, *Diary*, vol. 2, 248.
7. Quoted in Samuel Hynes, “The Whole Contention between Mr Bennett and Mrs Woolf,” *Novel* 1 (Fall 1967): 41.
8. Bennett’s reviews are reprinted in Samuel Hynes, *The Author’s Craft and Other Critical Writings of Arnold Bennett* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1968). On *To the Lighthouse* (1927), see 221; on *Orlando* (1928), see 222–4; on *A Room of One’s Own* (1929), see 225–7.
9. Bennett, “The Progress of the Novel,” in Hynes, *The Author’s Craft*, 96–97.
10. Woolf, “Character in Fiction,” in *Essays*, vol. 3, 384–89; Woolf, “Mr Bennett and Mrs Brown,” in *Essays*, vol. 3, 420–38.
11. Virginia Woolf, “Modern Fiction,” *The Essays of Virginia Woolf*, ed. Andrew McNeillie, vol. 4, 1925–28 (London: Hogarth Press, 1986), 157–65.
12. Virginia Woolf, *The Letters of Virginia Woolf*, eds. Nigel Nicolson and Joanne Trautmann, vol. 3, 1923–28 (London: Hogarth Press, 1978), 100.
13. Virginia Woolf, *The Letters of Virginia Woolf*, eds. Nigel Nicolson and Joanne Trautmann, vol. 2, 1912–22 (London: Hogarth Press, 1976), 55, 81.
14. Woolf, “Character in Fiction,” in *Essays*, vol. 3, 427.
15. *Ibid.*, 422.
16. David Trotter, *The English Novel in History 1895–1920* (London and New York: Routledge, 1993), 133; Robert Squillace, *Modernism, Modernity, and Arnold Bennett* (London: Associated University Press, 1997), 16. See Squillace’s opening chapter, “From Modernism to Modernity,” for a contextualized defense of Bennett’s craftsmanship, 15–35.
17. Trotter, *The English Novel in History*, 5.
18. Anne Fernihough, *Freewomen and Supermen: Edwardian Radicals and Literary Modernism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 22.
19. Wells, “The Contemporary Novel,” reprinted in *Henry James and H. G. Wells: A Record of Their Friendship, Their Debate on the Art of Fiction and*

- Their Quarrel*, eds. Leon Edel and Gordon N. Ray (London: Rupert Hart-Davis, 1958), 154.
20. Woolf, *Essays*, vol. 2, 295
 21. H. G. Wells, *Ann Veronica* (1909; Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1968), 9. All further page references are embodied in the text.
 22. Anon., "A Poisonous Book," *Spectator*, 103, no. 4247 (November 20, 1909): 846. Reprinted in *H. G. Wells: The Critical Heritage*, ed. Patrick Parrinder (London: Routledge, 1997), 169–72.
 23. See Anon., "The Library Censorship," *Spectator*, 103, no. 4250 (December 11, 1909): 986–7.
 24. Quoted in Nicola Wilson, "Circulating Morals (1900–1915)," in *Prudes on the Prowl: Fiction and Obscenity in England, 1850 to the Present Day*, eds. David Bradshaw and Rachel Potter (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 58.
 25. Wilson, "Circulating Morals," 59.
 26. *Ibid.*, 56.
 27. H. G. Wells, *Experiment in Autobiography* (1934; London: Faber and Faber, 1984), 2:470.
 28. Anon., "News of the Week," *Spectator* 105, no. 4282 (July 23, 1910), 119.
 29. D. H. Lawrence, *The Letters of D. H. Lawrence*, eds. George N. Zytaruk and James T. Boulton, vol. 2 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1981), 90. See also *The Letters of D. H. Lawrence*, ed. James T. Boulton, vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1979), 154, 339.
 30. Wilson, "Circulating Morals," 64.
 31. Woolf, *Essays*, vol. 2, 130.
 32. See Bradshaw and Potter, eds., *Prudes on the Prowl*, 68–70, 95–96. For a full account of Douglas's career, see David Bradshaw, "James Douglas: The Sanitary Inspector of Literature," in *Prudes on the Prowl*, 90–110.
 33. See Bradshaw and Potter, eds., *Prudes on the Prowl*, 84.
 34. Squillace, *Modernism, Modernity and Arnold Bennett*, 17.
 35. See H. G. Wells, "James Joyce," in Patrick Parrinder and Robert Philmus, eds. *H. G. Wells's Literary Criticism* (Sussex: Harvester Press, 1980), 171–5.
 36. Rachel Potter, *Obscene Modernism: Literary Censorship and Experiment, 1900–1940* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 157.
 37. Arnold Bennett, *Letters of Arnold Bennett*, ed. James Hepburn, vol. 1, *Letters to J. B. Pinker* (London: Oxford University Press, 1966), 261–2; see also Arnold Bennett, *Letters of Arnold Bennett*, ed. James Hepburn, vol. 3, 1916–1931 (London: Oxford University Press, 1970), 56.
 38. Maria Di Battista, "Realism and Rebellion in Edwardian and Georgian Fiction," in *The Cambridge Companion to the Twentieth-Century English*

- Novel*, ed. Robert L. Caserio (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009), 43.
39. Wilson, "Circulating Morals," 67.
 40. Virginia Woolf, *The Letters of Virginia Woolf*, eds. Nigel Nicolson and Joanne Trautmann, vol. 1, 1888–1912 (London: Hogarth Press, 1975), 383.
 41. I discuss this matter in greater detail in "'Tut, Tut': Censorship, Propriety and Obscenity in *The Voyage Out*," in *'The Voyage Out': Centenary Perspectives*, eds. Sarah M. Hall, Mary Ellen Foley, Lindsay Martin and Claire Nicholson (Southport: Virginia Woolf Society of Great Britain, 2015), 57–75.
 42. Woolf, *Essays*, vol. 3, 34.
 43. Virginia Woolf, *A Passionate Apprentice: The Early Journals and "Carlyle's House and Other Sketches"*, ed. Mitchell A. Leaska (London: Pimlico, 2004), 384.
 44. Woolf, "What Is a Novel?" *Essays*, vol. 4, 415.
 45. Woolf, "Character in Fiction," *Essays*, vol. 3, 425.
 46. Virginia Woolf, "Women and Fiction," in *The Essays of Virginia Woolf*, ed. Stuart N. Clarke, vol. 5, 1929–1932 (London: Hogarth Press, 2009), 35.
 47. Virginia Woolf, *A Room of One's Own* (London: Hogarth Press, 1929), 63.
 48. *The Diary of Virginia Woolf*, ed. Anne Olivier Bell, vol. 4, 1931–35 (London: Hogarth Press, 1982), 15–16.
 49. Woolf, *Diary*, vol. 2, 161.
 50. Virginia Woolf, *The Pargiters: The Novel-Essay Portion of The Years*, ed. Mitchell A. Leaska (London: Hogarth Press, 1978), 9.
 51. Virginia Woolf, *Three Guineas*, ed. Naomi Black (Oxford: Blackwell, 2001), 70.
 52. Liesl Olson, *Modernism and the Ordinary* (New York and Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), 84.
 53. Woolf, *A Room of One's Own*, 153.
 54. John Galsworthy, *The Forsyte Saga*, ed. Geoffrey Harvey (1922; Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008), 32. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*FS*).
 55. Tyrus Miller, *Late Modernism: Politics, Fiction, and the Arts between the Wars* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999), 20.
 56. Di Battista, "Realism and Rebellion," 44.

*“A Call and an Answer”:¹ E. M. Forster,
D. H. Lawrence, and English Modernism*

Howard J. Booth

In his 2013 study of Picasso, the leading art historian T. J. Clark explores what disturbs and unsettles about the artist. He recognizes, however, that as well as the modernist “destroyers” (an idea he borrows from Philip Larkin) there was another response: “the destruction had called forth a tremendous, reparative countermovement from within modernism itself: Stevens and Eliot, Proust and Lawrence, late Schoenberg and Bartok, Matisse and Bonnard and Mies van der Rohe.”² My aim here is to look at a specifically English form taken by this “reparative countermovement,” made by one of those Clark names, D. H. Lawrence, and also by E. M. Forster. Believing that modernity had damaged life and social relations, Lawrence and Forster adopted forms that allowed them to explore possible responses.

Both Lawrence and Forster established their careers in the years between 1900 and 1914; indeed only one of Forster’s novels, *A Passage to India*, appeared after this period. The old, teleological model of modernist studies looked in early modernism for what led, in theme and form, to the high modernism of the early 1920s. Stock charges against writing that did not anticipate what came later were that it was attenuated Victorian realism and that it still operated wholly within earlier structures of thought. Peter Brooker has usefully outlined an alternative to the teleological model that instead sees “movements *within* modernism.”³ What these two English writers attempted to locate were ways in which a whole, full life could be achieved in early-twentieth-century conditions. Though I focus on an English form here, the alternative I examine was, as Clark suggests, not unique in the Western world – indeed it can be

seen worldwide, for example in Rabindranath Tagore's response to modernization in Bengal.⁴ Such a project requires concomitant forms and styles, where these had to register the increasing difficulty of the task as modernity became ever more totalizing.

To take such a view of Forster is to differ from David Medalie's thoughtful study of the author. Arguing that modernism should not always be seen as an "exuberant" response to the new, he regards Forster as a "reluctant" modernist. Medalie notes that "revisionary projects" can be said to "lie at the heart of certain versions of modernism, where the rescue efforts, the recasting of traditions, the desperate experimentalism are inseparable from the recognition of what is no longer tenable, the elegies, and the sorrows born of newness."⁵ Though I agree with Medalie in regarding Forster's work as a response to the problems of the time, his language equates modernity with progress, seeing a particular form of change as inevitable. Medalie continues in the critical tradition most associated with Lionel Trilling's classic study of Forster, in that it considers Forster in relation to the liberal tradition.⁶ While acknowledging the influence of liberal thought on Forster, I will suggest here that both Forster and Lawrence can be related to the English radical tradition. Their texts look for alternatives to modernity, often figured in terms of the organic, and a full connection to the surrounding world – a life, in short, beyond alienation.

Peter Stansky's 1996 study of the Bloomsbury group argued that Forster's writing stressed the personal as a reaction to the way the Victorians had allowed public values to determine intimate life, thus taking a different route to Lytton Strachey who, in his *Eminent Victorians*, exposed the resultant contradictions and hypocrisies.⁷ More recent work than Stansky's has established that Bloomsbury's relationship to the Victorian past was highly complex; a point that runs against Virginia Woolf's admittedly playful claim "that on or about December 1910 human character changed."⁸ Indeed, Forster was himself never at the center of the Bloomsbury group, though he shared friendships and a Cambridge intellectual formation with many of its members. Both Forster and Lawrence were drawn to those who questioned the very tenets of the society produced by

industrialization. Forster singled out Wordsworth, Ruskin, and Samuel Butler as the authors who had helped him (a characteristic formulation, stressing the way his reading contributed to his personal development).⁹ He was always unsure whether anything could be done beyond the level of individuals and their relationships. Lawrence's literary formation left him very well read in nineteenth-century English and French literature, and his thought was strongly indebted to critics of the impact of industrialization, in particular Ruskin and Carlyle.¹⁰ Lawrence charted the changes to English lives and subjectivity through the successive generations of the Brangwen family in *The Rainbow*.

Intensifying economic and social change made articulating alternatives harder for Forster and Lawrence, let alone bringing them about. In their early careers both were drawn to write about what it would be like to be defeated by the world, not only at the level of incident or in sections of texts (e.g., the death of the baby in Forster's *Where Angels Fear to Tread*, or the story of Annable in Lawrence's first novel, *The White Peacock*), but in entire novels: Lawrence's second novel, *The Trespasser* and Forster's *The Longest Journey* both have a tragic main plot. By the time Lawrence was by Lake Garda in Italy, writing the final draft of his third, breakthrough novel *Sons and Lovers* in late 1912, he had resolved that writing should not give way to despair, something he saw in the preceding generation of novelists: "I hate England and its hopelessness. I hate [Arnold] Bennett's resignation. Tragedy ought really to be a great kick at misery." Writing to his then mentor Edward Garnett, Lawrence noted that "Conrad, after months of Europe, makes me furious – and the stories are *so* good. But why this giving in before you start, that pervades all Conrad and such folks – the Writers among the Ruins. I can't forgive Conrad for being so sad and for giving in."¹¹

Lawrence did praise H. G. Wells's *Tono-Bungay*, saying "it is a great book."¹² That was, it seems, more for its depiction of the state of the nation, gender relations, and the growth of consumer capitalism, because again he finds no proposed response: "it makes me so sad. . . . He is a terrible pessimist." What Wells lacks for Lawrence is

“the subtle soul of sympathy of a true artist. He rigidly scorns all mysticism.”¹³ For both Forster and Lawrence there was something beyond the surface of events, a religious sense indeed, that everyday language did not reach, but that art might. Forster, in his short story “The Machine Stops,” drew on Wells’s science fiction to attack the way he equated scientific discovery and machines with social progress. Forster noted in 1921 that “Wells has no sense of mysticism or of poetry.”¹⁴ Forster and Lawrence used the symbolism associated with aestheticism and decadence to delve beyond the surface world. In perhaps the most important literary debate in early modernism, Wells maintained that the novel should have a direct and explicit purpose while Henry James pointed out that there is no world of action outside of language and culture.¹⁵ Forster and Lawrence would have regarded Wells’s position as inadequate and crude, while rejecting any inward-looking focus on art and the process of artistic creation.

A shift away from the tragic toward proposing alternatives is evident in the fiction of both Forster and Lawrence. Forster’s *The Longest Journey* sees the tragic fate of its main character, Rickie Elliot, counterpoised by the very different trajectory of Stephen Wonham, the man he discovers is his half-brother. Parallels between Rickie and Stephen are underscored by linking them to the doubles found in Greek drama and Wagner’s operas. Many of the things associated with Rickie were also important to Forster, among them Cambridge and writing, and Rickie’s disability is described using the same discourses around degeneration found in contemporary accounts of homosexuality.¹⁶ Forster recognizes how much someone like Rickie would have to change to be like Stephen, with his very different way of relating to people and his closeness to nature (he takes his young daughter out to sleep under the stars at the end of the novel). Reconnecting with nature offered a way beyond modern constraint for both writers. Examples include the scene in Forster’s *A Room with a View* in which Lucy Honeychurch comes across George Emerson, her brother, and Mr. Beebe bathing in “The Sacred Lake.” As a result she starts to perceive that she must attend to what her body and feelings are saying, rather than the conventional

assumptions inculcated by her upbringing; she breaks with her fiancée, Cecil Vyse, in favor of George.¹⁷ In Lawrence's short novel *The Virgin and the Gipsy*, the flood both brings the lovers together and sweeps to her death the grandmother who has dominated and harmed her family.

There was, however, a keen awareness of the difficulties and challenges in bringing about change. Throughout *The Longest Journey*, Forster's favorite among his novels,¹⁸ Rickie idealizes those around him, failing to see the more mixed reality. Rickie turns Agnes and Gerald embracing into the very image of human love. Gerald, now in the army, had bullied Rickie when they were at school. Feeling that the danger of passing on his disability prevents him from marrying and having a child himself, Rickie offers Gerald a hundred pounds toward his marriage, something that both Gerald and Agnes feel to be highly inappropriate. The chapter ends:

She stopped laughing. "Oh, little beast, if he said all that!"

He was encouraged to proceed. Hitherto he had not talked about their schooldays. Now he told her everything – the "barley-sugar," as he called it, the pins in chapel, and how one afternoon he had tied him head downward onto a tree-trunk and then run away – of course only for the moment.

For this she scolded him well. But she had a thrill of joy when she thought of the weak boy in the clutches of the strong one. (*LJ* 50)

The next chapter begins: "Gerald died that afternoon" (*LJ* 51). We find out soon after that he has had an accident playing rugby. There is an obvious irony here – Rickie lives on, while the fit and strong soldier dies – which forms part of the way the novel probes what constitutes strength, weakness, and disability. The response to Rickie's generous, if misguided and socially inept, offer reveals that Gerald and Agnes are not worthy of his respect. Gerald's account of how he bullied Rickie at school shocks Agnes, but she takes a vicarious, sadistic pleasure in his account. Readers may well find themselves caught up in a similar response, feeling that Gerald's death is his comeuppance, only to reflect that it is a somewhat extreme punishment. Forster's shifting style does not let the reader settle as it returns on itself, qualifying and even undermining what has just been said.

The scene at the Cadbury Rings offers the possibility that nature can interrupt and unsettle the human world. It is there that Mrs. Failing reveals that Rickie and Stephen are half-brothers. A view of nature as unsettling rather than straightforwardly healing is found elsewhere in Forster, most importantly in his early “The Story of a Panic.” (The short story can be read as showing how nature, figured as an eruption of Pan, can disturb conventional society, transforming Eustace and allowing him to escape society’s clutches; it does, though, leave the young Italian boy, Gennaro, dead.¹⁹) For all the building of the set piece and symbolic scene as the main characters take their day trip to the Cadbury Rings, what happens there may not be down to the influence of place at all. Mrs. Failing is made irritable by the journey and the close proximity of her guests; she likes to say things that upset (*LJ* 128–30).²⁰ Rickie experiences shock because of his conventional response to Stephen and the impact on his feelings about his parents; he initially assumes his father to be their shared parent, even though Stephen does not have the disability said to be transmitted down the patrilineal line. Nature is neither predictable nor benign, and it is hard to interpret.

The reader finds that all is not what it seems, either in terms of narrative content or of form and style. Lawrence’s short novel *St Mawr*, written in New Mexico in the summer of 1924, pushes this to an extreme. It leads the reader to expect the novel to develop in one way only for it to take another direction entirely. The red horse *St Mawr* is wild, only appearing to be broken in, and throws Rico, who represents modern masculinity. There are various possible explanations as to why *St Mawr* rears – because of the “spirit of place,” in Lawrence’s terms, of the Devil’s Chair, a tor on Stiperstones ridge in Shropshire, “where the spirit of aboriginal England still lingers,” the effect of a snatch of a popular song (representing the degraded state of modern culture), or perhaps because the horse catches sight of a dead snake.²¹ However, the text’s narrative structure undercuts any sense of a clear message or resolution. These events occur not near the end of the text but less than halfway through. The main characters, the Witts, and *St Mawr* go to America, where the horse is soon peripheral. The closing pages

introduce a new character, a previous owner of Lou Witt's ranch in New Mexico. In one further dislocation between character and place, the unnamed New England woman is unable to impose herself on her new location.

The narrative structure of *St Mawr* may well not have been planned in advance. In line with Lawrence's stress on the spontaneity of the creative process, the narrative probably assumed its form as he wrote. Writing a novel has exploratory and developmental potential for the writer – with a concomitant experience for the reader of a successful work – but this will only be realized if the writer gives her or himself to the writing process in the present; it is not possible to stand back and plan an ensemble of literary effects. The narrator of *Lady Chatterley's Lover* maintains this view: "And here lies the vast importance of the novel, properly handled. It can inform and lead into new places the flow of our sympathetic consciousness, and it can lead our sympathy away in recoil from things gone dead."²² Lawrence often held that modern novels recoiled from their true material. At the start of his career, reviewing *Death in Venice*, he saw Thomas Mann as the "last sick sufferer from the complaint of Flaubert. The latter stood away from life as from a leprosy." Lawrence praises the potential of the unexpected over "carefully plotted and arranged developments."²³ In his essays on the novel from the mid-1920s, the works of Marcel Proust, Dorothy Richardson, and James Joyce are seen as the products of modern self-consciousness; for Lawrence, much of modern art replicates rather than challenges the "democratic-industrial-lovey-dovey-darling-take-me-to-mammy state of things."²⁴ Forster's writings on art are more conventional, perhaps because he believed criticism to be wholly different from artistic creation; however, he too emphasizes the process by which the order of a work of art emerges from within, the importance of repetition and variation and, in Gary Day's phrase, "the depredations of commercialism."²⁵

Women in Love considers many artists and works of modernist art in its depiction of two couples, Ursula and Birkin, and Gudrun and Gerald (a plot structure of comparisons that Lawrence borrowed from George Eliot).²⁶ As the novel developed, Lawrence

drew on Katherine Mansfield for the character of Gudrun, the latter's small sculptures standing as the equivalent of Mansfield's short stories. The sculptures are used to suggest that Gudrun is limited and bounded, unable to see herself in a larger context.²⁷ After her relationship with Gerald fails, she feels that she has been left staring into a huge clock face, alive, but trapped in a death-in-life.²⁸ The main artist figure in the novel is Loerke, who espouses different views to Lawrence's: an argument with Ursula establishes that he believes art should take on forms appropriate to industrialism and that he thinks art and its creator are quite separate, even though his own sexuality and relationships are shown to inform his art (*WL* 423–34).²⁹ In addition to portraying creative artists, the novel also explores responses to culture, including the “primitive” artworks in the “Fetish” chapter, and the role of artist sets or cliques. Birkin and Ursula, their response to the world sharpened by their engagements with art, maximize their chances of renewal and of a transformed future.

The novels of both authors often evaluate potentially transformative engagements, either with another person or a different culture. It is this stress on individual change that aligns them most strongly with the English radical tradition. The claim for such a tradition is particularly associated with the formation, after the Second World War, of the Communist Party Historians' Group and the rise to prominence of historians such as Christopher Hill and E. P. Thompson; it also informs the work of Raymond Williams. Going back beyond Carlyle and Ruskin, before even Blake, the broad contours of the argument run, one can point to interlinked religious and political dissent in the seventeenth century. The Protestant belief in a personal relationship to God informed a radical politics that began at the level of the individual, of personal relationships and the community, rather than at the level of a new model imposed from above by the state.³⁰

In the generation that preceded Forster and Lawrence, Edward Carpenter was a lynchpin figure, one who believed transformed sexual relationships provided a route to reconnection and wholeness.³¹ Forster and Lawrence responded to Carpenter

differently. Emile Delavenay has claimed that Carpenter greatly influenced Lawrence.³² The Cambridge University Press edition of Lawrence's work and letters does not support this claim, though we do find limited evidence that Lawrence responded negatively to Carpenter's homosexuality.³³ It is clear that Forster deeply admired Carpenter and that he was a significant influence, especially in the year after they first met in September 1913. While visiting Carpenter and his partner, George Merrill, Forster records that Merrill "touched my backside – gently and just above the buttocks. I believe he touched most people's." Forster claimed that, at the time, a "creative spring" was opened in him: "it seemed to go straight through the small of my back into my ideas, without involving my thoughts." The result was *Maurice*.³⁴ It seems that negative comments by Lawrence about Carpenter played a role in souring the visit Forster made to the Lawrences at Greatham in 1915. Forster wrote in his Locked Diary later that year, "[a]fter Lawrence's remarks about Carpenter realise with regret that I cannot know him."³⁵ However, only seeking evidence of contact between individuals and direct influence is limiting; the wider radical culture that informed English modernism was important, something that can be seen in journals such as the *Freewoman* and the *New Age*.³⁶

Forster's exploration of the transformative potential of personal relationships reached its furthest development in *Howards End*, with the novel's epigram – "Only connect . . ." – amplified in the message Margaret has for Mr. Wilcox:

Only connect! That was the whole of her sermon. Only connect the prose and the passion, and both will be exalted, and human love will be seen at its highest. Live in fragments no longer. Only connect, and the beast and the monk, robbed of the isolation that is life to either, will die.³⁷

A condition-of-England novel, *Howards End* is an attempt to reconnect the filaments of a disparate, fragmented society: the commercial Willcoxes, the cultured Schlegels, with their private income, and the clerk Leonard Bast and his wife, Jacky, represent different class positions. By the time of the novel's remarkable closing pages, the

broken Henry Wilcox is married to Margaret Schlegel, with her sister Helen bringing up the child she has had with Leonard. The novel thus offers what is possible by way of reparation. *Howards End* will go to Margaret and then her nephew, while the continuity and bounty of nature is reasserted in the final phrase, when Helen celebrates “such a crop of hay as never!” However, the colloquial shortening of “as there never was” to “as never,” so that the novel ends with word “never,” undercuts the sense of a positive resolution (HE 340). There is also an awareness that “London’s creeping,” where the encroaching city is part of “something else . . . Life’s going to be melted down, all over the world” (HE 337). And for all the championing of nontraditional family structures, and of “differences” over “sameness” (HE 336), there are significant absences, particularly among those lower down the social scale, in the new familial groupings situated at the novel’s end; Leonard is all but forgotten and his wife goes unmentioned.

In Forster’s *Maurice* (published posthumously in 1971 but first written 1913–14) and Lawrence’s *Lady Chatterley’s Lover* (1928), the authors explore how sexual relationships can aid personal development and bridge wider social divisions. A striking similarity – it is very unlikely that Lawrence had read Forster manuscript³⁸ – is that both texts involve a cross-class relationship involving a gamekeeper. However, there are also significant differences, not least that Forster depicted a homosexual relationship. *Maurice* is also a coming-of-age story that follows the main character’s discovery of his sexuality, and a failed relationship with Clive Durham, before he meets Alec Scudder. The novel tries to work against the template for relationships laid down by cultural precedents for same-sex relationships; Forster hopes to see lovers that “created untrammelled,”³⁹ but he is forced to recognize that these same precedents provide the main positive language available. Maurice becomes increasingly adept at identifying the cultural examples that aid his growth and development.⁴⁰ The novel’s status as one of the first major English texts to depict male homosexual relationships has overshadowed the way it explores personal experiences in relation to broader social fissures. It brings together Maurice – who had a middle-class

suburban upbringing, was public school and Cambridge educated, and employed in the City of London – and Alec, whose father is a tradesman and who, as a gamekeeper, is associated with nature and other ordinary people of rural England. To call it reconciliation though would mislead; to live together they have to leave the world they know. The novel is not a Bildungsroman for the same reason: Maurice and Alec find no accommodation with society as they mature.⁴¹

Lawrence's final novel *Lady Chatterley's Lover* was spurred by what he saw on his last trip to England in the autumn of 1926, toward the end of the miners' strike that followed on from the General Strike of that May. The first draft was very much a direct response to political crisis. All three versions depict the relationship between a woman married to a baronet and a man born into the industrial working class – so *not* the long-established trope of the master and female servant – and suggest a healing of the social fabric and adoption of a very different attitude to work and life. The increased stress on sex in the third and final version is not, as it might appear, a move away from the initial political impetus for the text, but rather the final form of the response to the crisis. New forms of relationship might provide the basis for a radically different society. Connie is pregnant at the end of *Lady Chatterley's Lover*. It is the most hopeful ending of any Lawrence novel, even though the lovers are apart. Presenting the lovers' letters to one another seems to return the novel to its epistolary form; perhaps for Lawrence the epistolary novel was the product of a more organic society than modern England.

In addition to the engagement with other people, both Forster and Lawrence explored how encountering other races, religions, and places could bring about change. They saw Italy as breaking down and recomposing the north European. For example, Lucy Honeychurch's extended period of time in Florence in *A Room with a View* not only enables her to meet the unconventional George Emerson and his father – they would not move in the same circles back home – but also starts her on a path toward attending to her feelings. The concern with otherness can be seen in terms of the primitivism found in the modernist period, the belief

that other peoples and places had cultural forms and vitality that had been lost in the West. A commitment to the West's inherent superiority was nevertheless retained, as much work from the 1970s on pointed out. More recently, though, critics have noted that the form and politics of primitivism is complex and takes varied forms.⁴² Many radicals in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries maintained that other parts of the world retained ways of living that were being lost in the West; an example would be Edward Carpenter's *From Adam's Peak to Elephanta* of 1892.⁴³ There was also the belief that such a better form of life had existed in the past, in earlier civilizations. Forster spent time in Egypt during the First World War, but his most sustained engagement with another part of the world came in his two periods, either side of the conflict, in India. After much work, and much dissatisfaction, he published his final novel, *A Passage to India*, in 1924. Colonialist assumptions about India, its people, and religions are recirculated in the novel, but, as Benita Parry points out, those who see it as formally conventional fail to see its modernism: it "undermines imperial grandiloquence," "offers a disenchanting perspective on empire," "registers a dispersed consciousness," reflects "ironically and critically on its own project," and knowingly exemplifies a wider "waning of narrative power."⁴⁴ Personal relationships, and the attempted rapprochement between colonizer and colonized, do not hold in the context of the alleged sexual assault in Marabar Caves. Unlike *Maurice*, which sees Maurice and Alec establish a relationship, a successful connection between Fielding and Aziz is not established in *A Passage to India*. However, the novel's final words – the voices of India saying "No, not yet" and the sky "No, not there" – suggest that the wider project of cross-cultural connection is deferred rather than abandoned forever.⁴⁵

Lawrence's shift toward engaging with otherness began in 1917, as he completed *Women in Love*. With his departure from Europe in 1922, it became his main preoccupation, until he settled back in Europe in 1925.⁴⁶ The major text here is the Mexican novel *The Plumed Serpent* (1926).⁴⁷ For a while, Forster thought it was Lawrence's best novel.⁴⁸ *The Plumed Serpent* imagines how the ancient Mexican religion could be reborn and Mexico revived. It

has often been condemned for the form that this imagined society takes, which for some readers is a projection of Lawrence's own cultural preoccupations and attitudes to gender onto other races and cultures. There is much force in these critiques, but it is important to register the extraordinary reach of what Lawrence attempted. The problems with European impositions on other cultures are so fundamental that the West itself needs to be displaced. Christianity has colluded with the spread of Western greed and materialism and has to give way to a specifically Mexican form of religion. After Lawrence went back to Europe, he returned to addressing relationships and wrote *Lady Chatterley's Lover*, but the idea that there were models elsewhere for a better life never left him. Now, though, these were often located in the past. For example, his late short novel, *The Escaped Cock*, retells the Christian story, imagining that Jesus had not died, but had experienced instead a bodily return to strength and sexual vitality.

Forster and Lawrence were never close, and there were differences between them, with Forster more focused on individual change. However, there was great mutual respect. Responding to *A Passage to India* in a letter to Forster, Lawrence wrote that "there's not a soul in England says a word to me – save your whisper through the willow boughs."⁴⁹ Forster defended Lawrence against the negative tone of many of the obituaries calling him "the greatest imaginative novelist of our generation."⁵⁰ Their English form of modernism is different from those, like Lawrence's sometime mentors Ford Madox Hueffer (later Ford) and Edward Garnett, who stressed the need to follow the precedents set by French writing and in particular Flaubert. Careful construction and received notions of "good style" were not the main concern of Forster and Lawrence. They rejected the path of the "destroyers" like Picasso (to return to T. J. Clark), or a retreat into the compensatory structures of art, in favor of forms and styles forged for the pressing task of repairing modern damage. Seeing Forster and Lawrence as writing against modernity, trying to imagine alternatives and how they might be effected, helps us discern why their fiction – in its plot, form, and language – was at once so questing and so provisional.

Notes

1. A phrase that was often used by Lawrence. See, for example, D. H. Lawrence, *Quetzalcoatl*, ed. N. H. Reeve (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), 26, 207.
2. T. J. Clark, *Picasso and Truth: From Cubism to Guernica* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2013), 4.
3. Peter Brooker, "Early Modernism," in *The Cambridge Companion to the Modernist Novel*, ed. Morag Shiach (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 32–47: 33.
4. Amit Chaudhuri compares Tagore to Whitman and Lawrence in his *On Tagore* (New Delhi: Penguin, 2012), 165.
5. David Medalie, *E. M. Forster's Modernism* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2002), 1.
6. Lionel Trilling, *E. M. Forster* (1943; New York: New Directions, 1964).
7. Peter Stansky, *On or About December 1910: Early Bloomsbury and Its Intimate World* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1996), 125. For a more advanced consideration of Forster, Cambridge, and Bloomsbury, see Joseph Bristow, "Fratrum Societati: Forster's Apostolic Dedications," in *Queer Forster*, eds. Robert K. Martin and George Piggford (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1997), 113–36, and, on Bloomsbury and liberalism, David Medalie, "Bloomsbury and Other Values," in *The Cambridge Companion to E. M. Forster*, ed. David Bradshaw (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 32–46.
8. See Steve Ellis, *Virginia Woolf and the Victorians* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007). Virginia Woolf, *Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown* (London: Hogarth Press, 1924), 4.
9. E. M. Forster, "A. E. Housman," in *The Creator as Critic and Other Writings by E. M. Forster*, ed. Jeffrey M. Heath (Toronto: Dundurn, 2008), 124–30: 126.
10. John Worthen, *D. H. Lawrence: The Early Years* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1991), 121–2. Raymond Williams perceived the impact of Carlyle on Lawrence in *Culture and Society, 1780–1950* (1958; London: Chatto & Windus, 1967), 199–202. See also Paul Delany, "Lawrence and Carlyle," in *D. H. Lawrence and Tradition*, ed. Jeffrey Meyers (London: Athlone, 1985), 21–34; George P. Landow, "Lawrence and Ruskin: The Sage as Word-Painter," in *D. H. Lawrence and Tradition*, 35–50; and the discussion of *The Rainbow* and gothic in Tony Pinkney, *D. H. Lawrence* (Hemel Hempstead: Harvester, 1990), 54–79.
11. D. H. Lawrence, *The Letters of D. H. Lawrence*, vol. 1, 1901–1913, ed. James T. Boulton (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1979), 459, 465.

12. *Ibid.*, 127.
13. *Ibid.*, 119.
14. E. M. Forster, "English Literature Since the War," in *The Creator as Critic*, 50–61: 59.
15. Responding to the view that art is "for use" in a July 1915 letter to Wells, James wrote that "[i]t is art that *makes* life, makes interest, makes importance, for our consideration and application of these things, and I know of no substitute whatever for the force and beauty of its process" (Leon Edel and Gordon N. Ray, eds., *Henry James and H. G. Wells: A Record of Their Friendship, Their Debate on the Art of Fiction, and Their Quarrel* [London: Rupert Hart-Davis, 1958], 267).
16. See Elizabeth Heine's introduction to her edition of E. M. Forster's, *The Longest Journey* (London: Edward Arnold, 1984), xviii–xxvi.
17. E. M. Forster, *A Room with a View*, ed. Oliver Stallybrass (London: Edward Arnold, 1978), 126, 143–52.
18. E. M. Forster, "Author's Introduction," in *The Longest Journey* (London: Edward Arnold, 1984), lxvi. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*LJ*).
19. Forster said that he did not know Arthur Machen's work early in his career, but that he recognized the similarity of his plot to that often used by the Machen. For example, Machen wrote about the past of a place influencing, and indeed overwhelming, people in the present in "The Great God Pan" and *The Hill of Dreams*. See E. M. Forster, "Some Books: Machen, Graves, and Others," in *The Creator as Critic*, 267–70: 267–8.
20. Forster noted in 1947 that *The Longest Journey* "does indeed depend from an encounter with the genius loci, but indirectly, complicatedly" (Introduction to *Collected Short Stories* [1947; London: Penguin, 1954], 6).
21. D. H. Lawrence, *St Mawr and Other Stories*, ed. Brian Finney (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983), 73, 75–8.
22. D. H. Lawrence, *Lady Chatterley's Lover*, ed. Michael Squires (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993), 101.
23. D. H. Lawrence, "German Books," review of *Der Tod in Venedig* [*Death in Venice*], in *Introductions and Reviews*, eds. N. H. Reeve and John Worthen (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005), 207–12: 211, 212.
24. D. H. Lawrence, "The Future of the Novel," in *Study of Thomas Hardy and Other Essays*, ed. Bruce Steele (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1985), 151–5: 154.
25. See Gary Day, "Forster as Literary Critic," in *The Cambridge Companion to E. M. Forster*, 223–34: 226. Day is responding to Forster's *Aspects of the Novel* (London: Edward Arnold, 1927), for his remarks on commercialism.

26. Jessie Chambers, *D. H. Lawrence: A Personal Record* (1935; Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1980), 103; and H. M. Daleski, "Lawrence and George Eliot: The Genesis of *The White Peacock*," in *D. H. Lawrence and Tradition*, 51–68.
27. See Mark Kinkead-Weekes, *D. H. Lawrence: Triumph to Exile, 1912–1922* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 330, 337.
28. D. H. Lawrence, *Women in Love*, eds. David Farmer, Lindeth Vasey, and John Worthen (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987), 464–6. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*WL*).
29. For Loerke's art, Lawrence draws on real works, including, for his large frieze, Mark Gertler's *Merry-Go-Round*, and, for his statuette, Joseph Moest's *Godiva*. See Kinkead-Weekes, *D. H. Lawrence: Triumph to Exile*, 343, and J. B. Bullen "Loerke's Statuette," in *Women in Love: A Casebook*, ed. David Ellis (New York: Oxford University Press, 2006), 273–8.
30. Some have questioned the evidence for a continuous radical tradition; the main alternative possibility is that similar arguments emerged independently at different times. The field is surveyed in Glenn Burgess, "Introduction," *English Radicalism, 1550–1850*, eds. Glenn Burgess and Matthew Festenstein (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 1–16.
31. The major study of Carpenter is Sheila Rowbotham, *Edward Carpenter: A Life of Liberty and Love* (London: Verso, 2008).
32. Emile Delavenay, *D. H. Lawrence and Edward Carpenter: A Study in Edwardian Transition* (London: Heinemann, 1971).
33. See Howard J. Booth, "D. H. Lawrence and Male Homosexual Desire," *The Review of English Studies* 53 (2002): 911–11.
34. E. M. Forster, "Notes on *Maurice*," in *Maurice*, ed. Philip Gardner (London: André Deutsch, 1999), 215–20: 215.
35. E. M. Forster, *The Journals and Diaries of E. M. Forster*, vol. 2, ed. Philip Gardner (London: Pickering & Chatto, 2011), 56.
36. See Anne Fernihough, *Freewomen and Supermen: Edwardian Radicals and Literary Modernism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013).
37. E. M. Forster, *Howards End*, ed. Oliver Stallybrass (London: Edward Arnold, 1973), 183–4. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*HE*).
38. Dixie King's claims, in "The Influence of Forster's *Maurice* on *Lady Chatterley's Lover*," *Contemporary Literature* 23:1 (Winter 1982): 65–82, have not been sustained. Forster and Lawrence were not that close, and Forster took care that only those sympathetic to homosexuality saw the text, later saying that all his gamekeepers and those of Lawrence would share is a "mug of beer" (Forster, *Maurice*, 218).

39. Forster, *Maurice*, 75.
40. Howard J. Booth, "Maurice," in *The Cambridge Companion to E. M. Forster*, 173–87.
41. Indeed the earliest surviving version, from 1913–14, has an epilogue in which Maurice's sister Kitty, years later, comes across Maurice and Alec working away from society as woodsmen (see Forster, *Maurice*, 221–4).
42. For an early example of this shift in approaches to primitivism, see *Prehistories of the Future: The Primitivist Project and the Culture of Modernism*, eds. Elazar Barkan and Ronald Bush (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1995).
43. See Parminder Kaur Bakshi, "Homosexuality and Orientalism: Edward Carpenter's Journey to the East," *Prose Studies: History, Theory, Criticism* 13 (May 1990): 151–77.
44. Benita Parry, "Materiality and Mystification in *A Passage to India*," in *Postcolonial Studies: A Materialist Critique* (London: Routledge, 2004), 162.
45. E. M. Forster, *A Passage to India*, ed. Oliver Stallybrass (London: Edward Arnold, 1978), 312.
46. See Mark Kinkead-Weekes, "The Genesis of Lawrence's Psychology 162–75: Books: An Overview," *D. H. Lawrence Review* 27, nos. 2–3 (1997/98): 153–70.
47. An earlier draft written in the summer of 1923 was first published in 1995 as *Quetzalcoatl*.
48. E. M. Forster, "D. H. Lawrence," in *The Creator as Critic*, 222–6: 223.
49. D. H. Lawrence, *The Letters of D. H. Lawrence*, vol. 5, 1924–1927, eds. James T. Boulton and Lindeth Vasey (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989), 77.
50. E. M. Forster, Letter to the Editor, *Nation and Athenaeum* 46:4 (29 March 1930): 888.

American Literary Realism: Popularity and Politics in a Modernist Frame

Janet G. Casey

By 1922, when *The Waste Land* and *Ulysses* were in circulation and avant-garde experimentalism was in vogue, realism seemed out-moded indeed. As Michael North has observed, “younger male [modernists]” such as T. S. Eliot and James Joyce expressed “massive condescension” toward, for instance, realist writer Willa Cather, who nonetheless was at the height of her popularity in 1922, when she won the Pulitzer Prize for *One of Ours*.¹ Subsequent versions of literary modernism have, of course, restored Cather’s luster, but her case recalls to us the inferior status generally accorded to realism by literary elites in the early twentieth century, a status that nonetheless failed to thwart the significance and influence of realism as a literary mode.

To be sure, Cather’s realism can only be understood as “backward” (her word) from a perspective that takes for granted high modernism’s cultural hegemony – a stance that seems odd in retrospect, and that requires the diminishment or even erasure of large numbers of modernist texts.² An alternative and more inclusive perspective would frame realism as a kind of undercurrent – more accurately, perhaps, a persistent *overcurrent* – that unites superficially disparate schools of modernist fiction, especially on the American scene. In particular, the modern middlebrow novel, the novels of the Harlem Renaissance, and Depression-era social realism are all connected stylistically, if not thematically, through their substantial reliance on realism as an expressive mode. Ironically, even high modernism can be conceptualized as part of this trajectory if we understand the experimental impulse to be motivated by a search for a more precise means of representation – a rendering of

perceptions in all of their complexity, an abandonment of the schema that previously regulated (and hence stylized and falsified) expressions of the human experience.

Nonliterary aspects of American life also revealed this investment in perceived veracity. Indeed, the significance of the *real* as a cogent category in the mainstream culture of the early twentieth century is understudied, especially as a means of contextualizing the aesthetics of the modernist novel. From the back-to-the-land movement to eugenics and nativism to advertising's reliance on "expert" testimony, Americans seemed increasingly preoccupied with, and persuaded by, articulations of genuineness, authenticity, "purity," and first-hand experience. Often such ideals were framed in opposition to the supposed ills of urban industrialism, deemed artificial, manufactured, or overly mediated. One key site for perceiving the tensions between these constructed oppositions is the commercial magazine (e.g., *Saturday Evening Post*, *Ladies' Home Journal*), which enjoyed immense popularity in the years between 1890 and 1940 and which often seemed eager to distinguish the *real* from the not-so-real in such varied arenas as narrative ("real-life" stories versus fiction), advertising ("natural" vs. synthetic consumer goods), and visual imagery (the "objective" mode of photography vs. more traditional types of illustration). While beyond the scope of this chapter, the emerging emphasis on various conceptions of the *real* in the early twentieth century deserves mention as a historical backdrop that helps to position literary realism as part of a prevailing cultural concern with validating the bona fide as distinct from the counterfeit, the imitative, or the overly embellished.

In accordance with this cultural preoccupation, and despite sophisticated literary-critical acknowledgments that realism as a genre is, of course, not a mirroring of reality but a set of rhetorical conventions, there were widespread assumptions that it was somehow less affected, and hence less alienated from actual experience, than elite modernisms. (Writing for the *Colored American Magazine* in 1916, Katherine Williams excoriated "'literary gem[s]'" that "suit the high-brows," and vowed to use "plain, commonsense language, so that the masses may read and understand."³) Standard definitions

of literary realism stress such notions as plausibility and verisimilitude, and its common techniques include the use of “natural” vernacular and close attention to physical detail; it also posits the quotidian as worthy of extended consideration. Hence despite its conventions, literary realism avoids aspects of expression or plot, including those typical of high modernism or sensationalism, that may be perceived as heightened, extreme, or excessively convoluted – that is, not “true” to actual life.

Further contributing to the accepted sense of literary realism as reflecting a *real* world was its typical subject matter. The classic nineteenth-century realism of William Dean Howells was closely identified with the bourgeois experience that was his theme; that particular relationship between form and substance persisted well into the twentieth century and helped to consolidate realism’s conceptual alignment with the actual. In short, realism framed middle-class experience as normative, thereby enabling its broad acceptance and appropriation by a large body of similarly positioned readers (and writers) that was expanding rapidly. Relatively unconcerned with the poles of poverty and wealth, literary realism aligned itself with the middle-class ethos that was both reflected and enabled by numerous other cultural discourses – about consumption, health, education, labor – that posited a comfortable bourgeois lifestyle as the aspiration of all Americans. Rural historian Katherine Jellison, for instance, has demonstrated that agricultural reform movements, concerned about rural out-migration, endeavored to frame farm life as compatible with urban middle-class patterns of buying, dressing, decorating, and raising children.⁴ And no less a personage than Theodore Roosevelt, preoccupied with the propagation of solid American “stock,” suggested that working Americans, those who reject “a life of slothful ease,” have a special responsibility to build the nation through productive and reproductive labor.⁵ By similarly validating what was perceived as “regular” mainstream American life, then, realism managed to align itself with the real, despite its carefully organized plotlines and reliance on accepted narrative patterns.

This perceived realness in both style and subject enabled literary realism to function as a powerful vehicle of social critique, and is a

useful way to understand its continuing status throughout the modernist period. It distinguished itself sharply from high modernist experimentalism on the one hand and formulaic genre fiction (e.g., crime, fantasy, horror, romance) on the other: both of these modes privileged stylistic and formal elements, potentially occluding any social critique they attempted to embody. In contrast, literary realism not only foregrounds, but leverages, serious social critique – partly because its accessible style plainly reveals it, and partly because it presents “typical” social problems as its very subject. Writing in a realist mode can thus be understood as a political maneuver as well as an aesthetic choice, and makes a great deal of sense for writers concerned with social issues who wish to reach a large, thoughtful audience. As it turns out, there were many such writers in the early decades of the twentieth century; while their political and social stripes differed, they shared a desire to nudge readers in particular directions and engage them toward particular ends.⁶

Within this context, literary realism in the modernist period emerges not as a weak aesthetic strategy – a default mode for those incapable of avant-garde extremes – but as a powerful expressive tool, given its capacity to illustrate the very behavior it seeks to elicit in the social world. Of course, it can also expose behavior that seems unwise, unjust, or simply untenable. Whether or not it accurately portrays “reality,” then, becomes something of a moot point in light of the belief that it can have genuine socio-political effects in the world outside the text. This is precisely what unites the American middlebrow novel, African-American fiction, especially of the Harlem Renaissance, and Depression-era social realism: a faith in the power of fiction to shape the minds of readers and possibly affect their behaviors. To be sure, this faith may have contributed indirectly to the marginalization of the realist novel: as Barbara Christian and others have argued, the academy tends to disavow the efficacy of the text just when marginal perspectives threaten to achieve a compelling literary presence.⁷ As middle-class readers, African Americans, and Leftists gained traction in American culture, it may have followed that realism, their avowed vehicle of fictional

expression, would be disparaged by an academic establishment eager to distinguish itself as deeply and complexly intellectual. But this hardly means that literary realism, arguably the primary mode of the period, was squelched; on the contrary, it thrived, and an intricate cultural machinery emerged to market, evaluate, and disseminate it.

In many ways the modern middlebrow novel, distinguished by its seriousness from the merely popular realm of genre fiction, offers the clearest and most substantive example of these dynamics. Realist in mode with relatively modest stylistic aspirations – “offering narrative excitement without guilt, and intellectual stimulation without undue effort,” as one recent critic puts it⁸ – the middlebrow novel was, in name and thematics, closely aligned with the middle class. It was often the open target of high critical culture, which mocked its alleged pretensions and dismissed its audience as intellectual lightweights. (In 1925 critic Waldo Frank, for instance, declared middlebrow texts a form of “Pseudo-Literature,” and Dwight MacDonald, commenting retrospectively in the 1950s, famously described them in the aggregate as “a tepid ooze.”⁹) Such acclaimed and widely read realist novels as Booth Tarkington’s *The Magnificent Ambersons* (1918); Dorothy Canfield Fisher’s *The Home-Maker* (1924); Ellen Glasgow’s *Barren Ground* (1925); and Louis Bromfield’s *Early Autumn* (1926) and *The Farm* (1933) were considered by literary elites to be noteworthy, perhaps, but certainly not in the same arena as what we might now call “academic” literature. Some critics specifically indicted such texts and their readers as tame and shallow, which, as Gordon Hutner points out, “lazily mystifies class-based values in the name of intellectual distinction.”¹⁰ The 1940s-era New Criticism further implied that a literature that fails to give rise to its own specialized vocabulary, or that precludes the need for teachers to explicate it, can hardly be worthy of serious consideration.

Yet middlebrow realists saw themselves as accomplished artists undertaking genuine cultural critique that could have far-reaching social implications. Pearl Buck, author of the best-selling realist novel *The Good Earth* (1931), learned from the Chinese culture in which she was raised that literature could be “dangerous, powerful,

transformative” for the masses.¹¹ Realists such as Upton Sinclair (*The Jungle* [1909]) and Zona Gale (*Heart’s Kindred* [1915]; *Peace in Friendship Village* [1919]) had strong political ties and were activists on various fronts; their fiction reveals these associations.¹² An excellent exemplar of this expressed dedication to combining (realist) accessibility and a zeal for social critique is Edna Ferber, whose best-selling novels (e.g., *Show Boat* [1926], *Cimarron* [1930], *Saratoga Trunk* [1941]) gained an even wider audience through Broadway and cinema adaptations. Her blockbuster hit *So Big* (1924), for example, tackled such topics as elitism, ethnic prejudice, shifting gender roles, and the shrinking of the landscape due to creeping industrialism – all while satisfying readers’ appetites for energetic characterization and sweeping historical epic. In a 1926 essay in *Bookman*, critic Grant Overton declared Ferber “the keenest social critic among our fiction writers” and intimated that her target was indeed the middle class, as her works display “contempt for correctly patterned existences.” Significantly, Overton championed Ferber’s realist style, arguing that her “gusto” and her “power to delight the faculty of recognition” happily distinguished her work from “fine writing, pure literature, belle lettres, and other disguises.”¹³ Nonetheless, Ferber grew to lament her eventual reputation as merely a “go-getting best seller and a deft writer of romantic and colorful American novels” and was driven to insist that she “never [had] written with an eye to what is called the public or the market or the trend or the editor or the reviewer”¹⁴; such comments highlight the implications of writing in a realist mode, the accessibility of which could be read as an aesthetic concession, a capitulation to the marketplace.

That Ferber’s *So Big* won the Pulitzer Prize is important, as the nascent literary prize culture was part of a critical apparatus that developed in tandem with middlebrow cultural dominance. That is, middle-class writers and readers were commanding a rapidly increasing share of the literary market, and a considerable book-selling industry arose to support them. Literary prizes, like bestseller lists and even the book review system, evolved substantially in the modernist period and became meaningful arbiters of taste among average readers. One of the most influential of these agents was the

Book of the Month Club, established in 1926 and attacked almost immediately by the literary establishment: its alignment with commerce was perceived as a threat to “pure” literature, which was imagined to be transcendent and hence external to market forces. Although the Book of the Month Club’s selections included highbrow and lowbrow offerings – fiction with avant-garde tendencies as well as, say, adventure stories and romance – it became firmly associated with the middlebrow and hence with realism. Many realist texts were featured selections of the club (e.g., Ferber’s *Show Boat*, O. E. Rölvaag’s *Giant in the Earth* [1927]), and its early judges included middlebrow novelists Dorothy Canfield Fisher and Christopher Morley. Indeed, Janice Radway has argued that the club forced the very category of the middlebrow into existence as “a disturbing new nebula” on the literary scene.¹⁵ Together with such institutions as the Pulitzer Prize (which similarly validated realist texts), the Book of the Month Club lent legitimacy to literary realism, though it was tainted: both the club and the prize jeopardized “genuine” literary authority and raised the specter of the potential standardization of creative work.

The uneasiness with which realism was situated within the literary culture of the day was perhaps best exemplified by Sinclair Lewis, arguably the most significant realist of his generation. Lewis was noted for his astute characterization, and his novels, including *Main Street* (1920), *Babbitt* (1922), and *Arrowsmith* (1925), were widely admired as sharp social critiques of both middle-class American life and capitalism. They were also bestsellers, which made them vulnerable to association with the commercial middlebrow at the expense of the highbrow recognition Lewis apparently sought. In 1926 he conspicuously declined the Pulitzer Prize for *Arrowsmith*, citing the “dangerous[ness]” of literary prizes generally, which, he claimed, encouraged writers to be “safe, polite, obedient and sterile.”¹⁶ Although he went on to become the first American to win the Nobel Prize (which he accepted), Lewis clearly struggled with the critical paradigms that would consign his realist works to a subordinate plane.

Of course, some would argue that Lewis was not a middlebrow writer at all, pointing to his pseudo-canonical status as evidence that he was superior to such writers as Edna Ferber. Yet Lewis's brand of realism was commonly identified in the modernist period as *the* middlebrow mode; moreover, the critical debates of the time suggest that the more meaningful distinctions were not those between lesser and greater realists, but between realists and avant-garde experimentalists. This largely explains the irresolute standing of such authors as Lewis and Willa Cather, whose talents were widely recognized but whose reputations suffered in the gradual consolidation of modernism-as-experimentalism. That Lewis struggled mightily to carve out a category of distinction for himself, and that Cather understood her writing to be somehow "backward," only demonstrates that the alleged exceptions proved the rule. As with Ferber, the works of Lewis and Cather easily align with definitions of the middlebrow: all three writers wielded an accessible realist style to capture, and possibly influence, a large and reasonably intelligent but unpretentious audience, and in the process they sold very well. Recondite distinctions notwithstanding, these writers collectively demonstrate realism's association, for better or worse, with a non-elitist literary culture characterized by relatively uncomplicated texts and mainstream readers.¹⁷

A more nuanced relationship existed, however, between literary realism and the fiction of the Harlem Renaissance – or indeed, between realism and "racial uplift" fiction more broadly defined. On the surface this may seem surprising, given the long-standing assumption that African-American narrative forms were largely, and necessarily, realist ones. James Olney explains that the very first African-American genre, the slave narrative, depended on an inexorable adherence to the illusion that the narrator "exercises a clear-glass, neutral memory that is neither creative nor faulty"¹⁸; only through an apparently undeviating articulation of actual events could she or he represent slavery in a manner justifying the ultimate argument for abolition. Many African-American novels of the 1890s and beyond – for example, Charles Chesnutt's *The Marrow of Tradition* (1901) or James Weldon Johnson's *Autobiography of an*

Ex-Colored Man (1912) – were seen as following suit, displaying an obvious interest in revealing and weighing the treatment of African Americans in the social sphere. Indeed, literary realism furnished a representational strategy with clear socio-political advantages, correcting for past inaccuracies in texts by whites and advancing new models of black citizenship.

The presumed causal connection between realistic representation of and by African Americans and eventual socio-political gains for the race was solidified in the Harlem Renaissance, when, as its champion Alain Locke put it, “enlightened realism” marked

the present hope of Negro art and literature, not merely because it is desirable for our art to be in step with the prevailing mode and trend of the art and literature of its time . . . but because both practical and aesthetic interests dictate truth as the basic desideratum in the portrayal of the Negro, – and truth is the saving grace of realism.¹⁹

Henry Louis Gates, Jr., traces this attitude back to the turn into the twentieth century, when “to manipulate the image of the black was, in a sense, to manipulate reality.” Significantly, Gates goes so far as to argue that the Harlem Renaissance failed as an art movement, especially in comparison to the more experimental blues and jazz scene, precisely *because of* its investment in realistic representation: “There was no new world a-coming, as Alain Locke so ardently hoped; the movement of America, as Bessie Smith saw, looked toward *The Waste Land* and not . . . to [Cather’s] *The Song of the Lark*.”²⁰

Yet despite such routine equations of literary realism with African-American literature generally and the Harlem Renaissance in particular (an alignment often stressed in the definitional venues used by and for undergraduates), the expedience of an African-American reliance on realism has long been challenged. Kenneth Warren traces the history of objections to realism’s efficacy, including Albion Tourgée’s claims in the nineteenth century that romanticism is the proper vehicle of the black narrative and Leslie Fiedler’s suggestion in the mid-twentieth that only a gothic mode could serve the purpose.²¹ More recently, scholars question both the

ghettoization of African-American fiction within the larger literary field – such that African-American writers are not typically discussed in the same breath as classic realists such as Howells – and the facile alignment of African-American realistic tendencies with a codified realism that was white-defined. Michele Birnbaum, for example, insists that the predilection in literary studies “to cluster African American writers under separate headings” related to race has overdetermined classroom conversations; in contrast, putting black realists into play with white realists reveals “that what constitutes the cultural ‘real’ is specific to a particular time and place and sometimes even to a particular race.”²² In a different but related vein, Gene Andrew Jarrett argues that the perceived necessity for African-American writers to be “accurate” for political purposes “shackled the creative decisions and objectives of many black authors” to what he calls “racial realism”²³; those black writers who resisted this formula were too often marginalized or accused of aping whites.

Neither Birnbaum’s nor Jarrett’s argument denies the close relationship between realism and African-American fiction in the early twentieth century, but they both seek to complicate and explicate more fully that relationship. And, of course, their shared emphasis on realism’s *textured* relation to blackness actually serves to underscore the persistence of the equation of literary realism and black fiction generally. Overall, there is little doubt of realism’s deep entanglement with African-American fiction, and of the firmly political *purposes* of such fiction – especially in the Harlem Renaissance, designed explicitly “to contain this culturally willed myth” of a New Negro.²⁴ As Jarrett puts it, “black cultural expressions of racial realism have consistently mediated and encouraged [a] relationship between cultural politics and the politics of culture in the name of ‘racial progress.’”²⁵

Yet the African-American canon of the early twentieth century boasts numerous writers who signified on realism (to use a term particular to black cultural practices), tweaking realist codes to make realism their own. Nancy Bentley argues that Pauline Hopkins’ novel *Of One Blood* (1903) pointedly subverted Howellsian realist premises, ultimately replacing “museum realism” with a realist

model more conducive to Hopkins' socio-political purposes.²⁶ Charles Chesnutt boldly harnessed blackface minstrelsy to a realist mode in his turn-of-the-century conjure tales, and W. E. B. DuBois situated a realist narrative, "On the Coming of John," within his masterly multi-genre work, *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903); both writers reframed the ways that realism might be read, highlighting its aesthetic and cultural flexibility. And while Harlem Renaissance classics such as Jessie Redmon Fauset's *Plum Bun* (1928) or Nella Larsen's *Quicksand* (1928) and *Passing* (1929) seem to adopt a more standard (read white) realist paradigm, they too revise some of the conventional narrative rules for realism: in addition to resisting, especially in Larsen's case, any neat resolutions, they generally challenge African-Americans' exclusion from white realist discourse and refute dominant white portrayals of blacks as degenerates or unfortunates. Indeed, simply placing realism at the service of black subject positions may be read as forcing a conventional white mode into a more culturally specific frame. Even more important, perhaps, these texts collectively trouble assumptions about bourgeois individualism that inform the Howellsian realist model, since the realities of American racism necessarily expose middle-class norms and aspirations as having different valences for blacks and whites. The end point of this revisionary realist trajectory is perhaps best exemplified by Richard Wright's bestseller, *Native Son*, in which a realist style – vernacular speech, verisimilitude, etc. – is used to explore topics, notably systemic racism and crushing poverty, that Howells and his followers avoided.²⁷

Significantly, even those texts of the Harlem Renaissance that incorporate experimental narrative elements seem to make room for realism – perhaps, as Jarrett asserts, because of the cultural pressure to do so, but equally possibly because of the advantages that realism offers in advancing ideological perspectives. The most acclaimed example is undoubtedly Jean Toomer's *Cane* (1923), which achieves its high modernist status through a sophisticated amalgam of poetry and prose (some realist, some not), and which clearly seeks to unsettle facile ideas about blackness and culture. At the extreme end of what could be considered the modernist timeframe, Ralph

Ellison's *Invisible Man* (written in the late 1940s but not published until 1952) similarly transcends a simplistic racial protest model by positioning realist cues within a work also characterized by the riffs, improvisations, and discordances of jazz. While these are not realist texts per se, their realist elements nonetheless ground them within an African-American literary tradition that values both "authenticity" in representation and the use of literature as a political tool.

Ironically, the advent of social realist aesthetics in the 1930s led many black intellectuals to look back on the Harlem Renaissance with disdain; in comparison to social realism, they argued, texts of the Harlem Renaissance were less openly political, and more decadent and self-indulgent, than texts produced within the framework of an active American Left. Stacy Morgan's study of African-American social realism outlines this disavowal, but Morgan is quick to point out that these post-1930 critiques reveal less about the style and political commitment of Harlem Renaissance writers than about the social realists who were trying to differentiate their own rhetorical and artistic position.²⁸ Indeed, one might see the work of African-American proletarian writers in the 1930s and 1940s (including William Attaway, Ann Petry, Richard Wright) as redoubling the realist *and* political efforts of their predecessors rather than creating a wholly new kind of engaged art. Specifically, it is their use of an insistent and full-bodied realism – rather than, as Morgan puts it, "two-dimensional protagonists" acting out "predictable" theories²⁹ – that separates them from some of their white social realist counterparts and allows them simultaneously to expose the horrors of American racism and to critique the social frameworks of the Leftist project itself.

To be sure, the social realist movement, black and white, marks in many ways the pinnacle of the alignment of realism and socio-political impulses in the modern American novel. As with middlebrow writers and those of the Harlem Renaissance, social realist authors aimed to reach a reasonably educated and presumably receptive audience through broadly accessible structures, but they often did so in a deliberate and even combative way. Indeed, they laid specific claim to the literary as a medium of social change, and

they sometimes belittled styles that might alienate average readers; in particular, some derided high modernist literature as effete, overly cerebral, and irrelevant. In his essay “The Cult of Unintelligibility,” for example, Leftist writer and critic Max Eastman accused Gertrude Stein of “emptying words of the social element” and of using them not for genuine “communion” but rather “as empty vessels, polishing them and setting them in a row.”³⁰ Along the same lines, proletarian theorist and novelist Mike Gold famously characterized Proust’s writing as the work of a “master-masturbator.”³¹ In contrast, social realism was considered genuinely communicative, “real,” and of social value. Clearly these constructed dichotomies oversimplify both the modernist and Leftist literary landscapes, but they are instructive here for what they suggest about the perceived need to claim for social realism, perhaps even more so than for middlebrow and African-American realisms, an activist stance.

Yet these exaggerated oppositions threatened to overshadow the genuine complexities of the social realists’ oeuvre. Most literary proletarians did not entirely repudiate experimentation; on the contrary, some of the most admired social realist texts accommodated experimental techniques even as, in Barbara Foley’s words, a concept of realism “guid[ed] most literary radicals’ sense of their enterprise.”³² Hence realism remained a touchstone, a weapon in the aesthetic arsenal, rather than an absolute requirement, although the majority of Leftist texts in this period were indeed realist in the accepted sense of the term. This is not to say, however, that the Leftist accommodation of realism was uncomplicated, or that it did not draw criticism from various quarters. For one thing, the realist novel’s insistent teleology, moving toward an end point of conflict resolution, was compelling for Marxist ideology but could also lead to formulaic “conversion” endings in which a working-class subject inevitably acquires a radical consciousness (e.g., Gold’s *Jews Without Money* [1930]); such texts were lampooned by critics as flat and simplistic. Another widely discussed problem concerned the ways in which classic realism’s emphasis on bourgeois individualism might compromise a collective radical politics by fetishizing personal development. And of course, since writers were more likely to

come from the intellectual classes, the question of how, or even whether, they might best represent the proletariat also dogged the Leftist literary project. As Foley discusses in great detail, these and other theoretical issues related to realism and author/audience “identities” were widely debated and continue to frame scholarly consideration of the 1930s Left. Yet while these deliberations frequently register realism as potentially retrogressive, they evidence its ongoing relevance as well: for Left writers in the 1930s, realism was clearly the preferred option for moving a large readership toward proletarian ideals.

In the context of the literary Left, realism was plotted along a spectrum between relatively standard adoptions and creative accommodations. Proletarian novels making use of realism in fairly conventional ways (except for their highly partisan perspectives) include, for instance, Myra Page’s *Gathering Storm: A Story of the Black Belt* (1932), Olive Tilford Dargan’s *Call Home the Heart* (1932), Jack Conroy’s *The Disinherited* (1933), Robert Cantwell’s *The Land of Plenty* (1934), and Albert Halper’s *The Foundry* (1934). These novels are akin to middlebrow fiction in eschewing markedly idiosyncratic formalisms, privileging instead a conventional style; they also prioritize their social and political messages. While they have not generally achieved the critical or cultural status of certain Harlem Renaissance novels or even the more well-known middlebrow novels mentioned earlier, they nonetheless share, and even amplify, the modern-era link between realist structures and socio-political commentary.

Notably, however, some of the more influential social realist novels either unsettled readers through appropriating sensational subject matter – such as Wright’s *Native Son*, already mentioned – or blended realist techniques with some amount of modernist experimentation. For instance, Clara Weatherwax’s *Marching! Marching!*, which won a prize in 1935 from *Survey Graphic* magazine for “the best novel on an American proletarian theme,” was apparently chosen because of its potential to challenge stereotypical ideas about the form of the proletarian novel. As Jon-Christian Suggs explains, there had already been two other novels written about the same lumber and marine industry strike in Aberdeen, Washington;

Weatherwax's manuscript was thus less noteworthy for its topic than for its unusual effort to establish a "collective unconscious" through the elimination of "traditional punctuation and syntactical markers."³³ Yet Weatherwax's work sustains important elements of realism in its verisimilitude and its linear, plot-driven structure; one critic of the time stated that *Marching! Marching!*, "however modernistic its husks of diction," is also fundamentally "familiar," depicting "real people" and offering, above all, "a dramatization of the sufferings and the virtues of the underdog."³⁴ In a similar vein, Pietro di Donato's *Christ in Concrete* (1939) weaves lyricism, fragmented narrative, and stream of consciousness into a reader-friendly realist-oriented plotline; its general accessibility is evidenced by its status as a selection of the Book-of-the-Month Club, through which "it achieved mainstream legitimacy for itself as well as the [proletarian] genre."³⁵ These texts hewed to recognizably realist structures and styles while also incorporating more untraditional elements, linking realism and high modernism and thereby reconfiguring their potential relations.

But by far the most significant Leftist novelist to bend realism to larger purposes – and to do so with apparent deliberateness – was John Dos Passos in his *U.S.A.* trilogy. Significantly, Dos Passos had quite a bit to say about the modern literary scene and the Left's place within it. In a piece entitled "They Want Ritzy Art," he lamented the tendency in American arts to perceive "experiments in thought and presentation" as the province merely of "a few highbrows," while supplying the "large and largely workers' audience" with "only the most smooth-worn routine."³⁶ Elsewhere he railed against the "idiotic schism between Highbrow and Lowbrow."³⁷ These comments contextualize the widely acclaimed *U.S.A.*, which takes pains to alternate among four separate stylistic modes: collage-like Newsreels, composed of song lyrics and journalistic snippets; Biographies of major figures of the time, such as Thorstein Veblen and Henry Ford; The Camera Eye, autobiographical segments rendered in poetic stream-of-consciousness; and finally, realistic narratives of fictional characters. That Dos Passos divided these modes into entirely discrete sections and allowed them implicitly

to frame and reframe each other over the course of some 1,500 pages suggests that he considered them equally important, equally essential to the story he wanted to tell. Spatially speaking, however, the narratives of fictional characters make up the bulk of the text; ironically, then, the work that has been hailed for its “technical inventiveness and freshness of style”³⁸ devoted itself largely to a straightforward, if somewhat clipped, realist mode.

Of course, this variety of stylistics helped Dos Passos balance the advantages and disadvantages of the various literary approaches at his disposal. (For example, the collectivism of the Newsreels compensates for the focus on individual personality in the other three modes, while the failed radical ambitions of the fictional characters “corrects” for the predictable “conversion” ending of the Camera Eye.) It is certainly harder to attach the simplistic charge of “propaganda” to Dos Passos’s complex work than to more standard realist proletarian novels. Yet if *U.S.A.* succeeds as a modernist experiment, it also stands as a statement on the continuing efficacy of realism. Significantly, Dos Passos never lost faith in the notion of a verifiable relation between fiction and perceived reality: he believed that a novelist should be a “second class historian” of his age,³⁹ and later in his life he referred regularly to his books as “contemporary chronicles.”⁴⁰ Doubtless he would have refuted Irving Howe’s classic assertion that “the *avant-garde* scorns notions of ‘responsibility’ toward the audience.”⁴¹ On the contrary, for Dos Passos, realism could be integral to an experimental aesthetic strategy holding interest for elite as well as general readers, and for Leftists and non-Leftists alike. The success of this broad appeal may be measured in part by his appearance on the cover of *Time* magazine on August 10, 1936, just following the publication of the trilogy’s final volume.

That Dos Passos was admired by modernist critics and embraced by mainstream audiences as well as those on the Left reminds us that the classifications established by literary historians are necessarily somewhat arbitrary; so too might we acknowledge that the categories of the middlebrow, the Harlem Renaissance, and the literary Left enjoyed considerable overlap. Wright’s *Native Son*, for example, bears a relationship to all three: a proletarian novel by an

African-American Leftist who grappled openly with the literary and racial legacies of the Harlem Renaissance, it was also a major selection of the Book of the Month Club. The slippage of such texts among these different categories suggests anew the shape-shifting nature of the modernist novel and challenges superficial carvings of the literary-historical pie; it also disrupts the notion, established retrospectively, that high modernist experimentation was the privileged mode of fictional expression while realism was merely a holdover from an earlier, less sophisticated time. To see realism as a conscious, meaningful social-aesthetic choice within the context of modernism is to imagine both realism and modernism in their historical fullness.

Elizabeth Ammons has asserted that “the most important characteristic of American realism” in the early twentieth century was “its racial, ethnic, sexual, and cultural range.”⁴² Exploring the modern realist novel through the combined lenses of middlebrow fiction, African-American literature, and the social realism of the literary Left reveals something of that range while also making visible realism’s strong link in the modernist period to advocacy and social critique. Even in its “straight” version, it represented not a lack of stylistic imagination but an active opportunity to posit reform for a wide audience; in perhaps its most ambitious manifestations, it lent itself to aesthetic experiments that merged its appeal with those of alternative expressive approaches. Realism’s significations through multiple registers have been the topic of much recent scholarly work, including that of Phillip Barrish, who advocates “that we recognize the multiple achievements of realism as fully and honestly as possible.”⁴³ One of those achievements is a strikingly versatile accommodation of a variety of socio-political critiques that enabled a rich commentary on modernist culture.

Notes

1. Michael North, *Reading 1922: A Return to the Scene of the Modern* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999), 179.
2. See Willa Cather, *Not Under Forty* (New York: Knopf, 1936), v. Werner Sollors comments on the unanticipated cultural status of high modernism:

- “Amazingly, what started as the fringe enterprise of a few radical artists at the beginning of the century who set out to ‘defamiliarize,’ to ‘alienate’ their small audiences, and what appeared as if it would be replaced by a second wave of realism in the 1930s . . . became the dominant expression of western art by the 1950s” (*Ethnic Modernism* [Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2008], 1).
3. Quoted in Noliwe M. Rooks, *Ladies’ Pages: African American Women’s Magazines and the Culture That Made Them* (New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press, 2004), 69–70.
 4. Katherine Jellison, *Entitled to Power: Farm Women and Technology, 1919–1963* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1993). See [chapter 2](#).
 5. Theodore Roosevelt, “The Strenuous Life” in *The Strenuous Life: Essays and Addresses* (New York: Century, 1900), 5.
 6. In stressing realism’s policing of social norms and commitment to social commentary, I am following such critics as Amy Kaplan, who suggests that realism, in couching critique within accessible formations, enables a flexible “manage[ment]” of the social world’s “explosive qualities” (*The Social Construction of American Realism* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988], 11). Nancy Bentley offers a useful overview of scholarly approaches to realism, including those that foreground its social investments (*Frantic Panoramas: American Literature and Mass Culture, 1870–1920* [Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2009], 71–2).
 7. Barbara Christian, “The Race for Theory,” *Feminist Studies* 14.1 (1988): 71.
 8. Nicola Humble, *The Feminine Middlebrow Novel, 1920s to 1950s: Class, Domesticity, and Bohemianism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001), 11.
 9. Waldo Frank, “Pseudo-Literature,” *New Republic* 2 Dec. 1925: 46–7. Dwight Macdonald, “Masscult and Midcult,” in *Against the American Grain* (New York: DaCapo, 1983), 54.
 10. Gordon Hutner, *What America Read: Taste, Class, and the Novel, 1920–1960* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2009), 11.
 11. Quoted in Jaime Harker, *America the Middlebrow: Women’s Novels, Progressivism, and Women’s Authorship Between the Wars* (Amherst: University of Massachusetts Press, 2007), 96.
 12. On Sinclair, see Anthony Arthur, *Radical Innocent: Upton Sinclair* (New York: Random House, 2006). On Gale, see Deborah Lindsay Williams, “The Cosmopolitan Regionalism of Zona Gale’s Friendship Village,” in *Middlebrow Moderns: Popular American Women Writers of the 1920s*, eds. Lisa Botshon and Meredith Goldsmith (Boston, MA: Northeastern University Press, 2003).
 13. Grant Overton, “The Social Critic in Edna Ferber,” *Bookman* 64 (Oct. 1926): 143, 138, 143.

14. Quoted in "Edna Ferber: About the Author" [Back matter] in Edna Ferber, *So Big* (New York: HarperCollins, 2000): 256.
15. Janice A. Radway, *A Feeling for Books: The Book-of-the-Month Club, Literary Taste, and Middle-Class Desire* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1997): 152.
16. Quoted in "Lewis Refuses Pulitzer Prize," *New York Times* May 6, 1926: 1.
17. We might put Edith Wharton into this category as well – yet another realist writer who sold very well and, like Lewis, received a Pulitzer Prize for her *The Age of Innocence* (1921). Academic efforts to brand Wharton as a *psychological* realist, thereby linking her to Henry James, hardly minimize her enormous popularity with mainstream readers.
18. James Olney, "I Was Born: Slave Narratives, Their Status as Autobiography and as Literature," *Callaloo* 20 (Winter 1984): 48.
19. Alain Locke, "The Saving Grace of Realism: Retrospective Review of the Negro Literature of 1933," in *The Critical Temper of Alain Locke*, ed. Jeffrey C. Stuart (New York: Garland, 1983): 30.
20. Henry Louis Gates, Jr., "The Trope of a New Negro and the Reconstruction of the Image of the Black," *Representations* 24 (Fall 1988): 137, 148.
21. Kenneth Warren, *Black and White Strangers: Race and American Literary Realism* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1993): 5–6.
22. Michelle Birnbaum, "Towards Desegregating Syllabuses: Teaching American Literary Realism and Racial Uplift Fiction," in *Teaching American Literature: A Companion*, eds. Tanya Agathocleous and Ann C. Dean (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2003): 60, 63.
23. Gene Andrew Jarrett, *Deans and Truants: Race and Realism in African American Literature* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2007), 1.
24. Gates, "Trope of a New Negro," 132.
25. Jarrett, *Deans and Truants*, 9.
26. Bentley, *Frantic Panoramas*, 216.
27. It is tempting to think of Wright's novel as naturalist, sharing the dynamics of other poverty-centered naturalist narratives such as Crane's *Maggie, A Girl of the Streets* (1893). Yet Wright's emphasis on Bigger Thomas's desire to *know* and *be* something seems an indirect commentary on the bourgeois aspirations typical of Howellsian realism, which appear misplaced or even absurd within the social context of a racist society.
28. Stacy I. Morgan, *Rethinking Social Realism: African American Art and Literature, 1930–53* (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 2004): 2–4.
29. *Ibid.*, 300.
30. Max Eastman, "The Cult of Unintelligibility." *Harper's* April 1929: 534–35.

31. Mike Gold, "Proletarian Realism," in *Mike Gold: A Literary Anthology*, ed. Michael Folsom (New York: International, 1972): 206.
32. Barbara Foley, *Radical Representations: Politics and Form in U.S. Proletarian Fiction, 1929–1941* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1993): 57.
33. Jon-Christian Suggs, "Marching! Marching! and the Idea of the Proletarian Novel" in *The Novel and the American Left: Critical Essays on Depression-Era Fiction*, ed. Janet Galligani Casey (Iowa City: University of Iowa Press, 2004): 163, 166.
34. Henry Seidel Canby, "Workers, Unite!" [Rev. of *Marching! Marching!*, by Clara Weatherwax], *Saturday Review* 4 Jan. 1936: 12.
35. Hutner, *What America Read*, 118.
36. John Dos Passos, "They Want Ritzy Art," in *John Dos Passos: The Major Nonfictional Prose*, ed. Donald Pizer (Detroit, MI: Wayne State University Press, 1988): 114.
37. John Dos Passos, "Is the Realistic Theater Obsolete?" in *John Dos Passos: The Major Nonfictional Prose*, 76.
38. Alfred Kazin, "John Dos Passos: Inventor in Isolation," *The Saturday Review* March 15, 1969: 16.
39. John Dos Passos, "Statement of Belief," in *John Dos Passos: The Major Nonfictional Prose*.
40. David Sanders, "John Dos Passos: The Art of Fiction No. 44" [Interview], *Paris Review* 46 (Spring 1969): n.p.
41. Irving Howe, "Introduction: The Idea of the Modern," in *Literary Modernism*, ed. Irving Howe (Greenwich, CT: Fawcett, 1967): 24.
42. Elizabeth Ammons, "Men of Color, Women, and Uppity Art at the Turn of the Century," in *American Realism and the Canon*, eds. Tom Quirk and Gary Scharnhorst (Newark: University of Delaware Press, 1995): 24.
43. Philip Barrish, *American Literary Realism, Critical Theory, and Intellectual Prestige, 1890–1995* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2001): 10.

CHAPTER 8

Modernist Domesticity: Reconciling the Paradox in Edith Wharton, Willa Cather, and Nella Larsen

Deborah Clarke

Domesticity and modernism appears, to many, as an incongruous pairing, the bringing together of two terms that, while they may denote modes that coexist temporally, seem intellectually and philosophically antithetical. A large body of scholarship on nineteenth-century American literature explores in depth the notion of separate spheres, both defining and interrogating the division of the domestic realm from the public one. But this intense scrutiny of domesticity tapers off in regard to modern literature, a tacit indication that the domestic is not modern – or, at least, not part of the modernist canon. Blythe Forcey says of domestic fiction, “While the genre has never died out, it became an object of near-constant disdain in the first half of the twentieth century as it was made the icon of everything that modern literature strove *not* to be.”¹ Francesca Sawaya, in her study of women and professionalism in the first half of the twentieth century, notes how modern “civilization” is characterized by specialized, differentiated labor. Women, she observes, “are included in modernity because they engage in differentiated labor – in other words, domesticity. At the same time, women are excluded from modernity along with other ‘primitives’ because domesticity is part of the untrained, undifferentiated labor of the past.”² If domesticity is aligned with nineteenth-century ideology, how can it be viewed as modern? Yet, given the modernist focus on ordinary everyday life, why should domesticity be excluded? With an obvious debt to Amy Kaplan’s now famous work on manifest domesticity, I’d like to posit modernist domesticity, a conception of

domesticity found in the work of many modern women writers.³ While we may first think of modernist domesticity in terms of the classic modernist rewriting of domesticity found in Gertrude Stein and Virginia Woolf, writers more associated with a realist tradition, such as Edith Wharton, Willa Cather, and Nella Larsen, proffer a slightly different approach to domesticity. *Ethan Frome*, *The Professor's House*, and *Quicksand* destabilize domesticity not so much through form and language – as Stein does so brilliantly in *Three Lives* – but precisely through their realist focus on domestic detail. In this chapter, I'll explore the ways that the representation of domesticity elicits a modernist alienation. When realist domesticity self-destructs, one is launched into a modernist realization that even the home provides no refuge from the vicissitudes of modernity.

The failure of so many scholars of modernism to consider domesticity is puzzling on a number of levels.⁴ First, scholarship has pushed the advent of the modernist era substantially earlier than Virginia Woolf's famous starting date of on or about December, 1910, or the more widely cited 1913 New York Armory Show, with the 1880s now more frequently accepted as the beginning of modernism. This situates it in much closer proximity to the heyday – roughly in the 1850s and 1860s – of the doctrine of separate spheres and its celebration of domesticity. Secondly, while no definition of modernism would satisfy all practitioners in the field, a focus on interiority is a critical component. One thinks of Faulkner's mesmerizing exploration of the inner psyche of Quentin Compson or of Leopold Bloom's constantly shifting ruminations as he wanders the streets of Dublin. Domesticity, too, is all about interiority, even if represented more spatially than psychologically or linguistically. The barren interior of the Frome homestead speaks to a modernist alienation just as profound as that experienced by the ever-alienated Quentin. Finally, if modern fiction tends to resist the grandiosity and sensationalism of the Victorian novel, favoring the mundane over the dramatic, then surely domesticity, the epitome of the everyday, should play an integral role in defining a modernist ethos.

Much has been written about the long-standing association between modernism and masculinity. From the trauma and

alienation generated by the Great War to the urban setting of the flâneur so common in modernist literature, the context of modernity supported a literary modernism that privileged male experience and male expression, a privileging reinforced by generations of scholars and critics. This ostensible gendering of modernism reflects a shift from nineteenth-century American interest in the sentimental that proved so favorable to the damned mob of scribbling women excoriated by Nathaniel Hawthorne.⁵ Enough work on modern women writers and feminist theory has now been done to challenge that bias, though the primary beneficiaries of this scholarship have been writers fairly easy to plug into the standard masculinist tradition: Virginia Woolf and Gertrude Stein. Wharton, Cather, and Larsen tend to receive less attention as modern writers. Less formally experimental, more associated with “traditional” women’s issues of marriage, home, and family, these authors push the boundaries of modern literature, at least partly through their exploration of domesticity as a space of modernist anxiety and instability. Katherine Mullin has noted the dismissal of “domestic life, love affairs, or motherhood” as “inappropriate subjects for modernist experimentation” by contemporaneous modern writers.⁶ As Virginia Woolf put it in *A Room of One’s Own*, “This is an important book, the critic assumes, because it deals with war. This is an insignificant book because it deals with the feelings of women in a drawing-room.”⁷ Indeed, none of the three writers considered here can match the formal innovation of Stein or Faulkner (though the same could be said of many male modern writers). But their scrutiny of domesticity unmoors the home as a site of comfort or refuge. That the narrative structures follow a more traditional pattern only adds to the jarring quality of these representations of modernist domesticity. The realist descriptions of the domestic scene crumble under the weight of modernist angst.

The modernist novel recasts the accepted ideas of domesticity, that it serves as the center of the home, providing sustenance, warmth, and order to family life. Rather, the costs of such assumptions are made vividly clear. The tale of modernist domesticity is not one of liberation from household labors nor of women finding

agency in reclaiming the domestic. It is a tale of how domesticity fails to shape female identity, sustain a space of interiority, or serve women's interests. As Thomas Foster contends, "modernist women writers reimagined domesticity in order to reject its positioning within the binary framework of the ideology of separate spheres."⁸ Positioned not against modernity, but firmly within it, modernist domesticity collapses any lingering belief that the home may be ideologically separated from public culture.⁹ Thus even those identified as domestic writers still function within a modernist ethos, and, in so doing, shape the development of that ethos. Modernism *is* domestic.

Rarely identified as a modern author, Edith Wharton resisted the modernist movement. In letters, as Jennifer Haytock points out, "she bemoaned what she saw as its disregard of social order and its abandonment of morality."¹⁰ Robin Peel has argued that Wharton cannot be viewed as a modernist writer:

My central argument will be that this rejection of the label 'modernist' is inevitable if we give due weight to the rhetoric of the fiction, which despite its political polyphony ultimately confirms the enduring influence of the ideological and class discourses that shaped Wharton as a young woman. These conservative discourses, which surrounded her from childhood and were questioned by her but never rejected, led her to esteem duty and the power of society above the individual, and made anathema to her Old New York principles the anarchy implicit in her reading of the aesthetic and cultural implications of modernism.¹¹

Wharton's fiction, she goes on, "interrogates" her "ideological inheritance" but does not "overturn" it.¹² I would suggest, however, that Peel over-reads form and individual consciousness as defining components of modern literature. In particular, Wharton's presentation of domesticity raises questions central to modernism: how can identity be defined if the home does not function as a space for self-definition? If domestic goods are prized above domestic relations, how can the home hold its place as the source of human interaction? Confronting these questions enables Wharton to explore domesticity through a modernist lens.

One of the challenges in exploring modernist domesticity, as Susan Fraiman articulates, is a scholarly tendency to collapse the

sentimental, the domestic, and the feminine. She looks to Wharton “for a vision of domesticity extricated from sentimental views – split off, in particular, from the sentimental framing of women as selfless, emotional creatures, their devotion to home bound up with their care for others.”¹³ If one separates domesticity from sentimentality, it makes for a much more productive avenue for considering modern fiction and domesticity. Wharton, Fraiman argues, develops a professional identity “by writing herself into the private domestic sphere.”¹⁴ Her organization of her Massachusetts home, The Mount, into many rooms allowed her to construct a domestic space “as a personal refuge *from* family,” to create her own space within the home.¹⁵ Domestic space does not necessarily need to include the baggage normally associated with domesticity: family, warmth, sentimentality. Wharton herself, of course, was well able to afford a house that incorporated a private domestic space in which to work as a professional author. In *Ethan Frome*, her characters are not so fortunate. Mattie Silver must be evicted from the home once Zeena determines to take on a hired girl because there is, literally, no place to put her. That Zeena insists on the hired girl as a more indirect means of getting rid of Mattie is clear; her shrewd awareness of the potential of limited domestic space to eliminate a rival reveals the absence of any sentimental attachment to family; Mattie is her cousin, as Ethan fruitlessly points out. By refiguring domesticity as a space of absence – of warmth, of conjugal love, of comfort – Wharton unmoors it from its nineteenth-century associations, adding it to the grab bag of concepts and beliefs unsettled by modernity.

Wharton’s modernizing of domesticity takes many forms. The Frome homestead is “one of those lonely New England farm-houses that make the landscape lonelier.”¹⁶ Modernism does not, of course, own such loneliness; one only needs to think of *Wuthering Heights*. But this domestic space encloses not the simmering passion of Brontë’s novel but a bleak and very modernist alienation and instability. Lacking the “L” – the “long deep-roofed adjunct usually built at right angles to the main house, and connecting it . . . with the wood-shed and cow-barn,” which, as the narrator points out, generally serves as the “centre, the actual hearthstone” of the home – the

“diminished dwelling” reflects Ethan’s own “shrunk body” (*EF* 14). It is a home noticeably lacking in the art of domesticity. Zeena has declared herself too ill and Mattie has “no natural turn for house-keeping, and her training had done nothing to remedy the defect.” Ethan believes that were she to marry “a man she was fond of the dormant instinct would wake, and her pies and biscuits become the pride of the country; but domesticity in the abstract did not interest her” (*EF* 24). Ethan’s rather traditional assumption that domesticity grows out of love would not be out of place in pre-twentieth-century fiction. Even Jo March, the rambunctious tomboy of Louisa May Alcott’s *Little Women*, settles into housekeeping upon the death of her highly domestic sister. Love for her sister turns household drudgery into meaningful service: “Brooms and dishcloths never could be as distasteful as they once had been, for Beth had presided over both.”¹⁷ But Wharton provides no such reward for household duties. The carefully plotted narratives of mid-nineteenth-century fiction do not apply here. We have the detailed plots and the domestic detail, but they do not add up to a secure, stable household. Wharton highlights the failure of domesticity as an ordering principle. Mattie’s cooking is mediocre and her housekeeping skills wanting. In an effort to hide her shortcomings and keep Zeena from firing her, Ethan sneaks down at night to remop the floor and helps with the churning, further destabilizing the domestic by unsettling the gender roles associated with it. By representing domesticity through its absence, Wharton produces a modernist angle on domesticity as yet another concept that used to provide stability but no longer does.

This focus on domestic detail is critical in thinking about modernism, as Liesl Olson points out.

Literary modernism takes ordinary experience as its central subject. Yet the pre-dominance of ordinariness has often been overlooked, largely because critics have overwhelmingly considered literary modernism as a movement away from the conventions of nineteenth-century realism and toward an aesthetic of self-conscious interiority. This line of thinking emphasizes how modernists sought to shed the heavy furniture of the realist and naturalist novel in order to render inner perception.¹⁸

Yet, as Olson elucidates, modernists do “dwell” in the “regularity of the ordinary,” which can be viewed as “a response to what is represented as the hollowness of modern life, the loss of abstract ideals in which to believe, and the difficulty of really knowing another person.”¹⁹ Wharton’s exploration of a modernist domesticity not only reflects this response to the emptiness of modern life but also illustrates that the “ordinary” domestic enterprise provides not a refuge but an intensification of that emptiness. *Ethan Frome* dramatizes both aspects of this exploration. Trying desperately to keep Zeena from realizing the extent of Mattie’s inadequacy as a housekeeper, Ethan completely overlooks the more serious issue of his wife’s awareness of his feelings. His naïve assumption that Zeena is only concerned with the impact of poor domestic practices on her health, and has no idea that he has fallen in love with her cousin, underscores his inability to fathom the depths of his wife’s inner consciousness or even to acknowledge the implications of his own consciousness of the situation. Focusing on the domestic situates him as a prime example of the unaware modern subject. Domesticity doesn’t just respond to the “hollowness of modern life,” it is implicated in constructing that hollowness.

The most telling moment of modernist domesticity in the tale is the breaking of the red glass pickle dish, Zeena’s most prized possession, an object never used, not even for the visits of the minister. Mattie takes it down from the china cabinet while Zeena is away because she wants to “make the supper-table pretty” (*EF* 85). Savoring time alone with Ethan, she tries to arrange a beautiful and harmonious home, bringing out the pickle dish and coordinating its color with a red ribbon in her hair, an action that “transformed and glorified her. She seemed to Ethan taller, fuller, more womanly in shape and motion.” Her personal adornment is matched by the table, with Ethan’s “favorite pickles in a dish of gay red glass” (*EF* 54). The entire scene imbues Ethan with a sense of well-being. Here is a classic scene of domestic comfort: a beautiful woman, a bright fire, a snoozing cat, and a well-apportioned table with a pretty red glass dish. But Wharton sets this up as a mockery of domesticity, not an ideal. The beautiful woman is not the wife and the beautiful dish is

smashed by the now-awakened cat. In other words, all of the components of domestic bliss, which should blend harmoniously together, shatter like the dish. The scene, so realistically detailed, highlights the false premise of domesticity and reveals the inability of the private sphere to function as a stable space. Like the dish, it is as fragile as glass.

It seems unfair to castigate Zeena, who hardly lives a life of luxury, for prizing her pickle dish so highly that it thereby loses its status as a domestic implement. This situation, however, in which the item actually undoes traditional domestic values, comprises the heart of modernist domesticity. The dish is not, in fact, a domestic good; rather, it is a personal one. Though it is a wedding gift, Ethan has no idea where it comes from. If a wedding gift is meant to celebrate a union of two people and to aid in setting up a household, this pickle dish has failed to accomplish its purpose. Hidden on a high shelf, unused in the home, it epitomizes a modernist domesticity that highlights fragility, instability, and the alienation of the individual. This is not *their* pickle dish; it is hers. While Zeena goes to considerable lengths to protect her marriage, claiming medical reasons for displacing Mattie from her home in exchange for a presumably stronger and more reliable hired girl, one gets the sense that this stems not from love but from an understandable dependence on stability. Losing her husband would mean losing her home. Her love, however, is devoted to the dish; once it is broken, she weeps over it, a reaction quite different from her response to the fear that she may be losing her husband to another woman: "you've took from the one [thing] I cared for most of all" (*EF* 85). This refers not to Ethan but to her meager collection of things. It may be tempting to read her grief over the pickle dish as a displacement over her grief for losing Ethan, but it's a hard reading to sustain. She prizes not Ethan but her home and her dish, a dish that is not to be used in service of the home. This inherent contradiction of valuing home, but undoing what it means, reflects the shaky nature of domesticity in the modern world.

Wharton remarked about *Ethan Frome* that she wanted to depict "the lonely lives in half-deserted New England villages, before the

coming of the motor and the telephone.”²⁰ In other words, she envisioned a premodern world. But Wharton modernizes this premodern world by her unsettling representation of domesticity, rather than through the introduction of cars and phones. Willa Cather, in *The Professor's House*, also draws on a premodern world, one set considerably earlier than that portrayed in *Ethan Frome*. The section devoted to Cliff City, Tom Outland's discovered cliff dwellings, depicts with epic grandeur the ancient, long-abandoned dwellings of pre-Columbian indigenous peoples. Interrupting the primary narrative set in the early twentieth century – that of Godfrey St. Peter's resistance to moving into a new house – Cliff City functions as an ideal site of domesticity. Tom and Roddy find all the implements of domesticity: pots, corn, fire pits, clay ovens, water jars. Yet they note a lack of disorder even hundreds of years after the site was abandoned, remarking that “wind and sun are good housekeepers.”²¹ Where Wharton explores how the materiality of the domestic reflects a distinctly modernist ethos, Cather explicitly distances modernism from domesticity and, through that distancing, highlights the uneasy association between them. This magnificent domestic space is devoid of people, particularly of women. It is a place of great spiritual power for Tom, but the sole female inhabitant is a mummified body aptly named Mother Eve. Through this uneasy intersection of domestic space, women, sexuality, and religion, Cather draws on the standard associations that have set domesticity in opposition to modernity. Her complex and nuanced use of those associations, however, calls attention to their inadequacy in a modern world. Like Wharton, she uses domesticity to undo domestic stability.

The majesty of Cliff City offsets the mundane details of the two St. Peter houses. St. Peter's study, in the attic of his old, rented home, is a place “where he could get isolation, insulation from the engaging drama of domestic life” (16). Surrounded by the dress-maker's forms used to make clothing for his wife and daughters, he escapes the household to work under the guidance of what he terms his “ladies.” If Mother Eve is a troubling figure in Cliff City, these literal dummies provide an even more problematic female presence,

never having been alive. In true modernist fashion, these forms emphasize rupture from the real, showcasing a man who prefers the forms of his wife and daughters to their actual bodies. For St. Peter, the best domesticity is characterized by its absence. True domesticity, the life of his family, is to be avoided. Once in his study, he stays put because on the "perilous journey down through the human house he might lose his mood, his enthusiasm, even his temper" (*PH* 18). Immersing himself in the study of history, he eschews the intimacy of household relations. Stubbornly clinging to the past, he refuses to move his workspace to the new house. As he tells Augusta, the sewing woman with whom he has shared the attic space, he will continue to work in his old study "and *board* at the new house" (*PH* 11, my emphasis). Home is where he works, not where he lives. In thus bifurcating his home space, St. Peter keeps domesticity at a distance. Its peril lies in the possibility of restoring St. Peter to his family, erasing his individuality and alienation. It does, indeed, pose a threat to the modernist individual consciousness.

Yet in his stubborn resistance to this threat, St. Peter experiences a very modern inner journey, rediscovering "the realist of his lives," the "original, unmodified Godfrey St. Peter" (*PH* 240, 239). In stripping away the conventions of modern culture, he performs a very modernist action. This "primitive" self "was solitary and must always be so; he had never married, never been a father" (*PH* 241). The originary St. Peter, in other words, was a modernist who abstains from marriage and fatherhood, the most common elements of domestic life. Cather's depiction of St. Peter's regression, his retreat from domesticity, identifies domesticity as intimately connected to the angst of modern life. Caught between two houses, he can find no place for himself within the home. If the goal of the domestic is to expand into newer and more comfortable quarters, it gets distracted by serving the physical body and neglects individual consciousness, reinforcing the modernist tension between the physical and intellectual.

But Cather goes beyond the representation of domesticity as troubled, split, and something to be avoided. She sets it up as female space, linked to destructive female sexuality. From the time he meets

his wife, St. Peter notes, “the design of his life had been the work of this secondary social man, the lover. It had been shaped by all the penalties and responsibilities of being and having been a lover” (*PH* 240). Marriage, work, fatherhood all commit St. Peter to a public position. His social identity is predicated on female sexuality; it all boils down to Lillian, his wife. Lillian causes the separation from the original unmodified self, particularly since she goes on to give birth to daughters (and resents his relationship with Tom Outland, a surrogate son). As he remarks to her, Euripides retreated to a cave in his old age. “It seems that houses had become insupportable to him. I wonder whether it was because he had observed women so closely all his life” (*PH* 136). Not only are women and houses aligned, they create an environment inhospitable to men. Such assumptions are also mapped onto Cliff City. With no evidence other than a mummified body, which appears to have died by violence, the male excavators carefully construct a narrative of female betrayal, identifying her as Mother Eve. As John N. Swift notes, they “badly need her to be something other than what she is: speechless, self-contained, and wholly indifferent – and thus threatening – to the symbolic orderings of the men who seek to understand and possess her.”²² In other words, she serves as an emblem of modernism: indifferent to order and to men. Mother Eve’s alleged outlaw sexuality reinscribes Judeo-Christian beliefs about women’s culpability in the loss of paradise; no home can survive the unrestrained expression of female sexuality. Situated among the domestic tidiness of the site and the beautiful jars and bowls left behind, her body speaks to the inadequacy of the domestic to contain female desire.

Sexual desire is not the only female threat to domesticity, particularly in the modern world where sexuality is increasingly expressed through consumerism. “The discourse of consumerism,” Rita Felski argues, “is to a large extent the discourse of female desire.”²³ Modernist domesticity engages both sexual and consumer desire. Lillian St. Peter’s desires for domestic comfort via consumer goods and services also unsettle the household. As St. Peter realizes, “Lillian couldn’t pinch and be shabby and do housework, as the

wives of some of his colleagues did. Under such conditions she became another person, and a bitter one" (*PH* 233). Lillian's inability to perform household labor would seem to situate her outside the domestic realm. Given modernism's association with the intricacies of consumerism, however, Lillian's cravings for a new house and attractive household goods reflect her participation in modernist domesticity, where one can purchase the domestic in lieu of performing it. In the modern era, domesticity is intertwined with consumerism, situating the home very much within the public sphere. In fact, Elizabeth Festa argues, Cather's homes in this text can be considered within the context of the home as museum, further detaching the house from domesticity and "underscoring the contiguity between the domestic interior and modern spheres of engagement and desire."²⁴

Both of these instances implicate women in the construction and destabilization of the home. As the example of Mother Eve illustrates, the female body has long proved an unstable but necessary element of domesticity. But Cather's modernist twist on a long-held assumption regarding women and domesticity reminds us of the slipperiness in shaping meaning; we don't actually know the reasons behind Mother Eve's death, nor is it clear that Lillian's desires are the cause of St. Peter's disillusionment. Surrounded by women, both real and fake, he finds his home life devoid of meaningful existence. "He loved his family, he would make any sacrifice for them, but just now he couldn't live with them. He must be alone" (*PH* 250). His salvation from a near-death experience by Augusta seems to reconcile him, but to a more traditional form of domesticity. Augusta evokes the "solid earth," religion, and domestic work (*PH* 256). Yet amidst this reminder of his ties to a mundane, everyday world, he comes to a very modernist realization that he will need to learn to live "without delight" (*PH* 257). His "temporary release from consciousness" allows him to return to the domestic sphere, acknowledging its inescapability, even in the modern world. Cather's portrayal of modernist domesticity reminds us that the exploration of individual consciousness occurs within the confines of domestic space, generated in part by the demands of domestic life. By imbuing

domesticity with modern angst and situating it within consumer culture, she establishes it as an integral element of modernity.

Modernity has been aligned not only with masculinity but also, of course, with whiteness. Even in current scholarship, the New Negro Renaissance is often considered as a separate movement. Mark Sanders posits what he terms “*heterodox modernism*, in which New Negroes participated fully,” as a way of defining a modernism inclusive of African-American participation. This heterodox modernism “takes as its point of departure reactions against the limitations of Victorian epistemology and responses to late nineteenth-century modernization.”²⁵ To apply this to domesticity means to consider a range of responses to nineteenth-century definitions of the private sphere, a sphere predicated on the assumption, Hazel Carby argues, that the true woman was white.²⁶ Elizabeth Ammons has suggested that *Ethan Frome* “offers a eugenics parable about white Anglo-Saxon New England disappearing.”²⁷ While this white disappearance would seem to make room for an African-American modern experience, Sanders reminds us that “the modernist era witnessed the nadir of race relations in America.”²⁸ Racist pressures on African-American domesticity generated particular challenges for African-American women writers such as Nella Larsen, as maintaining a stable domestic life proved much more difficult in African-American households where the immediacy of danger left little room for modernist psychological angst. While Larsen rarely confronts racist violence directly, she’s very aware of the impact of racism on domesticity, as she takes on not only white constructions of the home and stereotypical assumptions about black female sexuality, but also a traditional staple of African-American domestic culture, religion.

Larsen ratchets up Cather’s uncovering of the incendiary role of sexuality and materialism in exploring modernist domesticity. *Quicksand*’s Helga Crane longs for things: “Always she had wanted, not money, but the things which money could give, leisure, attention, beautiful surroundings. Things. Things. Things.”²⁹ But things provide no more domestic stability than they do in Wharton or Cather, particularly since things tend to fall into two categories,

those that imitate white culture and those that exoticize her body. Her friend Anne's home contains "bonneted old highboys, tables that might be by Duncan Phyfe, rare spindle-legged chairs . . ." (Q 44). Anne, who despises white culture, replicates it in her elegant house. Helga may revel in this luxury, as she does in her aunt's comfortable home in Copenhagen, but the household goods do not provide domestic stability, especially given the ways that such homes are shaped by a racial politics that essentially erases Helga's individuality. Anne's hatred for whites prevents Helga from admitting to having a white mother while Helga's white aunt dresses her in provocative clothes that make her feel "like a veritable savage" (Q 69). In Wharton, Zeena's pickle dish may call the domestic into question, but it does not challenge her humanity; rather, her attachment to it generates sympathy for a poverty so extreme that a pickle dish is the most valuable possession. Zeena derives personal pleasure from the dish, explaining her grief at its loss. For Helga, however, consumerism is imbricated with racism, denying any domestic comfort in household goods. If, as Felski argues, consumerism enables women to participate in modernism, that road offers a much less direct track to African-American women. Helga is not excluded from consumer culture; in fact, she lives, throughout most of the novel, in the lap of luxury, indulging in goods, clothes, and jewelry. The problem is that these expensive, beautiful objects fail to hold their value in a racist world since they serve to remind readers of the impossibility of employing them to establish a secure racial identity. Thus they reinforce modernist alienation, a realization that, as W.B. Yeats suggested, "the center does not hold."³⁰

Helga's attempt to find happiness through marriage and domesticity fails miserably for a number of reasons, including the allure of religion and the false promise of domesticity, both of which are aligned with a premodern world. In the aftermath of her questionable conversion, she "seemed to sink back into the mysterious grandeur and holiness of far-off simpler centuries" (Q 114). Retreating from the skepticism and complexity of modernity, Helga looks to faith, long a staple of premodern domesticity, to help anchor her. But

religion cannot heal the impact of white oppression, and Helga ultimately castigates not just herself but her fellow African Americans for believing in it. "How could ten million black folk credit it when daily before their eyes was enacted its contradiction?" (Q 130). If religion is traditionally a force that enables domesticity, especially in the face of poverty, Larsen documents the ways that twentieth-century racism reveals it to be a tool that "blunted the perceptions," thus miring African Americans further in disempowered domesticity (Q 133). While Helga comes to realize the emptiness of religion, Kimberly Monda suggests that her "process of self-reflection stops short, masking an even deeper layer of self delusion."³¹ Helga may fail to perform a full self-investigation, stopping short of a thorough modernist examination of the complex nuances of religion, but in documenting this failure, Larsen situates her as a modernist subject, seeking always and never finding.

Helga experiences the same problem with domesticity. "To be mistress in one's own house . . . to have a husband – and to be 'right with God' – what pleasure did that other world which she had left contain that could surpass these? Here, she had found, she was sure, the intangible thing for which, indefinitely, always she had craved. It had received embodiment" (Q 120). Modernist embodiment is always vexed, however, and Helga's embodied domestic life is one of failure and disorder, particularly with the onset of a difficult pregnancy. Giving birth in rapid succession destroys her health, and the novel ends, rather ominously with her fifth pregnancy in progress, which she is unlikely to survive. If the representation of modernist domesticity is inhospitable for women in Wharton and Cather, in Larsen it is deadly. As Helga very appropriately realizes, "the children used her up" (Q 123).

Wharton and Cather deftly sidestep, for the most part, the role of children in the domestic sphere, but for Larsen it constitutes the ultimate trap. This representation of ways that children prevent escape from the home strips the last vestige of sentimentality from domesticity. Wharton may have created space separate from family, but Larsen recognizes that for African-American women there is no

space that allows for a nondomestic existence. Partly due to her bifurcated racial identity, Helga can find no home. In the modernist celebration of the slipperiness of boundaries and the resistance to an unthinking private life, it is easy to forget that not all those living in the modern world enjoyed the privilege of existential angst, anxiety, and disruption. And yet, Larsen offers what is, in some ways, the most quintessentially modern perspective on domesticity, the difficulties of race adding layers of nuance and complexity, making it virtually impossible to articulate African-American domesticity in a world that does not recognize the value or sanctity of the African-American home. Keguro Macharia, tracing black nativism and queerness in the novel, concludes that, "as opposed to a nativist sense of being at home, of belonging, or of security due to color or ancestry, Larsen privileges a paradoxical sense of belonging as loss: part of an anonymous, moving crowd, one can only assert momentary presence."³² In true modernist fashion, the attempt to settle into domesticity brings only loss and anonymity, converting the domestic into the empty.

Domesticity may not serve the same function in modernity as it did in earlier eras, though, increasingly, scholarship on nineteenth-century fiction suggests that modernist domesticity represents less of a rupture than we might suppose. Nineteenth-century writers were hardly unaware of the various traps and disunities in the domestic realm. Pericles Lewis has observed, "Modernist experiments seldom simply destroyed or rejected traditional methods of representation or traditional literary forms. Rather, the modernists sought to enter into a sort of conversation with the art of the past, sometimes reverently, sometimes mockingly."³³ Modern women writers fully engaged in such conversations; they did not reject domesticity so much as they gave it a distinctively modernist twist. Fully imbricated with the instability and fragmentation of high modernism, modernist domesticity uncovers a space for women to participate in modernity – or to underscore their exclusion from it – and to establish that modernity and domesticity are mutually dependent, not mutually exclusive.

Notes

1. Blythe Forcey, "Domestic Fiction," in *The Oxford Companion to Women's Writing in the United States*, eds. Cathy N. Davidson and Linda Wagner-Martin (New York: Oxford University Press, 1995), 253.
2. Francesca Sawaya, *Modern Women, Modern Work: Domesticity, Professionalism, and American Writing, 1890–1950* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2004), 1.
3. Kaplan argues that the discourse of domesticity is complicit in the discourse of Manifest Destiny. Her insistence that the home was a site of participation in imperialism rather than a shelter from it inspires my claim that the home, some fifty years later, situated women within modernity as opposed to separating them from it. See Amy Kaplan, "Manifest Domesticity," *American Literature* 70:3 (September 1998): 581–606.
4. There are, of course, significant exceptions, too numerous to name. Of particular use to my analysis is Suzanne Clark's persuasive defense of the sentimental as functioning within modernism rather than in opposition to it. I make a similar claim for the domestic. See Suzanne Clark, *Sentimental Modernism: Women Writers and the Revolution of the Word* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1991). See also Betsy Klimasmith, *At Home in the City: Urban Domesticity in American Literature and Culture, 1850–1930* (Durham: University of New Hampshire Press, 2005), and Kristin J. Jacobson, *Neodomestic American Fiction* (Columbus: Ohio State University Press, 2010). Jacobson argues that domestic fiction continues throughout the twentieth century, developing into an ever more destabilizing genre by the latter part of the century.
5. Nathaniel Hawthorne, *Centenary Edition of the Works of Nathaniel Hawthorne*, vol. 17, *The Letters, 1853–1856*, eds. Thomas Woodson, James A. Rubino, L. Neal Smith, and Norman Holmes Pearson (Columbus: Ohio State University Press, 1987), 304.
6. Katherine Mullin, "Modernisms and Feminisms," *Cambridge Companion to Feminist Literary Theory*, ed. Ellen Rooney (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2006), 145.
7. Virginia Woolf, *A Room of One's Own* (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1957), 77.
8. Thomas Foster, *Transformations of Domesticity in Modern Women's Writing: Homelessness at Home* (New York: Palgrave, 2002), 2.
9. While most recent scholarship has interrogated the doctrine of separate spheres, noting that such divisions were not as absolute as some have suggested, it nevertheless carries a certain analytical weight. The September 1998 special issue of *American Literature*, "No More Separate

- Spheres,” challenges the value of the paradigm. As Cathy Davidson questions in her preface, “[W]hy is the metaphor of the separate spheres both immediately compelling and ultimately unconvincing as an explanatory device?” See Cathy Davidson, “Preface,” *American Literature: No More Separate Spheres!* 70 (September 1998): 444. The special issue launches a full exploration of the inadequacy of the separate sphere metaphor, yet this attention also perpetuates it as a critical device.
10. Jennifer Haytock, *Edith Wharton and the Conversations of Literary Modernism* (New York: Palgrave, 2008), 13.
 11. Robin Peel, *Apart from Modernism: Edith Wharton, Politics, and Fiction before World War I* (Madison, NJ: Fairleigh Dickinson University Press, 2005), 11.
 12. *Ibid.*, 12.
 13. Susan Fraiman, “Domesticity beyond Sentiment: Edith Wharton, Decoration, and Divorce,” *American Literature* 83 (September 2011): 480, 481.
 14. *Ibid.*, 281.
 15. *Ibid.*, 288.
 16. Edith Wharton, *Ethan Frome* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1996), 14. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*EF*).
 17. Louisa May Alcott, *Little Women* (New York: Penguin Books, 1989), 434.
 18. Liesl Olson, *Modernism and the Ordinary* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2009), 3.
 19. *Ibid.*, 4.
 20. Qtd. in Elizabeth Ammons, “The Myth of Imperiled Whiteness and *Ethan Frome*,” *The New England Quarterly* 81:1 (March 2008): 17.
 21. Willa Cather, *The Professor’s House* (New York: Vintage, 1990), 186. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*PH*).
 22. John N. Swift, “Unwrapping the Mummy: Cather’s Mother Eve and the Business of Desire,” *Willa Cather and the American Southwest*, eds. John N. Swift and Joseph R. Uργο (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2002), 14.
 23. Rita Felski, *The Gender of Modernity* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1995), 64–5.
 24. Elizabeth Festa, “Conveniently Situated Museums: The House Museum Movement and Modernist Interiority in Willa Cather’s *The Professor’s House*,” *Arizona Quarterly* 67:1 (Spring 2011): 76.
 25. Mark Sanders, “American Modernism and the New Negro Renaissance,” *The Cambridge Companion to American Modernism*, ed. Walter Kalaidjian (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2005), 129, 130.

26. See Hazel Carby, *Reconstructing Womanhood: The Emergence of the Afro-American Woman Novelist* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1987), 23–34.
27. Ammons, “The Myth of Imperiled Whiteness,” 9.
28. Sanders, “American Modernism,” 137.
29. Nella Larsen, *Quicksand and Passing*, ed. Deborah E. McDowell (New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press, 1986), 67. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (Q).
30. W. B. Yeats, “The Second Coming,” in *The Poems*, vol. 1 of *The Collected Works of W. B. Yeats*, ed. Richard J. Finneran (New York: Macmillan, 1983, 1989), 187.
31. Kimberly Monda, “Self-Delusion and Self-Sacrifice in Nella Larsen’s *Quicksand*,” *African American Review* 31 (Spring 1997): 37.
32. Keguro Macharia, “Queering Helga Crane: Black Nativism in Nella Larsen’s *Quicksand*,” *Modern Fiction Studies* 57 (Summer 2011): 271.
33. Pericles Lewis, *The Cambridge Introduction to Modernism* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 26–7.

The Matter of Modernism

*Energy, Stress, and Modernist Style**Enda Duffy*

How does modernism represent human physical well-being? Modernist literature, focusing often on the *flâneur*, the urban pedestrian wanderer, is also a literature adept at detailing, with an unprecedented interest and accuracy, every variety of human movement, sensation, and affect. This chapter explains how a nineteenth-century interest in scientifically observed human movement, suggested famously, for example, in the photo sequences by Eadweard Muybridge, developed into a medical fascination with exploring how movement read by machines could be the key to understanding human emotion. It points out that many modernist texts share the same logic: just as the scientists developed complex machines to measure breathing speed, heartbeat, and body heat, so too many of what we consider the most radical stylistic experiments of modernism annotate in detail the most subtle changes in characters' physical well-being. Further, modernist texts invariably defeat attempts to read them as love stories – which is to say that in modernism, the older protocols of emotion have largely been abandoned. This chapter claims that modernism's radical move is to lose interest in conventional trajectories of subjective feeling, to attend instead to human energy and its expenditure. “Deep feeling” is replaced by the ideal of a life lived intensely. Why did this change occur? With the rise of white-collar work, as service work of all kinds became a matter of emoting, feeling changed, and feeling's place on the map of bourgeois subjecthood had to be reconfigured. Further, with the coming of the global energy economy, and the age of oil and electricity, the subject's own energy became an obsession. “Stress,” a term for the management of personal energy, is one of the great

conceptual inventions of the interwar period. Modernist literature is the literature of stress.

To grasp how modernism portrays human energy expenditure, we must see that portrayal as a high point of a longer historical trajectory. Already, in 1833, Honore de Balzac was interested in the truths told by the rhythms of human energy expenditure. In his essay “Théorie de la démarche” (“The Theory of the Gait”),¹ he called the gait “the countenance of the body.” Balzac sees human movement as a topic deserving of literary attention; a century and a half later, Jacques Lecoq, a gymnast who became the great theorist of French mime, in his book *Le Corps Poétique*, of 1987,² cites Balzac’s continuing inspiration. Between Balzac and Lecoq the interest in observing human movement grew exponentially. First, consider the photographic experiments of Eadweard Muybridge and Jules Marey, with their sequences of human and animal movement. They were succeeded by the medical scientists who, near the end of the nineteenth century, developed machine after machine with esoteric names to make ever-more precise measurements of human exertion and reaction: in 1884, Angelo Mosso’s ergograph, for example, could track the twitches of each human finger. Gilles de la Tourette, who gave his name to Tourette’s syndrome, in 1886 marked rolls of paper on which patients walked with powdered feet, to precisely record their gait.³ Between the novelist of the 1830s and the 1980s’ mime-theorist, therefore, we witness work by some of the most innovative new media technologists, such as Marey and Muybridge, and by medical scientists, such as Mosso and Tourette, attending to the issue of how we move – human locomotion. At the climax of this attention to human movement, we have, in literature, the craze for texts about *flâneuses* and *flâneurs* that characterizes high modernism: Woolf’s *Mrs. Dalloway*, Musil’s *The Man Without Qualities*, Kafka’s *The Trial*, Mann’s *Death in Venice*, Eliot’s “Prufrock.” In Joyce’s *Ulysses* we have two characters, Stephen and Bloom, whose chief activity is their gait, characters who on a single day cover mostly on foot between them almost thirty miles.⁴

Why, in modernity, was there all this interest in walking, and in how the walk, or any other human movement, might be observed?

Lecoq suggests one answer, when he speaks of the “continuous back and forth between motion and emotion.” To humanist scholars this sounds convincing, since we are trained to read human movement allegorically – we might read Clarissa Dalloway’s tripping gait in *Mrs. Dalloway*, for example, as evidence of her refusal to be cowed by what she senses is her husband’s disinterest. The nineteenth-century scientists, however, were innovative precisely in refusing such allegorical readings. What they saw in motion, scientifically observed, was something simpler than emotion – it was simply the expression of human energy. In considering the historical development of this area of inquiry, we can see that it had profound implications: it meant nothing less than the recasting of the concept of human well-being from one of an “inner” life that is emotionally complex to that of an embodied life of energy and intensity.

A brief survey of the scientists’ interventions makes clear that their interest, focused initially on human physical movement, gradually evolved to encompass first subtle reactions, then emotions as evidenced in such movement. Through the nineteenth century, with their camera apparatuses and measuring machines, scientists’ emphasis was on the mechanics of motion. Gradually, the machines grew more sensitive: Griesbach’s aestheisometer measured changes on the skin’s surface. As subtle movements, such as sweating, or a rise in heartbeat, could be measured, the scientific attention turned from movement to excitability, and even more, as Anson Rabinbach explains in *The Human Motor*,⁵ to the issue of “Neurasthenia,” or “nervous fatigue.” This was rapidly applied to whole cultures: George Beard published *American Nervousness* in 1881,⁶ and, connecting this lack of energy to the pressures of the modern world, the emerging field of sociology, in the work of Ferdinand Tonnies, Émile Durkheim, and Georg Simmel,⁷ adopted it as a basis for theorizing modern metropolitan alienation. From this ferment, in such settings as Jean-Martin Charcot’s clinic in Paris, emerged modern psychiatry. The flourishing field of scientific clinical-physiological observation, however, continued in parallel, with findings possibly even more pervasive in modern culture, with the issue of emotion increasingly impinging upon the studies of human

motion. Darwin's final book, *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals* of 1872,⁸ showed the way. In William James's key essay "What Is an Emotion?" of 1884,⁹ James sides with the physiologists by insisting that an emotion is first experienced upon the body, and that the emotion is one's sensation of that experience. James, then, sees the emotion as the perception of the body's sensation – of one's feeling of one's visceral energy. This work was continued by Walter Cannon, whose *Bodily Changes in Pain, Hunger, Fear and Rage* appeared in 1915,¹⁰ where he wrote about such sensations as dry mouth, and on "The Energizing Influence of Emotional Excitement." The implications are psychological, but the physiological takes precedence. Whereas the nineteenth-century scientists had been concerned with muscles, the twentieth-century focus was on glands, especially the adrenal gland and adrenaline. Further, if fatigue had been the "other" interest earlier, by the late twenties the new century had found its version: stress, named by Canon but described by the Canadian-Hungarian doctor Hans Selye in 1936.¹¹ Stress is more than fatigue or even neurasthenia: its symptoms range from the inability to concentrate, to agitation, rapid heartbeat, overeating, nervous habits. In this condition, the human body cannot quite control its energies, is turned against its own efficiency, is stressed.

This is a brief account of how, beginning with movement studies, mostly male scientists colonized a whole new area of research – the terrain of emotion, which had up to then, in modernity, been left to culture, and cast also as the concern of women. With the arrival of science the zone previously designated "feeling" and cast as leisure was now rethought as energy and recast as work. In this change-over, the model of artistic feeling that valorized "depth" and suggested that "deep feeling" was more significant, was forsaken for a model of energetic reaction, which valorized intensity. Further, the scientific categories did not remain within science: many of the scientists' books, from Beard's *American Nervousness* on, became bestsellers, as the scientists, especially Beard and Selye, set out to popularize their findings, with tremendous success. Culminating with "stress," this science saw its new categories rapidly adapted as social truths.

With this scientific history in mind, we may grasp why, for example, Leopold Bloom, who walks and walks – until, when you think about it, he must have used up every last ounce of energy he possessed – gets to be the Energizer bunny of modernism. Yet as energy-user on foot, in modernism he is hardly alone. All the modernist *flâneurs* – Stephen in *A Portrait* and *Ulysses* along with Bloom, Musil's *The Man Without Qualities*, almost any of Kafka's heroes, Mann's Aschenbach in *Death in Venice*, Virginia Woolf's Mrs. Dalloway crossing St. James' Park and Bond St., Djuna Barnes' Dr. O'Connor in *Nightwood* – are metronomes marking the rhythms of the new energy economy. They appear on the cultural scene at the moment in the history of science when the interest in mechanics is giving way, via work on fatigue and neurasthenia, to the interest in excitability – when muscle measuring is being superseded by the discovery of secretions of glands. In a moment, we will consider how the horizon of this energy economy was not just scientific alone. First, however, let us take seriously the mechanics of the gait of these *flâneurs*: consider how Muybridge's camera, or the medical machines of Mosso or Tourette, would have seen the walk of Mrs. Dalloway or Leopold Bloom.

In this pedestrian-centered energy modernism, Joyce's Leopold Bloom in *Ulysses* is exemplary. Yet given how much walking he does, it is surprising how little sense readers have of Bloom's gait – of how he walks. For much modernist writing, the gait is the assumed baseline; it would only be in film, especially comedy (think of Charlie Chaplain) or in late modernism (as in Beckett) that the gait becomes fully visible. In *Ulysses*, as the stream-of-consciousness perspective is often Bloom's, we hear of others' gait, which he watches, while he (and we) remains unconscious of his own. In "Calypso," on Bloom's very first stroll of the day down Dorset St. the first memorable walk we hear of is that of the maidservant: "To catch up and walk behind her if she went slowly, behind her moving hams."¹² Later, Bloom remembers and tries to imitate her gait: "How did she walk with her sausages? Like that something. As he walked he took the folded *Freeman* . . . and tapped it at each sauntering step against his trouserleg" (*U* 5.47–50). Here

we are invited to contemplate how the girl walked, and to imagine Bloom imitating her walk, all evoked with just one tantalizing adjective, “sauntering.”

Only one sentence in “Calypso” annotates Blooms’ walk: as he crosses to the sunny side of Eccles St., we hear that “[h]is eyelids sank quietly often as he walked in happy warmth” (*U* 4.81). Bloom’s actual gait, which would characterize his chief activity, walking, and might, in Balzac’s terms, tell us “the truth . . . of the man” is one activity of his that is taken for granted, and not described in detail, in the book.

Compare this, for example, to the minute attention given the gait in Beckett’s *Watt*:

Watt’s way of advancing due east was to turn his bust as far as possible towards the north and at the same time to fling out his right leg as far as possible towards the south, and then to turn his bust as far as possible towards the south and at the same time to fling his left leg as far as possible towards the north¹³

Or consider the attention given to the gait of the most characteristic black-suited *flâneur* of all modernist art, Charlie Chaplain. Chaplain *is* his spread-toed gait – and his gait is a comedic parody of the gait of every *flâneur* of the modernist period. How, then, did Bloom walk? We do get a number of accounts, for example, by the narrator in “Cyclops,” but each is vague. When Bloom is watched in “Wandering Rocks,” he is standing still, at a bookstall. As we don’t get to see Bloom’s gait very much, it is naturalized to the point of erasure. Similarly Bloom, after all these miles, is not noticeably exhausted, his feet don’t ache or his bunions hurt. Yet when he encounters Blazes it is by his gait that he recognizes his tormentor: “Yes it is. The Walk. Not see” (*U* 8.1171). This walk is later described: “By the provost’s wall came jauntily Blazes Boylan, stepping in tan shoes and socks with skyblue clocks to the refrain of *My girls’ a Yorkshire girl*” (*U* 10.1240–2). Blazes steps jauntily, but how does Bloom step? Not knowing, but well aware he walks, the novel implies a mostly unremarked-upon rhythm of human locomotion as the baseline for lived life itself. Bloom, walking, engages in

continuous physical exercise as the basis for living. Yet Joyce does not have us see him in the way Muybridge beholds his walkers, or cinema did Chaplin. The transparency of Bloom's gait means that in *Ulysses*, physical movement, as locomotion, is both evidence for and guarantee of life. This is utterly in keeping with the materialist approach of scientific inquiry into human movement at the same period: the basic premise of that scientific inquiry, likewise, was that movement, in action and reaction, was the primary evidence of life. This movement, furthermore, means that it is the expenditure of energy – not the push and pull of emotion (as in the Victorian novel) – that is marked in *Ulysses* (through the mostly unremarked-upon *flâneur's* gait) as the novel's basic preoccupation.

Ulysses, in characteristic mode for a modernist novel, dwells on energy expenditure rather than on accounts of how emotions were developed, altered, matured. It pursues this by complimenting the largely unportrayed but ever present walk in *Ulysses* with, careful accounts, first, of other physical locomotive movements, and second, of Bloom's and others' repeated cessation of movement, whether in sitting, relaxing, or lying prostrate. First, *Ulysses* offers time and again almost scientifically accurate and complete accounts of complex physical movements. Here is one small example, from "Calypso":

While his eyes still read blandly he took off his hat quietly inhaling his hairoil and sent his right hand with slow grace over his brow and hair. Very warm morning. Under their drooped lids his eyes found the tiny bow of the leather headband inside his high grade ha. Just there. His right hand came down into the bowl of his hat. His fingers found quickly a card behind the headband and transferred it to his waistcoat pocket.

So warm. His right hand once more slowly went over his brow and hair. Then he put on his hat again, relieved. (*U* 5.20–8)

This is close to the annotations for the moves in a ballet. It is narration as scientific observation of the least physical gesture; it is utterly narrative of movement in the wake of Muybridge and his movement studies. It is also related to a new cinematic innovation of the day – slow motion. Like slow motion, it casts movement itself, incredibly closely observed, as utterly profound. In *Ulysses*, with the

base rhythm of the walk invisible, a slow-motion-like attention to movement of limbs, torsos, heads, and hands becomes the feast for the readerly mind's eye, while our ear hears the voiceover of stream-of-consciousness. Choreography intercuts sensing and thinking.

This is perhaps even more evident when characters sit. Bloom in fact sits a lot in *Ulysses* – almost as much as he walks: in the carriage in “Hades,” on the barstool in “Lestrygonians,” in the dining room in “Sirens,” at the table in “Oxen,” and so on. He sits, but does he relax? Most sitting is uncomfortable in *Ulysses*. In “Hades,” for example, “Mr. Bloom entered and sat in the vacant place All waited. Nothing was said I am sitting on something hard. Ah, that soap: in my hip pocket. Better shift it out of that” (*U* 6.9, 21–3). And a few moments later: “Martin Cunningham began to brush away crustcrumbs from under his thighs All raised their thighs and eyed with disfavour the mildewed buttonless leather of the seats Mr. Bloom set his thigh down” (*U* 6.95–6, 100–1, 106). Here, sitting is twisting, is torsion. The torsion of seated characters in modernist fiction might remind us of the figures in the paintings of one of the greatest twentieth-century painters, Francis Bacon; there is a refusal to imagine stillness, to represent repose. Gerty sits, strains back; Bloom, in the Ormond, refused to sit and listen to the song. Even when Stephen lies on the ground at the end of “Circe,” and Molly lies in her bed, each twists: Stephen “[s]tretches out his arms, sighs again and curls his body” (*U* 15.4944), while Molly, clambering out of bed, cries, “O Jamesy let me up out of this” (*U* 18.1128–9). This flexing and torsion of human bodies – which culminates when Stephen “whirls giddily” (*U* 15.4151) in the brothel before his dead mother and “lifts his ashplant high with both hands and smashes the chandelier” (*U* 15.4243–4) – all in a feverish climax of physical energy expenditure as body movement poetry, much of it carefully annotated, makes *Ulysses* a Bacon-like hall of mirrors, where the poetry of human body movement begs to have its energy measured as the index of the text's significance.

This choreography-narrative, in different registers for each author, marks the page-by-page preoccupations of much modernist fiction. However, this detail works only to record movement at the

level of muscle, as human mechanics, just as the nineteenth-century researchers explored it. It is in annotating the finer gradations of energy expenditure, in the movements in the most subtle changes in bodily temperature, sweating, blushing, and excitability, which was the purview of the turn-of-the-century researchers such as Mosso and Tourette, that the modernist textual experimentations of writers such as Joyce and Woolf also excelled. If the novel slows into slow motion to delineate the details of complex movements of limbs, as when Bloom removes his hat, it turns to telegraphese to transmit these subtler changes. Here is my key claim: it is in its painstaking efforts at the tracking of somatic changes on the bodily surfaces of the characters that generated a whole host of the stylistic novelties that are the central and most characteristic pleasures of the text. Each modernist writer developed his or her own novel stylistic telegraphese to transmit this kind of minutely observed data; the different forms each author generated marks the “signature style” of each of them. In each writer’s work, we see the styles strain to delineate minute somatic changes, a straining that often verges on self-parody. Recall in *Ulysses* the first mention of Bloom’s walk: “His eyelids sank quietly often as he walked in happy warmth” (*U* 4.81). This remarkable piece of Joycean poetry is as accurate as anything devised in the new machines measuring the minutest human physical reactions that were being devised in the same period. The alliterative “walked . . . warmth” here leads us back to a key trope of the episode: the pleasing sense of heightened body temperature that accompanies Bloom’s morning sleepiness. Here, the sun meets Bloom’s body warmth and the heat generated by the walk: soon we learn that the walk, and his excitement at a girl running toward him, led to “his quickened heart.” *Ulysses* takes Bloom’s temperature subtly and often; this repeated temperature taking, along with the specific attention to the detail of the often-sinking (“quietly”) eyelids, attends as obsessively to embodied well-being as did the scientists.

The novel’s interest in changes in body heat is accompanied by consistent attention to heartbeat and rates of breathing. (Bloom is “breathless” among the newsboys in “Aeolus,” Molly in “Calypso” “gazed straight before her, inhaling through her arched nostrils”

[*U* 4.378-9].) Before *Ulysses*' final "Yes I will yes:" the second-to-last phrase notes: "And his heart was going like mad." This kind of writing, unprecedented in its attention to somatic reaction, is built on minute attention to the activities generated in the work of, and in reaction to, the activities of each of the five senses, as discussed by Sarah Danius.¹⁴ Yet it is much more than a carnivalesque celebration of the "lower" senses of smell, taste, and touch. The modernist textual tracking of sensory reactions and interactions, in many cases, constitutes the novels' drama. It means that *Ulysses*, *Mrs. Dalloway*, *The Rainbow*, and other modernist fictions are sensation texts. They are novels bent on tracking somatic, haptic reactions and nervous energy, and correspondingly less interested in grand dramas of feeling and emotion. Modernist fictions share a textual strangeness arresting in the first instance because it is developing ways of annotating, with unprecedented delicate exactitude, the haptic and somatic reactions, the system of nervous energy, of its subjects. Each text is a vast symptomology of such nervous tics, rates of breathing, grimaces, blushes, and heartbeats of its characters.

If modernism's textuality, first, performs a version of Muybridgian attention to human locomotion and torsion, and then a Tourettian attention to nuances of energy expenditure such as increased rates of heartbeat and variations in body temperature, we can see how its approach is attuned to that of William James in his essay "What Is an Emotion?" James's central point in that essay was that emotions do not follow from thoughts, but are first experienced as bodily reactions, when, then, registered, lead to a sense of the emotion. His essays explain well the affective character of various modernist stylistic innovations. As a facilitator of attention to the minutest bodily changes in sensation, *Ulysses*' textuality, for example, registering the minutest fluctuation in bodily temperature, heartbeat, tics, grimaces, itches, and discomforts, performs the work of registering that embodied reactive sensation which, for James, is the origin and reality of emotions. Joyce's *Ulysses* seems the perfect Jamesian text; Woolf's *Mrs. Dalloway*, with its different cadences to register even more sensitively the oscillation of somatic reaction, shares the same role. We are so attuned to valorizing the focus on

bodily experience in cultural artifacts that we might be tempted simply to celebrate such obsessive attention to bodily sensation too. However, it is precisely this valorization of the embodiment of emotion, whether in William James or in subsequent modernist authors, that needs to be questioned, and historicized.

What, apart from a new and lingering pleasure of the text, does this symptomological exactitude achieve? By championing the body (for him, rather than the mind or consciousness) as the machine that registers and generates emotions, James allies the sensory and the emotional in a way that appears to run contrary to the general trajectory of scientific modernity. This trajectory, with its basis in an investigation of the “mind-body problem,” appears to valorize the mind. James makes his deductions, in his essay, on the grounds of his own experience, relying on commonsense observation of his own body, deducing how his own feelings are generated, and then universalizing his findings. However, when we take into account the full medico-scientific-technological tradition – from Muybridge with his camera or Darwin observing facial muscles in *The Expression of Emotions in Man and Animals*, and further, extend that tradition back in time, for example, to Descartes, who himself read movement in the body as the evidence of the existence of the soul – we can see that, far from advocating a new version of primitivism in tune with post-Romantic culture, but now reallocated to the Western body, James was in fact very much keeping faith with a scientific project which wanted to believe that minutely observed bodily movement would offer access to various life mysteries. As humanists, we can succumb too easily to a romantic faith in the validity of the body’s experience. But we need to be most on our guard against what Theodor Adorno, critiquing Heidegger, called “the jargon off authenticity” in any of its forms. James, far from salvaging “emotion” in any “humanistic” terms from the cold intellectualism and mind-centered reductive rationalism of science, is in fact handing it over to medical science and its rapidly developing medical-technological protocols for deciding what emotion might be by minutely observing how it is “expressed” by the body in its expenditures of its energy. James, in this sense, radically redefines

“emotion” (and its synonyms, “feeling” and “affect”) in order to render it much more biological than had been previously thought, and thus more amenable to regulation under the medico-scientific and technological gaze. To the humanist, to say that an emotion must be experienced upon the body might seem to guarantee its “authenticity” or its “depth,” but, seen by the scientist, it merely guarantees its external observability, and thus its actual material existence through the evidence observable in subtle bodily movement.

Where does this leave the somatically and haptically attuned textuality of *Ulysses*, *Mrs. Dalloway*, and *The Rainbow*, each textual machines in key with James’s text? It is hardly a secret that critics have always had a central problem with how Joyce, for example, treats what we might call emotion, even to the extent that they are never sure if he treats emotion at all. Here lurk the simplest but the most pressing questions about the real impact of Joyce’s writing. Such questions include: Are Bloom and Molly in love? Do they still love each other? Does Bloom feel jealousy for Boylan? It was telling that at the heart of the 1984 revised edition of *Ulysses*, both its maker, Hans Walter Gabler, and the dean of Joyce critics, Richard Ellmann, both touchingly found “love” to be the “word known to all men,” by reintroducing to the printed text a phrase which in earlier editions had apparently been omitted. It was as if the Joyce industry, in all its years of existence, had been looking for the holy grail of true emotion which, truth be told, they had missed in Joyce, and secretly hoped that a new, improved *Ulysses* might at last deliver up. But what if what Joyce is doing is this: far from secretly importing into his book, as some claim, a medieval Dantean or Franciscan endorsement of *eros* or *agape*, or, even worse, signing off in his book on the family romance plot, he might be radically, even frighteningly, recasting the whole notion of “emotions” altogether, and, like the scientists, re-envisioning them merely as bodily sensations measurable as variations in the human expenditure of energy? The same question lurks at the heart of criticism of Woolf. It seems clear that Woolf’s interest in Clarissa in *Mrs. Dalloway*, for example, concerns not the family-romance questions of whether she loves or once loved her husband, the tiresome Peter Walsh or even her schoolgirl crush,

but how her nervous energy, gathering to a point in something like intuition, makes her empathize with the plight of a perfect stranger with his own uncontrollable and haywire energies, Septimus Smith. For Woolf and Joyce, the sensation of energy expenditure trumps “emotion” developed within familiar frames.

The key moments in *Ulysses* and *Mrs. Dalloway* are where a switching over occurs, in scenes where conventional emotions could be brought into play but the texts turn their attention to energy dispersal instead. Modernist texts set up scenes that (given our reading habits) appear to beg to be read in terms of conventional accounts of the modulation of feelings, the registration of motivations for those feelings, and the place they can be assigned in what we presume is an emerging arc of the emotional development, all the elements we would conventionally expect in a novel. Time and again in modernist texts, even though the conditions for just such registrations are set up, our readerly expectations are quashed, and, rather, we get to witness a quasi-scientific annotation of the exact nervous energy displayed. An example is the final page of “Lestrygonians” in *Ulysses*. Here, when Bloom spots his arch-rival Boylan come toward him in Kildare St., the text offers us a series of final joke-echoes of tropes from conventionally emotion-laden tales, while the real interest, and the real pleasure of the text at that moment, is the annotation of the physical symptoms of Bloom’s excitement.

Straw hat in sunlight. Tan shoes. Turnedup trousers. It is. It is.
His heart quopped softly. To the right. Museum. Goddesses. He swerved
to the right.

Is it? Almost certain. Won’t look. Wine in my face. Why did I? Too
heady.

Yes it is. The walk. Not see. Get on.

Making for the museum gate with long windy steps he lifted his eyes . . .
The flutter of his breath came forth in short sighs. (U8.1168–76)

Bloom, avoiding Boylan, seeks refuge under the plaster statues in the museum; notice here the intense back and forth between the dream of what the statues might represent, as the possibilities race across Bloom’s stream of consciousness, and the insistent monitoring of

his vital signs during the incident: "His heart quopped softly He swerved Wine in my face [W]ith long windy steps he lifted his eyes The flutter of his breath came forth in short sighs. Quick. Cold statues: quiet there My heart! His eyes beating Hurry. Walk quietly. Moment more. My heart" (*U* 8.1169–90). It is all here: the "eyes beating," the gait hurried but only implied, the rate of breathing and the breathlessness, the rise in temperature ("Wine in my face") and above all, the heartbeat, the "quopping heart." It is as if a doctor were monitoring Bloom's reactions, in the mode of Tourette, who measured gait by the impress of footprints on paper rolls. This precise, detailed, almost medical annotation is what we are granted instead of what we might expect: either an actual confrontation of Bloom and Boylan (which would have changed the whole course of the plot and rendered it a "love story"), or failing that (imagine how Henry James or Joseph Conrad would have handled this scene) a judicious reckoning of the motivations and implications of Bloom's cowardice. Is Bloom, if we don't quite hear about it, cowardly, or jealous? Or is he "merely" flustered, excited? Is Joyce inviting us to give up thinking about grand emotions such as jealousy, cowardice, love itself? If so, in favor of what? What does Bloom's "quopping heart" communicate to us about life in modernity? Likewise, in *Mrs. Dalloway*, when Clarissa learns of Septimus's suicide, we hear that "Always her body went through it her body burnt."¹⁵ Again, Woolf's novel first attends to Clarissa's flush, her rise in temperature. Walter Cannon's book title, *Bodily Changes in Pain, Hunger, Fear and Rage* (1915) comes to mind. Why the obsessive interest in this embodied emotion at this moment? And what did modernist literature have to add to the field already colonized by science?

To begin to consider the implications of the novel's sensitivity to an unprecedented break in the history of what we call emotion, let us note at once that excitability is not necessarily celebrated in *Ulysses* or *Mrs. Dalloway*. On the contrary, Stephen spins, waves both arms, and smashes the light, yes, but Bloom's evenness is the dominant note. Clarissa's resting, her lassitude, like Bloom's, is as important as her energy expenditure. And just as James's essay on the emotions

can help us understand the radical switching mechanism at work at the heart of *Ulysses*' and *Mrs. Dalloway*'s experimental textuality, subsequent scientific work on human energies, often by James's own students, can help us understand the modernist textual innovations that allowed the texts to focus on energy. Walter Cannon turned to what used to be called "the passions" in *Bodily Changes in Pain, Hunger, Fear and Rage*; he read the evidence for them visible upon the body, and studied how glandular secretions, particularly adrenaline, were implicated in producing these subtle bodily changes. Crucially, he explored how arousal, by whatever means, could induce the body to produce the recently discovered and synthesized hormone, adrenaline. Cannon, and such later figures as Hans Selye, theorized such emotions as fear and rage as affects that were both arousable and possibly suppressible. They posited an equilibrium or homeostasis, a kind of human energy reserve kept under control, as an ideal. The maintenance of this homeostasis itself required a continuous outlay of energy. This work to regulate one's level of stimulation in reaction to the stimuli of one's environment came, by the 1930s, to be called stress. Stress is the great invention of this whole tradition of the medical-scientific takeover of the emotions, and it immediately entered the popular lexicon. Stress is assuredly a modernist invention, yet it has virtually never been mentioned, let alone theorized as a topic in culture, by modernist scholars.

So, were Leopold Bloom, Mrs. Dalloway, or Gregor Samsa, Ashenbach, or Paul Morel stressed? Yes. *Ulysses* may be the greatest novel on stress ever written; "The Metamorphosis" its greatest treatment in a short story, *Mrs. Dalloway* its first full-dress treatment as a female complaint. (This is so, even if the term "stress" only began to be used in this sense a few years after these texts appeared.) Each of these narratives explores in detail one day or more lived under extreme stress. Stress is the term for the most important theorization of modern angst in the interwar years, and almost every key modernist novel is a stress text. Why has this not been noted before? "Stress," a term taken by the scientist-doctors from the field of physics (just as it adopted "pressure" from either metrological or the same physics language), has become so mundane and

pervasive a descriptor of how we think of our well-being that it has not been allowed entrée to the arms-hoard of literary-critical categories. Clearly “stress” presupposes a somewhat different relation of subject and environment than that envisaged under the aegis of the terms we do use: alienation, ennui, anomie. “Alienation” works as a “deep,” if pervasive, precondition of feeling and is in the last instance a mindful relation of subject and world; thus, despite its modernist novelty, it fits well with a tradition that specialized in atomizing “deep” emotion. Stress, on the other hand, is an account of observed matter, and the physical and energetic changes as it encounters its environment; it is therefore biological and physiological in basis. To claim that Bloom, Samsa, or Dalloway are “stressed,” therefore, is to read their reactions within the tradition from Muybridge to Selye, a medico-scientific tradition that recasts emotion and feeling as observable movement and physical symptoms, and then to judge these reactions against an improvised account of “balance” “homeostasis.” To get beyond such improvisations, we need to take over stress as a cultural category. Before stress was first named in 1936, how did people name their frustrations, angst, and exhaustion, and tension? Or was it that their levels of exhaustion, tension, and so on were simply less, or less perceptible because not yet named? Modernist culture was an arena for the generation of counterversions of the relation of subject to environment in modernity, and many of its literary artifacts take on board the new interest in well-being as physical energy dispersal, jettisoning narratives of emotional development. We might well ask why stress came to be invented in 1936, and why modern medicine became obsessed with observing human movement and excitation. To understand stress, we need to historicize it.

To begin this historicizing project, to see this new science in context, we need to draw back from the focus on the singularity of the Western subject, to discern instead a series of contexts situating that subject. These contexts include, first, the rise of white-collar work, where physical exertion nearly ceased to matter; second, the arrival of automation and new technologies, which again meant less physical exertion was needed; and third, the rise of the modern

energy economy to fuel these new machines, and hence the rise of a new kind of global resource economy with which the human energy of the Western bourgeois subject now had to realign itself.

First, note that this science developed as most Westerners were no longer engaged in physical work as a means of livelihood, but were being recast as “white-collar” (or, as they were initially known, “black-coated”) workers. Gregor Samsa the functionary, Bloom the advertising agent, Paul Morel in *Sons and Lovers* who is escaping his father’s life as a miner to become a teacher are paradigmatic here. The Victorian interest in muscular-physical locomotion began in the era of mass physical labor; it culminated in Taylorism and the assembly line. As these mass coordinations of efficient worker-movements were achieved, however, a new mass embourgeoisification was underway. As Westerners now became service workers, performing “persuasive” tasks such as selling and advertising, they were required to emote for a living, so that the annotation and regulation of their exact displays of emotion became a topic both in medicine and in the new cultural forms. Modernism, as the literature of this moment of mass embourgeoisification, could show the new mass middle class how to work their emotional, rather than purely physical, energy.

Second, as this class grew, it relied on a burst of new technologies to perform the physical tasks previously done by servants, laborers, and animals such as horses. The new machines expended “horse power” energy at an unprecedented rate – and demanded huge new energy sources to feed them. The most pervasive version of this in the modernist era was mass electrification, which was launched in the early twentieth century. Automation and electrification introduced the need for an energy economy. Not only was the topic pervasive; there emerged quickly the notion of this new technologically driven up-to-the-minute energy everywhere available, beside which human energy seemed puny and unreliable. On the first page of *Ulysses*, electricity is cited in just these terms, and as an alternative to the older version the “life force,” the soul: Buck Mulligan, in his parody of the Mass, compares the transubstantiation of bread and wine into Christ’s body, with the 1900s’ dream of revivifying bodies with electricity.¹⁶

Third, because fuel sources for all of this new energy would come in large part from some of the parts of the world that were colonies of Britain and the other European powers, the new global energy resource economy was rapidly being developed, and the place of the Western subject within it had to be recast. In brief, 1904 was the year when Halford Mackinder pointed out that now the whole world had been mapped, and the age of expansionist empire, with its cultural fantasies rooted in otherness, was over.¹⁷ At that moment, the modern realization that resources, especially energy resources, such as oil, were what mattered had arrived. Territorial imperialism gave way to energy imperialism. Ireland, prize of that older imperial mindset, could be jettisoned, and the Middle East became the key zone of imperial fantasy, as such modernist texts as *The Seven Pillars of Wisdom* (1922)¹⁸ would prove. In this new geopolitics of energy, the Western bourgeois had to reascertain his place as the modulator of his own energy. This was the task of modernist culture: to suggest to that subject how energetic she could be, to explore her role in the new energy economy, and to educate her in the potential pleasures of varieties of energy expenditure.

Given these tasks, what specifically do *Ulysses*, *Mrs. Dalloway*, and the other stress texts achieve? Do they teach the reader how to manage “stress”? Or do they put into question the very presumptions about the relation of organism to environment upon which the category of stress was conceived? What, in other words, was their complicity in the fast developing medico-scientific discourse of human energetics? Do they radically, even frighteningly, announce a kind of end of emotion, and the start of a new stage of sensing subjective well-being based on the valorization no longer of “deep feeling” but of energy, excitement, and intensity? Do they, to put it simply, announce an era in which what matters is no longer to “feel deeply” but to “live intensely”? Do they educate their readers in the use of energy, their own and others? Clearly, critical work remains to be done on these issues. A final thought: literature may always have been on the side of vitality, energy, and verve. As closing evidence, consider a very literary word: “tender.” Made famous by Keats, it was made safe for modernist literature by F. Scott

Fitzgerald, who took *Tender Is the Night* as the title of his most interesting novel. "Tender" encompasses the emotional *and* the physiological-embodied energetic. Categories such as "tenderness," in the face of stress, which we must search for in modernist novels, bespeak a new set of values regarding embodied energetics, which *Mrs. Dalloway*, *Ulysses*, and its ilk inaugurate.

Notes

1. Honore de Balzac, *Théorie de la démarche et Autres textes* (Paris: Albin Michel, 1990).
2. See Jaques Lecoq, *The Moving Body: Teaching Creative Theatre*, trans. David Bradby (London: Methuen, 2000).
3. See the highly suggestive essay by Giorgio Agamben, "Notes on Gesture," in *Means Without Ends: Notes on Politics* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2000), 49–62. It opens: "By the end of the nineteenth century the Western bourgeoisie had definitely lost its gestures," and goes on to describe Tourette's measuring device.
4. Hugh Kenner, *Ulysses* (Baltimore, MD: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1987), 24.
5. Anson Rabinbach, *The Human Motor: Energy, Fatigue, and the Origins of Modernity* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1992).
6. G. M. Beard, *American Nervousness, Its Causes and Consequences* (New York: G. P. Putnam's Sons, 1881).
7. See, for example, Georg Simmel, "Metropolis and Mental Life," *The Sociology of Georg Simmel* (New York: Free Press, 1950), 409–24.
8. Charles Darwin, *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals* (London: John Murry, 1872).
9. William James, "What Is an Emotion?" *Mind* 9 (1884): 188–205.
10. Walter Bradford Cannon, *Bodily Changes in Pain, Hunger, Fear and Rage: An Account of Recent Researches into the Function of Emotional Excitement* (New York: Appleton, 1915).
11. See, e.g., Hans Selye, *The Stress of Life* (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1956).
12. James Joyce, *Ulysses*, ed. Hans Walter Gabler (New York: Random House, 1986), 4.171–2. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*U*) by chapter and line number.
13. Samuel Beckett, *Watt*, (New York: Grove Press, 1953), 30.
14. Sara Danus, *The Senses of Modernism: Technology, Perception and Aesthetics* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2002).
15. Virginia Woolf, *Mrs. Dalloway* (San Diego: Mariner-HBJ, 1990), 184.

16. See Enda Duffy, "Ulysses Becomes Electra: Electric Energy in Joyce's Novel," *James Joyce Quarterly* 48 (Spring 2011): 407–24. On electricity and other infrastructure in Joyce and later Irish fiction, see Michael Rubenstein, *Public Works Infrastructure, Irish Modernism, and the Postcolonial* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2010).
17. For the impact of this essay on modernist thought, see Con Coroneos, *Space, Conrad and Modernity* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002).
18. T. E. Lawrence, *Seven Pillars of Wisdom* (Lane, Herts., UK: Wordsworth Editions, 1997).

Modernist Materialism: War, Gender, and Representation in Woolf, West, and H.D.

Anne Fernihough

In a well-known letter to Margaret Llewelyn Davies, the secretary of the Women's Cooperative Guild, Virginia Woolf describes the First World War as a "masculine fiction": "I become steadily more feminist owing to *The Times*, which I read at breakfast and wonder how this preposterous masculine fiction [the war] keeps going a day longer . . . I feel as if I were reading about some curious tribe in Central Africa."¹ The letter was written on January 23, 1916, just four days before the passage of the Military Service Act, which introduced conscription to Britain as a result of terrible losses on the Western Front. It testifies to Woolf's sense of estrangement from the war and everything it represented ("as if I were reading about some curious tribe in Central Africa"); more specifically, it testifies to the fact that, as a woman, Woolf felt that the war, as described by the columnists of *The Times*, could have no reality for her ("this preposterous masculine fiction"). In *Bid Me to Live*, the autobiographical novel which H.D., Woolf's contemporary, began writing in 1918, Julia, the character based on H.D. herself, ponders upon Martha, the woman who delivers milk to her door. Martha's husband has been killed in the Mesopotamian campaign in the Middle Eastern arena of the war. Julia feels the same sense of remoteness from events and the same sense of incredulity that Woolf evinces in her letter to Davies: "Martha's husband had lately been reported lost, swept off a raft in a river, Mesopotamia (Mespot, Rafe called it). Things like that were so utterly fantastic."² For Julia, who as a woman cannot experience the war at first hand, the Mesopotamian campaign takes on the qualities of fiction or fairytale ("so utterly fantastic"). Rafe is Julia's soldier-husband, based on the writer and poet, Richard

Aldington, to whom H.D. was married during the war years (they separated in 1919). His public schoolboy's habit of abbreviating names ("Mespot") seems in this case an attempt to tame or domesticate the horrors of war.

For H.D., as will be seen later in the chapter, war finds its way into the home but is never domesticated. Her literary responses to it, like those of Woolf and of Rebecca West, whose novel, *The Return of the Soldier*, was published in 1918, were unavoidably a contribution to what Allyson Booth has called "civilian modernism."³ But, as Stephen Kern has pointed out in his study of the modernist novel, most of the formally innovative male modernists were also, like their female counterparts, noncombatants, and rarely depicted the horrors of the trenches in their work. Like the three women novelists treated in this chapter, they approached the war obliquely, focusing either on the experience of those who did not fight or on those who fought but were most affected *after* the event as sufferers of shell shock or nervous exhaustion. Crucially, Kern also argues that this indirect approach was not just the result of not having fought. He believes that a vital component of the modernist project was a reassessment of the kinds of experience that could be appropriate subjects for art, and in particular an extraction of the "wealth of riches" to be found in the "seemingly trivial."⁴ Woolf's famous line in her groundbreaking, polemical essay, "Modern Novels" (1919), springs to mind: "Let us not take it for granted that life exists more in what is commonly thought big than in what is commonly thought small."⁵ Certainly, Woolf, West, and H.D. all convey the war through small, domestic, or quotidian things: a captive crab circling the bottom of a child's bucket at the seaside (Woolf's *Jacob's Room*); a glass tumbler rattling in a cupboard (Woolf's *To the Lighthouse*); nine window blinds permanently drawn (West's *The Return of the Soldier*);⁶ a kettle simmering on a gas ring (H.D.'s *Bid Me to Live*, 6, 43).

Woolf's phrase in the letter to Davies, "this preposterous masculine fiction," elides the distinction between the war itself and representations of it. Her letter as a whole raises questions about the relationship between war, gender, and literary representation, questions that would resurface time and again in her novels. "Have I the

power of conveying the true reality?" she asks herself in her diary after finishing *Jacob's Room* (1922), her third novel but her first radically experimental one at a formal level and the first to address the issue of the war.⁷ It marks Woolf's departure from "masculine fictions" of a different kind – the novels of H. G. Wells, Arnold Bennett, and John Galsworthy, writers she had dismissed as out-moded Edwardian "materialists" in "Modern Novels." In that essay and in the equally well-known "Character in Fiction" (1924), Woolf complains that these three writers pay too much attention to the material fabric of life, to what she calls "the alien and external," to such things as houses, railway carriages, furniture, and clothing: Bennett, for example, has "given us a house in the hope that we may be able to deduce the human beings who live there."⁸ David Bradshaw, however, in his chapter for this volume, "[Bootmakers and Watchmakers](#)," convincingly argues that Woolf's conception of Edwardian "materialism" was too narrow, and that the trio of writers she targeted in fact constituted a vital bridge between late-nineteenth-century naturalism and those novelists who have become central to our understanding of modernism (Joyce, Woolf herself, Lawrence, and others).⁹ Nonetheless, Woolf in her best-known critical essays urges writers to rid their novelistic space of the material clutter that the Edwardians have bequeathed to them. Alongside this, she is critical of the conventional plots of the novels of Bennett and his fellow materialists, their presentation of life in terms of linear, logical, and teleological structures. In a determined ontological quest, she urges writers to abandon such rational structures in favor of that "varying, . . . unknown and uncircumscribed spirit" that, in the terms of the philosophical vitalism popularized by Henri Bergson and others at the turn of the twentieth century, she sometimes calls "life" and sometimes "reality."¹⁰

Bergson's distinction between intellect and intuition, and between real time (duration) and spatial time, was to exert a huge influence on modernist aesthetics. Although it is by no means clear that Woolf had read Bergson at first hand, her critique of the Edwardian "materialists" shows strong affinities with his work. The linchpin of Bergson's philosophy was that each individual consciousness has

its own uniqueness and its own *durée* (time) but that we have refused to recognize this by confusing time with space. Our understanding of time as a sequence of hours and minutes, of interchangeable units, is, Bergson argued, really a spatial notion. It is part of our misguided tendency to approach psychic experience, consciousness, in terms borrowed from the perception of physical objects. The faculty responsible for this deleterious confusion, according to Bergson, is the intellect, which can only deal with the mind in terms of physical, measurable entities. In *Creative Evolution* (1907), he asserts that “the human intellect feels at home among inanimate objects, more especially among solids,” and that the abstract concepts on which the intellect depends are themselves, paradoxically, “formed on the model of solids.”¹¹ In line with this, the materialist novelist, in Woolf’s view, gives us a world that is simultaneously too abstract and too solid; in Michael Whitworth’s memorable phrase, it is a world of “hard science as well as soft furnishings.”¹²

This too abstract yet too solid world is also a world which Woolf frequently genders masculine. In *To the Lighthouse* (1927), Mrs. Ramsay, marveling at the public school education that her sons have enjoyed, contemplates “the masculine intelligence”:

A square root? What was that? Her sons knew. She leant on them; on cubes and square roots; that was what they were talking about now . . . she let it uphold her and sustain her, this admirable fabric of the masculine intelligence, which ran up and down, crossed this way and that, like iron girders spanning the swaying fabric, upholding the world, so that she could trust herself to it utterly . . . (TTL 115)

Woolf’s descriptions of “the masculine intelligence” as criss-crossing iron girders on the one hand, and “this admirable fabric” on the other, again suggests Whitworth’s “hard science and soft furnishings.” A square root is an abstract concept, yet here it is evoked as something solid that can be “leant on.” Mrs. Ramsay’s misplaced trust, however, is palpable. Ironically, the system of iron girders which she feels to be so sustaining is the same system that condemns one of her sons to a premature death in battle. For Woolf, as will be seen later, the “masculine fiction” of the war and the masculine

fictions against which she defines herself as a novelist share certain fundamental characteristics.

It could be argued, however, that Woolf and the other female novelists treated in this chapter (West and H.D.), forge a version of the modernist novel that incorporates elements of materialism rather than repudiating it completely. In a sense, they use materialism against itself in order to counter what they think of as a specifically masculine worldview. In doing so, they suggest the possibility of a different understanding of the modernist novel characterized, paradoxically, by a destabilization of Woolf's modernist/materialist opposition (or of what literary historians today would term a modernist/realist opposition: Woolf's term "materialism" never really caught on). Gregory Castle, in his introduction to this volume, draws a distinction within fiction between "the *expressed* world, the diegetic level of fiction that constitutes the 'world' of the artwork, and the *represented* world, the non-diegetic level of lived experience." As he explains, the represented world is manifested in what we tend to characterize as "realist" styles. He suggests, however, that some modernist novelists blur this distinction and are best understood in terms of what he calls "the dialectical engagement of convention and innovation." I would argue that this is true of Woolf, H.D., and, especially, West.

It has been a leitmotif of West criticism that her work is difficult to classify.¹³ This unclassifiability characterizes one of her very early pieces, the short story "Indissoluble Matrimony," first published in *Blast* in 1914. It is set in Edwardian suburbia but its central character, Evadne, is a deeply unsuburban suburbanite, an exotic figure in a prosaic setting. In a sense, she can be seen as a synecdochal representation of West's story itself in its fusion of materialist (realist) and modernist modes. The story oscillates wildly between the materialism of the suburban passages, full of solid, prosaic detail (the lawnmower lying outside the front door, for example), and the psychologically charged scenes at the lake on the moonlit moors lying just beyond the newly built houses. There is more than a hint of D. H. Lawrence (whom West admired, and whose *Sons and Lovers* had been published the previous year) in the sudden eruption of

hatred and violence in an ordinary setting, the sense of a deep undercurrent of emotion that pays no heed to conventional moralities, the recognition of the fragility of the “civilized” surface.¹⁴

When the war came, shortly after the publication of “Indissoluble Matrimony,” it didn’t just expose the fragility of the “civilized” surface; it threatened to erode completely the very distinction between civilization and savagery upon which it depended for its justification. It also threatened to dissolve many of the other oppositions underpinning the ideology of war: the idea that public battles must be waged to protect the privacy and sanctity of the domestic sphere, for example, which is exposed as a damaging myth by many of the female novelists addressing the issue of the war. It is worth noting that, as well as being popular novelists, all three of the male writers Woolf targets in her famous essays were members of the War Propaganda Bureau; all of them wrote numerous newspaper articles in support of the war. So when Woolf asks in a literary-critical context, “What is reality?” her question takes on a deeper resonance in the context of the war propagandists who see it as their prerogative, for the purposes of war, to dispense their version of reality as the official version.

At the young age of twenty-four, Rebecca West published *The Return of the Soldier* (1918). In this novel she sets out to dismantle the myths that feed war propaganda. Like H.D. and Woolf, she shows how the war is emotionally detrimental both to the men at the front and the women at home, but also like them, she suggests that the social relations prevalent during peacetime are themselves inherently violent, and that war is, in a sense, merely a monstrous extension of the structural violence of society that governs both public and private spheres in times of peace and war. Alongside her critique of the dualisms governing war propaganda runs a critique of the realism/modernism dualism that would come to exert such a hold, in academic circles, over the understanding of the fiction of the period.

The novel centers on the figure of Chris Baldry, the soldier of the novel’s title, who is sent back from the front to his ancestral home, Baldry Court, in a state of shell shock. In his absence, his home has been lovingly maintained for him by his young wife, Kitty, and his

cousin, Jenny, the narrator of the tale. It transpires, however, that Chris's shell shock has resulted in selective amnesia: he has lost all memory of the previous fifteen years, all recollection of and feeling for his wife and their immaculate home. In many ways, West's novel embodies Woolf's "admirable fabric of the masculine intelligence" criss-crossed by iron girders. It exemplifies the fascination with the material surfaces of things that so exasperated Woolf (but to which Woolf also succumbed in her own way),¹⁵ and it also adheres to a clearly defined plot, the climax of which is the "cure" that the psychiatrist manages to bring about for the shell-shocked Chris at the end of the novel. What makes West's novel modernist is the way in which she foregrounds and ironizes both the materialism and the adherence to plot, inhabiting these "realist" modes in order to defamiliarize them and to show how oppressive and hollow they have become in the wake of war.

Chris's wife and cousin attempt to envelop themselves in the prewar past by preserving as best they can the material conditions of Baldry Court as it was before war broke out. Nostalgia, the backward glance, is here rooted in material conditions. What is recalled is an interpretation (a deliberate misrecognition) of those conditions from the vantage point of another time and place. Using a realist style to "get it right" is as much a psychological necessity as it is an aesthetic prerogative. The early pages of the novel are characterized by lingering descriptions of the rooms and grounds of the Baldry estate. Jenny, the narrator, praises the work that she and Chris's wife have done in creating the perfect material environment for Chris: "I could send my mind creeping from room to room like a purring cat, rubbing itself against all the brittle beautiful things that we had either recovered from antiquity or dug from the obscure piles of modern craftsmanship, basking in the colour that glowed from all our solemnly chosen fabrics with such pure intensity that it seemed to shed warmth like sunshine" (*RS* 15–16). But all is not as it seems: the "brittle beautiful things" prove to be brittle in more than one sense. The novel opens in the nursery which, we learn, belonged to Chris's and Kitty's son who died in infancy and whose room has been kept as if he were still alive, but the rocking horse and all the

other cherished objects in the room cannot bring the dead child back. The fact that it is Chris who has requested the room be kept as it was hints at the mental fragility that will make him vulnerable to shell shock. When he returns to Baldry Court in a state of amnesia, in Jenny's words, "Strangeness had entered the house and everything was appalled by it" (*RS* 55).

The idea of strangeness entering the home is strongly suggestive of Freud's notion of "the uncanny" (*das Unheimliche*) as outlined in his ground-breaking essay of that name published shortly after the war in 1919. For Freud, the uncanny combines the alien and frightening with "what is known of old and long familiar": strangeness and familiarity coexist in the same phenomenon or experience.¹⁶ Chris is both recognizable and unnervingly foreign to the women who have been waiting for him (in Kitty's words, he is "our splendid sane Chris, all broken and queer" [*RS* 38]). In his turn, Chris feels unhoused within his own home on both a literal and metaphorical level, failing to respond to any of the improvements that have been made to its fabric during the fifteen-year period obliterated by his memory loss, just as he fails to recognize his wife. When war penetrates Baldry Court in the form of Chris's "strangeness," Jenny's and Kitty's faith in the material fabric of the house as something "to fall back on" (*RS* 120), their belief in it as "the impregnable fortress of a gracious life" (*RS* 121), is shown to be deluded. Here, as at so many points, West's novel seems to take on an autotelic dimension, hinting at its own disruption of realist/modernist, or materialist/modernist, boundaries. Chris is completely oblivious to the "clear pink and white of Kitty's chintz, the limpid surface of the oak, the gay reflected colours in the panelled walls" (*RS* 120), and in a striking reversal of conventional literary materialism, the furniture is imbued with consciousness, responding to Chris rather than vice versa: "the furniture . . . with the observant brightness of old well-polished wood, seemed terribly aware" (*RS* 54–5). It is telling in this regard that, as we saw earlier, it is "everything" in the house rather than the expected "everyone" that is appalled by Chris's deterioration ("Strangeness had come into the house and everything was appalled by it" [*RS* 55]). Other female

modernist novelists in the period use the same trope of furniture possessing consciousness. In *Mary Olivier* (1919), for example, May Sinclair, the pioneering stream-of-consciousness novelist, uses the bedroom in which Mary is born, with its “polished yellow furniture: the bed, the great high wardrobe,” as a marker of Mary’s psychological and emotional growth. Initially offering Mary sanctuary and a comforting sense of symbiosis with her mother, the room soon starts to resonate with a sense of loss and disillusionment. Before long the furniture within it becomes recriminatory, wielding the same emotional tyranny over Mary that her mother wields over her: “Prisoned in her mother’s bedroom with the yellow furniture that remembered. Her mother’s face remembered. Always the same vexed, disapproving, remembering face.”¹⁷

In West, this sense of disillusionment reveals a broader ideological critique. Disturbingly for Jenny and Kitty, Chris is not just indifferent to their domestic zeal on an aesthetic level; he is oblivious to what their efforts signify in terms of “a gracious life,” a phrase that carries strong class connotations. Shell shock has jolted Chris out of the bourgeois straitjacket into which he had been locked, making him immune to the class codes that governed his life before the war. His memory loss has caused him to regress, returning to a time when he had not yet acquired the burdens and responsibilities of his affluent bourgeois existence. On becoming shell-shocked, he seeks out his first and, it transpires, only true love, a working-class woman named Margaret whom he had known fifteen years earlier. She has since been living in suburban poverty and has become care-worn in appearance, superficially no match for Kitty. Once again, Jenny as narrator chooses the terms of literary materialism to express what she and Kitty experience as the trauma of Margaret’s reentrance into Chris’s life: Margaret is seen as “a spreading stain on the fabric of our life” (*RS* 37), paralleling the “red suburban stain” (*RS* 22) of new houses encroaching on the land near Baldry Court. When she comes to Chris’s home to tell his wife of his illness, Jenny, typically, responds to her in terms of her material aspect and what it represents in class terms. Making no attempt to disguise or moderate the intensity of her feelings, Jenny describes Margaret as “repulsively

furred with neglect and poverty" (*RS* 25), and frequent mention is made throughout the novel of Margaret's cheap and vulgar attire (as Jenny sees it): her "evil, shiny, pigskin purse" (*RS* 28); her umbrella with its "unveracious tortoise-shell handle" (*RS* 80); her "yellowish raincoat" (*RS* 99). Here West uses literary materialism against itself, and Chris's failure to "read" the material signs marks him out as a modernist in the making. He anticipates Woolf's claim in "Character in Fiction" that to capture the essence of Mrs. Brown we do not need to know "whether her villa was called Albert or Balmoral" or "what she paid for her gloves" (433). Just as the war has turned Chris into a modernist, so West turns herself into a modernist novelist in order to do justice to Chris's shell-shocked state.

When Chris is with Margaret, the boundaries of class and indeed of gender seem to dissolve, to melt away. Margaret enables a state of nondifferentiation, a "magic state," to use the narrator's phrase (*RS* 102). In what is arguably one of the most modernist passages of the novel, Jenny recounts what she sees to have been the nature of the relationship between Chris and Margaret fifteen years earlier. As Chris contemplates the young Margaret at her home on Monkey Island, he regards her as completely at one with her environment, undifferentiated from it, blending into her surroundings:

In the liquefaction of colours which happens on a summer evening, when the green grass seemed like a precious fluid poured out on the earth and dripping over to the river, and the chestnut candles were no longer proud flowers, but just wet lights in the humid mass of the tree, when the brown earth seemed just a little denser than the water, Margaret also participated. (*RS* 77)

The "liquefaction of colours" is echoed in the liquidity of the sentence itself; time seems suspended until the occurrence of the main verb at the end. When, fifteen years later, the shell-shocked Chris re-encounters Margaret, he immediately immerses himself back into this state of nondifferentiation: as Jenny observes, "they were . . . clinging breast to breast. It was as though her embrace fed him . . ." (*RS* 123). Chris's mental state suggests what the psychoanalyst Jacques Lacan has characterized as the pre-Oedipal phase,

where the child has not yet developed a sense of separation from the mother/other, from the rest of the world; the child has not yet entered what Lacan calls the Symbolic Order, the structures of meaning that govern our understanding of the world, meanings premised on oppositions and differences.¹⁸

A crucial part of the Symbolic Order for Lacan is gender difference, and it is noticeable that what Kitty and Jenny find most distressing about the shell-shocked Chris is that he is no longer playing "the man." The trauma he has suffered exposes his masculinity as a cultural construction, a performance, a role that he is no longer able to play. In turn, this places Kitty's and Jenny's "femininity," which they have so assiduously cultivated, in jeopardy. Indeed, this idea of gender as a performance or masquerade seems to be a leitmotif of First World War novels by women. A decade after the end of the war, in 1929, the psychoanalyst Joan Riviere published a paper entitled "Womanliness as a Masquerade" based on the case study of a female lecturer who, after giving a lecture, would put on a "mask of womanliness" by "flirting and coquetting" with her male colleagues to avert the "retribution" feared from them on account of her having usurped their position of masculine authority. Intriguingly, having established the idea of a mask, Riviere then breaks down the distinction between the mask and what lies beneath: "The reader may now ask . . . where I draw the line between genuine womanliness and the 'masquerade.' My suggestion is not, however, that there is any such difference; whether radical or superficial, they are the same thing."¹⁹ Stephen Heath, in his now classic response to Riviere's paper, draws out the implications of this: "In the masquerade the woman mimics an authentic – genuine – womanliness but then authentic womanliness is such a mimicry, is the masquerade." Heath goes on to emphasize the performative aspect of the masquerade, with the man as audience: "The masquerade is the woman's thing, hers, but is also exactly for the man, a male presentation, as he would have her."²⁰

In West's novel, we see Kitty self-consciously performing her femininity in a desperate attempt to gain Chris's recognition:

[S]he was dressed in all respects like a bride. The gown she wore on her wedding-day ten years ago had been cut and embroidered as this white satin was . . . I saw that her right hand was stiff with rings and her left hand bare save for her wedding-ring. She . . . sat down, spreading out her skirts, in an arm-chair by the fire. . . . So she waited for him. (RS 55–57)

Chris, however, fails to register his wife in any meaningful way, thus invalidating Kitty's femininity; not only this, but whereas, within the terms of Riviere's paper, masculinity is the given state, the authentic state, Chris's breakdown exposes it as a masquerade on a par with Kitty's. Lacan's term for this male display is *parade*, a particularly appropriate term given the military context here.²¹ Just as Heath argues that female hysteria is in effect "[f]ailed masquerade" ("The hysteric," he explains, "will not play the game, misses her identity as a woman"), so West shows how Chris's shell shock is in effect "failed parade": he misses his identity as a man.²² For a brief period, on being reunited with Margaret, he experiences a sense of oceanic oneness with the world, but, in a brutal gesture, his wife insists on having him "cured," wrenched back into what Jenny calls, in an almost oxymoronic phrase, "the whole hostile reasonable world" (RS 178). West's novel ends as a "masculine fiction" of sorts, with a plot that comes to a definite conclusion, but her deployment of plot and resolution is heavily ironic: the values that prevail at the end, most notably the hegemonic masculinity to which Chris has been restored, have during the course of the novel been exposed as empty and dehumanizing.

Woolf, throughout her career, was also fascinated by the idea of gender as performance, by the gap that separates biological sex from culturally acquired gender. In *Three Guineas* (1938), for example, she ridicules masculinity (Lacan's parade) in the form of military display: "Your clothes . . . make us gape with astonishment . . . every button, rosette and stripe seems to have some symbolical meaning."²³ *To the Lighthouse* opens with Mrs. Ramsay contemplating the sight of her youngest son, James, bent over a catalogue of the army and navy stores, cutting out pictures. His mother looks at "his high forehead and his fierce blue eyes . . . frowning slightly" and it

makes her imagine him “all red and ermine on the Bench or directing a stern and momentous enterprise in some crisis of public affairs.” We are told that James has already evolved “his private code, his secret language, though he appeared the image of stark and uncompromising severity” (*TTL* 7). A division between private code and public persona has already set in. It is telling that, just a few pages later, Charles Tansley, the would-be professor, faithful disciple of Mr. Ramsay, out shopping with Mrs. Ramsay, finds her staring in amazement at a billboard advertisement for a circus: “a hundred horsemen, twenty performing seals, lions, tigers . . .” (*TTL* 15). This comes just after Charles has been thinking “he would like her to see him, gowned and hooded, walking in a procession. A fellowship, a professorship, – he felt capable of anything” (*TTL* 15). The implication is that the one is just as much a circus as the other. Masculinity is seen here not just as performance (“gowned and hooded”) but as linear progress: when Charles pictures himself progressing from fellowship to professorship, he replicates Mr. Ramsay’s famous vision of his academic research in terms of a march through the alphabet:

[I]f thought . . . like the alphabet is ranged in twenty-six letters all in order, then his splendid mind had no sort of difficulty in running over those letters one by one, firmly and accurately, until it had reached, say, the letter Q. He reached Q. Very few people in the whole of England ever reach Q. (*TTL* 39)

Structurally, *To the Lighthouse* deliberately eschews teleologies of this kind, cultivating the arbitrary and the nonhuman. This is especially true of the “Time Passes” section of the novel where we read, for example, that “a board sprang on the landing” (*TTL* 142); or that “Now and again some glass tinkled in the cupboard as if a giant voice had shrieked so loud in its agony that tumblers stood inside a cupboard vibrated too” (*TTL* 145). There is, however, an oblique reference to the shelling of the war in this last observation, and just afterward we are told with brutal nonchalance in a parenthetical aside that “[A shell exploded. Twenty or thirty young men were blown up in France, among them Andrew Ramsay, whose death, mercifully, was instantaneous]” (*TTL* 145).

True to Woolf's often-quoted claim in "Modern Fiction" (the revised version of her 1919 essay "Modern Novels") that "there would be no plot, no comedy, no tragedy, no love interest or catastrophe in the accepted style" if the modern novelist "could base his work upon his own feeling and not upon convention," Andrew's death in battle is not treated as a tragedy or catastrophe nor as the climax of a particular plot or subplot.²⁴ Nonetheless, it reverberates throughout the remainder of the novel, as do the deaths of Mrs. Ramsay and Prue Ramsay, which are reported just as casually and parenthetically (*TTL* 140, 144); these deaths are submerged into the texture of the rest of the novel, becoming part of the novel's "consciousness." Bereavement, Woolf suggests, is not to be understood as a climactic "event" in a sequence of discrete occurrences. We are all affected by death at some point or another, but, so the novel shows, life, and consciousness, go on. Bergson's time philosophy again springs to mind. Although he is frequently associated with stream-of-consciousness writing, the metaphor he preferred for consciousness was that of a snowball: "My mental consciousness," he wrote, "as it advances on the road of time, is continually swelling with the duration which it accumulates: it goes on increasing – rolling upon itself, as a snowball on the snow."²⁵ The final, elegiac section of *To the Lighthouse* is "swollen" with the loss of Mrs. Ramsay and two of her children. Its climactic events are nothing more than the completion of Lily's painting (a painting she has been struggling with throughout the novel) and the eventual, successful journey to the lighthouse on the part of Mr. Ramsay and two of his surviving children.

Woolf's earlier novel, *Jacob's Room* (1922), had already challenged the idea of masculinity as linear progress. Jacob Flanders is the public school, Oxbridge-educated young man whose traditional upbringing will lead him to accept war as the natural and honorable next stage in his seamlessly linear passage through life. The absurdity is that the war proves to be the surest way of rupturing this linearity: rugby and Cambridge are followed by death in battle, and the ideology that has shaped Jacob ends up consuming itself. On the last page of the novel, Mrs. Flanders holds out a pair of Jacob's old

shoes, empty and with no one to step into them: a vital link in the patriarchal chain has been broken. *Jacob's Room* is a classic example of what Stephen Kern calls "realist presence giving way to modernist absence," Jacob's empty shoes being just one of numerous instances of his absenteeism from the novel (Kern counts sixty-four instances, classifying them according to five different types of absence: physical, cognitive, and so on). For Kern, these absences symbolize the almost one million Englishmen who were killed in the war, and the modernist technique of what he calls "conspicuous absence" enables Woolf to "assail the war and the men who caused it, rewriting the national master narrative from a story of patriarchal pomposity and progress to one of deadly hubris and decline."²⁶ While I would agree with Kern that, at one level, Woolf replaces a narrative of progress with one of decline, I would argue that she goes further than this by dispensing, at a formal level, with the sense of any causal sequence that would lead us to accept the war as an inevitable outcome for Jacob, whether it be a triumphant or a tragic outcome. In this way, she subverts her own idea of a "masculine fiction." The disconnections in the narrative, from paragraph to paragraph and within each paragraph, undermine any notion of a meaningful plot. As in *To the Lighthouse*, Woolf assiduously cultivates arbitrariness and the non sequitur, bringing the human and the nonhuman, as well as the animate and the inanimate, onto the same plane: "A garnet brooch has dropped into its grass. A fox pads stealthily. A leaf turns on its edge. Mrs. Jarvis, who is fifty years of age, reposes in the camp in the hazy moonlight" (*TTL* 117).

In *Mrs. Dalloway* (1925), the shell-shocked soldier, Septimus Smith, is also a cultivator of the non sequitur: "The sun became extraordinarily hot because the motor had stopped outside Mulberry's shop window."²⁷ Sir William Bradshaw, Septimus's psychiatrist, is the epitome of scientism and logic; his language is one in which such a non sequitur could never be uttered. He sees Septimus's tendency to "attach . . . meanings to words of a symbolical kind" as "a serious symptom to be noted on the card" (*MD* 105). Yet for Woolf, Bradshaw is symptomatic of a collective human madness, of what West had, in *The Return of the Soldier*, called

“the whole hostile, reasonable world” (*RS* 178). His repressive psychological regime is complicit with the war in its emphasis on manliness and competition, and in its adherence to rigid categories; it is a cause of, rather than a cure for, Septimus’s condition. Septimus, whose consciousness is evoked through synesthesia, non sequitur, and other techniques associated with modernism, can be seen, in a metatextual gesture on Woolf’s part, as a kind of “double” of herself as novelist. His mental state suggests what William James, in *Principles of Psychology* (1890), had called “mind-wandering,” where the mind is completely open to the swarm of sense data bombarding it at any moment. James distinguished between this “promiscuous” mental faculty and what he calls “selective attention,” a more discriminating faculty which makes practical, everyday life possible by singling out the particular things that might be useful to us and suppressing or editing out the rest.²⁸ This notion of “selective attention” was to become central to the way in which the realist aesthetic was presented by its modernist disparagers. I have argued elsewhere that there is strong evidence to suggest that James directly influenced Woolf’s famous claim in “Modern Fiction” that “[t]he mind receives a myriad impressions . . . From all sides they come, an incessant shower of innumerable atoms” (*MF* 160).²⁹ Woolf’s narrative technique mirrors Septimus’s shell-shocked consciousness in its openness to what James in *Principles* calls the “redundant and superabundant” nature of reality (*PP* 39).

It must be borne in mind that James was no advocate of mind-wandering, in life or in art, for he argued that we would not thrive, or even survive, if we gave in to the “promiscuous” faculty of mind. Instead, we would find ourselves “lost in the midst of the world” (*PP* 444) an apt description of Septimus, who conspicuously lacks the capacity for “selective attention.” Sitting in Regent’s Park with his wife, Rezia, he struggles with the myriad sense data vying for his attention:

Happily Rezia put her hand with a tremendous weight on his knee so that he was weighted down, transfixed, or the excitement of the elm trees rising and falling, rising and falling with all their leaves alight and the

colour thinning and thickening from blue to the green of a hollow wave, like plumes on horses' heads, feathers on ladies', so proudly they rose and fell, so superbly, would have sent him mad. But he would not go mad. He would shut his eyes; he would see no more.

But they beckoned; leaves were alive; trees were alive. (*MD* 24)

This responsiveness to the "superabundancy" of reality puts Septimus on a par with Woolf as modernist novelist. Conversely, Bradshaw, the psychiatrist, is the perpetrator of the kind of "masculine fiction" Woolf associated with the Edwardian novel, both in his emphasis on logic and in his reductively materialist approach to the life of the mind. For his patients, he prescribes "six months' rest; until a man who went in weighing seven stone six comes out weighing twelve" (*MD* 108).

Many of the themes and techniques that inform West's and Woolf's war novels also inform H.D.'s radically experimental, autobiographical novel, *Bid Me to Live*. It was probably begun in 1918, and was revised extensively before its very belated publication in 1960, just a year before H.D.'s death. As noted earlier, it centers on the relationship between Julia (based on H.D. herself) and Rafe (based on Richard Aldington, the imagist poet and H.D.'s soldier-husband). Like West and Woolf, H.D. is concerned with the impact of war upon female civilians, and even more strongly than either of them, she asserts a continuity between civilian and military experience, showing how war, far from protecting the domestic sphere, turns it into a war zone in its own right. The subtitle of her novel (*A Madrigal*) ironically evokes a Renaissance musical form that celebrates love in timeless, pastoral settings, but the novel is really about love trapped in and mangled by "the crucifying times of history" (*Bid* 1). Time and history intrude into Julia's and Rafe's bedsit in the metonymic form of Rafe's army wristwatch, relentlessly ticking away "inside its little steel cage" (*Bid* 8). Later in life, reflecting on herself in the figure of Julia, H.D. wrote, "I had accepted the Establishment. That is, I had accepted the whole cosmic, bloody show. The war was my husband."³⁰ The acceptance of the war is evoked symbolically when Rafe kisses Julia during a period of leave, and she realizes that he has "breathed a taint of poison-gas in her

lungs . . . He had coughed a little but then she said, 'It's the room, we should open the windows, it's stuffy in here'" (*Bid* 21).

The long first part of *Bid Me to Live* takes place in this one claustrophobic bedsitting room in central London, and H.D. pays the same attention to material detail as West in *The Return of the Soldier*. Again, there is an attempt to find meaning and solace, a sense of "reality," in material things; and, again, in what appears to be a metafictional dimension to the novel, material things prove unreliable, not just metaphorically but literally, as air raids threaten the contents of the room: "Chief in importance the room itself, the frame to the picture, the curtains that might at any moment part on carnage in Queen's Square. Three double rows of curtains hung in parallel pleats from curtain poles. Julia had hemmed them herself" (*Bid* 2). As in West's novel, too, the death of a child plays a central role, in this case the death of an unborn child. H.D. had suffered a miscarriage in 1915, which she attributed to the stress of war. In *Bid Me to Live*, Julia establishes a direct continuity between her miscarriage and an air raid:

Superficially entrenched, they were routed out by the sound of air-craft; she stumbled down the iron stairs . . . and bruised her knee. Just in time to see the tip-tilted object in a dim near sky that even then was sliding sideways and even then was about to drop. . . . My knee. It was a black gash, she might have broken her leg . . . She had lost the child only a short time before. (*Bid* 3-4)

The language here asserts a link between civilians at home and soldiers in the trenches: both are only "superficially entrenched" until they are "routed out" by the enemy. More poignantly, however, this passage draws an implicit analogy between a woman's body scarred by the ordeal of childbearing (in this case, ill-fated childbearing) and a soldier's body mutilated in battle.

In a further striking similarity to West and Woolf, H.D.'s Julia is obsessed by the notion of gender as performance. She frequently describes Rafe's wartime persona in terms of masquerade (or parade, in Lacan's terminology): in his uniform he is "dressed up, play-acting . . . war-time heroics" (*Bid* 91). The people who drift in and

out of her room are seen as actors in a play ("that play, that trilogy, that room with the three French windows and the curtains" [*Bid* 91]), some of them taking center stage while others are no more than "noises off." In the context of war, "Noises off" carries a double meaning: "The sound of shrapnel. The noises . . . off" (*Bid* 92). In a reversal of the breakdowns of Chris Baldry and Septimus Smith, who both prove unable to act the role of the soldier, Rafe, initially the sensitive poet, "colourates" (Julia's term) to an army officer: "That is my husband, that is the man I married. The stranger became singularly strange, his language, his voice, the thing he brought into the room. Well, can you blame him? He was colourating to what he was" (*Bid* 25). Again this is suggestive of the Freudian uncanny, the unnerving combination of the alien and the familiar that forces us to rethink the relationship between the two. Rafe as poet and Rafe as an army officer: which is the "real" Rafe and which is the alien cultural construction? Julia's matter-of-fact statement, "he was colourating to what he was," seems to collapse the distinction between the two, turning all identity into performance.

On the other hand, there is an implication in *Bid Me to Live*, as there is in *The Return of the Soldier* and *Mrs. Dalloway*, that the trauma of war jolts the individual out of all culturally constructed identities, especially those governed by gender. In this case, it is Julia, the woman at home, who is in effect the shell-shocked soldier, unable to play the feminine role. Frederick, the character based on D. H. Lawrence, assimilates her to the ancient Greek culture which so strongly influences her writing, and perceives her as "st[anding] by . . . frozen altars, very cold" (*Bid* 77). Her husband Rafe explains to her that, while he loves her on a spiritual level, he desires Bella, the woman who becomes his mistress and who is adept at acting out womanhood. If Rafe metaphorically "colourates" to his role, Bella literally colourates to hers: "Bella cried prettily. The tears spilled down her rose-tint and did not spoil the prettily put-on rose paint from the rouge box upstairs." Beneath the make-up, however, "there were other dimensions, layers of poison-gas, the sound of shrapnel" (*Bid* 61).

On a formal level, *Bid Me to Live* is far more innovative than *The Return of the Soldier*, and on a par with Woolf's most experimental

fiction. It fractures narrative perspective and chronology to convey the ever-shifting subjectivities of consciousness and the eruptions of the unconscious. Julia is ostensibly the novel's narrator, but she is grammatically split, oscillating between the first and third persons, experiencing herself from both inside and outside: "Julia saw the room. This is not my room . . ." (*Bid* 71). The text switches frequently and abruptly from interior monologue to free indirect discourse to more conventional, omniscient narration and back again, and time is manipulated in complex ways. Cultural references to historical periods far apart in time are superimposed on one another ("Punch and Judy danced with Jocasta and Philoctetes" [*Bid* 1]), undermining any notion of linear progress. Teleology is similarly subverted by the frequent refrain, "the war will never be over": "[S]he watched them, wondering when it would ever be over? (the war would never be over)" (*Bid* 54). Time becomes a continuous, suffocating present in which everyone is at war in one way or another.

For these three women novelists, then, questions of war, gender, and literary representation are inextricably bound together. If H.D., looking back in later life at her time as a young woman during the First World War, felt that she had, in her own words, accepted the war as her husband, she, like West and Woolf, uses the modernist novel as a way of divorcing herself both from the actual war and from the daily domestic battles she fought as a woman. All three writers saw literary realism as in some sense complicit with these battles and deployed formally innovative techniques to disengage themselves from the ideology of war and its repercussions in the domestic sphere. At the same time, all three of them remained at some level attached to literary realism, particularly to its reliance on the material world, taking what Woolf called the materialist novelist's "delight in the solidity of his fabric" (*MN* 32). Woolf uses the masculine pronoun here, but, like West and H.D., she adapted literary materialism to her experiences as a woman, and, like them, she used the material world in modernist ways, demonstrating that "solid" entities and objects (buildings, furniture, and domestic paraphernalia in general) do not have to be mute appendages to a realist

plot. Instead, they can articulate the most intense, subjective experiences, including the trauma of war. They can also, as we have seen, prove unreliable, at times seeming brutally indifferent to the human beings who seek meaning and solace from them. But this very indifference serves to emphasize the way in which the experience of war for the civilian left at home was often one of isolation, impotence, and fear.

Notes

1. *The Letters of Virginia Woolf*, ed. Nigel Nicolson with assistant editor Joanne Trautmann, 6 vols. (London: Chatto & Windus, 1980–83), II:76.
2. H.D., *Bid Me to Live*, ed. Caroline Zilboorg (Gainesville: University Press of Florida, 2011), 20. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*Bid*).
3. Allyson Booth, *Postcards from the Trenches: Negotiating the Space between Modernism and the First World War* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1996), 5.
4. Stephen Kern, *The Modernist Novel: A Critical Introduction* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), 14.
5. Virginia Woolf, “Modern Novels,” in *The Essays of Virginia Woolf*, vol. 3, ed. Andrew McNeillie (London: The Hogarth Press, 1988), 34. The essay is often referred to as “Modern Fiction,” the title it acquired on being revised by Woolf for publication in *The Common Reader* in 1925.
6. Virginia Woolf, *Jacob’s Room* (London: Penguin, 1992), 5, and *To the Lighthouse* (London: Penguin, 1992), 145; Rebecca West, *The Return of the Soldier* (London: Virago, 1980), 55. Subsequent references to these editions will be made parenthetically in the text (*JR*, *TTL*, and *RS* respectively).
7. *The Diary of Virginia Woolf*, ed. Anne Olivier, assisted by Andrew McNeillie (London: Penguin, 1979–85), 2:248.
8. Virginia Woolf, “Modern Novels,” 33; “Character in Fiction,” in *The Essays of Virginia Woolf*, vol. 3, ed. Andrew McNeillie (London: Hogarth Press, 1988), 432. “Character in Fiction” is often referred to as “Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown.”
9. In *Freewomen and Supermen: Edwardian Radicals and Literary Modernism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), I also argue that Woolf deployed a reductive notion of Edwardian materialism in order to promote her own literary agenda; see 23–4, 27–8.
10. For Woolf’s debt to vitalism, see Fernihough, *Freewomen and Supermen*, 89–91, 136, 204–7.

11. Henri Bergson, *Creative Evolution*, trans. Arthur Mitchell (London: Macmillan, 1911), ix.
12. Michael Whitworth, "Virginia Woolf and Modernism," in *The Cambridge Companion to Virginia Woolf*, eds. Sue Roe and Susan Sellers (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000), 151.
13. See, e.g., Bonnie Kime Scott, ed., *The Gender of Modernism: A Critical Anthology* (Bloomington and Indianapolis: Indiana University Press, 1990), 562.
14. Rebecca West, "Indissoluble Matrimony," in *The Young Rebecca: Writings of Rebecca West 1911–17*, selected and introduced by Jane Marcus (London: Macmillan, in association with Virago Press, 1982), 267. The story was first published in *Blast* I (London: John Lane) on June 20, 1914, 98–117.
15. See, for example, the short story, "Solid Objects," in *The Complete Shorter Fiction of Virginia Woolf*, ed. Susan Dick (London: Hogarth Press, 1989), 102–7.
16. Sigmund Freud, "The 'Uncanny,'" in *Writings on Art and Literature* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1997), 195.
17. May Sinclair, *Mary Olivier: A Life* (London: Virago, 1980), 13, 170.
18. See Jacques Lacan, *Écrits: A Selection*, trans. Alan Sheridan (London: Routledge, 1977), 67.
19. Joan Riviere, "Womanliness as a Masquerade," in *Formations of Fantasy*, eds. Victor Burgin, James Donald, and Cora Kaplan (London: Methuen, 1986), 38.
20. Stephen Heath, "Joan Riviere and the Masquerade," in *Formations of Fantasy*, 49, 50.
21. See *ibid.*, 56.
22. *Ibid.*, 51.
23. Virginia Woolf, "Three Guineas," in *A Room of One's Own and Three Guineas* (London: Chatto & Windus, 1984), 127.
24. Virginia Woolf, "Modern Fiction," in *The Essays of Virginia Woolf*, vol. 4, ed. Andrew McNeillie (London: Hogarth Press, 1986), 160. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*MF*).
25. Bergson, *Creative Evolution*, 2.
26. Kern, *The Modernist Novel*, 21, 22–3.
27. Virginia Woolf, *Mrs. Dalloway* (London: Penguin, 1992), 16. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*MD*).
28. William James, *Principles of Psychology* (1918; rept. New York: Dover Publications, 1950), 2:417, 447, 444, 284–9. Subsequent references to this edition and volume will be made parenthetically in the text (*PP*).

29. Fernihough, *Freewomen and Supermen*, 89–90.
30. H.D., “Thorn Thicket,” in *Magic Mirror; Compassionate Friendship; Thorn Thicket; A Tribute to Erich Heydt: An Annotated Scholarly Edition*, ed. Nephie J. Christodoulides (Victoria, BC: ELS Editions, 2012), 170. Underscored sentence occurs in the original.

CHAPTER I I

Serial Modernism

Sean Latham

Introduction

It is no longer possible to think about modernism apart from its emergence within the massive expansion of the periodical press that began in the Victorian era and reached its full bloom before the arrival of television in the mid-twentieth century. The golden age of magazines, in fact, coincides with what we now call “high modernism.” Where critics once thought of modernist literary form exclusively in terms of abstract style, we now have begun to realize just how deeply entwined it was with its material emergence in the magazine, a medium that existed in complex relationships with an array of legal, technological, social, and physical constraints. These included the introduction of new copyright laws; the changes in industrial technologies that reduced the cost of printed material; the rise of first national then international markets for print; the rise of what Richard Ohmann calls the “Professional Managerial Class” alongside rapid growth in leisure time that created a massive demand for fiction;¹ and finally a new professionalization of authorship itself, abetted by the vast influx of revenue created by magazine advertising. The set of formal innovations critics once associated exclusively with an elite literary modernism, in other words, were themselves simply part of a much larger revolution in the material forms and social practices that shaped the early twentieth-century cultural marketplace.

Put simply, magazines helped transform authorship into a fully realized and often highly profitable profession. Joseph Conrad looked across this vast new publishing landscape while at work on

Lord Jim for *Blackwood's Magazine* and wrote to a friend that "artistic pleasure is neither here nor there. Bread is the thing."² Three decades later Virginia Woolf in *Three Guineas* warned aspiring writers against "prostituting culture," fearful that the overwhelming demand for fiction had reduced writing to mere piecework labor.³ The magazines made writing into a profitable, international business, and while authors such as Woolf and Conrad may have been anxious about the effect on an older, romantic notion of aesthetic autonomy, they nevertheless found their own work deeply rooted in this print revolution. To fully understand modernism, therefore, we have to treat it as part and parcel of a newly networked culture, one linked not by fiber optics but by sheets of printed paper that entangled authors, readers, and editors in complex, often unstable configurations.

This chapter will focus on modernism as an artifact of print culture by treating the physical form of journals alongside the aesthetic forms we associate with modernism. This invites a new kind of formalist literary practice, one that remaps the traditional hierarchies of high and low, difficult and easy, elite and popular, local and global, new and old.⁴ At its most basic level, this will require us first to relocate modernism as a node within the larger network of print culture shaped by changes in copyright law, print technologies, and the globalization of aesthetic culture. Within this context, some of modernism's novelty becomes less the austere product of isolated genius than the historical consequence of material and legal changes that irradiated and mutated writing of all kinds. A merely historical or contextual reading of magazine form, however, is insufficient, so we will have to look as well at the specific formal constraints and affordances of the magazines themselves. The twentieth-century periodical, in particular, can best be understood as a collage: a vibrant, often chaotic collection of fragmented pieces that generate meanings far in excess of authorial control or editorial design. In this sense, nearly every magazine can be seen as a jumble of Eliotic fragments poised in dynamic juxtaposition with one another.⁵ In addition to their spatial forms, magazines also exist in a peculiarly temporal dimension since each issue connects to a series and thus

cannot be treated easily in isolation. At least part of modernism's own experiments with temporality – from Faulkner's ruptured chronologies to Joyce's weaving of epic past and quotidian present – arises, in fact, from the unique serial quality of the periodical. By examining these three key elements of the magazines – their historical context, their physical shape, and their embedded temporality – this chapter will contend that key aspects of modernist form are, in fact, indissociable from the form of the modern periodical.

Networks

Magazines were the first of what would become a series of global mass media, their radical expansion in the late nineteenth century followed quickly by radio, cinema, paperbacks, television, and now the Internet. Efficient mail services, international transportation networks, new printing technologies, and increased literacy rates enabled titles such as *Blackwood's*, *Scribner's*, *Munsey's*, *The Strand*, and *The English Illustrated Magazine* to reach enormous audiences. Industrialization and the introduction of first gas then electric lighting furthermore created more opportunities for all kinds of entertainments, but especially for reading in the newly found "leisure" hours of the evening and weekend. Perhaps the most significant development, however, was the development of half-tone printing, which allowed presses to produce inexpensive images and illustrations. The first of these images appeared in October 1869 on the cover of the *Canadian Illustrated News*, and soon newspapers and magazines alike began using this technique.⁶ A new kind of visual culture quickly began to take root as the tightly packed columns of print so distinctive of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries suddenly gave way to more dramatic layouts in which fiction, reportage, and news stories alike were all increasingly illustrated with photographic as well as hand-drawn images. As Laurel Brake and Marysa Demoor have argued, what changed for late-Victorian audiences was not the mere appearance of images in print, but "the sheer number of images with which they were being bombarded."⁷

The use of photographic images, in particular, created new kinds of visual and spatio-temporal arrangements. “Just as the instant transmission of information by the telegraph signaled the co-presence of distant space,” James Mussell argues, “so the [magazine] photograph captured in a mobile, reproducible form a moment when the camera and the scene photographed were brought together in time and space.”⁸ Such images saturated the pages of the magazines, sometimes occupying full pages or being set aside as “frontispieces” that could easily be removed and used decoratively. A picture of the adolescent Ezra Pound shows his walls thickly plastered with just such images, including a cover from Scribner’s Magazine.⁹ In *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*, the snobbish young Stephen Dedalus visits his aunt and watches with distaste as the woman “looked a long time at a smiling picture that was set” in the newspaper. She doesn’t even raise her eyes to greet her son, who, entranced by the image, “mauled the edges of the paper with his reddened and blackened hands, shouldering her aside and complaining he could not see.”¹⁰ Similarly, in *Ulysses* Bloom hangs in his bedroom an image of a nymph, “given away with the Easter number of *Photo Bits*: Splendid masterpiece in art colours.”¹¹ Thematically, modernist texts clearly register the importance of these mass circulated images that arrived in an extraordinary number of magazines, becoming a part of everyday domestic life for everyone from the working class family in *Portrait* to the middle-class Blooms, to the elitist Pound.

One reason these images proliferated so widely is that the media technologies behind them had been put almost immediately to use in advertisements. Richard Ohmann’s *Selling Culture* describes in detail the interlinked emergence of consumer goods manufacturing, advertising, and magazines. At the core of this new – and remarkably durable – alliance was the strategic decision to shift the editorial and production costs for a magazine away from subscribers and onto the industries that sought to use this popular medium to sell goods and services. This part of the magazine revolution began with Frank Munsey, who in 1893 cut the price of his *Munsey’s Magazine* from a quarter to a dime while dramatically increasing the number of

advertising pages. The results were extraordinary: in two years the magazine's circulation increased from 100,000 to 500,000 as his advertising revenue leapt from \$12,000 a year to over \$320,000.¹² Other publishers quickly followed suit and enormous new magazine ventures such as *Scribner's* and *McClure's* were launched while older magazines like *Harper's* quickly took up the new model. An advertisement in the August 1904 issue of *McClure's* claimed that "the big 8" magazines (*Scribner's*, *The Century*, *McClure's*, *The Cosmopolitan*, *Harper's Monthly*, *The American Monthly*, *Leslie's Monthly*, and *Munsey's*) had a combined monthly circulation of 2.3 million. "Select your mediums with utmost care," the ad urges, and understand that "STUDIED duplication is the secret of IMPRESSION in advertising."¹³ Then as now, advertising began to saturate aesthetic media – surrounding and financially supporting fiction, poetry, news, reviews, and reportage.

In a typical copy of *McClure's* in 1906, readers would find one hundred pages of editorial content surrounded by over two hundred pages of advertising, almost all of it accompanied by rich illustrations. Indeed, it's not entirely clear what the magazine was really selling: its own letterpress or the promotional materials that filled two-thirds of its pages. An advertising agent well aware of this phenomenon, Leopold Bloom pauses in *Ulysses* to reflect on the phenomenon. "It's the ads and side features sell a weekly, not the stale news in the official gazette."¹⁴ This passage appears in an episode set in a newspaper office, amid the thrum of printing presses and the chatter of linotype machines. And this episode itself first appeared in a magazine where readers' eyes might easily pass from Joyce's text to an illustrated ad for the Multiplex Hammond typewriter.¹⁵

The influx of advertising revenue and the massive expansion of global audiences for print culture meant that publishing became a large, complex industry with entirely new models of distribution, the most significant of which was the press syndicate. Generally credited to S. S. McClure, who founded the McClure Literary Syndicate in 1884, this system allowed newspapers and magazine editors in hundreds of different markets to pay small fees to reproduce fiction from a central service rather than trying to create (and fund) original

content of their own. Here's how McClure describes the system in his autobiography (a book ghost written by Willa Cather, one of his magazine's editors and contributors): "My plan, briefly, was this: I could get a short story from any of the best story-writers then for \$150. I figured that I ought to be able to sell that story to 100 newspapers throughout the country, at \$5 each. News was syndicated in this way, and I did not see why fiction should not be."¹⁶ This gamble proved an enormous success, making McClure himself wealthy and also an essential – though long overlooked – player in the development of transatlantic fiction. His syndicate paid authors such as Henry James, Joseph Conrad, and Conan Doyle hefty fees for stories that had already been published in England, essentially giving the authors an additional revenue stream. Similarly, magazines like *McClure's* and *Scribner's* also owned publishing houses, so they could first serialize works of fiction in their pages, then publish them as books that would again be advertised in the magazine. Other publishers were equally adept in developing ways to capitalize on the immensely profitable magazine market. H. L. Menken, for example, supported *The Smart Set* and its contributors with funds derived from the sales of several pulp magazines with titles such as *Saucy Stories* and *Parisienne*. These magazines often shared material or were rebound and distributed through newsstands so that, as David M. Earle notes, "it is possible that a Joyce story or a Pound poem could have ended up in a popular pulp magazine in a rural train station."¹⁷ The literary marketplace in the early twentieth century, in short, was a complex network of exchange and circulation through which a single story written in London or Paris might travel on dazzling and often still unmapped itineraries through quality magazines, pulps, and local newspapers across the globe.

These rapidly evolving media networks posed real challenges for writers who often found it impossible to track their numerous copyrights and thus the royalties owed to them. The laws in the United States, in particular, deliberately raised significant obstacles to European writers since the manufacturing clauses of the 1891 and 1909 copyright acts stipulated that authors could only preserve their American rights by having their work set and printed by domestic

publishers. This law helped fuel the magazine boom, in part, because periodicals allowed writers as diverse as Ezra Pound, Joseph Conrad, and Conan Doyle to secure valuable American copyrights and thus fend off pirates, “book-leggers,” and reprinters who sought to capitalize on the patchwork nature of intellectual property law in the period. Samuel Roth, for example, reprinted much of *Ulysses* in his magazine *Two Worlds Monthly* because its copyright had not been secured and indeed spent much of an often profitable career publishing works which had lost or never acquired legal protection.¹⁸

Joseph Conrad too struggled with the need to secure simultaneous publication of both *Lord Jim* and the stories from *Youth*. He complained, for example, that the slow printing of one magazine would “ruin me because the delay in sending proof of *Youth* to McClure made the copyright of that story fall through.”¹⁹ Similar problems emerged when he began writing *Lord Jim* – a piece he initially imagined as a short story for *Blackwood’s* that eventually grew into a sprawling, complicated novel. In 1899 he wrote to the editor, saying it was “very good of you to delay Jim’s app’ce out of regard for my American business.”²⁰ A year later, as the story continued to grow in length and complexity, he acknowledged to his friend, David Meldrum, that the pressures of serial publication might themselves be shaping the story, driving him to meet complicated, interlocking deadlines. “If one only could do without serial publication!” he complained. The problem, however, is that magazines were not merely a subsidiary or derivative form of publication, but were instead now at the very center of the publishing world. To write, in the early twentieth century, meant to write first and foremost for the magazines. Modernism, in other words, took shape in and amid this periodical culture that was shaped by complex legal, technological, and economic structures. Understanding some its key structural aspects – ranging from Joyce’s decision to serialize *Ulysses* in *The Little Review* to the complicated narrative shape of Conrad’s *Lord Jim* – requires us to take better account of these larger structural forces that shaped everything from the global dissemination of texts to the work habits of authors who fit their practices to engage this rapidly changing system of cultural production.

Spatial Form

Although part of a complicated system, magazines can also be read as aesthetic objects themselves, each issue a unique iteration in a series capable of producing a distinct set of effects. The still evolving field of periodical studies is only now beginning to theorize the ways in which magazines actually work to produce meanings of their own – the ways in which they become more than just containers of hermitically isolated texts, but instead dynamic, interactive systems capable of generating emergent meanings all their own. As Robert Scholes and Clifford Wulfman remind us in *Modernism and the Magazines*, the words “magazine” and “museum” share a common etymology: “both denoted institutions where things were stored, though *magazine* connoted goods and *museum* connoted objects of knowledge.”²¹ Museums developed their own scientific methods for ordering things, whereas magazines retained elements of apparent chaos and unpredictability – something readily evident, for example, when Joyce’s darkly urban short story, “The Sisters,” appeared in *The Irish Homestead* next to an advertisement for an electric milking machine. Similarly strange juxtapositions multiply throughout the magazine archive when we go looking for them, from the teeming pages of *Scribner’s* where ads for cars and travel seem to pick up (and sometime subvert) the stories to the more austere little magazines where a poem by Else Freytag-Loringhoven reveals the dada-like patterns of the “Cyclops” episode of *Ulysses*. As seemingly unordered containers for textual and visual things, in short, magazines exemplified their own distinctly modernist aesthetics of juxtaposition, recombination, and montage. To read them is to experience something like the “luminous halo” Woolf associated with modern fiction or what Joyce later called in *Finnegans Wake* the “collideroscape” of modernity – a term that links the randomly generated patterns of the kaleidoscope to the collisions of things, people, and experiences in our everyday consciousness.²²

Modernism itself, of course, can be understood as a “collideroscape” aesthetic that seeks to develop new expressive forms for describing the constant bombardment of seemingly random

sensation so characteristic of mass-mediated, urban life. Where writers like Joyce, Woolf, and Stein found reason for celebration, however, others resisted it fiercely – both in their writings as well as in their understanding of what a magazine was and could do. T. S. Eliot offers one provocative example, in part because *The Waste Land* evokes a kind of magazine aesthetic that emphasizes juxtaposition and fragmentation. Yet Eliot is famous – or perhaps infamous – for his own strong misreading of *Ulysses* as an essentially mournful book, its epic elements imposed, he insisted, as “a way of controlling, of ordering, of giving a shape and a significance to the immense panorama of futility and anarchy which is contemporary history.”²³ Rather than a collideroscape, in other words, Eliot finds the strong voice of an author imposing order on chaos. It should thus come as little surprise that the poet developed a theory of magazines that similarly insisted on the importance of editorial order, structure, and meaning. In an article entitled “The Idea of a Literary Review” that appeared in the 1926 *New Criterion*, he wrote that “even a single number should attempt to illustrate, within its limits, the time and the tendencies of the time. It should have a value over and above the aggregate value of the individual contributions. Its contents should exhibit heterogeneity which the intelligent reader can resolve into order.”²⁴ For Eliot, in other words, the magazine should be a lot like his vision of *Ulysses* and perhaps *The Waste Land*: an apparent collideroscape deeply underwritten by a powerful, stabilizing structure.

Like Eliot, Ezra Pound also sought to impose his own strong misreading on Joyce’s work, even as its first typescripts reached him for magazine publication. After receiving a copy of “Sirens” in 1919, he wrote at length to Joyce, wondering if *Ulysses*, the first few episodes of which he admired, had somehow gone astray. Confused, he asks, “Are you sending me this chapter because you feel bound to send in copy on time?” He then offers a laundry list of complaints about the apparent lack of focus: “It is too long. One can fahrt with less pomp and circumstance . . . Besides Bloom has been disproportionately on ??? or hasn’t he.” Finally he asks, “Where the hell is Stephen Tellemachus?” Like Eliot, Pound has missed the

point. Stephen disappears, in part, because he is fixed in Eliotic rigor, still trying to find in 1904 Dublin some order or myth that will organize all of existence. Bloom, however, is “myridminded,” and thus able to accept the contradictory contingencies of modernity.

Just as Eliot’s misreading of *Ulysses* might have had something to do with his theory of a magazine, so too does Pound’s. In a 1930 essay entitled “Small Magazines,” Pound insisted that good magazines must have what he calls “a program” – any program at all. “It is,” he asserted, “not so important that an editorial policy should be right as that it should succeed in expressing and giving clear definition to a policy or set of ideas.”²⁵ Like Eliot, Pound underestimates the innovative form of the magazine and its central importance to the aesthetic revolution of modernism. Despite their brilliance as editors, both of these poets finally treat the magazine as just another kind of book, one organized by the strong genius not of an author but of an editor. Thus a successful magazine, by their lights, comes to look like a museum in which readers are not allowed to handle the objects, not allowed to move them about or put them in alternative relationships with one another. This is perhaps part of what drove Pound himself to leave his editorial post at *The Little Review*, writing in a huff to Joyce that “the editrices [Margaret Anderson and Jane Heap] have merely messed and muddled, NEVER to their own loss.”²⁶ What he fails to recognize, of course, is that the mess and muddle of a magazine is precisely the point. It invites us to flip back and forth between pages, to create unanticipated (or at least unauthorized) connections, and to see in the advertisements, articles, essays, poems, and illustrations a figure for modernity’s complexity that need not resolve itself into “order,” “myth,” or “program.”

Other modernist writers, however, were more directly engaged with this distinctively magazine aesthetic. Consider, for example, William Faulkner’s novels, many of which place enormous demands on the reader to extract meaning from an often dazzling array of fragments that range from the overlapping narrators of *The Sound and the Fury*, to the maps and ledgers of *Go Down, Moses*. Like many of the writers in this period, Faulkner was a prolific writer for magazines who understood the ways in which they could

recontextualize and sometimes significantly alter his work. As I have argued elsewhere, one of his most searing short stories, “Dry September,” underwent a number of changes when it passed from his hands into those of his editors at *Scribner’s*. The opening sections of the piece were shuffled in a way that shifted the frame of the story away from its female protagonist and toward the collective violence of a building lynch mob. This structural change, which Faulkner retained when he later published the piece, then echoed through the January 1931 issue of the magazine in which it appeared, since it was framed by a memoir entitled “On Leaving the South” and a piece of investigative journalism decrying the abuse of black citizens by the state.²⁷ In this case, the magazine not only directly influenced the shape of the story, but also moved it into a complex rhetorical context that was entirely lost when it was later anthologized. Far from the “muddle” Pound lamented, the magazine here produces new kinds of readings that enrich the political, ethical, and social dimensions of Faulkner’s work.

Magazines, in short, not only helped shape or transform the conception, circulation, and reception of key literary works from the early twentieth century, but also give us a way to better understand the distinctive aesthetic practices of modernism itself. What is Eliot’s *Waste Land*, for example, if not a kind of magazine in which the jagged “fragments I have shored against my ruins” jostle against one another without easy resolution or synthesis?²⁸ Pound’s ever-mutating *Cantos* suggest a similar kind of formal experimentation with the periodical form, evident in their long serial publication as well as their chaotic mix of genres. Magazines run through the very DNA of modernism, their distinctive form magnifying and often anticipating its stylistic innovations.

Temporal Form

Modernism’s magazine aesthetic is perhaps most evident – and most directly engaged – in *Ulysses*, a book that explicitly shapes some of its key episodes around newspapers and the periodical press. Indeed, the book makes its first explicit break toward narrative innovation in

the “Aeolus” episode, where strange insertions – variously identified as headlines, captions, and commentary – interrupt the narrative to comment with increasingly satiric wit on the characters and events. This marks the beginnings of an invasive set of “techne” that transform the book into what Karen Lawrence calls an “odyssey of style.”²⁹ An odyssey, however, implies a homecoming and it’s by no means clear that *Ulysses* reaches any kind of resolution or ending. Instead, as the long day of 16 June draws to a close, so too does the book, with none of the traditionally novelistic problems it poses (marriage, adultery, reconciliation, maturation) resolved. Instead, like a magazine, it simply ends, appearing to us as merely one term in an ongoing series. It is the story of merely one day and presumably the next day and the next will yield epic odysseys of their own. Thus as Bloom reflects on his wife’s affair with Hugh Boylan, he realizes that each man imagines “himself to be first, last, only and alone whereas he is neither first nor last nor only nor alone in a series originating in and repeated to infinity.”³⁰

This icy meditation on seriality – on the succession of what the book goes on to call the “perpetual motion of the earth through everchanging tracks of neverchanging space” – evocatively describes an essential aspect of modernism’s magazine aesthetic.³¹ As I have already argued, one way to understand periodicals as a medium in their own right is to learn to read them spatially by exploring the strange or surprising juxtapositions that can open new readings of familiar texts. Such a reading depends on treating the magazine as a singular, autonomous object. This interpretive strategy, however, captures only one half of what makes magazines – and the forms of modernism they helped produce – unique. After all, as Bloom recognizes at the end of *Ulysses*, magazines are a form built around seriality, around their own entangled place in a sequence that extends backward and forward in time. As Margaret Beetham argues, “each number must function both as part of a series and as a free-standing unit It is both open-ended and end-stopped.”³² To write for the magazines in the early twentieth century was to write in this strange temporal situation. It should, therefore, come as little surprise that modernist writers found themselves obsessed with

questions of temporality, identity, and the difficulty of finding an end. Conrad's work on *Lord Jim*, for example, becomes for him precisely a question of how to impose an ending on a work that began as a story then grew into a serial novel. He sometimes expressed a hatred for his magazine writing, which he thought wasted his "brain and nervous force"; but the strange structures of the serial had powerful aesthetic effects that we have yet fully to measure. Conrad himself glimpsed this when *Lord Jim* was being prepared for publication as a book. Suddenly aware of all that would be lost when removed from its original temporal context, he wrote to William Blackwood to ask if it would be possible "to dispense with the word *Chapter* throughout the book, leaving only the Roman numerals." This is not merely an eccentricity, but a recognition of the burgeoning modernist forms embedded within *Lord Jim*. "After all," he continues, "these divisions (some of them very short) are not chapters in the usual sense each carrying the action a step further or embodying a complete episode. I meant them only as pauses – rests for the reader's attention while he is following the development of *one* situation, only *one* really from beginning to end."³³ Conrad's quibble over the word "chapter" is an attempt to make evident at the level of form the kinds of temporal structures woven into *Lord Jim* as it emerged in the spiraling seriality of the magazine – a distinct media form that helped give both material and temporal structure to a still nascent modernism.

The magazines that played so essential a role in the rise of literary and aesthetic modernism did not fare well as a succession of other new media rapidly took their place and moved these print artifacts to the margins of our critical attention and cultural archives.³⁴ Seriality as an expressive form took other shapes, first in the pulps and then in film, comics, and eventually television. The digital turn in literary scholarship, coupled with the radical expansion of critical practices associated with the New Modernist Studies, has now begun to reverse this neglect, in the process opening up dynamic new ways of thinking about modernism's boundaries, innovation, production, and reception. Archives such as the Modernist Journals Project³⁵ allow us the chance to explore the spatial and temporal effects of

periodicals on aesthetic form, while new theoretical work emerging from within the digital humanities offer us new models for reading texts that cannot be exclusively understood within the isolated autonomy of the book. Scholes and Wulfman have influentially claimed that modernism began in the magazines. But this chapter has tried to make an even more ambitious claim: that modernism cannot be fully thought or understood apart from the magazines. Some of its most basic innovations – a fascination with time, a focus on the everyday, and a widely dispersed fragmentation of realist narrative – are not merely aesthetic effects. They are instead essential to the medium of the periodicals. Magazines of all kinds, from coterie journals to pulps to quality journals, were themselves a kind of modernism and only now can we begin to track their essential role in the staggering cultural and aesthetic innovations of the early twentieth century.

Notes

1. Richard Ohmann, *Selling Cultures: Magazines, Markets, and Class at the Turn of the Century* (London: Verso, 1996), 118–74.
2. Joseph Conrad, letter of January 3, 1900, in *The Collected Letters of Joseph Conrad: Volume II, 1898–1902*, eds. Frederick R. Karl and Laurence Davies (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983), 237.
3. Virginia Woolf, *Three Guineas* (San Diego: Harcourt Brace & Company, 1938), 97.
4. For a detailed argument about the way modernism establishes and evades these basic oppositions, see Robert Scholes, *Paradoxy of Modernism* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2006), especially 3–32.
5. James Joyce, in fact, once famously imagined himself as a kind of magazine editor rather than writer, telling his friend George Antheil in 1931 that “I am quite content to go down to posterity as a scissors and paste man” – from *The Letters of James Joyce*, vol. 1, ed. Stuart Gilbert (London: Faber, 1957), 297.
6. For a detailed history of this innovation, see David Reed, *The Popular Magazine in Britain and the United States, 1880–1960* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1987), 27–49.
7. Laurel Brake and Marysa Demoor, “Introduction: The Lure of Illustration,” in *The Lure of Illustration in the Nineteenth Century: Picture and Press*, eds. Brake and Demoor (Hampshire: Palgrave MacMillan, 2009), 12.

8. James Mussell, "Science and the Timeliness of Reproduced Photographs in the Late Nineteenth-Century Periodical Press," in Brake and Demoor, 204.
9. This image is reproduced in A. David Moody, *Ezra Pound: A Portrait of the Man and His Work*, vol. I (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), 144.
10. James Joyce, *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* (New York: Viking, 1964), 67.
11. James Joyce, *Ulysses* (New York: Vintage, 1986), 4.
12. These figures are cited by Reed, *The Popular Magazine*, 67.
13. Advertisement in *McClure's Magazine* 23, no. 4 (August 1904): 48h.
14. Joyce, *Ulysses*, 98.
15. Advertisement in *The Little Review* 5, no. 6 (October 1918): n.p.
16. Willa Cather, *The Autobiography of S. S. McClure* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1997), 168.
17. David Earle, *Re-Covering Modernism: Pulps, Paperbacks, and the Prejudice of Form* (Surrey: Ashgate, 2009), 52.
18. For a full discussion of the way copyright laws helped shape the circulation and reception of literary modernism, see Robert Spoo, *Without Copyrights: Piracy, Publishing, and the Public Domain* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2013).
19. For a more detailed account of Conrad's negotiations with McClure and his syndicate, see, Katherine Isobel Baxter, "'He's Lost More Money on Joseph Conrad Than Any Editor Alive!': Conrad and McClure's Magazine," *Conradiana* 41, nos. 2–3 (2009): 114–31.
20. Conrad, letter of August 22, 1899, in *The Collected Letters of Joseph Conrad*, vol. 2, 194.
21. Robert Scholes and Clifford Wulfman, *Modernism in the Magazines: An Introduction* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2010), 46.
22. Woolf, "Modern Fiction" in *The Common Reader* (London: Hogarth, 1962), 189; Joyce, *Finnegans Wake* (New York: Viking, 1959), 143.
23. T. S. Eliot, "Ulysses, Order, and Myth," *The Dial* 75 (November 1923), rpt. *Selected Prose of T. S. Eliot*, ed. Frank Kermode (London: Faber and Faber, 1975), 177.
24. T. S. Eliot, "The Idea of a Literary Review," *New Criterion* 4, no. 1 (1926): 2.
25. Ezra Pound, "Small Magazines," *The English Review* 19, no. 9 (November 1930): 697.
26. Pound, letter of October 1920 in *Pound/Joyce: The Letters of Ezra Pound to James Joyce*, ed. Forrest Read (New York: New Directions Press, 1967), 184.
27. For a discussion of Faulkner and "Dry September," see my "Unpacking My Digital Library: Programming Modernist Magazines," in *Editing*

- Modernisms in Canada*, eds. Colin Hill and Dean Irvine (Toronto: Toronto University Press, 2015).
28. T. S. Eliot, *The Waste Land and Other Poems* (San Diego: Harcourt Brace, 1934), 431.
 29. Karen Lawrence, *The Odyssey of Style in Ulysses* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1981).
 30. Joyce, *Ulysses*, 601.
 31. *Ibid.*, 606.
 32. Margaret Beetham, "Towards a Theory of the Periodical as Publishing Genre," in *Investigating Victorian Journalism*, eds. Laurel Brake, Aled Jones, and Lionel Madden (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1990), 29.
 33. Conrad, letter of July 18, 1900, in *The Collected Letters of Joseph Conrad*, vol. 2, 282.
 34. As Robert Scholes and I have noted, archives and libraries of all kinds typically stripped all the advertisement from magazines before binding and shelving them, producing a "hole in the archive"; see Scholes and Latham, "The Rise of Periodical Studies," *PMLA* 121 (2006): 517–31.
 35. The Modernist Journals Project, www.modjourn.org.

*Translation and the Modernist Novel**Emily O. Wittman*

During a leisurely group picnic in the Breadalby chapter of D. H. Lawrence's *Women in Love* (1920), a young Italian woman announces that she has just read a beautiful passage in her novel: "It says the man came to the door and threw his eyes down the street." This line, clearly the literal translation of a foreign idiom into English, leads the rest of the group to a knowing "general laugh." The "little foreigner" identifies the novel as Ivan Turgenev's *Fathers and Sons*.¹ Lawrence's alter ego Birkin smugly notes that her book is an American translation, whereupon his friend Alexander declares that the text was translated from the French not the original Russian, making the young woman's edition a double translation: "'Ha! Of course – translated from the French!'" he concludes before looking "brightly around."²

This brief passage demonstrates twentieth-century readers' interest in foreign literature as well as their concerns about the proper way to translate it. It also attests to the role of Russian literature in the modernist imaginary. Finally, it implicitly indicates that Lawrence – himself a translator from the Italian and the Russian – held in high esteem Constance Garnett, the chief translator into English of nineteenth-century Russian literature at the time. Garnett translated directly from the original Russian, neither from earlier French translations nor, unlike Lawrence, in collaboration with a native speaker.³ Birkin's curt dismissal of the translation from the French with its howler suggests that there are better translations out there.

Although he denigrated most Russian novelists, Joseph Conrad admired Turgenev, whose work he encountered in Garnett's

translations. In 1917 he vehemently declared that “Turgenev for me is Constance Garnett and Constance Garnett *is* Turgenev [. . .] She has done that marvelous thing of placing the man’s work inside English literature.”⁴ Joseph Conrad lauded Garnett’s translations of Turgenev and also anticipated the influential role they would play in English literature. Twenty years earlier Henry James had similarly avowed a great respect for Russian literature and for Turgenev in particular. In his 1897 essay, “Ivan Turgénieff,” he anticipates the writer’s future impact on English-language literature: “There is perhaps no novelist of alien race who more naturally than Ivan Turgénieff inherits a niche in a Library for English readers [. . .] His position is in this respect singular; for it is his Russian savor that as much as anything has helped generally to domesticate him.”⁵ In James’s view, Turgenev would serve as the twentieth-century’s “novelists’ novelist.”⁶

Discussions about the merit of translations of Russian literature also appear in novels from the other side of the Atlantic. In F. Scott Fitzgerald’s debut novel *This Side of Paradise* (1920), Amory Blaine engages in a telling conversation with fellow student Burne, who attributes his own revolutionary views to a variety of writers, Tolstoy in particular. “‘You have me stumped, Burne,’ Amory confesses. ‘I’ve read “Anna Karenina” and the “Kreutzer Sonata” of course, but Tolstoi is mostly in the original Russian as far as I’m concerned.’”⁷ In Amory’s view too much is lost in translation for a non-Russian reader to profit much from reading it.

Russian literature, always subject to a delay in translation, gained immensely in stature in the early decades of the twentieth century. Those years saw the development of a craze for Dostoyevsky following the 1912 appearance of Garnett’s translation of *The Brothers Karamazov*. This translation in particular cemented Garnett’s reputation and, for many years, granted her a visibility highly unusual for English translators of fiction. As Conrad’s emphatic statement suggests, readers attached Garnett’s name to the Russian novels that she tirelessly translated. Lawrence, who would vehemently rail against Russian literature *in toto* in his later critical work, paid tribute to Garnett’s industry and passion in a fond description of her approach to translation: “She would finish a

page, and throw it off on a pile on the floor without looking up, and start a new page. That pile would be this high – really, almost up to her knees, and all magical.”⁸

Garnett’s translations were extremely influential for modernist novelists, many of whom widened the readership of Russian literature by praising it in their fiction as well as their critical writing. In *Green Hills of Africa* (1935), Hemingway identifies Tolstoy as the master whose short story collection *Sevastopol* taught him how to write about war.⁹ Ford Madox Ford went further in his praise: “It is useless to say that he is greater than Shakespeare, but has, in common with Shakespeare, the quality of being unapproachable, and he lacks some of Shakespeare’s faults.”¹⁰ Garnett’s husband Edward also expanded the readership of his wife’s translations by means of the myriad prefaces and commentaries he wrote during the thirty-five years that she spent translating approximately seventy volumes from the Russian.¹¹ As a critic for *The Bookman* noted in 1919, “Edward Garnett has gradually driven into the heads of the reading public the news that these works are not solely grotesque and ridiculous fantasies about unwashed madmen, but are astoundingly creative performances of the finest kind.”¹²

Edward Garnett also argued that Russian literature had “widened the whole scope and aim of the novel.”¹³ Constance Garnett’s translations indeed played a key role in the transition from Victorian letters to modernism, first as inspiration and later – due to their overtly religious concerns – as a foil. As Donald Davie notes, “[T]he awakening of the Anglo-Saxon people to Russian literature – something that happened between 1885 and 1920 – should rank as a turning point no less momentous than the discovery of Italian literature by the generations of the English Renaissance.”¹⁴ Garnett’s contemporaries considered her fluent translations eminently readable and faithful to their source. Although these translations were later subject to criticism and the original works retranslated multiple times, their influence cannot be overestimated. As Lawrence Venuti aptly notes, “the translation of a canonical text can itself acquire canonicity, becoming a standard by which to evaluate competing retranslations or to pre-empt them.”¹⁵

In 1921, Katherine Mansfield wrote to Garnett to express gratitude for her translation of *War and Peace*.

As I laid down my copy of *War and Peace* tonight I felt I could no longer refrain from thanking you for the whole other world that you have revealed to us through those marvelous translations from the Russian. Your beautiful industry will end in making us almost ungrateful. We are almost inclined to take for granted the fact that the new book is translated by Mrs. Constance Garnett. Yet my generation (I am 32) and the younger generation owe you more than we ourselves are able to realize. These books have changed our lives, no less. What could it be like to be without them!¹⁶

Mansfield knew well the trials of translation from her participation in the second wave of Russian translations published by the Woolfs' Hogarth Press in the 1920s and 1930s. These translations were, for the most part, co-translations by Samuel Solomonovich Kotliansky and a variety of well-known modernists, including Mansfield, the Woolfs, and Lawrence. Kotliansky, or "Kot," a Russian Jewish émigré, translated the Russian texts into cribs. Kot's cribs were in turn revised into elegant English by his co-translators. Mansfield, Kotliansky, and Leonard Woolf's translation of Maxim Gorky's *Reminiscences of Tolstoy, Chekov, and Andreev* (1934) was published by Hogarth after Mansfield's death. Her letter to Garnett is thus a letter of praise but also a nod from an aspiring translator to an established and celebrated one.

Mansfield's glowing acknowledgment of her generation's debt to Garnett was followed by more complicated, if enthusiastic, responses from other modernists, most notably Virginia Woolf. In "The Russian Point of View" (1925), despite her lifelong dedication to Russian literature and her own translations of Dostoyevsky, Woolf questions whether, for all their enthusiasm, "the English can understand Russian literature." Furthermore, she argues, her contemporaries' enthusiasm for Russian literature has been formed by "critics who have never read a word of Russian, or seen Russia, or even heard the language spoken by natives; who have had to depend, blindly and implicitly, upon the work of translators." Like Fitzgerald's Amory Blaine, Woolf bluntly questions the value of

translation. In her view translations are “stripped of style,” leaving only “a crude and coarsened version of the sense.” She speculates that the depredations of translation account for the “simplicity, the humanity” praised by readers of Russian literature.¹⁷ Like Mansfield, Woolf knew intimately the trials of translation from her work with Kot. Published by Hogarth in 1922, the same year as *Ulysses* and *The Waste Land*, were her co-translations of Dostoyevsky’s *Stavrogin’s Confession* and *The Plan of the Life of a Great Sinner*. This work certainly enhanced her appreciation of the difficulty of translating overall.

Another significant 1922 publication was Ivan Bunin’s *The Gentleman from San Francisco and Other Stories*; the first story was revised by Lawrence and the final three by Leonard Woolf. The financial success of these Russian translations enabled the Woolfs to transform Hogarth from a cottage industry into an established publishing house that would publish translations of work by, among others, C. P. Cavafy, Rainer Maria Rilke, and Italo Svevo. Since the early translations were “more the apparatus of memoirs, letters, diaries, and commentaries surrounding [novels],” they did not, unlike Garnett’s translations, primarily introduce new writers but rather “reinforce the cult of personality surrounding Dostoyevsky, Tolstoy and others.”¹⁸ If Garnett gave modernists the famous Russian novels, Kot and his co-translators introduced them to lesser-known writers and important supplementary texts.

Despite such initial pessimism, Woolf acknowledges that translated works, those “[m]en reft of their coats and their manners, stunned by a railway accident,” are able to say new things to readers and to be heard. Readers are more ready, she concedes, to give translated works credence, precisely because of their bewilderment. The translations in question do not conclude “in a way that we recognize.” Because of this, she argues, they “raise the question of our own fitness as readers.”¹⁹ Tolstoy looms large here as a writer whom readers might usefully find “alien, difficult, a foreigner.”²⁰ Woolf thus links questions about translation with timely concerns about the value of difficult literature.

Just a few years earlier, in the 1921 essay “Modern Fiction” (penned in 1919 as “Modern Novels”), Woolf had reflected on the impact of these translations on contemporary writers. With particular attention to Joyce’s early innovations, she connects developments in recent English-language literature with Russian literature: “The most elementary remarks upon modern English fiction can hardly avoid some mention of the Russian influence.”²¹ For Woolf the overwhelming merit of Russian literature lies in its shared sadness and inconclusiveness that leaves readers in a state of “resentful despair.”²² It is the persistence of despair and inconclusiveness, not any stylistic template, that Woolf identifies as the influence Russian literature had on contemporary experimental writing. This is certainly true of Woolf’s own fiction. For instance, Roberta Rubinstein argues that Woolf’s encounter with Russian literature “stimulated her break from tradition.” She calls attention to the first chapter of Woolf’s novel *Orlando* (1928), in which the eponymous character meets a mysterious androgynous Russian princess whose “aura of intrigue,” Rubinstein argues, is “analogous to the mystery that Russia and its literature held for the English.”²³

Garnett’s and Kot’s translations also offered modernist novelists a literary model to embrace and then reject. Although a fan of Garnett and a co-translator with Kot, Lawrence’s later rants against “Russianitis” offer the most arresting examples of this phenomenon.²⁴ An enthusiastic budding scholar of the Russian language, Lawrence wrote an eager 1917 letter to Kot: “I feel that our chiefest hope for the future is in Russia [...] Send me a Berlitz grammar book.”²⁵ However, Lawrence came to reserve unmitigated ire for what he perceived as the Russian novelists’ shared commitment to life-denying Christianity. In a 1936 review of V. V. Rozanov’s *Solitaria*, he bemoans “morbidly introspective Russians, morbidly wallowing in adoration of Jesus, then getting up and spitting in His beard, or in His back hair.” “One gets tired,” he continues, “of being told that Dostoievsky’s *Legend of the Grand Inquisitor* is the most profound declaration which ever was made about man and life.”²⁶ Lawrence also defined his own vitalist views against his former idol Tolstoy – at that time the most popular Russian novelist in the

English-speaking world – whom he bitterly describes as “a perverse moralist” whose works “damp out the vividness of life.”²⁷ Lawrence particularly despised the theme of “unspeakable humiliation,” vehemently concluding that Russian literature is “all masturbation, half-baked, and one gets tired of it.”²⁸

After an initial period of enthusiasm, Ford also tempered his admiration for Russian literature. Like Lawrence, he tired of “variations of the Christ legend.”²⁹ But his admiration for the translator remained unequivocal: “I wish I knew, in the meantime, how to pay a tribute to Mrs. Constance Garnett for her translations from the Russian. [. . .] It is dreadful to think of what books in English would be if we had not her translations.”³⁰ For Ford, like Lawrence, the Russian novelists were a useful and arguably effective thematic foil even as English-language novelists remained “enormously indebted” to their translator for exposing them to Russian novels with their inward turn.³¹

The modernist novel, with its exploration of internal landscapes, likewise owes much to Sigmund Freud and thus to Bloomsbury member James Strachey, Lytton Strachey’s younger brother, and the first official translator into English of Freud’s work. Fittingly, the Woolfs’ Hogarth Press published these first official translations whose impact on the English language and the English-language novel cannot be overestimated. Strachey, often assisted by his wife Alix, translated Freud’s German, as Strachey put it, into the English of “an English man of science or wide education born in the middle of the nineteenth century.”³² Strachey’s translations of Freud’s scientific writing broadened the range of acceptable subject matter. They also introduced popular neologisms such as *id*, *super-ego*, and *cathexis*, while also altering the meaning and scope of many English words including *complex*, *fixation*, *symptom*, *regression*, and *transference*.

Freud, a proud stylist, was loath to repeat words and frequently made use of a pattern of words or a range of concepts. Strachey has been criticized for his approach to this difficulty, an approach that often entailed using a single word to translate a variety of words or else creating a single meaning for a word that Freud used in several

ways. For instance, Strachey distilled the word “transference” from the many places where Freud had made use of the polyvalent German word *Übertragung*.³³ This clarifying and systematizing translation strategy made the stylistically elegant Freud sound scientific but less poetic. Strachey has also been taken to task for translating Freud’s vital German into an overly scientific and occasionally stodgy English, unnecessarily peppered with words from dead languages. Strachey defended this approach, which he termed “literal translation.”

For wherever Freud becomes difficult or obscure it is necessary to move closer to a literal translation at the cost of any stylistic elegance. For the same reason, too, it is necessary to swallow whole into the translation quite a number of technical terms, stereotyped phrases, and neologisms which cannot with the best will in the world be regarded as “English.”³⁴

Something may indeed be lost in Strachey’s “streamlined Freud,” including, in the view of Freud scholar Alex Holder, the “ambiguities, uncertainties, and imaginative ponderings.”³⁵ Nevertheless, Strachey’s Freud translations expanded the English language, broadened the thematic scope of the modernist novel to include new and often scandalous topics, and offered readers and critics of these novels compelling new interpretive tools.

Just as a broad range of modernist writers read Garnett’s translations of Russian novels, they now discovered Freud via Strachey’s quasi-scriptural translations. They were “easily freudened,” to borrow Joyce’s pun from *Finnegans Wake*, and increasingly interested in childhood experiences and family dynamics.³⁶ Nevertheless, Freud was not universally embraced. Although Hogarth published Freud, Woolf assiduously avoided his work for fear of any influence that his controversial but compelling theories might have on her writing. In 1919, Lawrence railed against what he saw as Freud’s ill-conceived “plunge to the origins,” a bad faith journey into the unconscious that uncovered only “a huge slimy serpent of sex, and heaps of excrement, and a myriad repulsive little horrors spawned between sex and excrement.”³⁷

As a scientist, Freud escaped both legal and moral censorship in the English-speaking world despite his “frankness” when discussing

“the organs and functions of sexual life.”³⁸ Ford noted this double standard in a 1922 essay defending “what are called indecencies” in *Ulysses*, indecencies for which Freud’s *Interpretation of Dreams* (English translation 1913) arguably paved the way.³⁹

I used to be shocked by the fact that a great many ladies whom I respected and liked possessed copies of, and gloated as it appeared over, a volume of dream-interpretations by a writer called Freud – a volume that seemed to me to be infinitely more objectionable, in the fullest sense of the term, than *Ulysses* at its coarsest now seems to me.⁴⁰

Ford’s essay further demonstrates the extent to which we can deepen our understanding of the developments and contradictions of Anglo-American modernism by identifying the reception of significant translations into English.

Anthony Pym encourages literary scholars to ask “who translated what, how, where, when, for whom, and with what effect?”⁴¹ Such questions are perhaps easier to answer with a look across the channel. At least since the Abbé Prévost’s eighteenth-century translations of Samuel Richardson, translation was deemed a worthy activity for notable French writers whose translations promoted themselves as much as the writers they translated. As Georges May notes, “the most effective way of attracting the French public to a foreign writer has always proven to be the translation of his works by an established French author.”⁴² The history of English-language modernism is, in part, a history of the enthusiasm of established French writers for English-language modernists, many of whom were little known and unappreciated in their home countries at the time. Faulkner, for instance, once referred to as a god “for the youth of France” by the monolingual Sartre, gained a reputation in France in the 1930s before achieving widespread recognition in the United States in the mid-1940s.

André Gide and Valéry Larbaud were the most important translators and promoters or *passeurs* of English-language modernism. No interwar French writers did more to introduce modernist writers to French readers. Both Gide and Larbaud saw translation as a literary duty, a necessary part of any literary apprenticeship. Both writers

were also associated with the prestigious journal *La Nouvelle Revue française* (NRF), whose cluster of illustrious contributors has been widely compared to the Bloomsbury group. Gide, whose own work was translated in its entirety by James and Lytton Strachey's sister Dorothy, was the overseer of countless translations into French and the translator of numerous works. These include a notoriously unfaithful but highly influential 1918 translation of Conrad's *Typhoon*. Committed to elevating the status of translation, Gide encouraged every French writer to enrich French literature through translation.⁴³ His sense-for-sense approach to translation was highly appropriative. He insisted that translation be rooted in literary affinity and encouraged writers to translate works that they believed they could have authored themselves.

Gide's approach left most translated writers grateful but led to one particularly instructive dispute with Conrad that occurred while Gide was overseeing the translation of his entire oeuvre for the Éditions Gallimard. Although Conrad approved of Gide's philosophy of translation and hoped to win greater recognition on the continent, he was enraged that Gide had chosen a woman to translate *The Arrow of Gold* (1919). He penned an angry letter to Gide insisting that he take his novel away from the *traductrice*: "If my writings have a pronounced character, it is their virility – of spirit, inclination, style. [. . .] And you throw me to the women! In your letter, you yourself say that in the final reckoning, a translation is an interpretation. Very well, I want to be interpreted by masculine intelligences! It's perfectly natural."⁴⁴ For Conrad, who adroitly references Gide's philosophy of translation in his letter, fidelity to his work also meant fidelity to him as a person. Conrad's response, however retrograde with respect to questions of gender, anticipates several contemporary theories of translation that cast it as a violent and disfiguring act.

Larbaud also hoped to elevate the status of translation by insisting on "the role played by translators in literary history."⁴⁵ Described by Jean Cocteau as a "secret agent of literature," Larbaud, like Gide, tirelessly translated, reviewed, and prefaced translations.⁴⁶ Like Gide, he privileged sense-for-sense translations over word-for-word or literal translations, which he saw as uninspired and painful

to read. Larbaud's struggle to find a translator and publisher for *Ulysses* was certainly the most fervent literary campaign of his career. This campaign, begun in 1921, put him at odds with Jacques Rivière, then editor of the *NRF*, who dismissed Joyce's writing as "empty chit chat" (*vain bavardage*, my translation).⁴⁷ Larbaud's 1921 lecture at Adrienne Monnier's Maison des Amis de Livres (which T. S. Eliot translated into English in 1922 for the first issue of *The Criterion*), which Joyce listened to while hidden behind a screen, was arguably the first significant piece of Joyce criticism in either French or English. The talk was geared to convince Larbaud's audience, the vast majority of whom had not read the unpublished book, that *Ulysses* was a landmark novel.⁴⁸ It persuaded Sylvia Beach to publish *Ulysses*, thereby transforming the Shakespeare and Company bookstore into a publishing house. Monnier quickly followed Beach's lead and commissioned a French translation.

Larbaud believed that *Ulysses* would come to its highest fruition through translation into a multitude of languages.⁴⁹ The French translation of *Ulysses* was undertaken by Auguste Morel and Stuart Gilbert and supervised by Larbaud. Larbaud, Joyce's first choice of translator, attempted to recuse himself from the extraordinary undertaking and suggested André Maurois. In 1928, Joyce, in despair, convened his translators and publishers at the restaurant Les Trianons for a meeting that he would later call the "Trianons Treaty." At this meeting, he convinced Larbaud to continue his role as final arbiter.⁵⁰ Joyce reviewed the translation in its entirety before publication. The title page of the definitive translation published by Monnier in 1929 read: "Unabridged French translation by M. Auguste Morel, assisted by M. Stuart Gilbert, entirely revised by Valery Larbaud and the author."⁵¹ On 27 June of that year Adrienne Monnier held a *Déjeuner Ulysses*, to thank the translators and, belatedly – in one of its first celebratory incarnations – Bloomsday.

The difficulties associated with the French translation of *Ulysses*, difficulties resolved through the labor of multiple translators, are characteristic of the translation of many significant modernist novels. The writer whose own work best exemplifies and thematizes the struggles and feats of translation is Samuel Beckett. A professional

translator from and into a range of European languages, he participated at an early age in the second group translation into French of his erstwhile master Joyce before emerging as modernism's most notable self-translator.

In 1929, Beckett, at Joyce's behest and in collaboration with Alfred Péron, began translating the "Anna Livia Plurabelle" section of what would become *Finnegans Wake*. After he returned to Ireland, Beckett's work was revised and completed by Paul Léon, Ivan Goll, and Eugene Jolas.⁵² In 1930, Joyce challenged, reworked, and revised the translation with the occasional assistance of the surrealist writer Philippe Soupault. "Anna Livia Plurabelle" ultimately appeared in the May 1931 issue of the *NRF*, translated by Samuel Beckett, Alfred Péron, Ivan Goll, Eugene Jolas, Paul Léon, Adrienne Monnier, and Philippe Soupault "in collaboration with the author." In Richard Ellmann's view, this translation, the fruit of a team of seven translators which Joyce cleverly referred to as his "Septuagint,"⁵³ trumped that of *Ulysses* as "a triumph over seemingly impossible obstacles."⁵⁴ The translation pleased Joyce who, seeking recognition in England, wrote optimistically in a 1931 letter to Harriet Weaver that "they [the English] usually follow a Paris lead over there."⁵⁵ The group translation of "Anna Livia Plurabelle" is arguably the most significant work on which the young Beckett sharpened his already considerable skills as a translator into French.

Joyce's multilingual work had brilliantly cluttered the English language, his "acquired speech."⁵⁶ Beckett departed from English – "Horrible language, which I still know too well" – in 1945 and, for a decade, returned to it almost exclusively through self-translation.⁵⁷ Many Beckett scholars credit this midlife decision to write in French as a significant factor in the burst of literary activity that would result in the trilogy of *Molloy*, *Malone Dies*, and *The Unnamable* as well as *Waiting for Godot* and *Endgame*. Many also argue that this decision was motivated by Beckett's desire to gain distance from English-language traditions including Hiberno-English, and distinguish himself from Joyce. As he wrote in an early letter to Chatto and Windus editor Charles Prentice apropos of his 1932 story "Sedendo et Quiescendo": "And of course it stinks

of Joyce in spite of most earnest endeavours to endow it with my own odours.”⁵⁸

An early and significant expression of Beckett's desire to end his battle with English by writing in another language appears in a much-edited draft of his 1937 letter to German translator Axel Kaun. Although Kaun was little more than an acquaintance, the letter is written in a spirit of camaraderie and candor from one translator to another. In good but not flawless German, Beckett articulates his frustration with the English language: “It is indeed getting more and more difficult, even pointless, for me to write in formal English.” “[L]anguage,” he argues, “is best used where it is most efficiently abused.” Finally, Beckett conveys to Kaun his joy at “being allowed to violate a foreign language” in the letter.⁵⁹

During the Second World War Beckett lived in the French countryside with his companion and future wife Suzanne Deschevaux-Dumesnil and joined the Resistance. His lengthy departure from the English language thus occurred after a war that had vastly sharpened his French-language skills. Asked by the German translator Hans Naumann why he chose to write in French rather than English, Beckett cleverly responded with a pun: “le besoin d’être mal-armé.”⁶⁰ One possible way to translate this is: “the need to be ill equipped.” However, when heard out loud, the original French also sounds like “to be Mallarmé” (i.e., Stéphane Mallarmé, the French symbolist poet). In the mid-fifties Beckett famously told German postgrad Niklaus Gessner that “in French it is easier to write without style.”⁶¹ In 1960, he explained to director Herbert Blau that French appealed to him because it had “the right weakening effect.”⁶² His “vrai mobile,” his real motive, as he told novelist Ludovic Janvier, was to “further impoverish himself” (my translation).⁶³ Such explanations, always far and few between, soon disappeared. As Beckett's bilingual oeuvre grew, so did his unwillingness to discuss this pivotal decision.

Although Beckett continued throughout his life to work on translations of his work into other European languages, for our purposes here, we must consider why he chose to translate his own work from French to English and from English to French. It is fairly

certain that Beckett initially planned to leave the majority of his work to other translators or else co-translate it. In the early fifties, he joined forces with a young South African named Patrick Bowles to translate *Molloy*. According to Anthony Cronin, Beckett cautioned Bowles that the French could not be translated directly and explained that they would be writing “a new book in a new language.”⁶⁴ In 1953, he complained to Éditions de Minuit editor Jérôme Lindon about the futility of revising Bowles’s first selection: “I know that I shall not be able to bear my work being translated into English by someone else.”⁶⁵ Later that year he summed up the experience of co-translation in a letter to the English actress Pamela Mitchell: “I was kilt entirely co-translating in Paris, 8 stupid hours daily, and the result not very satisfactory.”⁶⁶ After co-translating *Molloy*, Beckett realized reluctantly that he could accept only his own translations of his work.

Despite his vast experience, Beckett found his own work exceedingly difficult to translate. His letters and notebooks detail this unwelcome chore, a subjectively impossible task that he likened to constipation. He very often translated his work after a considerable delay. For instance, he struggled for years with the English translation of *L’Innommable* (*The Unnamable*), a task that left him exhausted. In 1956, Beckett told Irish critic Vivien Mercier that he felt “all dried up, with nothing left but self-translation.”⁶⁷ He nevertheless continued for decades to compose new works in both English and French, works he knew that he would translate himself.

Beckett’s translations contain so many significant changes in sense and structure that we must consider whether we are even justified in speaking of them as translations. Venuti usefully reminds us that “what constitutes an accurate translation in one period may later come to be regarded not as a translation at all, but as an adaptation or even as a wholesale revision of the foreign text.”⁶⁸ Richard N. Coe maintains that Beckett was not a faithful translator in the contemporary sense, arguing that his translations function instead as parallel creations: “Beckett’s French linguistic self is not identical with his English-structured linguistic self; nor, even more significantly, are his English translations from his own French identical renderings

from one idiom to another.”⁶⁹ Does this mean that a reader who wants to read Beckett’s oeuvre must be bilingual, that his translations are adaptations in conversation with each other and perhaps only distantly related? The presence of cross-lingual connections and untranslatable puns alone begs questions about the authority of any single text. Brian T. Fitch, an early advocate of the bilingual oeuvre theory, argues emphatically in favor of treating Beckett’s work “as a single work constituted by two different texts.”⁷⁰

Did Beckett, as Fitch suggests, intentionally create a bilingual oeuvre ideally intended for bilingual readers who could read the French and English versions in tandem? Again, for readers and critics, the answer to these questions depends on our definitions of translation and adaptation, definitions that can change dramatically over time. According to some theorists, André Lefevere in particular, all translations are the result of an inevitable but instructive rewriting informed by the power that one culture has to shape another. Although “an act of manipulation, undertaken in the service of power,” Lefevere maintains that rewritings play a crucial role in the history of literature because they perforce lead to literary innovation.⁷¹

An indisputable literary innovator, Beckett was always loath to take up the richly deserved mantle of great translator. His self-translations began and ended as onuses. At times he felt verbally crippled and incapable of translating. Like *L’Innommable* (*The Unnamable*), *Fin de partie* (*Endgame*) caused him particular trouble. Before he began translating the play he wrote pessimistically to director Alan Schneider about “a text which does not yet exist and which, when it does, will inevitably be a poor substitute for the original (the loss will be greater from the French to the English *Godot*).”⁷² In a letter to Grove editor Barney Rosset, he estimated that the French was 20 percent “undecantable” into English.⁷³ When he finally finished the English translation of *Endgame* he was disappointed but not surprised to find that its sharpness and rhythms had been lost in the process. “Wish I had the courage to wash my hands of it all,” he lamented to the poet Thomas MacGreevy in 1957.⁷⁴ He soon began, in part, the reverse process

of writing part of his work in English and translating it into French. Years later he composed some of his shorter texts simultaneously in both languages. But his perhaps unintended solution to the chore of translation was the short English-language novel *Worstward Ho*, published in 1983, only six years before his death. Perhaps with some relief he informed publisher John Calder that the work was “untranslatable.”⁷⁵ For decades Beckett had lived the age-old dictum *traduttore traditore*, as both legendary translator of his own work and self-designated traitor to the same. Yet, by means of his bilingual oeuvre, he painfully but ingeniously reversed the centuries-old tradition of invisibility for the Anglo-American translator, while also making possible a very modern way of reading.

Notes

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27. D. H. Lawrence, "Thomas Hardy, Verga, and Tolstoy," in *Russian Literature and Modern English Fiction: A Collection of Critical Essays*, ed. Donald Davie (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1965), 147.
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IV

Modernism, Genre, and Form

Modernist Style and the “Inward Turn” in German-Language Fiction

Ritchie Robertson

The German émigré Erich Kahler composed a well-known study, *The Inward Turn of Narrative*, which traces the internalization of the novel from antiquity down to the eighteenth century.¹ He pursued the topic in relation to modernism in a lecture given in 1958 and published as an appendix to his study, entitled “The Transformation of the Novel.” Here Kahler pursues the inward turn through a number of stages. In the late nineteenth century, he argues, literature moved in one of two directions. One direction was collective: people were presented not primarily as isolated individuals but as members of a group, a crowd, a family, a social class, as in Zola’s naturalist fiction or in Mann’s *Buddenbrooks* where the individual is subordinate to the family. If collectivism looked outward toward society, the other direction moved inward, into the depths of the individual psyche. The visible surface of reality was decomposed to permit a minute analysis of sensations, emotions, psychological nuances.

In modernism’s exploration of inner experience, Kahler discerns a number of stages, which will be illustrated in the course of this chapter. First, modernism charts the conscious and unconscious life of the individual. It uses techniques such as free indirect speech and stream-of-consciousness narration to present a rich array of the diverse contents of consciousness, and to link them by emotional association rather than arranging them in an artificially rational sequence. Beyond that, it probes the unconscious drives that Freud – himself the heir of other philosophies of the unconscious – revealed as the hidden motives behind many of our supposedly deliberate actions. Second, beyond the individual unconscious, modernism draws on the collective unconscious by restoring life to myths and symbols

whose significance is more than merely personal. And finally, modernism presses even further to reveal the basic human condition, above all by showing how the individual transcends the limitations of personality in confrontation with death.

Schnitzler's Explorations of Consciousness

The technique used in some of the most innovative stories by Arthur Schnitzler (1862–1931) depends on a philosophically grounded skepticism about the integrity, indeed the very existence, of the self. In the late nineteenth century, some scientific psychologists became skeptical of the metaphysical unity of the self for which Kant had argued in the *Critique of Pure Reason* (1781). If, instead of starting from a metaphysical assumption, one sought empirical evidence for the existence of the self, there was none to be found. There was no “self,” no “me,” apart from the perceptions and sensations passing through consciousness. Accordingly, the polymathic scientist Ernst Mach (1838–1916), who was both a physicist and a psychologist, maintained in *Die Analyse der Empfindungen* (*The Analysis of Sensations*, 1886) that consciousness consisted of sensations, and that the self, which received these sensations, was simply a complex of feelings, moods, and memories attached to a body. By changing only gradually, this complex gives the illusion of permanence; but in fact there is no permanent, substantial self underlying the flux of sensations. “The self is past saving” (“Das *Ich* ist unrettbar”), Mach proclaimed.² This skepticism converged with the radical questioning of the self undertaken by Friedrich Nietzsche (1844–1900), for whom the word “I” is simply a grammatical function in phrases such as “I think” and “I want,” but language misleads us into mistaking “I” for a substantial entity.

The Machian flux of sensations is presented in narratives which later attracted the label “stream of consciousness.” The term was popularized by William James (1842–1910), who in *The Principles of Psychology* (1890) argued that consciousness was not divided into distinct objects or segments but was a continuous stream, different parts of which successively formed the focus of the subject’s

attention.³ Schnitzler first used this technique in *Leutnant Gustl* (1900), inspired by the French novelist Edouard Dujardin (1861–1949), whose *Les Lauriers sont coupés* (1888) he had read two years earlier. The subject of Schnitzler's story, however, seems highly unsuitable. Far from possessing a rich inner life, Gustl is an army officer in his early twenties with a thoroughly conventional outlook. We first meet him in a concert hall, which he only went to because he was given a free ticket, thoroughly bored and letting his thoughts roam. He eyes up a girl sitting opposite and threatens mentally to challenge a man who seems to be looking at him with disapproval, showing the reader that his central concern is the assertion of his insecure manhood. On the way out, Gustl jostles another concert goer, who in a whisper threatens to break his sword and calls him "dummer Bub" (stupid boy). Stunned by the threat to his sword, in which critics have seen the phallic symbol of his manhood, Gustl receives this insult in silence. Only when his antagonist has vanished does Gustl remember that under the military code such an insult to his honor can only be avenged by a duel. But the insult was delivered by a baker, and the code also declares such a lowly tradesman incapable of giving satisfaction. So since he cannot avenge the insult, Gustl is obliged as an officer to commit suicide. True, nobody has witnessed the incident, but that in no way weakens the obligation. So Gustl spends the whole night wandering around Vienna, and his thoughts wander even more. Instead of focusing on the existential crisis which has intervened in his accustomed life, Gustl thinks incoherently about his family, his many love affairs, his less than brilliant military career, and a duel which he is in any case due to fight the following afternoon. The humor of the style consists in Gustl's trivial response to the prospect of death and in the revelation that his inner world contains only the clichés derived from his outer world. Fortunately for Gustl, he learns the following morning that the baker has suddenly died of a stroke. Nobody knows about the incident, so Gustl can happily forget it and prepare to demonstrate his manhood by slicing up his opponent in the impending duel.

Despite the brilliance with which Schnitzler deploys it, the stream-of-consciousness technique used in *Gustl* is limited by

largely confining us to the thoughts that the protagonist is able to put into words. It does not show how consciousness is embodied. Consciousness consists not only of thoughts but also of bodily sensation. Even if one sees, hears, and smells things without always consciously registering them, they nevertheless make an impression. But since stream-of-consciousness narrative follows the selective focus of attention – the spotlight that the mind turns on successive objects – it risks giving an impoverished impression of consciousness.

Schnitzler took the technique further in *Fräulein Else* (1924). The story is set, like many of Schnitzler's plays and stories, at a hotel in the Austrian Alps frequented by members of the Viennese bourgeoisie. Else, a young woman of nineteen, is staying there with relatives. She receives an express letter from her mother in Vienna, informing her that her father, a lawyer, is in danger of being arrested for embezzling money. He has to raise a large sum within a very few days. The only way of raising the money is for Else to appeal to an old friend of her father's, a wealthy art dealer called Herr von Dorsday, who happens to be staying in the same hotel. Thus Else finds herself placed under intolerable pressure by her family. She goes to Dorsday, and he consents to supply the money, under one condition: she must allow him to look at her naked – nothing more. Unable to cope with this, Else goes downstairs into the hotel diningroom with nothing on under her coat, and shows herself to Dorsday like that, in public. She then collapses, is taken to her room, and when nobody is looking she manages to take an overdose of sleeping pills and drifts off into death.

Here the stream-of-consciousness technique is much more expressive than in *Gustl*. Since there is more dialogue, and other people's words are distinguished by italics, the distance between Else and others is indicated typographically and confirmed as we learn more of her inner life. She feels emotionally isolated. Her sexual emotions are undeveloped though constantly in her thoughts. No other life than leisure followed by marriage has ever been suggested to her: she is an object of display in the marriage market, and accordingly thinks much about her appearance and her clothes. Since she is an object to

be looked at, Dorsday's demand – that she let him look at her naked – underlines the status that she, as a woman with no purpose of her own in life, is allowed in this society. Her lack of self-esteem comes across vividly.

Since we have no independent access to the intentions of Else's parents, a crucial ambiguity is preserved. Do they really expect Dorsday to advance a large sum while asking nothing in return? Or are they, without admitting it, callously prostituting Else so that her father can avoid ruin? Their likely callousness corresponds to that of the friends with whom Else is staying in the hotel, and who kiss passionately beside the bed where she is lying semi-conscious and dying. The emotionally chilly atmosphere helps to explain why, as commentators have repeatedly emphasized, she is a hysteric, that is, she acts out her emotional distress in bodily form by displaying herself to Dorsday. Her emotional isolation also accounts for the obsession with death that her inner monologue reveals. Even before receiving the fateful letter, she imagines falling from her windowsill and being killed, and mentally drafts the newspaper report of her death – another indication that she is always seeing herself from outside, that she has internalized the gaze that society fixes on her.

Although Schnitzler did not return to stream-of-consciousness narrative after *Fräulein Else*, he made an almost equally radical use of free indirect speech in his last story to be published, *Flucht in die Finsternis* (*Flight into Darkness*, 1931), on which he had been working intermittently for some twenty years. The focal consciousness is that of a middle-aged, widowed civil servant, Robert, who has recently parted from his girlfriend Alberta and taken a six-month holiday on the advice of his elder brother Otto, a nerve-doctor (as was Freud). It soon emerges that Robert's relationship with Otto is profoundly ambivalent. He feels it to be ideally untroubled by the mysterious psychological problems that cause difficulties between men and women. But he also feels inferior to the more obviously successful Otto. Above all, he broods uneasily on how, some years ago, he made Otto promise to practice euthanasia on him if he ever showed signs of incurable madness. Now he finds himself prone to mood swings, forgetfulness, and sudden inexplicable feelings of hostility

toward his friends. What if Otto were to judge these to be signs of madness, and kill him? Robert's delusions increase. He imagines that he murdered Alberta and is not wholly relieved when he gets a letter from her. He comes to suspect that Otto himself may be mad and may kill him. On the pretext that Alberta's new husband has come to murder him, he flees to a country hotel; Otto comes and tries to reason with him; Robert shoots him, then rushes out, and his corpse is found three days later. Schnitzler keeps up the focus on Robert's consciousness almost consistently, so that we cannot be quite sure that he is deluded, and until almost the end it is possible that Otto may be the mad one. It is only just before he murders Otto that the narrator's viewpoint sharply diverges from Robert's: "In his [Otto's] eyes was fear, compassion, and immeasurable love. But to his brother the moist gleam of his gaze signified malice, menace, and death."⁴ Thus Schnitzler does in the end give us a firm standpoint. But he denies us the false consolation of a clinical explanation. After Robert's death, his friends diagnose persecution mania, but another doctor demurs from this over-simplification, observing that such neat categories are a mere refuge from the infinite and troubling variety of individual cases.

Reconstructing the Self: Musil's Törless, Rilke's Malte

In narrative technique, Robert Musil's *The Confusions of Young Törless* (1906) is more conservative than these texts by Schnitzler. Musil, who read avidly but had had a scientific education specializing in mathematics and psychology, adopts free indirect speech, using the protagonist as focalizer, with occasional interventions by the narrator. The novel recounts a few months in the life of a schoolboy, known only as Törless, who is attending a military academy loosely based on the school Musil himself attended at Mährisch-Weisskirchen (now Hranice in the Czech Republic, then situated in a border town of the Austro-Hungarian Empire). The novel turns on the apparent incompatibility of two worlds. One is the routine of the school, where the day is divided into periods by the ringing of the bell, and where education proceeds in a rigid and unimaginative way. The

other is the private world to which he is admitted, a world devised by two of Törless's fellow schoolboys, Reiting and Beineberg. Its focus is a secret room, draped in red, and hidden in a recess of the school's attics, where the three boys have set up a den, adorned by a loaded revolver. Having discovered that another boy, Basini, has been stealing, Reiting and Beineberg resolve to punish him by subjecting him to torments that he will not dare reveal for fear of expulsion. Reiting is a genial thug with a talent for manipulating others; Beineberg is a sinister, pseudo-intellectual who professes an intense interest in Eastern mysticism; Törless, who is younger, tags along in their wake. The torments inflicted on Basini are crudely sadistic, but the subtler Törless introduces a new note by compelling Basini to say "I am a thief" and thus humiliating him morally.

The sexual atmosphere of the meetings in the secret room links them with the regular visits that Törless pays to the local prostitute, Božena. It is in sexuality that the incompatibility of two worlds becomes most evident. Törless, who finds Božena both desirable and disgusting, has difficulty in accepting that she belongs to the same gender as his elegant mother, whom he imagines as a being of unearthly purity. This is the tendency to polarize women into the archetypes of mother and whore that Freud would describe in "On the Universal Tendency to Debasement in the Sphere of Love" (1912).⁵

Törless's attempt to reconcile the public and secret worlds is part of his ongoing effort to make sense of his unusual perceptions. One day, for example, lying on his back and gazing up into the sky, he realizes that the space above him has no end, and the concept of infinity, previously a mere word used in math lessons, suddenly becomes a real experience for him. He consults the math teacher when he is puzzled by imaginary numbers – the square root of minus one, a nonexistent number that is nevertheless indispensable for certain calculations. The teacher refers him to Kant, of whose philosophy Törless can make nothing. His encounters with infinity and with imaginary numbers show him the limits of reason. The most rational mathematical operations turn out to depend on fictions.

However, Musil is not making a facile contrast of the rational and the irrational. He does not suggest that reason should be abandoned

in favor of a plunge into pure feeling. Irrationalism is unattractively represented in the novel by the pseudo-mystical speeches of Beineberg. Rather, these puzzling concepts, though not rationally intelligible, are part of the world with which the reasoning mind has to deal. Törless is learning to talk clearly about aspects of experience that resist rational analysis. He comes closest to achieving this when he explains himself to the teachers, although they are unable to understand him. As he begins his speech, he looks out of the window and sees a crow sitting on a branch, silhouetted against a featureless snowy expanse; this represents, as Elisabeth Stopp observes, “the kind of clear-cut, black-and-white certainty that he has now reached, as sharply etched as the dark bird against the snow.”⁶ He explains confidently that he sees everything with two faces:

No, I wasn’t mistaken when I talked about a second, secret, unheeded life of things. It is I – I don’t mean it literally – not these things that are alive, it was I, not Basini who had two faces – but inside me there was a second face that did not look at all this with the eyes of reason. Just as I feel that a thought comes to life inside me, I also feel that something inside me is alive at the sight of things, when thoughts are silent. There is inside me, among all the thoughts, something dark that I cannot quantify with my thoughts, a life that is not expressed in words and that is yet my life.⁷

Törless does not wish to analyze what resists analysis, or to translate one side of his experience into the other. He now accepts that experience has two aspects, and he no longer intends to compare one with the other. He has reconciled the duality of his experience by learning to live with it.

Musil’s early novel marks an innovation by refusing to understand consciousness simply as an unending flux. There is much in subjective experience that cannot be analyzed, but it can be described; not, however, in the pared-down language of the scientist, but in a language enriched by bold yet precise metaphors. Törless comes through an adolescent crisis partly by learning to use language to exert some control over his experiences. At one point the narrator stands back enough from Törless to give us a glimpse of his future. He will become “one of those aesthetic/intellectual types” who are

concerned "solely with the development of the mind" and judge by aesthetic rather than moral standards. We may be intended to see him as a budding poet. At all events, his intellectual, moral, and sexual confusions are resolved by a combination of intellectual and aesthetic detachment.

Rilke shares with Musil the desire to escape from a cloudy, impressionistic representation of experience and to capture external objects with precision while using them as indirect expressions of the ultimately inexpressible self. His only novel, *The Notebooks of Malte Laurids Brigge* (1910), centers on an exceptionally fragile self and on how it can be reinforced and reconstructed. The fictive author of the notebooks is a twenty-eight-year-old Danish poet of aristocratic lineage, living in Paris, completely impoverished and isolated; during the novel he has no direct contact with any other person, apart from an unnamed doctor at the Salpêtrière hospital. He finds Paris oppressive and frightening. The crowds in the streets frighten him, as does the wall of a tumbledown house. Individual people are even worse. In the street, he sees a woman with her hands over her face (presumably in grief or despair); when she looks up, startled by his footsteps, her face seems to remain in her hands. When he has to visit the outpatients' department at the Salpêtrière, the patients sitting near him inspire disgust (rather than sympathy). Ultimately, he is afraid not of any specific thing, but of everything – "the existence of the horrible in every particle of air."⁸

Malte recoils from the appalling outside world into an inner world composed of memories. Not that these are in any way comforting. His childhood in Denmark was dominated by death. His grandfather, Christoph Detlev Brahe, took ten weeks to die, and his death dominated the household. Long before that, the family in which Malte was brought up seems in his recollections uncanny. His grandfather did not acknowledge the passing of time and spoke of people long dead as though they were still present. Malte recalls an occasion when the family at dinner received a visit from the ghost of Christine Brahe, a relative who died long ago in childbed. Childhood has many other terrors, including fear of his own sexual body, prone to uncontrollable erections. All these fears are still present in adult life.

The first hint of how Malte might overcome his terrors is given in a draft letter (based on an actual letter Rilke sent his wife on October 19, 1907) in which he talks about Baudelaire's poem "Une Charogne," a painstaking description of a decaying corpse, and about Flaubert's story "St Julien l'Hospitalier," whose hero performs a culminating act of sainthood in embracing a leper. For Malte, the artist has to cope with the apparently disgusting by embracing it: "It was his business to see in those terrible things, repulsive in appearance only, that being which alone is of value in all that exists. There is no choice or refusal."⁹ There are two steps in this process. First, the material that arouses horror, disgust, and fear has to be accepted as real (with the unspoken implication that it is somehow *more* real than the rest of reality). Second, the artist confronts this reality in order to transform it into art. This attests the value of his art by grounding it in what he considers reality, and he himself becomes a kind of saint, whose meticulous portrayal of the repulsive is an act of self-overcoming. The novel's open ending leaves it uncertain whether Malte would have conquered his terrors by turning them into an aesthetic reality, but it is at least possible that Malte reconstructs his personality through the act of writing the *Notebooks*.

Dreams and Archetypes: Kafka, Hesse, Schnitzler

If Rilke introduces a ghostly apparition into Malte's memories, Kafka, Hesse, and Schnitzler break even more decisively with fictional realism by letting their protagonists experience a "reality" whose relation to the everyday world is an insoluble problem. Thus the relation between "inner" and "outer" becomes an enigma.

Can one say, for example, that Kafka in *The Trial* (written in 1914–15, published in 1925) explores the inner world? While the arrest and investigation of Josef K. appear to release his hidden fears and obsessions, all the legal apparatus of the novel appears solidly external and circumstantial, however grotesque. The appearance of two guards in Josef K.'s flat to inform him that he is under arrest, his attendance at a hearing before the examining magistrate, his wandering through the stuffy, labyrinthine corridors of the court, and his

encounter with an official called the Thrasher whose duty is to punish misbehavior by Court employees, are all palpable events. On the other hand, although K. is not told exactly when to attend his first hearing, he is reprimanded for not arriving at a time that he decided on privately and which therefore cannot be known to anyone else; the stale air in the Court corridors makes him almost unable to stand upright; and the Thrasher and his victims not only appear in a lumber room of K.'s bank, but are still there, unchanged, exactly twenty-four hours later. The Court seems to exist both inside and outside K.'s head.

Although before his arrest K. was a bachelor workaholic whose social life was strictly regulated, the Court's sudden intervention in his life seems gradually to transform it. Having initially pooh-poohed his trial, K. becomes obsessed with it, seeking help not only from a highly suspect lawyer but from the Court painter and finally from the prison chaplain. In a parallel process, his sexual urges threaten to escape control, and the Court has an atmosphere of seedy sexuality, as though mirroring K.'s repressed desires: the examining magistrate is a sexual predator, and what K. supposes to be law books turn out to be crude pornography. If we want to read the Court as a summons to K.'s buried moral conscience, we have to account for the fact that it actually stimulates his sexual appetite. If we want to credit the Court with any moral authority, we will be puzzled by its sordid and often ludicrous manifestations and by the fact, made brutally clear in the Thrasher episode and confirmed finally by K.'s execution, that the increasing power it exercises over the defendant rests ultimately on raw violence. And while it is an independent power that is able to kill K., it often appears also as a mirror image of the bureaucratic hierarchy that he himself inhabits, as though in some way K.'s imagination had called it into being. This unresolved ambiguity helps to explain the continued fascination of Kafka's best-known novel.

Schnitzler in *Traumnovelle* (1926) also juxtaposes the world of dreams and a waking life that is intermittently dreamlike or surreal with a solid and concrete everyday reality. Fridolin, a doctor, and his wife Albertine, evidently a full-time mother, have plenty of

professional and domestic tasks, but the fragility of their daily routine is conveyed by startling dreams, memories, and baffling experiences. In the first of seven sections, each confesses to the other how the previous summer's holiday in Denmark brought each the temptation to leave their partner for an attractive Dane. Irritated by his wife's confession, Fridolin obeys the summons to a dying patient and undergoes a series of strange experiences. They culminate in his illicit admission to a secret gathering in a suburban villa, where men dressed first as monks, then as cavaliers, are apparently preparing for an orgy with women who are naked apart from masks. The password to this assembly is "Denmark," suggesting some inexplicable link with Fridolin's holiday experiences. On being discovered, Fridolin is threatened with death, but a woman offers herself in his place, and he is merely ejected from the villa. Returning to Albertine, he finds that his adventure has a counterpart in her dream life: she recounts an elaborate dream with a semi-Oriental setting and featuring the attractive Dane, in which Fridolin suffers a flogging and prepares to be crucified. The next morning, Fridolin discovers that the woman who offered her life for his has committed suicide, and he views her corpse in the morgue. The story ends with a reconciliation between husband and wife. Sobered, but also vicariously satisfied, by their glimpses of the unconscious world of violent fantasies and desires, they resolve to remain awake, conscious that "no dream is entirely a dream."¹⁰

In this strange mixture of realism and exotic fantasy, Schnitzler has rendered unconscious desires vivid by often perplexing symbolism. The sensual demands of the body are suggested by the recollections of the summer holiday on a Danish beach, while the repeated motif of disguise – Fridolin has to borrow a monk's habit from a theatrical costumier, Albertine dreams of looking for her bridal dress and finding it replaced by extravagant Oriental costumes – expresses the wish to assume a new and exciting identity.¹¹ The death of Fridolin's rescuer introduces a further theme, that of sacrifice: it is as though the woman has accepted death in order to save not only Fridolin's life but also his marriage. While Albertine's dream recalls Freud's theory of dreams as symbolic wish fulfillments, Schnitzler's

opinion of Freud was too ambivalent to let us read the story simply as a fictional enactment of Freudian theory, but he certainly read *The Interpretation of Dreams* on its publication in 1900 and, by his own account, not only had particularly vivid dreams but also dreamt about interpreting his own dreams.¹² In general terms *Traumnovelle* benefits from the new language for talking about the unconscious that Freud had made available. It justifies Freud's assessment of Schnitzler: "I believe that fundamentally your nature is that of an explorer of psychological depths, as honestly impartial and undaunted as anyone has ever been."¹³

Reality and fantasy are again intermingled in Hermann Hesse's *Der Steppenwolf* (1927), a text indebted less to Freud than to Jung. In the notebooks of the protagonist Harry Haller, which form the bulk of the text, Haller records his encounters with the Magic Theatre. One evening, aging, bored, and ill, he passes a sign saying "Magic Theatre – For Madmen Only!" When he returns, an unidentified man hands him a book entitled *Tractat vom Steppenwolf*, which contains a long analysis of Harry's situation. Unable to accept the "Bürger" (average citizen) in himself, he has retreated into a defiant, self-pitying outsider identity of a "Steppenwolf," a beast of prey roaming the Russian steppes, but he needs to get beyond this sterile antithesis through a process of "Menschwerdung," becoming human, which is also described by the Jungian term "Individuation." The treatise further asserts, in Nietzschean language, that the unity of the self is an illusion concealing a multiplicity of selves; humanity is not a firm construction but a bridge between Nature and God, an unfinished project whose completion is infinitely deferred.¹⁴ Haller's subsequent "Menschwerdung" is assisted by a sympathetic call girl, Hermine, who teaches him to dance and enjoy jazz. Through Hermine he gets to know another girl, Maria, with whom he has casual sex, and a seemingly bisexual musician, Pablo, who acts as a guide to the Magic Theatre. The climax of the novel occurs at Carnival time – the season given over to laughter and to the disruption of social hierarchies. Haller at last enters the elusive Magic Theatre, which permits the imaginary realization of his many selves. In one booth he releases his inner violence by shooting

at motorcars; in another he reexperiences his early love life; in another, he finds Hermine and Pablo asleep after lovemaking, and stabs Hermine, thereby fulfilling her earlier prophecy that he would obey her last command by killing her. But this fantasy of murder, Pablo explains, merely shows that Haller has not yet attained the sovereign standpoint that will enable him to face the horror of life with resigned and humorous acceptance shown by “immortals” such as Mozart. The novel ends with Haller still on his way towards “Menschwerdung.”

Haller’s experiences are refracted by a modernist juxtaposition of different perspectives. His notebooks not only include the lengthy “Tractat,” but are framed in the recollections of his landlady’s nephew, to whom Haller gave the notebooks on leaving the lodgings. The nephew introduces the notebooks, uncertain how far they correspond to reality, and gives us an external view of Haller’s life, with his isolation and frequent depressions. This introduction serves to anchor Haller’s life in conventional reality but makes it still more uncertain what the experiences recorded in the notebooks amounted to and whether they did in fact mark a stage in his personal development. As with Kafka, the ambiguity is fascinating. Though it used to be read naively as a celebration of counterculture, *Der Steppenwolf* survives as a complex and multilayered modernist text.

Confrontations with Death: Thomas Mann, Arnold Zweig, Hermann Broch

The final stage of modernism’s inward journey, according to Kahler, is the confrontation with impersonal, existential realities. Chief among these must be the fact of death. The strand of modernism that is being examined here, concerned with exploring individual consciousness, repeatedly reminds us that the individual is isolated. The emotional solitude of Schnitzler’s Fräulein Else is the norm; the restoration of marital unity at the end of *Traumnovelle* is a happy and hard-won exception. Dying, above all, must be done alone. The innumerable deaths of the First World War cast a shadow over life and literature in the following decade. We find writers not only

brooding on death but occasionally trying to imagine death from the perspective of the person dying. Here literature engages most ambitiously with basic human realities.

Although Thomas Mann's *The Magic Mountain* is set during the seven years preceding the First World War, its location in a Swiss sanatorium means that death is always close at hand. Patients suffering from tuberculosis sometimes leave the sanatorium, but often their cure is illusory and they return there to die. On one occasion the protagonist, Hans Castorp, undergoes an X-ray. This technique, first used in 1896, is little more than ten years old. It marks both the cutting edge of science and a disturbing, uncanny alienation from ordinary human life. Looking at his hand through the X-ray screen, "Hans Castorp saw exactly what he should have expected to see, but which no man was ever intended to see and which he himself had never presumed he would be able to see: he saw into his own grave."¹⁵ The X-ray, exposing the skeleton beneath the skin, is a modern version of the traditional *memento mori*, in which a skull reminds the mortal that he must inevitably die. For Castorp it is a threshold experience, bringing home to him his own mortality.

Hans Castorp does not die during the novel, though our last glimpse of him, advancing through mud and shell fire on the front line, suggests that he has not much longer to live. Death in war does, however, befall the titular figure of Arnold Zweig's *Der Streit um den Sergeanten Grischa* (*The Dispute about Sergeant Grischa*, 1927), one of the first German novels to depict the war from a critical perspective.¹⁶ Grischa does not die on the battlefield, however. He is a Russian prisoner of war, wrongly accused of spying, who is shot by a firing squad after a long but ineffectual campaign by the novel's main characters on his behalf. As he faces the marksmen, Grischa's fragmenting consciousness is illuminated by the author, using the present tense. An incoherent set of images is succeeded by a wholly inarticulate, brute awareness that as he has conceived a child, something of his substance will survive.

Zweig then tries to represent what goes on in Grischa in the last seconds of consciousness as five bullets penetrate his body. The narrative shifts from the present to the past tense, implying an

analytical reconstruction of events rather than an immediate rendering. We are told that there were three kinds of time in Grischa: the objective, measurable time which the bullets took to enter his body; the subjective time in which images flash through his dying consciousness; and finally the physical time in which his body reacts to the bullets' impact. The bullets strike his body with the force of battering rams, and during the seconds in which they lacerate his veins, heart, and lungs he suffers briefly but abominably. Then the perspective moves outside Grischa and the reader joins the onlookers who see his body lying in the snow. Zweig has here forced the imagination to its limits in the attempt to recreate the instants of dying.

In its physicality, Zweig's rendering of death contrasts sharply with what has been called "the most spectacular rendition of death in the twentieth century."¹⁷ This is the final section of Hermann Broch's *The Death of Virgil* (1945), in which the dying poet imagines himself setting off on a voyage across an endless ocean, with a pilot who is a composite of figures from his past and the god Hermes. On his imaginary journey he passes in reverse through the stages of creation and the animal, plant, and mineral kingdoms. Instead of being absorbed into the physical universe, however, Virgil's death culminates in a mystical vision of a mother and child, and, beyond that, an apprehension of "the simultaneous stream of creation in which the eternal rests, the first image, the vision of visions."¹⁸

Both Zweig and Broch go beyond any verifiable experience. No traveler ever returns to tell us which account of death is the more accurate. Moreover, they evoke different kinds of death. Grischa dies by violence, Virgil drifts away after a debilitating illness. Zweig adopts a mode of writing that bears at least some relation to scientific analysis and physiological data. Broch's poetic prose, structured by hypnotic repetition and full of unfamiliar compound nouns, develops the symbolic texture of his novel as a whole; Virgil's vision of the mother and child is based on the image of renewal through a miraculous child that is present in his own poetry (the Fourth Eclogue) and caused him to be understood for many centuries as an inspired prophet of the Christian revelation.¹⁹ Insofar as this

image remains associated with Virgil the poet, his death becomes less of a universal human experience and more the experience of a particular, uniquely gifted individual. While Grischa's death is also that of an individual at a particular time and place, Zweig's focus on the psychology and physiology of dying may bring us closer to the existential bedrock which Kahler saw as the final goal of the novel's inward turn.

Notes

1. Erich Kahler, *The Inward Turn of Narrative*, trans. Richard and Clara Winston (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 1987).
2. Ernst Mach, *Die Analyse der Empfindungen und das Verhältniss des Physischen zum Psychischen*, 2nd ed. (Jena: Gustav Fischer, 1900), 17.
3. William James, *The Principles of Psychology*, ed. Frederick H. Burkhardt (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1981), 233. On earlier occurrences of the term, see Helen Groth and Natalya Lusty, *Dreams and Modernity: A Cultural History* (New York: Routledge, 2013), 49–54.
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9. Rilke, *Notebooks*, 68.
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11. On this Oriental motif, see Julie Allen, "Dreaming of Denmark: Orientalism and Otherness in Schnitzler's *Traumnovelle*," in *Modern Austrian Literature* 42.2 (2009): 263–82; on Orientalism in turn-of-the-century Austrian literature, see Robert Lemon, *Imperial Messages: Orientalism as Self-Critique in the Habsburg Fin de Siècle* (Rochester, NY: Camden House, 2011).
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13. Sigmund Freud, *Letters of Sigmund Freud, 1873–1939*, ed. Ernst L. Freud, trans. Tania and James Stern (London: The Hogarth Press, 1961), 344–5.
14. See Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, trans. Graham Parkes (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005), 11–13 and 30.
15. Thomas Mann, *The Magic Mountain*, trans. John E. Woods (London: Everyman's Library, 2005), 260.
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17. Theodore Ziolkowski, *Dimensions of the Modern Novel: German Texts and European Contexts* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1969), 243.
18. Hermann Broch, *The Death of Virgil*, trans. Jean Starr Untermeyer (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1983), 415.
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*Mann's Modernism**Todd Kontje*

As he was in the midst of writing *Doctor Faustus* (1947) in the summer of 1944, Thomas Mann was concerned about his place in the modernist tradition. He worried that in comparison to James Joyce's "eccentric avant-gardism" his own "work was bound to seem like lukewarm traditionalism." After reading Harry Levin's introduction to James Joyce, however, Mann was reassured that despite their stylistic differences, he and Joyce shared a similar sense of belatedness. Both authors wrote about "the decomposition of the middle class" and each in his own way was writing "a novel to end all novels."¹ When *Doctor Faustus* appeared a few years later, however, Mann was bitterly disappointed to read a sharply critical review in *The New York Times* by none other than Harry Levin. To add insult to injury, Mann "learned that Levin had changed the title of his famous Harvard course, 'Proust, Joyce, and Mann,' to 'Proust, Joyce, and Kafka.'"²

Although this particular incident occurred relatively late in life, it reawakened debates about Mann's modernism that stretched back to the beginning of his career. His first novel, *Buddenbrooks* (1901), became a perennial bestseller at least in part because it was a gripping good read, a seemingly old-fashioned, multigenerational saga of a family in decline told with vivid realistic detail. Even Mann worried that he had stooped too low in his little-read second novel, *Royal Highness* (1909), a comic tale of a German prince who marries an American millionaire. He spent months working on a never-completed essay in which he struggled to defend himself against the charge that he was a mere *Schriftsteller*, an uninspired writer of popular prose who lacked the sublime genius of the true poet or

Dichter.³ In more sanguine moments, however, Mann acknowledged and even took pride in the conviction that his prose could bridge the gap between high art and entertainment. As he put it in a letter to Hermann Hesse, “I want to appeal to stupid readers too.”⁴

Mann’s novels are like the proverbial Trojan horse, reassuringly realistic on the outside but subversively modern within. In the following chapter I will highlight defining features of Mann’s modernism: decadence, essayism, montage, myth, and exoticism. I suggest his affinities to other modernist writers while stressing the peculiar flavor of his literary works. As we shall see, Mann did not simply reject nineteenth-century realism, but adapted and subverted it in accordance with his modernist sensibilities and thereby transformed realism into a modernist style.

Decadence

The decades following the first German unification in 1871 were marked by an unprecedented industrial and military expansion. A sense of exuberance and unbridled national chauvinism filled the air. Intellectuals spoke of Germany as a Faustian nation, plunging recklessly forward to fulfill its destiny; imperialists clamored for their place in the sun.⁵ Monuments were erected to such national heroes as Arminius or Hermann, who had once defeated the Roman legions, and Kaiser Barbarossa, who seemed on the verge of awakening from his centuries-long slumber to summon Germany to martial glory. Larger-than-life heroes strode the stage of Wagner’s operas, while Karl May’s Old Shatterhand tamed the American wilderness with a combination of Saxon wit and Germanic brawn. Nietzsche’s Zarathustra commanded his disciples to “become hard,” inspiring a generation of German youths to join the *Wandervogel* and hike through the healthy countryside, while Max Nordau envisioned a “muscular Judaism” that would transform degenerate modern Jews into Zionist pioneers.⁶

“How I hate ‘healthy’ men,” wrote the twenty-year-old Thomas Mann to his friend Otto Grautoff.⁷ Although Mann was an avid bicyclist during his early years in Munich and took daily walks

throughout his life, he had a deep-seated aversion to the stench of sweat-drenched machismo that filled the air of imperial Germany and wafted its way into the Nazi era. "Having grown up in the atmosphere of a bellicose, triumphant, and rejuvenated Fatherland," writes Mann of young Hanno Buddenbrook's schoolmates in a passage inspired by his own experiences as an adolescent in Lübeck, "they had embraced the habits of crude virility High on their list of virtues were physical strength, gymnastic skill, and prowess at drinking and smoking; the most despicable vices were effeminacy and dandyism."⁸ Yet Mann, like Kafka, *was* a dandy; photographs invariably reveal a stylishly dressed man with a flair for style.⁹ His protagonists may be attracted to physically charming if intellectually limited young men – for example, Tonio Kröger, who pines wistfully for the handsome Hans Hansen – but they tend to be dreamy, sickly, and even physically deformed: Little Herr Friedemann is a hunchback; Prince Klaus Heinrich of *Royal Highness* has a withered left hand.

Mann's interest in decadence and dandyism links him to a nineteenth-century tradition that extends from the impossibly good-looking and impeccably tailored heroes of Balzac's fiction to Baudelaire's elegant *flaneur*, from the sensationally decadent Lord Byron to the devastating wit of Oscar Wilde. All are joined by a studied indifference to the instrumental reason that drives modern industry, by an ironic detachment from the earnest morality of respectable bourgeois society. Yet Thomas Mann differed from those such as Byron, Wilde, or his contemporary German Stefan George, who were willing to flout tradition with a flamboyant cult of personality. Mann may have been a stylish dresser, but he was no "gypsy in a green wagon,"¹⁰ as Tonio Kröger puts it; his sexual desires may have been overwhelmingly homosexual, but he maintained a respectable façade as a married man and the father of six children. There was always the threat, however, that the façade might crumble, that the respectable mask may be torn off. "It is the idea of visitation by drunken, ruinous, and destructive powers invading a life of composure that, with all its hopes for dignity and a modicum of happiness, is sworn to that very composure."¹¹

A deep philosophical pessimism pervades Mann's modernism that has its roots in the work of Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, and Wagner. From Schopenhauer Mann learned of the Will, an amoral life force that has us in its grasp and makes a mockery of human reason and its delusions of progress. The best we can hope for are fleeting moments of aesthetic pleasure that grant us temporary respite from its inexorable force. The early Nietzsche tried to wrest the promise of rejuvenation from Schopenhauer's bleak worldview, arguing in *The Birth of Tragedy* that a plunge into the Dionysian waters of Wagner's music could strip off the stultifying constraints of bourgeois society and give birth to a new more vital and authentic Apollonian culture. Nietzsche's faith in Wagner's revitalizing powers proved short-lived, however, yielding to the view that Wagner was in fact a charlatan whose music was calculated to produce the effect of inspiration among the masses but was not truly inspired.

Nietzsche's increasingly critical perspective on Wagner's music informs a central tension within Mann's work. On the one hand, Mann's fiction might be said to center on a single theme: the effort to draw inspiration from destruction, to harness the chthonic power of the Will, to give Apollinian form to Dionysian rapture. For this reason he repeatedly writes of artists whose genius is heightened by illness. *Buddenbrooks* tells the story of a family whose physical decline releases hitherto unknown aesthetic sensibilities. Hans Castorp discovers new philosophical and artistic interests when infected with a touch of tuberculosis on the magic mountain, and in *Doctor Faustus*, Adrian Leverkühn breaks through stale musical conventions to a new vitality in his compositions only after he has contracted syphilis. On the other hand, Mann's fiction is haunted by dilettantes and poseurs who aspire to profundity but erect only a decadent façade devoid of authentic feeling or genuine inspiration. One thinks of the title character in his short story, *Bajazzo* (*Joker*, 1897), a morose young aesthete who wanders aimlessly around Europe, the self-styled "writer" in *Tristan* who has in fact published virtually nothing, or the handsome but vapid Felix Krull, who glides through life with the effortless grace of a con man. Neither Thomas nor Hanno Buddenbrook is able to turn his artistic sensibility into the

production of art, for Hanno dies horribly of typhoid fever before reaching adulthood and Thomas suffers the grotesque indignity of being killed by a rotten tooth.

Essayism

In the fourth chapter of *The Magic Mountain* (1924), Mann interrupts the story of Hans Castorp's early days at the sanatorium with a narrative excursus on the subjective experience of time: the longer we stay in one place and follow a familiar routine, the faster time seems to slide by. Mann's garrulous narrator extends his reflections at the beginning of the seventh chapter, as he ponders the abstract question of whether it might be possible to "narrate time – time as such, in and of itself."¹² Meanwhile Naphta has made his appearance, and he and Settembrini have begun their seemingly interminable debates about the relative virtues of the Enlightenment versus medieval scholasticism, the democratic nation-state versus the authoritarian City of God, Western democracy versus Oriental despotism.

These discussions and narrative digressions interrupt the otherwise realistic descriptions of character and event in *The Magic Mountain*, transforming a novel about a young man's unexpectedly long visit with his cousin in a Swiss sanatorium into an example of what David Luft has termed "philosophical essayism": "the novel moved away from the story and immediate aesthetic totality in the direction of essayism, interpretation, and fragmented form."¹³ Hermann Broch's *The Sleepwalkers* (1930–32) inserts abstract discussions about the disintegration of values into a tale about life in modern Germany. Hermann Hesse begins *The Glass Bead Game* (1943) with a critical essay about the modern "Age of the Feuilleton," while Robert Musil's colossal fragment, *The Man Without Qualities* (written 1921–42), raises hypothetical questions about God and chance in a society torn between science and subjectivity. Luft argues that such novels reflect the state of "transcendental homelessness" that Georg Lukács found typical of modernity.¹⁴ In the place of philosophical systems of

metaphysical certainty, we have novelists who make fragmented forays into abstract thought that disrupt realism without yielding systematic closure or ultimate truth in keeping with the spirit of Nietzsche's aphoristic literary style. Such writers as Broch, Hesse, Musil, and Mann "believed that the tasks of philosophy, literature, and cultural criticism had converged" (*RM* 20); "what was perceived elsewhere as the end of the novel was defined by these German writers as the characteristic fulfillment of the form" (*RM* 18).

Philosophical essayism abounds in Mann's later fiction. *Joseph and His Brothers* (1933–43) begins with a forty-page "prelude" on the nature of time and the meaning of myth. *Doctor Faustus* recapitulates in detail Wendell Kretzschmar's lectures on the history of Western music, and concepts from his talks resurface in the debate between Adrian Leverkühn and the devil in the twenty-fifth chapter. Professor Antonio José Kuckkuck entertains Felix Krull with lectures about the origins of life and the theory of evolution. Naphta and Settembrini debate the merits of democracy and the Enlightenment at great length in *The Magic Mountain*, while *Joseph the Provider* (1943) includes detailed disquisitions about the relationship between polytheism and monotheism in ancient Egypt. Such passages can create the impression that Mann was an immensely erudite and profound writer; less sympathetic readers may find him superficial and sententious. Almost inevitably, however, Mann punctures the speculative bubble of abstract discussions and pseudo-philosophical debates with a return to realism. Hans Castorp has a seemingly profound insight into the meaning of life, but his vision in the snow may have been provoked by a combination of altitude and alcohol; in any case he quickly forgets what he thought he once knew. Naphta and Settembrini talk on and on, completely oblivious to the fact that poor, sick Joachim Ziemssen is turning blue with cold. Adrian Leverkühn's debate with the devil may well be a syphilitic hallucination. And Mann leaves it up to his readers to decide how seriously they ought to take the pronouncements of a professor named Kuckkuck.

Montage

When questioned about the extent of his seemingly encyclopedic knowledge into topics ranging from epistemology to entomology, from Chaldean mythology to Catholic theology, Mann insisted that he learned only as much as he needed to know about a given subject for the purpose of his fiction. When he completed a project, he packed up his notes and his manuscript and moved on to a new topic. He further dispelled any sense of his omniscience by admitting that he had no qualms about borrowing ideas and even incorporating the precise words of other writers into his fiction in a practice that he cheerfully labeled “a kind of high-class plagiarism.”¹⁵ In *The Story of a Novel* Mann tips his hand to reveal many, but by no means all, of the sources he incorporated into *Doctor Faustus*.¹⁶ These range from Luther's Bible and Adorno's demanding *Philosophy of Modern Music* to his own essays and an article on the bathysphere culled from the pages of *Life* magazine. Mann's use of what he termed his *montage technique* was not limited to *Doctor Faustus*, however; the famous description of the typhoid fever that fells Hanno Buddenbrook in Mann's first novel was drawn from previously published sources as were the impromptu lectures of Dr. Kuckkuck in Mann's last. Before beginning to write on a given project Mann gathered together what could amount to a small library of source material – we owe the novella *Mario and the Magician* (1930) to the fact that Mann was away from his Munich villa and thus unable to access the books necessary for work on the Joseph novels – but once underway he could incorporate serendipitous discoveries into his preconceived plans.

Not everyone who found their ideas or words in one of Mann's novels was willing to excuse intellectual property theft in the name of artistic license. Arnold Schoenberg was furious to discover the ideas behind his twelve-tone or row technique in *Doctor Faustus* and insisted that all subsequent editions of the novel contain a footnote identifying him as the source of this concept. Mann reluctantly agreed in an effort to placate the avant-garde composer, while at the same time being convinced that Schoenberg was missing the

point of his innovative techniques. In the theoretical passages in *Doctor Faustus* Mann outlines the history of Western art as it liberates itself from service to the Church or the State to become the autonomous vehicle for bourgeois self-understanding. Innovation becomes the key factor that distinguishes a pioneering work of the artistic avant-garde from the hackneyed clichés of popular culture. Novelty does not last long, however; a musical motif or chord progression that seemed strikingly original in the work of one composer might seem tediously familiar in the next. At a certain point innovation reaches a dead end and the modern composer is reduced to the sterile parody of exhausted forms. Adrian Leverkühn tries to break through this artistic impasse by voluntarily surrendering his freedom to the constraints of a strict style that determines in advance the sequence of notes that structures his composition. The autonomous artwork produced by the unique creative genius yields to a skillful assemblage of prefabricated parts. One thinks of the Cubist collages of Pablo Picasso and Georges Braque, Marcel Duchamps' Dadaist Ready-Mades, Andy Warhol's reproductions of Campbell's soup can labels, or the willful eclecticism of postmodern architecture.

Thomas Mann's use of the montage technique in *Doctor Faustus* has been viewed as just such a voluntary renunciation of artistic freedom, as Mann cuts and pastes previously published prose into his text; the novel puts into practice the theory of modern art that informs Leverkühn's imaginary compositions. Yet there is a crucial difference between Mann's modernism and the calculated shock effect of Duchamps' decision to mount a urinal in a museum, for Mann cloaks his innovations with a veneer of tradition; he spackles a layer of realistic stucco over the bricks of his modernist montage. The result, once again, is a calculated compromise in a work of art that seeks to bridge the gap between high and low, to appeal simultaneously to the smart and the stupid.

Myth

Death in Venice (1912) begins as a work of realistic fiction: a middle-aged writer reaches an impasse and decides to clear his head by

taking a walk. We can trace his path through the streets of Munich from his apartment on Prinz-Regentenstrasse through the English Gardens to the Northern Cemetery, just as we will be able to follow his routes on water and land through the city of Venice. Already in the opening pages, however, Gustav von Aschenbach drifts into a daydream that transports him to a tropical landscape filled with exotic plants and threatening animals. Time for a vacation, he thinks, trying to shrug off the disturbing vision, but as we know, his trip to Venice will not end well. Shortly before he dies, Aschenbach has a second disturbing vision, a vivid nightmare in which he becomes an eyewitness to and eventually a participant in a frenzied bacchic orgy that removes all traces of the self-control that had once distinguished this celebrated European writer.

At first glance Mann seems to have punctuated his otherwise realistic narrative with fantastic visions that we can attribute to Aschenbach's deteriorating mind; that they take the form of classical mythology is in keeping with his character. Upon rereading Mann's novella, however, we discover that many of the seemingly realistic characters and events can also be read as thinly veiled mythic allusions: the mysteriously threatening red-haired man in the cemetery doubles as Hermes in his guise as the guide to the underworld; the black gondola is a floating coffin crossing the river Styx, the gondolier is an incarnation of Charon, and so on and so forth. The myth that seemed an aberration from a realistic norm turns out to be the structuring framework of a story cloaked in a translucent veil of plausible detail.

Northrop Frye uses the term "displacement" to describe such retellings of ancient myths in modern disguise.¹⁷ *The Magic Mountain*, for instance, presents a realistic account of life in a Swiss sanatorium – so realistic, in fact, that the doctors at the sanatorium where Mann visited his wife threatened to sue the author for his unflattering depiction of their enterprise – but the literal journey to a high altitude clinic can also be read as a figurative descent to the timeless underworld. *Joseph and His Brothers* follows a similar pattern: the hero descends not once but three times to a realm of symbolic death, as he is cast by his brothers into the well, sold into

slavery, and sent off to prison, only to rise each time to greater glory. *The Holy Sinner* (1951) recasts the legend of Pope Gregory as a medieval Oedipus; *Felix Krull* (1954) features a picaresque hero as a modern Narcissus, and Adrian Leverkühn does double duty as an avant-garde composer and a reincarnation of Faust.

Often Mann's stories and novels can be read as transpositions of Wagnerian opera into fiction, most notoriously in the case of the decadent Jewish twins of the novella *Wälsungenblut* (*The Blood of the Walsungs*, 1905) who are inspired to imitate Wagner's demigods by committing incest after a performance of *Die Walküre*.¹⁸ Mann admitted that he was thinking of *Die Meistersinger* as he brought the romantic comedy of *Royal Highness* to its happy ending, a triumph that he reprised in a majestic key in the closing chapters of *Joseph the Provider*. The *Joseph* tetralogy begins with a prelude inspired by the opening chords of *Das Rheingold*, a musical narrative that ripples up from the depths of time and rises to a majestic crescendo. Detlev Spinell tries to seduce Gabriele Klöterjahn by playing passages from *Tristan* in the novella of that name, while both Clavdia Chauchat and Potiphar's wife, Mut-em-enet, can be viewed as modern Russian and ancient Egyptian incarnations of *Tannhäuser's* Venus. Even *Buddenbrooks*, Mann's early tribute to the tradition of nineteenth-century realism, transposes the epic conflicts of Wagnerian gods into the offices and bedrooms of the bourgeoisie. The novel begins with a dinner party to celebrate the Buddenbrooks' lavish new home on Meng Strasse, just as the gods walk across the rainbow bridge to their new palace of Valhalla at the end of *Das Rheingold*, and both men and gods go down in the flames of their respective *Götterdämmerungen*.

Mann incorporates mythic elements into his modern fiction for two diametrically opposed reasons. On the one hand, Mann's realism simultaneously disguises and discovers the timeless truths of ancient myth as viewed through the lens of modern pessimism. Aschenbach's dream opens a window to the Will, a Dionysian realm of seething lust that destroys all decorum. The window reopens for Hans Castorp to reveal horrible hags munching on bloody babies; we see Mut-em-enet driven to obscene rituals by

her obsessive lust, and we hear the barbaric howling of Adrian Leverkühn's *Lamentation of Doctor Faustus*. On the other hand, however, Mann uses myth to address issues of central political importance in his contemporary society, including, most importantly, the rise of German National Socialism.

When war broke out in August 1914, the previously "non-political man" found himself swept up in the general patriotic enthusiasm. Within weeks he had published an essay, "Thoughts in War," in which the influence of Nietzsche's work is unmistakable. Mann views the military struggle between Germany and France in terms of an ideological conflict between German culture (*Kultur*) and French civilization (*Zivilisation*). He equates civilization with reason, the Enlightenment, intellect; "it is the sworn enemy of drives, passions; it is anti-demonic, anti-heroic." Culture, in contrast, gives form to the "emanations of a deeper, darker, and hotter world." Civilization is decorum without depth, social etiquette without sex; culture taps into the chthonic power of oracles, magic, orgiastic cults, and ritual violence.¹⁹ German culture gives Apollinian form to Dionysian passion, whereas French civilization remains mere Socratic reason, skeptical and sterile.

Mann spent much of the war expanding these ideas into the *Reflections of a Non-Political Man* (1918), which center on a bitter critique of his brother Heinrich as "civilization's literary man," a Francophile traitor to German culture. By the time he wrote the preface to the completed essay, however, Mann's anger had cooled to a melancholy awareness that he was fighting a lost cause with the enemy's weapons: words, reason, rhetoric, not music, feeling, or myth. Within a few years Mann had completed a remarkable about-face: the man who had heaped scorn on French civilization found himself publicly defending Western reason and the fledgling democracy of the Weimar Republic. Mann's conversion was motivated by the changing political landscape of postwar Germany. As he notes in the preface to *The Magic Mountain*, the war had completely and irrevocably swept away the past. Chaos reigned where stability had once been the norm. Mann was shocked by the assassination of Walther Rathenau by right wing radicals and he watched the rising

power of Hitler and the Nazi Party with growing alarm. In such a dangerous political climate, Mann grew increasingly impatient with the reactionary intellectuals of the “Conservative Revolution,” who continued to disparage reason and democracy in favor of mysticism and myth.²⁰

Over the course of the next two decades Thomas Mann battled on multiple fronts against the eclipse of reason. In 1930 he had to beat a hasty retreat from a Berlin lecture hall after delivering an impassioned “Address to the Germans: An Appeal to Reason.” Other essays praise Freud and Lessing as enlightened alternatives to such figures as Dostoevsky, Spengler, Wagner, and Nietzsche, whom Mann viewed with increasing critical distance. Although he hesitated during the first years of exile to speak out in public against the Nazis, Mann eventually did break his silence to become the most prominent member of the exile community in the struggle against Nazi Germany. Mann’s rejection of irrationalism carried over into his fiction as well. The Goethe of *Lotte in Weimar* (*The Beloved Returns*, 1939) maintains a skeptical distance from the nationalist hotheads in pursuit of Napoleon, arguing that Germans should cultivate a cosmopolitan openness rather than militant nationalism. In *Doctor Faustus* Mann lays partial blame for the rise of National Socialism at the feet of irresponsible intellectuals who dabble in reactionary ideologies without considering the potential political consequences of their thought. Mann described the entire Joseph project as the effort to wrest myth from the hands of the fascists, as his protagonist emerges from the darkness of superstition and prejudice into the light of reason; *Doctor Faustus* provides the negative counterexample of a man who casts restraint aside in his quest for artistic inspiration and pays the price in madness and death.

Exoticism

The Nazi ideology was racist to the core, founded on faith in the “Aryan myth” and fear of racial contamination that motivated an unprecedented program of mass extermination.²¹ The Holocaust may have been unique in the annals of evil, but the racist sentiments

that lay behind it were not. The European exploration and colonization of the non-European world brought with it a growing interest in ethnic diversity and racial difference. Immanuel Kant was one of many who wrote treatises on race in the eighteenth century; whether intentionally or not, Darwin's theory of evolution and Nietzsche's concept of the blonde beast fueled the biological racism of such figures as Joseph Arthur de Gobineau, Houston Stewart Chamberlain, and Alfred Rosenberg.²² In an age of near total European domination of the globe, prejudice against colonized peoples was the norm; as Edward Said puts it, "every European, in what he could say about the Orient, was consequently a racist, an imperialist, and almost totally ethnocentric."²³

Modern artists were nevertheless drawn to the non-European world as a vital alternative to the sterility of conventional bourgeois culture. Already in the eighteenth century Rousseau and Herder laid the foundation for an interest in the "noble savage" that would influence such diverse writers as François-René de Chateaubriand, James Fenimore Cooper, and Henry Wadsworth Longfellow. Paul Gauguin turned his back on modern France to seek a simpler culture in Tahiti; Pablo Picasso incorporated the facial features of African masks into his portraits of Parisian prostitutes, and Wilhelm Worringer argued for an appreciation of African sculpture in works that had a decisive influence on European expressionism.

Thomas Mann was openly scornful of the Nazi theories of racial superiority and repulsed by the Holocaust, but he also shared some of the prejudices of his contemporaries. His diaries reveal a frequent curiosity about individuals' ethnic origins that sometimes slides into racism, an ambivalence that also marks his complex relationship with Jews, which hovers between philo- and anti-Semitism.²⁴ Questions of race took on particular urgency for Mann because his mother was of partial Portuguese descent, born in Brazil, and raised by slaves before she was brought to Germany at the age of six or seven. Whether or not there was any objective truth to Mann's frequently stated conviction that his mother's heritage set him slightly apart from his fellow Germans, he was convinced that it did; his sense of racial difference combined with his repressed homosexuality and his

artistic inclinations made him feel alternately distinguished and stigmatized, an ambivalence reflected most memorably in the appropriately named Tonio Kröger, whose conflicting impulses between bourgeois respectability and artistic bohemianism are directly attributed to his mixture of German and Latin blood.

Mann repeatedly links Dionysian passion to racial difference and geographic distance from Europe in his modern fiction. We are told in the opening pages of *Death in Venice* that Gustav von Aschenbach has never ventured beyond Europe in his travels, and yet he succumbs to a cholera epidemic that originates in India on the shores of the Ganges. The former colonial plantation owner, Mynheer Peeperkorn, commits suicide with cobra venom from the Malaysian jungles in *The Magic Mountain*. At the height of her passion for Joseph, Potiphar's wife enlists the aid of Tabubu, a withered African witch who dabbles in black magic. Adrian Leverkühn incorporates "magical, fanatical African drums" into his apocalyptic art.²⁵

Mann's modernism gives him the essayistic tools he needs to diagnose the evils of National Socialism, but his fiction is also infused with decadence, exoticism, and myth in ways that play into the hands of the ideology it would refute. He rejects National Socialism as the political manifestation of philosophical irrationalism even as he remains wedded to his personal understanding of the artist as one who gives Apollinian form to Dionysian passion; he rejects racism even as he draws on the reservoir of the imperialist imagination. In other words, Mann's politics evolved from conservative nationalism to anti-fascist cosmopolitanism, but the structure of his literary imagination remained the same. As a result, his critique of German fascism takes on a central ambivalence in *Doctor Faustus*, which suggests on the one hand that German intellectuals prepared the way for political disaster by rejecting reason and democracy; they could and should have done otherwise, as Mann did in his role as the Nazis' public enemy number one. On the other hand, Mann demonizes the German soul, suggesting that National Socialism is merely the latest outbreak of a madness that lies latent within. There is nothing to be done; philosophical pessimism vitiates any

hope for political progress, and the Germans are doomed to the eternal recurrence of the same.

Notes

1. Thomas Mann, *The Story of a Novel: The Genesis of Doctor Faustus*, trans. Richard and Clara Winston (New York: Knopf, 1961), 91.
2. Anthony Heilbut, *Thomas Mann: Eros and Literature* (New York: Knopf, 1995), 483.
3. Hans Wysling, "'Geist und Kunst': Thomas Manns Notizen zu einem 'Literatur-Essay,'" *Thomas Mann Studien* 1 (1967): 123–233.
4. "*Mich verlangt auch nach den Dummen*" (italics in original), to Hermann Hesse, April 1, 1910, in *Hermann Hesse Thomas Mann Briefwechsel*, eds. Anni Carlsson and Volker Michels (Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 1999), 44.
5. Hans Schwerte, *Faust und das Faustische: Ein Kapitel deutscher Ideologie* (Stuttgart: Klett, 1962).
6. Todd Samuel Presner, *Muscular Judaism: The Jewish Body and the Politics of Regeneration* (New York: Routledge, 2007).
7. Quoted in Heilbut, *Thomas Mann*, 18.
8. Thomas Mann, *Buddenbrooks: The Decline of a Family*, trans. John E. Woods (New York: Knopf, 1993), 694–5.
9. Mark Anderson, *Kafka's Clothes: Ornament and Aestheticism in the Hapsburg Fin de Siècle* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1992).
10. Thomas Mann, "Tonio Kröger," trans. David Luke, in *Death in Venice, Tonio Kröger, and Other Writings*, ed. Frederick Lubich (New York: Continuum, 2003), 4.
11. Thomas Mann, *Joseph and His Brothers*, trans. John E. Woods (New York: Knopf, 2005), 882.
12. Thomas Mann, *The Magic Mountain: A Novel*, trans. John E. Woods (New York: Knopf, 1995), 531.
13. David S. Luft, *Robert Musil and the Crisis of European Culture 1880–1942* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1980), 18. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*RM*).
14. Georg Lukács, *The Theory of the Novel: A Historico-Philosophical Essay on the Forms of Great Epic Literature*, trans. Anna Bostock (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1971), 41.
15. Thomas Mann to Theodor W. Adorno, December 30, 1945: "Aber ich weiß nur zu wohl, daß ich mich schon früh in einer Art von höherem Abschreiben geübt habe" [But I know all too well that I practiced a kind of high-class plagiarism early on (in my career)]. Mann, *Briefe 1937–47*, ed. Erika Mann (Frankfurt am Main: Fischer, 1963), 470.

16. For more sources see Gunilla Bergsten, *Thomas Mann's Doctor Faustus: The Sources and Structure of the Novel*, trans. Krishna Winston (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1969).
17. Northrop Frye, *Anatomy of Criticism: Four Essays* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1957), 136.
18. On Mann and music, see Hans Rudolf Vaegt, *Seelenzauber: Thomas Mann und die Musik* (Frankfurt am Main: Fischer, 2006); Eckhard Heftrich, *Zauberbergmusik: Über Thomas Mann* (Frankfurt am Main: Klostermann, 1975).
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20. Fritz Stern, *The Politics of Cultural Despair: A Study in the Rise of the Germanic Ideology* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1961); Jeffrey Herf, *Reactionary Modernism: Technology, Culture, and Politics in Weimar and the Third Reich* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1984).
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23. Edward W. Said, *Orientalism* (New York: Vintage, 1979), 204.
24. Todd Kontje, *Thomas Mann's World: Empire, Race, and the Jewish Question* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2011).
25. Mann, *Doctor Faustus*, 393.

Democratic Form and Narrative Proportion in Joyce and Dos Passos

Sam Alexander

The novel, in the hands of an unscrupulous writer, could be despotic. [...] It was undemocratic to compel characters to be uniformly good or bad or poor or rich. Each should be allowed a private life, self-determination and a decent standard of living.

Flann O'Brien, *At Swim-Two-Birds*

We tend to think of the novel as a democratic genre, one that rose out of and tended to verify, on a number of levels from form to ideology, theories of liberal democracy from Wilhelm von Humboldt to John Stuart Mill. As Nancy Ruttenburg points out, the novel's focus on "the common person," its elevation of "interiority [and] self-scrutiny over authority," and its orientation toward "a growing middle, commercial class" have led theorists to view it as the most democratic of literary forms.¹ However, in the above passage from *At Swim-Two-Birds* that serves as my epigraph, Flann O'Brien calls for a novel that would be democratic not in its subject matter or appeal, but in the way it treats its characters. O'Brien's critique of "undemocratic" characterization outlines (in negative form) what such a democratic novel might look like, and builds on the modernist approach to character expounded by James Joyce.

For O'Brien, the characters in a democratic novel, like citizens in a democracy, would have autonomy or "self-determination." Characters are not real, of course, and their fates are ultimately determined by their authors. In their demands on our sympathy and attention, however, they engage us very much as real people do, and Joyce often suggests that he has an ethical duty to give full and fair representation to the individuals he has created. He seems to

envision Molly Bloom, for instance, as a real person who takes issue with his representation of her when he has her call out in “Penelope,” “O Jamesey let me up out of this.”² The conceit of self-willed characters, which O’Brien amplifies in *At Swim-Two-Birds* when he has a group of characters overthrow the novelist who created them, is a playful way of making a serious point. The author’s treatment of his characters models a particular kind of ethical relationship and even – to the extent that he structures their relations with each other and assigns them a share of narrative attention – a particular kind of political organization.

Along these lines, O’Brien suggests that the democratic novel must also be impartial toward its characters. It must refuse to judge any character (as readers of *Ulysses* have sometimes judged Molly) as “uniformly good or bad.” This call for impartiality recalls Joyce’s emphasis on authorial “indifference” both in *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* and in an early essay in which he credits the playwright Arnold Graves for showing “indifferent sympathy” to his characters.³ A more extreme form of impartiality is the basis of O’Brien’s other requirement for the democratic novel: that it respect the principle of equality not so much in selecting its characters (from the ranks of everyday people, for example), as in developing those selected. In claiming that no character should be “uniformly” one thing or another and that each should be allowed “a private life,” O’Brien objects to the economy of character in which some are “flat” – “constructed round a single idea,” in Forster’s classification – and others “round.”⁴

O’Brien’s demand that each character be granted “a decent standard of living” appropriates the language of political platforms to draw attention to the mismatch between the novel’s democratic ethos and the formal inequality with which it develops some characters at the expense of others. This paradox has been at the center of recent work on nineteenth-century realist fiction. Alex Woloch argues persuasively that the realist novel is “a dialectical literary form generated out of the relationship between inequality and democracy”; its democratic insistence that “any character *can* be a protagonist” is counterbalanced by an unequal formal structure in which

“only one character is.”⁵ Realism’s ideological commitment to democracy, in other words, comes up against the formal inequality of what Woloch calls its character-system – the development and arrangement of characters at the level of discourse. As George Levine points out, “To follow out the democratic impulse . . . fundamental to the development of realism would be to move to a narrative in which there are no focal figures but every figure would gather the fullest sympathetic and imaginative attention.”⁶ To write a novel that was completely democratic in this sense, of course, would be to preclude narrative altogether, which is perhaps why Levine claims that “the ultimate attitude of the realist [is] something like contempt for the impossible enterprise of writing realist novels.”⁷

Some of the most distinctive experiments in modernist fiction, however, attempt the “impossible enterprise” of aligning the novel’s democratic ethos with its formal structure by distributing narrative attention evenly among characters regardless of narrative role. The central “Wandering Rocks” episode of Joyce’s *Ulysses* (1922) forces its protagonists to share the stage equally with a host of minor characters, and extends stream-of-consciousness narration beyond the main protagonists, Leopold Bloom and Stephen Dedalus, to encompass characters such as Tom Kernan and Patrick Dignam. Similarly, an early section of Woolf’s *Mrs. Dalloway* (1925) embeds the novel’s two protagonists in a crowd of Londoners who have little relation to the novel’s plot but whose thoughts are recorded at length in direct and free indirect discourse. On a larger scale, Woolf’s *The Waves* (1931) is narrated as a series of alternating monologues spoken by six characters, and John Dos Passos’s *U.S.A.* trilogy (1930–36) narrates the lives of twelve protagonists who come of age in the first third of the twentieth century.

Such experiments in egalitarian distribution were no doubt motivated in part by the socialism of the novelists, a political influence that Michael Tratner explores in *Modernism and Mass Politics*. But whereas Tratner reads modernist fiction as making a radical break with “nineteenth-century individualist conventions,” I will explore in this chapter the democratic form of Joyce and Dos Passos as an

extension and intensification of what Fredric Jameson has called a “centrifugal tendency” in realist fiction, one that leads “secondary characters to move forward and to eclipse the relationships of the main characters.”⁸ This dispersal of narrative attention away from the protagonist signals realism’s democratic ethos through a formal embodiment of democracy itself, defined as a political system in which, as the political theorist Claude Lefort puts it, “The locus of power” once filled by the monarch “becomes *an empty place*.”⁹ In *Vanity Fair* (1847–48) and *Bleak House* (1852–53), William Makepeace Thackeray and Charles Dickens go farther than most realist novelists in seeking to accommodate this diffusion of narrative attention even as they undercut the hereditary aristocracy. Their important efforts to align the character system of the novel with its egalitarian social principles influenced modernist fiction in ways that require us to rethink the conventional understanding of modernism as a break from realism.

For his part, Joyce sketches this genealogy through a conspicuous web of allusions to Dickens’s *Bleak House* in “Wandering Rocks.” The importance of Dickens to Joyce’s work has been obscured by Stanislaus Joyce’s claim that his brother “never cared for Dickens” and by a particularly harsh parody of *David Copperfield* in “Oxen of the Sun.”¹⁰ It should be remembered, however, that *David Copperfield* and *Bleak House* are very different novels. The first narrates the *Bildung* of a single autobiographical hero. The second – like Inspector Bucket, who “know[s] so much about so many characters, high and low” – tries to tell many stories at once.¹¹ Split between two narrative voices, *Bleak House* resembles *Copperfield* only in the first-person sections narrated by Esther Summerson; and indeed, Esther herself worries constantly about the potential egotism of first-person narration (“I seem to be always writing about myself . . .”) (*BH* 102). As though in answer to Esther’s concern, Dickens adds a third-person narrator who moves between London and the country seat of the Dedlocks as the crow flies, and represents a remarkable number of characters in the process.

Exploring these minor characters in detail is Dickens’s formal means of counteracting the allied and crushingly anti-democratic

institutions of Chancery and the hereditary aristocracy represented by Sir Leicester Dedlock – a man who “supposes all his dependents to be utterly bereft of individual characters” and rejects all democratic reform as “levelling” (*BH* 78). Dickens himself “levels” socio-economic distinctions through a plot that shows how money, information, and disease connect multiple levels of English society, even as he levels distinctions between major and minor characters by allowing secondary figures an unusual share of the novel’s discourse. The montagelike juxtapositions that Dickens uses to achieve this goal has led Alexander Welsh to credit him with “composing in 1852–53 a distinctly modernist text.”¹² Rather than read Dickens’s experimental structure as modernism *avant la lettre*, however, I will read Joyce’s “Wandering Rocks” as a continuation of the realist effort to contrast antidemocratic institutions with democratic form.

Through Dickens’s rival, William Makepeace Thackeray, realism exerted a similar influence on Dos Passos’s effort to reassert American democracy in *U.S.A.* Despite the tendency to associate *U.S.A.* with the radically new – in particular, cinematic montage and avant-garde movements in the visual arts – Dos Passos himself was always careful to mention Thackeray’s realism as a complementary and antecedent influence. After acknowledging the effect of early film on *U.S.A.*, for example, he adds, “I had already been affected . . . by the sort of novel that Thackeray invented in English with *Vanity Fair*.”¹³ In another piece on the genesis of the trilogy he adds, “I remember reading *Vanity Fair* for the tenth time rather early in my life; after that I lost count.”¹⁴ Dos Passos took over from *Vanity Fair* the effort to use an egalitarian character system as a literary means of countering socio-economic inequality. That inequality was Thackeray’s main theme, and it determined his characterization of hypocritical aristocrats such as Miss Crawley, who tells Becky Sharp, “I consider you, my love, as my equal in every respect,” only to “make her equal run of her errands, fetch her millinery, and read her to sleep.”¹⁵

Thackeray counters the arbitrary and inequitable social structure exemplified by Miss Crawley not only through parody, but also by making equality itself into a formal principle. *Vanity Fair* is subtitled

A Novel without a Hero, and its narrator rejects every possible criterion for selecting an individual protagonist – including Becky Sharp’s cunning, Amelia Sedley’s virtue (sufficient to make a heroine for many of the conventional Victorian novels that Thackeray lampoons), George Osborne’s martial heroism (as soon as George distinguishes himself at the Battle of Waterloo, halfway through *Vanity Fair*, he dies). Rather than select a single hero, Thackeray distributes attention according to what he calls “the rules of all proportion” (*VF* 136). These rules lead him to maintain a focus on Becky even when her life has become rather dull, and to shift the narrative focus from Waterloo back to “a number of persons living peaceably in England who . . . must come in for their share of the chronicle” (*VF* 406). Dos Passos follows Thackeray when he appeals to what he calls in one essay “our true sense of proportion” by devoting narrative attention to characters whose social and narrative importance – and often, as a result, their interest to the reader – are at a low ebb.¹⁶ This strategy risks boring readers, but it also forces them to identify with characters who are as marginal with regard to the main storyline as they are to the centers of American power.

The experiments with narrative form in *Bleak House* and *Vanity Fair* help illuminate the ethics of the modernist novel by drawing attention to its efforts to model democracy in its own organization of characters. They urge us to question some of our assumptions about literary history and demonstrate the extent to which Joyce and Dos Passos create forms of what Jameson has called “modernist realism.”¹⁷ In their engagement with the realist styles of Dickens and Thackeray, Joyce and Dos Passos, I argue, intensified the realist drive for narrative proportion in an effort to test the democratic potential of the novel.

Vere dignum et iustum est: Joyce’s “Wandering Rocks”

“Wandering Rocks” juxtaposes anti-democratic institutions with the “Citizens” who populate the episode and whom Joyce identifies with the Wandering Rocks in the schema he gave Stuart Gilbert.¹⁸ The

opening and closing sections of the episode represent the two major sources of institutional power in Irish society: the Church represented by Father Conmee and the colonial government represented by the Vice Regal Cavalcade. These sections are constantly interrupted, however, by the “citizens” who command the attention of Conmee and the lord lieutenant as they pass through Dublin. This form of interrupted attention models the character system of “Wandering Rocks” as a whole, which brings forward a host of characters who, until this point in the novel, have been relegated to the background. This experiment with a more egalitarian distribution of narrative attention extends the project undertaken by Dickens in *Bleak House*, as Joyce suggests through a number of allusions to Dickens’s novel.

The aristocratic characters in “Wandering Rocks” – William Humble, Earl of Dudley and his wife, Lady Dudley – resemble the Dedlocks of *Bleak House* both in the consonance of their names and in their formal function. Like the Dedlocks, the Dudleys enjoy a privilege that is both socio-political and formal: the lord lieutenant rules Ireland, but his progress also unifies the space of “Wandering Rocks.” Yet Joyce, like Dickens, undercuts that privilege by allowing minor characters’ thoughts and stories to erupt into the passage devoted to the Dudleys’ journey:

Between Queen’s and Whitworth bridges lord Dudley’s viceregal carriages passed and were unsaluted by Mr Dudley White, B.L., M.A., who stood on Arran quay outside Mrs M.E. White’s, the pawnbroker’s, at the corner of Arran street west stroking his nose with his forefinger, undecided whether he should arrive at Phibsborough more quickly by a triple change of tram or by hailing a car or on foot through Smithfield, Constitution hill and Broadstone terminus. (*U* 10.1184–90)

The syntax of this passage demonstrates how narrative attention moves centrifugally away from any focal character in “Wandering Rocks.” Clauses and phrases pile on top of one another as new characters enter the scene; we know their thoughts and itineraries, regardless of their connection to Dudley. Indeed, there is not even the minimal connection of a greeting to justify this excursus, since

Dudley is “unsaluted” in the prepositional phrase that begins the syntactical movement away from him. By the end of the passage, we know as much about “Mr Dudley White” as we do about the lord with whom he shares a name.

The periphery of the character system commands as much attention as the center in “Wandering Rocks,” and Joyce diverts his focus not only from the Dudleys but also from his own protagonists. He extends and intensifies the democratic energy of *Bleak House*, particularly the “Tom-all-Alone’s” chapter, in which a third-person narrator rapidly shifts focus to present characters from very different social stations in answer to his own question, “What connexion can there be, between the place Lincolnshire, the house in town, the Mercury in powder, and the whereabouts of Jo the outlaw with the broom[?]” (*BH* 197). A disguised Lady Dedlock traces these connections when she visits the London slum known as “Tom-all-Alone’s,” passes by the office of the powerful Tulkinghorn without being noticed (is “unsaluted,” in Joyce’s terms), and then “crosses with” Jo, a destitute young street-sweep who has already been described in great detail before he meets her (Jo knew her lover and Esther’s father, Captain Hawdon, before he died) (*BH* 200). Like Dickens, Joyce introduces major characters as though they were “dressed up” as minor characters: Lady Dedlock disguises herself for her visit to Tom-All-Alone’s, and Joyce disguises Bloom in his first two appearances as “A darkbacked figure” (*U* 10.315, 520). Dickens’s roving third-person narrator, who is omniscient in his ability to see all of England at once but does not always reveal what he knows, is a model for the “harsh and awkward” narrator of “Wandering Rocks.”¹⁹

Joyce goes further than Dickens in decentering narrative attention. He divides “Wandering Rocks” into nineteen sections, each with its own focal character or characters, and interrupts those sections themselves with “interpolations” that give a simultaneous view of a character not physically present. Yet he also gestures toward the continuities between this experiment and what might be called the interruptive form of *Bleak House*. In “The Centenary of Charles Dickens,” Joyce praises “the well-crowded Dickensian

gallery,”²⁰ and at the point when the character system of *Ulysses* seems most crowded, the figures in Dickens’s gallery start to surface. Joyce mentions “Poor Joe, the crossing-sweeper” in the essay on Dickens, and Jo is recalled in “Wandering Rocks” by one of the “barefoot urchins” who picks up a coin for a “one-legged sailor” who himself is clearly an allusion to Silas Wegg from *Our Mutual Friend* (both sing “The Death of Nelson”) (*U* 10.256).²¹ The first interpolation in “Wandering Rocks,” which presents a dancing instructor “walking with grave deportment” in another part of the city, is also a glance at Dickens’s Mr. Turveydrop, the “model of deportment” who lets his son run his dancing school for him in *Bleak House* (*U* 10.58, *BH* 171). Another interpolation, this one in the section devoted to Bloom, again alludes to Dickens: “An elderly female, *no more young*, left the building of the courts of chancery . . . having heard in the lord chancellor’s court the case in lunacy of Potterton” (*U* 10.625–7, emphasis added). As Don Gifford points out, Joyce’s “elderly female” strongly resembles Miss Flite, the mad old woman in *Bleak House* who comes every day to the Court of Chancery “expecting some incomprehensible judgment” (*BH* 7).²² With the description “no more young,” Joyce links Miss Flite’s appearance with an unnoticed allusion to *Bleak House* earlier in the episode, and the joint reference further illustrates the shared method by which Joyce and Dickens assert democracy through their character systems.

We see this kind of Dickensian echoing again when Father Conmee ponders aristocratic homes that have become Jesuit schools and projects a book on the first countess of Belvedere, Mary Rochfort, who was accused of adultery with her brother-in-law and placed under house arrest by her husband: “A listless lady, no more young, walked alone the shore of lough Ennel . . . listlessly walking in the evening, not startled when an otter plunged. Who could know the truth?” (*U* 10.164–6). The themes of dynastic betrayal, sexual indiscretion, and secrecy, along with Mary Rochfort’s listless pacing, all point to Dickens’s Lady Dedlock and the story that haunts her throughout *Bleak House*: a previous Lady Dedlock was maimed after betraying her husband, and her spirit will limp along the “Ghost’s Walk”

at Chesney Wold “until the pride of this house is humbled” (*BH* 84). The dual allusion to Lady Dedlock and Miss Flite (both of whom are “no more young”) recalls Dickens’s method in *Bleak House*, in which a profusion of characters encourages the reader to draw unexpected analogies – between Lady Dedlock and Miss Flite as “mothers” to Esther, or between Krook and the Lord Chancellor as low-plot and high-plot rulers amidst the chaos of Chancery.

By doubling his main characters with other figures who have similar stories, Dickens reminds his reader that other protagonists might have been selected, and these unchosen protagonists sometimes takeover in scenes that have no clear bearing on the main plot of the novel (see chapter 50 of *Bleak House*, “Dutiful Friendship,” for a particularly clear example). Joyce’s doubling of names – Mr. Dudley, above, or “Mr. Bloom” the Dublin dentist – acts as a similar reminder of the unselected (*U* 10.1115). More importantly, in an exaggeration of the phenomenon noted by Woloch in which Dickens’s minor characters wrest attention from his protagonists, “Wandering Rocks” is overrun by characters who are “not to be thought away,” to quote Stephen on the forgotten byways of history, just because their stories have not been prioritized up to this point in *Ulysses* (*U* 2.49). Thus we meet not Dignam, whose death is an important unifying motif in the novel, but his son (*U* 10.1121–74), and we spend less time in the episode with Stephen than with his family – including a sister who wants to speak French but (unlike him) has not had the chance to learn (*U* 10.854–80). Joyce does not simply give such characters a greater share of the narrative discourse; he forces the reader into sustained engagement with their thoughts. Anticipating O’Brien’s assertion that every character should have a “private life,” Joyce uses stream-of-consciousness narration, which has hitherto been reserved for the protagonists, to explore the thoughts of young Dignam, as well as Blazes Boylan, Boylan’s secretary, Miss Dunne; and Tom Kernan, a Protestant who in many ways resembles Bloom.²³

The engagement with so many characters at once enacts a kind of democratic proportion or justice that is a literary means of counter-ing the repressive politics on display in “Wandering Rocks.” This

contrast is visible in section that opens the episode, which follows Father Conmee. Conmee nearly forgets the name of the first person to cross his mind, young Patrick Dignam: "What was that boy's name again? Dignam. Yes. *Vere dignum et iustum est*" (*U* 10.4–5). These last words ("It is truly fitting and just") open the Preface to the Holy Trinity in the Latin Mass, but they also point to the authorial imperative of doing *justice* to the *dignity* of each individual. Conmee's failure to be just in this sense points not only to the political injustice with which he is complicit, but also to the risks that Joyce himself faces as the creator of many characters. Conmee's memories of Clongowes, where he figures in *A Portrait*, together with his interpolation into Stephen's section of "Wandering Rocks," suggest that he is an impoverished version of the Joycean author as "priest of the eternal imagination."²⁴ Where he fails in sympathetic engagement, Joyce must succeed.

By giving the stage to so many and yet showing how much remains unrevealed, "Wandering Rocks" encourages curiosity about characters whom the reader might otherwise be tempted to view only as instrumental to the development of Stephen and Bloom. Some of these characters will appear later in *Ulysses*, at times totally usurping narrative point of view. These include Molly and Gerty McDowell (both of whom appear in "Wandering Rocks"), as well as the unnamed narrator of the "Cyclops" episode. Critics have often dealt with these usurpations by reading the minor characters less as individuals than as disembodied discourses that reflect the growing prominence of language over character in the novel. But to read *Ulysses* as *either* about its protagonists *or* about language as a supra-individual entity is to miss both the simple point that the book is about many people and a more complex point about literary history. Reading *Ulysses* alongside *Bleak House* makes clear that Joyce was drawn to the realist tradition that he cites so liberally in "Wandering Rocks" primarily for its democratic drive toward narrative proportion. Dos Passos, whose ethical commitment to proportion rivals Thackeray's, attempts to sustain this democratic impulse not for a brief (if central) interlude, but across all three volumes of *U.S.A.*

“Our True Sense of Proportion”: Dos Passos’s *U.S.A.*

U.S.A. is, as George Packer points out, “one of the great neglected achievements of literary modernism, with its nervy, jarring formal juxtapositions.”²⁵ Yet the most eye-catching modernist modes of *U.S.A.* – the free-verse biographies, the newsreels, and the stream-of-consciousness “Camera Eye” sections – only account for about one quarter of the text. The rest is devoted to the narrative juxtaposition of twelve fictional protagonists, which is presumably what Dos Passos had in mind when he mentioned the influence of Thackeray’s “novel without a hero.” When critics discuss the absence of a hero in *U.S.A.*, however, they tend to fill the gap with some other entity. America, for example, or “that abstraction called society” is claimed as the protagonist of *U.S.A.*, a novel that is said to espouse a “deterministic worldview” that would align it less with modernism or realism than with the naturalism of a Zola.²⁶ Such readings miss Dos Passos’s very real effort to individuate his characters. As Lionel Trilling points out, “For all the collective elements of his trilogy,” Dos Passos “puts a peculiar importance on the individual.”²⁷

Individualism and collectivism are not necessarily incompatible. For Dos Passos, these ideals exist in a precarious balance that hinges on the concept of real democracy, with its dependence on the principles of equality and proportion. Even as Dos Passos’s political vision changed during the composition of *U.S.A.*, it remained primarily an attempt to synthesize two forms of democracy, socialism and the principles of the American Revolution. In *U.S.A.*, this vision comes up against a problem of language. “Democracy” is one of the “old words” that Dos Passos felt had been given a new, corrupt meaning by the very political-corporate propaganda (or “public relations”) machine that he critiques in the novel.²⁸ Early in volume one, a biography of the labor leader Eugene Debs makes clear the difference between true democracy premised on equality and what Dos Passos considered the sham democracy of the war years. When Debs spoke to crowds of railway workers, Dos Passos says in Whitmanesque free verse, he “made them want the world he wanted, / a world brothers might own / *where everybody would split*

even.”²⁹ As though wary of the possible coercion implied in that “made them,” he quotes Debs’s warning against the seductions of heroic leadership: “*I am not a labor leader [. . .] I would not lead you into this promised land if I could, because if I could lead you in, someone else would lead you out*” (*USA* 31).

To Debs’s radically egalitarian vision Dos Passos opposes the faux democracy that he associates with Woodrow Wilson and the fictional J. Ward Moorehouse, an advertising executive who hungers after personal success and will do anything – including giving lip service to “fairplay and democracy” – to achieve it (*USA* 236). Wilson’s and Moorehouse’s ideas of “democracy” are ciphers for capitalism and, ironically, ideological blocks to equality. In a litany of clichés that models the substitution of ideology for thought, the biography goes on to say that working Americans loved Debs,

but on account of the flag
and prosperity
and making the world safe for democracy,
they were afraid to be with him,
or to think much about him for fear they might believe him.
(*USA* 32)

Later in the trilogy, in his biography of Wilson, Dos Passos makes clear that the “democracy” of such slogans is good for little more than swelling industrial profits through “cost-plus” government contracts: “If you objected to making the world safe for cost plus democracy you went to jail with Debs” (*USA* 568).

Debs’s version of democracy, which emphasizes proportion and equality, is foundational for *U.S.A.*, in which narrative proportion is achieved by featuring twelve protagonists. Debs’s presence and philosophy bookends the first volume of the trilogy, *The 42nd Parallel*. When his brother-in-law proposes a get-rich-quick adventure in real-estate speculation, Mac McCreary retorts, “Suppose a feller didn’t want to get rich . . . you know what Gene Debs said, ‘I want to rise with the ranks, not from the ranks’” (*USA* 109). Debs is again invoked near the end of the volume, when Charley Anderson is wondering whether to profit from the American declaration of war

by going to work at a munitions factory. The communist leader Benny Compton scolds him, “Didn’t Eugene V. Debs say, ‘I want to rise with the ranks, not from them?’” (*USA* 353). This statement is a formal key to *U.S.A.*; it describes the character system of the novel itself, in which no single character is allowed to “rise from the ranks” as a protagonist.

The ranks of Dos Passos’s characters do not, however, merge into an indistinct vision of “society.” In contrast to *Manhattan Transfer*, which intersperses its narratives so rapidly that readers can find it difficult even to identify the main characters when they appear, *U.S.A.* uses extended narratives to flesh out the biography of each protagonist, thereby exploiting the notational capacity of realism to overturn the imperative toward selection at the heart of realist representation. Thackeray, unlike Dickens, tended to include the back story of his multiple protagonists, as when he provides exposition concerning Dobbin’s childhood just before he appears in the decisive scene at Vauxhall with Jos and Becky (*VF* 48–60). In *U.S.A.*, this effort to give proportionate representation is intensified, in large part because Dos Passos does not refuse or obscure personal history; none of his characters are “born at the age of twenty-five,” as Flann O’Brien memorably put it, “with a memory but without a personal experience to account for it.”³⁰ But he also takes aim at novel forms that do not share out narrative time and space equitably. Like Thackeray, he critiques the military novel and its glorification of individual heroism. Thackeray famously narrates the Battle of Waterloo by narrating everything but the Battle of Waterloo: “We do not claim to rank among the military novelists. Our place is with the non-combatants” (*VF* 364). Similarly, Dos Passos is less interested in war than with its shaping influence on society, and in particular its anti-egalitarian emphasis on heroism – as when Jim Anderson urges his brother Charley back in uniform to sell cars to customers who “eat up this returnedhero stuff” (*USA* 795). Like Waterloo in *Vanities Fair*, First World War in 1919 transforms Paris into a hub where fortune seekers attempt to “rise from the ranks,” to quote the anti-Debsian goal that Richard Ellsworth Savage’s mother sets for him when he joins the army (*USA* 656). Indeed, Dos Passos implies that it was because

Wilson himself “wanted to be a Great Man” that he erred at Versailles (*USA* 565).

This political context informs *U.S.A.* at every turn. For example, Dos Passos’s biography of Big Bill Haywood claims that organized labor lost a generation when young Americans went to war “to save Wilsonian Democracy [and] stood at Napoleon’s tomb and dreamed empire” (*USA* 89). By the end of the trilogy, a drunken Savage – one of the young men in Paris in 1919, now middle-aged – comes very close to “telling people he was Napoleon” (*USA* 1191). Men like Wilson, Savage, and Moorehouse illustrate the transformation of America from an egalitarian republic into a state ruled by a “great man” like Napoleon. However, none of them emerge as a central protagonist; like Joyce in “Wandering Rocks,” but on a much larger scale, Dos Passos brings in new protagonists whenever they are needed; indeed, one senses that the protagonists are interchangeable or replaceable. At the same time, following the example of Thackeray more than Dickens, he focuses primarily on similar characters from a single stratum of society, the middle class, which he once called “the weekly-magazinereading class that people appeal to when they talk about public opinion.”³¹

Dos Passos’s characters, however, are more socio-economically diverse than they might at first appear. Mac labors as a book salesman, printshop worker, and itinerant laborer before becoming a communist organizer and then disappearing near the end of *The 42nd Parallel*. Joe Williams is a sailor on merchant vessels who is placed in jail and has a very hard time scraping together a living. If anything, such characters seem sub-working class. They are the ones Charley Anderson refers to when he says, “Most of the fellers I know are trying to get into the workin’ class” (*USA* 822). Joe and Mac connect only tangentially to the power politics that form the main storyline of *U.S.A.*: Joe’s sister Janey works as a secretary for Moorehouse, whom Mac meets by chance in a Mexican bar just before disappearing from the novel. Even though they do not advance the plot, both “come in for their share of the chronicle,” as Thackeray would say. This strategy, while evading hierarchical disparities, assumes that all characters are equally interesting, an

assumption that, in the case of Mac and Joe, may try the reader's patience. But the risk of dullness serves a key function for Dos Passos. It helps the reader to identify with characters whose relationship to the plot is as tenuous as their relationship to socio-economic power. Dos Passos clearly wanted his readers to understand the lived experience of economic inequity, even as he attempted to redress that inequity through narrative form.

By showing the variety of individual experiences found in the middle class, Dos Passos attempts to change public opinion, to hold a mirror up to middle-class Americans (as Joyce claimed to be doing in *Dubliners*) so that they could see how unrestrained capitalism hurts them as much as it does the working class. The democratic inclusion of multiple protagonists, whose life experiences undermine simplistic views of class, illustrates how narrative selection need not be arbitrary or exclusive.

Dos Passos's version of modernism, which has not captured much critical attention, reminds us that the "inward turn" in canonical modernists, such as Virginia Woolf, Marcel Proust, William Faulkner, and a host of others, is not the only model of narrative representation and perspective open to modernist writers. By seeking proportionate representation in narrative space, by according something akin to equal value to both major and minor characters' experience and point of view, modernists like Joyce and Dos Passos articulate a democratic ethos. The nineteenth-century realist tradition, in which this ethos first emerged, reasserts itself in experimental novels such as *Ulysses* and *U.S.A.* Such texts do not so much represent an "outward turn" as they do a more egalitarian vision of what turning inward might mean at a time of historical crisis.

Notes

1. Nancy Ruttenburg, "Is the Novel Democratic?" *Novel* 47, no. 1 (March 20, 2014): 3. This issue of *Novel* is devoted to the question Ruttenburg raises in her title.
2. James Joyce, *Ulysses*, ed. Hans Walter Gabler (New York: Random House, 1986), 18.1128. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*U*) by chapter and line number.

3. James Joyce, *Critical Writings of James Joyce*, eds. Ellsworth Mason and Richard Elman (New York: Viking Press, 1959), 127.
4. E. M. Forster, *Aspects of the Novel* (New York: Harcourt Brace Janovich, 1927), 67.
5. Alex Woloch, *The One vs. the Many: Minor Characters and the Space of the Protagonist in the Novel* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2003), 31.
6. George Levine, "Literary Realism Reconsidered: 'The World in Its Length and Breadth,'" in *A Concise Companion to Realism*, ed. Matthew Beaumont (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2010), 22.
7. *Ibid.*
8. Michael Tratner, *Modernism and Mass Politics: Joyce, Woolf, Eliot, Yeats* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1995), 3; Fredric Jameson, "Afterword: A Note on Literary Realism," in *A Concise Companion to Realism*, ed. Matthew Beaumont (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2010), 287.
9. Claude Lefort, *Democracy and Political Theory*, trans. David Macey (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1988), 17.
10. Stanislaus Joyce, *My Brother's Keeper: James Joyce's Early Years* (New York: Viking Press, 1958), 78. A small but growing body of work has begun to illuminate the continuities between Joyce and Dickens. See Jay Clayton, "Londublin: Dickens's London in Joyce's Dublin," *Novel* 28, no. 3 (1995): 327–42; Matthew Bolton, "Joycean Dickens/Dickensian Joyce," *Dickens Quarterly* 23, no. 4 (2006): 243–52; and Barry McCrea, *In the Company of Strangers: Family and Narrative in Dickens, Conan Doyle, Joyce, and Proust* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011), 103.
11. Charles Dickens, *Bleak House*, eds. George Ford and Sylvère Monod (New York: Norton, 1977), 638. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*BH*).
12. Alexander Welsh, *Dickens Redressed: The Art of Bleak House and Hard Times* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2000), 124.
13. John Dos Passos, *John Dos Passos: The Major Nonfictional Prose*, ed. Donald Pizer (Detroit, MI: Wayne State University Press, 1988), 272.
14. *Ibid.*, 239.
15. William Makepeace Thackeray, *Vanity Fair*, ed. John Sutherland (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1983), 127–8. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*VF*).
16. Dos Passos, *Major Nonfictional Prose*, 33.
17. Fredric Jameson, "Antinomies of the Realism-Modernism Debate," *Modern Language Quarterly* 73, no. 3 (September 2012): 479.
18. Stuart Gilbert, *James Joyce's Ulysses* (New York: Vintage, 1955), 227.

19. Clive Hart, quoted in Hugh Kenner, *Ulysses* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1987), 65. Kenner associates this voice with the “Arranger” who takes over *Ulysses* from this point forward and was retroactively inserted (in the form of the mock headlines) in “Aeolus” at the revision stage.
20. James Joyce, *Occasional, Critical, and Political Writing*, ed. Kevin Barry, trans. Conor Deane (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), 185.
21. *Ibid.*, 186. See Clayton, “Londublin,” 336–7.
22. Don Gifford points out this echo in *Ulysses Annotated: Notes for James Joyce’s Ulysses* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1988), 261. Gifford also points out the allusion to Mr. Turveydrop.
23. On the resemblances between Kernan and Bloom, see James H. Maddox, *Joyce’s Ulysses and the Assault upon Character* (New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press, 1978), 149–51.
24. James Joyce, *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*, ed. Chester G. Anderson (New York: Penguin, 1968), 221.
25. George Packer, “The Spanish Prisoner: When Hemingway and Dos Passos Went to War,” *The New Yorker*, October 31, 2005, 84.
26. Townsend Ludington, *John Dos Passos: A Twentieth Century Odyssey* (New York: Carroll & Graf, 1980), 64 (Ludington is discussing Dos Passos’s admiration of *Vanity Fair*); Brian McHale, “‘Talking U.S.A.’: Interpreting Free Indirect Discourse in Dos Passos’s *U.S.A.* Trilogy,” *Degrés* 6, nos. 16–17 (1978–79): c3.
27. Lionel Trilling, “The America of John Dos Passos,” in *Dos Passos, the Critics, and the Writer’s Intention*, ed. Allen Belkind (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1971), 37.
28. Donald Pizer, *Dos Passos’ U.S.A.: A Critical Study* (Charlottesville: University Press of Virginia, 1988), 52.
29. John Dos Passos, *U.S.A.* (New York: Library of America, 1996), 31, emphasis added. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*USA*).
30. Flann O’Brien, *At Swim-Two-Birds* (Dublin: Dalkey Archive Press, 1998), 1.
31. Dos Passos, *Major Nonfictional Prose*, 132.

*The Modernist Genre Novel**David M. Earle*

Robert Coates' little known novel, *The Eater of Darkness*, has all the trappings of modernism. Written by a member of the group that would form around *transition* and published by Robert MacAlmon's Contact Press in Paris in 1926, the book is a rich, absurdist experiment about a machine that can see through objects at long distances, something like an X-ray machine, but it can also shoot an invisible bullet at the object of the user's choice. At one point, the machine shoots through "a copy of Ranch Romances" as well as Reginald Marsh, Theodore Dreiser, and Malcolm Cowley. It is exactly such blending of low-brow literary ephemera as "Ranch Romances" pulp magazines with such high-brow impresarios as Cowley that led Ford Madox Ford to call the book "Not the first but the best Dada novel."¹ Despite Ford's judgment, the novel remains largely (and undeservedly) forgotten by critics today. One reason for this could well be that the book itself smacks of science fiction, and relies upon a formula that blends high and low, modernist experimentation with popular literary tropes. The book's disruptive experimental nature is framed within a conventional melodramatic storyline similar to what is found in much popular romance fiction. The book itself is dedicated to Nick Carter, hero of hundreds of dime novels and pulp stories, and "Sapper," the author of the popular Bulldog Drummond adventure series. Though contemporary critics considered the book part of the modernist avant-garde, *The Eater of Darkness* falls too close to the dynamics of popular literature for the comfort of those literary critics who would later canonize modernism.

The Eater of Darkness is just one example of what I'm calling the *modernist genre novel*, a body of novels through which modernist

authors examine their own relationships to reading, audience, and modernity while using the tropes and generic conventions of popular fiction, sometimes as *métier* and sometimes as a means of satire. In so doing, these authors straddle the line between popularity (or popular forms) and what amounts to a self-reflective antagonism to their own reliance upon popular style, themes, or aspirant commerciality. Examples of the modernist genre novel can be found in the oeuvres of many of the central figures of modernism, including Gertrude Stein, Aldous Huxley, Joseph Conrad, as well as figures of the Harlem Renaissance such as George Schuyler, Rudolph Fisher, and (later) Richard Wright.² These novelists are working in the tradition of Flaubert's *Madame Bovary* in their criticism of popular literary forms and the popular reader; but despite their critical position with respect to popular forms and the commercial literary marketplace, their work is at times complicit in both. They consciously sought a popular audience and commercial success while still relying upon modernist stylistics, themes, and reflexivity. What emerges from an examination of the modernist genre novel is the idea of a modernism that nominally positioned itself as antagonistic to the marketplace and the popular audience, but in practice sought out mass exposure and economic salability – in other words, a modernism deeply complicit in both self-marketing practices and the market economy of popular publishing.

I'd like to examine the genre novels of William Faulkner and Ernest Hemingway because these authors relied heavily upon popular forms yet have unquestionably been canonized as modernists. Given the long-standing tradition of seeing modernism as antagonistic to popular culture, these authors' genre novels bring into relief the double standard of canonicity implicit in the idea of an antic-commercial modernism – a standard that governed the hypocritical rejection of the tropes of popular genres that modernist authors employed as they made their appeal to a wide spectrum of readers.

One reason for the prevalence of the genre novel in modernism was, obviously, the rise and popularity of genre fiction in popular magazines during the first decades of the twentieth century, especially in America where genre fiction was popular enough to drive

the evolution of magazines into specialty titles dedicated to such distinct genres as mystery and crime, adventure, science fiction, and romance and melodrama. Hence genre fiction made up a large part of the publishing ecosystem in which modernism developed. To understand the distinct form of the modernist genre novel, then, we must understand how it grew out of, was defined against, and was ultimately inseparable from commercial publishing – especially magazine production, where the form's generic conventions were solidified. For most authors, magazines constituted the literary milieu, the market, and the critical apparatus that built their reputations and disseminated their works. Even authors such as James Joyce, who normally eschewed popular magazines, made his American debut in the popular *Smart Set* and later relied upon magazines to further his and his work's reputation.³ Magazines were how most authors earned a living since only a small percentage of novels ever made a profit.

Many modernists had a conflicted relationship to magazine publishing. Faulkner denounced both his short fiction and the economic situation that forced him to write for magazines. Referring to the stories that would become *The Unvanquished*, Faulkner wrote, "As far as I am concerned, while I have to write trash, I don't care who buys it, as long as they pay the best price I can get."⁴ He believed that magazine writing distracted both his time and energy from writing novels. Yet his stories not only allowed him to flesh out the history and characters of Yoknapatawpha, but to experiment with themes for the novels. Stories such as "That Evening Sun" and "A Justice" inform our understanding of *The Sound and the Fury* and *Absalom, Absalom!* by supplying context and motivation for Quentin Compson's actions. Faulkner's success both in the magazine market and Hollywood, where he wrote scripts during the period 1932–37, point toward his own familiarity with and skill at formulaic writing. Critics now consider his stories not trash, as Faulkner referred to them, but as integral to his canon and inseparable from our understanding of his novels.

Whereas Faulkner snubbed his magazine work, Hemingway was first and foremost a magazine writer. Of the nine novels that appeared

in Hemingway's lifetime, only four didn't start as magazine stories or serializations, and of those, two were from before he had a reputation that would garner him serialization.⁵ He often resisted pressure from his publisher to stop writing stories and get started on his next novel. Hemingway's earliest tutelage wasn't under the wings of Sherwood Anderson, Gertrude Stein, and Ezra Pound; he began by emulating pulp writer Stewart Edward White and sought advice from at least two different pulp editors – both of whom advised him always to put a love interest in his stories. Manuscript fragments of his early stories show him writing toward formula and trying to break into the pulp market.⁶

These opposing views on the literary marketplace reveal that authors such as Faulkner and Hemingway not only *had* to position themselves in regard to the magazine and short story market as the means to secure a living and establish a reputation, but that both authors were familiar with and relied upon the popular magazine story formula and this influenced the composition of a number of their novels.

Genre and the Magazine Marketplace

The importance of popular magazines in the history of modernism is often overshadowed by the centrality of little magazines and the materiality of the book. Little magazines, though, were rarified, controlled and read by a coterie, and had extremely limited distribution, hence they were seen as mechanisms for constructing an artistic reputation and securing a publisher. Both Faulkner and Hemingway started in little magazines but quickly left them behind for mass-market magazines. In fact, modernism could not have flourished nor had such widespread influence in the later twentieth century if its practitioners hadn't moved beyond the limited reach of the little magazines and taken advantage of other modes of publication and distribution, including popular magazines and reprints, which are often overlooked in favor of first appearances (and first editions) and hardcover publication.

Despite the fact that many modernist novels were initially serialized in magazines or subsequently republished in popular reprint

magazines and newspaper literary supplements, critics tend to privilege both little magazines and first editions for a number of reasons. Foremost among these reasons is that the magazine form has always been more commercial, closer to the public due in part to their separate spheres of dissemination. First run books (and most little magazines, for that matter) were relatively costly and sold in bookstores, of which there were few outside of urban centers; magazines on the other hand were sold in street stalls, newsstands, drugstores, and tobacco stores. What is missing in these venues is the dictatorial apparatus of selection, whether that of the knowledgeable staff or the literary critic. Besides this question of commercial distribution, first editions, like manuscripts, are seen as purer manifestations of the author's intent since they are monovocal rather than multivocal and diluted like a magazine, hence less "sullied" by possible contamination intrinsic to commercial publishing (i.e., surrounded by ads and other voices, in danger of corruption at the hands of editors, suffering from the dilution of aura attributed to reprints). This is why first editions are more highly prized than magazines: they are seen as genealogically closer to the author and the moment of creative inspiration. In other words, the canonical and archived material forms of the novel reaffirm the aura of artistic production through a sense of anticommerciality.

But beneath this fetishization of the book was the vast literary ecosystem of magazine publishing. The number of new editions and new book titles for hardcover fiction in the second half of 1921 was 321, and 379 in the first half of 1922.⁷ In comparison, in 1920 there were 3,415 monthly periodicals published.⁸ Theodore Peterson contends that by 1923 the aggregate circulation of all magazines in the United States was 128,621,000, and by 1926 there were at least 25 magazines with circulations in the millions.⁹ Most first edition modernist novels usually had print runs in only the hundreds or, at most, tens of thousands. Books were generally expensive commodities, an economic situation that was not countered until the rise of inexpensive books, reprint houses, and the Book-of-the-Month Club, founded in 1926. Novels in book form constituted only a small percentage of literary output when compared to the overall scene

of publishing. Magazines constituted the main outlet for fiction and the general milieu for modernist publishing; they exerted a gravitational pull upon the novel as illustrated in how magazines supplied authors with the generic forms and inspiration for the modernist genre novel.

The first popular magazines were a hodgepodge of fiction, nonfiction, news, criticism, editorials, art, and advertisements, but competition on the newsstand was such that publishers started pandering to niche interests by splintering each feature off into its own dedicated magazine, hence the 1890s saw the rise of magazines of criticism such as *Current Opinion* and *The Review of Reviews*, as well as the first popular all-fiction magazine, Munsey's *The Argosy* in 1894. By the early teens there were dozens of all-fiction magazines such as *All-Story*, *Cavalier*, *Blue Book*, *Parisienne*, *Young's*, and *Snappy Stories*. Many modernist authors, such as Djuna Barnes, Robert Coates, and Edna St. Vincent Millay got their start in these magazines and rose to popularity before there was cohesive stratification of cultural standing as linked to fiction (i.e., modernist, high-brow, middlebrow, lowbrow). For example, Barnes's poetry and one-act plays in *All-Story* and *Cavalier* evince many of the themes that would eventually manifest in *Nightwood*. Perhaps the most literary or modernist of these magazines were the "snappy" magazines of situational romance, such as *Saucy Stories*, *Snappy Stories*, *Breezy Stories*, *Brief Stories* (where Edna St. Vincent Millay got her start under the pseudonym Nancy Boyd), and *The Parisienne*, all of which pushed moral boundaries and would eventually become venues for fiction by authors such as Dawn Powell that focused on "flappers," young women who flaunted conservative social values, fashions, and practices.¹⁰

There were of course hundreds of general interest magazines featuring genre stories, but it was in the all-fiction magazines where the work of defining genre was most consciously performed and is most evident. By the mid-1910s, the public's demand for fiction was such that magazine publishers started producing magazines dedicated to single genres, starting with *Detective Story Magazine* in 1915. This was soon followed by *Western Story* in

1919; *Love Story* in 1921; *Sea Stories* in 1922; *Sports Story* in 1923; *War Stories* in 1926; and *Air Stories* in 1927, and each of these was successful enough to warrant numerous imitators. Soon, newsstands were covered with multiple titles of almost every genre imaginable. Each of these genres offered both mud and gems, fiction of every quality; many of them have become canonized, such as science fiction and romance, while others are long forgotten despite immense popularity at the time, such as aviation and rail stories. Allusions to genre magazines surface in modernist novels generally and the modernist genre novels specifically: the Tall Convict in “The Old Man” section of Faulkner’s *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem* models his life of crime on dime novels, just as Harry Wilbourne in the “Wild Palms” section turns to confessional sex stories to make a living. In Faulkner’s *Pylon*, the reporter buys the aviators a stack of aviation pulps, while Joe Christmas reads a pulp magazine before murdering Joanna Burden in *Light in August*. Hemingway, too, uses the pulps in dramatic fashion; for example, a vet in *To Have and Have Not* asks Richard Gordon, the pretentious writer character, “Did you ever write for *Western Stories*, or *War Aces*? I could read that *War Aces* every day.”¹¹ Bigger in Richard Wright’s *Native Son* thinks about reading “Real Detective Story Magazine.” Such allusions are more than mere cultural referents, but clues to these novels’ own generic foundations or inspiration. The steady stream of genre fiction “swarming” over the newsstand (as Marcus Duffield described the situation in 1933) constituted the general milieu of fiction for modernist authors, often ignored since critics seldom look beyond the rarified and relatively restrictive body of canonical novels when considering authors’ literary influences.¹² However modernism didn’t exist in a vacuum but on the same spectrum of production and cultural influences as popular fiction.

The Modernist Genre Novel

Genre fiction as a mode of modernist stylistics has been overlooked because genre fiction is popular and formulaic by definition. Every genre is defined by the marketplace and the reiteration of plot

devices, tropes, character types, and stylistics. The success of specific genre stories depends upon meeting or manipulating audience expectations, which can only be done if those expectations are established through familiarity with similar tropes and conventions already established in similar stories. Experimentation with generic conventions is quickly absorbed into the formula due to emulation by other authors, hence formulaic experimentation propels the evolution of the genre. We can assume from the high sales of genre novels that this kind of experimentation helped to entrench and delimit variations of the formulae.

The ways in which the market dictated the formula of genre fiction is readily evident in trade magazines such as *The Writer*, *The Student-Writer*, *Author and Journalist*, and *Writer's Digest*, which provided the infrastructure for the craft of professional writing in articles such as "Selling Western Stories," "How to Write a Salable Scientific-Detective Story," "How to Write Love Stories That Sell" (by the Editor of *Cupid's Diary*), and "The Saturday Evening Post Formula," which describe the distinct formula for each genre and for the magazines in which they appear.¹³ In short, these magazines make evident the formulaic conventions of genre fiction. For example, *The Student-Writer*, started in 1916, published articles on characterization ("The magazine of today has little room for character description. True, the demand for vivid portrayal of character remains – but it must be met by indirect methods"), dialogue, and how to write emotion.¹⁴ Other magazines gave advice about acceptable themes and topics, word length, and warned, as *Ten Story Book* did, that the magazine could "never get enough manuscripts containing stores which reflect or deal with radical viewpoints relative to sex, religion, color, race, politics, etc. We are especially prejudiced against 'he and she' love stories in which 'he' and 'she' are confronted by an obstacle, overcome it, and thus close the story."¹⁵ The literary "little magazines" also issued similar advice. *The Double Dealer*, which was the most important little magazine from the southern United States and which published both Faulkner and Hemingway, described itself in *The Student-Writer* as "a new magazine highly sophisticated in tone" which "has no policy whatever but

that of printing the very best material it can procure, regardless of popular appeal, moral or immoral stigmata, conventional or unconventional technique, new theme or old.”¹⁶ That both the little magazines and pulp magazines appeared in these trade magazines illustrates how modernism was complicit in the *business* of writing, complicit in the very marketplace that it otherwise condemned.

The modernist genre novel itself relies upon a basic structural logic, the first aspect of which is that *the work melds modernist style and popular tropes, formulae, or situational aspects established in popular magazines*. For example, *The Eater of Darkness* can be read as an experiment with generic formula as it conflates science fiction with Dadaist experimentation before climaxing in a conventional romantic ending. The most extreme example of this formula is Faulkner’s *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem* (the planned title of *The Wild Palms*), which is composed of two distinct storylines alternating between the modern “Wild Palms,” about a couple, Harry and Charlotte, who increasingly separate themselves from the worldly need of money so as to better experience their “pure” love, and the mythic “The Old Man,” an adventure about a convict set adrift during the great 1927 flood of the delta. The relationship between these storylines is initially unclear, though both borrow their narrative situations from popular genre fiction: in “Wild Palms,” Charlotte says to Harry, “the second time I saw you I learned what I had read in books but had never actually believed: that love and suffering are the same thing and that the value of love is the sum of what you have to pay for it.”¹⁷ What Charlotte describes and what the story introduces in a pastiche fashion, is the popular romantic melodrama – exactly the kind that Harry turns to writing out of economic necessity, “complete from the first capital to the last period in one sustained frenzied agonizing rush” (*If* 103). Faulkner even metafictionally stresses the generic underpinning of the story line when, upon finding a wallet full of money, Harry thinks “*That’s it. It’s all exactly backward. It should be the books, the people in the books inventing and reading about us*” (*If* 44). The tall convict in “The Old Man” story line is initially imprisoned because he patterned his attempted train robbery after “the Diamond Dicks and Jesse Jameses and such” that

“he had followed [. . .] to the letter,” even saving “the paper-backs for two years, reading and re-reading them, memorizing them, comparing story and method against story and method” (*If* 20–1). Over the course of the novel, both story lines crystalize into perverse, extreme (larger-than-life) “real” examples of the generic literature from which they drew their inspiration: “Wild Palms” becomes more and more melodramatic, culminating in Charlotte’s death from blood poisoning and a botched abortion; “The Old Man” turns into an almost cartoonish (and mythic) adventure story, with the Tall Convict riding waves of flood debris, wrasslin’ alligators, and delivering a baby.

If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem is an extreme example of a modernist genre novel in that its very structure stems from the contrapuntal tensions between modernism and popular fiction, the modern world and the mythic delta, but it is possible to see how even canonical modernist novels rely on the conventions of popular literature. *The Sun Also Rises* works the same themes and settings as the situational melodramas popular in the “snappy” magazines of the post–First World War era. These magazines challenged Edwardian morality through risqué situations, flapper heroines, open sexuality, and settings in the bohemian worlds of either Greenwich Village or Left Bank Paris. *The Parisienne* magazine, for example, relied on the promise of sex that Paris held for provincial America during the First World War, while *Snappy Stories* pandered to a rising youth culture through flapper-themed stories and modern women (see [Figure 2](#)). The formulae of these situational romances often involve heroines who use their sexuality (“vamping”) to capture or keep a husband, and despite clichéd endings (usually marriage), the heroine often learns to be comfortable with her sexuality. By the mid-1920s, many stories featured independent and intellectual heroines from the growing population of women in the urban workforce. In 1925, such magazines were numerous enough to be humorously cartooned (see [Figure 3](#)) in *Judge* magazine and condemned as “Filth on the Street” in the conservative *Independent* (see [Figure 4](#)).

The popularity and sensational subject matter of *The Sun Also Rises*, in particular, illustrates Hemingway’s ability to cater to the



Figure 2 *Snappy Stories*, October 20, 1924 (v.86 n.1). Copyright 1924, The New Fiction Publishing Corporation.



Figure 3 "Summer of 1926," cartoon from *Judge*, May 30, 1925 (v.88 n.2274). Copyright 1925, The Leslie-Judge Co.

same popular audience that made the snappy magazines so popular. As he famously wrote to his publisher, his work could "be praised by highbrows and can be read by lowbrows. There is no writing in it that anybody with a high school education cannot read" and Malcolm Cowley noted how because of *The Sun Also Rises* co-eds were "modelling themselves after Lady Brett" while young men were "trying to be like Hemingway Heroes, talking in tough understatements from the sides of their mouths."¹⁸

There is little question that Hemingway could write to an audience. Critics have seen the Hollywood studio system and the 1932 film adaptation of *Farewell to Arms* as responsible for both his popularity and public persona, but the fact that Hemingway tried to place short stories in *Pictorial Review*, one of the best-selling women's magazines on the newsstand, proves that he tried to reach a female audience. A



Figure 4 “Whaddya Read?” cartoon illustrating the article “Filth on Main Street,” *The Independent*, June 20, 1925. Copyright 1925, Independent Publications Inc.

1931 article on Hemingway and his mother in the *Home Magazine* (distributed solely in the Woolworth stores) proves that Hemingway indeed had captured both a popular female and popular magazine audience.¹⁹ It is possible to see *Farewell to Arms* as itself participating in

literary fads. That the relationship between a First World War soldier and a war nurse was an established trope in popular literature, and that *Farewell to Arms* spoke to an existing public consciousness, is illustrated by the December 1929 publication of a new pulp magazine, *Love and War Stories*, the cover of which could just as easily be an illustration of Hemingway's novel (see [Figure 5](#)).

The second aspect of the modern genre novel's structural logic, *a self-referential concern with high and low culture*, is exemplified by Faulkner's *Sanctuary*, which also illustrates the influence of specific magazine genres. Numerous critics have noted the influences of popular fiction upon *Sanctuary*, most notably Walter Wenska who considers the scenarios found in the pulp fiction of Dashiell Hammett, W. R. Burnett, and Raoul Whitfield to be the raw material for the novel: "Faulkner clearly trolled the muddy waters of popular fiction for what he might learn about what readers (and he'd had very few of them to this point in his career) were responding to, and what (aesthetic sensibilities kept reasonably unbesmirched) he could give them."²⁰ Similarly, Leslie Fiedler considers the detective formula established by Hammett to have influenced the novel, just as S. S. Van Dine influenced Gavin Stevens of *Knight's Gambit* and *Intruder in the Dust*.²¹ What goes unremarked by either Wenska or Fiedler is that while Faulkner was composing *Sanctuary*, the gangster genre in magazines such as *Gangster Stories*, *Gangland Stories*, *Gun Moll Stories*, and *Speakeasy Stories* solidified the stereotypical characteristics of the gangster figure in the public consciousness ([Figure 6](#)).²² These magazines, with their focus on the gangster rather than the detective, contextualize the bootlegger aspects of the novel even better than Hammett's or Van Dine's fiction. Just as *Sanctuary*'s action shifts back and forth between Yoknapatawpha and Memphis, Horace and Temple, the style alternates between modernist density and pulp aesthetics. The best example of the gangster genre's conventions in the novel is the funeral of Red, which takes place at a speakeasy, the site of an earlier liaison between Red and Temple. The craps tables have been pushed aside and the mourners are well on their way to getting very drunk. A discussion is going on about appropriate music:



Figure 5 *Love and War Stories*, January 1930 (v.1 n.1). Copyright 1929, Good Story Magazine Co.



Figure 6 *Gangster Stories*, "A Magazine of Racketeers and Gun Molls," March 1931 (v.5 n.2). Copyright 1931, Good Story Magazine Co.

"Let em play Jazz," says one man, "Nobody liked dancing better than Red."

"No, No," says the proprietor. "Time Gene gets em all ginned up on free whiskey, they'll start dancing. It'll look bad."

"How about the Blue Danube," says the [orchestra] leader.

"No, No; don't play no blues, I tell you. There's a dead man in that bier."

"That's not Blues."

"What is it?"

"A waltz, Strauss."

"A wop? Like Hell. Red was an American."²³

Soon the wake devolves into a drunken debauch with, finally, the corpse tumbling from the casket in *grand guignol* style. But this tension between the waltz and the blues, low humor on Faulkner's part, is indicative of the tensions between decorum and chaos, between high and low culture, which drives the novel forward. As a theme, this tension between high and low is established at the very opening of *Sanctuary* as Horace Benbow and the Popeye stare at each other across a stream. In this way, Faulkner dramatizes the tensions between the urban and rural, North and South, modern and traditional. The high/low cultural divide is symbolized by what each character hides in his pocket:

"You've got a pistol in that pocket, I suppose," [Horace] said.

Across the spring Popeye appeared to contemplate him with two knobs of soft black rubber. "I'm asking you," Popeye said. "What's that in your pocket?"

The other man's coat was still across his arm. He lifted his other hand toward the coat, out of one pocket of which protruded a crushed felt hat, from the other a book.

"Which pocket?" he said.

"Don't show me," Popeye said. "Tell me."

The other man stopped his hand. "It's a book."

"What book?" Popeye said.

"Just a book. The kind that people read. Some people do."

"Do you read books?" Popeye said. (S 4-5)

In a novel known for its sexuality and violence, as well as its conflicted reputation as both modernist classic and popular bestseller,

the tension between the two symbols of book and gun goes oddly unremarked. Horace, a classically educated idealist, is decidedly the kind of person who reads; Popeye, consistently characterized in terms of mechanized modernity, is not. The navigation between stagnant Southern ideal (Horace) and impotent modernity (Popeye) is embodied in the novel's own amalgamation of formulaic tropes and cartoonish characterizations drawn from popular magazines (the gun) with the stream-of-conscious stylistics of literary modernism, often associated with the Horace narrative (the book).

Pylon, likewise concerned with this high/low divide, illustrates the third structural aspect of the modernist genre novel: *a reflexive concern for the novel or author's own commerciality*, a concern that grows out of its own navigation of the commercial and literary via the conflation of modernist style and pulp genre. Critics often see *Pylon* as transfiguring "such classical modernist texts as James Joyce's *Ulysses* (especially its 'Aeolus' chapter), T.S. Eliot's *The Waste Land*, and 'The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock,'" which is also the title of one of the book's chapters, in order to find "an appropriately 'alienated' narrative idiom with which to represent the new modern realities, a narrative idiom now determined by the imperatives of a mechanized culture."²⁴ But the setting, characters, situation, and plot of the novel – built as it is upon "Death Drag" and "Honor," Faulkner's aviation stories for the magazines²⁵ – is inspired by the dozens of popular aviation pulps at the time, including *Air Stories*, *Wings*, *War Birds*, *Flying Aces*, *Aces*, and *Sky Birds*. *Pylon* is about two male and one female barnstormers, artistic figures unconcerned with social norms and pressures. The woman's pregnancy forces them back to earth, as it were, in order to provide for the future. The ground is linked to sully economic concerns and flying with artistic concerns. This conflict, as well as the characters' plight, is figuratively and literally symbolized by the airport recently built by the chairman of the sewage board. Roger Shumann, the pilot, eventually takes unsafe risks for the prize money, crashes, and dies. *Pylon* is an exposé on the destructive aspect of the material need for money, hence a Faulknerian criticism of his own indenture to commercial writing.²⁶

Alternatively, Hemingway's "hard-boiled" *To Have and Have Not* advocates for proletariat pragmatism and craftsmanship while deriding literary pretention. In dual storylines, Harry Morgan's increasingly desperate struggle to make a living in Depression-era America is dialectically opposed to the self-indulgent figure of Richard Gordon, an author who panders to the critics by writing fiction with empty proletariat trappings. *To Have and Have Not* is generally seen as Hemingway's response to the critical reaction to *Green Hills of Africa*, which regarded the latter as socially irrelevant during the Depression. If this is so, then Gordon becomes a reflexive embodiment of how critics saw Hemingway, as opposed to the Morgan figure, who embodies how Hemingway wanted himself to be seen, that is, as a craftsman. (One of the stories that composes *To Have and Have Not* is titled "The Tradesman's Return.") Morgan does what he must, but does so according to his (increasingly endangered) ethics; Gordon seemingly has no professional ethics and writes what he doesn't know for critical success. As in *Sanctuary* and *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem*, the two story lines of *To Have and Have Not* mark the high/low hybrid nature of the modernist genre novel. Faulkner and Hemingway write novels that fit into popular pulp genres while simultaneously separating themselves from the popular marketplace by commenting critically upon their own commerciality, purportedly (though not necessarily successfully) protecting the authors' literary reputations. What emerges from these works is a formula for commercial success: hybrid books that had both literary and popular appeal.

Generic Modernism

What is made evident in the modernist genre novel is the commerciality of modernism, or how modernism was deeply enmeshed in the commerciality of the literary marketplace. The fact that many modernist genre novels enjoyed long afterlives in popular editions only confirms this, and, to a certain extent, negates the novels' own stance outside commercialism. Faulkner's genre novels were all printed in mid-century pulp paperbacks and sold millions of copies – many

before the resuscitation of his career at the hands of literary critics such as Malcolm Cowley.²⁷ As early as 1935, *Pylon* (as well as Hemingway's *Death in the Afternoon*) was reviewed positively in the girlie pulp *Snappy Magazine*.²⁸ And Hemingway himself became a larger-than-life figure of hyper-masculinity in the men's magazine of the 1950s. The modernist genre novels examined here are metonymic of a shadow history of modernism, a larger strain of modernism that has a deeper, richer, more complex relationship to popular culture and mass audience than usually allowed.

Despite – or perhaps because of – the way these novels persisted in popular forms such as paperbacks, reprints, and film versions, their critical reputations often suffered when compared to more “purely modernist” works in each author's canon. In all cases, the novels examined here have been either neglected or derided as flawed and uneven: *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem* was effectively split apart for Cowley's *The Portable Faulkner*, which featured “The Old Man” section because it worked in the mythic southern Yoknapatawpha, rather than the “Wild Palms” story. The novel was largely seen as a failed structural experiment because critics were unwilling to see the link between the two story lines as dependent upon their foundations (and commentary upon) genre fiction.²⁹ *Sanctuary* was long derided, even by Faulkner, for both its sensationalism and popularity (Faulkner lamented that he would eternally be known as the “corncob man”). Until the rise of cultural studies, critics took the author at his word that the book was a “cheap idea [...] deliberately conceived to make money.”³⁰ Besides *The Torrents of Spring*, *To Have and Have Not* is perhaps seen as Hemingway's weakest effort, and at the time it was criticized for its gratuitous violence and thought to be inferior to Dashiell Hammett.³¹ Other modernist genre novels experienced both critical disregard and a successful afterlife in popular forms. Coates' *The Eater of Darkness*, now forgotten, was published in a commercial edition by Macauley in 1929; Joseph Conrad's *Lord Jim* was seen as flawed because its second half falls into straight adventure fiction. *The Great Gatsby* (like *Sanctuary*, influenced by both the gangster fiction and situational fiction formulae) was not canonized until the mid-century but

was almost immediately reprinted in the pulp magazine *Famous Story*, and it enjoyed numerous other reprints in both paperback and newspaper literary supplements. Even when these novels, like *Lord Jim* and *Gatsby*, were canonized, their generic foundations were either unscrutinized or fodder for derision.

The reasons for this disavowal of the modern genre novel has to do with its commercial and formulaic elements, which are grounded in popular forms. The distancing between modernism and popular fiction, and the reasons behind it, are strikingly evident in the critical reaction to pulp magazines. Marcus Duffield's remarks in *Vanity Fair* in 1933 are exemplary:

They swarm over the newsstands, gaudy, blatant, banal. [. . .] Into this underworld of literature most of us never dive unless, like Mr. Hoover's Committee on Recent Social Trends, we are curious about the literary preferences of those who move their lips when they read. [. . .] The mass production of day-dreams by the Pulp has been accompanied by a phenomenon unique in literature: the standardization of fiction. Even as Fords and hairpins are standardized, so are the stories. These magazines represent an incursion of the Machine Age into the art of tale-telling.³²

There is more than a fear of Fordism at work in this description, for we can detect here as well an element of literary eugenics. Duffield's image of magazines "swarming" over newsstands, which seems to indict the unintellectual working class, smacks of the fear of literary production run amok. This fear finds its most lasting embodiment in Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno's model of the culture industry as a system composed of "film, radio, and magazines" that infects "everything with sameness."³³ For them, even the "sharp distinctions like those between A and B films, or between short stories published in magazines in different price segments, do not so much reflect real differences as assist in the classification, organization, and identification of readers." The aim of this reification of culture, for them, is "the standardized mode of production of the culture industry which makes the individual illusory in its products."³⁴ Standardized culture, they insist, kills individualism while selling the illusion of individuality.

Generally, modernist critics failed to take into consideration that the marketplace can empower both individual talent and experimentation because of its hyper-competitiveness. It is possible for genre formulae to emerge that are both structured and critically or politically astute. Genre magazines even fostered what amounts to a political “pulp avant-garde,” the most obvious example being Hammett’s *Maltese Falcon* and *Red Harvest*, both originally published in *Black Mask*. Other examples include the fiction of Harry Stephen Keeler, which took pulp formula to surreal extremes; the flapper fiction of the 1920s snappy magazines; and the antifascist formula of the Depression-era hero pulps.³⁵ These last two examples illustrate how a popular genre formula can itself do political and cultural work.

As with the authors of the pulp avant-garde, modernist novelists looked to popular literature as an inspiration for formal and stylistic experimentation. By drawing such stringent lines between literary and popular culture, critics of modernism neglected to see how literary art, particularly the hybrid form of the modernist genre novel, emerged from the thematic, formal and stylistic formulae of popular literature — the very literature that modernists and their critics felt the need to repudiate.

Notes

1. Quoted in the review of *The Eater of Darkness*, *Time* 14, no. 6 (August 5, 1929): n.p.
2. Examples of important modernist novels that fall into this body of work include Faulkner’s *Sanctuary* (1931), *Pylon* (1935), *The Unvanquished* (1938), *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem (The Wild Palms)* (1939), and *Intruder in the Dust* (1948); Hemingway’s *Farewell to Arms* (1929) and *To Have and Have Not* (1937); Fitzgerald’s *The Great Gatsby* (1925); Robert Coates’ *The Eater of Darkness* (1926); Gertrude Stein’s *Blood on the Dining Room Floor: A Murder Mystery* (1948); Joseph Conrad’s *Lord Jim* (1900), *The Secret Agent* (1907), and *Chance* (1913); and Aldous Huxley’s *Brave New World* (1932). Among Harlem Renaissance writers, George Schuyler, in *Black No More* (1931), Rudolph Fisher, in *The Conjure Man Dies* (1932), and Richard Wright in *Native Son* (1940), drew for inspiration on the themes, style, or conventions of contemporary popular genres.

3. "The Boarding House" and "Little Cloud" appeared in the May 1915 *Smart Set*. Numerous other stories from *Dubliners* would appear in American reprint magazines such as *The Golden Book*, which published "Eveline" in July 1932.
4. William Faulkner, *Selected Letters* (New York: Random House, 1977), 84.
5. David M. Earle, "Magazines," in *Ernest Hemingway in Context*, eds. Debra A. Modellmog and Suzanne del Gizzo (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012), 96.
6. David M. Earle, *All Man!: Hemingway, Men's Magazines, and the Masculine Persona* (Kent, OH: Kent State University Press, 2009), 33–43.
7. *Publishers Weekly* 102 (August 12, 1922): 540.
8. Statistics taken from *Ayer's Directory of Newspapers and Magazines*, qtd. in Theodore Peterson, *Magazines in the Twentieth Century* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1956), 58.
9. Peterson, *Magazines in the Twentieth Century*, 59, 62.
10. On the history of pulp magazines and their confluence with modernism, see David Earle, *Re-Covering Modernism: Pulp, Paperbacks, and the Prejudice of Form* (Hampshire: Ashgate, 2009).
11. Ernest Hemingway, *To Have and Have Not* (New York: Scribner's, 1965), 210.
12. Marcus Duffield, "The Pulp: Day Dreams for the Masses," *Vanity Fair* 40 (June 1933): 36–41.
13. *Writer's Digest* 12, no. 4 (March 1932); *Writer's Digest* 10, no. 3 (February 1930); *The Writer's 1930 Yearbook and Market Guide*, ed. Aron M. Mathieu (Cincinnati: Writer's Digest, 1930), respectively.
14. *The Student-Author* 1, no. 9 (September 1916): 1.
15. *The Student-Author* 5, no. 6 (June 1920): 5–7.
16. *The Student-Author* 6, no. 12 (December 1921): 3.
17. Faulkner, *If I Forget Thee, Jerusalem* (New York: Vintage, 1995), 41. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*If*).
18. *Ernest Hemingway, Selected Letters, 1917–1961* (New York: Simon Schuster, 2003), 155; Malcolm Cowley, *Exiles Return* (New York: Penguin, 1994), 225.
19. Leonard Leff, *Hemingway and His Conspirators: Hollywood, Scribner's, and the Making of American Celebrity Culture* (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield, 1997); Earle, "Magazines," 94–5.
20. Walter Wenska, "There's a Man with a Gun over There": Faulkner's Hijacking of Masculine Popular Culture," *The Faulkner Journal* 15 (Fall 1999/2000): 35–60; see as well Scott Yarbrough's dissertation "The Mean Streets of Jefferson: Faulkner's Intersection with Pulp Fiction" (University of Alabama, 1996).

21. Leslie Fiedler, "Pop Goes the Faulkner": In Quest of *Sanctuary*," in *Faulkner and Popular Culture*, eds. Abadie and Fowler (Jackson: University Press of Mississippi, 1990), 85–6.
22. David M. Earle, "Yoknapatawpha Pulp, or What Faulkner Really Read at the P.O.," in *Fifty Years After Faulkner: Faulkner and Yoknapatawpha*, eds. Jay Watson and Ann Abadie (Jackson: University Press of Mississippi, 2015).
23. William Faulkner, *Sanctuary* (New York: Vintage, 1985), 244–5. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*S*).
24. Michael Zeitlin, "Pylon," in *A Faulkner Encyclopedia*, eds. Robert Hamblin and Charles Peek (Westport, CT: Greenwood, 1999), 306.
25. "Death Drag," *Scribner's* 9, no. 1 (January 1932); "Honor," *American Mercury* 20, no. 79 (July 1930).
26. Michael Zeitlin, "Faulkner's Pylon: The City in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," *Canadian Review of American Studies* 22, no. 2 (Fall 1991): 229–40; Karl Zender, "Money and Matter in *Pylon* and *The Wild Palms*," *Faulkner Journal* 1, no. 2 (Spring 1986): 17–29.
27. Lawrence Schwartz, *Creating Faulkner's Reputation* (Knoxville: University of Tennessee Press, 1988), 39–72.
28. A different magazine from *Snappy Stories*, mentioned earlier.
29. See Joseph Moldenhauer, "Unity of Theme and Structure in *The Wild Palms*," in *William Faulkner: Three Decades of Criticism*, eds. Frederick J. Hoffman and Olga W. Vickery (New York: Harcourt, Brace, 1960), 305.
30. See Faulkner's introduction to the Modern Library edition of *Sanctuary* (New York: Modern Library, 1932).
31. See Robert Trogdon, *Ernest Hemingway: A Literary Reference* (New York: Carroll & Graff, 1999), 200–4.
32. Duffield, "The Pulp," 37–8.
33. Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno, *Dialect of Enlightenment* (New York: Continuum, 1990), 94.
34. *Ibid.*, 97, 124.
35. Earle, *Re-Covering Modernism*, 141–9, 105–21, 51–9.

*Modernism and Historical Fiction:
The Case of H.D.*

Lara Vetter

The conventional narrative about modernism has writers of the period turning consciously away from the sweeping nineteenth-century historical epic, embracing instead highly experimental novels concerned more with plumbing the life of the individual mind than with capturing the scene of cultural or political life. Literary historical fiction disappeared for decades, to be resuscitated only very recently in the postmodern era. Modernists eschewed literature that evoked historical events and contingencies in favor of an art that captured a universal world of psychology and myth-making. High modernists were exclusionary, locked in a world at once ahistorical and apolitical, sequestering themselves safely from contamination by mass culture and the everyday. Since Andreas Huyssen argued against this apparent "great divide" between high modernism and mass culture, however, scholars have begun to see the relationship between modernism and the world as far more complicated than we had assumed.¹ And, more recently, Marianne DeKoven reminds us that we cannot easily extricate the novel form itself from history: "'The novel' is a genre that would not exist, or would not exist in the same way, without the foundational historical narratives of its rise . . . , its origins . . . , and its intimate historical connection to domesticity and gender."² That said, there does seem to be a crucial distinction to be made between earlier and later phases of the modernist movement. Study of the emerging category *late modernism* aims to theorize what Jed Esty has termed an "anthropological turn" among aging modernists from the experimental and transcendent to the political and historical.³ Marina Mackay's study of Second World War era literature likewise identifies the 1940s as a time

“when modernists were compelled to scrutinise the political and moral claims of insular nationality at a time when allegiance was demanded as rarely before.”⁴

My aim is to call into question conventional narratives by looking at historical fiction of the modernist era. Not only were readers of the period eagerly consuming potboilers by popular authors such as Zane Grey, Katharine Burdekin, and Rafael Sabatini, but writers as diverse as Willa Cather, Virginia Woolf, Arna Bontemps, Ford Madox Ford, Laura Riding, Bryher, William Faulkner, Robert Graves, Joseph Conrad, and Mary Butts dabbled in the genre. Not surprisingly, given the shifting focus of late modernism, many penned historical fiction late in their careers: Cather’s *Sapphira and the Slave Girl* was her final work; Woolf’s *Between the Acts* was her last novel; Conrad’s Napoleonic novels were written at the end of his life; Butts’ *The Macedonian* and *Scenes from the Life of Cleopatra* were written shortly before her death; and historical novels by Bontemps, Riding, and Faulkner were written not in the heyday of modernism but in the 1930s.⁵ H.D. was another such writer, not a dabbler but one who made more extensive use of the genre. One of the first writers of free verse in English, she is perhaps best known for her participation in Imagism, a movement that countered sentimental Victorian verse with terse, stripped-down poems that defied traditional, nineteenth-century poetic conventions. But she wrote four decades of prose as well, including several historical stories and novels, and was an avid reader herself of historical fiction, happily devouring novels by Katharine Burdekin, Leonard Ehrlich, Valentine Williams, Helen Beauclerk, and D. L. Murray.⁶

This chapter compares two phases of H.D.’s interest in the genre – the 1920s and the 1940s. H.D., I contend, was interested in historical and political matters earlier than were many of her compatriots. What shifted for her, as she entered the late modernist phase of her career, was that her vision of the political was heightened and her sense of how the personal and political overlap became much more complicated. The trauma of the war – the experience of the Blitz that left her psychologically shaken, the food rations that rendered her weak and malnourished – provoked an aesthetic response unique in

her oeuvre. By examining her early “Hipparchia” (published in 1926) and her later novel *The Sword Went Out to Sea: (Synthesis of a Dream)* by Delia Alton (completed in 1947), we can see how she develops the form of historical fiction to explore how personal trauma is embedded in larger nationalist and imperialist narratives.⁷ A fairly straightforward treatment of the topic in her earlier phase is critiqued in the later work, as she begins to problematize nationalist responses to war and to see the need for a more experimental style to grapple with complexities she had come to recognize in the immediate post–Second World War era. Ultimately, in *Sword*, she is able to contemplate an ethical system for living in the wake of a world war, one that allows her to confront private and public trauma by accepting the permeability of the boundary between self and other.

Set in early Greece, Rome, and Judea, three of H.D.’s early fictions of the 1920s examine the politics of gender and sexuality in the ancient world. As much of her early poetry and translation work strives to realize just this kind of analysis, historical fiction was undoubtedly a natural choice for her in this period of her career. To a point, H.D.’s earlier historical work – “Hipparchia,” *Pilate’s Wife*, and *Hedylus*⁸ – can be productively regarded within a framework Ruth Hoberman constructs to describe the work of early twentieth-century British women writers of historical fiction, who explore the “interlocking issues of power, gender, and narrative authority.”⁹ Hoberman notes the specific pitfalls for women writers in a genre that requires, as many have theorized about historical fiction, that the protagonist be an emblematic subject of a tumultuous era whose life must be molded by events in a way that is representative of the larger populace, a feature Avrom Fleishman’s landmark study refers to as “symbolic universality”: “The historical novel is pre-eminently suited to telling how individual lives were shaped at specific moments of history, and how this shaping reveals the character of those historical periods.”¹⁰ Because women of previous eras were rarely participants in the public sphere, they do not tend to be the subjects of historical fiction. The women writers of historical fiction in Hoberman’s study devise female characters negotiating the gendered limitations of the past, or they cross-dress, creating male

protagonists who can explore the past without being subject to gendered restrictions. H.D. employs both strategies in her 1920s work. The titular character of *Hedylus* is a young man based on herself, battling his mother over his love for a girl modeled on H.D.'s lifelong companion, Bryher, for instance. *Pilate's Wife* centers around a young woman, Veronica, married to Pontius Pilate but erotically drawn to a female fortune-teller, Mnevis.

In the early historical works by H.D., the ancient world largely serves as backdrop in much the way Hoberman describes. The dominant subjects and plots of these texts mirror those of H.D.'s other autobiographical novels of the 1920s: her bisexuality, her marriage to British writer Richard Aldington and his infidelity, and her initial meeting with Bryher. But the first story of H.D.'s three-part *Palimpsest*, "Hipparchia," departs subtly from this formula. In this narrative, H.D. is not just interested in the politics of gender and sexuality but also the politics of imperialism. Set in Rome at the beginning of the third and final Mithridatic War, "Hipparchia" considers the theme of betrayal and the figure of "the other woman," "*l'autre*," by mapping wartime sexual betrayal onto the Roman imperialist project. H.D. transmutes herself into the Greek Hipparchia as she struggles to come to terms with an affair between her lover, the Roman soldier Marius, and another Roman, Olivia. Here H.D. manipulates the historical situation so that she can place Hipparchia, the fictional daughter of a real radical female and proto-feminist Cynic philosopher of the fourth century BCE, Hipparchia of Thrace, in a time *after* Greece has fallen to Rome. Had Hipparchia the philosopher given birth to such a child, that daughter would have lived in the Hellenistic period of Greece. It is not until 146 BCE, following the Battle of Corinth, that Rome claims all of Greece as a Roman protectorate. By moving the fictional Hipparchia forward in time, H.D. places her in an historical moment of Roman imperialism; by setting the story in 75 BCE, she further establishes a wartime setting in an historical moment in which Rome is still embroiled in wars defending its right to expand its empire.¹¹

As a Greek in this period, then, Hipparchia is the conquered, while Marius is the conqueror; if Greeks are grapes, Romans are

“wine pressers,” she avers (*Palimpsest* 4). A remnant of a lost civilization that fell centuries before the story opens, Hipparchia is “vanished” and “vanquished,” consistently described in terms of death; she is a “phantom,” one of Niobe’s children, smelling of the “death-flower” Hyacinth (29, 11, 31, 12). Hipparchia haunts Marius, as traces of Greece linger in Rome. As Susan Stanford Friedman observes, Marius conceptualizes sex with Hipparchia as “reenact[ing] Rome’s conquest of Greece.”¹² His growing alliance with Olivia metaphorically solidifies the reality that “Greece was now lost” (3). As Marius turns from the Greek Hipparchia to the Roman Olivia, Greece recedes further and further into the past.

The Greek is the self in this short story, the Roman the other. When Marius looks at Hipparchia, she does not return his gaze – “her eyes . . . had been seeing elsewhere” – and he fears that a glance from her would produce “dire memories, the long death-plunge forward” (65). She sees only “the other.” But when the Roman Olivia and Marius look at each other, they see sameness. They are physically similar, “dark rowed” with “wide eyes” and “static and exact speech,” and they are intellectually alike: “[e]ach knew the other perfectly . . . [e]ach could follow each” (32). For Hipparchia, looking at Marius or at Olivia through the mediating object of “an enchanter’s mirror” entails occupying several subject positions simultaneously: “She saw with her own eyes, with the eyes of Marius, with the dark eyes of Olivia, Olivia. She saw Olivia as Olivia must see Olivia” (65). When Marius touches her, she feels that he is touching Olivia (66).

In response, Hipparchia staunchly rejects a demand for empathetic identification with the other, characterizing the episode “some horrible phantasy,” “false, theatrical” (65–6). “No, no, no, no,” she tells herself, “this way was madness” (66). In this story, moments of encounter between self and other are portrayed as bearing an insurmountable threat. The philosopher Emmanuel Levinas has placed a great deal of emphasis on face-to-face interactions in his theories of ethics, finding them unique sites of confronting alterity. When self faces other, the other makes an implicit ethical demand on the self.¹³ In Levinasian terms, Hipparchia is confronted with an other that

cannot be assimilated into her sense of self – an other she sees as fundamentally different, that must be repudiated. The ending of the story reestablishes and reifies the boundary between self and other and denies the demand made by the other. Hipparchia meets Julia Cornelia Augusta, a figure based on Bryher, who loves Greek poetry and whose father collects Greek artifacts. Her decision to align herself with Julia, not Marius, enables her to shore up the fragments of her embattled identity, to effect a reaffirmation of Greek values in the midst of Roman civilization. “Greek must rule,” Hipparchia concludes, “Not Rome only but the world” (75). In the late 1920s, H.D. sees as necessary a fundamentally essentialist – and proto-nationalist – stance to at once strengthen the ego and ensure that the ethos of ancient Greece is not forever lost.

As a genre, historical fiction navigates a precarious divide, situating a fictional narrative within a factual setting. As Alessandro Manzoni observes aptly and concisely in his influential study of the genre, the historical novel “is a work impossible to achieve satisfactorily, because its premises are inherently contradictory.”¹⁴ In other words, the historical novel must be simultaneously and paradoxically true and untrue. Autobiography similarly negotiates claims to truth and authenticity. Like historical fiction, autobiography assumes a static, closed temporal system dependent upon the techniques of fiction for the representation of events fixed in the historical past. So H.D.’s early work compounds the theoretical complexities of historical fiction by interweaving two sets of factual events that are nonetheless fictionalized in order to tell what she sees as a timeless story, iterations of which recur throughout history. Constrained by the demands of factual historical events and her own life’s story, H.D.’s early historical fiction is doubly ensnared by demands for truth. This paradox highlights a seeming incongruity between modernism as an aesthetic movement and historical fiction as a genre. Temporally bound, “true” accounts of the past belong to the deterministic world of realism or naturalism, not modernism. Richard Murphy makes this point when he suggests that “the modernist avant-garde . . . emphasises the open, and eminently *reversible*, montage form precisely in order to oppose the strict linearity and

causality of conventional narrativisation, often with the aim of giving the reader more responsibility for organising the fragments into other forms of coherence and alternative meanings.”¹⁵ For the modernist who had lost faith in notions of historical authenticity, who had no clear sense that truth was representable, “[h]istory ha[d] become a burden, from which one wishe[d] to be and must be liberated.”¹⁶

In most Western fiction, Harry Shaw notes, “[d]evaluing history becomes a moral act that asserts human dignity, freedom, and moral responsibility.”¹⁷ If other post-Enlightenment fictional genres permit at least the illusion of agency and freedom, historical fiction – and autobiography – cannot. A closed temporal system is necessarily guided by not just a logic of teleology but a logic of determinism, conditions that might preclude any consideration of ethics or morality. How, after all, can characters confined to historically specific settings make ethical choices? And what would an ethical choice look like in a world in which the outcomes are predetermined, unaffected by a character’s intervention? Linda Hutcheon proposes that what she calls postmodern “historiographic metafiction” circumvents some of these thorny problems by questioning the very idea that we can know the past and by undermining and violating conventional modes of representation: “Postmodern fiction suggests that to re-write or to re-present the past in fiction and in history is, in both cases, to open it up to the present, to prevent it from being conclusive and teleological.”¹⁸ This is a model for an historical novel that attends closely to the role of the present in the past. As Walter Benjamin astutely claims, “every image of the past that is not recognized by the present as one of its own concerns threatens to disappear irretrievably.”¹⁹

H.D.’s “Hipparchia” uses an historical setting of war and imperialism to draw an extended metaphor between gender and imperialism – in which men are (Roman) conquerors and women are the (Greek) conquered – but the personal narrative dominates that frame. Efforts to deconstruct these binaries falter, and a universalizing logic is upheld in both arenas, the politics of nationalism and heterosexuality. H.D.’s 1940s historical fiction, I would contend,

aims to accomplish something quite different and a great deal more complicated, more along the lines that Hutcheon describes. In a time when so many late modernists were just beginning to respond to contemporary political exigencies, H.D. returns to the genre of historical fiction with an expanded focus; rather than remaining solely in the ancient world, the 1940s fiction explores episodes in the history of European war and imperialism, including, for instance, the medieval Crusades, the 1066 Norman Conquest, the French Revolution, the Crimean War, and the 1857 Sepoy Rebellion. A London denizen during the years of Second World War and the Blitz, H.D. was stirred to contemplate more expressly political topics. The universe of “Hipparchia” had been a cyclical one, in which war, imperialism, and betrayal are constant, recurring realities that cannot effectively be altered by the actions of its characters. As a translator and Greek historian, Hipparchia may choose to take a stand against Roman imperialism by recourse to a kind of proto-nationalism – by recovering, translating, and disseminating Greek knowledge and culture – but the next story in *Palimpsest*, “Murex,” makes clear that history remains unchanged by her actions, for “Murex” retells that same story of war and sexual betrayal in a modern setting. The artist figure at the center of “Murex” contemplates her soldier lover’s sexual betrayal as she strives to compose a poem that expresses and documents her trauma. Despite a significant difference in time and setting, the situation and the outcome remain virtually unchanged. The first of the 1940s historical novels, *Sword*, however, takes into account the notion of the present as a constitutive part of our understanding of the past instead of situating the present and the past as equal parts of a static equation. Here the personal narrative fades – evoked only to be critiqued – while the historical situation is pushed into the foreground.

In *Sword*, the personal serves as mere metaphor for the political. Indeed, H.D.’s persistent retelling of the story of her betrayal by Aldington in her 1920s work is called into question in the first half of *Sword*, “Wintersleep,” where the focus on infidelity is pushed to such an excess that the novel calls into question its importance in the face of a greater historical and political reality. In the novel’s opening, she

is again the wronged party in an affair. The phrase the Aldington figure utters more than once – “I love you but I desire *l'autre*” – becomes a refrain that echoes throughout part I of the volume. But instead of her husband, Aldington, the principal soldier lovers in this part of *Sword* are men H.D.'s autobiographical protagonist, Delia Alton, hardly know: Lord Howell (based on Air Chief Marshal Hugh Dowding), a war hero she only met a few times; and Thomas Moore, a figure from Delia's teen years, a boy she met just once, not a military man but playing the role of one on stage. Howell and Moore, I would contend, are empty signifiers, flat characters sketched in abstract terms. The degree to which Delia is obsessed with these phantoms – to the point, in fact, of near psychosis – becomes the measure of the absurdity of her desire. That experiences with these men begin to overlay the very real personal trauma of Aldington's betrayal points to a distancing of herself from the past tragedy and the man who has – to use her term – “repudiated” her. In other words, the intricacies of the personal experience cease to be important, for these men serve as mere symbols, actors floating in different guises within a larger theater of war and militaristic violence throughout the remainder of the book. H.D. appears to have come to the realization Primo Levi expresses in *The Drowned and the Saved*, that “a memory evoked too often, and expressed in the form of a story, tends to become fixed in a stereotype, in a form tested by experience, crystallized, perfected, adorned, installing itself in the place of the raw memory and growing at its expense.”²⁰ *Sword* begins to take apart the trauma “crystallized” in autobiographical fictions of the 1920s.

When Delia receives a dismissive letter from Howell, her response interlaces personal and cultural trauma: “The impact of his letter left me cold, as the impact of the high explosives and the bombs had done” (*Sword* 8). She reflects later that he had “struck” her, she was “vanquished,” her self obliterated: “I simply wasn't there, any more” (*Sword* 32, 61, 33). In representing the experience of personal betrayal in terms of this excess, divorced increasingly from her psychic reality, H.D. puts a great deal of pressure on the parallel between the personal and the political she had established in

"Hipparchia." In the second half of the book, "Summerdream," Delia splinters into a panoply of personages that surface in different historical periods associated with war and imperialism: ancient Greece as it falls to Rome; Rome in the time of Britain's conqueror, Julius Caesar; Elizabethan England; and Normandy on the eve of the 1066 invasion.²¹ As Cynthia Hogue notes of the multiple settings, "The world of 'Summerdream' is . . . portrayed as being at war, having been at war for some time, or going to war. That world defines the hero's horizon, for he is defending, building, or conquering an empire."²² While Delia is anchored in London during a world war, these various and varied protagonists occupy a range of subject positions representing different forms of alterity. She is, alternately, Greek, Roman, English, French; she is also, importantly, *l'autre*, the "other woman," not Caesar's wife, Calpurnia, but his paramour. When she begins the Roman section of the book, the narrator initially recoils from becoming what Olivia had been in "Hipparchia," a Roman mistress: "I can hardly bring myself to write it. Why must I think about it? It is foreign and unfamiliar" (*Sword* 223). But she moves forward, imaginatively becoming *l'autre* in the Roman vignettes of the novel.

The fragmentation of Delia's identity – portrayed in a remarkably disjunctive and disorienting novel – signals a shift in H.D.'s thinking about the tenuous line between self and other. Through Delia, H.D. makes herself vulnerable to an other she had, in the past, seen purely as a threat to her sense of personal and national identity. Judith Butler has argued that exposure to violence in political life can engender an ethics based in the shared experience of mourning because "each of us is constituted politically in part by virtue of the social vulnerability of our bodies."²³ This form of vulnerability, then, involves a recognition that the self is not autonomous but constituted relationally: the *I* and the *you* are inextricably linked in ways that can become clearer in times of trauma. As Michael Gardiner puts it in his discussion of Levinas and ethics, "An understanding of this alterity requires that we cultivate a sense of 'exteriority', and develop an awareness of our *relationality* to the world and other selves."²⁴ Kaja Silverman's terms *idiopathic* and *heteropathic*

identification (adapted from Max Scheler) are particularly elucidating in this context.²⁵ In "Hipparchia," the protagonist fears a face-to-face confrontation with Marius and Olivia because she fears idiopathic identification, an interaction that would entail a loss of self, a total absorption of her Greek identity by the Romans. Thus she "refus[es] to live in and through alien corporealities."²⁶ Marius, too, views the encounter idiopathically; according to Friedman, "[h]is desire for her ever-elusive body is the longing to possess the Other, a desire for conquest."²⁷ And he, too, fears that Greece will consume him when he reflects that the sound of the syllables of Greek poetry "ate into him, scalded, flayed him" (*Palimpsest* 6). He has no such fear of Olivia, as he easily sees through her eyes (22, 25, 31). In the second part of *Sword*, however, a multiply divided identity flows in and out of definitive categories of selfhood and otherness, engaging in the temporary identificatory relationships Silverman terms "heteropathic," in which the self respects alterity and accepts the risks inherent in temporary and partial identification with the other. Delia is "induced to occupy a subject-position which is antithetical to . . . her psychic formation."²⁸ H.D.'s protagonists in *Sword* respond, then, to the other's ethical demand for empathy in a series of sporadic but meaningful moments of identification.

It is not insignificant that H.D. imagines this deconstruction of the self/other binary in a time when the world has been divided violently and decidedly between an *us* and a *them*, in a time when nations are conquering one another, arguably, idiopathically, with an aggression that "conceals the reality that the self is heterogeneous, a product of its alterity with the Other."²⁹ Interestingly, Delia's psychotic break, from which the diffusion of her identity stems in part II of the book, takes the form of contemplation about nation and war. After years of nightly bombings, food rationings, and illness, Delia hallucinates a third world war in which "[g]eographic boundaries were bombed away" and major European cities – "Rotterdam, Warsaw, London" – were "one" (*Sword* 64). This experience forces her to reconsider the focus on ancient Greece in her earlier poetry and fiction: "So maybe," she muses, "this obsession with past civilizations was simply a matter of our own imminent danger and

constant preoccupation with death and with dead cities" (64). Here she acknowledges the central function of the present in articulating the past, a recognition much less apparent in her early work. The present is the starting point for any historical analysis. "To articulate the past historically . . . means to seize hold of a memory as it flashes up at a moment of danger," Benjamin has remarked, and H.D.'s *Sword* floods the reader with an historical procession of "moment[s] of danger" that provoke a disintegration of self that is not annihilation and absolute, but fleeting and generative.³⁰

Where H.D.'s *Sword* departs most discernibly from the work of many other late modernists is in its form. If other writers largely turned back to realism to articulate political interests, H.D. invents a new form of narrative construction to depict her shifting sense of political and personal realities. Abandoning the impressionism of "Hipparchia," H.D. employs a more experimental, highly fractured style that better captures the fragility and instability of the boundaries between present and past, self and other. It is as if the text itself must come apart, the narrative fragmenting and spinning centrifugally out of its London center, with the various protagonists time-traveling through a dizzying array of historical periods key to Britain's history. The shards of Delia's identity – the residue lingering after her psychotic episode – appear and reappear as disparate narrators of a jumble of historical fictions. The form of *Sword*, then, can be viewed fruitfully within the context of Silverman's contention that "[c]rucial to the encouragement and maintenance of a heteropathic identification is the designation of the scene of representation as radically discontinuous with the world of the spectator."³¹ Like Delia, readers of *Sword* are never comfortable, never sure of their bearings. Settings and characters constantly shift and bleed into one another. The recurrent theatrical scenes, and Delia's forays into the supernatural, only function to reinforce this sense of the unreal, the unstable, the unknowable.

In *Sword*, H.D. does not simply cast herself in an autobiographical role set in the remote past; rather, she creates distance between herself and her multiple protagonists, thinking carefully about the power of her choices as author. She seems to have moved from

thinking about the relationship between herself and her autobiographically based protagonists as isomorphic to acknowledging a more heteropathic perspective on autobiographical identity. In a reflective essay written several years later, H.D. sounds a note of caution to her readers about the various personae she created over the years: mentioning Hipparchia and several of *Sword's* protagonists among others, she insists both that the characters are autobiographically based *and* (pointedly employing both the first person singular and plural) that “we are not one or any of those whose lovely names startle and enchant me, as I read them now as if for the first time, in my own prose and poetry.”³² She is not just Hipparchia, not just Delia, but she is (and is not) a host of very different kinds of characters.

Though still physically bound to a world of nationalism, imperialism, and war, moreover, H.D. responds to the closed temporal systems of autobiography and historical fiction by devising innovations in the respective genres. The universe is no less sealed in *Sword* than it is in “Hipparchia.” However, using the devices of time travel and multiple, variously unstable narrators, she is able to pry open a space for her characters to exercise agency and to make ethical choices. This is not the freedom typical of the Western novel, which Shaw argues “[d]evalu[es] history” and Levinas terms “an imperialism of the same” — “maintain[ing] oneself against the other . . . to ensure the autarchy of an I.”³³ H.D. cannot change history, or her life story, but she can shift profoundly her relationship to that history, public and private. When she tells a version of her own story in the 1940s, she does so through a narrative voice based in a relational understanding of a vulnerable and malleable self, not a self that desires its autonomy and isolation at the expense of an acceptance of alterity. The 1940s self is shaped by history but not determined by it.

In a letter to Aldington dated December 13, 1946, H.D. voices her deep ambivalence about her German heritage during the war, referring to it as a “political onus.”³⁴ Her mother’s family was ethnically German, and she had, to that point, been proud of the Moravian tradition from which she had descended. For H.D. in 1947, imaginatively embodying the position of *l’autre* constitutes an attempt to

understand, even embrace, the permeable and contingent nature of the relationship between self and other. Clearly, the ramifications of such an attempt do not just concern how she learns to cope with the personal trauma surrounding her break with Aldington. It is an expressly antinationalist position that she contemplates, and we can see the evidence in the subjects and settings of the poetry and prose she produces after 1940, which range far beyond the borders of ancient Greece. To be clear, the narrators of *Sword* are not happy or even hopeful – they do not revel in a newly gained sense of postmodern identity – but they nonetheless perform what they see as a painful but necessary task. H.D. never again makes use of this fragmented narrative form, but she continues to write both historical fiction and autobiography. Four years later, in 1951, a more hopeful H.D. finishes *The Mystery*, in which a different cast of characters works toward a world without national borders – “a unity, a world-unity without war” – sifting through old documents and letters to reconstruct some sense of the past in order to better envision the future.³⁵ “It is more than family history,” one character tells another, “It is history” (*Mystery* 70).

Notes

1. Andreas Huyssen, *After the Great Divide: Modernism, Mass Culture, Postmodernism* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1986).
2. Marianne DeKoven, “History, the Twentieth Century, and a Contemporary Novel,” *Novel* 42 (2009): 332.
3. Jed Esty, *A Shrinking Island: Modernism and National Culture in England* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2004).
4. Marina Mackay, *Modernism and World War II* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 2.
5. Willa Cather, *Sapphira and the Slave Girl* (New York: Vintage, 2010); Virginia Woolf, *Between the Acts* (New York: Harcourt, Brace, 1941); Joseph Conrad, *The Rover* (London: Dent, 1956); Joseph Conrad, *Suspense: A Napoleonic Novel* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2011); Mary Butts, *The Classical Novels* (Kingston, NY: McPherson, 1994); Arna Bontemps, *Black Thunder* (Boston: Beacon, 1992); Laura Riding, *Lives of Wives* (Manchester, UK: Carcanet, 1988); William Faulkner, *Absalom, Absalom* (New York: Modern Library, 1993).

6. H.D.'s personal library is catalogued at the Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript Library; some of her books are also located in Bryher's private library in East Hampton, NY. For a catalogue of the latter collection, see Virginia Smyers, "H.D.'s Books in the Bryher Library," *H.D. Newsletter* 1, no. 2 (1987); and Virginia Smyers, "Errata to 'H.D.'s Books in the Bryher Library,'" *H.D. Newsletter* 2, no. 1 (1988).
7. H.D., *Palimpsest* (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1968); H.D., *The Sword Went Out to Sea: (Synthesis of a Dream)*, by Delia Alton, eds. Cynthia Hogue and Julie Vandivere (Gainesville: University Press of Florida, 2007). Subsequent references to these volumes will be cited parenthetically in the text. In the brief space of this article, I am able to extract just a few brief scenes from "Hipparchia" and cannot treat this rich text comprehensively. Moreover, "Hipparchia" is one of three interlaced stories; the other two stories are not historical fiction and thus I am treating "Hipparchia" here in isolation.
8. H.D., *Pilate's Wife*, ed. Joan A. Burke (New York: New Directions, 2000); H.D., *Hedylus* (Redding Ridge, CT: Black Swan Books, 1980).
9. Ruth Hoberman, *Gendering Classicism: The Ancient World in Twentieth-Century Women's Historical Fiction* (New York: State University of New York Press, 1997), 2.
10. Avrom Fleishman, *The English Historical Novel: Walter Scott to Virginia Woolf* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1971), 10.
11. Eileen Gregory, *H.D. and Hellenism: Classic Lines* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1997), 62, asserts that H.D. drew upon accounts of Hipparchia of Thrace by Diogenes Laertius, Plutarch, Pausanias, Appian, and Arrian.
12. Susan Stanford Friedman, *Penelope's Web: Gender, Modernity, H.D.'s Fiction* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1990), 241.
13. Emmanuel Levinas, *Totality and Infinity: An Essay on Exteriority* (Pittsburgh: Duquesne University Press, 1979).
14. Alessandro Manzoni, *On the Historical Novel*, trans. Sandra Bermann (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1984), 72.
15. Richard Murphy, "History, Fiction, and the Avant-Garde: Narrativisation and the Event," *Phrasis* 48, no. 1 (2007): 86.
16. Horst Steinmetz, "History in Fiction – History as Fiction: On the Relations between Literature and History in the Nineteenth and Twentieth Centuries," in *Narrative Turns and Minor Genres in Postmodernism*, eds. Theo d'Haen and Johannes Willem Bertens (Atlanta, GA: Rodopi, 1995), 91–2.
17. Harry E. Shaw, *The Forms of Historical Fiction: Sir Walter Scott and His Successors* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1983), 34.

18. Linda Hutcheon, *A Poetics of Postmodernism: History, Theory, Fiction* (New York: Routledge, 1988), 110.
19. Walter Benjamin, *Illuminations*, ed. Hannah Arendt (New York: Schocken Books, 1968), 255.
20. Primo Levi, *The Drowned and the Saved* (New York: Random House, 1989), 24.
21. Adalaide Morris, "Autobiography and Prophecy in H.D.'s *The Gift*," in *H.D.: Woman and Poet*, edited by Michael King (Orono, ME: National Poetry Foundation, 1986), observes that H.D.'s autobiographical fiction of the early 1940s, *The Gift*, makes clear the difference between author, narrator, and protagonist, but the fragmentation that occurs in *Sword* is much more extensive. Pieces of Delia manifest as very different characters in different time periods, and, in one case, in two characters within one period.
22. Cynthia Hogue, "(Re)Storing Happiness: Toward an Ecopoetic Reading of H.D.'s *The Sword Went Out to Sea* (*Synthesis of a Dream*), by Delia Alton," *ISLE: Interdisciplinary Studies in Literature and Environment* 18, no. 4 (2011): 855.
23. Judith Butler, "Violence, Mourning, Politics," *Studies in Gender and Sexuality* 4 (2003): 10.
24. Michael Gardiner, "Alterity and Ethics: A Dialogical Perspective," *Theory Culture Society* 13 (1996): 129.
25. Kaja Silverman, *The Threshold of the Visible World* (New York: Routledge, 1996).
26. *Ibid.*, 24.
27. Friedman, *Penelope's Web*, 241.
28. Silverman, *Threshold*, 91.
29. Gardiner, "Alterity," 130.
30. Benjamin, *Illuminations*, 255.
31. Silverman, *Threshold*, 86. It is an interesting coincidence that Silverman turns to Sergei Eisenstein for an extended example of the approach to filmmaking best suited to inducing heteropathic identification. H.D. and Bryher greatly admired Eisenstein, whose theories influenced their own approach to filmmaking and film reviewing. For a discussion of Eisenstein's impact on H.D., Bryher, and other modernists, see Susan McCabe, *The Cinematics of Modernism: Modernist Poetry and Film* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2009).
32. H.D., "H.D. by Delia Alton," *Iowa Review* 16, no. 3 (1986): 220.
33. Shaw, *Forms*, 34; Levinas, *Totality*, 87, 46.
34. This letter from H.D. to Aldington can be found in the H.D. Papers, Yale Collection of American Literature, Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript

Library, New Haven, Connecticut. The author gratefully acknowledges New Directions Press and the H.D. Estate for permission to quote from this letter.

35. H.D., *The Mystery*, ed. Jane Augustine (Gainesville: University Press of Florida, 2009), 33. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text.

Modernism in Transit

*The Modernist Novel in Its Contemporaneity**Pamela L. Caughie*

Nothing is less real than realism.

Georgia O'Keeffe

When Georgia O'Keeffe sought to convey the spectacle of a flower in bloom, she found an affective equivalent in the quintessential modernist structure, the skyscraper: "And when the bloom came out, I felt as though a skyscraper had gone up overnight."¹ When Virginia Woolf wanted to capture the rapid changes of bodily sensations that comprise the modern woman, she found her figure in the "raging torrent" of objects and impressions that one experiences when motor-ing fast through London and created the verbal equivalent of an abstract modernist collage: "Vast blue blocks of building rose into the air; the red cowls of chimneys were spotted irregularly across the sky; the road shone like silver-headed nails; omnibuses bore down upon her with sculptured white-faced drivers; she noticed sponges, bird-cages, boxes of green American cloth."² When Gertrude Stein needed a concrete example to distinguish the "time-sense" of the twentieth century from that of the nineteenth, she turned to the Ford assembly line: "instead of having the feeling of beginning at one end and ending at another, [the twentieth century] had the conception of assembling the whole thing out of its parts."³ The famed difficulty of modernist art, often attributed to the radical formal experimentalism of avant-garde artists, actually hails from more mundane circumstances: everyday life in the early twentieth century. Through the writings of Gertrude Stein, Virginia Woolf, and Nella Larsen, this chapter considers the temporality of the now, the modernist novel in its contemporaneity, to show how the ambient environment of daily life takes shape in, and shapes, the modernist novel.

In "How Writing Is Written," a lecture delivered at the Choate School during her American tour of 1934–35, Gertrude Stein counters the notion of the modernist artist as avant-garde in the sense of "ahead of his time" with a characteristically simple, if not simplistic, declarative statement: "everybody is contemporary with his period" ("How" 488). This homiletic remark has profound implications for our understanding of the modernist novel. Long revered, and feared, for its celebrated difficulty, the modernist novel is in many ways down to earth. Replete with the detritus of everyday life, it strives to capture the material reality and sensate experience of the early twentieth century and, in the process, renders realism, the representation of life in its social and historical specificity, a bit strange. For our perceptual habits, Stein says, always languish behind the times. "In the things concerning art and literature," she tells her audience, "you will want the things you know" ("How" 488–89), and what we know, as opposed to what we sense, depends on artistic and literary conventions that no longer strike us *as* conventions. The "accepted convention of what things looked like,"⁴ as Roger Fry puts it in "An Essay in Aesthetics" (1909), acts as a drag upon the senses. The "persistent drag" of habit, Stein argues, made it difficult for readers to grasp the contemporaneity of the modernist novel, which in turn made it appear to be "ahead of its time" when actually its contemporary readers' perceptual equipment was outmoded.

From Henry James's retort to his critics in "The Art of Fiction" (1884), in which he affirms that a novel attempts to give an "air of reality,"⁵ yet maintains that that reality exists in the minute examination of consciousness and perception rather than in plot-driven events; to Fry's claim in "An Essay in Aesthetics" that "ordinary people have almost no idea of what things really look like," so influenced are they by past aesthetic conventions that they are incapable of comparing art to nature, ironically the very test of a good painting; to Virginia Woolf's concession in "Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown" (1924) that character is central to the novel but that human character changed circa December 1910, even though the public still expects to see the hot water bottle to believe in an old woman like Mrs. Brown; to Fredric Jameson's declaration in

Postmodernism, or the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism (1991) that “we do not yet possess the perceptual equipment” to navigate postmodern hyperspace “because our perceptual habits were formed in . . . the space of high modernism”⁶ – each generation of artists and writers for over a century has proclaimed that the perceptual tools of the previous generation impede our apprehension of the contemporary scene. In this respect, they are all modernists, emphasizing the importance of mediation.

With the waning of a strictly formalist analysis of literature and the rise of cultural criticism in the 1980s and 1990s, modernism began to be understood from the bottom up, so to speak. Studying modernism in the 1960s and 1970s, one received the impression that modernist artists were removed from, if not hostile to, mass culture. Clive Bell’s opposition to jazz, Theodor Adorno’s critique of the culture industry, Woolf’s class elitism all came to emblemize a modernist sensibility. Aesthetic modernism – or at least “a certain austere image of ‘high modernism’, as advanced by the New Critics”⁷ – privileged stylistic innovation and insisted on the autonomy of the artwork to the extent that it remained aloof from everyday social life. More recent scholarship, now referred to as the new modernist studies, has insisted on modernism’s intimate relationship to mass culture, specifically the changing social, economic, and technological conditions of late modernity.⁸ New sensorial experiences – the perspectival shift produced by a skyscraper, the shrinkage of spatial distance achieved by a radio broadcast, the minute examination of an object through a filmic close-up, the reflexive gaze of a mannequin in a shop window – made writers and audiences alike more aware of mediation, creating the ironic distance and self-consciousness that has come to characterize the modernist novel. “The inevitable mediation of experience,” proclaims Michael North, “has also become inescapably obvious, so much so that self-consciousness about it has to be considered as a sociopolitical fact.”⁹ The modernist novel does more than mediate readers’ experiences of contemporary life; it acknowledges modern lived experience as itself mediated. Modernism is, for North, “a play on the artificial mediation so prominent in modern life.”¹⁰

What Walter Benjamin says of film is true as well of the modernist novel: "By close-ups of the things around us, by focusing on hidden details of familiar objects, by exploring commonplace milieus under the ingenious guidance of the camera, the film, on the one hand, extends our comprehension of the necessities which rule our lives; on the other hand, it manages to assure us of an immense and unexpected field of action."¹¹ The modernist novel immerses its readers in the familiar and the commonplace, providing an affective equivalent of everyday life, but more importantly, it immerses readers in the moment, "an immense and unexpected field of action," in the instant when the perceptual apparatus is catching up with new media and new forms of mediation. This function can best be illustrated by Woolf's *Jacob's Room*, published in that defining year for modernism, 1922.

The kind of synchrony Stein identifies with the twentieth century through the analogy of the assembly line is evident in Woolf's *Jacob's Room*. The novel begins abruptly – "'So of course,' wrote Betty Flanders, pressing her heels rather deeper in the sand, 'there was nothing for it but to leave'"¹² – and consists of scenes juxtaposed in a collagelike structure, with no narrative agency to orient the reader to the time or place setting of the scenes. Although the novel moves chronologically, from Jacob's boyhood to his untimely death, it does not flow linearly; it jumps, cuts, skips. The end of the first chapter, with its close-up of a crab in a bucket, and the last scene of the novel, where Mrs. Flanders holds up a pair of Jacob's old shoes, are both framed moments, film stills. They do not lead to anything; they are what they are: a crab in a bucket, a pair of shoes. The "'realist' pathos"¹³ of those shoes, a metonym for the departed Jacob, stops short of sentimentality as our vision is drawn to the mundane. The shoes and the bucket are familiar objects whose reality has been significantly altered in the modernist era by technologies like the camera. The natural perception of the nineteenth century has given way to the photographic perception of the twentieth, an insight artist Thomas Lawson encapsulates: "The photograph is the modern world."¹⁴ *Jacob's Room* abounds with such photographic moments. In this novel, the emphasis is on the mediation of the world. Its

narrative structure and point of view are filmic. In chapter four, for example, Mrs. Pascoe is described standing at her garden gate, “looking now to the right, now to the left” (*JR* 55). Why narrate that? When Jacob visits the Erechtheum, whose caryatid figure on the left reminds him of Sandra Wentworth Williams, the narrator tells us, “He looked at her, then looked away. He looked at her, then looked away” (*JR* 151). Why repeat that? Because that is the kind of thing film captures, the way film works. “The cinema goes on the same principle,” writes Stein: “each picture is just infinitesimally different from the one before.”¹⁵ It’s not a question of the novel imitating film; rather, the modernist novel conveys the perspectival shift, a new principle of selection, driving new technologies.

In “Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown,” a defense of character in *Jacob’s Room*, Woolf argues that what is true about a character is what is accepted as being true within the narrative conventions of the time. In using Mrs. Brown to illustrate a change in the conception of character in fiction in the modernist era, Woolf shows that the old view of character comes from a certain type of narrative. For the Edwardians like Arnold Bennett, character had to do with the “fabric of things”: with houses, clothing, families, property – that is, it was fixed, bounded, empirical.¹⁶ For Woolf, in contrast, a “real” character does not mean a character who is “life-like” in this way; rather, a real character is one who makes us see things through its eyes, one who mediates our relation to lived experience (“Bennett” 103). Woolf’s essay is less a critique of social reality than a critique of certain literary conventions through which we have learned to negotiate that reality. Realists draw boundaries, identify properties; they are empirically inclined. Modernists concern themselves with social *space*, with relations; they are structurally inclined. In writing her story of Mrs. Brown (as earlier in writing her novel of Jacob), Woolf tells us “how keenly [she] felt the lack of a convention, and how serious a matter it is when the tools of one generation are useless for the next” (“Bennett” 111). Often referred to as Woolf’s aesthetic manifesto, “Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown” invites us to “[t]olerate the spasmodic, the obscure, the fragmentary, the failure” (“Bennett” 119) because we are living in the moment when one set of

conventions is in abeyance and another has yet to take form. What happens during that lag? How does one represent not the social world itself but how that world is being seen *now*? That is the question Stein raises, and the question *Jacob's Room* pursues.

Most striking in *Jacob's Room* is the way Woolf includes the perspectives of so many characters, especially female and lower-class characters, who inhabit Jacob's living space, a modern, urban space cluttered with people as well as objects. The point of view shifts so abruptly and frequently that Jacob is not so much refracted through myriad perspectives as he is, to employ Stein's analogy, *assembled* in time out of glimpses and inferences created by chance encounters. The narrative calls attention to the mediation of point of view. Mrs. Norman finds herself alone in a carriage with Jacob as both travel to Cambridge. Initially alarmed to be closeted with a young man, she quickly sums him up, based on his appearance, as "indifferent," "unconscious," "distinguished" – "like her own boy?" (*JR* 31). The interrogative marks the shift in perspective to that of the narrating agency, who then undermines the reliability of Mrs. Norman's characterization: "One must do the best one can with her report" (*JR* 31). We must not only make do with the bits and pieces we can scrape together about Jacob, we must be aware of whose vision provides those details. Similarly Mrs. Papworth reports on Jacob and Bonamy's argument overheard from the scullery where she washes up the evening's dishes, getting Jacob's name wrong (she calls him Sanders) and failing to grasp their words: "'objective something' . . . and 'common ground' and something else – all very long words" (*JR* 102). Again, the mediation is emphasized: "and where an inquisitive old woman gets a name wrong, what chance is there that she will faithfully report an argument?" (*JR* 102). In this novel, a grand generalization, "For he had grown to be a man and was about to be immersed in things," that sounds like the voice of an omniscient narrator is attributed to "the chambermaid "fingering [Jacob's] keys, studs, pencils, and bottles of tabloids strewn on the dressing-table" (*JR* 139) as she cleans his room. To be immersed in "things" means not abstractions and ideals, such as politics and patriotism, not housing and property, but ordinary objects.

Explicitly in *Jacob's Room*, and implicitly in "Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown," Woolf explores the effects of urban mass culture on the structure of experience and on new formations of the subject. We stand on Mudie's corner in Oxford Street and see the omnibuses locked in traffic: "The proximity of the omnibuses gave the outside passengers an opportunity to stare into each other's faces" (*JR* 64), a social relation unique to urban mass culture, as sociologist Georg Simmel had noted earlier.¹⁷ In telling the story of Jacob Flanders, Woolf seeks to steep us in that atmosphere, to capture and reproduce the sense modalities of modern urban life. As Woolf writes in "Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown," fiction has changed because social relations have changed. The cook now pops into the drawing room to borrow the daily paper. The city streets are now crowded with working women: Milly Edwards, the waitress; Nelly Jenkinson, the typist; Fanny Elmer, the artist's model. What kind of narrative perspective comes with that kind of change in social relations?

By way of an answer, let me turn to another passage in *Jacob's Room*. Describing the multitudes around St. Paul's, where Jacob is playing the tourist, the narrator writes:

Nothing could appear more certain from the steps of St. Paul's than that each person is miraculously provided with coat, skirt, and boots; an income; an object. Only Jacob, carrying in his hand Finlay's *Byzantine Empire*, which he had bought in Ludgate Hill, looked a little different; for in his hand he carried a book, which book he would at nine-thirty precisely, by his own fireside, open and study, as no one else of all these multitudes would do. They have no houses. The streets belong to them; the shops; the churches; theirs the innumerable desks; the stretched office lights; the vans are theirs, and the railway slung high above the street. If you look closer you will see that three elderly men at a little distance from each other run spiders along the pavement as if the street were their parlour, and here, against the wall, a woman stares at nothing, boot-laces extended, which she does not ask you to buy. The posters are theirs too; and the news on them. A town destroyed; a race won. A homeless people, circling beneath the sky whose blue or white is held off by a ceiling cloth of steel filings and horse dung shredded to dust. (*JR* 66)

"They have no houses" not because they are literally homeless but because the urban scene is the only place where we confront these

modern subjects, the “multitudes.” They can’t be identified by their houses, like Bennett’s Hilda Lessways, for we know them only in their urban setting. The phrase, “If you look closer,” calls attention to a new perspective. Woolf’s “if you look closer” implies no moral address to the reader; in its movement from distance to close-up, the narrative perspective is like a camera zooming in on an object. As Benjamin observes, “a different nature opens itself to the camera than opens to the naked eye – if only because an unconsciously penetrated space is substituted for a space consciously explored.”¹⁸ Woolf consciously (and self-consciously) explores this space not only to draw attention to the people of the street, and to new class relations, but to the narrative perspective itself and to the difference new forms of narrative and new technologies make to how we relate to our changed social environment. In *Jacob’s Room*, the dizzying shifts in the angle of vision create a pervasive uncertainty in the novel, a narrative uncertainty that is usually interpreted as Woolf’s belief that we can never know another. But such an interpretation overlooks the emphasis on mediation. The novel is not about Jacob’s world so much as it immerses us in the materiality of the moment, the lag when the perceptual apparatus is catching up with new technology, new media, and new social relations.

O’Keeffe’s remark that “nothing is less real than realism,” like Woolf’s remark that by “real” she does not mean “life-like” (“Bennett” 103), is not, then, a rejection of realism so much as an acknowledgment that the nineteenth-century realist aesthetic created a way of seeing the world that no longer conforms to the lived experience of modern life, a point echoed by all three novelists considered here. To see a skyscraper in a calla lily is to perceive the flower looming large, a mass of color and texture. As an objective correlative for O’Keeffe’s emotional experience of the flower, the skyscraper dominates one’s field of vision as the flower dominated O’Keeffe’s, providing a perspective unavailable to previous generations. To say that O’Keeffe’s flowers are not realistic would be to assume the perceptual apparatus remains unchanged from generation to generation. “The only thing that is different from one time to another is what is seen,” Stein proclaims in “Composition as

Explanation" (1926), "and what is seen depends upon how everybody is doing everything."¹⁹ And in the modernist era, everybody is doing everything quickly. A skyscraper rises overnight; a motor car stirs up a "raging torrent" of impressions; the shutter of a lens captures its subject in a tenth of a second; a radio broadcast reaches the ears of thousands of listeners instantaneously. The twentieth century, Stein avers, is movement. The nineteenth-century writer could describe a building or display window in precise detail as if it stood before her because her perspective was static. The modernist's perception of the same building or window gives the impression of speed – blocks of color, glimpses of bits and pieces that never cohere into a picture. "[T]he only thing that is different [from generation to generation]," Stein insists, "is what is seen *when it seems to be being seen*, in other words, composition and time-sense."²⁰ "When it seems to be being seen" refers at once to the present moment in which the composition takes shape, and to the self-conscious awareness of its mediation, its "being seen." The drag upon the senses produced by old habits of seeing, that lag between what one is capable of seeing, or sensing, and what is "being seen" or felt is the substance of the modernist novel.

The modernist novel is about what happens in time, not just about a particular time. It works against the obliteration of the moment in the event. For, as Stein writes, "the novel which tells about what happens is of no interest to anybody."²¹ Not surprisingly, given her famed ego, but perhaps surprisingly given that Stein says the twentieth century is movement, Stein pronounced her novella "Melanctha," written in 1905, "the first definite step away from the nineteenth century and into the twentieth century in literature,"²² a point echoed in Howard Finn's assessment of *Three Lives* as "the first truly modernist novel."²³ In "Melanctha," Stein developed what she termed the continual or continuous present, where the narrative moves so slowly and repeats itself so often, "a constant recurring and beginning" as Stein puts it, that it is as if time did not flow linearly, as if past, present, and future coexisted. Time in this novella is synchronous, not chronological, a "constellation" of moments, to borrow Benjamin's term.²⁴ As Carl Van Vechten remarked in his

introduction to the 1933 edition of *Three Lives*, “its [“Melanctha’s”] subject matter . . . is similar to the subject matter of the realists, Zola and Flaubert . . . but so different is the treatment that any question of influence may be immediately dismissed.”²⁵ Van Vechten attributes influence to Cézanne; Stein would later credit the film and the assembly line.

Yet for a modernist work, the novella is notably devoid of references to new technologies or descriptions of urban scenes. Confined to the small town of Bridgeport, the banalities of the everyday are reflected in the banalities of its language: “Melanctha took good care of her mother. She did everything that any woman could, she tended and soothed and helped her pale yellow mother, and she worked hard in every way to take care of her, and make her dying easy. . . . Melanctha did everything that any woman could, and at last her mother died, and Melanctha had her buried.”²⁶ Mundane repetition is the rhythm of her writing. In its emphasis on language, however, in its disrupted syntax (which North has characterized as a modernist strategy of “linguistic mimicry and racial masquerade”²⁷), and especially in its strings of modifiers repeated with infinitesimal differences, the novella mimics, even anticipates, the “endless repetition of the average”²⁸ that structures not only the routine of everyday life but also the comic strip and the electronic message board and which, Ann Douglas notes, was “a trick fast becoming a cultural law.”²⁹ “If much modernism is about human movement,” Enda Duffy observes, “then speed itself becomes the very narrative heft of much modernist artistic production. . . . In each high modernist experimental form, the death of distance is hidden in plain sight, and speed as a way of life, a way of living, and a way of being has come true.”³⁰ Even in such a low-tech novel as this, the speed of modern technologies alters, if not the pace of the novel, at least the writer’s and readers’ “experience of time and space.”³¹ For the everyday, as Rita Felski notes, comprises not only the routines and rituals of daily life, but “forms of consciousness” emergent in those routines.³²

“Melanctha” opens with a dead baby, an event presented so nonchalantly that any “‘realist’ pathos” is undercut by the matter-of-fact style: “The child though it was healthy after it was born, did

not live long. . . . Rose Johnson had liked the baby well enough and perhaps she just forgot it for awhile, anyway the child was dead and Rose and Sam her husband were very sorry but then these things came so often in the negro world in Bridgepoint, that they neither of them thought about it very long" (TL 85). Nor does the narrative. "The painful, difficult birth-into-death of the black Johnson baby," writes Marianne DeKoven, is "implicated in the disruption of traditional narrative," a metaphor, DeKoven says, "of a new story not yet quite ready to be written."³³ Here again we have the notion of writing in the lag between the break-up of former perceptual habits and literary conventions, and the formation of new ones. Again and again the narrative describes Melanctha on the cusp of wisdom, in the moment of coming to understand: "she knew very early how to use her power as a woman, and yet Melanctha with all her inborn intense wisdom was really very ignorant of evil" (TL 95); "Sometimes she would almost go over, and then the strength in her of not really knowing, would stop the average man in his endeavor" (TL 96). What we get in this novella is not experience in retrospect but experience as it unfolds in time, in the moment of its coming to be seen, or sensed. What we get, as Stein would put it, is experience, not events.

For in "Melanctha," "nothing much happens," as Stein famously said of *Ulysses*.³⁴ Melanctha "wanders" – Stein's opaque yet revealing verb – throughout the story, from home to home, lover to lover, job to job without ever leaving the confines of her small town: "She was really very safe with all the wandering,. . . in these days of her attempted learning" (TL 97). She and her lover, Jefferson Campbell, talk endlessly, exhaustively, without really communicating: "I certainly do wonder, Miss Melanctha, if we know at all really what each other means by what we are always saying" (TL 128). Stein's achievement lies in the minute parsing of emotional and sensual experience as it unfolds in time. In *Jacob's Room*, nothing much happens either in that events that might be considered significant in Jacob's life – his first sexual encounter, his first employment, his death on the battlefield – happen "off camera," so to speak. In Larsen's *Quicksand*, a lot happens, and yet nothing much happens

in that the structuring of events is so repetitious that while Helga Crane moves a lot, she goes nowhere. Where Woolf's novel depicts the emergence of the modern woman – from Clara Durront, “a virgin chained to a rock” (*JR* 123), whose passions are still held fast in the arms of social convention, to Fanny and Florinda, who go about freely with men – Stein, like Larsen, presents the coming into consciousness of the modern woman herself through a protagonist who sometimes seems “like one kind of girl” and sometimes “like a girl that is all different” (*TL* 138). The repetition that structures Stein's novel, the glacial pace of the narrative, captures (or to adopt Stein's locution, “really captures”) the emotional and sensual life of the modern woman in the interval between the old and the new, between what women, especially black women, were in fiction and in life, and what they will be, in that moment before new social identities stabilize. “Melanctha Herbert was always losing what she had in wanting all the things she saw. Melanctha was always being left when she was not leaving others. . . . Melanctha Herbert was always seeking rest and quiet, and always she could only find new ways to be in trouble” (*TL* 89). Helga Crane exactly. “If we cannot look back of Miss Stein and find a literary ancestor,” Van Vechten states, “it is easy to look forward: a vast sea of writers seems to be swimming in the inspiration derived from this prose.”³⁵ And Nella Larsen professed herself one of them.

In a 1928 letter to Stein, accompanying a copy of her first novel, *Quicksand*, Larsen wondered with many other readers how Stein came to write “Melanctha.” Acknowledging she has read “Melanctha” many times, Larsen writes: “And always I get from it some new thing – a truly great story. I never cease to wonder how you came to write it and just why you and not some one of us should so accurately have caught the spirit of this race of mine.”³⁶ For all the “racial ventriloquism”³⁷ attributed to its prose style, what seems to have captivated Larsen in “Melanctha” was the way the novella moves, the repetition of scenes and phrases that captures the slow emergence of a restless desire without any goal or resolution. What North refers to as the “most objectionable” aspect of Stein's story, “its fixation on the sexual lives of its subjects, as if African-American

characters are to be understood primarily in sensual terms,”³⁸ might just be what Larsen found so compelling, and what she found missing in so much African-American writing that either elided sexuality altogether in an effort of “racial uplift,” or focused on the sensuality as a form of defiance. Larsen seems to have been attracted by the way Melanctha’s sensuality is conveyed linguistically and structurally, appreciating how Stein has seized the interval, the moment of a black woman’s emotional and sensual awakening that remains inchoate.

Quicksand shows its indebtedness to Stein’s novella as much in its formal qualities as in its representation of race – repetition with variation, experience over event, free indirect discourse. Long read in terms of the “tragic mulatto” narrative tradition and the aesthetic debates of the Harlem Renaissance, more recent scholarship treats Larsen’s *Quicksand* as a distinctly modernist novel. In her forward to Larsen’s second novel, *Passing* (1929), Mae Henderson defines aesthetic modernism in terms of “aesthetic self-consciousness, stylistic fragmentation, and . . . [a] questioning of representation” within the context of “a distinctively modern sense of dislocation and ambiguity.”³⁹ To read Larsen’s novel in the context of Stein’s and Woolf’s modernism is to highlight the way the novel expresses its contemporaneity both thematically and formally, to see the estrangement from realism in its apparently realistic style. Helga Crane represents not the confinement of identity by racial and sexual ideologies, as earlier readings emphasized, but, as Jeanne Schepher has argued, “the expansion of identity promised . . . by geographic mobility.”⁴⁰ Helga’s movements from one geographic location to another – to the north and then back south, across the Atlantic and then back home – like her desire to keep moving, are not an expression of the tragedy of having no home, no determinate race, but rather, Schepher claims, “a mobile performance of modern subjectivity.”⁴¹ Yet that promise of expansion is never realized; the novel ends not with a resolution but with the endless repetition of the same as Helga’s monotonous cycle of childbirth begins for the fifth time.

Helga, who “could neither conform, nor be happy in her unconformity,”⁴² continually finds contentment in some new place

only to discover it cannot last, continually has the “sense of having come home” (*Q&P* 43) only to realize there is no place for her: “She, Helga Crane, who had no home” (*Q&P* 30). Home, with its comfort of familiar conventions and its connotations of stasis and permanency, does not fit the time-sense of the twentieth century as Stein has defined it. Instead, Helga conceptualizes herself as “moving shuttle-like from continent to continent” (*Q&P* 96). As North says of D. H. Lawrence, who spent almost the entire year of 1922 traveling around the world, one might say of Helga Crane: “the only place [she] finally belonged was in transit.”⁴³ The sense of being in transit need not represent spatial movement alone, but also the temporality of the interval, the synchronicity of the now.

The opening scene of the novel presents a *tableau vivant* of Helga “alone in her room,” which the narrative describes as “a small oasis in a desert of darkness” (literally, the dark bodies of the faculty and students of Naxos, figuratively the darkness of her “not really knowing,” like Melanctha) (*Q&P* 1). “This little time” alone in her room marks a hiatus in the long, frustrating hours of teaching recalcitrant students. Helga uses “little time” later to refer to her mother’s brief moment of passion “before that gay suave scoundrel, Helga’s father, had left her” (*Q&P* 23). The phrase “little time” captures the fleetingness of the interval. From the beginning, the narrative conveys a sense of restlessness without real movement as a discontented Helga chafes against the “strenuous rigidity of conduct” at this all-black college. And as in *Jacob’s Room*, it is a framed moment, drawing our attention to its mediation: “An observer would have thought her well fitted to that framing of light and shade” (*Q&P* 2). (“Would have thought” in the sense of, had there been anyone observing, but also had the observer been using outmoded perceptual equipment.) Framed moments recur in this novel, most notably in the vaudeville house where Helga, “an ironical and silently speculative spectator,” watches the negro performers on stage in a “slavish imitation of traits not their own,” performing a masquerade of blackness that stirs in her both revulsion and “urgent longings”: “But she returned again and again” (*Q&P* 82, 83). Or the revival scene that Helga watches in fascination and

horror until, overcome with “weakness and nausea,” she succumbs, “and in that moment she was lost – or saved” (*Q&P* 113). Each of these framed scenes conveys the sense of being caught in a space between old forms and the possibility of something new that characterizes the time-sense of the modernist novel.

Quicksand is a quintessentially modernist novel in other, more familiar ways: its urban settings, its nightclub scenes, its references to jazz, its fashion sense. Larsen too immerses us in the everyday life of Chicago, New York City, Harlem, and Copenhagen: the crowded city streets, “swarming with people, merging into little eddies and disengaging themselves . . . the myriad human beings pressing hurriedly on” (*Q&P* 30), the advertisements in the shop windows, the rush of taxi cabs, the oppressive noise and odor. Helga’s clothing is described in meticulous detail, the fabric, color, and accoutrements of the modern woman’s attire. Helga’s aesthetic and literary tastes, like Larsen’s, are modern. Helga has read Henrik Ibsen and Anatole France’s “The Procurator of Judea,” with its “superbly ironic ending” (*Q&P* 132). Her room at Naxos is decorated with a “blue Chinese carpet,” “oriental silk,” a “shining brass bowl crowded with many-colored nasturtiums,” and books with “bright covers” (*Q&P* 1).

But it is less in the “fabric of things,” as Woolf describes the Edwardian novel, that Larsen’s novel feels modernist than in Helga’s, and the narrative’s, self-conscious awareness of “being seen.” Whether describing the teachers at Naxos, the swarming masses in Chicago, the Harlem social elite, or the rural Alabama folk, Larsen always makes us aware of the narrative perspective so that we are not just watching the scene before us but aware that we are watching, as in a movie. Larsen’s use of free indirect discourse exposes Helga’s mindfulness of her own position as an onlooker, of and apart from the scene, and leads the reader – as Woolf does more explicitly – to an acute awareness of mediation. Helga sees that everyone around her (and maybe the reader as well) looks at race as it has been seen, not in its *being seen*.

Take, for example, the most self-reflexive scene in the novel, Alex Olsen’s portrait of Helga Crane. In Copenhagen Helga’s exotic

tastes and aesthetic sense come to define her, and not just the things she desires, as a fetishized commodity. Her aunt and uncle, delighted to have this rare specimen of Africa decorating their home, dress Helga in “batik dresses,” “a leopard-skin coat,” “turban-like hats,” “feathers and furs” (*Q&P* 74), clothing “selected or suggested” by Olsen, the artist who paints her portrait, which Helga describes as “some disgusting sensual creature with her features” (*Q&P* 89). It is a modernist painting in the Picasso style, admired by artists and critics, disliked by the public, and one that, Helga insists, is not at all “like her” (*Q&P* 89). Her vision of who she is mediated by that painting as it was earlier by the cabaret performance. Larsen, like Woolf, calls attention to the various forms of mediation that structure our sense of what is “life-like,” drawing attention to “what is seen *when it seems to be being seen*.” No wonder Helga doesn’t recognize herself, for the modernist portrait is not of her, not “life-like” in that way, as Woolf would say. Larsen realizes that the familiar themes of the Harlem Renaissance novel can never be the same after modernism, that she cannot portray black characters without awareness of how they have been mediated in modern art and culture. Helga doesn’t recognize herself in any image in her cultural repertoire. That image repertoire is stable, but Helga, a modern woman, is on the move. “The tradition has always been that you may more or less describe the things that happen,” writes Stein in “What Are Master-pieces” (1936), “but nowadays everybody all day long knows what is happening and so what is happening is not really interesting, one knows it by radios cinemas newspapers . . . until what is happening does not really thrill any one The painter can no longer say that what he does is as the world looks to him because he cannot look at the world any more, it has been photographed too much and he has to say that he does something else.”⁴⁴ Larsen can no longer look at the world the same after reading Stein. The rejection of traditional realism, as Stein’s statement reveals, is linked to the temporality of the moment and the heightened mediation of “what is happening” everyday.

Everyday life, then, provides more than the backdrop for the modernist novel or its thematic content; the everyday structures the

very experience of being modern and shapes the form of modernist literary works. Modernist literary techniques not only reflect everyday life in the modern world, recreating, for example, the sensorial experience of motoring through London or the uncanny experience of hearing a voice divorced from a body. These literary devices also prepared readers to live, as Stein put it, their “contemporariness.” “Each generation has to do with what you would call the daily life,” Stein continues. “[The writer] is expressing the thing that is being expressed by everybody else in their daily lives. The thing you have to remember is that everybody lives a contemporary daily life. The writer lives it, too . . .”⁴⁵ Modernist writers drove motor cars and rode omnibuses, watched skyscrapers erected, and shopped in department stores, listened to the gramophone and radio, and attended the cinema and jazz clubs. New visual, aural, and corporeal experiences created new sensory perceptions, new forms of imagination, and new states of consciousness conveyed in the novelistic styles that we have come to call modernist. The practices of everyday life rendered explicit in the modernist novel structure the very emergence of the modern subject. In this way, the modernist novel taught its audience how to read the contemporary scene, even, one might say, how to *be* contemporary.

Notes

1. Anita Pollitzer, *A Woman on Paper: Georgia O'Keeffe* (New York: Simon & Schuster Inc., 1988), 224.
2. Virginia Woolf, *Orlando: A Biography* (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1928), 299.
3. Gertrude Stein, “How Writing Is Written,” in *The Gender of Modernism*, ed. Bonnie Kime Scott (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1990), 489. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (“How”).
4. Roger Fry, “An Essay in Aesthetics,” in *Vision and Design* (1909; repr. London: Pelican, 1961), 23–9.
5. Henry James, “The Art of Fiction,” in *Theory of Fiction: Henry James*, ed. James E. Miller, Jr. (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1972), 27–44.
6. Fredric Jameson, *Postmodernism, or the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1991), 38–9.

7. Andreas Huyssens, "Mapping the Postmodern," *New German Critique* 33 (Autumn 1984): 17.
8. Douglas Mao and Rebecca Walkowitz, "The New Modernist Studies," *PMLA* 123 (May 2008): 737–48.
9. Michael North, *Reading 1922: A Return to the Scene of the Modern* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999), 29.
10. *Ibid.*, 139.
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The Modernist Novel in the World-System

Laura Winkiel

Structures are those coral reefs of human relations which have a stable existence over relatively long periods of time. But structures too are born, develop, and die. Immanuel Wallerstein

The global turn in literary studies has been manifest for the last decade or so and not least among studies of modernism. As Elleke Boehmer, in her review essay of *The Oxford Handbook of Global Modernisms*, notes, “Modernism may be one of the few movements or approaches in the arts that can take the qualifier of the global without conceptual jarring.”¹ Perhaps not jarring, but certainly this conceptual shift to a global purview has entailed a fundamental – and still contentious – transformation of the term “modernism.” The global remit of modernism has allowed us to dismantle the narrow definition of modernism as the high aesthetic experimentalism of Anglo-European writers, composers, and painters in the first few decades of the twentieth century. However, as Boehmer notes, “modernism, formally conceived, is to some extent the casualty of the methodology of comparative reading across and between modernizing contexts that motivates many of the essays”² collected in *The Oxford Handbook of Global Modernisms*. In geographically and temporally expanding the range of modernisms, modernist aesthetic form and its relation to its specific politico-historical contexts too often falls by the wayside. The result, Boehmer contends, are new blind spots. She asks, while global modernism provincializes modernism’s Eurocentric conception, what new, and necessarily partial world – because totality is unrepresentable – does it yield?

One culprit in the new partiality of global modernisms, according to Boehmer, is world-systems theory. She writes, "Even if the world of global modernism/s presses beyond the east-west divisions of the world of a more conventional Anglophone modernism, it remains nonetheless a divided world, a world necessarily still split into the zones of centre, semi-periphery and periphery."³ At issue for Boehmer are the macro-levels of "imperialism," "capitalism," and "empire" and their related socio-economic zones of center, periphery and semi-periphery through which world-systems theory conceives of historical change. Do they still give too much attention to large-scale formations such as empire at the expense of the local specificities of resistance and difference and thus re-erase the very heterogeneity global modernisms purports to uncover? I do not believe this is necessarily the case. This chapter will demonstrate how world-systems theory can be revised and adapted to literary studies to take into account the fluid, dynamic circulations of large-scale socio-economic formations and, most importantly for the purposes of this chapter, be understood through its mediation as modernist narrative form and the aesthetics of everyday life. I will attempt to show how the modernist novel in the capitalist world-system can be made to articulate the very heterogeneity that Boehmer worries will be lost.

The Structures of Everyday Life

World-systems theory, as I draw upon it, primarily arose from two locations.⁴ In Latin America in the 1950s, world-system theory began as a reaction to development theory that promulgated a mimicry model of colonial development in which "primitive" or "less developed" societies would follow the path to development that had been forged successfully by the leading Western nations. Out of this reaction came, as Immanuel Wallerstein recounts, the concept of core-periphery developed by the United Nations Economic Commission for Latin America (ECLA) and by the Latin American economist Raul Prebisch.⁵ Core-periphery refers to the fact that "some countries were stronger economically than others

(the core) and were therefore able to trade on terms that allowed surplus-value [i.e., profits] to flow from the weaker countries (the periphery) to the core" (*WS* 12). The second notable beginning of world-systems theory occurred when a group of social scientists rejected the most common unit of analysis among economic historians and sociologists: the nation. While the first generation of world-systems theorists, the *Annales* group, was formed in France in the 1920s and led by Lucien Febvre and Marc Bloch, it only gained international attention after the Second World War under the direction of the French historiographer Fernand Braudel. Braudel situated his work between two extremes: those historians concerned with spectacular events (wars, revolutions, crises of various sorts), an attention that Braudel criticized as ephemeral, and those historians who sought timeless, eternal truths. Instead, Braudel worked with two overlooked units of social time: structural time (*longue durée*), the time period in which the basic structures of a particular historical system exist and, secondly, the cyclical processes within the structures (medium-run trends), such as expansions and contractions or movements from one hegemonic center to another. In addition, he stressed that the unit of analysis should be that of a "world-economy," or system, that joined together disparate territories and cultures by means of trade and the division of labor (*WS* 14–15).⁶ The sociologist Immanuel Wallerstein coined the term "world-system" to build upon and describe Fernand Braudel's long-term, or *longue durée*, historical approach to deep structural change. Importantly, for Wallerstein, as for Braudel, world-systems theory integrates different kinds of institutions and material practices across times and spaces without eliminating their specificities, hierarchies, or the possibilities of change. Wallerstein, however, differs from Braudel by bringing a Marxist dimension to the *longue durée*. He argues that the division of labor and the accumulation of capital give formal coherence, or logic, to the contemporary world-system (*WS* 23–4).

The methodology of world-systems theory has been criticized for being Eurocentric (it began with the study of the development of capitalism from the cradle of Europe), impossibly huge in scope (consider Franco Moretti's controversial call for "distant reading"

and computer modeling of literary texts), hierarchical in its understanding of economic development (persisting, for instance, in the use of the terms “core,” “periphery,” and “semi-periphery”), and economically deterministic.⁷ While these criticisms may be warranted in particular cases, it is important to recognize that world-systems theory arose as a materialist history that pays close attention to the structures of everyday life that are, as my epigraph indicates, organically secreted over time and that are different depending on where they are located. Everyday life is defined here as repetitive routine, the uneventful experience of the quotidian that accumulates over long, multi-generational time that is oppositional – in literary studies – to the momentary aesthetic pleasure of transcendence enacted by modernist epiphany and moments of being.⁸ What is materially possible in the everyday depends upon one’s location: What are the amenities, the laboring conditions, the geographical space and infrastructure? What are the possibilities of the place: does one long to be elsewhere or does the promise of the modern seem close by? How do modernist aesthetics allow us to see these quotidian conditions as being produced by forces and materials both near *and* far? Rather than assuming a European location and a developmental narrative, world-systems theory enables us to compare the aesthetics of everyday life, for example, in the London metropolis, provincial Dublin, and the pastoral hinterlands of the Orange Free State in South Africa. The examples I discuss in this chapter are within the British Empire, the geographical and historical network that I research. However, there exists a fundamentally distinct experience of modernity in parts of the world such as post-Ottoman Turkey, China, and Japan that have not been directly informed by Euro-imperialism.⁹ The complex circuitry of influence in these regions suggests a much greater heterodoxy in literatures, in large part because of Asia’s ancient and rich traditions of print cultures and its semi-autonomous modernity. As Emily Apter argues, “In the context of intra-Asian world-systems, Western modernism continues to figure strongly as a lexicon of avant-garde techniques and genres, but the emphasis is on how that lexicon enabled Asian modernism to redefine what modernism is.”¹⁰

These locations need not be viewed as deterministic, especially when aesthetically represented within the dynamic form of the novel, but certainly writers who present these details of everyday life are affected by their place, structured as it is by the world-system of capitalist modernity.¹¹ Hence, if we compare the aesthetics of the everyday as presented in novels, we will find similarities and differences, constraints, and the possibility of transcendence, depending on the novel's location in the world-system. World-systems theory, when carefully historicized, can be used as a heuristic tool for moving beyond the national geographical boundaries of the modernist novel in order to see novels from disparate locations as part of the same system, comprising coeval parts of a single whole, yet integrated differently. And it can also be used to reveal significant factors that produce transformations in the novel form: its style, affect, narrative form, and imagined space. Stephen Shapiro asserts that world-systems theory can serve as "an explanatory device [that] can be marshaled as a means of understanding the rise and fall of aesthetic forms, generic conventions, and the varying centers of cultural consecration, especially as it breaks from nationalist studies by foregrounding the systemic features shaping individual components of the network."¹² In examining the history of the modernist novel, it is important to consider the context of late Empire and its unevenly distributed socio-economic pressures, both innovative and constraining, that served, in part, to reshape the novel.

The Modernist Novel and the Everyday

In imperialism, a contradiction arises between territorial arrangements of commodity production – the nation – and the spatial flows of finance capital – the imperialist world. The interaction of the two logics of capital produce unstable structures of everyday life that can be felt in modernist novels as the tension between the realist detail of the nation state and the abstraction of global finance that attenuates meaning.¹³ And this tension may be felt within literature as it affects subjects and their relations to others. Consider Virginia Woolf's well-known call for a new literary form in "Mr. Bennett and Mrs.

Brown.” This essay registers a profound geopolitical shift underway, one that demands a new form of the novel. Woolf gives only a few fragmentary details of her subject, Mrs. Brown: “She was one of those clean, threadbare old ladies whose extreme tidiness – everything buttoned, fastened, tied together, mended and brushed up,” and combines these details with an indication of emotional depth: “she was crying.”¹⁴ But even as Mrs. Brown’s context is sharply curtailed by Woolf’s impressionist eye, she is also set free from the formal constraints of realist representation: the place of knowable communities and the homogenous temporal register of the nation form, made available by an omniscient narrator. Instead, Woolf says that Mrs. Brown “must be rescued, expressed, and set in her high relations to the world before the train stopped and she disappeared for ever.”¹⁵

These “high relations to the world” suggest that, though fragmentary, Mrs. Brown as aesthetically expressed is part of a whole and it is precisely here that the genre of the novel pulls apart into two irreconcilable components: the naturalist and the symbolic.¹⁶ On the one hand, Mrs. Brown is described in realist, fragmentary detail. Woolf, a detached observer who shares the train car with Mrs. Brown, imputes to her some personal drama with a fortyish man who may be her son. Though the narrator speculates as to the type of drama (financial? family? health?) underway – which the naturalist details cue us to undertake – we are never given definitive answers. Rather, the uncertainty surrounding Mrs. Brown signals her threshold identity. Mrs. Brown’s presence in the train car and Woolf’s appropriation of her bifurcates the scene into two class sectors. Unlike the Edwardian novelists Arnold Bennett, H. G. Wells, and John Galsworthy whom Woolf targets in her essay, Woolf refrains from resituating Mrs. Brown’s class position within the national space of legislation and assimilation. Rather, Woolf’s authorial persona speaks for the anonymous Mrs. Brown by imputing to her an affective interiority that anchors an unbounded world metonymically suggested by the train.¹⁷ Despite the impoverished banality of her class position, Mrs. Brown, too, is capable of deep feeling. Indeed, her interiority suggests a connection between subjective affect and a divided and unknowable (because unbounded

and divided) environment. Woolf's evocation of the new aesthetics of the modernist novel is strongly influenced by her brother-in-law, the influential art critic Clive Bell, whose theory of "significant form" argues that the arrangement of formal features of art, a particular collection of colors, sounds, and forms, elicit specific emotions that recalibrate the modernist subject to an increasingly fragmented and visibly class-riven society.¹⁸ The fact that Woolf only speculates about her indicates Mrs. Brown's inability to represent herself, and yet her symbolic presence in the train sparks an occasion for Woolf's pronouncement that realist novels are "useless" and her announcement of a new form in the making, one that is premised on interiority, significant form, and the everyday. The altered class relations of the twentieth century produce the relativization and inward turn of the modernist novel.¹⁹ In effect, Woolf's essay figures the contradictory dynamics of the world-system as it is riven between the territorial logics of commodity production that is represented by realism and the nation form and the unbounded abstract logics of capital flight and financial speculation that is represented by symbolism.²⁰

I discuss Woolf's well-known essay in order to think about class relations, world-systems, and the everyday in the British modernist novel. Next, I turn to comparative everydayness. Because world-systems theory spans an entire economic system (that extends beyond any one political system), its approach to genre is flexible enough to speak to wholly different socio-cultural contexts. It is comparative insofar as it can capture similarities and differences between different nodal points within a literary network. Braudel, for instance, understands the workings of economics and culture in terms of geographical extension and comparison. His work delineates "zones" of activity that fall beneath the purview of traditional economics, a zone he calls the "infra-economy"²¹:

There are not one but several economies. The one most frequently written about is the so-called market economy, in other words the mechanisms of production and exchange linked to rural activities, to small shops and workshops, to banks, to exchanges, fairs, and (of course) markets. [. . .]

But there is another, shadowy zone, often hard to see for lack of adequate historical documents, lying underneath the market economy: this is that elementary basic activity which went on everywhere and the volume of which is truly fantastic. This rich zone, like a layer covering the earth, I have called for want of a better expression *material life* or *material civilization*. (CC 23; italics in original)

This material life, he says, is repeated on an everyday basis so as to become a “generality or rather a structure” (CC 29). One can think here of Wallerstein’s analogy to the coral reef in the essay’s epigraph in which tiny polyps excrete exoskeletons that, over long periods of time, slowly build the structure of the reef. Braudel refers to a non-transcendent, indeed largely unseen, unwritten, “shadowy” archive of everyday life. Despite its being banal, immediate, and unremarkable, he notes that it is a “rich zone, like a layer covering the earth.” One thinks of the underwater reef or of compost in which organic materials have been broken down, mixed together, and metabolized. The accreted structure of everyday life supports the more easily visible, and widely networked, market economy. Furthermore, this “elementary basic activity,” says Braudel, “pervades society at all levels and characterizes ways of being and behaving” over generations. These naturalized and accumulated styles, forms, and modes of being, solidify and, according to Braudel, erect “a barrier between the possible and impossible” (CC 29). This activity hardens and what was once new activity becomes a constraint. What modernity might bring – the desire to see the whole, suggested by the interconnected nature of modern world-expansion and dynamic transformation – is curtailed by the immediacy of the everyday that blocks the possibility of transcendence.

In the early twentieth century, these world-system determinants in semi-peripheral and peripheral locations (e.g., Ireland and South Africa) both shifted in exciting, promising ways and made their presence also uncomfortably, even catastrophically, felt. A semi-peripheral location in the world-system does not mean “relatively minor” or “irrelevant” but rather denotes a location that unevenly combines, on the one hand, a managerial group of people who are highly individualistic, consume luxury items, belong to elite

institutions (such as universities and country clubs), and ostentatiously showcase their high-style of living (the Anglo-Irish in Ireland and the English and, differently, the Boers and English in South Africa) and, on the other hand, a larger laboring class (Irish Catholic peasantry and black and colored South Africans). For authors in these uneven situations, the formal structure of character and plot in the novel becomes one of fragmentation, discontinuity, allegorical displacement, and projection. The structure of feeling these sites convey attempts to make sense of the absent cause of capitalist modernity, the stark bifurcations between one class and another: the envy and angst, but also the wonder and promise of modernity. An analysis of this affective contradiction occurs in Ian Baucom's essay "Township Modernism" in which he deploys Baudelaire's aestheticization of modernity as a structure that oscillates between "an object . . . horizon of expectation and desire" that is simultaneously "distanced *and* no longer distant" from its observers.²² For those living in the shantytowns of South Africa and the slums of Dublin, modernity *is* both the promise of a modernization that can be seen and desired in the colonial capitals and the violent foreclosure of that desire. This structure of feeling tantalizes. It both defers and delivers, makes good and refuses the possibilities of the collective good.

This double consciousness makes its presence felt in generic discontinuity as well as affective content. It allows us to understand that terms such as "realism" and "modernism" shift over time and place. For instance, metropolitan modernism is often called a more realistic realism.²³ On the other hand, as Simon Gikandi has argued, postcolonial novelists routinely disavow their modernist leanings. He writes that Chinua Achebe deploys the modernist technique of free indirect discourse but refuses the term "modernism" because, at the time, it was too closely linked to metropolitan modernism and its imperialist pretensions.²⁴ Instead of adhering to stark categories – that European texts are modernist while African and other colonial and postcolonial texts are realist – it makes more sense to think about generic discontinuities as expressing uneven development within various sites of the world-system. If we think about genre in this

manner, then comparing *Ulysses* and *Mhudi* (the first novel in English written by a black South African, Solomon T. Plaatje, in 1917 and published in 1930) makes sense though their aesthetic projects are very different.

For instance, both novels are premised upon a temporal gap and recursive structure. *Ulysses* is set in 1904, but as Enda Duffy has strongly argued, it also, in an occluded fashion, interrogates the violent history of the birth of Ireland as a postcolonial nation, partially achieved in 1922. *Mhudi* concerns the *mfecane*, or scattering, of the Rolong tribes in the northwest portion of the Cape Colony in 1830 and the Rolong's first contact with Boer missionaries. But layered onto this first contact narrative is a national allegory of the founding of the Union of South Africa in 1910. Plaatje offers a trenchant critique of this recent history in which the British Empire nominally removed itself from South African concerns and placated the Boers by allowing them to deny basic rights given to black and colored South Africans in the Cape Colony and to pass the catastrophic Native Land Act of 1913 that effectively removed all black South Africans from ownership of their land. This recursive temporal gap serves to critique the trajectory and development of the nation, raising important questions about its future socio-economic and political development.

Secondly, both novels are fully committed to realist detail as well as generic experimentation. This detail scaffolded on generic multiplicity describes the concrete situation of development and community building, in all of its modernist displacement and discontinuity. *Ulysses* is encyclopedic in its realist description but cancels that realism through the fragmentation and dislocation of detail with respect to plot trajectory. Bloom, it has been noted, barely consumes any of the luxuries on display in the colonial metropolis.²⁵ His melancholy rumination on the death of his son and estrangement from his wife cancel the promise and excitement of Joyce's prose fireworks. Bloom both revels in the abundance of modern consumption and empties them of their potential. Furthermore, as a Jew, Bloom both interrogates communal belonging and national development and is foreclosed from such belonging. He figures the

disjunctive site of postcolonial nation building, always in process and always canceled by the larger capitalist system and its machinations. An example of this formal structure is the way in which the later episodes – Eumaeus and Ithaca – slowly swallow Bloom as character, altering the scale of representation from that of a realist narrative to abstracted cosmic and microscopic speculation. This alternation allows for further plot critique as, from the cosmos, we see the both the fleeting nature of imperialist ambitions and the quantitative abstraction of mathematical speculation to which human agency and even subjectivity is subordinated. This scale cancels Bloom's cosmopolitan critique by suggesting a system beyond the human scale, one that produces deeper capitalist penetration. If we read recursively (as Molly's "yes" invites us to), however, this cancellation is not final but, rather, is part of an ongoing process of community formation and interrogation, a relation between a particular site in the capitalist world-system and the whole in which the circle is never squared, so to speak. Ireland exists in a discrepant angle to the major centers of capital accumulation and, as such, must always recalibrate its relation to those centers.²⁶

While Woolf's "Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown" offers fragmented realism and affective interiority in the face of an abstracted world-system, *Ulysses* pursues a different strategy for representing the link between the everyday and the world-system. "Ithaca," the penultimate episode of *Ulysses*, sidelines literary style in favor of a mathematical catechism, a form of impersonal and systematic knowledge. The pretense of the form is to provide exhaustive realist detail in order to summarize Bloom's day. But in actuality, the form undermines and parodies the system of total quantification and global abstraction by means of two different, but related, registers. The first is the resilience of the ordinary to abstraction. As Bloom considers the wider world, he evades abstraction. He names specific places (the cliffs of Moher, Connemara, the Golden Vale of Tipperary, Ceylon, Jerusalem, the straits of Gibraltar, Wall Street, the Parthenon, Niagara, to name just a few) to which he'd like to visit or emigrate.²⁷ In addition, the episode undercuts the abstraction of infinity. Bloom imagines the ghost of Major Tweedy, Molly's father,

retreating, at the terminus of the Great Northern Railway, Amiens street, with constant uniform acceleration, along parallel lines meeting at infinity, if produced: along parallel lines, reproduced at infinity, with constant uniform retardation, at the terminus of the Great Northern Railway, Amiens street, returning.²⁸

While the Great Northern Railway of Ireland was designed in imitation of its British counterpart, its global expansiveness, unlike the railway described by Woolf, is undermined by parody. The ghost of Major Tweedy who goes out to infinity and returns (an absurd idea when translated from geometrical symbolism to realist detail) suggests that Ireland's semi-peripheral position in the world-system is vastly different from that of the British metropolitan center.

Likewise, the aesthetic transcendence of commodified objects is canceled. In place of the aura of commodities, "Ithaca" catalogs a jumble of commonplace objects and texts that refuses symbolic meaning. Realist detail morphs into modernist experimentation by means of its own futile attempts at exhaustiveness. Another instance of the cancellation of aesthetic transcendence by means of realist detail occurs, Majumdar argues, with the soap that Bloom purchases in Lestrygonians. Majumdar notes that the soap's many permutations in the novel (sticking to Bloom's body, melting from the heat) resists its ideological location as part of the colonial project (as in Pears soap advertisements) and reflects "colonial Ireland's ambiguous relations with the more advanced models of capitalism of the time."²⁹ Stripped of aura, the objects in *Ulysses* resist transcendence while the abstract ruminations in "Ithaca" are undercut by parody. Both registers are constrained by their location in the world-system. As Joe Cleary puts it, "[t]o be peripheral is precisely to be compelled to develop within constraints, sets of forces and agendas – economic, political, cultural, intellectual – that have largely been prescribed or conditioned by developments in the [imperial] metropolis."³⁰

When we turn to Plaatje's *Mhudi*, we are in a very different milieu from Dublin, but formally a similar disjunction between realist detail and generic disruption obtains. When the novel was first published, as contemporary reviews of the novel make clear, readers objected to the novel's form. It combined the tragic, elevated diction of

Shakespeare and the Bible with African oral traditions. Its epic form is disjointed (linking epic-scale historical events with a pastoral romance), open-ended, and hybrid (combining dramatic dialogue, Tswana folktales, anthropological realism, and adaptations from Shakespeare, Bunyan, and the Romantic poets). Largely self-taught and mission-educated, Plaatje's facility with languages allowed him to work as a journalist and translator. He was fluent in six African languages (Zulu, Qoranna, Tswana, Rolong, Basuto, Hlubi) as well as Dutch, English, and German. In his writing and political activism, he was a tireless crusader for black South African rights; he helped to found the South African Native National Congress in 1912 (the organization that would become the ANC). Plaatje occupied the difficult position of seeking an alliance with the liberal tradition of the British Empire as it was implemented in the Cape Colony in order to stem the tide of whites-only nationalism after the Union of South Africa in 1910. In addition, he supported the particular traditions and languages of African peoples while also anticipating the promises of Christian universality and rights-based legal and political equality under Empire. Casting his political gaze further afield, he sought out African-American and African-Caribbean leaders (W. E. B. Du Bois, Marcus Garvey, James Weldon Johnson, and R. R. Moton) as examples of black community resilience and leadership in the face of white nationalist privilege.

These multiple and often competing affiliations endow *Mhudi* with a complex multi-discursivity and inter-culturality.³¹ As an anticolonial novel that refuses the colonial narrative in which African peoples are cast outside history as the primitive other, *Mhudi* rewrites imperial history and the adventure stories of Rider Haggard by foregrounding the historical actions and point of view of Southern African tribes. It interrupts diachronic colonial history by focusing on the Mfecane: a series of wide-scale native treks – a decade or so before the iconic Voortrekkers made theirs – and the consolidation of the militarist Zulu nation of Ndebele during the 1820s and 1830s. This examination of history allegorically – that is, cyclically and repetitively – spoke to South Africa's present moment in the 1910s in which another brutal, whites-only nation was

asserting itself. The novel's outlook is geared toward a pan-African nationalism, and it poked fun at the Boers and prophesied that great empires are destined to fall. Finally, it is not written in the expected realist form (for native writers) and does not concern itself with native life on the Bantustan and colorful dialects. In fact, *Mhudi*'s original subtitle: "An Epic of South African Native Life a Hundred Years Ago" makes clear that Plaatje intended this novel to depict African life and history as epic — that is, on world-scale proportions.

And, yet, *Mhudi* punctures its epoch-making, masculine historical developments in South Africa with the comic romance featuring its heroine, Mhudi. The novel ends with the resurgence of the domestic rhythms of the everyday, inflected with the advent of capitalist modernity that brings to South Africa both promise and catastrophe. The novel concludes with the following passage:

In the centre of the waggon away on the low road sat Mhudi, the happy proprietress of a valuable "house on wheels." Her husband having boarded the vehicle from the rear came to sit beside her. Side by side they watched the team of tired oxen lumbering along slowly in the direction of Thaba Nchu, where a warm welcome was awaiting them. The vast plains were dotted by conical koppies now donning their purple mantle in the waning light. Already the stars had begun to twinkle overhead as together they viewed the surrounding landscape. [Ra-Thaga, Mhudi's husband] recalled with delight the charm that attracted him and held him to her since first they met. He mused over the hallowed glories of being transported from one end of the country to the other like White people, in their own waggon.³²

Simon Gikandi argues that this ending "transports its readers to a fantastic world in which the violence of colonial rule has been transcended, signaling [as with a proper romance] 'the victory of fertility over the waste land'" (*M* 327). To achieve such a signal victory, the diachronic narrative of colonialist history must be suppressed and this, Gikandi says, becomes untenable in the course of anticolonial struggle so that realism again asserts itself in later colonial and postcolonial fictions. But his univocal reading of the novel's ending erases Plaatje's irony and complex worldliness, his yoking of realism and romance.

As a token of his friendship, the one “humane” Boer, Sarel de Villiers, gives Ra-Thaga and Mhudi an old wagon and its gear, along with two oxen whose sale will allow the repair of the wagon. Ra-Thaga, always the romantic stargazer, seems entirely overwhelmed by the generosity of the gift as shown in the preceding quote. But Gikandi leaves out the rest of the passage that asks: “Was it real, or was it just an evanescent dream?” (*M* 187–8). Given the black South Africans’ banishment from their own lands with the Native Land Act of 1913, this question reverberates in favor of the latter. (To confirm this reading, one must also ask, if the oxen are sold to repair the wagon, what good will the wagon be?) Moreover, after this optimistic peon to the wonders of the modern, white world, the novel concludes with Mhudi’s plea for Ra-Thaga to settle down. He promises, “from henceforth, I shall have no ears for the call of war or the chase; my ears shall be open to one call only – the call of your voice” (*M* 188). Given Mhudi’s symbolic role as Mother Africa, we can read this pledge as Ra-Thaga’s decision to stop affiliating with the Boers and to tend to his own people. Significantly, Ra-Thaga and Mhudi are from different ethnic and linguistic groups so that their union figures the larger collectivity of the nation. The final scene presents the simultaneous allure of high-tech travel in the wide-open country enabled by the Boer’s European technology against the commitment to the local, everyday domestic sphere. With the promise to withdraw from colonial skirmishes, the covered wagon points toward a banal, ordinary existence in the newly established colonial modernity as well as to the mobile forms of trading outposts and commodity production. While Gikandi argues that the novel, as an anticolonial romance, must be superseded by realism, I propose that Plaatje anticipates this claim and already ushers in the realism of the everyday.

In Plaatje’s novel, everyday existence on the periphery is suffused with anxiety concerning the promise of modernity: “[W]as it real, or was it just an evanescent dream?” (*M* 188). The novel ends with Ra-Thaga convincing himself that he “ought to be satisfied” and – promises to attend to Mhudi’s domestic realm. Yet the conflicting drives – to settle for domestic routine or to leave on a

history-making endeavor (as Plaatje himself had done, leaving his family in South Africa for years on end in order to raise awareness of black South African struggles in the United Kingdom, Canada, and the United States) – suggest that the wider, global forces of modernity have produced a particularly banal and yet also unsettling experience of the everyday for black South Africans. The very indeterminacy of the ending, as Liesl Olson argues in another context, suggests the difficulty in narrating the everyday, which, in this context, is heightened given the uncertainty produced by South Africa's peripheral location in the world-system.³³ Whereas romance offers the possibility of transcendence, for Plaatje this possibility is already undercut by the limitations imposed by Afrikaner nationalism and colonial underdevelopment. He expresses these limitations by yoking together realism and romance so that the everyday is affectively charged with uncertainty. The chronotope of the covered wagon perfectly captures this liminal state: its mobile nature connects local territory to wider province, nation, continent, and beyond while its interior space denotes the sedimented structure and banality of domestic concerns set against the ever-changing landscape of modernity. Like the railway, the wagon figures the world-system that continues to change drastically everyday life in Africa.³⁴

My purpose in comparing writings by Virginia Woolf, James Joyce, and Sol Plaatje is to suggest that the modernist novel in the world-system demands that we read with attention to how the world-system produces the social and structures everyday life. To map this uneven system, it is necessary to compare locations as disparate as London, Dublin, and the Western Cape, but also as linguistically and geographically far flung (beyond the purview of this chapter) as writing by Lu Xun, Ismat Chughtai, Mahasweta Devi, and Pramoedya Ananta Toer. These writers, whatever their political leanings, will reveal the social ground of their literary vision as an integral part of a wider world-system. The structure of everyday life, conditioned by the world-system, will affect the generic scaffolding of the literary form and the possibilities for resistance. These symptoms may appear as spatio-temporal compression, as in temporal folding (accordionizing) or telescoping (bringing

the distant near), the juxtaposition of asynchronous orders and levels of historical experience, strange encounters, alienating effects, surreal cross-linkages, and the production of “untimely space.”³⁵ The heterogeneity of these effects, as I have shown in this short chapter – realist detail, fragmentation, dislocation, threshold identities, parody, unruly objects, anxiety and uncertainty, multi-discursivity and temporal recursivity – I hope disprove the notion that world-systems analysis has little to offer literary studies, particularly to the study of modernism and postcolonial literature from around the world. Much work, however, remains to be done in charting modernism’s heterogeneous and differently inflected travels – and afterlives – in the world-system.

Notes

1. Elleke Boehmer, “How to Feel Global: The Modern, the Global, and the World,” *Literature Compass* 9 (2012): 599.
2. *Ibid.*, 602.
3. *Ibid.*, 600.
4. There are other possible genealogies. Emily Apter’s “The Literary World-System” (in *Teaching World Literature*, ed. David Damrosch [New York: MLA, 2009], 44–60) traces an alternative, far more wide-ranging genealogy of a particular branch of world-system theory, the literary world-system, as practiced by Pascale Casanova and Franco Moretti.
5. Immanuel Wallerstein, *World-Systems Analysis: An Introduction* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2004). Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*WS*). Both the sources that Wallerstein names are influenced by Marxist theories of “combined and uneven development,” that, according to Leon Trotsky, refers to the discrepant experience of modernity between, in Russia, the state of advanced industrial production and peasant subsistence farming (Leon Trotsky, *History of the Russian Revolution* [1932; repr. Chicago: Haymarket, 2008], 3–12).
6. Wallerstein says of the unit of analysis: “Note the hyphen in world-system and its two subcategories, world-economies and world-empires. Putting in the hyphen was intended to underline that we are talking not about systems, economies, empires *of the* (whole) world, but about systems, economies, empires *that are* a world (but quite possibly, and indeed usually, not encompassing the entire globe). This is a key initial concept to grasp. It says that in ‘world-systems’ we are dealing with a spatial/temporal zone

which cuts across many political and cultural units, one that represents an integrated zone of activity and institutions which obey certain systemic rules" (*WS* 16–17). Wallerstein affirms that the world-system in the twentieth-century encompasses the entire globe.

7. These critics include Apter; Alex Beercroft, "World Literature Without a Hyphen: Towards a Typology of Literary Systems," *New Left Review* 54 (November 2008): 87–100; Susan Stanford Friedman, "World Modernisms, World Literature and Comparativity," in *The Oxford Handbook of Global Modernisms*, eds. Mark Wollaeger with Matt Eatough (New York: Oxford, 2012), 499–525; Christopher Prendergast, "The World Republic of Letters," *Debating World Literature*, ed. Christopher Prendergast (New York: Verso, 2004), 1–25; André Gunder Frank and Barry K. Gills, "The Five Thousand Year World System in Theory and Praxis," in *World System History: The Social Science of Long-Term Change*, eds. Robert A. Denemark et al. (New York: Routledge, 2000), 3–23.
8. This definition is drawn from Saikat Majumdar's work on the prosaic. For Majumdar, everyday life in the British colonies of late Empire is experienced as banality, that which "thwarts the spatial transcendence of the immediate and the temporal transcendence of the everyday" (*Prose of the World: Modernism and the Banality of Empire* [New York: Columbia University Press, 2013], 4).
9. Thanks to Karim Mattar for this crucial observation. See also the Warwick Research Collective's work in progress, "Combined and Uneven Development: Towards a New Theory of World-Literature," which seeks to integrate a much wider sampling of literature into the world-system. http://www2.warwick.ac.uk/fac/arts/english/research/currentprojects/collective/wrec_papers/ (accessed 10 Mar. 2014).
10. Apter, "The Literary World-System," 54.
11. Wallerstein's term "geoculture" might prove useful here for thinking about the interrelation of economics and culture in a particular location. Geoculture is not "the superstructure of this world economy . . . [rather, it is] its underside, the part that is more hidden from view and therefore more difficult to assess, but the part without which the rest would not be nourished. I term it the geoculture by analogy with geopolitics, not because it is supra-local or supra-national but because it represents the cultural framework within which the world-system operates" (*Geopolitics and Geoculture: Essays on the Changing World-System* [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1991]) p. 11.
12. Stephen Shapiro, *The Culture and Commerce of the Early American Novel: Reading the Atlantic World-System* (University Park: Pennsylvania State University Press, 2008), 35.

13. See Leerom Medovoi, "'Terminal Crisis'? From the Worlding of American Literature to World-System Literature," *American Literary History* 23, no. 3 (Fall 2011): 643–59, for a detailed examination of these logics and their related modes of aesthetic representation.
14. Virginia Woolf, "Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown," *The Captain's Death Bed and Other Essays* (New York: Harcourt, Brace, 1950), 98–100.
15. *Ibid.*, 114.
16. I take this close attention to modes of aesthetic representation in tension with one another from Saikat Majumdar's discussion of banal objects in James Joyce's *Ulysses* (*Prose of the World*, 50–9).
17. Wolfgang Schivelbusch memorably calls train-travel "the annihilation of space and time" (qtd. in Lynn Kirby, *Parallel Tracks: The Railroad and Silent Cinema* [Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1997], 7). He borrows this phrase from Karl Marx, who links "the creation of the physical conditions of exchange . . . [which include] the means of communication and transport" to the necessity for capital accumulation (*Grundrisse*, trans. Martin Nicolaus [New York: Penguin, 1993], 524). Fredric Jameson's essay "Modernism and Imperialism," in *Nationalism, Colonialism, and Literature*, eds. Terry Eagleton, Fredric Jameson, and Edward W. Said (Minneapolis: Minnesota University Press, 1990), 43–68, likewise situates the train/road travel in E. M. Forster's *Howard's End* as indicative of the infinity of an unbounded modernity.
18. This formulation is taken from Matthew Eatough, *Affective World-Systems and the Atlantic Economy* (PhD Dissertation, Vanderbilt University, 2012), 8.
19. On the shifting relations of the working classes to realist representation in the novel, see Raymond Williams, "Knowable Communities" in *The Country and the City* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1973), and Bruce Robbins, *The Servant's Hand: English Fiction from Below* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1986).
20. For a longer analysis along these lines and in the context of the decline of the American century, see Medovoi, "Terminal Crisis?" For a critique of the British Empire in terms of its commitment to returns on capital investment, see J. A. Hobson, *Imperialism: A Study* (London: James Nisbet & Co. 1902).
21. Fernand Braudel, *Civilization and Capitalism 15th–18th Century*, vol. 1, *The Structures of Everyday Life: The Limits of the Possible* (New York: Harper & Row, 1979), 28. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (CC).
22. Ian Baucom, "Township Modernism," in *Geomodernisms: Race, Modernism, Modernity*, eds. Laura Doyle and Laura Winkiel (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2005), 237.

23. Concerning the modernist form of Joyce's *Ulysses*, Franco Moretti writes, "Far from being a resistance to the reality principle, advertising, the stream of consciousness, absentmindedness, fantasizing – are all *so many versions of that principle*" (*Modern Epic: The World System from Goethe to García Márquez* [New York: Verso, 1996], 140). Likewise, Erich Auerbach calls Virginia Woolf's attention to daily life and the chance occurrences (exterior events that have lost their hegemony) that serve to release inner thoughts "a more genuine, a deeper, and indeed a more real reality" (Auerbach, *Mimesis: The Representation of Reality in Western Literature* [Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1974], 540).
24. Simon Gikandi, "Realism, Romance, and the Problem of African Literary History," *Modern Language Quarterly* 73 (September 2012): 314–16.
25. See Enda Duffy, *The Subaltern Ulysses* (Minneapolis: Minnesota University Press, 1994), 69; Majumdar, *Prose of the World*, 59–62; Garry Leonard, "The History of Now: Commodity Culture and Everyday Life in Joyce," in *Joyce and the Subject of History*, eds. Mark A. Wollaeger, Victor Luftig, and Robert Spoo (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1996), 18.
26. Joe Cleary, in *Outrageous Fortune: Capital and Culture in Modern Ireland* (Dublin: Field Day Publications, 2007), argues for a structural and locational approach to Irish political and cultural life along the lines of Roberto Schwarz's work on Brazilian culture: "The postcolonialist perspective [...] suspends the notion that geography, economy and culture are all neatly homologous with each other, and attempts to investigate the *discrepant* ways in which Irish political and cultural life, which were obviously shaped and textured by wider European developments, were at the same time overdetermined by the country's dependent socio-economic composition" (23; italics in original).
27. James Joyce, *Ulysses* (New York: Vintage, 1986), 597.
28. *Ibid.*, 600.
29. Majumdar, *Prose of the World*, 61.
30. Cleary, "Toward a Materialist-Formalist History of Twentieth-Century Irish Literature," *boundary 2* 31, no. 1 (2004): 210.
31. For more on Plaatje's complex positioning and multi-discursivity, see Elleke Boehmer, *Empire, the National, and the Postcolonial, 1890–1920: Resistance in Interaction* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002); Laura Chrisman, *Reading the Imperial Romance: British Imperialism and South African Resistance in Haggard, Schreiner, and Plaatje* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2000); and Brian Willan, *Sol Plaatje: South African Nationalist, 1876–1932* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984).
32. Solomon T. Plaatje, *Mhudi* (Portsmouth, NH: Heinemann, 1978), 187. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*M*).

33. Liesl Olson, *Modernism and the Ordinary* (New York: Oxford, 2009), 35.
34. Though his novel is set in the interior of South Africa at the time of initial contact with white colonizers, Plaatje connects the events in the novel to the world-system as it impacted Africa. After praising the tribal organization of the Rolong a century earlier, he writes, "These peasants were content to live their monotonous lives, and thought nought of their overseas kinsmen who were making history on the plantations and harbours of Virginia and Mississippi at that time; nor did they know or care about the relations of the Hottentots and the Boers at Cape Town nearer home" (*M* 27).
35. I take much of this catalogue from the Warwick Research Collective's introduction to their work in progress, "Combined and Uneven Development," 25. The phrase in quotes, "untimely space" is derived from Henri Lefebvre's *The Production of Space* (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 1991): "The past leaves its traces; time has its own script. Yet this space is always, now and formerly, a *present* space, given as an immediate whole" (37; italics in original). Some of the formal features are drawn from Roberto Schwarz, who analyzes the effects of the periphery on the work of Brazilian novelist Machado de Assis, "not even time and space, those final defenses of common sense, are safe: volubility squeezes them, stretches them, and explores them in every direction, in any way it pleases" (*A Master on the Periphery of Capitalism: Machado de Assis* [Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2001], 18).

*Modernist Cosmopolitanism**Jessica Berman*

Cosmopolitanism presents both an allure and a challenge. As the term long used to identify the deeply internationalist impulse that emerges in writing in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, even in the face of the consolidation of the nation-state and the expansion of imperial systems, it seems to offer an antidote to rank parochialism or the kind of cultural imperialism enforced by the spread of empire and the travels of late capitalism. Writers such as Henry James, Joseph Conrad, James Joyce, and Virginia Woolf famously take up cosmopolitan attitudes, which allow their intellects and allegiances to travel – as their bodies often do as well. Yet the seeming ease with which they move about the world, whether figuratively or literally, sometimes makes them suspect as elitists or derided as naïve. Consider the different ways in which James and Jean Rhys move to London, one as heir to the European tradition, ready to demonstrate the best of what the upstart American nation has to offer; the other a barely educated, penniless escapee from the white creole society of Antigua. Think of the complexity of Rabindranath Tagore's or Mulk Raj Anand's travels to Bloomsbury, bringing with them concerns about the possibility of literary autonomy and activism under conditions of Indian coloniality. Cosmopolitanism as a political, literary, and social attitude hardly seems adequate to indicate the complex tissue of loyalties and affiliations among these authors.

Or is it? In fact, all of these modernist writers considered themselves to be cosmopolitans, taking as their mantra in one way or another the Senecan phrase, "I was not born for any one corner; all the world is my country."¹ Henry James turns to the cosmopolitan

worldview in order to escape the jingoism of patriotism and the parochialism of American commercial attitudes that he so eloquently describes throughout his fiction. Decrying the laws that stripped a British woman of her citizenship when she married a foreigner, Virginia Woolf famously proclaims in *Three Guineas*, “As a woman I have no country, as a woman I want no country, as a woman my country is the whole world.”² Jean Rhys’s letters describe her sense of belonging both to Antigua and to London at the same time and her efforts to convey that dual loyalty in her narratives.³ For Rabindranath Tagore and Mulk Raj Anand, writing from India, the constraints and injustices of British imperialism lead not to an intense parochialism but rather to a nuanced appreciation of the value of the cosmopolitan argument for anticolonial work. As Anand would put it in a 1943 radio essay, “The World I Hope For,” “I hope for a world in which men and women can enjoy real freedom (social, economic, political, intellectual, and emotional freedom) in common with other citizens of the world . . . I hope for a world in which states voluntarily abdicate some of their unlimited power, and pool their economic, military, and political resources for world federation.”⁴ Anand places cosmopolitanism in the service of Indian anticolonial and anti-imperial activism and uses his claim to be a “citizen of the world” as a demand for improved “social, economic, political, intellectual, and emotional” conditions.⁵

Clearly then, modernist cosmopolitanism demands a more nuanced treatment than my first quick summary suggests. Or, we might say, modernist writers place cosmopolitanism under a kind of pressure that yields a revised model, one that does not necessarily rest on privileged world traveling, imply disaffiliation from local communities, or point primarily to the public sphere. As I have elsewhere argued, modernist writers such as James, Woolf, Rhys, Anand, and others often create new models of cosmopolitanism that are intimately bound to community affiliation, building what I have called “cosmopolitan communities” that complicate the dichotomy between private and public life, home and away.⁶ Their efforts at both local- and world-belonging counter the concentric model of cosmopolitanism, which privileges the movement from private inner

circles of loyalties through an ever-widening sphere from self to family, locality, region, nation, world on the way to a single global cosmopolitan sphere. This concentric model ignores the possibility that private life might be the source of cosmopolitan sympathies or that community feeling might reasonably be linked to world-belonging, or indeed become a constitutive part of it, without a necessary movement “outward” to the public sphere or political nationalism.⁷ The concentric model also ignores the fractured dispersed communities of the global world and has led to models that imagine the widest circle of belonging as something like a single global polity.

Modernist cosmopolitanism often posits a set of dispersed, intersecting spheres of identity, some expressly political, others less so, some more “local” and others networked across the world. Modernist writers use their narratives to create “cosmopolitan communities,” overlapping webs of relation that narrate the story of affiliation as multiple, ever in process, and not bound by the limits of national belonging. In practice, the various models of cosmopolitanism that emerge in modernist fiction often carry with them an attempt to use global insights to revise local or national models of belonging or to temper rather than dismiss nationalist politics.⁸ Cosmopolitanism becomes an activity, sensibility, or attitude that crosses and contests matters of identity, ethics, sovereignty, and politics and marks the imbrication of these identities in other loyalties and affiliations, whether local or global.

The complexity of modernist cosmopolitanism also demands what I would call a transnational critical optic or perspective, one that challenges the discursive structure of the nation as the primary locus of literary and cultural coherence even while continuing to engage with the repercussions of its politics, history, and ongoing power. Such a transnational optic decenters the “national tradition” as an object of inquiry, exploring texts in relation to other, transnational horizons of expectations, even while recognizing the importance of their local aspirations. In the context of the modernist novel, a transnational critical perspective allows us to see not only the imbrication between the local and the global within narrative fiction

or the longing for broader spheres of belonging among its authors, but also the extent to which these worldly aspirations create nodes of connection between and among literary traditions across the globe. To turn back to my initial examples, a transnational critical optic prompts us to see how Woolf's work might intersect with Anand's, or to explore the similar ways in which, despite their dramatically different backgrounds, Rhys and Tagore travel to London. In other words, reading modernism from a transnational perspective adds to its often multi-faceted and fluid cosmopolitanism, exposing how modernist fiction spins out into a world of discursive interconnections and showcasing its many locations and multiple nodes of creation.⁹

The tension between the local and the universal inhabits the history of the term "cosmopolitan" from its beginnings in Western thought and continues in contemporary debate among a range of theorists, including Jacques Derrida, Bruce Robbins, Martha Nussbaum, Tim Brennan, K. Anthony Appiah, and Paul Gilroy.¹⁰ For theorists of cosmopolitanism old and new, discussion of the cosmopolis always brings with it questions about how much one owes to one's homeland and how the wider world affects that locality. In Western political thought the notion of cosmopolitanism begins with the conception of the *polis* as a small civic unit where community arises from the face-to-face relations of family and friends, yet which remains in need of civil associations beyond the local.¹¹ The development of a specific philosophy of the cosmopolis as a single community, however, dates from the writings of the stoics. The Republic of Zeno, to follow Plutarch's commentary on it, "may be summed up in this one main principle: that all the inhabitants of this world of ours should not live differentiated by their respective rules of justice in separate cities and communities, but that we should consider all men to be of one community and one polity, and that we should have a common life and an order common to us all."¹² According to the Stoics, the demands of civic duty compel man to act in the realm of the world at large. The unity of all men as rational beings within the universe, and as common citizens of the mortal realm, demands that the universe function as

if it were a “single polity.”¹³ Thus the distinction between community and cosmopolis is presumed to have fallen away as the cosmopolis is seen to subsume and supplant the community.

This conflation of terms also lurks behind Seneca’s phrase “the whole world is my country.”¹⁴ And with the influence of Seneca on early modern and modern Europe we see this emphasis on the cosmos as community enter eighteenth- and nineteenth-century notions of cosmopolitanism. Yet here we can easily see the tension between the local and the universal reemerge. In the thought of the French *philosophes*, the *esprit cosmopolite* becomes a universal humanism, where the rights of man extend beyond national borders and where the European community exerts claims that go beyond the duties of the citizen. But the concern for republicanism also focuses on more local issues; Montesquieu’s *esprit général* develops out of the national past and local customs and manners.¹⁵ For Kant, cosmopolitanism appears as a specific antidote to the rule of despots, and the “barbaric freedom of established states.”¹⁶ His later essay, “Perpetual Peace” elaborates this notion as the grounds for establishing international law and government that will make standing armies unnecessary.¹⁷ Still, Kant does not relinquish the idea of the local state; his cosmopolitan model is a federation rather than any universal entity. His cosmopolitan solution to warfare rests on the paired assumptions that citizens owe primary loyalties to local states but that their more universal interests arise from the demands of worldwide commerce.

The connection between cosmopolitanism and commerce was not lost on Marx and others in the nineteenth century who identified cosmopolitanism with the bourgeois managerial class and its movement of capital from state to state, even as working conditions remained determined by local conditions of production. For Marx, the cosmopolitan “ideal” often looked more like the cosmopolitan menace, one linked to the rise of an international bourgeoisie and the concomitant exploitation of national work forces. “The bourgeoisie has through its exploitation of the world market given a cosmopolitan character to production and consumption in every country.”¹⁸ On the other hand, Marx will argue famously that the proletariat is

fundamentally cosmopolitan (“working men have no country”¹⁹) and that its power will derive partly from embracing internationalism. The paradox is deep and irresolvable, in Marx’s writing and beyond.²⁰

This tension between internationalism and the differentials of power associated with global commerce also undergirds contemporary theoretical debates on cosmopolitanism. Martha Nussbaum’s ideal concentric cosmopolitanism posits “allegiance to the worldwide community of human beings,”²¹ and seems to assume, like Kant, that uneven dynamics of power or capital will sort themselves out on the international stage, a position that critics from a range of perspectives have debated.²² K. Anthony Appiah espouses a pragmatic cosmopolitanism, based on the assumption of shared universal values and liberal conversation. “Cosmopolitanism shouldn’t be seen as some exalted attainment: it begins in the simple idea that in the human community, as in national communities, we need to develop habits of coexistence: conversation in its older meaning of living together.”²³ In this liberal model, commerce and global capital create the conditions for (or impediments to) the development of global consensus around human rights but do not either allow or limit the possibility of cosmopolitanism.²⁴ For critics of globalization, on the other hand, this pragmatic cosmopolitanism seems to ignore the inherent connection between commerce, imperialism, and modern cosmopolitanism that Marx made clear.²⁵ Paul Gilroy, for example, contrasts the deployment of the term “cosmopolitanism” in a way that serves to justify Western political and commercial expansionism with his notion of a cosmopolitanism “from below,” which begins from “a degree of estrangement from one’s own culture and history” and the economic and social power associated with it.²⁶

Ironically, despite his elite background, Henry James’s encounter with cosmopolitanism at the end of the nineteenth century revolves around the role of state authority and the problems of the marketplace. James was concerned with the expansiveness of American commercialism, the jingoism of its political posturing, and the threat of warfare, and sought to mitigate its effects by espousing a cosmopolitanism opposed to imperial and commercial swagger, which was

often deeply connected to ideals of femininity and harmony. In the 1877 piece "Occasional Paris" he argues as though he were a cosmopolite more by default than by preference. "Being a cosmopolite is an accident, but one must make the best of it."²⁷ James seems to share Mme. Merle's perspective in *The Portrait of a Lady* when she decries herself and other expatriates as "mere parasites, crawling over the surface; we haven't our feet in the soil."²⁸

Yet James has other motives for embracing cosmopolitanism, making it a more purposeful, positive sentiment, opposed to excessive state power, jingoism, and war. James decries the preparations for the World Exhibition of 1878, suggesting that a celebration of national achievements during the Russo-Turkish war, when "the world is too occupied with graver cares, with reciprocal cannonading and chopping, with cutting of throats and burning of homes," is wrong.²⁹ He also questions the policing of national identity by the state and deplores the treatment of travelers across borders. When entering France he is "marshaled" by a French functionary with "a very nasty weapon . . . out of the train, and under a sort of military surveillance, into an enclosure containing a number of human sheep-pens" and is "imprisoned" for half an hour.³⁰ Whether or not James at this point feels himself to be a cosmopolite with loyalties divided among France (where he lived in 1875–76), London (where he has just been living), and America (where he is a citizen), matters not at all to the state, its apparatus, and those who police its rules and borders. In these interconnected episodes, the essay makes clear that cosmopolitanism may seem to be an accidental attitude, but embracing it through travel or through refusal of jingoism or warmongering, brings to the fore the fierce, often military regulation of local identities and allegiances.

The tension between the local and the global in connection to politics and commerce also lurks beneath James's later reengagement with cosmopolitanism. The word crops up more often in his writing of the nineties than at any other time in his career linked to the possibility of a kind of harmony that can bridge gaps in background and understanding. James shapes cosmopolitanism into a domestic motive at least equal to "concentrated patriotism" and juxtaposes it

to national codes of behavior, the market-driven forces of immoderate or trumped-up speech, and ultimately, the bellicose posturing of the United States. At the same time, the cosmopolitan is often a pawn in the commercial game of the international press, or a naïf who does not recognize the determining power of local authorities. Story after story from the period between 1892 and 1898 focuses on artistic production and its conflict with the marketplace, or on the reemergence of national differences and patriotism even among those with cosmopolitan sympathies.

The 1892 story “Collaboration,” for example, presents an ideal version of cosmopolitanism, where dramatic differences are adjudicated by the power of harmony and justice, which looks distinctly Kantian at the outset. The story is set within an American artist’s studio in Paris where French, English, and German artists, writers, and musicians meet, and ultimately, collaborate.

There are discussions of course and differences . . . but . . . beauty flourishes and . . . harmonies prevail in the end . . . the place is really a chamber of justice, a temple of reconciliation: we understand each other if we only sit up late enough . . . My studio in short is the theatre of a cosmopolite drama.³¹

Still, despite the ideal of the studio as a “temple of reconciliation,” much of the story is occupied with describing the national identities of the various characters and the fact that the two women in the story are the widow and daughter of a man killed in the 1870 war between Germany and France. The lingering effects of the war appear throughout to reinforce the real-world significance of national difference, and, as in “Occasional Paris,” to demonstrate the physical threat of the failure of cosmopolitanism. On the other hand, the marketplace in this story is shown to be tied to national sympathies and interests, and cosmopolitan collaboration comes at the price of financial success. A German composer who collaborates with a French poet recognizes that he will no longer be able to sell his music at home. The story represents this collaboration as a testament to the power of art to generate both literal and figurative harmony as a means to cosmopolitanism. Yet it also reminds us at every turn that

“we are all readers and consumers,” that the marketplace for art categorizes and polices national identities and borders, and that the composer and the poet risk abject poverty through their collaboration.³²

By contrast, in “Greville Fane” a very successful woman writer of melodramas is described negatively as “cosmopolitan” because her characters “make love to each other from Doncaster to Bucharest” and her style is commercial.³³ Yet the story ultimately undermines this equation of cosmopolitanism with vulgarity of style and behavior. Greville Fane is revealed to be as direct as her novels are far-fetched, and honest about her profit motive. James uses this woman writer to help redefine cosmopolitanism, wresting it back from its connections with dishonesty, greed, and the international marketplace but also pushing it beyond Kantian idealism. Cosmopolitanism in these stories reveals itself to be neither a fantasy nor an ideal, but an everyday, pragmatic response to real-world tensions in international relations and the parochialisms of the literary marketplace.

But just as at the end of the seventies in Paris, the pressures of war at the end of the nineties in the United States make the uneasy alliances necessary to this form of pragmatic cosmopolitanism difficult. Cosmopolitan characters proliferate in *The Wings of the Dove*, *The Ambassadors*, and *The Golden Bowl*, but the effort at reconciling local and global loyalties becomes more fraught and the struggle over American national and commercial interests more clear. As John Carlos Rowe puts it, characters such as Maria Gostrey, Lambert Strether, Maggie Verver, and Milly Theale “fail to reconnect their American identities with their international destinies” and often appear diminished by the struggle.³⁴ For Strether in *The Ambassadors*, cosmopolitanism can neither be reconciled with the demands of Woollett nor acceded to as a permanent condition. In *The Golden Bowl*, Maggie Verver may play the role of the cosmopolitan woman applauded by the magazines for using her fortune to marry a prince, but she must ultimately maneuver between the expectations of American City and the exigencies of Prince Amerigo, a process that brands her as inescapably American. For all of these women in James’s late novels, the price of playing on the cosmopolitan field is

high, as is the danger of becoming reduced to a commodity in trade on the global market.

While less directly tied to the marketplace itself, Virginia Woolf's cosmopolitanism becomes a necessary response to her own complex sense of exclusion from British national, cultural, and economic life and her concern about women's imprisonment in the private house. Famously proclaiming her outsider status in the 1938 *Three Guineas*, Woolf makes clear her refusal to participate directly in the socio-political arena that not only denied women the same permanent citizenship rights as men but also shut them up in the domestic sphere even while purporting to represent them on the battlefield. Her famous cosmopolitan statement, then, proclaims a feminist alternative to the same jingoism and state-oriented capitalism that dogged Henry James. Rather than turn to an aesthetic attitude of harmony, however, Woolf argues by way of indirection, ellipses, and involution toward a cosmopolitan outsider politics, which creates a new community of those who refuse the authoritarian state and its demand for unreal (and unequally repaid) loyalties.

Three Guineas is explicit in its feminist, antiwar politics and makes clear allusion in its text, images, and copious footnotes to the public record about war and patriarchy in newspapers, propaganda images, and political statements.³⁵ The essay's mock epistolary form and disrupted structure of address become crucial to Woolf's efforts to interrupt the continuity of political violence and to demonstrate the need for a new feminist cosmopolitan attitude. *Three Guineas* begins *in media res* and never explains the details of the letters that form its mock-epistolary structure or who sent them. The narrator describes her first letter writer even as she addresses him: "You, then, who ask the question . . . have reached the middle years of life not without effort, at the Bar; but on the whole your journey has been prosperous . . . And without wishing to flatter you, your prosperity – wife, children, house – has been deserved . . . you began your education at one of the great public schools and finished it at the university" (*TG* 3–4). Thus the relationship between the Woolfian narrator, who will "give an account of herself"³⁶ and her reasons for declining to participate in the ventures described in each letter begins

cordially enough. But then it shifts – Woolf writes “But” and then stops and inserts three ellipses that, she says, mark a “precipice.” “A gulf so deeply cut,” based in gender and its privileges, yawns between them (*TG* 4). If Woolf is to give an account of herself (and in this text, the accounting is both narrative and monetary) it will begin with the difficulty of that gulf, those ellipses, which make simple common cause impossible, despite the experiences, background, and – one presumes – nationality, shared with the letter writer.

Woolf’s essay clearly ties this gulf in experience to the financial underpinnings of British patriarchy, famously describing “Arthur’s Education Fund” – the cache of money – “a voracious receptacle” (*TG* 7) sequestered by families of means to educate their sons, and into which daughters and sisters contributed, if unwittingly, through their unpaid labor. She defines men and women as separate classes and points out that “your class possesses in its own right and not through marriage practically all of the capital, all the land, all the valuables, and all the patronage in England” (*TG* 22). In this way, the commonalities between Woolf and the letter writer, between the male and female members of British society are seen as irrevocably undermined by the financial gap between them and their different levels of access to the British economic and political system. But she also ties this gap in experience and class to her refusal to participate in direct efforts to help the Spanish Republicans, even though she supports their anti-fascist cause. If the anonymous letter writer hopes that the documentary images of the siege of Madrid will spur Woolf to join his efforts, Woolf sees these propaganda images, which presume similarity of perspective and demand uniformity of response on the part of the viewer, as more reasons why it is impossible to join his cause. She interrupts the argument again, saying, “let us give up for a moment, the effort to answer your question [How in your opinion are we to prevent war?]” (*TG* 10), because the only answer she can muster is that “patriotism” leads men to go to war (*TG* 11–12). She thereby rejects propaganda’s forced fusion of sensibility in the service of patriotism (whether of right or left) and refuses to accede to unequal categories of (national) identity created by and perpetuated in war and patriarchy.

A quick look at *Orlando* shows the play of a similar dynamic across the temporal and geographical terrain of that novel. When Orlando falls into his transformative trance at the midpoint of Woolf's marvelous romp of a novel, he is an agent of the British Empire in Constantinople, at the moment of receiving his newly conferred dukedom.³⁷ Yet, awakening as female, Orlando also awakens to life with the Gypsies, abandoning, for a time, not only the ambassadorial dwelling and its trappings of imperial power, but also his/her national identity.³⁸ Her transgender identity seems to require a transnational, cosmopolitan attitude while the space of the Gypsies becomes one that not only creates the possibility of new forms of gender expression but that also challenges the primacy of British patriotism. And remember the difficulty Orlando's sex change ultimately poses to her British civil identity and her ability to inherit her ancestral estate. Returned to England more female than male but often prone to shifts in gender expression, Orlando's identity is nonetheless recognized by her friends, her servants, and her dogs. But until a court fixes her gender status, the state hardly knows what to do with her/him. While it is clear that her/his shifting gender poses a problem to social codes, domestic mores, and property law in the nineteenth century, the primary matter is a broader one of civic identity and standing as a full citizen of Britain. The nation must domesticate Orlando by naming her as female, and assigning her the diminished rights and opportunities of women in late-Victorian England. "The lawsuits are settled . . . My sex . . . is pronounced indisputably, and beyond the shadow of a doubt . . . Female. The estates which are now desequestrated in perpetuity descend and are tailed and entailed upon the heirs male of my body."³⁹ Thus Orlando's ultimate loss, as a woman, of the right to inherit her ancestral estate outright demonstrates not only women's political and economic poverty within the Victorian gender system, but also the degree to which the state depends on this system as a basis for assigning citizenship roles, policing its borders, and determining who has legal standing to inherit, hold property, or sue for redress. In other words, the disequilibrium of the Victorian gender system undergirds the very possibility of British justice and

its exclusionary practices. Thus, in the same manner as in *Three Guineas*, and with equally experimental narrative form, Woolf makes the case for the exclusion of women from full British citizenship and makes the case (here more implicitly) for their necessary cosmopolitanism.

For Mulk Raj Anand, a writer from colonial India who visited Woolf in Bloomsbury and spent much of his career shuttling back and forth between India and Europe, the matter of citizenship is even more fraught, bound as it is to questions of imperial economy and power. Known for his commitment to representing the lives of ordinary Indians, championing Indian folktales and other art forms, and fighting for the cause of Indian independence, Anand became one of the so-called big three novelists of the late-colonial period in India, and a key figure in the development of India's English language literary tradition, as well as a vocal advocate for Indian autonomy. But throughout his long life, he was also intensely committed to what he would describe as a rooted cosmopolitanism, one that recognized commonalities with writers such as James Joyce and welcomed philosophical influences both Western and Eastern even while focusing on the materiality of everyday life under colonialism in India.

Anand describes himself awakening as a novelist while reading Joyce as a student in London, when he vowed secretly to pattern himself after the Irish writer.⁴⁰ But the resulting novel, *Untouchable*, a tour de force, also represents a different, more materialist modernism. The novel presents a day in the life of an impoverished Indian sweeper boy, Bakha, whose naïve perspective yet emotional perspicacity illuminate both the abuse he suffers and the complexity of any solution to it. The novel is stunning in its depiction of Bakha's corporeal existence, showing him being abused by upper-class and British characters, suffering the bodily indignity of being forced by caste to clean latrines for others, and being vehemently rejected because of his "polluted" status even when trying to rescue an injured boy. The novel makes the paradox of the sweeper boy's existence clear: inseparable from the physical space of his village and sent out to work in its crowded streets, he is both untouchable and

destined to be touched. Yet, as many have remarked, Bakha's self-awareness forms the core of the novel, allowing us to look at the material circumstance of his restricted life as focalized through his perceptive though limited eyes, and from time to time presented through interior monologue.⁴¹ As Anand said of the book, I had wanted to show Bakha's "unique sensitiveness as against the people of the upper caste who thought that merely touching him is a degradation."⁴²

In Anand's second novel, *Coolie*, economic status rather than caste becomes the defining characteristic of the hero and a primary driver of the novel's plot. *Coolie* follows the short lifetime of a poor Indian laborer, Munoo, forced out of his home in a hill village and sent to find his way through a number of menial jobs in an extraordinary series of locations throughout India. While working as a servant for a bank official, in a pickle factory, in a cotton mill, or as a rickshaw boy, before his death at fifteen from consumption, Munoo encounters the entire social fabric of India. He is befriended in unexpected places: among other servants, coolies, and cotton mill workers, but also in the house of the pickle factory owner and in the home of an emancipated Anglo-Indian woman.⁴³ Yet the brilliance of the novel is not in the specific details of the various trials that Munoo is made to face: rather as in *Untouchable*, it lies in the novel's combined focus on Munoo's internal life and his struggle to respond to the material conditions of the impoverished and disenfranchised in late-colonial India. The narrative, focalized through Munoo's perspective, is permeated by his self-reflections, which often begin from the material circumstances that surround him. For example, when he arrives at his factory job in Daulatpur, Munoo's senses drive the way he understands his new city, full of colors, smells, and incomprehensible "tinkling bells and chanting hymns and loud hysterical shouts." Munoo "felt he was in a strange world" but "I shall be comfortable there . . . and the factory is dirty enough not to be spoilt by sitting around."⁴⁴ But life in the primitive factory, where smoke belches constantly and the heat is often unbearable, causes him to hallucinate, and the narrative makes clear the physical manifestations of the "dark, evil life" in the "dark underworld" that Munoo has come to

inhabit. Though this chapter in his peripatetic working life is among the most settled in the novel and produces moments of nuanced self-reflection, Anand's defamiliarizing, modernist narrative keeps Munoo's sensory experience of these "evil" conditions at the center of our attention and makes clear that the dirty, inhospitable factory floor will never be the simple, comfortable home Munoo desires.

While these novels take place entirely in India, both also gesture, although in different ways from James and Woolf, toward a cosmopolitanism that responds to the (global) marketplace and the complex politics of domestic life. Without stepping out of the restricted narrative foci of these two novels, Anand makes clear that Munoo and Bakha suffer social and material impoverishment as a function of the Indian colonial condition and posits their life stories as matters of human cultural, economic, and political freedom. In this sense, the novels work to espouse a rooted cosmopolitan approach to Indian political and domestic life and show the extent to which a rooted cosmopolitanism can be engaged with material conditions and local politics. Anand understood this cosmopolitanism as a way to link East and West, India with Europe. As he wrote in a late essay, the writers of the twenties and thirties were creating

a kind of bridge trying to span, symbolically, the two worlds of the Ganga and the Thames through the novel . . . Their roots lay in the local landscapes of North and South India. But they seem, along with quite a few others to have done something which is not generally admitted, to have brought some roots from abroad.⁴⁵

Despite his clear understanding of the many gulfs separating himself from his British colleagues in London, whose standoffishness he often resented, Anand conceived of his writing as a way to be both locally "rooted" and to bring some "roots from abroad."⁴⁶

But the colonial (and postcolonial) setting of Anand's life and work also demands a different way of describing the relationship between location and world in the construction of cosmopolitan identity, one that finally rejects the binary distinction between home and away and which foregrounds the importance of the colonial experience to (modernist) ideas about location and

dislocation. Homi Bhabha makes a claim for the transnational as a crucial aspect of the culture of survival among colonized or formerly colonized peoples, arguing that “specific histories of cultural displacement” are at the root of postcolonial discourses.⁴⁷ This theory provides a way to see experiences such as Anand’s travel to London and his cosmopolitanism as *formative* rather than disruptive of his commitment to his Indian identity, even during his subsequent years away lecturing in London or speaking on the BBC Eastern Service in the 1940s. Gayatri Spivak’s notion of “critical regionalism” might provide another framework for understanding Anand’s connection to India as emerging out of a transnational structure of belonging that is neither nationalist nor global, and which derives its categories from local identities and allegiances rather than from reified, external definitions of regions.⁴⁸

In other words, Anand’s work illuminates a dynamic that was only nascent in the writings of James and Woolf – transnational interconnections and solidarities produce new modernist versions of cosmopolitanism and are produced by them, and thereby not only challenge the nation as the primary category of affiliation but also contest the notion of an ideal global sphere lurking somewhere beyond the local. We know, for example, that Anand’s experience of the 1928 General Strike in London helped him recognize the transnational dimensions of class oppression and propelled him back toward India – in that sense the Thames/Ganges connection, however fraught, was crucial to his political identity.⁴⁹ Woolf’s creation of the Outsider’s Society emerges out of an intense (and intensely personal) concern with the Spanish Civil War – her recognition of the limitations of British national feeling is made sharper by her understanding that fascism works both at home and abroad. In this way Woolf’s cosmopolitanism also connects her to others, like Anand, who are excluded by the authoritarian British state. Even for James, as we have seen, the bellicose posturing of governments and the policing of their borders help confirm his transition from baleful to committed cosmopolite, even as his continuing awareness of the power of the international marketplace puts pressure on his notion of ideal harmony. James’s

cosmopolitanism – like that of many other modernists – becomes a complex and creative attitude, reaching out beyond the dichotomy of home and world, nation and globe, to new models of transnational belonging at once rooted and dislocated.

Notes

1. “Non sum uni angulo natus, patria mea totus hic mundus est,” *Epistles* 28, Seneca, “On Travel as a Cure for Discontent,” in *Moral Epistles*, vol. 1, trans. Richard M. Gummere (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, Loeb Classical Library, 1917).
2. Virginia Woolf, *Three Guineas*, annotated by Jane Marcus (1938; repr. New York: Harcourt, 2006), 129. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*TG*).
3. Jean Rhys, *Letters, 1931–66*, eds. Francis Wyndham and Diana Melly (New York: Penguin, 1985), 171, 24.
4. Mulk Raj Anand, “The World I Hope for No. 4,” BBC Eastern Service. Broadcast October 28, 1943, 1515–1530 GMT. Typescript, BBC Written Archives Centre.
5. *Ibid.*
6. See Jessica Berman, *Modernist Fiction, Cosmopolitanism and the Politics of Community* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), especially chapter one, “Cosmopolitan Communities.”
7. On concentric cosmopolitanism, see Martha Nussbaum, “Patriotism and Cosmopolitanism,” in Nussbaum et al., *For Love of Country: Debating the Limits of Patriotism*, ed. Joshua Cohen (Boston: Beacon Press, 1996).
8. Tim Brennan describes cosmopolitanism as a “fundamentally ambivalent phenomenon.” It begins from local concerns while overtly denying that fact (“Cosmo-Theory,” *South Atlantic Quarterly* 100 [Summer 2001]: 659–60).
9. The term “transnational,” as I deploy it, shares the oppositional valence of the prefix in such words as “transgress” and “transform,” just as we might say the “post” of postcolonial implies a critical position rather than a temporal-historical location. The “trans” dimension of the practice of transnational literary study can serve to denaturalize the connection between modernist fiction and its euro-metropolitan contexts, as, more generally, between the nation-state and its literary traditions.
10. See Jacques Derrida, *On Cosmopolitanism and Forgiveness*, trans. Mark Dooley and Michael Hughes (New York: Routledge, 2001); Pheng Cheah and Bruce Robbins eds., *Cosmo-Politics: Thinking and Feeling Beyond the Nation* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press,

- 1998); Nussbaum et al., *For Love of Country*; Tim Brennan, "Cosmo-Theory"; K. Anthony Appiah, *Cosmopolitanism: Ethics in a World of Strangers* (New York: Norton, 2006); and Paul Gilroy, "Cosmopolitanism Contested," in *Postcolonial Melancholia* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2005).
11. On this conception of *polis*, see Aristotle, *The Ethics of Aristotle: The Nicomachean Ethics*, trans. J. A. K. Thomson, rev. Hugh Tredennick (New York: Penguin, 1976), Book IX, x (307–8).
 12. Plutarch, "On the Fortune or Virtue of Alexander," in *Moralia*, vol. IV, qtd. in Derek Heater, *World Citizenship and Government: Cosmopolitan Ideas in the History of Western Political Thought* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1996), 13.
 13. Marcus Aurelius Anoninus, *The Communings with Himself*, qtd. in Heater 19.
 14. Seneca, "On the Happy Life," in *Moral Essays*, vol. II, qtd. in Heater, 18.
 15. On Montesquieu and Diderot, see Julia Kristeva, *Nations Without Nationalism* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1993), 27–8, 54–5; and Cheah, "Introduction Part II," in *Cosmo-Politics: Thinking and Feeling Beyond the Nation*, eds. Pheng Cheah and Bruce Robbins (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1998), 22.
 16. Immanuel Kant, "The Idea for a Universal History from a Cosmopolitan Point of View," in Kant's *On History*, ed. Lewis White Beck (Indianapolis, IN: Bobbs-Merrill, The Library of the Liberal Arts, 1963), 20.
 17. "Since the narrower or wider community of the peoples of the earth had developed so far that a violation of rights in one place is felt throughout the world, the idea of a law of world-citizenship is no high-flown or exaggerated notion" (Kant "Perpetual Peace," in Kant's *On History*, 105).
 18. Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, *The Communist Manifesto*, ed. Gareth Stedman Jones (New York: Penguin, 1998), 223.
 19. *Ibid.*, 241
 20. This ambivalence is echoed, for example, in Antonio Gramsci's writings. See Tim Brennan, "Cosmo-Theory," 667–8.
 21. Martha Nussbaum, "Patriotism and Cosmopolitanism" in Nussbaum et al., *For Love of Country*, 4.
 22. See the debates in Nussbaum, "Patriotism and Cosmopolitanism."
 23. Appiah, *Cosmopolitanism*, xviii–xix.
 24. Appiah is interested in the "conceptual questions that lie beneath the facts of globalization" (*Ibid.*, xx).
 25. See Brennan, "Cosmo-Theory."
 26. Gilroy, "Cosmopolitanism Contested," 59, 67.

27. Henry James, "Occasional Paris," in *Collected Travel Writings: The Continent* (New York: The Library of America, 1993), 721. Susan Griffin opens her introduction to the "Global James" issue of the *Henry James Review* with an extended excerpt from this essay (see Griffin, "Global James: Introduction," *Henry James Review* 24 [Fall 2003]: 201).
28. Henry James, *The Portrait of a Lady* (1908; repr. New York: The Modern Library, 2002), 186.
29. James, "Occasional Paris," 724.
30. *Ibid.*, 727.
31. Henry James, "Collaboration," in *The Complete Stories 1892–1898* (New York: The Library of America, 1996), 234–5.
32. *Ibid.*, 242.
33. Henry James, "Greville Fane" in *The Complete Stories 1892–1898* (New York: The Library of America, 1996), 220.
34. John Carlos Rowe, *The Theoretical Dimensions of Henry James* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1984), 296.
35. The vehemence of Woolf's rhetoric and her angry refusal to donate the three guineas requested of her have been the subject of much critical commentary from Jane Marcus's "No More Horses: Virginia Woolf on Art and Propaganda," *Women's Studies* 4 (1977): 265–89, to Brenda Silver's "The Authority of Anger: *Three Guineas* as Case Study," *Signs* 16 (Winter 1991): 340–70.
36. Adriana Cavarero, in *Relating Narratives: Storytelling and Selfhood*, trans. Paul A. Kottman (New York: Routledge, 2000), describes "giving an account of oneself" as key to the ethics of narrative, which always asks (and answers) the question "Who are you?"
37. The ceremony is a pageant of Empire, which gathers "people of all nationalities" to celebrate Orlando's status, while the text makes frequent reference to the testimonials of "English ladies and gentlemen" at the show of British superiority in this event (Woolf, *Orlando*, annotated by Maria Di Battista [1928; repr. New York: Harcourt, 2006], 193, 94).
38. And of course, in Woolf's era as in our own, the Gypsies stand for the very principle of resistance to the nation-state.
39. Woolf, *Orlando*, 193.
40. Mulk Raj Anand, *Conversations in Bloomsbury* (1981; repr. Oxford: Oxford University Press, Oxford India paperbacks, 1995), 7. For a more complete discussion of the connections between Joyce and Anand, see my "Comparative Colonialisms: Joyce, Anand and the Question of Engagement," *Modernism/Modernity* 13 (September 2006): 465–85.
41. See Paul Saint-Amour, "From *Ulysses* to *Untouchable*: Mulk Raj Anand's Joycean Transmigrations" (unpublished paper, International James

- Joyce Symposium, Dublin, Ireland, June 2004) on the connections between *Ulysses* and Anand's *Untouchable* and on the importance of reading style in Anand's novel.
42. Quoted in Marlene Fisher, *The Wisdom of the Heart: A Study of the Works of Mulk Raj Anand* (New Delhi: Sterling, 1985), 30.
 43. See Jane Marcus's reading of this relationship in *Hearts of Darkness: White Women Write Race* (New Brunswick: Rutgers University Press, 2004), especially chapter six.
 44. Mulk Raj Anand, *Coolie* (New York: Liberty Press, 1952), 85.
 45. Mulk Raj Anand, *Roots and Flowers* (Dharwar: Karnatak University Press, 1972), 15.
 46. Anand's version of cosmopolitan humanism owes much to his reading of the Greeks and of eighteenth-century continental philosophy while in London as a student. Yet, he also carefully delineates his close connections to Indian history and philosophy. Anand describes the sources for his "universal humanism" in the many religions of India and their intermixing, even within his family, in India's history of conquest, survival, and change over the millennia, as well as in specific philosophies of contemporary life. He wrote, "I have derived much inspiration from the life and teachings of Gautama Buddha and the medieval saints, Nanak and Kabir, as well as the latter-day thinkers of India, Gandhi, Tagore, Nehru, M.N. Roy, and Ananda Coomaraswamy, as well as some of the Western writers, Russell, Santayana, and Sartre" (Anand, "I Believe . . .," *Illustrated Weekly of India* [October 26, 1969], 28).
 47. Homi Bhabha, "The Postcolonial and the Postmodern," in *The Location of Culture* (New York: Routledge, 1994), 172.
 48. As Spivak puts it, critical regionalism "goes under and over nationalisms" and leads to "the production of collectivities" that could be forces for "sustained resistance" out of international and intranational coalitions (Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak and Judith Butler, *Who Sings the Nation State?: Language, Politics, Belonging* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2007], 247).
 49. Fisher, *The Wisdom of the Heart*, 17.

*Modernism and the Big House**Nicholas Allen*

As a matter of local concern, the Big House is the most persistent of Ireland's literary subjects. Its contours and symbolism have been picked over by critics who have come to see the architecture of these buildings and their possessions as major parts of the colonial experience.¹ The intellectual issue at stake was that of identity. The formation of revised categories of Irishness was tested in the struggles between landlord and tenant; the fates of families and houses were figured as coefficients in the logic of national self-determination.² This last liberty was provided for by a postcolonialism that patrolled the distance between Anglo and Irish with a certainty that the texts under discussion rarely provided. This is not to question the applicability of postcolonial perspectives to the condition of Ireland. Rather, the kinds of imperial attachments that the Big Houses tended to make were not always visible through the frames provided by an Irish Studies obsessed with identity at the expense of materiality.

This is where recent modernist studies become important. An attention to objects, their provenance and suggestion, has opened new avenues into the early-twentieth-century text. This is notably true of James Joyce and Samuel Beckett, more of which later. The circulation of things follows paths of exchange and consumption that render outmoded ideas of center and periphery as they are applied in postcolonial studies. A new vocabulary to describe this alternative economy might derive from other historical traditions in the Atlantic world, of which Ireland was long a part.³ Its terms could extend beyond the northern hemisphere and be legible in those things from elsewhere, which register in texts. The revolution that was

modernism depended in part on its attention to the minute detail of life. Joyce's Dublin was a catalogue of objects, each of which was sensational. The rich texture of the city in literature became the overlap of things that signify in multiple relations to each other. Their strands of crossing are complex geographically, historically, politically, and culturally. Joyce met the challenge of rendering this world in literature but his was not a specifically Irish achievement. It took his experience of two empires, the British and the Austro-Hungarian, to write the memory of one. For Joyce inhabited a moment of global change. It has been argued that the period from 1850 to 1914 was a first phase of globalization, in which the dominant ambition of the British Empire was to establish hegemony of trade.⁴ The theories of exchange that built this world-system could be catastrophic for parts of it (as Ireland and India found out with famine).

Port cities were the hub of this sea-borne empire, its confederates and competitors, as Joyce observed in Dublin and Trieste. This was not a world in which nations, however imagined, were discrete from each other. Ireland was part of a trans-imperial network that was global, mobile, and subject to constant competition. It was a possession of the British Empire and so its own possessions were conditioned by larger flows of politics and economy. The outbreak of First World War fractured this system in England; it broke in Ireland with the Easter Rising of 1916. The aftermath of this rupture, and the inauguration of a new world-system, was coincident entirely with the greatest period of literature in which Ireland was a subject. Joyce, Beckett, and William Butler Yeats moved in the late imperial archipelago, which extended through Dublin, London, and Paris. Their crossings touched many places aside from the understanding of core and periphery. For Yeats, Gonne, Beckett, and Joyce read Stone Cottage, Brittany, Roussillon, and Zurich – all of which are outside the circuit of colonial capitals. The grand architecture of imperial power held its symbolic seat in its designated cities; the global reality of daily life did not depend on these configurations.

It is at this site of crossings that the contexts of modernism and the Big House meet. The landlord was apex of a local economy, the

conditions of which were provisional and binding. Each house had its own traditions of servitude and governance, and its own hinterland of troubles, all of which became foreground in the Irish revolution. The single object of melancholy in the novels that documented this period is the house and its contents, to the point that the house itself becomes a character. If this is so, and if things can be read aside from the now well-worn narrative of the Big House as home to a failed identity, then the condition of the house and its possessions becomes a meter of Ireland's imperial history of migration. Reading the Big House in context of a global modernism invites questions of acquisition and dispersal, not of inevitable, or moral, failure. In doing so, the integrated account of these exceptional places invites the adjustment of a national narrative that has presented them only as anomaly. The Big House is in no way representative of any national identity, but its interiors frame one history of Ireland's global past.

This chapter will make some of these processes legible in the modernist novel as a means to shift the critical coordinates of discussion about literature and history in the period of late empires. I will concentrate on two examples: Elizabeth Bowen's *The Last September* and Samuel Beckett's *Watt*, with reference also to Joyce, Yeats, and others. In all of these, the fall of the Big House is part of a wider process of global realignment, of which Ireland is part, first in the British world-system and then out of it. This transition may wear the dual face of identity and difference, but its reality resides in the dispersal of objects, to the point in *Watt* where these things themselves have a strange and unknown life. At this extremity, the Big House is exchanged for the asylum, a good enough metaphor for the institutional life of these constructions in empire and state.

The most enduring of all the Big House novels is Elizabeth Bowen's *The Last September*. Bowen was the daughter of Bowen's Court in County Cork. Her family home survived the Irish troubles, unlike Danielstown, the home of the Naylor and fictional subject of *The Last September*. The novel is set in 1920 and describes the impact of the military occupation on the local population, of which Danielstown is both a part and apart. The novel is a Bildungsroman that brings Lois, niece of the Naylor, to a consciousness of fatality in

her doomed love affair with Gerald Lesworth, a young officer serving in the British army.⁵ By the end of the novel both Lesworth and Danielstown are dead. Bowen's novel is written at the edge of things. There is melancholy in the characters' consciousness of their late place in the history of the house. But there is also a consistent counter-narrative that undercuts any nostalgia for a settled time before the Troubles, a tension that is common in the late modernist novel. Lois's innocence allows her to make connections that a character dulled to the world could not. Her empathy with the republicans who threaten her home evolves from her feeling that the house itself was founded in an original act of injustice. This intuition does not solidify into statement. It stays as a feeling of disturbance that registers in Lois's artistic nature. Lois is aesthetic; Lady Naylor tries to repel Gerald from Lois's affections by saying she must study at the Slade. Visual art and the army do not mix.

The Last September is set at the end of one history. The future has no shape and is invisible beyond the fragments of light that shoot through the novel. Lois is the medium for these illuminations, which can be read in the novel as Bowen's serial attempts to draw the landscape around Danielstown in a painterly style. There are many examples of this. Perhaps the best is the short section that follows Lois's return to the Big House after she has driven past the Connors' farmhouse with Hugo. Peter, the young man of the house, is on the run. There is no animosity between the characters, although the old farmer stays at the gate to watch them leave. Lois and Hugo felt their talk "had been less than a shadow."⁶ She wondered that "they were not smothered" by the landscape (*LS* 66).

From the slope's foot, where Danielstown trees began, the land stretched out in a plain flat as water, basin of the Maddar and Darra and their fine wandering tributaries, till the far hills, faint and brittle, straining against the inrush of vaster distance, cut the droop of the sky like a glass blade. Fields gave back light to the sky . . . as though the sheen of grass were but a shadow on water, a breath of colour clouding the face of light. Rivers, profound in brightness, flowed over beds of glass. (*LS* 66–7)

Bowen is given to repeating words in *The Last September*. Shadow, glass, and pink are part of her palette. Repetition builds melancholy into the text as fate takes hold by association. The effect is tragic and uncertain. Inside the house this confused world takes shape in a jumble of conversation. At lunch Sir Richard talks to Gerald about the South African war and the Cork militia, Laurence talks to Marda about whaling, and "Lois tried to explain to Hugo about Augustus John" (*LS* 91). John was by 1920 one of the most famous post-impressionist painters in Britain. His portraits included those of T. E. Lawrence, Thomas Hardy, and William Butler Yeats.⁷ It is not clear from the conversation what Lois had to explain about John's art. But the practice of portraiture makes a still life of the lunch scene. That Lois should represent a force of art in life is obvious enough. That such art should take impressionistic form shows her contemporaneity. Her picture is not the portrait of her ancestors that look down from the walls. It is a more human form, alive and uncertain.

A changing perspective renders many of Bowen's subjects uncertain. Danielstown is described as unmoored, ready at times to float off into the sky. Characters are drawn in colors that the novelist dips into over and again. The present is a bleached out moment in which the traces of the past are still visible, a condition also visible in the work of Woolf and Walter Benjamin. This is evident from the first pages of the novel, when we are introduced first to the house. Its drive and steps open into a series of rooms that are populated with things from elsewhere. The Kerry cows of the outer fields are seen through high windows with sun-blistered frames,

as though the house had spent a day in the tropics. Exhausted by sunshine, the backs of the crimson chairs were a thin light orange . . . Pale regimental groups, reunions a generation ago of the family or the neighbourhood gave out from the walls a faint depression. There were two locked bookcases of which the keys had been lost, and a troop of ebony elephants brought back from India by someone she did not remember paraded along the tops of the bookcases. (*LS* 10)

The bookcase has form in the modern novel in Ireland. James Joyce and Flann O'Brien played with it as a symbol of the reader's

accessibility to the English canon. Shakespeare and company was familiar to the colonial subject; they might even be said to have been formed by the process of empire itself. This suggests that the colonial exchange required imaginative energy to sustain it, an energy given substance by the canonicity of the works on display, such as happens in Forster's *Howard's End*. The greater idea of empire was the decoration of the world within the home space. Danielstown retreats from this system the moment the bookcase is locked. Some refugees still make their way in. Myra finds a technical book on rubber tapping in her room, left behind last summer, while Laurence bores himself with a book about Nigeria.

The death of the Big House is not significant of Anglo-Ireland's slippage from Ireland, but from the world. The faint depression that attends it is the shallow mark left in the landscape from its colonial possession. One of *The Last September's* tricks is to disguise the emptiness of Danielstown before it is destroyed. Everything is worn, molding, or locked away, like the storeroom with its old cardboard boxes. When the family assembles for dinner they sit in a room whose scale diminishes them, a "disproportionate zone of emptiness" (*LS* 20). The things that do remain are objects that have no place elsewhere, like the ebony elephants. The Big House represents a world hollowed out by the First World War. Its spaces are the grand apertures of an empire that is in the process of shrinking. All that remains are the human attachments that bind a class to its extinction. This is inexact. There is no sense of a group attachment in the relatives who occupy and visit the Big House. All are on the verge of moving on or breaking up. There is no guide to this life but the senses, those nervous attachments that generations have tried to suppress. Life is made real only through the troubles, and even then suffering is reserved for the soldiers. There is some truth in the characters' observation that this is an English war, not an Irish one. The Cork countryside is the latest outpost in the border wars of the British Empire.

The problem is that the enemy is hard to demonize at close quarters. The Naylor's choose to ignore the young son of local farmers who is on the run. Intimacy becomes farce when history is

so personal. The arch manners of aristocratic life are a function of the material economy that provides for them. In this way, Bowen's insistence on Danielstown's particular history and architecture is an acknowledgment that the colonial arrangement is unjust. The illusion of gentility cannot be maintained beyond the demesne. Outside, "the trees run, watery, into the sky" (*LS* 15). Inside there is nervous conversation. Hugo asks Laurence at dinner:

"And what do *you* think of things?"

"Things? Over here?"

"Yes – yes."

"Seem to be closing in," said Laurence, crumbling his bread detachedly;
"rolling up rather." (*LS* 24–5)

This is the sensation Yeats caught in his "Meditations in Time of Civil War." The lonely tower stood watchful of the night as violence overtook the colonial outpost. The approach to disintegration is well flagged in the novel. The orange light of the evening sky is a premonition of Danielstown's burning just as the British army drive around in armored cars that belong better in further parts of the empire: "You'll do no good," the soldiers are told, "in this unfortunate country by running about in a thing like a coffee-pot" (*LS* 26).

The question remains of how to put form on this miscellaneous world. Modernism in the Irish context is associated most often with the extravagant explosion of writing. *Finnegans Wake* is the master document of an experimental literature whose foundations in the locally realized conflicts of global colonialism are laid deep beneath the book's twisting superstructure. But there was another and related strategy, which was to strip language of its historic exoskeleton, the bones left visible and heaped in an unrelated pile. Joyce played with this form too, as did Beckett and Flann O'Brien (think, for example, of the puzzle scholars still find in the letters "U.P.: up" in *Ulysses*). Elizabeth Bowen used this notational modernism to give her text a clarity that was reserved previously for realism. The age of empire petered out in the backwaters of County Cork. The sporadic off-stage violence comes to us in a style that notes crisply the disruption it causes. When Lois stumbles upon a sleeping volunteer

there is a shot, but at a distance and described only after. Bowen was interested in the substrate of her time, which she sensed to be particular to its history. And while Danielstown was never a center of modernity, its colonial founding guaranteed that it would become a symbol of the modern precisely at its moment of destruction. This, I think, explains the particular style of *The Last September*. Clear on the surface, sharp in its prose and social observation as any novel of the century before it, the novel's modernity hides in the depths of its sensitivity to world change. Bowen's modernism is a play on uncertainty. Her images undercut the words used to describe the things she sees. The effect is like walking on ice, through which her characters sometimes fall.

The narrator is a gentle companion to these human disasters. In this it mimics the assumed decency of the imperial tradition. The hollowness of this self-definition is visible in the shell-shocked veterans of the war and the uncertain subalterns, hunting rebels through the night. Perhaps this is all too dramatic a way to put it. Failure is an absolute end that *The Last September* does not quite reach. The extinction of Danielstown is one thing, the end of a world-system another. The novel imagines the relationship between these two extremes of scale in images of coast and water. Danielstown is an island in the Irish countryside, as are the other Big Houses given brief mention. They form an archipelago whose other uncertain parts extend into the farmland and roads that cross County Cork. Early in the novel the Naylor's listen to a lorry on patrol outside the demesne. They talk of tennis to distract themselves.

"D'you remember the fours we had on that court that summer – wasn't it nineteen six – you and I and O'Donnell and poor John Trent?"

"I do. Now was it James O'Donnell or Peter that went to Ceylon?"

"That was a great summer; I never remember a summer like it. We had the hay in by the end of June."

The lorry ground off east towards Ballyhinch; silence sifting down on its tracks like sand. Their world was clear of it and a pressure lightened. (LS 31)

The constant comparison of here to elsewhere is a class condition of colonialism. The geography of that imagined world is still

significant. It is not generic but particular, the arrangement of a landscape and seascape representative of wider pressures that shape the novel. Ceylon and sand are two keys. The stretch of empire is understood by the Naylor's to be impermanent. The tennis court has holes in its net by this summer of 1920, a summer that gives way to a darker autumn, hints of which are throughout the text.

This patchwork idea grows a few pages after when Lois watches the volunteer walk through the Naylor's land. It is a famous scene because it is read to pit a definite nationalism against an uncertain, because unethical, colonialism. The text bears more reading than that.

It must be because of Ireland he was in such a hurry; down from the mountains . . . Here was something else that she could not share. She could not conceive of her country emotionally: it was a way of living, an abstract of several landscapes, or an oblique frayed island, moored at the north but with an air of being detached and washed out west from the British coast. (*LS* 34)

This is the beginning of a shift in the novel's sense of place. Lois's visual sense allows her to see the abstract in the immediate. She pictures a refigured archipelago of islands that do not abide by the arrangements of empire or nation. Her lack of an emotional attachment to Ireland can be read as evidence of her class's detachment, except that she is equally unable to commit to her proposed lover, Gerald Lesworth. Detachment is not some abiding condition of the Anglo-Irish. It is a condition of Lois's historical moment as it unfolds. The unmooring of her affections is part of saying good-bye to an old world. Returning to Danielstown she finds the house quivering.

Chairs standing round dejectedly; upstairs, the confidently waiting beds; mirrors vacant and startling; books read and forgotten, contributing no more to life; dinner-table certain of its regular compulsion; the procession of elephants that throughout uncertain years had not broken file. (*LS* 34)

The mirror and the books are dejected. Those objects that allow for self-reflection are least accessible. They are guides to a lost world

and its subjectivities. This moment explains the leeching life of objects in the novel. There is little boundary between the human and things in Danielstown, as when a rug lies like a body in the hall. This condition spreads out to contaminate the house and its grounds. It is an uncertainty that a seceding Ireland cannot tolerate. The house is burned as an act of national sanitation.

Bowen sketches this critique of the independence movement lightly. When Lois and Mr. Montmorency share a trap through the countryside they enter open territory:

Coming up out from the lanes they bathed an hour or so in the glare of space. Height had the quality of depth: as they mounted they seemed to be striking deeper into the large mild crystal of an inverted sea. Out of the distance everywhere, pointless and unrelated, space came like water between them, slipping and widening. They receded from one another into the vacancy. On yellow furze-dust, light was hard and physical; over parching heather shadow faded and folded on tone, and was drawn to the sky on delicate brittle peaks. (*LS* 62)

It is remarkable the degree to which this passage can be read as a template for the modernists who followed Bowen. The Anglo-Irish were the first to be excluded from the idea of the new nation to which they could assimilate or leave. But there were others, including many who had fought for independence only to find themselves in armed uprising against the Free State because they felt it was a betrayal of their republican ideals. The civil war was bitter in Cork. Bowen later had an affair with Sean O'Faolain, who fought with the Irregulars and remained skeptical of Ireland's liberty. Another figure here is Ernie O'Malley. His great memoir of the troubles is *On Another Man's Wound*. Much of it was written when O'Malley lived in the United States. O'Malley was no friend of the Big House; he trained his volunteers in demesne grounds to rid them of their deference toward their masters.⁸ Still, his path to alienation saw him draw the landscape in the same bright spaces that Bowen had sketched before him.

In addition, both O'Malley and Bowen were drawn to images of water and liquidity. This is where the Big House novel becomes significant of something more than the failure of a particular set of

cultural and economic concerns. The fall of Danielstown becomes a scene in the transfiguration of empire into smaller nation-states. Uncertain of their existence these new states policed all kinds of dissidence. The Big House becomes in the novel what it was not in reality: a stage for difference and a refuge for alterity. Reading social freedom in the Big House as nostalgia is a mistake; the liberties dreamed of in *The Last September* are personal. They hide in a present that is summoned by the act of reading. Color, line, and space are the coordinates of a subjective landscape that mechanism tries to catch. The characters feel at their most uncomfortable when they are viewed in a frame, like a camera. The ghosts of the war are caught in the photographic portraits Mrs. Fogarty keeps of the dead junior officers. The young men's faces, "candid and vigorous" (*LS* 161) appall Lois. She hides in a dazzle. In the countryside again she "felt streaks of light fly over her face"; elsewhere she thinks of Gerald in an "escape of sunshine" (*LS* 128, 163). Bowen paints the end of empire in bright colors. Danielstown burns in scarlet. In the ruins, "light had possessed itself of the vacancy" (*LS* 206).

Making art from nothing can be read as a project of modernist writing. The investment of agency in material objects is one aspect of this ambition, an investment made political by the attachment of empire to capital. The life of things invites the reader to experience the world through perceptions to which the literary text gives historical depth. Bowen's use of light was one play on the senses; her attention to the fulcrum between vision and text is one example of her modernism. There were other ways, and again the Big House, in however degraded a form, was the narrative stage. I am thinking here of Samuel Beckett's use of the form in *Watt*. The novel is a late addition to the tradition, which has invited a parodic reading. Beckett began his first notebook for the novel in early 1941. He sent the manuscript to Routledge in the summer of 1945, which began its long history of rejection. The date is important because it bookends the writing of the novel through the middle and later stages of the Second World War. It also marks his purchase of Jack Yeats's painting, *Regatta*, which Beckett referred to as "Night."⁹ Yeats was the brother of the poet and a favorite of an intellectual set

that included Beckett's friend Thomas MacGreevy, Ernie O'Malley, and Louis MacNeice. Beckett admired Yeats's use of light. The painting was some consolation for the failure of *Watt*, which he admitted to George Reavey after two years of disappointment in trying to publish it, was "an unsatisfactory book, written in dribs and drabs, first on the run, then of an evening after the clodhopping, during the occupation."¹⁰ It could barely have been otherwise; Beckett was on the run from the Gestapo from 1942, seeking refuge in the village of Roussillon. The book was not published until 1953 and then imperfectly, the text's errors still a source of scholarly dispute.

Watt is hard to unpack. Its setting and characters are indeterminate, its logic twisted. The character of Watt lived in the house of a Mr. Knott, the model for which has been taken as Beckett's own family home in Cooldrinagh, Foxrock. The significance of this is more than autobiographical. *Watt* is a novel obsessed with systems. These are alimentary, material, and colonial. The novel contains extended passages on the progress of food through the body, the organization of objects, and the acquisition of subjects connected to the house, some human, some animal. Like Danielstown, Knott's house represents a local phase of global transition. The two houses are sites of evacuation. Each holds fragmentary signs of the presence of a world order whose points of contact with local history have moved on after their dislocation. Traces of *Watt*'s parody of human certainty is more than satire; it is a form extended to accommodate the emerging elements of a still uncertain future. Joyce established this technique with *Ulysses*. The absurd lists of things and people were a magic realism that merged objects of the everyday in a continuous historical tense. This "semidigested slowly surely earthward struggling mass" is the substance of social form at several points in *Watt*.¹¹ Traces of human habitation are found in the vomit that maps the Big House for the reader, traces found in "the coal-hole, the conservatory, the American Bar, the oratory, the cellar, the attic, the dairy and, I say it with shame, the servants' W.C." (*W* 45).

The historical context of the Irish Big House surfaces in the colony of dogs that Knott keeps out of charity. The master's feeding

of the animals invites others: "very soon it was much more than this, for immense impoverished families abounded for miles in every conceivable direction, and must have always done so" (*W* 84). The famine unsettles another novel in Beckett's sequence, the earlier *Murphy*. There the famine is associated with the emaciated figure of Cuchulainn in the statue at the General Post Office.¹² Militant republicanism and the Big House had their violent reckoning in *The Last September*. Watt is a far-flung part of the same historical arrangement. Knott's house is as unstable an object as Danielstown. Beckett's furniture shifts daily. The tallboy, night stool, and washstand dance through their rooms: "Alone the bed maintained the illusion of fixity, the bed so tasteful, the bed so solid, that it was round, and clamped to the ground" (*W* 179) (the binding of objects to human use is mindful again of *Murphy*).

These encumbrances invite consideration of larger issues of space and time. The correlation creates the language of modernism. Watt speaks

with scant regard for grammar, for syntax, for pronunciation, for enunciation, and very likely, if truth were known, for spelling too, as these are generally received. Proper names, however, both of places and of persons, such as Knott, Christ, Gomorrha, Cork, he articulated with great deliberation, and from his discourse these emerged, palms, atolls, at long intervals. . . . (*W* 133)

As with Bowen, history becomes literature in a process of refinement that tends toward the insular. The lost words of Knott's sentences are submerged. The points that rise are extremities (which explains the comedy of their association). Watt seems to associate such points with significant meaning. He "knew nothing about physics." But Beckett's use of words such as "interval" and "duration" suggest the author continues his reflections on space and time, which can be traced back to *More Pricks than Kicks*. Watt finds a painting in Knott's house. It is a point and a circle. He is puzzled by which is in the foreground, and which is in the background. Watt wonders if the two will "mingle, or keep steadfast on their ways, like ships in the night" (*W* 110). He asks whether the picture is Knott's property or

Erskine's (this again shows Beckett thinking of Ireland; Erskine Childers was the author of *Riddle of the Sands* and captain of the *Asgard*, which imported guns for the Irish Volunteers in 1914 from Hamburg). The picture's provenance is critical. A recent arrival in the house, it is part of a "paradigm, here to-day and gone to-morrow, a term in a series" (*W* 111). Beckett's systems do not often tell the reader much of the object that forms part of his deliberation. The formula of his character's attachments to things is notoriously difficult to unpack and prone to error, intentional or not. For all that, the medium between the human and history is material.

The Big House was an emblem of these transactions for Beckett, and for Bowen. The long decline and fall of empires into new world arrangements is the subject both of *Watt* and of *The Last September*. The Big House was Bowen's visible subject. Later, in Beckett, it is settled into a historical category that is no longer present. The fated form of the old regime gives way in their writing to images of light and water. Gomorrha was a city of the plain destroyed by God. Cork was an imperial port and a plantation county. The two places intermingle in *Watt*'s last lines. Beckett writes the obituary to "the long wet dream" (*W* 214) of the old world. In doing so, he made the Big House modern. Writing images of dictatorship and destruction into the view from the demesne, Beckett keeps open the connections between the empire that made Anglo-Ireland and the world after the war, "the sky falling to the hills, and the hills falling to the plain, made as pretty a picture, in the early morning light, as a man could hope to meet with, in a day's march" (*W* 214).

Notes

1. The field of subjects and criticism related to the Big House is vast. It includes significant authors such as Maria Edgeworth, Molly Keane, George Moore, Edith Somerville, Kate O'Brien, and John Banville. See Derek Hand, *A History of the Irish Novel* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), and Vera Kreilkamp, *The Anglo-Irish Novel and the Big House* (Syracuse, NY: Syracuse University Press, 1998).
2. See, e.g., Jed Esty, "Virgins of Empire: The Antidevelopment Plot of Rhys and Bowen," in *Unseasonable Youth: Modernism, Colonialism and the*

- Fiction of Development* (Oxford and New York: Oxford University Press, 2012), 160–94.
3. Ireland's place in the Atlantic world has been mapped by Nicholas Canny and other scholars in context of paradigms developed by Bernard Bailyn and others. For a general field summary, see Nicholas Canny and Philip Morgan, eds., *The Oxford Handbook of the Atlantic World: 1450–1850* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011).
 4. The outlines of this argument are made in John Darwin, *The Empire Project: The Rise and Fall of the British World System, 1830–1970* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011).
 5. For more on the Bildungsroman, see Esty, *Unseasonable Youth*; Gregory Castle, *Reading the Modernist Bildungsroman* (Gainesville: University Press of Florida, 2006); Franco Moretti, *The Way of the World: The Bildungsroman in European Culture* (London: Vintage, 2000).
 6. Elizabeth Bowen, *The Last September* (1929; London: Vintage, 1998), 65. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*LS*).
 7. For a study see S. B. Kennedy, *Irish Art and Modernism, 1880–1950* (Belfast: Institute of Irish Studies, 1991). See also Michael Holroyd, *Augustus John: The New Biography* (London: Farrar, Strauss & Giroux, 1996). John's portrait of W. B. Yeats is in the Tate Museum of Modern Art in London.
 8. This, and other insights into the anticolonial consciousness of the volunteers who fought in the war of independence can be read in O'Malley's *On Another Man's Wound*, which is at the same time one of the great twentieth-century modernist works in prose in Ireland. O'Malley's experiences outside Ireland and his response to visual art, both of which influenced the book, can be read in Cormac O'Malley and Nicholas Allen, eds., *Broken Landscapes: Selected Letters of Ernie O'Malley, 1924–57* (Dublin: Lilliput Press, 2011).
 9. George Craig, Martha Dow Fehsenfeld, Dan Gunn, and Lois More Overbeck, eds., *The Letters of Samuel Beckett*. vol. 2, 1941–1956 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), 73. For more on Beckett, Jack Yeats, and the visual implications of modernism in Ireland, see my *Modernism, Ireland, and Civil War* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009), and more generally David Lloyd, *Irish Times: Temporalities of Modernity* (Dublin: Field Day, 2008).
 10. George Craig et al., eds., *The Letters of Samuel Beckett*, 2:55.
 11. Samuel Beckett, *Watt* (London: Faber, 2009; 1953), 44. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*W*).
 12. For more on this, see my *Modernism, Ireland, and Civil War*, 128.

*In the Wake of Joyce: Beckett, O'Brien,
and the Late Modernist Novel*

Patrick Bixby

In the spring of 1939, shortly after the publication of *At Swim-Two-Birds*, Brian O’Nolan (better known by his pen name, Flann O’Brien) sent a copy of his first novel to James Joyce in the care of a mutual friend, Niall Sheridan. On the flyleaf of the book, the young writer had scrawled a seemingly modest inscription: “To James Joyce from the author / Brian O’Nolan with plenty of / what’s on page 305,” where the words “diffidence of the author” had been underlined.¹ When Sheridan called on the modernist master to deliver the gift, Joyce informed him that he had already read the book, apparently at the urging of his close friend, one Samuel Beckett. Not long after this encounter, O’Brien had an opportune meeting with Beckett in Dublin, where the author of the recently published *Murphy* told his counterpart that Joyce had deeply enjoyed the humor of *At Swim-Two-Birds*. But O’Brien, now evidently feeling a little less diffident, responded that the compliment had come from a writer in Joyce who was nothing more than a “refurbisher of skivvies’ stories.”² It is perhaps too easy to explain away this apparent change of heart as a product of O’Brien’s growing anxiety of influence, since he was already being compared rather unflatteringly to Joyce in reviews of novel. But when O’Brien had written to his publisher in May about the prospects of a follow-up novel, he did not miss the opportunity to report that Joyce had read the earlier book, even though the nearly blind novelist required a magnifying glass to do so: “this may be taken as a compliment from the fuehrer,” he quipped. Although Joyce was, according to O’Brien, “very particular that there should be no question of reproducing [an endorsement] for publicity purposes,”³ very few editions of O’Brien’s work have

appeared without an authoritative gloss from Joyce, as told to Sheridan: "A real writer, with the true comic spirit."⁴ Although Beckett had both praised and parodied Joyce's style in his early writings, he was chagrined that O'Brien had turned his comic spirit, rather thanklessly, on their older compatriot (something he would continue to do under the pen name of Myles na gCopaleen for another two decades and more). Looking back years later, with a good deal of his own diffidence, Beckett would famously acknowledge "Joyce's heroic achievement," which moved always "in the direction of knowing more, in control of one's material," as one he could never emulate himself.⁵

I would like to suggest that this collection of remarks is revelatory not just of Beckett's and O'Brien's circumstances as budding novelists in late-thirties Ireland, but of a particular variety of what we might call the late modernist disposition, that complex admixture of diffidence and derision characterizing their writing during this period. To pursue this claim, I would like to explore not only a certain coyness of temperament, which blends a strained modesty with a creeping sense of failure, but also the literary forms and historical conditions that attend the emergence of that temperament. Although the story of the meetings among these Irish writers has seldom been told, and the socio-political context of these relationships has been almost entirely ignored, the intertextual connection between Joyce and the younger novelists has long been a topic of critical discussion. What cannot be disregarded is that by the late 1930s Joyce had become a key figure in the emerging history of modernism, which was already being written by a host of commentators who were, by and large, invested in a notion of literature that Roland Barthes would later describe as "tyrannically centered on the author, his person, his history, his tastes, his passions."⁶

A perusal of the critical heritage reveals that during these years commentators repeatedly associated Joyce's modernist aesthetic with the image of a singular personality, capable of forging its own singular vision of the world in its own singular style. Discussion of the writer almost always began with the acknowledgment, whether laudatory or deprecating, of his innovations in form, technique, and

subject matter, before seeking explanation in accounts of his peculiar compulsions, his unrelieved narcissism, his sexual perversions, his personal rebellion, his enduring exile, his vexed Catholicism, or his particular relationship with words, as an Irishman under no obligation to observe the sanctity of the English tongue.⁷ According to John Eglinton, writing in 1929, Joyce was already perceived as “the idol of a good many of the young men of the new Ireland,” who fell under the influence of his achievements even in the era of new censorship legislation, not least because his writing had triumphed “over the Anglicism of the English language.”⁸ To be sure, Joyce was like something in the air: an unavoidable, if ethereal, presence for Irish writers coming of age in the 1930s, just as he was an unavoidable precedent for critics evaluating their writing. Beckett would admit that a large section of his first novel, *Dream of Fair to Middling Women* (completed in 1932, but published posthumously in 1992) “stinks of Joyce, in spite of most earnest endeavors to endow it with my own odors.”⁹ O’Brien came to resent more fiercely the opinion of those like Sean O’Faolain, who suggested that *At Swim-Two-Birds* had “a general odour of spilt Joyce all over it.”¹⁰

It is perhaps unsurprising, given the imposing presence of Joyce, that both writers were preoccupied with authors, authorship, and the question of authority in their first novels. Repeatedly shuttling back and forth between narrative and narrative theory, *Dream of Fair to Middling Women* reflects directly on the storytelling techniques associated with the giants of the nineteenth-century novel, alluding to Austen, Balzac, Dickens, Flaubert, and Stendhal, as the text questions their ability to create believable characters, convincing plots, and credible images or projections of a social world. But the problem of authorship is also raised at the more basic level of the narrative personae: by proceeding in the first person plural, “we,” Beckett’s novel repeatedly draws attention to the figure of author, while dispersing his authority across the coupling of the narrator and the implied author. In doing so, the novel presages the lines from *Texts for Nothing* that Michel Foucault famously identified with the disappearance of the authorial subject: “What does it matter who is speaking?”¹¹ That is, Beckett’s “we” plays on the fact that, as

Foucault points out, in a novel offered as a narrator's account neither the first person nor present indicative refers to the writer himself, but to an alter ego at some distance from the author. The author function operates in the division and distance between "he" and "I," marked here by the first personal plural. *At Swim-Two-Birds*, on the other hand, distributes the author function across a number of authorial figures in the text, with the nameless narrator writing a novel about one Dermott Trellis, a publican who is himself writing a novel that brings together characters from other novels, stories, and myths. This Chinese box structure of a novel-within-a-novel-within-a-novel highlights the issue of authorship even as it compromises the authority of the author, whose controlling presence is repeatedly displaced from one ontological level of the narrative to the next. This crisis of authority is dramatized in the story of Trellis himself, as his characters begin to keep him drugged so that they can write their own story, eventually placing the young man on trial for all manner of creative or narrative offenses.

In this ludic fashion, the late modernist novels of both Beckett and O'Brien draw attention to the compromised status of the author as unified origin or authoritative source of meaning, and to a related opening up of the text to other voices and other writings. Anticipating the insights of Barthes and Foucault by almost three decades, the narrator of *At Swim-Two-Birds* claims that "the entire corpus of existing literature should be regarded as a limbo from which discerning authors could draw their characters as required, creating only when they failed to find a suitable existing puppet. The modern novel should be largely a work of reference. Most authors spend their time saying what has been said before – usually said much better" (*AS* 20). Indeed, O'Brien and his narrator draw on tales from Gaelic antiquity, cowboys from dime novels, and numerous other sources, even quoting an extended passage from a horse racing column. In *Dream of Fair to Middling Women*, Beckett and his narrator are just as brazen in their thefts, absconding with characters from Stendhal and Dickens, lines from Synge and Tennyson, and enough echoes and allusions to fill more than 350 pages in John Pilling's companion study of the novel.

Of course, Joyce could well be accused of a similar offence. If a personal style, as the sign of a unified and authoritative subject, can be seen evolving in Joyce's early writings, that category no longer seems to apply to the grand verbal experiments in the later chapters of *Ulysses* and *Finnegans Wake*, which, as Fredric Jameson has claimed, should be seen as a "pastiche of styles" and "impersonal sentence combinations and variation beyond all point of view," exemplified in the procession of imitations that make up the "Oxen of the Sun."¹² It appears, however, that for Beckett, O'Brien, and their contemporaries, these efforts at impersonality paradoxically made the figure of Joyce all the more conspicuous. Such "strategies of self-erasure," as Brian McHale would argue much later, "while ostensibly obliterating surface traces of the author, in fact call attention to the author *as strategist*" – absolutely in control of his or her material.¹³ In making this assertion regarding modernist impersonality, McHale went on to identify Beckett and O'Brien as early contributors to a postmodernist sensibility: writers who, precisely by drawing attention to the figure of the author, his compromised authority, and his ontological status in relation to his fictional worlds, have heightened our awareness that writing has eclipsed the writing subject. McHale, of course, has been followed by a great many critics eager to identify Beckett and O'Brien as postmodernists *avant la lettre*.

It may be more instructive to view Beckett's and O'Brien's writings of the 1930s and 1940s as examples of transitional or late modernism – a postcolonial modernism, to be more precise – skeptical both of the authoritative gestures of Joycean modernism and partisan claims to cultural authority made in Ireland during the period. Beckett's and O'Brien's responses to modernism's achievements, made in the context of an emergent postcolonial nation-state, play out not in the dominance of epistemological questions regarding what can be known about the world from a given perspective, or in the dominance of ontological questions about how worlds are constituted through language, but precisely in the initiation of a hesitant shift from epistemological to ontological issues, which calls into question the authority to represent, reconstruct, or project worlds.

When Beckett and O'Brien engage directly with Joyce in their writing, it is generally with his early prose and its emergent modernist style, particularly as that style is dedicated to cognitively mapping the Irish nation:

Yes, the newspapers were right: snow was general all over Ireland. It was falling softly upon the Bog of Allen and, further westwards, softly falling into the dark mutinous Shannon waves. It was falling too upon every part of the lonely churchyard where Michael Furey lay buried. It lay thickly drifted on the crooked crosses and headstones, on the spears of the little gate, on the barren thorns. His soul swooned slowly as he heard the snow falling faintly through the universe and faintly falling, like the descent of their last end, upon all the living and the dead.¹⁴

This well-known passage, from the final paragraph of "The Dead," epitomizes Joyce's lyrical prose, which rises to a climax in the symmetrical structure of repetition, inversion, and alliteration, as well as the complex use of metaphor, metonymy, and allusion, all devoted to evoking an image of the national landscape. Luke Gibbons has noted that, as the passage traces the thoughts of the isolated and egocentric Gabriel Conroy, it recreates the "transverse, cross-time" of the newspapers mentioned in the opening sentence.¹⁵ Much like the novel form, the newspaper allows individuals to connect with the simultaneous presence of people and places beyond their immediate experience, thus establishing the grounds for what Benedict Anderson influentially called the "imagined community" of the nation.¹⁶ In this final, epiphanic moment, Gabriel seems to come to some insight regarding the Irish nation, an insight that, informed by his particular education and experience, apparently contrasts greatly from the perspective of his less urbane and more parochial wife, Gretta. We might read the passage, then, as evidence of Gabriel's newfound sympathies for Ireland or his sense of alienation from Gretta and the Irish people, though in either case we can also read Joyce's lyricism as a parody of his protagonist's apparent slide into a moment of nationalist sentiment. This did not stop Beckett, however, from parodying the passage himself at the end of *Dream of Fair to Middling Women* by replacing the picturesque snow that falls across Ireland with rain that falls "upon the bay, the champaign-land

and the mountains, and notably upon the central bog . . . with a rather desolate uniformity.”¹⁷

O’Brien’s revision of these lines near the end of *At Swim-Two-Birds* is, if anything, more caustic, depicting the mythic Sweeny as an isolated individual who sits high in the trees and listens to “bark answer[ing] bark till the call spreads like fire through Erin” (*AS* 237). With these coarse substitutions and transformations, travestying the romantic lyricism of the story’s conclusion, the passages refract the unifying vision of both cultural nationalism and authoritative subjectivity, whether we attribute that subjectivity to Gabriel Conroy or James Joyce. For Anderson, evocations of national “communities are to be distinguished, not by their falsity/genuineness, but by the *style* in which they are imagined,” since such evocations are not mere forgeries but inventions or creations.¹⁸ In their parodic responses to Joyce, Beckett and O’Brien trouble not just the notion of a unique modernist style (and the attendant notion of a coherent individual subject), but also the styles in which Ireland has been imagined, especially as those styles appear to mend the rift between an alienated consciousness and a racial conscience, a private self and the social world, through voices that announce their own authority to imagine Ireland in particular, even personal ways. This is a matter not so much of epistemology but of ontology.

The relatively narrow focus on literary history, the anxiety of influence, and a certain understanding of authorship and intertextuality that has dominated critical discussion of the relations among these writers finally fails to offer a satisfactory account of the complex interactions that shape the late modernist aesthetics of Beckett and O’Brien. For it tends, among other things, to privilege the autonomy of Joyce’s writing, reaffirming the myth of modernism and the sovereignty of modernist styles, even as it detaches Beckett’s and O’Brien’s writing from the social and political conditions of Ireland in the 1930s and 1940s, when the newly independent nation-state emerged into an uncertain future plagued by questions regarding cultural *and* socio-political authority. What is now necessary is to view the formal elements of their writing, the aesthetic response we can call late modernism, in relation to their social and political

situation. To put it perhaps too schematically, Joyce wrote his modernist masterpieces in the context of Home rule aspirations and cultural nationalist agitation, publishing *Ulysses* just a fortnight after the transition of power from an English to an Irish government; Beckett and O'Brien, on the other hand, wrote their late modernist novels in the context of a postcolonial state that had largely failed to live up to the promise of independence. No doubt, as postcolonial criticism has amply demonstrated over the last two decades, *Ulysses* "exposes nationalist and other chauvinist ideologemes of the 'imagined community' chiefly as inheritances of the colonialist regime of power-knowledge that they condemn."¹⁹ One might even claim, as Jameson has, that the novel takes its linguistic energies precisely from the fact that it deals with a community in late imperial Dublin, which possesses an inherent form of closure derived from its status as an "underdeveloped village" and "cultural backwater" (never mind that Joyce's "leap" to the postmodern in the later chapters of *Ulysses* troubles Jameson's "cultural logic of late capitalism").²⁰ But, in doing so, the same novel also provided opportunities for those critics, journalists, ideologists, and young Irish writers who sought to nominate Joyce as the voice of Irish independence and an attendant cultural autonomy. Insofar as he achieved international recognition as master of style and form, Joyce was ironically granted a kind of absentee victory in the effort to forge the conscience of the Irish race, however suspect the proclamation of that desire at the end of *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* may have been. The late modernist novels of Beckett and O'Brien, on the other hand, abandon any notion of national unity or moral unanimity, as well as the effort at formal mastery or aesthetic heroism, starting instead with a pervasive sense of failure.

This sense of failure can be attributed in no small part to the circumstances the young writers encountered in postcolonial Ireland, where the independent state founded in 1922 could not live up to the revolutionary vision that brought it into existence – not least due to a crisis of authority at its very founding. The new government in Dublin felt the need to legitimize itself after the split with the Sinn Féin party, the erstwhile leaders of the Irish Parliament, and the

ensuing civil war, which had resulted in the horrible loss of life on both sides. In the effort to stabilize the newly founded state, its administrators adopted many of the institutions that had defined the previous colonial regime, including English-style jails, courts, and police force, together creating a paradoxical continuity between the colonial and postcolonial regimes. At the same time, the new leaders harnessed the unifying power of the Catholic Church in Ireland, legislating a conservative social agenda over the next decade, while effectively cordoning off the Irish nation from external influences, including the perceived threats of American films, English newspapers, and Continental fashions. The cultural authority once exerted by the Irish Literary Revival, the Gaelic League, and other forms of cultural nationalism was thus steadily co-opted by the state itself as the dynamism of these movements calcified into the restrictive norms of social purity and authentic Irishness. Although the ascension of Eamon De Valera and his Fianna Fáil party in 1932 represented a peaceful transfer of power to those who once opposed the Anglo-Irish Treaty, it only compounded the conservatism of the postcolonial state.

Within these circumstances, the social positions occupied by Beckett and O'Brien could hardly have been more divergent, a fact that makes the shared features of their writing in the 1930s and 1940s all the more striking. Born to an upper-middle-class Protestant family in the suburbs of Dublin and educated at the Portora School and Trinity College, Beckett grew into a rather disaffected young man, unhappy not just with the limitations of his class, but with the ostensibly Catholic and Gaelic vision of the new state, until he finally abandoned Ireland in 1937. O'Brien, on the other hand, was born to a devout Catholic family in Strabane, County Tyrone, where he spoke Gaelic as a child, before moving to Dublin, graduating from University College and eventually taking up a position in the civil service, which he held until his death in 1966. What unites the two writers is not just their complicated relationship with Joyce, but their experiments with the novel form, experiments that – sometimes subtly, sometimes not so subtly – defy the prevailing vision of the newly independent nation. Interwar writing in Ireland has often

been categorized in two contrasting ways: “a conventional, often somewhat bitter realism exposing the constrictive difficulties of life in Ireland, and an experimental fabulist mode seeking to escape such realities” with both sides owing something to Joyce.²¹ Less often appreciated is just how much Beckett and O’Brien, as key exemplars of the experimental fabulist mode, also engage with the “constrictive difficulties” of Irish life through a critical utopian form of satire and social critique – a challenge to the authority of any hegemonic or totalizing vision of postcolonial Ireland, but in the questioning, ironizing, or negation of authority itself.

Rather than present a masterful account of the postcolonial nation in all its promise for (or even denial of) communal self-determination and individual self-realization, Beckett and O’Brien struggle with the imperative to offer a coherent vision of civic life through which Ireland and its people might be ascribed stable identities. There are no grand verbal experiments here, only willful failures to produce a form of narrative closure that would contain a verbal, social, political, or ontological multiplicity, rendering suspect the dominion of the author and the solidity of his projected world, as well as the precursor texts and traditions that assume these qualities. In other words, their writing engages in a relentless challenge to authority that derives precisely from their own impotence to represent (to speak *of* and *for*) or, more to the point, to successfully *imagine* a postcolonial nation, without endorsing the standard modes of novelistic representation, ethnographic realism, republican rhetoric, and nationalist mythology. Take, for instance, O’Brien’s irreverent treatment of the legendary figures Finn MacCool and Sweeny in *At Swim-Two-Birds*, where their incongruous presence does not so much mock their significance as point to the gap between their virtues and the sorry state of the present. Or take Beckett’s comic General Post Office scene in *Murphy*, where Mr. Neary registers his disgust by bearing his head and assaulting the buttocks of the mythic hero Cuchulain, recently given material form by Oliver Sheppard’s bronze and memorialized by De Valera’s rousing dedication ceremony.

R. F. Foster has claimed that the real accomplishments of De Valera and his regime during this period were essentially rhetorical,

rewriting a disappointing postcolonial reality in terms of timeless nationalist emblems and persistent republican aspirations.²² This is nowhere more evident than in De Valera's signature achievement as a statesman, the 1937 Constitution of Ireland. In contributing to its authorship, he was motivated by a desire to replace the Constitution of the Irish Free State, which many in Fianna Fáil saw as imposed by the Anglo-Irish treaty, and to thereby reaffirm the fundamental Irishness of their governmental institutions, if only in symbolic terms. It is all the more striking that, as most commentators acknowledge, the constitution is made up of an eclectic set of discourses, including liberal notions of popular sovereignty, familiar elements of Gaelic Revivalism, and fashionable principles of Catholic social teaching, with clearly theocratic implications for the new state. Thus Article 1 claims "sovereign right" for the "Irish nation" to choose its own government and Article 40 asserts the sovereignty of the individual in the tradition of Continental liberalism, while other articles prohibit divorce and confirm the position of women in the home. Perhaps the most radical claim in the constitution was the assertion in Article 2 that "the whole island of Ireland, its islands and territorial seas" formed a single "national territory" – an assertion that not only risked offending Unionists in Northern Ireland, but also failed as a performative avowal of the relationship between a well-defined territory and a particular group of people. Approved by a narrow plurality during the plebiscite of July 1, 1937, the new constitution went into effect on 29 December, effectively unifying and formalizing a dominant vision of the Irish nation which, as Charles Townshend points out, "excluded the minority for which both the Irish language and the Catholic Church were the opposite of integrative symbols."²³

It is illuminating to recall *At Swim-Two-Birds* in light of this document and the impulse that led to its production, especially since much of the novel was finished during the period including the national plebiscite on the constitution and the initial period of its enforcement. O'Brien, indeed, was performing his role as a civil servant for the Irish government at the time, though as his biographer Anthony Cronin points out, there was no particular respect for

politicians among the civil service. It is also true that O'Brien was a native Gaelic speaker, a lifelong Catholic, and had a general sympathy for the nationalist movement, but that, in his fiction and in his newspaper writing, he was relentlessly skeptical of the opportunistic politicians and Celtic fetishists who asserted a narrow, parochial, or essentialist vision of Irishness. The dialogic, heteroglossic, and Menippean elements of his first novel have been noted often by critics as attacks on the monologic vision of Irish nationality promoted widely in the 1930s.²⁴ They have cited, for instance, how the novel addresses the debate over birth control and the discourse of sexual purity, reading these elements as a protest not only against these policies, but also against the literary censorship that would ban their discussion. José Laners has even proposed that the narrator's friend "Mr. Corcoran represents de Valera's brand of sentimental nationalism by recommending Irish dancing over foreign imports like waltz, which he claims are disapproved of by the Gaelic League and the clergy."²⁵ I would suggest further that we can read the formal elements of the novel, more directly but also more abstractly, as protests against the authorship of the state by narrow-minded theocrats and dogmatic Gaelicists, and identify these innovations not so much as challenges to a particular version of Irishness, but to the very possibility of a univocal, definitive, or authoritarian account of Irish nationality. As we have seen, O'Brien repeatedly mixes a variety of source materials and disperses the authority of the author across a range of ontological levels, but never reins in this multiplicity with an overarching narrative structure or domineering authorial "strategy" – suggesting, finally, that such world making is necessarily eclectic and unstable. In the context of 1930s Ireland, this eclecticism and instability can be understood as a brand of critical utopianism, which contests the ability of discourses such as a populist nationalism and a constitutional republicanism to project new social, political, and economic solidities.²⁶

The same critical utopian function, troubling the authoritative and totalizing vision of an imagined community, can also be identified in O'Brien's next novel, *Third Policeman* (completed in 1940, but published posthumously in 1967), which might otherwise be seen

as sharing little with its precursor. The world of the novel, as described by the unnamed narrator, contains many of the familiar features associated with rural Ireland: the green fields, the stone walls, the frequent rain, and even, in a brief aside, the story of Andy Gowan, “a beautiful commentary on Home Rule,” all of which make the place easily recognizable as “Ireland.”²⁷ Nonetheless, this is still a “strange world,” a “queer country,” a disorienting realm that consistently refuses to conform to the rules of “reality”: the narrator speaks with a dead man, witnesses the sudden appearance of his own soul, encounters a police barracks that confounds spatial description, and descends into an underground realm where the laws of physics seem to have been completely suspended. As Tom Shea puts it, the narrative contains scenes that are “ludicrous and logically impossible,” and the narrator eventually discovers that, in his efforts to describe these scenes, his “known words” are inadequate or simply invalid (*TP* 24). All of this is compounded by the proliferation of footnotes in the text, detailing the academic controversies surrounding the philosophy of one De Selby, which are the source of unending fascination for the narrator. Indeed, the reader might be prompted to ask how she can trust a narrator who has dedicated so much of his life to studying the work of such a figure: De Selby’s theories include, among many other bizarre notions, the claim that nightfall is not brought on by the rotation of the earth, but by “a staining of the atmosphere due to volcanic eruptions” (*TP* 116).

Yet this is not merely an unreliable narrator, in the tradition of so many modernist storytellers and the epistemological questions they raise: “What is there to be known? Who knows it? . . . How is knowledge transmitted from one knower to another, and with what degree of reliability?”²⁸ For, as we learn at the end of the novel, he too is a dead man, condemned to relive his crime and its aftermath in this surreal version of Ireland. He is, literally enough, a dead author figure, a storyteller who occupies a problematic position in relation to the purgatorial realm of his story, since, as we finally learn, there is no substantial or reconstructible world forming an ontologically stable background against which his “known words” can be arranged and compared. That is, the questions raised by the text

abruptly shift from the epistemological to the ontological, as the projected world begins to “flicker” into and out of existence, contingent on whether we accept not so much the “certainty” but the “reality” of what the narrator tells us. In the move away from modernist perspectivism, this flickering effect mediates between the language or “style” of the text and the our ability to reconstruct a stable and substantial mental image from that language.²⁹ It may be that the purgatory of *The Third Policeman* – a strange kind of posthumous, postcolonial world doomed to repeat history – is, as Bernard Benstock has suggested, a metaphor for “the rural Ireland of [O’Brien’s] time,” with its poverty, disease, and emigration.³⁰ And it may also be that, as Anthony Cronin has claimed, it fails as a metaphor, though I would add that this failure is precisely the socio-political significance of the novel. This is national allegory only in the most fractured and attenuated sense.

Beckett’s *Watt* and O’Brien’s *Poor Mouth*, both written during the war, bear even more closely on the problem of representing Irishness and the attendant crisis of cultural authority in postcolonial Ireland. Beckett’s novel has increasingly been read as a rather bizarre parody of the Irish Big House Novel, a genre that often chronicles the declining fortunes and surfacing idiosyncrasies of the Anglo-Irish ascendancy. Subjecting the reader to an almost endless series of epistemological and linguistic conundrums (many of which recall the similar conundrums in *The Third Policeman*), *Watt* troubles the representation of Irish life offered in the genre by rendering any cultural knowledge provided in its pages radically uncertain. Critics have also remarked on the interpolated narrative of Ernest Louit, a would-be anthropologist from an unnamed Dublin university, who conjures one Mr. Nachybal, a pig-loving, potato-grubbing native of western Ireland, in an elaborate hoax to prove the “Mathematical Intuitions of the Visicelt.” Viewed alongside the epistemological issues raised throughout the novel, the episode appears to parody the representational authority of both imperial and native anthropological projects that would reveal the authentic nature of the Irish. These epistemological issues are raised, however, within a novel whose narrative point of view evokes pressing ontological questions. For, as we learn

in chapter three, the entire narrative has been dictated by the protagonist to one “Sam,” a fellow asylum inmate who struggles to transcribe, translate, or transform Watt’s strange way of speaking into the text that we read. Indeed, his struggles are such that we must suspect that much of the novel, including its account of Big House culture and the interpolated narrative of Louit and Nachybal, are at least partially invented by an ineffectual author figure (named after the ostensible author of the novel itself), who cannot finally integrate the information he collects into a coherent verbal construct or projected world. In other words, “Sam” breaks the frame around this world by inserting a version of himself into the fiction, but in doing so, he does not so much assert his ontological superiority as efface his authority by drawing our attention to the unstable ontological boundary and his own flickering between ontological levels.

Like *Watt*, O’Brien’s third novel, *An Beal Bocht* (written under the penname Myles na gCopaleen in 1941 and translated from the Irish as *The Poor Mouth* in 1973), is a text that parodically heightens certain clichéd images of authentic Irishness to produce a fictional world with critical utopian implications – not a more credible or more truthful account of Irishness, but one that is overtly fabricated or contrived. Here the object of parody is a tradition of Irish language memoir by writers such as Séamus Ó Grianna, Peig Sayers, Peadar Ó Laoghaire, and especially Tomás Ó Criomhthán, whose *An t-Oileánach* was published to great acclaim in 1929 (and translated into English as *The Islandman* in 1934) for its portrait of life in the rural west. *The Poor Mouth*, on the other hand, farcically exaggerates many of the stereotypes of western life: the narrator experiences desperate poverty, characters cohabit with dozens of pigs, the rain almost never ceases, and family tragedies accumulate in outrageous fashion. This image of Gaelic destitution challenges stereotypes of colonial discourse that date back to the nineteenth century, precisely by comically overstating them, while dramatizing their gullible acceptance by British authorities. But the novel also highlights the clichés of the Gaelic life that had become a staple of Irish writing in the 1920s and continued to appear in political

speechmaking through the 1930s and 1940s, most famously in De Valera's idealized vision of a devout rural people "satisfied with frugal comfort."³¹ In this way, O'Brien's text mocks the way a narrow and restrictive self-image had been adopted and perpetuated by the Irish themselves, including a gentleman from Dublin who, much like Beckett's Ernest Louit, arrives full of prejudices to study the customs of his rural countrymen. This is underscored again by the narrator's impromptu parenthetical as he repeats these very stereotypes – "(if the books be credible)" – which draws our attention to the power of such discourses to shape the Irish imagination, to forge the racial conscience.³² With this brief phrase, the narrator also calls attention to the shift from epistemological to ontological concerns in the novel, which is itself less about the difficulty of capturing a credible image of the national character than about the long-standing problem, to borrow Declan Kiberd's resonant phrase, of "inventing Ireland."³³ *The Poor Mouth* is, ultimately, a novel about the failures of such invention, precisely because it can claim no more authenticity than the books that it parodies – rather, it projects a radically inauthentic authenticity.

I have been arguing that these failures should be read as a key feature of a late modernism, which registers the inability of earlier modernists to somehow "realize" the promise of their art to produce new futures, new worlds. But, as I have also been suggesting, this can only be properly appreciated by registering the particular social and political "realities" from which the writing of Beckett and O'Brien emerged. Their novels represent a challenge not just to the formal mastery modeled by their famous predecessor, but to the authority of any discourse that would seek to capture and enclose the Irish within a stable and restrictive vision of the national community. Their careers diverged dramatically after the early 1940s, with Beckett remaining abroad to become an icon of the international avant-garde, and O'Brien staying at home to become a popular columnist for the *Irish Times*. Nonetheless, they continued to share a certain late modernist disposition, pushing that disposition to what appears in retrospect to be its final, perhaps necessary, enunciation.

Beckett's novels, moving ever further from Joycean control and toward "impoverishment," "lack of knowledge," and "taking away," continued to dismantle modernist poetics and the figure of the author³⁴: applying his thesis to the famous trilogy of the 1950s, McHale points out that the world of Molloy is revealed as a projection of Malone, whose death leaves us to wonder about the ontological status of the worlds he projects, only to have our assumptions further upset by the ontological improvisations of the Unnamable.³⁵ In this way, the novels also dismantle the ontological and narrative structures of the so-called imagined community, not by abandoning a political geography for a "dreamscape without presence," as influential critics have suggested, but by negotiating the tension between presence and absence, mimesis and semiosis, in a fictional landscape haunted by the specters of Irish history.³⁶

Meanwhile, O'Brien settled into his role as Myles na gCopaleen and, in his long-running newspaper column, continued to assail the reputation of James Joyce and his cult of authorship (with the occasional change of heart, if not a slide into unreserved diffidence), even as he travestied the narrowness and nostalgia of the Gaelic Revival. Finally, in his last novel, *The Dalkey Archive* (1964), O'Brien undertook what he called "a study in *derision*, various writers with their styles, and sundry modes, attitudes and cults being the rats in the cage"³⁷: therein, he revives Joyce and places the modernist master back home in postwar Ireland, where he lives under a false name, having denounced his novels and taken to writing pamphlets for the Catholic Truth Society. Sweeping up the "real" author and his styles or modes into his own fiction, O'Brien calls our attention yet again to the oscillation between presence and absence that characterizes authorship and the ontological "flicker" that characterizes the world of his text. In doing so, O'Brien also extends the late modernist project in one final challenge to the discourses that claim to offer an authentic, stable, or definitive image of the "Irish people," a phrase that had always evoked in Beckett, he slyly confessed, a "chronic inability to understand."

Notes

1. Qtd. in Anthony Cronin, *No Laughing Matter: The Life and Times of Flann O'Brien* (London: Grafton, 1989), 92.
2. *Ibid.*, 72.
3. Robert Hogan and Gordon Henderson, eds. "A Sheaf of Letters," *The Journal of Irish Literature* 3, no. 1 (January 1974): 68.
4. Qtd. in front matter, in Flann O'Brien, *At Swim-Two-Birds* (Dublin: Dalkey Archive, 1998), n.p. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*AS*).
5. Qtd. in James Knowlson, *Damned to Fame: The Life of Samuel Beckett* (New York, Grove Press, 2004), 111, 319.
6. Roland Barthes, "The Death of the Author," in *Theories of Authorship: A Reader*, ed. John Caughie (New York: Routledge, 2001), 209.
7. See Robert H. Deming, ed., *James Joyce: The Critical Heritage*, vol. 2, 1928–41 (New York: Taylor and Francis, 2005).
8. John Eglinton, "Joyce's Emancipation," in *James Joyce: The Critical Heritage*, ed. Robert H. Deming, vol. 2, 1928–1941 (New York: Taylor and Francis, 2005), 459.
9. Samuel Beckett, *The Letters of Samuel Beckett*, eds. Martha Dow Fehsenfeld and Lois Overbeck, vol. 1, 1929–1940 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009), 81.
10. Cronin, *No Laughing Matter*, 92.
11. Michel Foucault, "What Is an Author?" in *The Foucault Reader*, ed. Paul Rabinow (New York: Pantheon, 1984), 101.
12. Fredric Jameson, "Nationalism and Imperialism," in *Nationalism, Colonialism, and Literature* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1990), p. 62.
13. Brian McHale, *Postmodernist Fiction* (New York: Routledge), 101.
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25. Lanthers, *Unauthorized Versions*, 194.
26. Anderson speaks of how the novel is able to confirm “the solidity of a single community, embracing characters, author and readers, moving onward through calendrical time” (*Imagined Communities*, 28).
27. O’Brien, *The Third Policeman* (Dublin: Dalkey Archive Press, 1999), 159. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*TP*).
28. McHale, *Postmodernist Fiction*, p. 9.
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Destinies of Bildung: Belatedness and the Modernist Novel

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all is meaningful; nothing is small

Olive Schreiner

Time and Achievement

Bildung always comes late. This might well be the motto for any fiction that narrates self-cultivation, whether it takes the form of a classical Bildungsroman or any number of variants that seek to avoid its dialectical closure. The idea that *Bildung* comes late (sometimes too late, sometimes never) is implicit in the temporality of nineteenth-century Bildungsromane, which is characterized by an aspiration for an ideal that is *yet to come*.¹ That same ideal, however, serves as a model that preexists the experience of aspiration, for while our experience toward the ideal makes achievement belated, we are at the same time engaged in another temporality, one that glances back to the model that's been left behind. Our futurity is defined by a curious "afterwardsness" that leaves us traumatized for having aspirations at all.² Modernism, by unveiling these temporalities of *Bildung*, opens new narrative horizons, in which the aspiration toward *Bildung* (even its failure) becomes an achievement in its own right.

Classical *Bildung* aims at the perfection of inner culture. The *Bildungsheld* (the hero of formation) undergoes the rigors and pleasures of aesthetic education and the dialectics of friendship, marriage, and social collaboration that enables his faculties to develop harmoniously toward the goal of achieved, unified *Bildung*. Symbolic celebrations of *Bildung* tend to mask the fundamentally contrary nature of its achievement. Take, for example,

Johann von Goethe's *Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship* (*Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre*, 1795–96), the *Ur-text* of the Bildungsroman tradition and of classical Weimer's Enlightenment humanism. At the novel's conclusion, when Wilhelm is inducted into the "Tower Society" (*Turmgesellschaft*), the custodians of his destiny mull over the implications of his formative quest

"What I find most difficult," the Abbé says to Jarno, "is the separation a man must achieve within and for himself if he is ever to attain self-cultivation Anyone who aims at acting or experiencing with his total self, or tries to embrace everything outside himself into one total experience, will spend his time in constantly unfulfilled striving."³

The internal temporal logic of *Bildung* threatens to cancel it out, since the aspiration to totalize one's experience through self-cultivation will, according to the Abbé, lead to yet more striving for an impossible totality. He is saying, in effect, that one should aspire for an inner life, cultivated to perfection, through an organic separation from the whole of life. Wilhelm learns this lesson the hard way, through the experience of belatedness that afflicts his triumphant achievement of *Bildung* with a vertiginous feeling of being out of time. Thus he laments to Lothario, his soon-to-be brother-in-law, "Time and time again my eyes have been opened to what I am, but always too late and always to no purpose We are all miserable creatures destined for misery." His doubts appear to evaporate once he clinches the union with Natalie, and he stands on the brink of his own future, holding "a treasure [he] never deserved" (*WM* 371, 373). His self-assessment, however, leads one to feel that he mistrusts the achievement of *Bildung* that had been, in significant ways, mapped out in advance of his aspirations.

Achieved *Bildung* is *belated* with respect both to the lived experience of aspiration that conditions it and to our reflections on that experience, which very often serve in lieu of the crowning achievement. "The owl of Minerva takes its flight only when the shades of night are gathering," Hegel has written, meaning that our "ideal" knowledge of things is past the time of our experience of them.⁴ We move in daylight toward a final flowering of *Bildung* that is

enshrouded in night. This belatedness is the general condition of our conscious lives (and thus of our consciousness of *Bildung*), since our reflections *on* ourselves come too late to align perfectly or completely with our experience *of* ourselves *as selves*. Belatedness is the incommensurability of two temporalities: one of experience and one of reflection.⁵ These two temporal moments come together in the dialectics of classical *Bildung*, according to which our own best selves are postponed with the promise that there will be time for a true recognition of ourselves. We can redeem this promise only from the standpoint of achievement, of fulfilled *Bildung*. Yet the Abbé, preeminent mentor, cautions against the “unfulfilled striving” that attends upon the desire for a “total self” or a “total experience.” How else are we to conceive of satisfactory *Bildung* if not by way of a totality that leaves no remainder, no reason for further striving?

Goethe and other thinkers in classical Weimar believed that dialectics could overcome this contradiction (and the attendant dangers of infinite striving and deferral) and that self-cultivation could proceed accordingly toward a harmonious and unified end.⁶ Indeed, Wilhelm von Humboldt, in *Limits of State Action* (written 1792; published 1851), is wary of the satisfactions of “partial cultivation,” by which I think he means the very separation that the Abbé advocates. Instead, he advises the individual

to unite the distinct and generally separately exercised faculties of his nature, by bringing into spontaneous cooperation, at each period of his life, the dying sparks of one activity, and those which the future will kindle, and endeavouring to increase and diversify the powers with which he works, by harmoniously combining them, instead of looking for a mere variety of objects for their separate exercise.⁷

Bildung is an ongoing process (“at each period of his life”), an organic “endeavor” to combine one’s resources (even the “dying sparks” of character) and to realize what the “future will kindle”: a promise of revived fire that conveys the utopian quality of *Bildung*, its perfect-tensed temporality (that is, it will have transpired that *Bildung* was achieved). Humboldt’s *Bildung* captures the temporality of belatedness and the formative power of memory, activity, and

desire and advocates an inclusiveness of faculties that models a more general embrace of multiplicity and diversity. A more unified sense of self means, for him, that one's choice of "external matters" – one's involvement, in short, in the life of the community – "springs from [one's] inner being." And only "frequent and intimate . . . cooperation of these two sources of motive" (external matters and inner being) can guarantee this unity even when such choices are not freely made.⁸

For Humboldt, as for Friedrich von Schiller and J. S. Mill, *Bildung* is a teleological process, one that requires a complex, well-calibrated dialectical integration of the individual and the community (i.e., the State), which, as Jed Esty shows, is often figured as a "soul-nation allegory."⁹ Though fundamentally holistic and unifying, Humboldt's thought about *Bildung* lays bare the antinomy between the absolute harmony of achieved selfhood and the open-ended risk of "spontaneous cooperation" with others, an antinomy that prevents *Bildung* from ever attaining its ideal form. Marc Redfield, in fact, has argued that the identification process at work in *Bildung* necessarily excludes any kind of objective identification with an ideal model. "*Bildung*'s engine" thus "runs on the double bind of identification," he writes, for "the subject must identify with the model in order to become what the subject already is; however, this also means that the subject must *not* identify with anything – particularly not a master or exemplar – that is not always already the subject itself."¹⁰ In this formulation, *Bildung* would appear to be disqualified in advance from the very harmony of dialectical closure that it advertises and that leaves experience to languish in a belated state. As Redfield points out, even Goethe fails to offer a stable, much less ideal model of *Bildung* to emulate.¹¹ Wilhelm "engages himself in the errancy of family romance," Redfield writes, "to the extent that, within the orbit of aesthetic judgment, he *fails* to perform one." He thus commits himself "to the ironic recuperation of aesthetics through failure."¹² By recognizing the contradiction and errancy at the heart of *Bildung*, by recognizing its underlying logic of misrecognition, the *Bildungsheld* can transform "the failure of *Bildung*" into "the knowledge of failure," and "*Bildung* can rediscover itself as the production of an ironic consciousness."¹³

The instability at the heart of *Bildung* is well masked in the unifying narrative dynamics of the classical Bildungsroman, the persistence of which has conditioned our critical understanding of the modernist Bildungsroman as a failed enterprise.¹⁴ This is particularly the case in colonial and postcolonial traditions, where the narrative logic of the Bildungsroman confronts formative experiences and values that do not reproduce the liberal humanism of Humboldt and Mill and that in fact oppose “national *Bildung*,” in which, as Pheng Cheah puts it, “universal ideals are incarnated in the daily practices of a collective’s individual members.”¹⁵ From an ideological perspective, one fails if one does not “incarnate” the universal in oneself; but by *failing* to universalize in this way, the recalcitrant subject still struggles *in her non-identity* to aspire, to make a meaningful connection between an evolving subjectivity and her social milieu; she struggles to incarnate *Bildung* within daily practice and thus to redistribute achievement along new temporal lines.

This raises a crucial question, for if the ideal of *Bildung* is impossible, what does failing to attain it offer? The obvious answer is that failing opens up avenues of experience that would otherwise have been missed. This is the principle task of the modernist novel that seeks to free the idea of *Bildung* from a temporality of self-abnegating closure. In modernism, for perhaps the first time, belatedness – experience coming after and obeying a model; an ideal that promises to crown experience at a later time – is recognized as the authentic condition of *Bildung*. It emerges as the *now-time* of experience, by which recalcitrant subjects overwrite and reterritorialize “homogeneous, empty time” and *make time* within their own horizons and their own orientations, out of synch with the nation-time that nurtures classical *Bildung*.¹⁶ This passage into a new temporal field transforms *failure* (a static state that reinforces the ideal by its very nonachievement) into *failing* (a redistribution of achievement decoupled from the ideal). As an aesthetic or social practice, failing accords with the resistance of genuine works of art in Theodor Adorno’s sense, works that “push contradiction to the extreme, and realize themselves in their resultant downfall.”¹⁷ Adorno links this aesthetic result to an “innermost striving towards an image of

beauty free of appearance” that is ultimately destructive of art itself. “This downfall is the goal of every work of art, in that it seeks to bring death to all others.”¹⁸ Failing in this way transforms inadequacy into a new mode of adequation, which, in the context of the Bildungsroman means self-destruction in the name of aspiration (“innermost striving”) that transforms the disunifying temporal lag of belatedness into an open temporal field. By reimagining the temporality of *Bildung* in this way, the modernist Bildungsroman disperses the *reward* of achievement along the varied pathways of aspiration.¹⁹

Aspiration and Inner Life

Early modernist experiments with narrating *Bildung* took a number of forms, from the meticulous exploration of conscious states and the phenomenology of the other that we see in Henry James’s *The Portrait of a Lady* (1881) to the sweetly didactic resistance to classical *Bildung* that we see in H. G. Wells’s *Ann Veronica* (1909). At about this time, naturalist accounts of self-development reveal the devolution of classical *Bildung* into pure instrumentality. In U.S. and English naturalism, self-cultivation takes on a frankly socio-economic character and “coming of age” is cynically linked to the *Bildungsheld*’s commitment to dominant social values. Too often, however, coming of age is a comeuppance, a failure to thrive in an increasingly instrumentalized and consumerist milieu. Theodore Dreiser’s *Sister Carrie* (1900) and Thomas Hardy’s *Jude the Obscure* (1895) are fine examples of this tendency, each using a naturalist style to depict the perils and vicissitudes of self-development. In most cases, as in Frank Norris’s *McTeague* (1899), naturalism leaves the Bildungsroman behind, for the protagonist aspires only toward the satisfaction of immediate desire. Norris depicts with surgical precision McTeague’s fall into inhuman greed and violence, a profoundly bleak “snapshot” of a man whose inner life has degenerated into the domain of blind instinct. No aspiration for an ideal, even a broken ideal, can ever be driven by instinct. At this extreme) – depicted also in Stephen Crane’s *Maggie: A Girl of the Streets* (1893) – naturalism illustrates the tragedy of young men and women who lack

the conditions of freedom necessary to sustain an inner life – the garden of *Bildung* – and who find themselves prevented from aspiring toward a vision of their own futurity.²⁰

Jude Fawley, the benighted protagonist of *Jude the Obscure*, exemplifies the naturalist *Bildungsheld*, for his aspiration for *Bildung* is conducted in the face of opposition from a system of knowledge and worship – “the magnificent Christminster dream”²¹ – in which, by dint of social class, he is prevented from finding a place as a cleric and scholar. His aspirations unfold in a social milieu that manipulates and taunts him, that seduces him with a way of life but gives him no chance to live it:

“I am in a chaos of principles – groping in the dark – acting by instinct and not after example . . . I doubt if I have anything more for my present rule of life than following inclinations which do me and nobody else any harm . . . I perceive there is something wrong somewhere in our social formulas.”²²

In the sense that aspiration has degenerated into instinct and inclination, Jude is no better than McTeague; he gropes in the dark, with no example or model, no “right formula,” to give shape and direction to his striving. Unrelenting failure has cast his ideal behind him as a dead thing, never to be reacquired. For Jude, belatedness is not an opening up of time, but its foreclosure.

It is always too late for Jude, as it is for Dorian Gray, who is also haunted by an ideal that precedes him. In Oscar Wilde’s *Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890–91), Lord Henry Wotton pedantically invokes the ideal of *Bildung* – “The aim of life is self-development” – and blithely banishes the pernicious influence of *influence* (which is “immoral from the scientific point of view”). However, through his Mephistopholean manipulation of Dorian, he preempts the “aim of life.”²³ Lord Henry’s New Hedonism emphatically turns Dorian into an instrument for his aesthetic pleasure: “Talking to him was like playing upon an exquisite violin” (*DG* 34). It makes his aesthetic *Bildung* possible at the same time that it sharply delimits its lines of development, as surely as the ecclesiasts in Christminster drew a line under Jude’s aspirations. Dorian is not quite the blank slate that Lord

Henry and Basil take him for; the former's hedonistic gaze and the latter's picture idealize him in advance of his own experience of life. "If it were only the other way!" he exclaims. "If it were I who was to be always young, and the picture that was to grow old! . . . I would give my soul for that" (*DG* 25). Unlike Wilhelm, who readily accepts the document outlining the "authorship" of his life, Dorian revolts against Basil's painting once he realizes that his wish has been granted. An endless array of sensations substitutes for the experiences he has forfeited by his desire to step out of time. Near the end of the novel, when "for curiosity's sake," he decides to try "the denial of self" (*DG* 183), the irony of his position is lost on him because he misrecognizes the indiscriminate drive for sensation as the intentional act of an experiencing self. It is not the love of Beauty that kills Dorian, but the rage he feels for having lost the experience of himself. When he confronts the painting, he confronts the horror of belatedness when viewed from the perspective of a soiled ideal. It confronts him with the achievement of a life lived – but an achievement that is not his, and he comes to loathe and finally reject that life. The radical falling away from the ideal that he experiences when he attacks the painting expresses in a Gothic register the same belatedness Wilhelm experiences – the perverse time of the revenant, in which one is too late for one's own life. Like Jude, Dorian falls out of alignment with himself, and remains permanently in a condition of disorientation with respect to normative developmental time, with no alternative that does not amount to stepping out of time into eternity.²⁴

A strikingly similar desire to step out of time (and thus out of the singularity of unwanted selfhood) can be found in Olive Schreiner's *Story of an African Farm* (1883). Schreiner's novel contains a very early example of the modernist *Bildung* plot; it is a strange melange of naturalist notation, Orientalist description, religious allegory, and didacticism. It tells the story of a girl named Lyndall, orphaned and stranded in an isolated Boer community in South Africa, whose desire for self-cultivation is trumped by an environment that fails her. Brave about her own failings, she demands from those few around her the due she deserves: to be left alone, like Jude, to her inclinations and instincts.

The aspiration for *Bildung*, when it arises in isolated settler colonies, finds the individual bereft of models. Schreiner presents a world in which boys and girls, young men and young women, are left stranded with such a limited palette for imagining an alternative life that their horizons barely extend to the next town. The question of a normative *Bildung* cannot be raised in good conscience in colonial and postcolonial locations in which the ground of freedom necessary for achievement is either nonexistent, constrained by edict, or distorted by forms of custom and consensus. In novels such as Schreiner's *African Farm*, as Esty has shown, a narrative form premised on freedom, individuality, and infinite aspiration cannot express radically different forms of human experience and sociality.²⁵ These new forms of experience must struggle against conditions of privation that sharply delimit the horizon of development, both in terms of geographical orientation and literary representation. In the settler families that Schreiner depicts, formative limits are constrained by a permanent sense of not belonging to one's "native" community. In a trope that will dominate modernist Bildungsromane, *Wanderjahr* becomes exile, and aspiration is estranged, set loose in a new geography. Lyndall's four years away from the farm in nearby towns only solidifies her sense of limitation, despite attempts at self-cultivation. "I read, and epitomized what I read," she explains to her friend Waldo. "[A]nd I found time to write some plays, and find out how hard it is to make your thoughts look anything but imbecile fools when you paint them with ink and paper . . . I have not learnt what I expected; but I have learnt something else." That "something else" is the knowledge that *Bildung* is unattainable, for she has learned that "we are cursed . . . born cursed from the time our mothers bring us into the world till the shrouds are put on us."²⁶ Lyndall returns to the farm to reflect on the life she had only just started to live; she weakens and becomes like the "beautiful soul" in Goethe – a sublime example of partial cultivation, in Humboldt's sense, whose desire for self-harmony arises out of deprivation. "Why am I alone, so hard so cold?" she asks, echoing Dorian Gray, fully aware that she can be no other way. "I am so weary of myself! It is eating my soul to its core, – self, self, self! I cannot bear this life!" (*AF* 232).

In the absence of freedom, of a field for aesthetic education and the exercise of one's faculties, the belatedness of *Bildung* is transformed into a brute denial of possibility. Lyndall's friend Waldo is stifled and swiftly brought up short, as if his inner life were emaciated and weak, unable to express the will to self-form that is the alternative to animal life. Unlike Waldo and her cousin Em, who gives little evidence of inner life, Lyndall grasps the concept of *Bildung*, but her lively intelligence, a prerequisite for it, is forced into an avid self-examination that reveals how unfit she is for cultivation. The future is an unlikely and undeserved place, remote and free of definite contours. The marriage plot has no hold on her. To one suitor she says, "I want nothing more than your name," and sets a three-week deadline for marriage; to another, she says, "I cannot marry you . . . because I cannot be tied; but if you wish, you may take me away with you, and take care of me; then when we do not love any more we can say goodbye" (*AF* 229, 232).

The faith in *Bildung* that sits negatively at the heart of Lyndall's cold inner life is guarded by a cynical sensualist whose love affair and brief self-exile appears to commit her to the usual *Bildungsroman* script concerning women and their role in a patriarchal society in which male *Bildung* dialectically subsumes the merely instrumental formative energies of women. But she develops, in Tobias Boes's phrase, an "individuating rhythm," which emerges from and retroactively defines a disjunctive mode of development.²⁷ She will give in to sensuality, even to being dominated, but never to being a subordinate player in the *Bildung* of another. Her story is indirect, symbolic, and allusive, as if the sense of disorientation and untimeliness that characterizes her stunted and aimless aspirations could only be conveyed non-mimetically, through religious allegory, mystical revelation, Orientalist and didactic fantasy. The didacticism of the novel is especially important, for it places Lyndall in a position to offer critical insight about her own situation. In her monologues delivered to the ever-patient Waldo, she draws on and critiques the most radical thinkers of the nineteenth century to argue for the necessity of freedom for self-cultivation, the same freedom she failed to achieve for herself.²⁸

As with Wilde's *Dorian Gray*, the mélange of styles in Schreiner's *Story of an African Farm* expresses the chaos of inner life and raises the problem of self-representation in a way that neither realism nor naturalism alone could manage. By the time of Dorothy Richardson and early Woolf, innovations in free-indirect style were making this chaotic inner life more legible in narrative form. In Woolf's *The Voyage Out*, Rachel Vinrace appears to model the "beautiful soul," but Woolf in fact de-idealizes this option. Rachel suffers horribly the intellectual isolation that seems the only alternative to an empty marriage and equally empty social obligations; and in that isolation she enjoys "moments of being" in which the *Bildung*-ideal is manifested in flashes. In such moments, she enjoys the thrilling but evanescent temporality of self-achievement that marriage would annihilate in dialectical closure. Richardson's Miriam Henderson, in the multi-volume *Pilgrimage*, celebrates such moments and fiercely defends her claim to her "strange inner life," to "herself, the nearest most intimate self she had known It was not perhaps a 'good' self, but it was herself, her own familiar secretly happy and rejoicing self – not dead."²⁹ In both cases, advances in free-indirect style enable the protagonists to reveal the richness of their mercurial inner lives and the contradictions that prevent those lives from being dialectically absorbed in the "marriage plot" that entangles so many female *Bildunghelden*.³⁰ For Richardson, as for Woolf, the inner life was a forum for belatedness, where the wish to violate time was granted in the *now-time* of reflection – where Miriam, absorbed in the "ever-recurring joyous sense of emergence," felt certain "that if she could go back, things would get clear. She would talk and think and understand."³¹

Early modernists used free-indirect style to capture the thought and verbal style of a character and by so doing the novel for the first time could focus directly on inner life, without recourse to the conventional organization of psychological development that the classical Bildungsroman effortlessly modeled. Free-indirect style provided a new ground of artistic freedom, but it came at a cost, for inner life could easily take the form of solipsism. Hence, Stephen

Dedalus regards himself (his “inner world”) as exiled from the “sensible world”:

Did he then love the rhythmic rise and fall of words better than their associations of legend and colour? Or was it that, being as weak of sight as he was shy of mind, he drew less pleasure from the reflection of the glowing sensible world through the prism of a language manycoloured and richly storied than from the contemplation of an inner world of individual emotions mirrored perfectly in a lucid supple periodic prose?³²

Joyce’s depiction of the inward turn amplifies the sense of (self-) separation that the hero of *Bildung* feels in his native land. In Stephen’s case, artistic solipsism – an inward turn *toward language* (“manycoloured and richly storied”) – proves to be a necessary self-defense maneuver in a colonial culture that actively petitions him to lay down his intellectual arms and surrender his quest for *Bildung*, or at least yoke it to the greater cause of Irish nationalism.

Stephen’s inner life is informed by a negative dialectics that privileges nonidentity *as such* and redistributes the elements of *Bildung* in ways that puts paid to *failure* and makes possible modes of critical and creative *failing*. The chief power of nonidentity is that it forestalls dialectical closure and opens up the possibility of new time frames for development. For example, recursive time, modeled on memory and commemoration and expressed in a free-indirect style, provides a framework for understanding development that transforms the sense of belatedness into a project that brings aspiration toward self-fulfillment into every present moment. As Stephen says in the diary entries that conclude *A Portrait*, “[t]he past is consumed in the present and the present is living only because it brings forth the future” (*P* 222).³³ A confluence of temporalities is expressed in a spatial dynamic in which displacement along geographic lines redistributes belatedness *across every point* of development. For Stephen is paradoxically integrated socially only in the globalized inner culture of self-exile abroad: “the shortest way to Tara was via Holyhead,” he tells his nationalist friend, Davin (*P* 221–2). He can occupy the *now-time* of self-cultivation only once he has displaced it temporally and

geographically. Belatedness becomes the *sine qua non* of his colonial *Bildung*.

Moments of Being

In the modernist Bildungsroman, the subject and the politics of representation are equally predisposed to a disequilibrium in which the ethical responsibilities of the subject in the social world are challenged by a textual practice that foregrounds the constitutive failing of the *Bildung* ideal. In the form of a negative dialectical passage, the tempo of aspiration becomes the explicit hallmark of *Bildung*, which refuses to seek satiety or closure of the self. The focus of representation shifts from achieving (or having failed to achieve) *Bildung* to the aspiration to achieve, which can always survive *nonachievement*. As so many modernist novels in the inter-war years show, *Bildung* is nothing other than one's reflection on the stages of the journey, moments of "spontaneous cooperation," when experience and reflection converge in a narrative structured not by calendrical time but by the open temporality of belatedness, when time flows like a powerful river that surrounds as it passes an island in its path.

Aspiration, not achievement, matters. In "high" or mature modernism (ca. 1922–39), writers such as Woolf, Joyce (in *Ulysses* and *Finnegans Wake*), Gertrude Stein, and the French and German modernists (Robert Musil is a good example) were exploring the limits of *Bildung* as a construct for narrating self-development, an exploration driven in large part by a complete reassessment of the concept of the *self*. Woolf exemplifies the vicissitudes of the self in books such as *Jacob's Room* (1922) and *Mrs. Dalloway* (1925), which subordinate the *Bildung* plot to the intense presentness of moments and the fluid recursive movement of memory which redeems time, reconstituting belatedness as the temporality of the present. "Our image of happiness," Walter Benjamin writes, "is indissolubly bound up with the image of redemption. The same applies to our view of the past, which is the concern of history."³⁴ Benjamin regards the truth of the past as a moment's passage, a dialectical image "wherein

what has been comes together in a flash with the now to form a constellation. In other words: image is dialectics at a standstill.”³⁵ Woolf’s “moment of being” is remarkably close to Benjamin’s dialectical image, and serves a similar function in her mature work of urging *Bildung*’s achievement into the lit-match of a moment: “an illumination; a match burning in a crocus; an inner meaning almost expressed.”³⁶

In moments of being, *Bildung* finds its temporality. In flashes we know Mrs. Dalloway’s *Bildung* plot and in a heartbeat we know what her daughter Elizabeth strives for, though we are left hanging as to her ultimate path in life. Woolf’s rejection of the narrative requirements of the Bildungsroman extend to biography and autobiography – *Orlando* (1928) and *Flush* (1933) stand out. Her later works only implicitly indict *Bildung*, and then only as part of a critical project of “writing the self” – consider, for example, the performative *Bildung* of Miss La Trobe and the foiled, stamped-out aspirations of Isa, both embedded in the Big House narrative of *Between the Acts* (1939). Woolf’s practice is indicative of the modernist talent for appropriating the *Bildung* concept while eschewing the narrative “contraption” (to speak in Beckett’s idiom) that had misrecognized the responsibility of narrative, which is not to entice readers toward an ideal that cannot be narrated but to present the enjoyment of *Bildung* in “spontaneous cooperation” with those “external matters” that Humboldt believed were inevitably part of self-cultivation.

High modernists reconceived belatedness as a new framework for development in which the individual thrives in the absence of temporal coherence and in new modes of belonging with others (those “external matters”). As we have seen, the early modernist Bildungsroman was able to sustain an immanent critique of *Bildung*; but time and again in the era of high modernism, the concept of *Bildung* is decoupled from the Bildungsroman form and set into new narrative situations. Stephen Dedalus, for example, plays out his *Bildung* plot in *Ulysses*, not once, not twice, but three times!³⁷ Lawrence’s experiments with the *Bildung* of sisters in *Rainbow* and *Women in Love* combines the biographical arc of the classical Bildungsroman and the deep historical view over generations of

the saga form. This tendency to extend *Bildung* into the space of the other characterizes a good many novels that focus on the colonial world. For example, E. M. Forster tackled the *Bildung* of men from widely different cultures in *Passage to India* (1924). Across this panoramic novel of geopolitical power, Forster made possible a whole new way to reflect on the ethics of friendship in self-cultivation. In *Passage to India*, *Bildung* bears an ethical stamp that we see elsewhere in global literatures, where the ideal of harmonious integration is complicated by racial, ethnic, religious, and political differences that enliven and shape the material ground of aspiration but that scuttle any attempt to take friendship to the level of achieved *mutual Bildung*. For Dr. Aziz and Cyril Fielding, the quest for *Bildung* is doubly challenged, for not only does it exist on the sufferance of the other, it is displaced into near middle age. Temporal belatedness is expressed in terms of displacements and disorientations that stymie colonizer and colonized alike.

"Why can't we be friends now?" said the other, holding him affectionately. "It's what I want. It's what you want."

But the horses didn't want it – they swerved apart; the earth didn't want it, sending up rocks through which riders must pass single file; the temples, the tank, the jail, the palace, the birds, the carrion, the Guest House, that came into view as they issued from the gap and saw Mau beneath: they didn't want it, they said in their hundred voices, "No, not yet," and the sky said, "No, not there."³⁸

We might say that the desire for such mutual achievements duplicates at the level of interpersonal intimacy the belatedness native to *Bildung*. Even the sky says, *not yet*: shared *Bildung* will not be possible until later.

In keeping with this new destiny of *Bildung* to extend into the space of the other, modernists rejected the idea of an ideal harmony of faculties as the necessary condition for authentic selfhood. Hence the dissonant yet lyrical "double voicing" that we find in Zora Neale Hurston's *Their Eyes Are Watching God* (1937), which fractures the unity of selfhood at the same moment that it transforms reputed failing (nonstandard English) into a new mode of self-expression. This same sense of fracture is treated in a less celebratory vein in

F. Scott Fitzgerald's *The Great Gatsby* (1925), the cool mystifications of which conceal a rotten inner life. The coming of age story told in Fitzgerald's novel – feverish aspiration for a bogus ideal – is given a Gothic treatment in Faulkner's *Absalom! Absalom!* (1936). Like Lawrence, Faulkner weaves individual *Bildung* within generations of families, and depicts the scandal of miscegenation in a way that challenges the sovereignty of selfhood at the basis of American political identity. Henry Sutpen and his progeny complicate the *Bildung*-dynamic because their aspirations are almost entirely at the mercy of heredity, historical contingency, and instinctual need. Henry, Judith and Charles Bon are defined in terms of a “pure and perfect incest,” which undermines the libidinal economy of classical *Bildung* and abstracts them from the world of aspiration, suspended in a “fairy balloon-vacuum.”³⁹ Charles Bon, belated and benighted avatar of Dorian Gray, strips away the faith in self-cultivation as aesthetic project that made Dorian's drag form of *Bildung* so appealing and leaves in its place a blank-eyed narcissist concerned only for his own preservation, with no sense of aesthetic or ethical commitment to the self he creates.

Bildung has never been so undead.

Failing Time

Adorno's theory of negative dialectics helps explain the persistence of *Bildung* despite such undead conditions, for it holds out the promise of achievement for recalcitrant nonidentical subjects who resist a socialization process that threatens to “normalize” them through identification with the state. Gothicized versions of this process, in which protagonists such as Dorian Gray and Charles Bon seek the absolute closure of death rather than the struggle for achieved *Bildung*, effectively annihilate the possibility of a transvalued belatedness. Alternatively, the belated temporality of “negative *Bildung*” forestalls the totalizing closure of dialectics, without requiring the sacrifice of the pleasures of achievement. Indeed, it tends to recuperate those pleasures within a temporality that confounds the *telos* of socialization that is particularly onerous in the formation of girls and young women. For example, Lois Farquahar, the protagonist of Elizabeth Bowen's *The Last September* (1929), is subject to a

form of proleptic nostalgia that pervades the Anglo-Irish gentry depicted in the novel, a sense of looking forward to looking back at what *will have been* by then “the best of times.” Lois is always performing a backward glance in a present quickened by memory, in which aspiration *will have been* transformed into *what will have been achieved*. She has to reassure herself as well as Hugo, an older family friend, that “she was not enjoying anything he had missed, that she was now unconvinced and anxious but intended to be quite certain, by the time she was his age, that she *had once been* happy.”⁴⁰

As Bowen’s style of surreptitious irony suggests, this form of belatedness is not what it seems – that is, it is not (or not exclusively) the tempo of arrested development, as Esty claims.⁴¹ I am suggesting that Lois transforms her own belated condition into a standpoint for reflection on arrestment *as such*, on the stasis that contaminates her caste and that threatens to rob her of a future. She comes to realize that a lively inner life requires more than the “intransitivity” of artful solipsism. She wants “to be in a pattern” – “to be related; to have to be what I am. Just to *be* is so intransitive, so lonely.”⁴² Her ardent appeal to the memory of her mother results in a timely reminder that belatedness *is* a choice: one can conjure up ghosts or one can live with the living. Only the latter opens *Bildung* to the future. The tragedy of her story, then, is not that her *Bildung* is stalled or stunted, but that she came so late to understand that the conventional framework for it – the “marriage plot” that would sequester her own *Bildung* in dialectical harmony with Gerald’s – would no longer suffice to orient her aspirations. Lois’s exile, like Stephen’s, signals that the problem is not so much *Bildung* as the horizon of its potential achievements.

Kate O’Brien’s *Land of Spices* (1941) approaches this idea of a new horizon by expressing it through the structure of “a government of women.” *Bildung* persists, as does some of the framework of the Bildungsroman, but this persistence is driven in large measure by an openly hostile relation to the nationalism of the Catholic Church hierarchy and its paternalistic attitude toward the sisters and students of *Sainte Famille*, a Belgian order with a convent near Limerick. O’Brien’s novel stands in parodic relation to Joyce’s *Portrait*, but it is parody of the sort that appropriates Joyce’s own appropriations, taking the critical interrogation of the

Bildungsroman a step further to focus on young Irish-Catholic schoolgirls, whose parochial worldliness constructs narrative temporalities that model a form of belated self-cultivation that is both outside time and in touch with the quicksilver presentness of aspiration itself. The girls and young women of *Sainte Famille* undergo the kind of socialization that would prepare them for marriage; but this preparation is called into question by the very milieu of their education, for the convent takes the students (and their teachers) outside the nation-time in which they would perform their instrumental function (as wife and “help-meet”) and provides them with the opportunity to create new horizons in which to form themselves. For the protagonist, Anna Murphy – who triumphs over a patriarchal system and wins scholarships to university – it means that it is too late for her to become a “good wife” for Ireland.

In what seems, on first glance, to be a work of understated realism, quietly ironic in its narratorial circumspection, turns out to be revolutionary in the way that it converts the solipsistic time of belatedness into new forms of “spontaneous cooperation” – something Anna learns from her mentor, Helen Archer. Anna’s *Bildung* plot concludes with an episode that captures both her aesthetic vocation and a new willingness to embrace the society of women from which she has remained aloof for so long. Her friend, Pilar, struggling over Milton’s *Lycidas*, asks for Anna’s help. Her ordinary “girlish and silly” nature strikes Anna “in a new way. She became aware of her and of the moment on a plane of perception which was strange to her, and which during its visitation she did not understand but could only receive.”⁴³ It is an epiphanic moment, strikingly like Stephen Dedalus’s with the young woman on the strand.⁴⁴ “Her eyes had called him and his soul had leaped at the call,” Stephen realizes. “To live, to err, to fall, to triumph, to recreate life out of life!” (*P* 150). Anna’s experience is more tempered and less derived from sacred ideas; but it matches Stephen’s in that she too sees the other as the motive of aesthetic *Bildung*. Pilar is defamiliarized and stands momentarily for something both simple and extraordinary:

A foolish schoolgirl, smiling at poetic verbiage – yet herself a symbol as complicated as any imaginative struggle in verse; a common piece of creation, an exquisite challenge to creativeness; she saw Pilar as a glimpse, as if she were a line from a lost immortal; she saw her ironically, delightedly, as a motive in art.⁴⁵

There is something Wildean about this aesthetic epiphany, for Pilar strikes Anna as Dorian did Basil: she is “the appearance of a new personality for art” (*DG* 13). Anna is inspired by a “foolish school-girl” who, unlike Dorian or Stephen’s “birdgirl,” is not an idealized beauty. She is “a common piece of creation,” emblem at once of the moment she embodies (in a glimpse) and of every moment’s achievement. Her nonidentity (“something *not yet* understood”) is embraced and exalted as a state of being outside the temporal limit of dialectical closure. The interpersonal bond of friendship, strung out over moments of being, recuperates *Bildung* on a new footing, with a utopian vision of sociality and cooperation that converts the detainments and delays of belatedness into untimely opportunities for social belonging. The hero of *Bildung* in late modernism is marked by the most advanced failing of all: she must resist not only a mode of formation and collectivization but also a mode of *being human*.⁴⁶

Samuel Beckett’s fiction of the 1950s, with its negative dialectics of disorientation, charts this resistance, the detainment and delay in the *terra incognita* of a posthuman world. If his early works find themselves ambivalently situated on the shifting divide between modernism and postmodernism, it is because his narrators retain the aspiration for *Bildung* even in the ruins of the culture that created it. The multiplication of disabled bodies and disembodied voices frustrates permanently any nostalgia for a humanist ideal. Beckett’s people are irretrievably disoriented, recalcitrant, nonidentical beings who appear to have given up on the achievement of *Bildung*. Characters such as Molloy and Moran, in *Molloy* (1951), do not come into form (*Bildung*) so much as stave off deformation – that is, when they can be bothered to try. The “frenzied collapsing,” the “growing resignation to being dispossessed of self,” is accompanied by an increasingly detached awareness of the “body properly so-called.”⁴⁷ Such a life, as Moran says, is an “inenarrable contraption”

(*TN* 156), a machinic device that aspires toward little more than speaking. As we learn in *The Unnamable*, voice and being, aspiration and aim refuse to coalesce into “selfhood” – “the confusion of identities being merely apparent and due to my inaptitude to assume any” (*TN* 130). Encouraged by contradiction and failure – “I can’t go on, you must go on, I’ll go on, you must say words, as long as there are any” (*TN* 418) – Beckett’s protagonists admit into the realm of achievement the possibility of *not going on*. Yet they keep going, Molloy and his avatars, and they achieve nothing more than the conquest of every moment.

The aspiration for *Bildung* trumps the achievement of it, even if it means aspiring for an impossible ideal or a broken one – or one that is gloriously debased. Beckett’s experiments with aspiration are bold acts of defiance that teach us how to embrace the state of failing as a mode of being: “Ever tried. Ever failed. No matter. Try again. Fail again. Fail better,” he writes in one of his last works, *Worstward Ho*.⁴⁸ Something remotely akin to *Bildung* remains, even after the travesty of the body’s degeneration. This remainder, the unassailable voice, constitutes itself as pure aspiration (desire in and as breath), in the absence of the stable “I”: “The words come back, someone says I, unbelieving” (*TN* 402). Breath, mere tones on the air, constitute the being of a voice – and not just one voice, but a congregation of voices, that reterritorialize the time of community, over against the empty homogenous time of the nation. “It is solely a question of voices, no other image is appropriate,” a speaker says in *The Unnamable*, referring, as did his avatars before him, to the obscure authority that alone seems to penetrate his consciousness. “Unfortunately it’s a question of words, of voices, one must not forget that” – a question “of a statement to be made, by them, by me, some slight obscurity here” (*TN* 384, 347).

Achievement may be annulled, the authority behind it obscured, but the temporality of aspiration is neither annulled nor obscured, for it does not follow a straight chronological line of orientation and so does not find itself *late upon the scene*. Belatedness is overwritten in the pure enjoyment of fracture, in which voice and writing capture the joy of nonbeing: “Yes, there were times when I forgot not only

who I was, but that I was, forgot to be. Then I was no longer that sealed jar to which I owed my being so well preserved, but a wall gave way and I filled with roots and tame stems" (TN 65). In this radical "spontaneous cooperation," figure and ground melt away and aspiration hinges on every moment.

If Beckett's late modernist writing "still has an 'intransitive' quality to it," Tyrus Miller writes, "it is no longer because it refers back to the autonomy of a thinking consciousness, as did modernist writing, but rather to the autonomy of *social* forms and practices ungroundable by reliable knowledge: narrating, waiting, searching, playing."⁴⁹ *Bildung*, decoupled from the realist guarantee and the temporality of closure, relies upon the freedom of the negative, "ungroundable" subject (not identical to itself); it relies upon freedom from categories of time that create *early* and *late* as conditions of being *out of time* and thus out synch with oneself. The problem of *Bildung* in postmodernity has continued to evolve within the context of a critique of "I"-centered humanism that regards *Bildung* as the unity of a single person's experience. Beckett's work reduces the subject to a voice in order to fuse the voice within a chorus of voices. This strikes me as an apt dialectical image of *Bildung*, in which the terrible loss of our humanity is accompanied by moments of "spontaneous cooperation" that merge self and environment ("filled with roots and tame stems") and that cap aspiration in every breath – "no need of a mouth, the words are everywhere, inside me, outside me, well well a minute ago I had no thickness" (TN 386). At this limit, the failings of *Bildung* count as our finest achievements.

Notes

1. On the classical Bildungsroman and classical *Bildung*, dominant in the late-eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, see Gregory Castle, *Reading the Modernist Bildungsroman* (Gainesville: University of Florida Press, 2006), chaps. 1–2.
2. Jean Laplanche uses the English term "afterwardsness" to translate Freud's *Nachträglichkeit* (deferred action or *après-coup*), a complex temporality that moves between the past and the present, through processes of revision and translation and that implicates the other in a retroactive reconstitution of

- the past. See Laplanche, *Essays on Otherness*, ed. John Fletcher, trans. Luke Thurston, Leslie Hill, and Philip Slotkin (London and New York: Routledge, 1999), 260–5.
3. Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, *Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship*, vol. 9 of *Goethe: The Collected Works*, ed. and trans. Eric A. Blackall (1795–96; repr. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1995), 351. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*WM*).
 4. Hegel, G. W. F., *Philosophy of Right*, trans. S. W. Dyde (London: George Bell and Sons, 1896), xxx. “Philosophy, as the thought of the world, does not appear until reality has completed its formative process, and made itself ready.”
 5. *Belated* has two distinct meanings: “Overtaken by lateness of the night; hence, overtaken by darkness, benighted” and “detained beyond the usual time, coming or staying too late; out of date, behind date” (“belated, adj,” OED Online, June 2014 [Oxford University Press, <http://www.oed.com/view/Entry/17318?redirectedFrom=belated&>, accessed July 17, 2014]).
 6. “Balanced activity can unfortunately only be achieved by counterbalancing,” Jarno tells Wilhelm (*WM* 345), acknowledging the role of dialectical negation, in this case in politics.
 7. Wilhelm von Humboldt, *The Limits of State Action*, ed. J. W. Burrow (1850; repr. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1969), 16.
 8. *Ibid.*, 27.
 9. Jed Esty, *Unseasonable Youth: Modernism, Colonialism and the Fiction of Development* (Oxford and New York: Oxford University Press, 2012), 13–15.
 10. Marc Redfield, *Phantom Formations: Aesthetic Ideology and the Bildungsroman* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1996), 49.
 11. Goethe’s text bristles with narrative variety, from the picaresque realism of the main story of Wilhelm’s travels to the set-piece lecture on Hamlet and the allegory of the Beautiful Soul, to the quasi-mystical concluding scene with the “Tower Society.” The narrative conventions we think of as characteristic of *Bildungsromane* come mainly from French and English realist exemplars.
 12. Redfield, *Phantom Formations* 82.
 13. *Ibid.*, 46.
 14. Tobias Boes, in *Formative Fictions: Nationalism, Cosmopolitanism and the Bildungsroman* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2012), argues contrary to this tendency that Ernst Bloch’s notion of the “synchronicity of the non-synchronous” allows us to read failure in the *Bildungsroman* as “successful responses to internally contradictory imaginative worlds” (34–5).

15. Cheah, *Spectral Nationality: Passages of Freedom from Kant to Postcolonial Literatures of Liberation* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2003), 8. In Goethe's *Wilhelm Meister*, *Bildung* is ultimately tied to the community, represented in the utopian "Tower Society" (see, e.g., *WM* 345f).
16. On "homogeneous, empty time," see Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (London and New York: Verso, 1991). Anderson develops the idea in a consideration of Walter Benjamin's radical historical materialism. *Now-time* (*Jetztzeit*) comes from Benjamin's reflections on history; see "On the Concept of History," in *Selected Writings*, eds. Marcus Bullock and Michael W. Jennings, vol. 4, 1938–1940 (Cambridge, MA: Belknap-Harvard University Press, 1996), 389–411.
17. Theodor W. Adorno, *Minima Moralia: Reflections from Damaged Life*, trans. E. F. N. Jephcott (1951; repr. London: Verso, 2005), 227.
18. *Ibid.*, 74.
19. This conception of *Bildung* is in keeping with modernist revisions of biography and autobiography. See Max Saunders, *Self Impression: Life-Writing, Autobiografiction and the Forms of Modern Literature* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010) and the special issue of *MSF* 59 (Fall 2013), guest ed. John Paul Riquelme, "Modernist Life Narratives: Biography, Autobiography, *Bildungsroman*."
20. Von Humboldt and Goethe both use metaphors of natural growth and teleology to illustrate the tempo and ideality of *Bildung*. "In the highest ideal of human nature which the most glowing fantasy can conceive," writes Humboldt, "each actual moment is a beautiful flower, but nevertheless only *one*. Only memory can wreath the garland which binds together past and future" (qtd. in Barrow's introduction to Humboldt's *Limits* xxi).
21. Thomas Hardy, *Jude the Obscure* (1895; repr. London: Penguin, 1985), 84.
22. *Ibid.*, 399, 396.
23. Oscar Wilde, *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, ed. Donald L. Lawler (1890/91; repr. New York: Norton, 1988), 19. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*DG*).
24. What Fredric Jameson says of Bergson is relevant here: "[F]or Bergson, in analogy to the aesthetics of Baudelaire himself, the present time is doubled by a strange and identical present out of time which is explicitly identified as eternity" (*A Singular Modernity: Essay on the Ontology of the Present* [London: Verso, 2002], 193).
25. Esty, *Unseasonable Youth*, 71–83.
26. Olive Schreiner, *The Story of an African Farm* (Peterborough, Ont.: Broadview Press, 2003), 183–4. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*AF*).

27. Boes, *Formative Fictions*, 132–7.
28. Joseph Bristow writes of this aspect of the text: “Deeply informed by the political economy of John Stuart Mill, the Social Darwinism of Herbert Spencer, and the Transcendentalism of Ralph Waldo Emerson, Schreiner’s strongly intellectual novel courageously faced up to the increasing agnosticism of her age, its growing doubts about the sanctity of marriage, and the violence incurred by imperialist expansion” (Introduction, *The Story of an African Farm*, ed. Joseph Bristow [Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998], viii).
29. Dorothy Richardson, *Honeycomb*, 431, and *Backwater*, 282, both in *Pilgrimage*, vol. 1 (London: Virago, 1989).
30. See Rachel Blaue DuPlessis, *Writing beyond the Ending: Narrative Strategies of Twentieth-Century Women Writers* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1985), 47, 52.
31. Richardson, *Pointed Roofs*, 81, 90, in *Pilgrimage*.
32. Joyce, *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*, ed. John Paul Riquelme (New York: Norton, 2007), 146. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*P*).
33. In *Ulysses*, this confluence of temporalities takes on a broader historical significance: “I moved among them on the frozen Liffey, that I, a changeling, among the spluttering resin fires. I spoke to no-one: none to me” (Joyce, *Ulysses*, ed. Hans Walter Gabler [New York: Vintage, 1986], 303).
34. Benjamin, “Concept of History,” thesis ii.
35. Benjamin, *Arcades Project*, trans. Howard Eiland and Kevin McLaughlin (Cambridge, MA, and London: Belknap Press, 1999), 463. Benjamin goes on to claim that “the relation of the what-has-been to the now is dialectical: not temporal in nature but figural (*bildlich*). Only dialectical images are genuinely historical.”
36. Virginia Woolf, *Mrs. Dalloway*, ed. Mark Hussey (New York: Harcourt, 2005), 31. On the “moment of being,” see Woolf, “Moments of Being. ‘Slater’s Pins Have No Points.’” *A Haunted House and Other Short Stories* (New York: Harcourt, Brace and Company, 1944), 103–11.
37. In Proteus, Circe, and Ithaca; see Castle, *Reading the Modernist Bildungsroman*, 193–6.
38. E. M. Forster, *A Passage to India* (San Diego: Harcourt, Brace, Jovanovich, 1984), 322.
39. William Faulkner, William. *Absalom! Absalom!* (1936; New York: Vintage 1991), 77, 256.
40. Elizabeth Bowen, *The Last September* (1929; repr. New York: Anchor Books, 200), 41; emphasis added.
41. Esty, *Unseasonable Youth*, 179–94.

42. Bowen, *The Last September*, 142.
43. Kate O'Brien, *Land of Spices* (1941; repr. London: Virago), 271.
44. For parallels with *A Portrait*, see Ann Owens Weekes, "Kate O'Brien: Family in the New Nation," in *Irish Women Writers: An Uncharted Tradition* (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 1990), 123.
45. O'Brien, *Land of Spices*, 271–2. Earlier in the novel, adoration colors Anna's description of Molly Redmond – looking "very beautiful and piteous then, almost as if crucified" (131) – which links aesthetics to theology in a way that reminds us of the "outburst of profane joy" that the birdgirl inspires in Stephen (*P* 186).
46. On the modernist *Bildung* in postcolonial fiction, see Castle, "My Self, My Other: Modernism and Postcolonial *Bildung* in Assia Djebar's Algerian Quartet," *Modern Fiction Studies* 59 (Fall 2013): 628–48.
47. Samuel Beckett, *Three Novels: Molloy, Malone Dies, The Unnamable*, trans. Paul Bowles and Samuel Beckett (New York: Grove Press, 2009), 148–9, 168. Subsequent references to this edition will be made parenthetically in the text (*TN*).
48. Samuel Beckett, *Worstward Ho*, in *Samuel Beckett: The Grove Centenary Edition*, ed. Paul Auster, vol. 4, *Poems, Short Fiction, Criticism* (New York: Grove Press, 2006), 471.
49. Tyrus Miller, *Late Modernism* (Berkeley: University of California, 1999), 251n23

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